



The Palgrave Handbook of Emotions and Values in Organizational Institutionalism

Edited by Gry Espedal · Trish Ruebottom
Marta Struminska-Kutra · Jose Bento da Silva
Douglas Creed

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“Theoretical and empirical attention to emotions and values represents a profoundly important development for scholars interested in the intersection of institutions and organizations. Although emotions and values are the energizing forces behind core institutional processes, systematic examination of those forces has only recently emerged as a significant endeavor. This Handbook marks a turning point for organizational institutionalism. Providing both wayfinding conceptual essays and detailed studies of values and emotions, this collection will be required reading for institutional scholars wishing to advance their understanding of these key issues.”

—Thomas B. Lawrence, *Professor of Strategy, Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, UK*

“This Handbook invites readers to take a closer look at how emotions and values interact and shape the inner workings of institutions. Moving beyond traditional institutional theory, the volume calls for a more human-centered approach—one that recognizes how feelings and personal convictions drive our commitments and influence organizational behavior. By unpacking issues like reflexivity, ambiguity, and even the complex, ‘darker’ sides of emotional and value entanglement, the Handbook sheds new light on the moral and emotional foundations of organizational life. It’s a timely resource for anyone interested in understanding how institutions are evolving in a rapidly changing world—whether you’re a researcher or a practitioner.”

—Jane E. Dutton, *Professor Emerita of Business Administration and Psychology, University of Michigan, USA*

“This Handbook offers a timely and exciting contribution to the social sciences. It tackles the important topic of how institutionalized values and emotional experiences interact with one another to shape social structures. This intellectually intriguing topic matters for how we organize our societies in a context of AI, growing inequalities, green transition, and political instability. I am truly excited about this Handbook. Its anchoring in organizational institutionalism makes it theoretically and ontologically coherent, and the chapters are of high academic quality and well connected to one another. The editors and contributors include both internationally leading and upcoming scholars, which is a powerful constellation. Moreover, the wide scope of empirical studies is inspiring and shows the practical significance of the topic. At the end, methodological chapters guide scholars in pursuing institutionalist research at the intersection of values and emotions. Altogether, the Handbook successfully opens a new line of academic inquiry, one that advances our theorizing and carries potential to shape how we train leaders of tomorrow and restructure organizations of the future.”

—Eva Boxenbaum, *Professor of Organization and Management Theory, Copenhagen Business School, Denmark*

“This is a book the field needs. A top-tier collection of seasoned and new contributors explore the mutual constitution of values and emotions in institutions, processes that can be messy, ambiguous and fraught with vulnerability. The book’s non-obvious insight is that this entanglement is the very engine of institutional stability and change—from the ‘dark side’ of shame and hate to the creative power of reflexivity. The authors provide new lenses for seeing how we collectively construct—or erode—the good in our organizations, demanding we attend to the full, complex human experience. On these pages, institutional theory feels alive and urgent.”

—Arne Carlsen, *Professor at the Department of Leadership and Organizational Behaviour at BI Norwegian Business School, Norway*

“In an era of accelerating polarization, inequality, climate crises, and the erosion of institutions, humanity needs to center on values to find our way forward. This Handbook reveals emotions, moral aspirations and collective values as central forces in the transformation of the institutions that shape our lives. Featuring accomplished scholars and diverse contexts, this book presents insights that are indispensable

for scholars, leaders, and change-makers seeking to navigate turbulent times with greater understanding of the emotional and moral landscapes that underpin institutional engagement.”

—Dr. Charlene Zietsma, *Max McGraw Professor of Sustainable Enterprise and Director of the Erb Institute, University of Michigan, USA*

“This Handbook’s heart is in the very right place—exploring the work of emotions, values, and their interrelations in institutional dynamics. Covering a rich array of phenomena (from the dissolution of values in academia, through the erosion of democracy, polarization in social media, AI, to community gardens and academia), organizational dynamics (leadership and leaders, social innovation, purpose-driven organizing; executive decision making), and emotions (from shame and hate to melancholia and compassion), the handbook offers fascinating explorations of the institutionalization of emotions and values, as well as the emotional and value-laden fabrics that underly institutions. It shows how emotions and values can have both positive and negative effects, and how emotions work and value work materialize in other kinds of work, like care work and body work. As such, it reflects and further strengthens the efforts to bring institutional theory closer to people’s actions and interactions on the ground, complementing macro-level explorations of structures with micro-level explorations of human experience, including ideal aspirations and hidden vulnerabilities. In these times of change and uncertainties, the handbook reminds us of the best and the worst we humans are capable of, and the intellectual purchase in thinking of this moment through an expanded institutional lens that also accounts for emotions and values.”

—Tammar B. Zilber, *Hebrew University, Israel, and Copenhagen Business School, Denmark*

“This Handbook offers a compelling reorientation of institutional theory by positioning emotions and values as core elements of institutional processes. Rather than treating affect and morality as peripheral influences, the contributors show how they actively shape institutional dynamics and how institutional arrangements, in turn, form people’s emotional and value commitments. Through this focus, the volume advances a more human-centered institutionalism that views individuals as reflective and morally embedded actors who navigate institutional tensions through care, vulnerability, and ethical engagement.

The chapters demonstrate that institutional theory must evolve if it is to remain relevant in a world marked by uncertainty and upheaval. By examining reflexive awareness, the pull of ambiguity and ambivalence, embodied and aesthetic forms of sensemaking, and the more troubling emotional undercurrents that define institutional life, the Handbook encourages scholars to confront both the generative and corrosive aspects of institutional processes. It offers a nuanced perspective that illuminates the complex moral and emotional terrain underlying institutional engagement and opens new pathways for understanding how institutions are lived, felt, and contested.

The result is a timely and integrative contribution that deepens our understanding of the moral and emotional landscapes that animate institutional processes, providing a valuable resource for scholars seeking a more human-centered institutional theory.”

—Charlotte M. Karam, *Professor, Ian Telfer Professorship in Inclusive Human Resource Systems, Telfer School of Management, Ottawa*

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Acknowledgements

This project began when Gry Espedal, Marta Struminska-Kutra, Jose Bento da Silva, and Douglas Creed organized a sub-track on the European Group for Organizational Studies (EGOS) conference in Vienna, Austria in 2022 titled, *The Micro-dynamics and Embodiment of Emotions and Values*, which was fortuitously attended by Trish Ruebottom. The response was overwhelming to the hybrid section, sparking a discussion about writing a book with editor Alec Selwyn at Palgrave, who immediately suggested it could be a Handbook.

The following year, in Cagliari, Italy (2023), we held a new sub-track: *Values and Emotions as Animating Forces in Social Symbolic Work*. This section also exceeded our expectations, with many participants expressing interest in contributing. We invited all participants to submit abstracts, and reached out to other scholars who had made significant contributions to the study of emotions and values within institutional contexts. This outreach led to the impressive collection of chapters you hold in your hands now.

Since initiating the project in 2023, we have encouraged authors to provide abstracts, participate in workshops to refine and connect their ideas, and submit their chapters for multiple rounds of editorial review. The editors convened approximately once a month for more than two years to read, discuss, and develop the submitted papers. Ultimately, after countless hours of labor, we are proud to present 26 exceptional chapters in this Handbook on Emotions and Values in Organizational Institutionalism. This Handbook features contributions from 48 scholars, ranging from Ph.D. students

to senior scholars, and representing a diverse set of geographical locations, including Australia, Canada, Brazil, India, Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, South Africa, Spain, Ukraine, UK, and US. We are so very grateful to all the authors for their enthusiastic and comprehensive contributions, which have challenged us and propelled the field forward beyond our initial expectations; without your input, this book would not have been possible.

The editors also wish to express their sincere gratitude to all those who provided their valuable advice and feedback on this book, particularly the three anonymous reviewers who evaluated an early version of the Handbook and offered constructive insights that contributed significantly to its development. We are also thankful to both the European Group for Organizational Studies (EGOS) and the Academy of Management for allowing us to organize sub-tracks and panels focused on the theme of emotions and values in organizational institutionalism. Furthermore, we gratefully acknowledge VID Specialized University in Oslo, Norway, and McMaster University in Ontario, Canada, for their financial support in facilitating the open-access publication of this work. Lastly, we wish to express our appreciation to Alec Selwyn and Supraja Yegnaraman at Palgrave and Springer Nature for their invaluable collaboration and encouraging feedback throughout this process.

All best and good reading,

Gry Espedal
Trish Ruebottom
Marta Struminska-Kutra
Jose Bento da Silva
Douglas Creed

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Part I

Introduction



1

Introduction to Emotions and Values in Organizational Institutionalism

Gry Espedal, Trish Ruebottom, Marta Struminska-Kutra,
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Introduction

Emotions and values are widely recognized as vital driving forces underpinning institutional processes, shaping how institutions emerge, persist, and transform (Kraatz et al., 2020; Zietsma et al., 2019). Emotions—described as the “glue binding people together” (Zietsma et al., 2019)—are central to the “embodied world of concern” that motivates individuals to engage in institutional processes (Creed et al., 2022). They act as catalysts for social action, fueling both collective mobilization and individual commitment (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018; Voronov & Vince, 2012). Values, meanwhile, serve as moral compasses, guiding motivations, shaping judgments, evaluating, and informing actions (Kraatz et al., 2020; Selznick, 1957). They reflect what

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people consider “worth having, doing, and being” (Kraatz et al., 2020), and thus play a critical role in linking individuals to institutions and driving institutional work (Askeland et al., 2020; Gehman et al., 2013; Kraatz et al., 2020; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015; Wright et al., 2017).

Despite broad consensus on the interconnectedness of emotions, values, and institutions, the nature of these relationships remains under-theorized. Existing research often treats emotions and values in isolation, overlooking the ways they are mutually constitutive and co-construct meaning and influence action. When emotions align with values, they can amplify each other—anger paired with a strong sense of justice, for instance, can generate a potent force for change. Conversely, misalignment between emotional experiences and value commitments can lead to internal conflict, paralyzing decision-making, and obscuring moral clarity. Emotions can shape how values are enacted, just as values influence emotional investment in institutional life.

This Handbook invites readers to delve into the complex interconnections between emotions and values within institutional theory. By foregrounding these dimensions, we aim to illuminate the attachments and moral concerns that animate institutional participation (Creed et al., 2022; Voronov & Vince, 2012). This approach contributes to the broader project of “rehumanizing institutional theory” (Kraatz et al., 2020), recognizing individuals as moral, reflexive agents navigating complex realities through lenses of vulnerability, care, and well-being (Sayer, 2011). We contend that institutional theory—particularly organizational institutionalism—must evolve to better understand the nexus of emotions, values, and institutions if it is to remain relevant in an era of radical disruption. To make institutional theory “matter more” (Hampel et al., 2017), we must confront the multidimensional and complex entanglements of hope, fear, and moral aspiration that shape people’s relationships with institutions.

In this Handbook, we provide a comprehensive exploration of contemporary perspectives on emotions and values, examining the manifestation of emotions and values within institutions, their interrelationships, and their role as drivers of actions, practices, and processes. The central question addressed is: *How do emotions and values shape institutional processes, and how institutional processes, in turn, shape emotions and values?* Through this question, the link between emotions and values comes to the fore.

Pushing the Boundaries of Theorizing

Examining emotions and values within institutional processes deepens our understanding of how people encounter and evaluate the practical challenges of organizing—challenges that capture their attention and trigger their concerns. Thus, what we offer in this Handbook is not merely a collection of “add-ons” to existing perspectives, but a step toward breaking free from the dualism of heart and reason, rationality and irrationality. Instead, we treat emotions and values as essential to our ways of knowing and acting, developing a framework that pushes the boundaries of existing theories.

Through discussions with chapter authors and review of their contributions, we have identified several themes that hold significant potential to advance understanding of the role emotions and values have within institutional processes: (1) reflexivity as antecedent and outcome in emotional and value-laden processes; (2) the role of ambiguity and ambivalence in institutional processes; (3) embodied and aesthetic perspectives on values and emotions; and finally, (4) the dark side of values, emotions and institutional processes.

Reflexivity as antecedent and outcome in emotional and value-laden processes. Reflexivity is defined as a process through which people, “as knowing subjects, achieve a deepening awareness both of the sociohistorical reality which shapes their lives and of their capacity to transform that reality” (Freire, 1970, p. 27). Such reflexivity features an understanding of the impact of institutional structures and the social order on individuals’ lives, not only allowing actors to make conscious choices and envision change, but as Freire, holds, compelling them to act.

It is therefore unsurprising that many chapters in this Handbook touch on issues of reflexivity, or the lack thereof. The absence of reflexivity is highlighted in Sharma and Amis’ chapter (Chapter 16), where the authors demonstrate how entrenched values perpetuate inequality and moral indebtedness, even in the face of changing practices. Their case study of farmers reveals how hierarchical structures and dependence remain entrenched within material realities. The lack of reflexivity hinders critical examination of long-standing values, ultimately sustaining existing power imbalances and moral obligations within the community. Malhotra and Voronov (Chapter 9) focus on the rise of authoritarianism, erosion of democracy, and how this process is aided by the muted response of mainstreamers. They show how mainstreamers’ emotional passivity fosters non-reflexivity, while reactionaries’ unrestrained emotional expressiveness amplifies anti-democratic rhetoric. This asymmetry erodes the ethos of democracy and inadvertently

implicates mainstreamers. The authors extend discussions of non-reflexivity, noting how mainstreamers often rely on cognitive justifications or express only non-threatening emotions when institutional norms are challenged (Delmestri & Goodrick, 2016). They also build on the notion of anti-reflexivity as strategic—avoiding the self confrontation required to address the consequences of modernization, such as climate change and inequality. While non-reflexivity and anti-reflexivity are typically framed as cognitive, Malhotra and Voronov foreground a socio political emotional anti-reflexivity, in which mainstreamers become trapped in self-reinforcing cycles of emotional passivity.

Lack of reflexivity also arises in other chapters. Specifically, Costello, Barbera-Tomas and de Bakker (Chapter 14) show how authority claims facilitated by within-group social symbolic work (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019) impedes others' reflexive understanding; and Pouthier and Ma (Chapter 7) touch on the individual struggles that emerge when institutional goals are non-reflexively accepted, leading to melancholic paralysis.

While these depictions show that a lack of reflexivity fosters harmful institutional erosion or the reproduction of toxic institutional arrangements, the chapters also show how reflexivity is a key facet in more productive organizing. Ruebottom and Toubiana (Chapter 10) suggest that the pathway out of hate will require reflexivity—critically challenging one's own assumptions and the norms of the community. Pouthier and Ma (Chapter 7) argue that academics can reject or resist emotional cultures that privileges speed, competition, productivity, and performativity through reflexivity; through critical exploration, individuals can purposively relearn to enjoy a collective, connected, and generative approach to slow learning, thereby regaining temporal autonomy. Thus, challenging institutional arrangements can be taken on through individual responses, creating new embodied expressions and ways of working (Creed et al., 2010). Goswami and Smolka's (Chapter 17) chapter extends these insights. They present instances of bodily reflexivity in which Indigenous people use the body as a source, conduit, and canvas for the expression of values and emotions that challenge the dominant institutional arrangements.

These studies highlight the importance of individual reflexivity, which has particular relevance for leadership. In their exploration of leadership reflection and sense-making, Espedal and Askeland (Chapter 6) identify that leaders integrate emotions and values through four distinct reflexive pathways: fostering relational practices within organizations, establishing motivational objectives, promoting coherent leadership, and initiating moral dialogues. April and Downes (Chapter 21) also delve into this issue, showing how

reflexivity is a component of leaders' emotional maturity that helps them deal with institutional complexity. Emotional and moral maturity generated by reflexivity enable leaders to address conflicting demands, enhance decision-making, and sustain organizational trust. Teams can also be a critical resource for generating reflexivity and change. Eriksen and Løvaas (Chapter 19) describe the role of emotions and values for institutional innovation, which includes new ways of organizing, new structures, new mindsets, new practices, and processes in organizations that disrupt institutional arrangements. The authors present a deeper understanding of the interplay between emotions and values within innovation in two global faith-based organizations, indicating the role of emotions and values both as a starting point for innovation (i.e., ashamed of current practices), as well as nurturing the ongoing innovative processes (i.e., feeling safe to voice concerns).

Several chapters address how such reflexivity can be generated through an inquiry. In the work of Jimenez Pena and Toubiana (Chapter 2), we find an illustration of how the embeddedness of values and emotions in institutional logics gives rise to institutional complexity and contradictions, which provide a starting point for deliberating and act as a source of reflexivity and agency (Friedland & Alford, 1991; Seo & Creed, 2002; Thornton et al., 2012). Indeed, contradictions were pivotal in Ruebottom and Toubiana's (Chapter 10) chapter, as the trigger for individuals to question their hate for certain groups. Next, Edwards, Grigoletto, Alves, and Momesso (Chapter 15) provide a conceptual framework to explain the motivations underlying reflexive inquiries, offering valuable insights into the interplay between emotions and values in evaluation and reflection within institutional processes. Espedal and Struminska-Kutra (Chapter 26) show how various leadership practices cultivate a heightened reflexive consciousness regarding emotions and values in organizations. They propose a three-step process designed to enhance leaders' awareness of emotions and values at work: identifying the issues that engage awareness of emotions and values; recognizing the emotions and values that arise in specific situations; assessing the stakes involved and how they relate to sense-making; and finally, determining appropriate actions to address the situation effectively. Similarly, Espedal (Chapter 12) discusses how the enactment and institutionalization of compassion as an organizational value unfold through a reflexive process of value inquiry; such inquiry entails, for instance, storytelling paired with purposeful and shared discussion about the role of compassion. Tappel and Løvaas (Chapter 18) show how several value-driven processes—"inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing"—are integral to creating space

of belonging. As a complement to these process-based chapters, Wright (Chapter 23) presents methodological tools suited for situated and reflexive processes of inquiry involving values and emotions.

The chapters in this Handbook show that reflexivity, as well as non-reflexivity and anti-reflexivity, are all critical factors animating or deadening institutional processes. They demonstrate that, for better or worse, emotions and values are crucial analytical entry points for the exploration of reflexive processes. But they also show that within these processes, reflexive inquiry, working with and through values and emotions, can ultimately help us determine what is worth having, doing, and being. These chapters open the door to new avenues of research. Critically, we recommend a focus on reflexivity as intimately tied to emotions and values, as interconnected constellations rather than separate entities. By examining how these constructs interact with each other, we can gain deeper insights into their combined effects on institutional dynamics. An interconnected approach will offer a more comprehensive understanding of the complexities of institutional life, and improve our ability to tackle the challenges that arise within these systems.

Ambiguity and ambivalence in organizational institutionalism. The next theme that emerges within the chapters of this Handbook involves both ambiguity and ambivalence. Several of the chapters in this volume address the role of interpreting and reinterpreting ambiguous realities, our often-ambivalent experiences of social arrangements, and the uncertain commitments we have to actions that maintain, disrupt, or reform those arrangements. Often, our interpretations struggle with rendering tacit, fuzzy institutional phenomena sufficiently concrete as to inform our choices.

Attempts to clarify institutional ambiguity and cut through ambivalence often draw on emotions and values to guide the way. For example, Fioravente and Vaccaro (Chapter 4) describe the role of invoking overarching values in navigating between competing or hybrid goals. Attention to overarching values can be consequential in shaping strategic orientation and collective decision-making. Lou and Stensaker (Chapter 22) explore how: the ambiguity of competing institutional demands makes leaders' decision-making difficult; the acknowledgement of ambiguity, though, enables executives to integrate the competing demands, consider additional factors in a slower, recursive, and values-based decision-making process, ultimately leading to better outcomes. Jellema and Werner (Chapter 11) discuss purpose-driven organizing as an emerging institutional form. Within this context, they describe how emotions and values interact during times of organizational ambiguity. They show how members' strong emotional attachment to their values can both inspire commitment to purpose and, when confronted

with value pluralism, generate tensions and conflict as members fight to safeguard their value-infused activities from perceived threats. The chapter highlights how purpose is continuously negotiated through these value-laden and emotional dynamics and emphasizes the critical role of leadership in managing such tensions.

While ambiguity and ambivalence can complicate decision-making processes and animate conflict, clarifying ambiguity through our emotions and values does not necessarily clear the air. Instead, resolving ambiguity can lead to destructive outcomes, as shown in Herland's chapter (Chapter 24), which explores the uncertainty facing social workers, particularly in potential sexual abuse cases. Because of the secrecy that often pervades sexual abuse, it is often difficult to know what is happening, raising ethical dilemmas regarding the well-being of children and their families. This can become overwhelming and lead to avoidance. On the other hand, acknowledging and attending to uncertainty, without necessarily resolving it, can strengthen the choices we make.

In contrast, two chapters explore the ambiguities of a seemingly clear and well-established value, specifically that of academic freedom (Pouthier and Ma Chapter 7, and Gorska Chapter 8). These chapters show how academic freedom is being reinterpreted, weakened, or passively silenced and how such changes generate emotional dissonance that leads to alienation and "academic melancholia" (Pouthier and Ma) and can ultimately drive academics from the profession (Gorska). Overall, these chapters raise critical questions about the role of emotions and values in navigating the ambivalence and ambiguity within institutional processes.

While most of the chapters highlight the struggles with institutional ambiguity and ambivalence, emotions and values are themselves multifarious, and when operating in concert, often ambiguous. Flores and Kraatz (Chapter 3) present how numerous contemporary institutional challenges, such as threats to professional identity stemming from institutional pluralism, involve intricate interrelations between pluralistic values and emotions. Ahmad and Phillips (Chapter 13) tackle the complexity and, indeed, ambiguity of empathy in mental health services provided by AI chatbots. They highlight how users experience genuine emotional benefits from interactions with systems incapable of feeling emotions themselves, illuminating broader questions about how we conceptualize emotional competence and connection. Rather than simply asking whether AI can simulate human empathy, additional questions arise, such as whether these technologies are reshaping institutional understandings of empathy and other feelings, and the nature and value of authenticity. Indeed, Wang, Yuan, and Lounsbury (Chapter 5)

and Jimenez Pena and Toubiana (Chapter 2) conceptualize emotions as interpretations of bodily sensation, an interpretation that is made through the lens of institutional understandings, in order to render our experiences intelligible. These authors propose a constitutive ontology that pushes us to see that emotions are constructed by institutions in ways that are intimately connected to what we value.

While many of these chapters show that we often seek to clarify institutional ambiguity and address the ambivalence surrounding emotions and values, there remains a significant need for further research in this area. Future inquiries could helpfully illuminate how institutional ambiguity interacts with overarching frameworks, such as logics, and the benefits of value pluralism. This includes exploring the implications of such ambiguity for professional practice and decision-making. Research could investigate how emotions and values influence the interpretation and navigation of ambiguous situations in various professional contexts, particularly in fields like social work, healthcare, and education. Additionally, the link between ambiguity in institutional arrangements and our ambivalent responses offers a new perspective on values and emotions, one that may be particularly relevant in times of increasing polarization and societal conflict.

Embodied and aesthetic perspectives on values and emotions. To fully understand the links between emotions, values, and institutional processes, some chapters in this Handbook employ embodied and aesthetic perspectives. Such work aims to provide a more holistic picture of how emotions and values figure into our lived experiences of organizations and organizing.

A focus on embodied and aesthetic dynamics is particularly useful for illuminating how institutions are, quite literally, inhabited by people (Hallett & Ventresca, 2006), as they “encounter, evaluate and enact institutions” (Creed et al., 2020, p. 415). The two chapters by Wang, Yuan, and Lounsbury (Chapter 5) and Jimenez Pena and Toubiana (Chapter 2) articulate a new perspective on emotions that is inherently rooted in institutions. In their constitutive perspective, bodily activation in response to a situation is interpreted as a specific emotion through our internalized understanding of the institutional norms in play and the emotions that are then expected.

Two other chapters focus on how our bodies move through the world (Ruebottom & Toubiana, in press). Goswami and Smolka (Chapter 17) connect values and emotion work to body work: as actors engage in social action, their bodies become both instruments and products of actions. In their chapter, the bodies of Indigenous people become an active site where social structures, cultural meanings, and individual agency intersect. In a very different context, Ruebottom and Toubiana (Chapter 10) describe how the

embodiment of hate shapes a person's dispositions, comportment, and ways of interacting with others. Hate becomes embodied through the broad stance, the strong, forceful movements, and twisted facial expressions; it is in the voice that reveals the emotion, the tone of disgust. Yet, critically, in both of these examples, the ways of using the body enable connection with others in the community.

Indeed, embodied perspectives can illuminate important aspects of belonging, as illustrated by Tappel and Løvaas (Chapter 18). A sense of institutional belonging includes processes of inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing fostering a strong sense of community. Additionally, Neher, Wuersch, and Small (Chapter 20) describe perspectives on belonging in a pollinator garden on the university campus, and the embodied interplay between “self-work, organizational, and institutional work.” Embodied belonging and community connections are thus inherently expressions of emotions and values within a given institutional context.

Thus, these chapters bring to light a collective sense of embodiment—the ways of being and of seeing that are shared by community members. For example, in Ruebottom and Toubiana's chapter (Chapter 10), members of hate communities often have typical body language when greeting each other or in dancing to music or other celebrations; in these shared bodily expressions of hate, they argue that individuals in the community feel a sense of comfort, support, and belonging. In Goswami and Smolka's chapter, “boys wearing braids” and other symbols of Indigenous culture will feel different when they are in an Indigenous community surrounded by others who are similarly styled; when the person is in a primarily settler community and they are the only one in braids, the experience is not likely to be as comfortable—our embodied expressions are experienced differently depending on the embodied expressions of the group we are in. This is reminiscent of Merleau-Ponty's (1968) concept of *intercorporeality*, which he argued was a more helpful concept than intersubjectivity for understanding how people experience the social world as interacting bodies.

As such, emotions and values are deeply entrenched in and mediated by our bodies. We encourage future research to draw on embodied and aesthetic perspectives when investigating emotions and values in institutions. Such research is critical to questioning and rethinking our assumptions about how institutions both constrain and enable, how communities come together, and the possibilities for action. Investigating typical body language or language that includes aesthetic assumptions will be of importance to understand the depth of institutions and the take-for-granted and invisible forces that drive institutions.

The dark side of emotions, values, and institutional processes. Through institutional processes, we enact the very best and the very worst of human nature. The arena of values and emotions often carries inherently positive connotations, although the picture is often much more complex. Some of the chapters in the Handbook dive into the darker side of emotions, values, and institutional processes.

Values, in particular, are most often considered to be positive in the literature. However, the designation of what is valuable and desirable is only one side of the value coin; value research must also grapple with what is deemed useless or even despicable. In this vein, Sharma and Amis (Chapter 16) uncover the role that values play in sustaining social inequalities amid shifting institutional arrangements in rural India. They develop the concept of moral indebtedness to describe how obligations to reciprocate perceived favors that are embedded within a patron–client exchange relationships, are shaping participation in changing economic relations. While these values can legitimize new hierarchies and reproduce caste-class rigidities, the chapter also reveals how emotions such as anger and discontent can generate possibilities for contesting these seemingly entrenched arrangements.

In another example, a workforce driven by strong, yet diverse values might struggle to agree on common goals or operational methods due to value pluralism, as in Jellema and Werner's (Chapter 11) chapter. And in an institutional field that values objectivity and certainty, there can be no time to resolve feelings of uncertainty and doubt, leading to high levels of emotional distress among workers, as in Herland (Chapter 24).

The institutional processes explored in this Handbook also surface the role of negative emotions within our social world. Malhotra and Voronov (Chapter 9) present the dark side of emotional suppression, whereby the majority are not always emotionally engaged to fight for and maintain democratic values, thus making critical institutions vulnerable to erosion. Additionally, the chapters explore particular negative emotions. While attention has been given to the moral emotion of shame (e. g., Creed et al., 2014; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024), the chapters of Pouthier and Ma (Chapter 7) and Gorska (Chapter 8) explore a much wider range of negative emotions, such as melancholia, alienation, and emotional exhaustion. Uncertainty and doubt are explored in Herland (Chapter 24), emotional strain in Lou and Stensaker (Chapter 22), and hate in Ruebottom and Toubiana's chapter (Chapter 10).

Even in the context of social entrepreneurship and social purpose business, which are assumed to be formed from emotions of compassion and other-oriented, pro-social values, there can be deeper negative emotions at

play. The chapter by Prokopovych (Chapter 25) shows that leaders' stories are predominantly laced with negative sentiment as they explain the challenges before they can rise to a hopeful conclusion. Jellema and Werner (Chapter 11) show how value heterogeneity and democratic leadership in social purpose businesses can lead to tension, conflict, and apathy.

While these chapters present a rather bleak picture of our social world, understanding the often obscured and unpredictable negative emotions and values that underpin institutional processes can allow people to more successfully challenge these situations.

The Content of the Handbook

In exploring each of these themes, the Handbook brings together a vibrant collection of scholarly approaches, showcasing the diverse ways in which emotions, values, and institutions are theorized, investigated, and reflected upon. Some chapters employ conceptual explorations that use empirical cases only for illustrative purposes, others engage in empirical explorations of the value-emotion-institution interface, while others pursue methodological and practical reflections on emotions and values. The discussions presented in this volume reflect the knowledge and experiences of 48 scholars from diverse geographical locations, including Canada, the US, the UK, Portugal, India, Spain, the Netherlands, Norway, Ukraine, Poland, South Africa, Australia, and Brazil.

To facilitate the theoretical conversation, we organized the Handbook into four overarching sections. The first section dives into emotions and values in the institutional context, considering the theoretical implications of a joint analysis of values and emotions in organizational institutionalism. In the second section, the chapters provide a focused exploration of emotions and values work, examining how each field engages with and informs the other. The third section presents empirical cases showing how emotion and values are enacted and practiced in different contexts. Finally, a fourth section presents chapters that rethink methodology in researching emotions and values, and practical approaches to values and emotions within organizations and leadership.

Part 1. Emotions and Values in the Institutional Context

The first section of the Handbook consists of conceptual chapters bringing emotions and values together. Here we present chapters that delve into the

theoretical implications of integrating emotions and values, for example, by illustrating how institutional logics or institutional leadership bring emotions and values to the forefront, and how emotions and values are together implicated in processes of reflexivity, ambiguity and embodiment, as well as the darker side of these.

We start the section with the chapter by Jimenez Peña and Toubiana (Chapter 2) theorizing how values, emotions, and institutional logics intersect. They argue that separating values and emotions can facilitate the understanding of these discrete concepts; however, it undermines more general progress in the study of institutional logics. Thus, in the chapter, they seek to discuss the intricate embeddedness of values, emotions, and institutional logics, bringing together Nussbaum's philosophical approach with Feldman Barrett's neuropsychology of emotions.

Next, we present two papers that theorize from the point of research on values, which aim to integrate emotions in order to understand institutional dynamics. Flores and Kraatz (Chapter 3) posit an overarching values-centric institutional approach that integrates perspectives on emotions. By facilitating a dialogue between perspectives of values-centric institutionalism (Selznick, 1957) and people-centered research on emotions in institutional life (Creed et al., 2020, 2022), they present a theoretical understanding of the joint influence of values and emotions. They build on these literatures to bring forward the concepts of evaluative embodiment (the individual-level process through which abstract values become lived commitments) and emotional-historical sedimentation (the institutional-level crystallization of accumulated embodied patterns), which can provide a launchpad for future research.

Fioravante and Vaccaro (Chapter 4) introduce the concept of *overarching value* in organizations. Drawing on evidence from a social enterprise, they show how the most critical core value serves as a universal guiding principle, providing coherence, legitimacy, and ethical direction during uncertain situations within organizations. The chapter critically examines debates surrounding moral values, particularly their connection to humanistic values, and the role of values work, where values often emerge and evolve dynamically in relation to emotions.

Next, we turn to the way institutions construct emotions. Wang, Yuan, and Lounsbury (Chapter 5) re-paraphrase Mary Douglas' book title on "how institutions think" to "how institutions *feel*."¹ They argue that the

¹ Douglas, M. (1986). *How institutions think*. Syracuse University Press.

interpretation of emotions in institutions is composed of two parts: physiological activation and interpretation, which is based on a person's experiential learning within particular institutional contexts. In a constitutive ontology, they emphasize that emotions do not exist separately from the field; they are instead enabled by institutional ways of interpreting the world and what is valued within it. In doing so, they open up new conversations about the ways emotions are embedded in and shape institutional processes.

Espedal and Askeland (Chapter 6) then go to the foundations of institutional leadership. They theorize the role emotion plays in safeguarding and promoting values. They recognize emotions alongside values and how they involve four key qualities in leadership: fostering relational practices within organizations, setting motivational aims, advancing leadership coherence, and initiating moral dialogues. Paying attention to the link between emotion and values enhances our understanding of sense-making within the institutional leadership tradition.

Part 2. Emotions and Values: A Focused Exploration

In the second section of the Handbook, we provide chapters that bring a focused exploration to particular emotions and values at work. In doing so, these chapters unpack how emotions and values unfold and impact institutional processes.

To begin, Pouthier and Ma (Chapter 7) delve into the concept of academic melancholia by describing the affective injuries of surviving “excellence” in neoliberal universities. Investigating the academic workers’ auto-ethnographic and collective biographical accounts, they constitute the haunting of academic melancholia and chart an affective path forward. They add to the literature on institutional control, oppression, and resistance by underscoring the paralyzing impact of melancholia, but also the emancipatory potential that can emerge from these affective injuries.

Gorska (Chapter 8) delves into the academic landscape from the values field as a point of departure. The value of intellectual freedom faces significant challenges amid political pressures and neoliberal reforms marked by metrics-driven performance indicators that undermine genuine knowledge production and contribute to alienation and emotional exhaustion. The author examines these dynamics, shedding light on how emotions and values shape experiences within the institutional contexts of academia, continued participation, and the future of the value of academic freedom.

Malhotra and Voronov (Chapter 9) examine how asymmetries in emotional expressiveness between mainstreamers and reactionaries drive the

erosion of democratic institutions. They argue that mainstreamers' restrained emotional engagement - shaped by cycles of tolerance, denial, and adherence to norms of civility-stands in stark contrast to reactionaries' unrestrained, emotionally charged rhetoric. This growing asymmetry emboldens reactionary forces and accelerates the hollowing out of democracy's foundational ethos. The chapter illuminates how remaining trapped in cycles of emotional passivity, mainstreamers inadvertently become complicit in legitimating the very forces undermining the democratic ethos they hold dear.

Next, Ruebottom and Toubiana (Chapter 10) explore a pathway leading from shame to hate. They unpack the individual, collective, and institutional processes that constitute a trajectory from the moral emotion of shame to an embodied hate habitus, which then serves as a defense against the return of shame. The authors posit that escaping this cycle of shame-hate is challenging but possible through reflective practices that dismantle the hate habitus, but also, importantly, avoid a return to shame.

Jellema and Werner (Chapter 11) articulate how value-driven organizations may grapple with the complexities of collective sense-making when formulating a new purpose. They demonstrate how strong emotional attachments to personal values can amplify value heterogeneity and challenge collective alignment around a new purpose and highlight the importance of leadership in managing these tensions in ways to connect personal commitments to broader organizational aims.

How compassion becomes institutionalized through values work is the aim of Espedal's chapter (Chapter 12). With inspiration from Nussbaum (1996), she conceptualizes institutionalized compassion as a form of reasoning of values and a social-emotional response to alleviating pain. Drawing on a case from a faith-based healthcare organization, the chapter highlights how emotional awareness supports work on values, as a way of bridging connections between individuals and the community through a process of compassion-in-work.

Pointing to the challenges of AI-mediated emotional support in organizational settings, Ahmad and Phillips (Chapter 13) use Carl Rogers' person-centered therapy framework to critically examine empathy in the emergence of AI chatbots. The authors analyze how these AI systems emulate only some aspects of Rogerian therapeutic relationships. The integration of AI into emotional support roles represents not merely a technological innovation but a profound institutional transformation that challenges fundamental assumptions about emotional authenticity, human connection, and organizational responsibility.

Moving to the challenges that emotions and values offer in polarized public discourse, particularly within social media environments, Castello, Barberá-Tomás, and de Bakker (Chapter 14) theorize the framing of emotions, values, and symbols. They identify ways in which emotion-symbolic work shapes polarization, for instance, through authority claims negotiated through the crafting of symbols; by enabling strategic interactions aimed at influencing meaning; and by promoting small-group cohesion through the circulation of symbols.

Edwards, Grigoletto, Alves, and Momesso (Chapter 15) delve into the institutional concept of shared world of concern (Creed et al., 2022). Their approach aims to investigate how these concerns influence both individual and collective participation in and understanding of institutional processes. The authors map the antecedents, highlighting the sedimented and embedded nature of the experiences, values, and concerns that then shape the engagement of family farmers in negotiations.

Part 3. Practicing Emotions and Values in Context

In the third section of the Handbook, we showcase empirical studies. These empirical studies illustrate the ways in which emotions and values are enmeshed in institutional processes within and through organizations and individuals.

Sharma and Amis (Chapter 16) show how inequality can be maintained despite extensive changes to institutional practices. Through a case study that illustrates the dependency between an Indian agricultural technology enterprise and rural farmers, they demonstrate how *moral indebtedness* remains as a detrimental value structuring the economic relationship. Despite acute awareness of disadvantaged status, farmers' adherence to moral indebtedness facilitates their sustained participation in unequal labor arrangements, reinforcing inequalities. Despite the situation, which caused emotions of anger among farmers, they remained in the situation, demonstrating the strength of their values.

Goswami and Smolka (Chapter 17) identify three modes whereby body work is practically embedded in and connected to values work and emotion work—namely, body as source, body as conduit, and body as canvas. They leverage a qualitative study of Indigenous actors from the Canadian province of Saskatchewan and build a framework that explains how values, emotions, and body work are intrinsically connected and serve as drivers of various forms of social action.

Tappel and Løvaas (Chapter 18) provide an empirical example at the organizational level of how emotions and values influence institutional processes by examining how actors organize for belonging. Based on a study of a religious organization with extensive experience in creating belonging in everyday work, the chapter foregrounds how actions of inquiring, valuing, empowering, training, and trusting play a role in organizing for belonging for the volunteers, organizational members, and communities.

Eriksen and Løvaas (Chapter 19) describe the role of emotions and values for institutional innovation, which includes new products and services, as well as new ways of organizing, structuring, and practicing in organizations. The authors present a deeper understanding of the interplay between emotions and values within innovation in two global faith-based organizations, indicating the role of emotions and values both as a starting point for innovation (i.e., ashamed of current practices), as well as nurturing the ongoing innovative processes (i.e., feeling safe to voice concerns).

Neher, Wuersch, and Small (Chapter 20) show how establishing a community garden as a practical grassroots initiative enhances the related values and emotions work. Their investigation of a pollinator garden project at a regional university in Australia, focuses on how self-work, organizational work, and institutional work are woven into the project, promoting environmental sustainability and strengthening local communities.

The emotional aspects of shaping leadership roles are elaborated in the chapter by April and Downes (Chapter 21). Their study demonstrates how emotional and moral maturity together create the micro-foundations for reflexivity, principled decision-making, and institutional trust, and thus becomes a critical construct for practical and effective leadership. Emotional maturity encompasses the ethical and contextual application of emotional competence, informed by institutionally relevant moral considerations, social positioning, and power dynamics. The chapter discusses how leaders with emotional maturity are adept at leveraging emotions; and how this knowledge reinforces moral maturity and values, creating cultures of trust and shared purpose.

In a similar vein, Lou and Stensaker (Chapter 22) present how leaders can work toward emotional equanimity by exploring values and emotions. Their study shows that executives who adopt a slow, circular, values-based decision-making process, guided by their personal values and what “feels right,” are more effective. To compensate for the emotional strain caused by the tensions of competing logics, executives strive for emotional equanimity by balancing a values-based personal purpose with ongoing self-care.

Part 4. Rethinking Methodologies and Practices

The fourth and final section features chapters that re-evaluate methodologies for researching emotions and values, along with practical strategies for fostering discussion about these concepts within organizations and leadership.

Wright (Chapter 23) opens up the methodological conversation explaining how to undertake field studies to generate empirically based and reflexive insight into the relationships between values and emotions. The chapter proposes three approaches—theory-centered, phenomenon-centered, and personhood-centered—for uncovering both/and insights on emotions and values within institutional processes. Each approach has unique foci and represent different choices that field researchers make about how and where to center their attention. These methodologies have important implications for the different ways that values and emotions potentially show up in data and analysis, as well as the potential theoretical contributions that we are able to make.

Then moving to practice, Herland (Chapter 24) examines the ambivalent relationship between emotions and values in professional social work. More precisely, she aims to develop an empirically grounded theoretical framework that re-examines the role of emotions and uncertainty in cases of child abuse. The emotional toll of the profession is often treated as a negative side effect or an individual problem, akin to burnout. However, an alternative view can be identified that integrates emotions and interconnected professional instincts into the organizational and institutional structures of social care workplaces. Thus, the author advocates for fostering an organizational environment that supports emotional literacy, aligning professional practitioners with their organizations, while also recognizing the profession as an institution with its own rules and standards.

Prokopovych (Chapter 25) investigates how social entrepreneurs start out by leveraging negative emotional language in their narratives to engage with societal issues and values in Ted Talks. Given the extensive research on how social entrepreneurs tackle complex social challenges, the findings show that social entrepreneurs generally use negative emotional language and take their audiences on a tumultuous journey throughout their stories. This chapter enhances our understanding of how entrepreneurs manipulate emotions in their emotion-symbolic work. The performative use of emotion allows the storytellers to frame themselves as both credible and transformative, as people addressing pressing societal issues and values.

In the epilogue of the Handbook Espedal and Struminska-Kutra (Chapter 26) examine the role of leaders in shaping emotions and values

within organizations. To understand how leaders impact emotions and values, they examine leadership *moves*, defined as steps taken to be conscious of emotions and values in organizations, relating to how to act and make decisions. They propose a three-step process for leaders to enhance awareness of emotion and values at work: First, identifying the issues that engage consciousness of emotions and values; second, recognizing the emotions and values evoked in the situation; third, assessing what is at stake in the situation and how it relates to sense-making; and finally, identifying the actions that should be taken to recognize the situation.

In sum, the Handbook offers a rich and multifaceted exploration of the interplay between emotions, values, and institutions, drawing on a wide range of theoretical, empirical, and methodological perspectives. By organizing the contributions into four thematic sections, we provide a coherent structure that guides readers through the complexities of this unique terrain, making it a valuable resource for researchers, practitioners, and students seeking to deepen their understanding of how emotions and values shape, and are shaped by, institutional processes.

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Part II

The Emotions and Values in the Institutional Context



2

Inhabiting the Heart of a Crossroad: The Intersection of Values, Emotions, and Institutional Logics

Carolina Jiménez Peña and Madeline Toubiana

The study of emotions and values in institutional theory, and logics in particular, has been increasing during the last decade (e.g., Dalpiaz et al., 2016; Lee & Lounsbury, 2015; Vedula et al., 2022; Vince, 2019; Voronov & Weber, 2016; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018). This focus has been incredibly enriching for institutional theory. We have begun to see the ways in which values shape and construct logics (Bento da Silva et al., 2022), the ways in which logics have registers of emotion (Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017), and how emotions can drive change of logics (Sadeh & Zilber, 2019). All of this has contributed to our understanding of the “coalface” or the “micro-sociology” of institutional theory (Barley, 2008, p. 495).

These advances have tended to come independently, and most scholars have invoked a perspective that engages values *or* emotions. Yet, we know that emotions can also be considered judgments of value (Nussbaum, 2003), and as such emotions and values may be seen as intimately intertwined (Friedland, 2018). In this chapter we seek to engage scholarship that has explored values and emotions in the institutional logic perspective to better understand how we might move forward to a more integrated perspective.

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Emotions and Values: Growing (and Separate) Conversations

We began by searching the *EBSCO-Business Source Complete* for articles that were published in the top management journals (using the Financial Times list). We used the search terms “institutional logics” AND (emotion* OR values) in all available fields within the database to retrieve the most comprehensive results possible. This search yielded 68 articles.¹ The references were imported into Covidence, a specialized software for managing literature reviews. There, the system identified 4 duplicates, leaving a total of 64 articles to be screened against title and abstract to ensure they were effectively at the intersection of institutional logics and values/and or emotions, leaving at the end a sample of 43 articles that were further analyzed by looking at the full text to ensure the aforementioned criterion was fully addressed. During the course of writing the paper, if we became aware of new papers that met this criterion, we read them and added them to the review. In the end we closely reviewed 47 articles. This search is not meant to be exhaustive, but rather a starting point to explore the ways in which these conversations have begun to be tackled. Our hope is that this initial inquiry and the trajectory we propose, will trigger more elaborate reviews and empirical work.

What we discovered through our reading was that there has been growth in the number of papers engaging these topics, but, as suspected, the papers have tended to be about logics and values *or* logics and emotion. While eleven papers do mention both values, emotions and logics, only five deeply integrate all three in their theorizing.

Values and Institutional Logics

While there are many different ways of defining or conceptualizing values, we found the literature tended to avoid discussions of what values are directly and instead focused on their role or function in a given empirical setting, and as being part of an institutional logic.²

Across the papers our analysis revealed that the majority focused on the ways in which values intersect and shape (or are shaped by) institutional logics. For example, a number of papers examine what values do to logics (Bento da Silva et al., 2022; Lee & Lounsbury, 2015; Sonpar et al., 2009;

¹ Last search conducted on May 29th, 2025.

² This would not be the case if we were looking at values more generally, but our search targeted work on values and institutional logics.

Yin & Jamali, 2021). Bento da Silva and colleagues (2022) showcase this in their paper on the “mysterious” side of institutional logics, where institutional values such as love, and spirituality are core to the logic itself and form the very essence of the logic through being deliberately conceived as transcendental and mysterious. These transcendental values shape the logic itself and ensure its endurance for centuries.

Another stream of papers, focus on the ways logics themselves dictate and shape values (Almandoz, 2014; Bishop & Waring, 2016; Braga et al., 2021; Brown et al., 2018; Chaudhary et al., 2025; Clarysse et al., 2023; Dalpiaz et al., 2016; Gillett et al., 2019; Gruban & Feix, 2024; Kyratsis et al., 2017; Lewis & Carlos, 2022; Lo & Li, 2018; Luo et al., 2019; Mars et al., 2023; Newenham-Kahindi & Stevens, 2025; Power, 2021; Tan & Wang, 2011; Vedula et al., 2022; Vickers et al., 2017; Vurro et al., 2010; Xiao et al., 2025). Braga and colleagues (2021) show that the ways in which human resource managers conceive different issues as being ethical or not, and the way in which they respond to ethical dilemmas are both dictated by the values embedded in the institutional logic of their profession and their countries (i.e., Brazil, Colombia, and the UK). In a similar vein, Vurro and colleagues (2010) propose a typology of how configurations of institutional logics can shape cross-sector social partnerships (CSSPs). Values in this case are considered as embedded in the different institutional logics, and institutional logics are considered to shape the different decisions around building CSSPs, including the very decision of how to address social issues. For example, it is the configuration of logics that is theorized to influence the use of social values instead of self-interest when building the partnership.

Kraatz and colleagues (2020) have stated previously that while “values operate at multiple levels of society (Agle & Caldwell, 1999; Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004; Smith, 1991), it is conventional to view values as personal beliefs” (p. 476). We discovered, however, that across the papers we reviewed it was more common to see values as theorized as a component of institutional logics (Almandoz, 2014; Bento da Silva et al., 2022; Bishop & Waring, 2016; Botha & Hamann, 2025; Braga et al., 2021; Brown, 2022; Castellás et al., 2019; Chaudhary et al., 2025; Clarysse et al., 2023; Dalpiaz et al., 2016; Drencheva & Au, 2023; Gillett et al., 2019; Gruban & Feix, 2024; Hedberg & Lounsbury, 2021; Lee & Lounsbury, 2015; Lewis & Carlos, 2022; Lo & Li, 2018; Luo et al., 2019; Mars et al., 2023; Newenham-Kahindi & Stevens, 2025; Pallas et al., 2016; Power, 2021; Thorén et al., 2018; Vedula et al., 2022; Vickers et al., 2017; Vurro et al., 2010; Xiao et al., 2025; Yin & Jamali, 2021). This perspective sees values as internal to the logic, and reflects the very definition of institutional logics given by Thornton and colleagues

(2012): “the socially constructed, historical patterns of cultural symbols and material practices, including assumptions, *values*, and beliefs, by which individuals and organizations provide meaning to their daily activity, organize time and space, and reproduce their lives and experiences” (p. 2).

Across these papers, values are conceptualized as core to logics and part of their very constitution. Many papers point this out in different ways with different implications. For example, Lee and Lounsbury (2015) describe logics (and in this paper the community logic in particular) as having “a strong value basis” (p. 847). In a similar vein, Pallas and colleagues (2016) show how institutional logics are translated inside organizations; they are interpreted, endowed of local meaning, and consequently the value systems attached to the logics become enacted within these localized spheres. Pushing this perspective further, Hedberg and Lounsbury (2021) recently proposed that even though values are core to the logic, they can be decoupled (and recoupled) from it for strategic purposes. In this way they seem to suggest that while values are tied to a given logic, they can be disentangled—giving space or opportunity for values outside of the logic to be brought in—albeit temporarily—in situations of complexity.

Although in the majority of the articles, values are thus institutionally constructed and defined by the institutional logic, a few papers do lean into the traditional view of values as personal beliefs (Anderson-Gough et al., 2022; Braga et al., 2021; Kraatz et al., 2020; Kyratsis et al., 2017; Sonpar et al., 2009; Tan & Wang, 2011). For example, Sonpar and colleagues (2009) state that values that are in the logic can be influential at the macro level, but it is the individual values that will shape the enactment and *interpretation* of the logic and its values. In this case, trust is considered a personal value that interacts with the institutional logic in shaping action. In this view individuals are seen as having more agency in their engagement and understanding of the values inside of the logic.

In summary, the literature has focused on the impact of values on logics, or logics on values—both foci revealing the central and critical role they play in institutional dynamics. In addition, while conceptions of value remain highly institutional, there is movement to consider the multiple ways in which values operate. Work that suggests values can be decoupled and recoupled, and are also shaped by personal values, highlighting that values have dynamism in relation to logics.

Emotions and Institutional Logics

In contrast with the number of articles on values and institutional logics, we found there were less focused on emotions and institutional logics (e.g., Jarvis, 2017; Sadeh & Zilber, 2019; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017). Indeed, this is likely the result of the stage of development of work on values versus emotions in organization theory. Values being a more longstanding topic of interest, and emotions being more recent (Voronov & Vince, 2012; Voronov & Weber, 2016, 2017; Zhang et al., 2023; Zietsma et al., 2019).

Across the papers on logics and emotions we can see that emotions are often studied as triggering action which implicates a logic in various ways. For example, Jarvis (2017) argues that emotional displays that are strategically used by individuals to achieve specific goals, can become typified and, through repeated enactment, may achieve a taken-for-granted status, eventually shaping institutional logics. Sadeh and Zilber (2019) show how “unbidden emotions” arise from external events and that emotions can be cultivated and even prescribed to “strengthen a desired constellation of logics” (p. 1414) influencing the way in which the logic is enacted. In this sense, emotions can have impacts on the enactments and understandings of logics.

Going beyond this people-focused or agentic view of emotions, almost all papers have also acknowledged the ways in which logics themselves shape or prescribe emotions (Botha & Hamann, 2025; Giorgi & Palmisano, 2017; Jarvis, 2017; Sadeh & Zilber, 2019; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017; Tracey, 2016). For example, Toubiana and Zietsma (2017) studied the influence of emotions (e.g., betrayal, shame and anger) in cases of institutional complexity, showing how emotions can be central to institutional dynamics. Perhaps one of the most important insights they make was that not only can emotions trigger disruptive work to challenge logics, but that emotions can be specified by a logic—what they call emotional registers (Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017, p. 923). For example, the care logic has more emotionality permitted within the logic, than does a professional logic where neutrality is expected. This is a point that is also core to Giorgi and Palmisano (2017), in this case, emotions are part of the religious rituals embedded in the logic. While individuals can certainly feel contradictory emotions, a logic can lead individuals to focus and more frequently express the emotions dictated by the logic. Meaning that a logic can prime, activate, or allow certain emotions and not others.

Across the literature, thus, we can see perspectives that acknowledge that emotions can trigger action and engagement with logics, and also that emotions are shaped and constituted in and by logics (Toubiana et al., 2017;

Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017). Even with this acknowledgement it should be noted, that like values, while the literature beyond our review papers primarily adopt a psychological highly individualized views of emotions (Zhang et al., 2023), the papers we study adopt a sociological perspective to emotions. Emotions are thus “intersubjective, collective and relational – conditioned by one’s place in the social world and one’s relationship with others, especially the groups to which one belongs” (Zietsma et al., 2019, p. 4).

Emotions and Values as Distinct or Inextricably Connected?

While we can imagine values and emotions as related, the literature characterizes them quite differently. On one hand, values are treated as rational and enduring. For example, Sonpar and colleagues (2009) suggest that values have strong “rational dimensions” (p. 347), and Almandoz (2014), like others (e.g., Battilana & Dorado, 2010), show how values persist and are even carried by people as they enter distinct domains.

Emotions on the other hand, are rarely conceptualized as rational, and instead are often seen as “irrational” or “illogic” (Vince, 2019, p. 954) and portrayed as more temporary. For example, Vince (2019) proposes what he calls “institutional illogics” as a complementary side of institutional logics that rests on unconscious dynamics. As such, he proposes emotions come from the unconscious, something that contrasts with the rational and cognitive ways in which values are discussed. Jarvis’s (2017) work on emotions and logics highlights the more temporary characterization of emotions. He suggests that emotional displays are sometimes sustained or prolonged (i.e., tightly coupled displays), and are sometimes ephemeral (i.e., diametric feigning). In Sadeh and Zilber (2019) this potential temporariness is also highlighted when they speak to the power of “emotional eruptions”: intense emotions that can “change in other elemental categories of logics during disruptive events” but that are “short-lived” (Sadeh & Zilber, 2019, p. 1430).

Overall, while both emotions and values are seen as shaped by logics with the potential to also shape logics—emotions tend to be temporary and irrational, and values enduring and highly cognitive. Yet this does mean these concepts are incommensurate.

In a handful of studies, we begin to see a picture of how values and emotions might be interrelated, or in other words, how values and emotions are mutually constitutive. For example, Friedland (2018) leans on Weber to

suggest that “feelings are an essential basis of valuation” (p. 517) and he gives the example of love, where love is at the same time a value, an emotion and an institutional logic, thus being inextricably connected.

Vince (2019) points out the importance of understanding the intersection between values and emotions by explaining that values can be understood as “emotion-laden conceptions of the desirable that underlie value-identities” (p. 967). Interestingly in these cases, and in contrast to how emotions are conceptualized when being studied independently from values, emotions are seen as more enduring and institutionally constructed. For example, Brown and colleagues (2012) show how the institutional logic of “age-appropriate care” is favored by the state, which employed moralizing and emotion-evoking rhetorics to catalyze the connection to it. In this case, emotions were used to build a connection to a specific institutional logic and a specific set of values, thus showing emotions as enduring and connected to both values and logics. In this way, when we begin to think of emotions and values as inter-related in their relationship to logics, how we understand all three of these concepts might fundamentally change in the process.

We build off these nascent conversations to propose a theoretical model of the intimate interconnectedness of values, emotions, and institutional logics. Our aim is to stimulate more research at their intersection. To do so we will draw on the work of the philosopher Martha Nussbaum, and the psychologist and neuroscientist Lisa Feldman Barrett.

Re-envisioning Emotions, Values, and Logics

“Severing emotion from belief, it severs emotion from what it is not only a necessary condition itself, but also a part of its very identity.” (Nussbaum, 2003, p. 30)

Nussbaum: Logics as Objects of Value

The literature on institutional logics has articulated how values are institutionally specified within logics—or, said differently, certain values and interests are “embedded within prevailing logics” (Thornton et al., 2012, p. 6). As such, the values associated with one institutional logic may not be equally valued or not valued at all in another logic. Indeed, certain values may

be the very essence of logics³ (Lounsbury et al., 2021) grounding their emergence and quasi-religious qualities (Thornton et al., 2012; Voronov & Weber, 2016, 2017). Here we are not seeking to claim logics are the only place where values reside, but we are emphasizing that core to logics are ideals, interests—and an expectation of valuing that drives practices and the enactment and attachment to logics. In this way, the basis of the relationship between logics, values and emotions we seek to articulate is premised on value(s) specified and tied to logics.

Nussbaum (2003) proposes that values *and* emotions are inextricably tied, in fact she proposes that values are part of the very identity of emotions. Specifically, she argues that emotions are only possible, only felt because of values. Emotions are not, in this way, innate evolutionary physiological reactions, but are tied and possible because of value. In her work she shows that just like societies have different normative teachings around honor, money, and political power, they also have a great variety in experiencing emotions such as anger, love, or grief. She argues that “emotions, [...] involve judgments about important things, judgments in which [we appraise] an external object as salient for our own well-being” (p. 19). In this sense, emotions are tied to an object, emotions are *about* something. Core to her theorizing is that emotions involve the “thought of the object’s salience” (p. 23). This means the object needs to be important and as such, emotions involve evaluation, they are judgments of value. The “aboutness” (p. 28) of emotions, that close relationship with an object of value is part of the very core of what emotions are. We cannot care or feel about something we do not value. In fact, if the object has no value, if we have no interest, there is no emotion at all. In this sense Nussbaum argues that emotions are absent without an object of value (Nussbaum, 2003). As an example of this, Nussbaum discusses the emotion of grief and how the death of a mother is not the same of the death of *my* mother. Even though both are huge losses, the valuation in each case is different and so too is the emotion of grief attached to each object. The object needs to be important to the individual; they need to value it to feel something about it. Nussbaum proposes that our beliefs about an object of value are what discriminate emotions from mere bodily sensations (e.g., rapid heartbeat). If the valued object (including ourselves) is believed to be in imminent danger, fear may arise, if the object is believed to be necessary for our own happiness yet another has it, jealousy may arise, or if the object is

³ While Friedland conceptualizes logics as grounded by an institutional substance—such as romantic love or artistic beauty—which he theorizes as distinct from value (Friedland, 2018, p. 526), we adopt the view of Lounsbury et al. (2021) and use value as a concept that captures aspects of Friedland’s substance but focuses on the interests and ideals inherent to institutional logics.

believed to be lost forever, grief may arise. Thus, judgments of value are both necessary and sufficient conditions for the existence of emotions (Nussbaum, 2003). In a nutshell, emotions are “value-laden ways of understanding the world” (Nussbaum, 2003, p. 88).

Physical conditions, metaphysical, religious and cosmological beliefs, practices and routines, language and social norms, shape emotional life through the definition of what is valued (Nussbaum, 2003). While Nussbaum does not tie her work or theorizing to institutional theory, we see important links here that can help make sense of the intimate connection between logics, values, and emotions. If logics indeed drive and embed values into people who activate or identify with these logics, these values become ways of feeling within the world. Logics, thus, become shapers of what objects of values are—and in doing so the very availability and fabric of an emotional world. Thus, institutional logics are deeply connected to not only values but also—as a result—to the emotions of individuals and societies. As Nussbaum (2003, p. 149) proposes “a person who does not know the emotional “grammar” of his or her society cannot be assumed to have the same emotional life as one who knows this “grammar””. The structure of this “grammar” is embedded in institutions and institutional logics, in the different values constituted and constructed by individuals and organizations inhabiting these institutions.

Feldman-Barrett: Logics as Schemas of Emotion

Lisa Feldman Barrett’s views on emotion can also help us make sense of the connection between logics, emotions, and values. Based on decades of research, she challenges the classic evolutionary view of emotions finding that they are not hardwired and universal but rather constructed by the brain as interpretations of bodily sensations and environmental cues. According to her theory, emotions are not pre-existing essences, but instead emerge from our perceptions, experiences, and cultural context. Feldman Barrett’s model contrasts with the classic view in that it does not assign specific brain regions or fingerprints for each emotion and so challenges the notion of a fixed set of universal emotional expressions. She argues that the brain integrates sensory input from the body with contextual information to create emotional experiences. The brain’s ability to construct emotions from these inputs allows for a wide range of emotional variability and cultural differences. Her research highlights the influence of culture and individual experiences in shaping emotional responses, emphasizing that emotions are not innate and hardwired, but rather flexible and context-dependent.

Like Nussbaum, Feldman Barrett suggests that emotions are not innate. However, for Feldman Barrett (2018) it is not merely value that specifies emotion, it is prediction. “You feel what your brain believes. Affect primarily comes from prediction ... Your brain employs concepts to make the sensory signals meaningful, create an explanation for where they came from, what they refer to in the world, and how to act on without needing fingerprints” (p. 86). Thus, while values as we explained in the previous section are tied to the objects that we deem important, concepts for Feldman Barrett are tied to the available discourse and language we have to name and explain experiences (and thus predict what a physical sensation means). Knowledge and mental concepts are communicated through language. As Feldman Barrett (2018) puts it “emotion concepts are most easily learned with emotion words” (p. 138); culture introduces emotion concepts through words and symbols, which are then associated to specific contexts and felt bodily sensations. For example, if a person knows the concept of *saudade* in Portuguese (meaning a strong and deep desire to have the object of value nearby but not being able to do so) this new concept will add granularity and specificity to the concept of *sadness* that is taught in other cultures since childhood. Knowing this word can give more specificity to certain emotional experiences that might not be available to those who lack such concepts and language. Parents teach their children to make sense of their emotions by labeling their reactions, their bodily movements, and sensations, schools teach them what happy means, what sad means, and the expressions associated with them. These actions of labeling and teaching through emotional labels frame the emotions the members of society will have (as well as what is appropriate to express), emotion is thus socially taught. In fact, “[emotions] are real, because people agree that they are real [...] but they exist only in the presence of human perceivers” (Feldman Barrett, 2018, p. 140), they are socially constructed, they are more human constructions of the world than human reactions to it (Feldman Barrett, 2018). The brain employs concepts, through processes of categorization and predictions, to make the sensory signals meaningful, create an explanation for where they came from, what they refer to in the world, and how to act on it. For Feldman Barrett concepts are requirements to both the experience of emotions and the perception of emotion in others; in order to experience love, the concept of *love* needs to exist first in your mind (Feldman Barrett, 2018). While her views are seen as radical by many scholars

in evolutionary psychology, they fit well with more sociological perspectives of emotion.⁴

And while Feldman Barrett refers to concepts and culture, and does not connect to institutional theory, her view deeply resonates with the ways in which institutions have been seen to shape cognition and action. Institutional logics are more than the values we discuss above—they also represent critical frames that condition the way in which individuals make sense of the world, as they provide the vocabulary actors use to motivate action (Thornton et al., 2012); influencing the perception, conceptualization, and experience of reality.

“Institutional logics help social actors generate top-down knowledge structures or schemas to process information and guide decisions [...] schemas are learned, organized cognitive structures that shape attention, construal, interference and problem solving. (Thornton et al., 2012, p. 88)

We argue that Feldman Barrett’s notion of concepts is aligned with that of schemas articulated in the institutional logics perspective. As the schemas shape the language, frames, and ways in which we process information—they are, in the words of Feldman Barrett, becoming the concepts by which we make sense of physical sensation and thus, experience emotion. As she shares “an emotional experience [occurs] only when we imbue the sensations with additional functions by social agreements. [...] social reality is not just about words – it gets under your skin [...] your body can metabolize things differently when it thinks it is something distinct [...] the words and concepts of your culture help to shape your brain wiring and your physical changes during emotion” (Feldman Barrett, 2018, p. 39). In sum, institutional logics can shape the ways in which we interpret physical sensation, and thus code it into particular emotion experiences. Such predictions, and learning, can train and lead to emotional experiences.

When we weave together Nussbaum and Feldman Barrett perspectives, what we can see is how emotions, values, and logics have an inseparability—a connection that is rarely theorized or empirically explored in the literature. Rather than a view of emotions as universal biological fingerprints, we articulate a perspective where they are constructed in relationship to the objects that we value and the vocabularies we have to understand the world (via schemas

⁴ It is important to note that there are a wide range of thinkers who have unpacked similar sorts of ideas about emotion, our goal is to use these two as fodder, not to suggest that are the only ones with such perspectives.

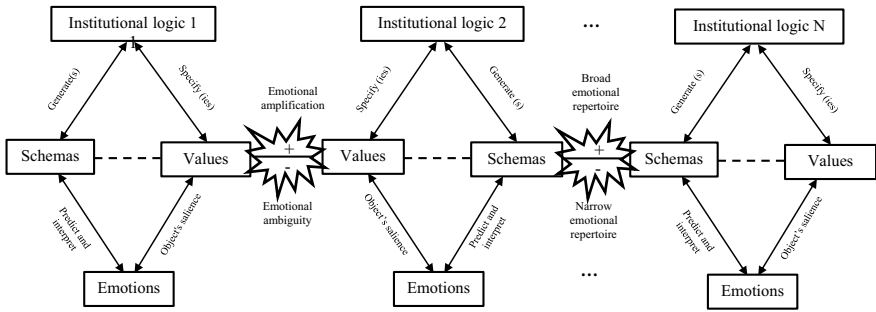


Fig. 2.1 Crossroad between values, emotions, and institutional logics

or concepts). In Fig. 2.1, we present a visual depiction of the relationships these perspectives encourage us to consider.

Elaborations: Complexity, Emotional Amplification, Ambiguity, and Emotional Repertoires

In Fig. 2.1, we illustrate how logics can shape values and thereby emotions, and that logics shape cognitive structures that provide the language through which we can interpret, understand, and act on physical sensation. These relationships are depicted in the arrows from logics down to emotions. However, individuals are exposed to, activate, and identify with more than one institutional logic. As such, the relationship among values, emotions, and logics, can be in conflict and tension, complicating the relationships we articulate. These dynamics are represented in the collision between logics and concepts.

We inhabit an interinstitutional system and so “institutions cannot be analyzed in isolation from each other, but must be understood in their mutually dependent, yet contradictory relationships” (Friedland & Alford, 1991, p. 241). Since logics generate “not only that which is valued, but the rules by which it is calibrated and distributed”, they form the “bases of action” (Friedland & Alford, 1991, pp. 251, 253). We have argued, as a result, they also formulate the bases of emotion. Yet, as individuals carry and are exposed to multiple logics, the extent to which the values and schemas within them are compatible or contradictory can change the bases of emotions emergent from them.

If logics cohere around similar values, identification or enactment of these logics may amplify emotions. The interaction of the logics making more salient and intense the object of valuation from which emotions are constituted. Just like two waves of the same amplitude come together to form a

bigger one, values alignment across logics can strengthen the evaluation of an objects worth, and thereby our emotional reactions to activity in and around the object.

However, often institutions are in contradiction. For example, the care and science logics outlined by Toubiana and Zietsma (2017) pointed to different objects of value—one the patient (the person with the disease), the other the objectivity and rigor of research. These values, in the specific context they outline, were not compatible. To the extent individuals are carriers of multiple logics, with different objects of value, they may experience emotional ambiguity rather than amplification. Emotional ambiguity is the experience of values conflict and inconsistencies that derive in feeling contradictory emotions (e.g., love and hate). Friedland and Alford (1991) point to this tension when they give the example from ancient Greece: Sophocles they share “is torn between familial duty to bury her brother and a political obligation not to bury a traitor” (p. 255). The objects of value—the brother (family logic)—the state—are at odds here. The grief complicated by a betrayal. Scholars of the institutional logics perspective have long articulated how institutional complexity can be the source of reflexivity and agency (Friedland & Alford, 1991; Seo & Creed, 2002; Thornton et al., 2012). In this way, tension and contradiction lead to plurality and emotional ambiguity. However, they may also lead to emotional agency. An untethering from the logics, and an opening for the creation of new values and feeling. This may be the mechanism through which values and emotions can reconstitute logics, something that warrants a great deal more attention.

In our model, however, values are not the only aspects of logics that can come into collision. As logics provide schemas, vocabularies of motives—they provide frameworks, toolkits for understanding and engaging in the world (Pache & Santos, 2013; Thornton & Ocasio, 1999; Thornton et al., 2012). To the extent actors are exposed to, activate, and identify with multiple logics, they have been argued to have more repertoires of action (McPherson & Sauder, 2013; Zilber, 2024). What Feldman Barrett argues is that our emotional experiences are similarly constrained or enhanced by the availability of the concepts that we use to interpret sensation. To the extent that logics provide more vocabulary, and specifically that which makes sense of our physical sensation and reactions to the world, people may have expanded emotional repertoires. We define emotional repertoires as the availability of varied emotion concepts that are tied to the exposure of interinstitutional systems, deriving in a variety of emotional experiences. Acquiring new concepts due to the exposure of different institutions and institutional

logics will translate into new predictions that will then facilitate the experience and perception of new emotions (Feldman Barrett, 2018). An emotional repertoire is enhanced then by exposure to different emotion concepts and schemas. In the same way, if exposure to institutional logics is more homogeneous, with less variability, there are less emotional concepts that are socially and historically constructed and taught, people's emotional repertoire may narrow. Thus, interactions across logics may broaden or narrow emotional repertoires. Yet so too may emotional repertoires feed back into both what we value, and thereby logics themselves. For example, the emotion of *Ikigai* is grounded in a community logic in Japan—it translates roughly to a feeling of purpose and contentment. While the second author is not embedded in this community, through interaction with this logic and emotional concept, she has come to reinterpret how she might feel about work within the professional logic she identifies with. In this sense, the professional logics instantiation and constitution can be changed, if people want to *feel* different about an object of value and find new emotional vocabularies that enable them to do so.

Conclusion

Zietsma and Toubiana (2018) propose three components of emotions and institutions: the valuable (related to the relationship between values and emotions in institutional processes), the constitutive (referring to the possibility of emotions being constituted in institutions and also constitutive of them) and the energetic (referring to the different dynamics around emotional energy). Throughout this chapter we have addressed both the valuable and constitutive components. The former by suggesting that values and emotions are inextricably connected to the point that there is no emotion without an object of value. The latter by considering the relationship between institutional logics and emotions themselves, how the concepts of emotions are embedded in the schemas across different institutional logics and vary from society to society generating distinct emotional experiences. Additionally, we have pushed further to propose a new system of conceiving emotions and values in institutions. We therefore hope to inspire a research agenda for studying emotions, values, and logics not as a collection of individual concepts, but as an interrelated system in which all pieces are needed to understand each one.

Values and emotions have been important topics of study within institutional theory, and specifically within the institutional logics perspective for some time. Important insights have been gleaned from these studies, such

as the idea that values intersect and shape (or are shaped by) institutional logics, the idea that values are institutionally constructed and defined by each institutional logic, and that values are both in and around individuals and institutions. Also, that emotions are often studied as triggering action, that logics themselves shape or prescribe emotions, and that that emotions tend to be temporary and irrational, while values tend to be enduring and highly cognitive.

In the midst of these highly separate conversations, there is a nascent perspective that considers values and emotions as related. We have sought to extend this work, by connecting these concepts through an integrative model of emotions, values, and logics. To do so we have drawn on the work of Nussbaum and Feldman Barrett building on an alternative view of emotions that we tie deeply to values and logics.

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3

From Value Infusion to Evaluate Embodiment: Integrating Emotions into Values-Centric Institutionalism

Ricardo Flores and Matthew S. Kraatz

Institutional scholarship has increasingly recognized the centrality of both values and emotions in understanding institutional dynamics, yet these literatures have developed as largely separate theoretical conversations. Values-focused institutional research has demonstrated how moral commitments become embedded in organizational structures and influence institutional behavior (Chandler, 2014; Kraatz et al., 2020; Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Risi, 2022; Selznick, 1957), while emotions research has revealed the affective dynamics underlying institutional maintenance and change (Creed et al., 2010; Lok et al., 2017; Voronov & Vince, 2012; Voronov & Weber, 2016; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018). These parallel developments have enhanced our understanding of institutions as more than just cognitive-cultural structures (Scott, 2014), showing them as places of moral importance (Heclo, 2008; Selznick, 1992) and emotional investment (Voronov, 2014; Wijaya & Heugens, 2018). Despite significant theoretical advances in each domain, these parallel developments have generated distinct ontological approaches and methodological commitments that remain poorly integrated.

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However, this theoretical separation creates a significant analytical blind spot because values are essentially “emotion-laden conceptions of the desirable” (Hitlin, 2003, p. 132), and emotional responses naturally occur when institutional values are either upheld (Wright et al., 2017) or violated (de Rond et al., 2022; Delmestri & Goodrick, 2016). The lack of systematic integration between these literatures prevents institutional theory from fully explaining how moral commitments generate emotional energy for institutional work, how visceral experiences shape value formation, or how values–emotions dynamics maintain institutional stability while enabling change. This gap is particularly problematic given institutional theory’s broader challenge of linking micro-level individual experience to macro-level institutional structures (Powell & Colyvas, 2008).

The purpose of this chapter is to develop theoretical foundations for integrating values and emotions research within institutional theory through systematic ontological mapping and conceptual synthesis. We address this integration challenge by first providing a comprehensive ontological taxonomy of values research in institutional theory (Table 3.1) and extending Zietsma et al.’s (2019) framework for emotions research with greater ontological nuance (Table 3.2). Building on this analytical foundation, we demonstrate how values-centric institutionalism—an approach derived from Selznick’s (1949, 1957) institutionalism and focus on value infusion—exhibits particular compatibility with pragmatist–realist approaches to embodied institutional experience. This integration yields two recursively related concepts: evaluative embodiment (the individual-level process through which abstract values become lived commitments) and emotional-historical sedimentation (the institutional-level crystallization of accumulated embodied patterns). The bidirectional relationship between these concepts—operating through mechanisms of upward and downward causation—provides a novel theoretical solution to what has remained an enduring challenge in institutional scholarship: explicating the recursive micro–macro link through which individual experience and institutional structure mutually constitute one another (Powell & Colyvas, 2008). By demonstrating how embodied evaluative processes simultaneously emerge from and generate institutional arrangements, this framework transcends both methodological individualism and structural determinism, offering instead a dialectical understanding of institutional life grounded in the phenomenological reality of values–emotions integration.

Table 3.1 Four ontological approaches to “values” in institutional analysis

Cluster (Historical order)	Ontological anchor and role of individuals	Conceptualization of values	Representative scholarship
Selznickian	Ontological anchor: Values rooted in human moral agency; organizations become “infused with value” through persons (leaders, founders, custodians). Role of individuals: Central carriers, transmitters, and moral custodians who embody and institutionalize values	Values as moral commitments and identity anchors. Values are enduring convictions that shape organizational character, mission, and sacralized practices	(Askeland, 2020; Kraatz, 2009, 2015; Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Kraatz et al., 2010; Selznick, 1949, 1957; Struminska-Kutra & Askeland, 2020; Suddaby et al., 2023)
Practice/ valuation	Ontological anchor: Pragmatist and practice ontology—values are enacted in, and inseparable from, social practices and valuation work. Role of individuals: Participants/actors-in-practice; individuals’ agency is distributed across practice networks and interactions	Values as emergent, performative, and processual. Values arise in “sayings and doings” (values practices) and through processes of valuation, inquiry, and moral work in situ	(Espedal, 2020; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024; Gehman et al., 2013, 2019; Skeggs & Loveday, 2012; Wright et al., 2021)

(continued)

Table 3.1 (continued)

Cluster (Historical order)	Ontological anchor and role of individuals	Conceptualization of values	Representative scholarship
Logics	Ontological anchor: Values as cultural-symbolic elements anchored in supra-organizational logics and field grammars. Role of individuals: Positioned carriers or interpreters of logics; individuals enact and recombine logics but are shaped by templates	Values as relatively stable meaning structures (value spheres/orders of worth) that provide templates for legitimacy, identity, and appropriate behavior across fields	(Friedland, 2013, 2017; Gehman, 2021; Lounsbury et al., 2021; Sirris, 2020a)
Political/ ideological	Ontological anchor: Values as contested, political, and ideological constructions embedded in institutions and practice. Role of individuals: Strategic and political actors who mobilize, contest, or resist value claims as part of struggles for legitimacy, power, and resources	Values as discursive and political resources —rhetorical tools used to legitimate projects, delegitimize rivals, prefigure alternatives, and perform political projects; emphasis on ambiguity, manipulation, and power	(Creed et al., 2022; Daskalaki et al., 2019; Sirris, 2020b)

The aim of this table is to present a parsimonious, relatively ontologically coherent set of clusters that characterize the scholarship on values within institutional analysis. We are fully aware that several pieces of scholarship deliberately bridge clusters (e.g., Gehman, 2021, Creed et al., 2022, some Askeland chapters). However, for simplicity's sake, we have placed each work where its primary ontological argument and empirical emphasis point most strongly

Table 3.2 Functional orientations and ontological approaches to “emotions” in institutional analysis

Functional orientation	Ontological approach and anchor	Conceptualization of emotions/role of individuals	Representative scholarship
Structuralist (<i>Outside-in</i>)	Normative-phenomenological: <i>Emotional competence</i> Anchor: Institutions pre-exist individuals; emotions are institutional properties	Emotions as institutional requirements that individuals must learn/perform; individuals as carriers of institutionally prescribed emotional templates; competence exists in the institution, individuals acquire it	(Grodal, 2018; Toubiana et al., 2017; Voronov & Weber, 2016)
	Field-structural: <i>Emotional capital/habitus</i> Anchor: Field structures determine emotional possibilities	Emotions as field-specific resources; individuals as positioned actors whose emotional repertoires are determined by their location in social space; individuals embody field-structured dispositions	(Illouz, 2007; Kerr & Robinson, 2012; Voronov et al., 2013)
	Moral-disciplinary: <i>Shame nexus</i> Anchor: Institutional moral order shapes emotional experience	Emotions as institutional disciplinary mechanisms; individuals as subjects of institutional moral regulation; systemic shame operates through individuals but belongs to the institution	(Creed et al., 2010, 2014; Moisaner et al., 2016)

(continued)

Table 3.2 (continued)

Functional orientation	Ontological approach and anchor	Conceptualization of emotions/ role of individuals	Representative scholarship
People-centered (<i>Inside-out</i>)	Psychoanalytic: <i>Systems psychodynamics</i> Anchor: Collective unconscious structures transcend individuals	Emotions as collective unconscious forces; individuals as vessels for institutional anxieties; defenses operate through but beyond individual awareness	(Padavic et al., 2020; Petriglieri & Petriglieri, 2020; Voronov & Vince, 2012)
	Symbolic interactionist: <i>Inhabited institutions</i> Anchor: Individuals create institutional reality through interaction	Emotions emerge from individuals in interaction ; individuals actively construct emotional meanings; institutions exist only through individual emotional experiences	(Binder, 2007; Hallett, 2010; Hallett & Ventresca, 2006)
	Pragmatist-realist: <i>Affective institutionalism</i> Anchor: Individual embodied experience is primary	Emotions as individual visceral evaluations ; individuals as experiencing subjects whose feelings constitute their institutional reality; institutions exist through individual affective engagement	(Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019)

Functional orientation	Ontological approach and anchor	Conceptualization of emotions/ role of individuals	Representative scholarship
	Durkheimian-vitalist: <i>Emotional energy</i> Anchor: Individual accumulation through collective rituals	Emotions as energy individuals accumulate through participation; individuals as active collectors of emotional resources; individual energy derives from but transcends collective experience	(Collins, 2004, 2014; Massa et al., 2017; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017)
Strategic (<i>Instrumental</i>)	Rhetorical-performance: <i>Strategic emotional work</i> Anchor: Individual agency in emotional deployment	Emotions as tools individuals consciously wield ; individuals as strategic actors manipulating emotional displays; emotions as individual resources for influence	(Giorgi, 2017; Kellogg, 2011; Tracey, 2016)
	Relational-collective: <i>Emotional mobilization</i> Anchor: Individual coordination for collective action	Emotions as bonds individuals strategically create ; individuals as architects of emotional solidarity; collective emotions result from individual strategic efforts	(Fan & Zietsma, 2017; Farny et al., 2019; Gutierrez et al., 2010)

Institutional Scholarship(s) and Values

The intellectual history of institutional theory reveals a field marked by both remarkable theoretical advances and persistent conceptual fragmentation. As Glynn and D'Aunno (2023) demonstrate in their comprehensive genealogy, institutional theory has evolved through six major pivots since the 1950s, each reorienting scholarly attention toward new questions while simultaneously generating distinct subfields that often operate in relative isolation from one another. This proliferation of perspectives—from neo-institutionalism to institutional entrepreneurship, from institutional logics to institutional work—has enriched our understanding of how institutions shape social life. Yet, it has also created what Alvesson et al. (2019) characterize as “uninhibited institutionalisms,” where theoretical coherence increasingly gives way to conceptual sprawl.

Within this expanding and fragmented theoretical landscape, the role of values in institutional analysis is often underappreciated and oversimplified, particularly in terms of their multiple and varied ontological roots and theorizations. In our understanding, institutional scholars have taken various ontological commitments about where values “live” (in persons, in practices, in fields, or in power struggles), what sort of empirical moves those commitments license, and how they position individuals relative to organizational life. Specifically, we suggest that these varied approaches to the theorization of values in institutional analysis can be bundled in four potentially distinct historically, ontologically, and conceptually distinct clusters: (1) Selznickian, (2) Practice/Valuation, (3) Logics, and (4) Political/Ideological (see Table 3.1). Below, we tentatively outline each cluster and how they differ from one another.

A *Selznickian approach to values* establishes an ontology that anchors values in moral agency. From this vantage, values are not mere cultural labels or preferences; they are enduring commitments held and defended by individuals (founders, leaders, and institutional custodians) that become woven into an organization's mission, practices, and identity (Askeland, 2020; Kraatz, 2009, 2015; Kraatz et al., 2010; Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Selznick, 1949, 1957; Struminska-Kutra & Askeland, 2020; Suddaby et al., 2023). In Selznickian studies, individuals are central: leaders and core members are explanatory drivers who infuse organizations with normative meaning.

In turn, a *Practice/Valuation approach*, responding in part to the limitations of static conceptions of values, and inspired by pragmatism and the practice turn, reframed values as accomplished through social action (Espedal, 2020; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024; Gehman et al., 2013, 2019; Skeggs &

Loveday, 2012; Wright et al., 2021). Values, on this account, are visible in the micro-processes of organizations—in the conversations, routines, knotting of concerns, and value practices through which actors evaluate and decide. These studies shift analytic priority from possession to performance: the key question becomes how values become recognizable as such in the flow of work. Individuals are also present in this cluster, but their explanatory status changes: they are participants in practice, not the ontological source of values.

The *institutional logics* tradition introduced a meso-level grammar: values are elements of broader logics (market, profession, family, state, religion, etc.) that supply cultural vocabularies and priorities. In this view, values possess a structural quality, as they form part of the rules and scripts that coordinate actors and organizations across various fields (Friedland, 2013, 2017; Gehman, 2021; Lounsbury et al., 2021; Sirris, 2020a). Within this cluster, individuals are “positioned”—they interpret and enact value vocabularies, but those vocabularies are supplied by logics whose force and reach exceed any single actor.

Finally, a *Political/Ideological approach* runs alongside and sometimes in tension with the logics tradition, as a body of scholarship that treats values as political and ideological. Here, values serve as rhetorical resources for legitimizing projects, delegitimizing rivals, and managing power relations (Creed et al., 2022; Daskalaki et al., 2019; Sirris, 2020b). Individuals in this cluster are strategic and political: actors mobilize value talk to pursue goals, defend identities, or contest institutional orders.

Two final observations follow this brief synthesis of the theorization of values within institutional analysis. First, these clusters are analytically distinct but empirically porous: the most generative studies combine them. Gehman’s (2019, 2021) recent work explicitly seeks to bridge practice and logic; Creed’s (2022) programmatic writings link embodied, emotional valuation with institutional field processes. The Askeland et al. (2020) volume, as a whole, demonstrates how leaders, practices, fields, and political struggles intersect in values work. Second, each cluster implies different method-theory packages: Selznickian questions favor historical and narrative methods; practice studies favor processual ethnography; logics research favors field mapping and comparative work; critical studies favor discourse and power analysis. Being explicit about the ontological commitments that underpin “values” is therefore both a conceptual and a methodological obligation.

We undertake these obligations in our effort to explicitly explore integration opportunities between values, institutions, and emotions (discussed later in this chapter) by clearly defining our own ontological and conceptual commitments and understandings in the following subsection.

Values-Centric Institutional: Premises, Concepts, and Contributions

Values-centric institutionalism (VCI) is a continuation and “aggiornamento” of the work started by Selznick (1949, 1957, 1992) in the past century, where institutions and institutional processes cannot be fully comprehended without a deep understanding and integration of the role of values within them. Selznick’s theory posits that values serve as the fundamental mechanism through which organizations transform into institutions, conceptualizing this process as one in which technical arrangements become “infused with value beyond the technical requirements of the task at hand” (Selznick, 1957, p. 17). Central to Selznick’s framework is the understanding that institutional values emerge through historical processes of character formation and must be discovered rather than imposed, existing as “latent” phenomena within human experience that effective leaders articulate and embed within organizational structures through what he termed the integration of “poetry and plumbing”—the synthesis of meaning-making and technical competence (Besharov & Khurana, 2015). His humanist science (Selznick, 2008) methodology positions values as natural facts amenable to empirical investigation, while simultaneously recognizing their role in fostering emotional identification that generates “sources of energy” for organizational resilience and serves as the foundation for institutions as moral communities capable of advancing human flourishing alongside technical objectives.

VCI, while building upon Selznick’s foundational insights, introduces several significant theoretical departures that expand the role of values within institutional analysis. It enhances our understanding of institutional dynamics while bridging the gap between theoretical insight and practical application (Chandler, 2014; Kraatz et al., 2020; Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Risi, 2022). Indeed, VCI is anchored in two fundamental premises concerning human values and their institutional manifestations. The first premise establishes the multilayered nature of human values, demonstrating how they simultaneously operate at individual and collective levels (Agle & Caldwell, 1999; Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004), permeating various social structures from multiple groups to formal institutions and broader societal units (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004; Tsirogianni & Gaskell, 2011). The second premise contextualizes values within the broader institutional landscape, recognizing them as one element within a loosely coupled system (Scott, 2014). Despite apparent surface-level alignment among institutional elements, this approach acknowledges the persistent tensions and contradictions that characterize the interactions among these elements (Scott, 2014).

Following these VCI's positioning clarifications, the ensuing synthesis examines three crucial aspects of this framework: the role of emotions in conceptualizing values within VCI, the diverse functions of values in institutional contexts, and the somewhat unorthodox approach that VCI embraces regarding the origin and development of values within social entities.

The Central Role of Emotions in the Conceptualization of Values by VCI

Within VCI, values are conceptualized as foundational beliefs about what is considered desirable (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004), beyond simple preferences to encompass abstract ideals about worthy states of being, action, and existence. This perspective *emphasizes* the emotional dimension of values, departing from traditional organizational scholarship that primarily frames values as cognitive constructs. These emotion-laden conceptualizations of the desirable represent more than mere wants or preferences; they embody fundamental aspirations regarding worthy pursuits and meaningful objectives (Hitlin, 2003). VCI also recognizes the multi-level manifestation of values across social structures, acknowledging their presence and influence within individuals, groups, institutions, and broader societal cultures (Gecas, 2008; Giorgi et al., 2015; Patterson, 2014). Values carry significant normative weight and elicit distinct emotional responses, particularly when they emerge from comprehensive moral frameworks. These morally grounded values serve as guiding principles or 'bright lights' in social navigation (Hitlin, 2008, 2011). This scholarship highlights the understanding of values through a processual perspective, emphasizing 'valuing' as an active, dynamic process rather than treating values as static attributes (Dewey, 1939; Rohan & Zanna, 2001; Stocker, 1990; Stocker & Hegeman, 1996). This process involves integrating values into social entities through concrete actions, with subsequent behaviors either reinforcing or potentially undermining these value commitments. A critical insight within this framework is the recognition that social entities regularly encounter and embrace multiple, simultaneously held values, all of which are genuinely perceived as desirable. This multiplicity of values does not necessarily result in conflict; instead, individuals and organizations demonstrate the capacity to internalize and accommodate diverse value sets. This adaptability represents a fundamental source of development and growth across individual, organizational, and societal domains. These value structures exhibit remarkable durability while maintaining relevance across various contexts and temporal dimensions.

The Functions of Values

Within VCI, values are conceptualized as performing multiple critical functions, foremost among which is their capacity to motivate and direct human behavior through principled, autonomous action. While recognizing this motivational primacy, VCI maintains a balanced theoretical perspective that acknowledges values as one element within a broader constellation of behavioral determinants, thus avoiding oversocialized conceptions of human agency (Wrong, 1961). Values simultaneously serve as mechanisms for meaning-making, providing frameworks through which individuals and organizations construct purpose and significance in their existence (Chandler, 2014; Hollensbe et al., 2014; Pratt & Hedden, 2023). Moreover, values operate as evaluative criteria, offering accessible normative standards for legitimizing and assessing behavior (Hitlin, 2011). This evaluative function manifests both internally, through self-reflection, and externally, through social judgment, with values providing sophisticated vocabularies for articulating motivations and constructing rationalization narratives within social contexts (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004). Lastly, VCI views values as essential in conceptualizing personhood and the concept of the “self” (Brewer & Roccas, 2001; Hitlin, 2003; Smith, 1991). This perspective contrasts with traditional sociological approaches, which primarily understand identities as social attributions (Stryker, 1987, 2008; Stryker & Burke, 2000) that emerge from group memberships and role performances (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Burke & Tully, 1977; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). Instead, VCI posits a more comprehensive theoretical framework in which *the self*, fundamentally grounded in values, serves as a mediating construct among multiple social identities (Callero, 2003; Gecas, 2000; Roccas et al., 2014). This expanded conceptualization enables individuals to integrate diverse identities, maintain psychological coherence, exercise moral agency, and establish temporal continuity in their self-understanding. Through this theoretical lens, personal identity emerges as a dynamic construct that facilitates the interpretation and integration of multiple social identities while maintaining coherence and continuity (Hitlin, 2003, 2008, 2011).

The Origins of Values

VCI has an unconventional perspective on the relationship between cultural contexts and value formation processes, differing from the premises commonly used by most sociologists. While acknowledging cultural influences on social entities' value systems (Vaisey, 2007; Wuthnow, 2008), this

perspective emphasizes individual agency in socialization processes (Dewey, 1939; Tsirogianni & Gaskell, 2011). VCI highlights that even within comprehensive socialization experiences, internalized values are experienced as autonomously derived rather than externally imposed, highlighting the *subjective nature of value acquisition*. In comprehending this dynamic, it is essential to recognize that even during comprehensive socialization experiences, the values assimilated by individuals are regarded as “uncoerced” and self-derived. In other words, phenomena that might be interpreted as brain-washing from an external vantage point may be perceived differently from an internal perspective. VCI also emphasizes how individuals navigate multiple cultural contexts and concurrent socialization processes, encountering diverse value propositions that serve as resources for constructing personalized value systems (Graham et al., 2015; Kraatz & Block, 2017; Tetlock et al., 1996). These processes frequently result in hybrid configurations that transcend simple cultural derivation, often incorporating seemingly contradictory elements. Such hybrid systems may generate internal tensions that challenge self-coherence while simultaneously creating opportunities for synthesis and resolution. Thus, this perspective conceptualizes values as emergent phenomena that arise through multiple pathways, including interpersonal interactions, environmental engagement (Dewey, 1938; Jaeger & Selznick, 1964; James, 1907 (2010); Selznick, 1961), and identity formation processes (Erickson, 1995; Feather, 1995; Stryker et al., 2000; Taylor, 1989). The emphasis on emergence highlights the importance of understanding values as discoveries rather than predetermined cultural transmissions, acknowledging their dynamic nature and the active role of individuals and institutions in their creation and perpetuation. This theoretical stance illuminates how values emerge through complex interactions between individual agency and broader social contexts rather than through simple processes of cultural transmission.

In sum, VCI explicitly foregrounds the emotional dimension of values, challenging traditional organizational scholarship’s predominantly cognitive conceptualizations and positioning emotion-laden values as fundamental to institutional dynamics rather than secondary considerations. Furthermore, VCI advances a perspective on the origins of value that emphasizes individual agency within socialization processes, arguing that values are experienced as autonomously derived rather than externally imposed, even during comprehensive cultural transmission.

With VCI’s conceptualization of values and its detailed view on how these values function and emerge within social entities, we are now in a

strong position to analyze VCI's unique contributions to institutional analysis. The following section will explore these distinctive contributions, setting the stage for further research into how values and emotions can deepen our understanding of institutions and their specific processes and dynamics.

VCI's Contributions to Institutional Analysis

VCI plays a crucial role in advancing institutional scholarship in two main ways: first, by improving our understanding of individuals and their interactions with institutions, and second, by expanding the conceptual framework used to interpret institutions. A brief explanation of these contributions is then provided.

Enhancing Our Understanding of People and Their Relationship to Institutions (Including the Role of Individuals' Emotions). Contemporary institutional scholarship has witnessed multiple calls to reintegrate humans into institutionalism. These calls encompass diverse research streams such as institutional work (Lawrence et al., 2009), embedded agency (Battilana, 2006; Green et al., 2009), inhabited institutions (Hallett & Ventresca, 2006), institutional actorhood (Voronov & Weber, 2016, 2017), institutional micro-foundations (Powell & Colyvas, 2008), and the influence of emotions on institutions (Creed et al., 2010; Lok et al., 2017; Voronov & Vince, 2012; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018). Values-centric institutionalism is a perspective that contributes to this overarching theoretical aim through three distinctive paths. First, VCI enriches theoretical conceptualizations of human nature by positioning values as fundamental to personhood, particularly in relation to moral agency, reflexive consciousness, and intersubjective understanding (Kraatz et al., 2020). This theoretical emphasis *highlights a more nuanced comprehension of institutional actors*.

Furthermore, VCI illuminates individual autonomy within institutional contexts by recognizing that while human selves emerge through social processes, they derive values from various sources and are not solely defined by institutional constraints. Second, VCI expands the theoretical understanding of individual–institution relationships by *reconceptualizing institutions as moral frameworks rather than control mechanisms exclusively*. This theoretical reorientation reveals multiple relational possibilities, including institutions as sources of cherished values and contexts for meaningful social connections (Heclo, 2008; Selznick, 1992; Smith, 2003). However, VCI offers some theoretical sophistication by acknowledging potentially problematic aspects of institutional values, including psychological burdens of

unattainable ideals and the potential for values to generate conflict or serve power interests. Third, VCI enhances understanding of the reciprocal dependencies between institutions and individuals, *conceptualizing institutional values as historically accumulated and structured, while recognizing individual capacity for institutional influence*. In this way, VCI illuminates the critical role of institutional leadership in value protection and promotion (Selznick, 1957), suggesting that the absence of values from institutional analysis fundamentally alters the understanding of leadership functions and organizational dynamics. It is essential to acknowledge that the omission of values from our comprehension of the institution results in the simultaneous disappearance of the challenge associated with sustaining these values. In an institution devoid of values, functioning merely as a control structure, the leadership referenced by Selznick becomes neither feasible nor essential (Kraatz, 2009).

Understanding (Organizational) Institutions. A theoretical emphasis on values in institutional analysis illuminates previously unrecognized dimensions of institutional functionality and potential. Values-centric institutionalism articulates five fundamental institutional capacities that emerge through value integration. First, institutions can manifest as *moral orders* (Selznick, 1957, 1992) where values emerge, undergo codification, and are transmitted to new participants (who can “discover” and internalize them during their time within the institution) through processes of discovery and internalization. While these value structures may vary in their external visibility and internal prominence, they constitute fundamental organizing principles of (organizational) institutions. Second, (organizational) institutions can emerge as *historically constructed entities whose values develop through unique temporal trajectories, reflecting particular organizational histories*. This theoretical emphasis on historical specificity and organizational distinctiveness distinguishes VCI from contemporary perspectives, which prioritize systemic constraints and homogenizing pressures. Third, (organizational) institutions can function as *integrative social structures* where historically accumulated values facilitate collaborative engagement among autonomous individuals toward shared objectives. Fourth, value integration enables the conceptualization of (organizational) institutions as *purposive entities with distinctive organizational lives*, derived from the dual function of values in fostering internal cooperation and establishing societal linkages.

Furthermore, the institution’s historically accumulated values develop a connection to society and delineate its role within that context. Fifth, (organizational) institutions can *demonstrate adaptive capacity through their value systems*. While values establish relatively enduring moral frameworks, they remain amenable to expansion, refinement, and reinterpretation in

response to environmental changes. These value structures can serve as critical resources for organizational transformation, particularly when institutional actors leverage disparities between espoused values and organizational practices to catalyze change.

The preceding paragraphs have explicitly reviewed VCI's contribution to contemporary institutional scholarship. When considered in conjunction with the previous section, which delineates values, their functions, and their emergence within social entities, this allows us to subsequently explore various opportunities for integrating values and emotions from a VCI perspective.

How Does Emotions Research Within Institutional Analysis Fit with VCI?

The study of emotions in institutional theory has emerged as a crucial area of research, offering valuable insights into how emotions shape and are shaped by institutional processes. Our understanding of this literature relies heavily on the work of Zietsma et al. (2019), which employs a tripartite categorization scheme. This scheme distinguishes between *structuralist*, *people-centered*, and *strategic perspectives* on emotions in organizational theory. While this parsimonious framework has proven valuable for cross-theoretical analysis, our examination of the literature (especially in the last five years) suggests that institutional scholars have developed considerably more nuanced ontological positions regarding the nature, locus, and operation of emotions. We tentatively offer a provisional synthesis of the different orientations and ontological approaches to emotions in institutional analysis in Table 3.2.

This synthesis, although maintaining an overarching *structuralist cluster* that locates emotions primarily within institutional structures, identifies **slightly different ontological approaches** within this orientation that conceptualize this structural embeddedness through radically different mechanisms.

Indeed, what we labeled as the normative-phenomenological approach (Grodal, 2018; Toubiana et al., 2017; Voronov & Weber, 2016) treats emotions as institutional requirements that exist independently of any particular individual—emotional competence standards that actors must acquire to achieve institutional actorhood. By contrast, the field-structural approach, while still structuralist, locates emotions within the relational architecture of social fields, where one's position determines the accessible emotional repertoires (Illouz, 2007; Kerr & Robinson, 2012; Voronov et al., 2013). The

moral-disciplinary approach shifts focus to emotions as instruments of institutional control, operating through anticipatory self-regulation and collective surveillance (Creed et al., 2010, 2014; Moisander et al., 2016). Most radically, the psychoanalytic approach posits emotions as collective unconscious forces that operate through, yet fundamentally transcend, individual awareness, manifesting as institutionalized defenses against primordial anxieties (Padavic et al., 2020; Petriglieri & Petriglieri, 2020; Voronov & Vince, 2012).

These distinctions within the structuralist orientation are not merely taxonomic refinements but reflect fundamentally different theoretical commitments about the relationship between emotion and social structure. Where the emotional competence approach posits conscious learning of institutional emotional requirements, systems psychodynamics reveals unconscious collective processes that no individual fully apprehends. Where the field-structural approach emphasizes position-based emotional resources, the shame nexus focuses on moral emotions that operate through intersubjective recognition. These differences carry profound implications for empirical investigation: studying emotional competence requires examining institutional role prescriptions and individual performance. At the same time, investigating systems psychodynamics demands attention to collective defensive patterns and unconscious group dynamics.

In contrast, the *people-centered orientation* presents an entirely different ontological starting point, locating emotions primarily within individual experience; yet, here too, we find some critical ontological distinctions.

What we label a symbolic interactionist approach (Binder, 2007; Hallett, 2010; Hallett & Ventresca, 2006) of inhabited institutions conceptualizes emotions as emergent properties of situated interactions—neither purely individual nor structural but arising in the interactional space where individuals collectively construct institutional meaning. This contrasts markedly with a **pragmatist-realist** position, which grounds institutional reality in individual visceral evaluations and embodied experiences (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019). Here, institutions exist through and because of individual affective engagement; the institution has no emotional reality independent of individual feeling. A Durkheimian-vitalist approach occupies a distinctive middle ground, theorizing individual emotional accumulation through collective rituals—a dialectical process in which individual emotional energy derives from and yet transcends collective experience (Collins, 2004, 2014; Massa et al., 2017; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017).

Lastly, the *strategic orientation* introduces yet another ontological stance, treating emotions neither as structural properties nor as emergent experiences

but as deployable resources. However, even within this instrumental framing, crucial ontological distinctions emerge. A rhetorical-performative approach (Giorgi, 2017; Kellogg, 2011; Tracey, 2016) conceptualizes emotions as conscious tools individuals wield—discursive resources strategically deployed to influence institutional processes. A relational-collective approach (Fan & Zietsma, 2017; Farny et al., 2019; Gutierrez et al., 2010) emphasizes the intentional orchestration of emotional bonds to facilitate collective mobilization while remaining strategic. The former treats emotions as individual weapons in institutional battles; the latter as collective resources for coordinated action.

In closing this brief synthesis of this literature, this effort enables us to begin exploring how each of these orientations can be integrated into our VCI approaches. For instance, the theoretical integration of the structural orientations with VCI would present substantial challenges rooted in philosophical differences. Where VCI emphasizes interpretive agency, the structural approach's emphasis on institutional conditioning suggests limited individual discretion in emotional-institutional processes. Several fundamental tensions would emerge. Reconciling the VCI's focus on active interpretation and construction appears extremely challenging if one considers the institutional determination highlighted by the work of scholars within the structural orientations. Similarly, the structural perspectives' conception of emotions as predetermined institutional elements contrasts sharply with the focus on individual engagement characteristic of values-centered analysis. These philosophical divergences suggest significant barriers to straightforward theoretical integration.

Analogously, the integration of VCI with work by institutionalists embracing the strategic orientations would present significant theoretical challenges stemming from fundamental philosophical tensions. First, VCI's emphasis on authentic value engagement conflicts with the strategic orientations' focus on calculated emotional deployment. Second, the strategic orientations' emphasis on emotional maneuvering for institutional purposes stands in tension with VCI's focus on genuine value internalization. These philosophical tensions suggest significant barriers to meaningful theoretical integration between the strategic perspective and VCI.

In contrast, given their shared philosophical commitments to individual interpretation and authentic engagement, the people-centered orientations demonstrate particular promise for integration with a values-centered institutionalism. Both perspectives emphasize how individuals actively make sense of and engage with institutional elements, whether emotions or values. Several points of philosophical alignment merit attention. Both approaches

recognize individual agency in institutional processes while acknowledging institutional constraints. Similarly, both emphasize authentic engagement rather than strategic manipulation or structural determination. These shared commitments suggest potentially fertile ground for theoretical integration. While this ontological analysis remains preliminary and requires empirical validation, we tentatively explore these integration possibilities below. These integration possibilities, we argue, may offer new and promising directions for advancing the study of emotions, values, and institutions, opening many new avenues to developing richer understandings of human beings, individual-institution relationships, and the nature of institutions themselves.

Integrating VCI and People-Centered Emotions Research

The theoretical integration of values-centric institutionalism (VCI) with people-centered emotions research could benefit from careful consideration of ontological compatibility across various approaches within this people-centered perspective. As mentioned earlier, the people-centered orientation encompasses three distinct ontological positions: symbolic interactionist, pragmatist-realist, and Durkheimian-vitalist approaches, each with meaningfully different assumptions about the nature of emotions, individuals, and institutional reality.

Among them, the pragmatist-realist approach appears to offer the most substantial ontological alignment with VCI's theoretical foundations. In contrast, the symbolic interactionist and Durkheimian-vitalist approaches may present significant tensions that hinder meaningful integration.

To illustrate these ontological differences concretely, consider how each approach would analyze the implementation of patient-centered care values in a hospital setting. The symbolic interactionist approach, exemplified by inhabited institutions theory (Hallett & Ventresca, 2006), would examine how healthcare professionals collectively create the meaning of "patient-centered care" through their daily interactions, treating this value as an outcome of situated encounters among doctors, nurses, and patients. This constructivist perspective appears to conflict with VCI's realist stance on institutional values, which views patient-centered care as a discoverable moral principle that exists independently of specific healthcare interactions and can be identified through empirical research into medical practice and ethics (Kraatz et al., 2020). If we were to apply VCI's focus on values as "latent in

human experience” (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004), it would suggest that patient-centered care is a core element of medical practice that effective leaders can identify and communicate. In contrast, symbolic interactionism might argue that this value only emerges through ongoing social processes rather than existing independently of particular encounters.

The Durkheimian-vitalist approach would examine the same hospital setting by highlighting how collective emotional energy builds through institutional rituals—such as medical team meetings or patient rounds—where individual healthcare workers become energized by collective enthusiasm for patient care that goes beyond their personal awareness or control (Massa et al., 2017; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017). This view potentially creates ontological tensions with VCI’s focus on individual moral agency and autonomous value creation (Kraatz et al., 2020), which sees healthcare professionals as active moral agents who intentionally discover and apply patient-centered care values through reflective practice rather than as vessels for collective emotional energies. While VCI emphasizes individual agency in developing values—implying that a physician forms a commitment to patient-centered care through conscious reflection on medical ethics and personal experience—the vitalist approach tends to view individuals as carriers of collective emotional forces that operate beyond their personal consciousness or control.

In contrast, the **pragmatist-realist approach** presents remarkable ontological coherence with VCI’s theoretical framework by understanding emotions as individual visceral evaluations that form institutional reality (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019). Both approaches share realist ontological commitments while emphasizing the importance of individual experience in shaping institutional reality. In our hospital example, the pragmatist-realist approach would analyze how individual healthcare professionals develop commitment to patient-centered care through accumulated bodily responses to patient interactions—such as feelings of professional satisfaction when patients recover, distress when witnessing suffering, and fulfillment when providing compassionate care. These visceral evaluations form the basis of institutional engagement, affirming the objective reality of values and creating compatible theoretical foundations for meaningful integration with VCI’s focus on values as essential to personhood and moral agency (Kraatz et al., 2020).

Before examining how the integration of VCI and pragmatist-realist approaches can be integrated across different dimensions of institutional life, we first offer the conceptual architecture underlying this integration. Table 3.3 presents the two theoretical constructs that emerge from this initial

integration effort, each addressing specific gaps in existing institutional scholarship. These concepts—evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation—provide a parsimonious theoretical framework for understanding how values and emotions operate as interconnected phenomena through embodied processes at both individual and institutional levels.

We present this initial integration exploration in the following subsections by structuring it according to VCI's three principal theoretical contributions.

Enhancing Understanding of Human Beings and Their Relationship to Institutions

The integration of VCI's emphasis on moral agency with pragmatist-realist insights about embodied institutional experience may reveal how individuals engage institutional values through visceral evaluations rather than purely cognitive processes, potentially transforming our understanding of how emotions and values interact in institutional settings. VCI's recognition that values serve as fundamental components of personhood, particularly concerning moral agency and reflexive consciousness (Kraatz et al., 2020), aligns naturally with the pragmatist-realist understanding that institutional reality emerges through individual affective engagement as experiencing subjects whose feelings constitute their institutional reality (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019).

This suggests that moral agency may operate through what we term **evaluative embodiment**—a concept requiring careful theoretical development (see Table 3.3). Existing frameworks may not fully capture how institutional actors develop value commitments. Neither embodied cognition literature (Varela et al., 2016) nor emotional intelligence frameworks (Salovey & Mayer, 1990) seem to adequately address the unified phenomenological process through which values might become personally compelling. Drawing tentatively on neuroscientific evidence of integrated cognitive-emotional processing (Bail et al., 2017) and phenomenological accounts of moral experience (Levinas, 1961), we propose that evaluative embodiment could serve as a conceptual lens for understanding the simultaneous visceral-cognitive mechanism through which abstract institutional values potentially transform into lived commitments. This preliminary conceptualization aims to theorize what might be a pre-reflective, integrated assessment process that could precede conscious value articulation, possibly addressing what Haidt (2001) identifies as moral intuition while potentially extending beyond his social intuitionist model to encompass institutional value formation.

Table 3.3 Core concepts emerging from VCI-pragmatist integration

Dimension	Evaluative embodiment	Emotional-historical sedimentation
Level of analysis	Individual	Organizational/institutional
Definition	The unified phenomenological process through which abstract institutional values transform into lived commitments via simultaneous visceral-cognitive assessment	The temporal process through which accumulated patterns of embodied engagement crystallize into enduring institutional character and moral order
Theoretical roots	• VCI: Values as “emotion-laden conceptions of the desirable” (Hitlin, 2003, p. 132) that constitute fundamental components of personhood and moral agency (Kraatz et al., 2020) • Pragmatist-realist: Visceral evaluations constitute institutional reality through individual affective engagement (Creed et al., 2020; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019)	• VCI: Values as historically accumulated structures that develop through unique organizational trajectories (Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Selznick, 1957) • Pragmatist-realist: Institutional reality emerges through aggregated individual visceral experiences accumulated over time (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019)
Distinction from existing constructs	Unlike emotional intelligence (Salovey & Mayer, 1990), which represents conscious skill in recognizing and managing emotions, or affective commitment (Mercurio, 2015), which describes attitudinal orientation toward organizational membership, evaluative embodiment captures the pre-reflective integration of moral and emotional assessment. This concept transcends the cognition-emotion dichotomy by theorizing a unified phenomenological process rather than sequential or parallel processing	Unlike path dependence (Mahoney, 2000), which emphasizes structural lock-in through increasing returns, or collective memory (Halbwachs, 1992), which focuses on cognitive retention of shared experiences, emotional-historical sedimentation specifically captures how affective experiences undergo compression and crystallization into institutional bedrock. This process creates the phenomenological substrate of institutional character rather than merely cognitive schemas or structural constraints

(continued)

Table 3.3 (continued)

Dimension	Evaluative embodiment	Emotional-historical sedimentation
Recursive relationship	Upward causation (micro → macro): Individual evaluative embodiment contributes to institutional sedimentation through iterative accumulation. As organizational members experience visceral-cognitive alignment (or misalignment) with institutional values, these embodied experiences aggregate across actors and time. Patterns of shared evaluative embodiment—what generates professional satisfaction, triggers moral distress, or evokes meaningfulness—gradually compress into institutional sediments, establishing the affective contours of organizational character. This upward process transforms individual phenomenological experiences into collective institutional properties	Downward causation (macro → micro): Emotional-historical sediments establish the phenomenological context that shapes (but does not determine) individual evaluative embodiment. These accumulated institutional patterns create what might be termed an “affective opportunity structure”—making certain forms of embodied value engagement more probable than others through established repertoires of legitimate emotional expression, recognized sources of professional satisfaction, and institutionalized triggers of moral concern. Newcomers encounter these sedimented patterns as the taken-for-granted emotional landscape of institutional life, experiencing their own evaluative embodiment within (and sometimes against) these accumulated structures. This downward influence preserves individual agency while acknowledging institutional conditioning

Note The recursive relationship between these concepts operates continuously, with individual embodied experiences both emerging from and contributing to institutional sediments in an ongoing dialectical process that accounts for both institutional stability and the possibility of endogenous change

The theoretical necessity of evaluative embodiment emerges directly from reconciling VCI's fundamental insight that values constitute inherently emotional phenomena with the pragmatist-realist position that institutions achieve existence through patterns of individual visceral engagement. If values indeed represent “emotion-laden conceptions of the desirable” (Hitlin, 2003) rather than purely cognitive constructs, and if institutional reality manifests through accumulated “visceral evaluations” that individuals experience in their encounters with institutional arrangements (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019), then the mechanism connecting values to institutions cannot operate through purely cognitive or purely emotional channels—it must constitute an integrated phenomenon that transcends this traditional dichotomy. Evaluative embodiment captures this integration, describing not a sequential process where cognition leads to

emotion or emotion prompts cognition, but rather a unified phenomenological experience where moral assessment and visceral response remain fundamentally inseparable, occurring simultaneously in ways that existing theoretical frameworks have yet to adequately conceptualize.

This conceptual innovation addresses a critical lacuna in both theoretical traditions. While VCI acknowledges the emotional dimension of values and positions them as central to institutional dynamics (Kraatz et al., 2020), the framework lacks specification regarding how this emotional dimension operates in the lived experience of institutional actors navigating their organizational worlds. Similarly, the pragmatist-realist approach emphasizes visceral evaluation as constitutive of institutional reality, but it provides a limited theoretical explanation for how these embodied evaluations connect to the moral frameworks that VCI positions as fundamental to institutional life (Jarvis et al., 2019). Evaluative embodiment bridges this theoretical gap by explicating the mechanism through which institutional actors simultaneously feel and judge, experience and evaluate, in ways that transform abstract institutional values into personally compelling commitments that carry genuine motivational force and generate the “sources of energy” that Selznick (1957, p. 17) identified as essential for institutional resilience.

Moreover, these concepts exist in a recursive relationship, wherein individual evaluative embodiment contributes to institutional sedimentation through processes of upward causation—as embodied experiences accumulate and crystallize into institutional character—while sedimented patterns simultaneously shape the phenomenological context for subsequent individual experience through downward causation, creating a bidirectional dynamic that addresses what Powell and Colyvas (2008, p. 277) identify as institutional theory’s persistent challenge of linking micro-processes to macro-structures. This recursive architecture transcends traditional multi-level frameworks by theorizing not merely cross-level influences but the ongoing dialectical process through which individual and institutional phenomena mutually constitute one another through embodied engagement.

Enhancing Understanding of Individual-Institution Relationships

Building on VCI’s consideration that institutions can also serve as moral frameworks rather than solely as control mechanisms (Heclo, 2008; Selznick, 1992), and integrating pragmatist-realist insights, it can be shown how institutional moral frameworks gain reality through embodied individual experience. This could fundamentally alter our understanding of how emotions

and values shape the way individuals interact with institutions. This synthesis moves beyond the traditional view of institutions as control structures by suggesting that institutions may become meaningful moral contexts precisely because individuals experience them as affectively significant rather than solely cognitively comprehensible. The pragmatist-realist view, which posits that institutions exist through individual emotional engagement (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019), provides the experiential foundation for VCI's claim that institutions can serve as sources of valued principles and spaces for meaningful social connections.

To illustrate this integration, consider how religious institutions serve as moral frameworks through the embodied experiences of their members. A congregation member does not merely accept theological doctrines intellectually; they develop a commitment to religious values through accumulated embodied experiences, such as feeling transcendence during communal worship, experiencing comfort during pastoral counseling, sensing community solidarity during shared service projects, and finding meaning through liturgical participation. These visceral evaluations make abstract theological principles personally meaningful while also reinforcing institutional moral frameworks. The concept of "cherished values" within VCI's framework arguably becomes more precise when understood through pragmatist-realist insights into visceral evaluation—individuals cherish institutional values not just as cognitive commitments, but as affectively charged orientations that trigger bodily responses of attraction, commitment, and investment.

The interaction between emotions and values in sustaining individual-institution relationships becomes especially clear in professional settings where institutional moral frameworks must compete with alternative value systems. For example, physicians working in managed care organizations often face pressures for economic efficiency that can conflict with patient-centered care values. This connection illustrates how healthcare professionals uphold their commitment to medical values through embodied experiences that extend beyond organizational boundaries: feeling professionally fulfilled when providing quality care despite administrative hurdles, experiencing moral distress when organizational policies compromise patient well-being, and finding renewed purpose through meaningful patient relationships. These embodied assessments enable individuals to maintain their core values while navigating institutional conflicts, aligning with VCI's emphasis on the emotional aspects of values and avoiding the pitfalls of perceiving institutional values as unattainable ideals or sources of psychological stress (Chandler, 2014; Hollensbe et al., 2014).

This integration also enhances understanding of the reciprocal dependencies between institutions and individuals that VCI highlights through its concept of institutional values as historically accumulated, while acknowledging the individual's capacity to influence institutions (Kraatz et al., 2020). The pragmatist-realist focus on individual emotional engagement illustrates how institutional values, although accumulated over time, necessitate ongoing personal, embodied effort to sustain institutional existence. Think about how academic institutions uphold scholarly values through faculty members' embodied experiences: excitement during research breakthroughs, satisfaction from mentoring students well, and pride in contributing to disciplinary knowledge. People influence institutions not just by thinking or following rules but through the strength of their emotional engagement—their deep embodied commitment to institutional goals determines the institution's vitality and ability to adapt.

To clearly illustrate this reciprocal relationship, look at how law schools uphold legal education values through the lived experiences of faculty and students. Professors may sustain their commitment to legal scholarship through visceral reactions to intellectual challenges, while students shape their professional identity through embodied encounters with legal reasoning and advocacy. If these embodied experiences were to evoke positive emotional engagement, they could reinforce institutional values and enhance institutional vitality. Conversely, when embodied experiences trigger negative responses—such as faculty experiencing moral distress over declining academic standards or students feeling disconnected from the practical relevance of legal education—these visceral reactions may prompt institutional change. This synthesis highlights the vital role of institutional leadership in protecting and promoting values (Besharov & Khurana, 2015; Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015; Selznick, 1957) by demonstrating how leaders must attend to both the historical development of values and the ongoing, embodied experiences that help sustain the institution's reality.

The Recursive Relationship Between Evaluative Embodiment and Emotional-Historical Sedimentation

The theoretical relationship between individual-level evaluative embodiment and institutional-level emotional-historical sedimentation represents a crucial recursive dynamic that illuminates how micro-processes aggregate into macro-structures while those structures simultaneously shape the conditions for individual experience—a theoretical puzzle that has long challenged institutional scholars seeking to bridge levels of analysis (Powell & Colyvas, 2008).

This recursivity, we argue, operates through three interconnected mechanisms that collectively explain both institutional persistence and the possibility for endogenous change.

First, individual evaluative embodiment contributes to institutional sedimentation through processes of **upward causation**—a mechanism whereby micro-level phenomena generate macro-level structures through iterative accumulation (Felin & Foss, 2006). This upward causation operates not through simple aggregation but through what might be characterized as phenomenological compression, wherein patterns of evaluative embodiment across multiple actors and temporal moments undergo a transformation analogous to geological sedimentation. As organizational members experience similar patterns of visceral-cognitive alignment—the embodied satisfaction that comes with enacting patient-centered care, the somatic discomfort that arises when bureaucratic demands override professional values, and the phenomenological resonance that occurs when institutional and personal values converge—these experiences do not merely accumulate but undergo a qualitative transformation. Consider how a medical school's commitment to patient-centered care emerges: thousands of moments wherein faculty experience visceral satisfaction when prioritizing patient welfare, students feel embodied pride when mastering compassionate communication, and administrators sense deep alignment when resource allocations support care quality. These distributed experiences of evaluative embodiment gradually compress into what Selznick (1957) identified as institutional character, though our framework specifically theorizes the embodied mechanisms through which such character crystallizes.

Second, emotional-historical sediments shape individual evaluative embodiment through processes of downward causation—whereby macro-level structures condition (though do not determine) micro-level experiences (Archer, 2000). This downward causation manifests through what we conceptualize as an affective opportunity structure: the accumulated institutional patterns that render certain forms of evaluative embodiment more phenomenologically accessible than others. The emotional-historical sediment of an institution—its crystallized patterns delineating what generates professional fulfillment, what triggers moral distress, what evokes collective pride—establishes not merely cognitive schemas or behavioral scripts but the very phenomenological terrain within which actors experience institutional life. New physicians entering a hospital characterized by deep sediments of patient-centered care do not simply learn rules or adopt behaviors; they encounter a structured phenomenological landscape wherein certain embodied experiences feel natural, meaningful, and institutionally validated

while others feel foreign, uncomfortable, or illegitimate. This represents more than socialization into cognitive frameworks; it constitutes what Bourdieu (1990) might recognize as the acquisition of institutional habitus, though our framework specifically emphasizes the emotional-valuational rather than merely practical dimensions of such embodied knowledge.

Third, this recursive relationship exhibits both remarkable stability and genuine dynamism, addressing what Zietsma and Toubiana (2018) identify as the paradox of institutional persistence amid emotional volatility. While emotional-historical sedimentation creates substantial institutional inertia—making certain patterns of evaluative embodiment significantly more likely than others through the weight of accumulated experience—it does not determine individual experience in any mechanistic fashion. Individual actors retain meaningful agency to experience evaluative embodiment that diverges from established institutional sediment, potentially initiating new accumulation patterns that gradually shift the institutional character through processes that resemble what Padavic et al. (2020) describe as systems psychodynamic change, albeit operating through conscious, embodied experience rather than unconscious collective defenses.

Enhancing Understanding of (Organizational) Institutions

The integration of VCI's conceptualization of institutions as moral orders with pragmatist-realist insights can provide a stronger theoretical basis for understanding how values develop, become codified, and are passed on to new participants through processes of discovery and internalization. This highlights the essential role of embodied emotion-value interactions in institutional processes (Selznick, 1957, 1992). Institutions as moral orders emerge and endure through the accumulation of individual, embodied evaluations, rather than existing solely as structural phenomena. This integration suggests that the “discovery and internalization” process described by VCI functions through embodied institutional participation, where individuals assess institutional arrangements and practices viscerally. Successful institutionalization relies on creating positive embodied experiences that make institutional values personally meaningful.

To elucidate this process, think about how medical schools function as moral orders that transmit professional values to new physicians. Traditional views might conceptualize this transmission as cognitive learning (memorizing ethical codes) or social conformity (adapting to professional norms). However, the VCI-pragmatist-realist approach would reveal a more

complex process in which medical students discover and internalize professional values through accumulated embodied experiences: feeling a sense of responsibility during patient encounters, experiencing moral weight when making treatment decisions, sensing professional pride when healing occurs, and developing emotional resilience when facing medical limitations. These visceral evaluations help students realize the moral importance of medical practice while also internalizing professional values through personally meaningful experiences. The success of medical education would rely not only on the cognitive transfer of technical knowledge but also on creating embodied experiences that make medical values emotionally resonant and personally meaningful.

The historical specificity highlighted by VCI in organizational development is understood here as the accumulation of embodied evaluative experiences over time, showing how emotions and values interact to form unique institutional characters. VCI's focus on historically shaped entities, whose values evolve through distinct temporal paths (reflecting specific organizational histories), gains greater explanatory strength when grounded on pragmatist-realist insights into individual visceral evaluations (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019). Organizational distinctiveness would arise not only from the unique timelines of formal decision-making processes but also from the accumulation of characteristic patterns of embodied engagement that shape recognizable institutional cultures.

In illustrating this potential integration, consider how prestigious law firms can develop unique institutional identities through the accumulation of embodied professional practices over time. Lawyers at white-shoe Wall Street firms experience distinct patterns of professional satisfaction, including intellectual stimulation from complex corporate transactions, social status from representing prestigious clients, and material rewards from successful deal-making. These embodied experiences, accumulated over decades, shape distinctive institutional cultures that highlight elite professional identity, technical expertise, and exceptional client service. Conversely, public interest law firms cultivate distinct institutional identities through alternative patterns of embodied experience, including moral satisfaction from advancing social justice, emotional connections to client communities, and professional fulfillment from advocating for systemic change. The long-term accumulation of these contrasting embodied experiences yields distinctly different institutional cultures, illustrating how emotions and values interact over time to create institutional distinctiveness.

VCI's conceptualization of institutions as integrated social structures where historically accumulated values facilitate collaborative engagement among autonomous individuals toward shared goals aligns naturally with the pragmatist-realist view of institutional reality, which sees it as formed through individual emotional engagement. This connection suggests that institutional integration relies not only on value alignment but also on creating embodied experiences that make collaborative efforts personally meaningful and satisfying. The dual role of values in promoting internal cooperation and building societal links, as VCI highlights, is understood to function through embodied processes—where individuals experience both internal solidarity and external connection through their participation in institutions.

To illustrate this integrative function, examine how successful orchestras operate as cohesive social structures through the interaction of emotions and values. Musicians retain individual artistic autonomy while collaborating toward shared musical goals through embodied experiences that promote both internal cooperation and external connection. These experiences include feeling a sense of musical transcendence during outstanding performances, experiencing professional satisfaction through technical mastery, sensing collective achievement through ensemble coordination, and forming emotional bonds with audiences through shared aesthetic moments. These embodied assessments enable individual musicians to maintain personal artistic integrity while contributing to collective institutional goals, illustrating how institutions serve as integrative social structures through emotional value interactions rather than solely through formal coordination methods.

Finally, VCI's focus on adaptive capacity through value systems is better explained by pragmatist-realist insights into ongoing individual affective evaluation, showing how emotions and values interact to support institutional change while maintaining continuity (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019). Institutional adaptation occurs not only through cognitive reinterpretation of existing values but also through altered patterns of embodied institutional experience that preserve emotional investment while changing institutional practices. When environmental pressures necessitate institutional change, success hinges on fostering new forms of embodied engagement that promote positive, visceral evaluations while adapting to environmental challenges.

Reflect on how traditional newspapers adapt to the challenges of digital media while upholding their journalistic values. Successful adaptation involves creating new ways for journalists to connect with their work—maintaining their emotional dedication to investigative reporting, truth-telling,

and serving the public—while adopting digital storytelling, social media, and multimedia. Journalists should find genuine satisfaction in digital practices—feeling excitement from interactive reporting, sensing audience engagement through social media, and maintaining investigative fulfillment via data journalism. When digital adaptation offers positive, embodied experiences that strengthen rather than weaken journalistic values, institutional change is successful. However, when digital pressures lead to negative embodied experiences—such as moral distress from clickbait demands or frustration from limited investigative resources—institutional change is hindered. This analysis highlights VCI's insight that value structures can be vital resources for organizational change, especially when actors use the gaps between proclaimed values and actual practices to foster change. It shows that successful transformation depends on aligning new practices with lived value experiences, not just altering formal structures or stated commitments.

Implications and Conclusions: Toward an Embodied Theory of Values and Emotions in Institutional Life

Theoretical Implications of the VCI-Pragmatist-Realist Integration

The theoretical integration of values-centric institutionalism with pragmatist-realist approaches to embodied experience, crystallized in the twin concepts of evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation, offers a parsimonious yet theoretically generative framework for understanding how values and emotions operate as fundamentally interconnected phenomena within institutional life. These two concepts—one capturing the individual-level mechanism through which values-emotions integration occurs in lived experience, the other explicating institutional-level processes of accumulation and persistence—provide the theoretical architecture for reconceptualizing several fundamental aspects of institutional theory that have remained under-theorized despite decades of scholarly attention. By demonstrating how micro-level embodied processes recursively relate to macro-level institutional structures, this framework addresses what Powell and Colyvas (2008) identify as the persistent challenge of linking institutional micro-foundations to organizational and field-level phenomena.

The concept of **evaluative embodiment** that emerges from this synthesis could potentially mark a significant shift in institutional analysis; instead

of seeing values as mental ideas that later gain emotional meaning, or emotions as reactions to situations involving values, evaluative embodiment sees these as closely connected phenomena. When a doctor develops a commitment to patient-centered care, this happens not through separate thinking and emotional learning processes, but through accumulated visceral responses—feeling professional satisfaction when treatment succeeds, experiencing moral distress when witnessing preventable suffering, and sensing fulfillment when providing compassionate care. These bodily evaluations may form the experiential foundation through which abstract institutional values become personally meaningful and have real influence within the institution.

This new perspective may address a long-standing gap in institutional scholarship: the transition from abstract ideas to lived experiences within institutional values. While Selznick (1957) famously described institutions as “infused with value beyond the technical requirements of the task at hand,” the exact processes behind this infusion have remained largely unexplored. The VCI-pragmatist-realist integration suggests that value infusion occurs through patterns of embodied engagement that develop over time, creating what we might call **emotional-historical sedimentation** (see Table 3.3).

Institutional memory research may have yet to fully theorize how affective experiences potentially accumulate and solidify into enduring organizational character. While path dependence literature (Mahoney, 2000) offers explanations of structural lock-in, and collective memory studies (Halbwachs, 1992) address cognitive retention, neither appears to fully capture what might be a transformative process through which repeated emotional experiences could be compressed into institutional bedrock. Drawing speculatively from geological morphology and tentatively extending Connerton’s (1989) concept of bodily social memory, emotional-historical sedimentation attempts to theorize a potential temporal process through which accumulated affective experiences might undergo metaphorical pressure and heat, potentially crystallizing into the deep structures of institutional character. This proposed process may parallel what Schatzki (2010) terms “timespace,” though it would specifically emphasize affective rather than practice-based accumulation.

The provisional boundaries of this conceptualization merit careful consideration to prevent theoretical overreach. The concept would likely address gradual, accumulative processes and therefore might not explain sudden institutional disruptions or punctuated equilibrium changes that could rupture rather than sediment institutional character. It presumably would exclude conscious strategic efforts to reshape institutional culture, as these might represent deliberate interventions rather than organic accumulation processes. Individual resistance to institutional emotional patterns could fall outside

the concept's scope, as such resistance might represent counter-sedimentation forces rather than the sedimentation process itself. Additionally, cross-institutional emotional diffusion processes, while potentially significant, may involve horizontal transfer rather than vertical accumulation and thus could require separate theoretical treatment.

Implications for Understanding Human Agency in Institutional Contexts

The most significant contribution of the integration might be its potential redefinition of moral agency as a function that operates through embodied evaluative processes. This challenges the long-held Cartesian divide between reason and emotion in organizational scholarship, proposing instead that institutional actors navigate moral issues through integrated cognitive and emotional processes. Should an environmental scientist feel visceral discomfort when asked to suppress inconvenient findings, they would not merely be applying abstract ethical principles; they would be engaging in an embodied moral evaluation that occurs before and influences their conscious ethical reasoning.

This analysis suggests that embodied understanding of moral agency has important implications for how we analyze individual autonomy within institutional constraints. VCI's focus on individuals as active moral agents who derive values from multiple sources (Kraatz & Block, 2017; Kraatz et al., 2020) becomes richer when viewed through the lens of embodied evaluation. Individuals maintain moral consistency across various institutional roles not by abstractly reconciling conflicting values, but through bodily evaluations that indicate alignment or misalignment with their core commitments.

Furthermore, this integration highlights the recursive link between individual agency and institutional structure. As individuals participate in evaluative embodiment, their accumulated visceral responses not only influence personal value commitments but also help shape the institutional reality itself. The pragmatist-realist idea that institutions exist through individual affective engagement (Creed et al., 2022; Hudson & Okhuysen, 2009; Jarvis et al., 2019), combined with VCI's recognition of values as historically constructed structures, suggests a dialectical process in which individual embodied experiences both emerge from and contribute to the creation of institutional moral orders.

The recursive relationship between evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation, while offering substantial explanatory power for understanding values-emotions dynamics in institutional life, operates within

specific boundary conditions that merit theoretical specification. First, in coercive institutional contexts where participation occurs through force rather than voluntary engagement—such as prisons, detention facilities, or certain military conscription systems—the mechanism of evaluative embodiment may be fundamentally disrupted or irrelevant to institutional persistence (Dilulio, 1987; Sykes, 1971). These institutions maintain their existence through external enforcement rather than through the accumulation of positive, embodied experiences that generate institutional legitimacy, suggesting that our framework primarily applies to institutions that depend on some degree of voluntary participation or normative commitment. Second, the emergence of virtual and digitally-mediated organizational forms poses theoretical challenges to both evaluative embodiment, which presumes phenomenological presence and visceral experience, and emotional-historical sedimentation, which assumes the accumulation of embodied patterns over time (Bailey et al., 2022; Faraj & Leonardi, 2022). While digital institutions may generate affective responses, the absence of full somatic engagement and the attenuation of visceral evaluation potentially necessitate alternative theoretical mechanisms for understanding values-emotions integration in virtual contexts. Third, temporary organizational forms—such as project-based organizations, pop-up ventures, or emergency response teams—may lack sufficient temporal duration for emotional-historical sedimentation to occur, operating instead through imported sediments from participants' primary institutional affiliations or through anticipatory rather than accumulated patterns (Burke & Morley, 2016; Sydow & Windeler, 2020). These boundary conditions do not invalidate the theoretical framework but rather specify its domain of application: institutions characterized by voluntary participation, embodied presence, and sufficient temporal duration for recursive processes to unfold. Future theoretical development might explore whether modified forms of the recursive relationship operate in these boundary cases, or whether fundamentally different mechanisms govern values-emotions dynamics in coercive, virtual, or temporary institutional contexts.

Reconceptualizing Individual-Institution Relationships

The integration fundamentally changes our understanding of the relationship between individuals and institutions by showing that emotional engagement is a core part of the relationship, not just a result. Institutions gain legitimacy as moral frameworks because individuals find them emotionally meaningful, not just because they provide cognitive schemas or behavioral

guidelines. This insight expands VCI's view of institutions as sources of "cherished values" (Heclo, 2008; Selznick, 1992) by explaining how these values become special through ongoing patterns of positive emotional reactions that build emotional bonds between people and institutional goals.

This reconceptualization has potentially significant implications for understanding institutional dysfunction and reform. Should institutions fail to create positive embodied experiences that align with their stated values—when healthcare professionals experience moral distress rather than professional fulfillment, and when educators face bureaucratic overload rather than pedagogical purpose—this profound emotional discord would undermine institutional legitimacy more fundamentally than mere cognitive disagreement with policies. Conversely, institutional reform that focuses only on formal structures and declared values, while ignoring the embodied experiences of participants, is likely to fail because the emotional reality of institutional life stays unchanged.

Implications for the Nature of (Organizational) Institutions

The historical specificity highlighted by VCI in institutional development gains new significance when viewed through the lens of embodied processes. Institutional uniqueness stems not only from distinct sequences of strategic decisions or environmental adaptations, but also from characteristic patterns of embodied engagement that develop over time. The unique cultures of elite law firms versus public interest legal organizations develop through contrasting patterns of visceral satisfaction—intellectual stimulation and material rewards versus moral fulfillment and community connection—that shape fundamentally different institutional identities, even though they operate within the same professional field.

This embodied understanding of institutional distinctiveness challenges isomorphic tendencies in institutional theory. While institutions may adopt similar formal structures and endorse comparable values, the embodied experiences they create—and thus their lived reality—may differ significantly. Two hospitals may both claim a commitment to patient-centered care, but one fosters patterns of professional fulfillment. At the same time, the other causes moral distress; they represent fundamentally different institutional realities despite surface-level similarities.

Implications for Institutional Leadership and Change

The integration's insights have transformative implications for institutional leadership, indicating that effective leaders must focus not only on articulating values and aligning structures but also on cultivating embodied experiences that make institutional values viscerally compelling. Selznick's (1957) concept of leadership as "infusing organizations with value" becomes more specific: leaders must create conditions for positive evaluative embodiment, enabling experiences that help institutional participants discover values through visceral engagement rather than purely cognitive learning.

This embodied perspective on leadership challenges traditional change management methods that focus on communicating new values and restructuring formal systems. We suggest that successful institutional transformation may involve changing patterns of embodied engagement—creating new forms of visceral satisfaction that align with evolving institutional goals while preserving emotional continuity with existing institutional values. The traditional newspaper's successful shift to digital media depends not just on journalists cognitively accepting new technologies but on finding genuine excitement in interactive reporting, sensing audience engagement through social media, and maintaining investigative satisfaction through data journalism.

Methodological and Empirical Implications

These two theoretical constructs suggest distinct but necessarily complementary methodological approaches that together can capture the full complexity of values–emotions integration in institutional contexts. Evaluative embodiment requires phenomenological methods capable of accessing the simultaneous visceral–cognitive experiences that characterize this integrated process: experience sampling methodologies that track bodily sensations alongside value assessments in real-time (drawing on approaches developed by Voronov & Weber, 2016), video ethnography that captures embodied responses to institutional situations as they unfold in naturalistic settings, and interview protocols specifically designed to probe what Connerton (1989) terms "biographical body memory"—the accumulated embodied knowledge that shapes how individuals navigate institutional contexts.

Emotional-historical sedimentation, operating at a different temporal scale and level of analysis, demands historical methods capable of tracing accumulation processes over extended periods: organizational genealogies

that map the evolution of emotional patterns across institutional generations (following, for instance, methodological innovations by Suddaby et al., 2023), career history interviews that reveal how individual trajectories contribute to and are shaped by institutional sediments, and comparative case studies that explain divergent institutional characters despite similar formal structures and espoused values. The integration of these methodological approaches—phenomenological and historical, micro and macro, synchronic and diachronic—mirrors the theoretical integration we propose, suggesting that advancing our understanding of values-emotions dynamics in institutional life requires methodological pluralism that matches the phenomenon's inherent complexity.

Critically, investigating the recursive relationship between evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation demands longitudinal research designs capable of simultaneously tracking individual trajectories and institutional evolution—what might be termed recursive process methodologies. Multi-level ethnography becomes essential, following individual actors' embodied experiences while concurrently mapping institutional change, attending to how particular moments of evaluative embodiment contribute to institutional sedimentation and how evolving sediments shape subsequent embodied encounters (Zilber, 2002). Recursive process tracing, adapted from historical institutionalism (Mahoney, 2000), would examine specific pathways through which individual visceral-cognitive experiences aggregate into institutional patterns that subsequently condition new generations of embodied experience. Career history methodologies, expanded to incorporate phenomenological dimensions, could trace how individuals' accumulated evaluative embodiments both reflect and reshape institutional sediments across professional lifecycles (Bucheli & Wadhwani, 2014; Hargadon & Wadhwani, 2023). Such methodological innovations must capture what Pettigrew (1990) terms “temporal interconnectedness,” though specifically attending to the embodied-emotional rather than merely strategic or structural dimensions of institutional time. These approaches require researchers to be reflexive about their own evaluative embodiment within research settings, recognizing that investigating embodied institutional processes necessarily involves the researcher's own visceral and cognitive engagement with institutional phenomena.

Practical Implications for Institutional Design and Intervention

The insights from this integration provide practical guidance for institutional architects and reformers. Institutional design should focus not only on formal structures and declared values but also on cultivating embodied experiences that make institutional purposes emotionally meaningful. Professional education programs, for example, should go beyond simply transmitting professional codes to create immersive experiences where students can discover professional values through embodied engagement—through the felt responsibility of client interaction, the visceral satisfaction of skilled practice, and the embodied solidarity of the professional community.

Similarly, institutional interventions focused on cultural change or value transformation must consider the embodied reality of institutional life. Change efforts that modify formal structures but leave patterns of visceral experience untouched—those that promote new values while maintaining embodied practices that oppose them—will ultimately fail. Effective intervention requires careful attention to the phenomenological aspects of institutional participation, creating new opportunities for positive evaluative embodiment that support the desired institutional values.

Conclusion: Toward an Embodied Institutionalism

The theoretical architecture presented in this chapter—two concepts linked through recursive causation—achieves a parsimony that paradoxically enhances rather than reduces explanatory power. Where more discrete concepts might offer comprehensive coverage through conceptual proliferation, the recursive relationship between evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation generates emergent theoretical capacity that transcends additive explanation. The bidirectional causation linking these concepts creates what systems theorists recognize as non-linear dynamics (Byrne & Callaghan, 2022), wherein the recursive interaction between individual and institutional levels produces institutional phenomena—stability, change, persistence, transformation—that cannot be reduced to either level independently. This theoretical refinement addresses a fundamental challenge in institutional scholarship: the tendency toward either reductionist accounts that privilege individual agency or deterministic frameworks that emphasize structural constraint. By theorizing recursivity

as constitutive rather than merely connective, this framework demonstrates how institutional life emerges through the ongoing dialectical relationship between embodied individual experience and sedimented institutional patterns. The recursive architecture thus provides not merely a bridge between levels but a reconceptualization of how levels themselves are mutually constituted through processes of evaluative embodiment and emotional-historical sedimentation.

The implications go beyond academic discussions to address urgent issues facing modern institutions. In an era marked by institutional fragility, where traditional organizations face unprecedented pressures and public trust declines across various sectors, understanding how values become emotionally meaningful through embodied experiences is crucial for the survival and renewal of institutions. Institutions that do not foster positive evaluative embodied patterns—those that cause moral distress instead of professional fulfillment, bureaucratic overload instead of meaningful engagement—may struggle to sustain themselves, regardless of their formal structures or stated values. However, this integration also offers hope for institutional renewal. By revealing the embodied processes through which institutional values become personally meaningful and collectively sustained, it suggests potential pathways to revive institutions that have lost their purpose. Instead of viewing institutional reform simply as restructuring or rebranding, an embodied institutionalism focuses on fostering visceral experiences that reconnect individuals with institutional values, thereby creating patterns of evaluative embodiment that support both personal growth and institutional vitality.

As we face an uncertain future for institutions, the framework introduced in this chapter offers promising tools for understanding and supporting institutions that fulfill human needs and aspirations. By taking seriously the embodied reality of institutional life—the visceral evaluations through which people engage with institutional values—we can better understand both how institutions stay resilient and how they are vulnerable. This understanding would enable the development of approaches to institutional design and leadership that respect the full complexity of human experience within institutional settings. By integrating values and emotions through embodied processes, we find not only a theoretical innovation but also a vital practical need for maintaining the foundations of human well-being.

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4

Overarching Values: The Pivotal Role of Organizational Values in Navigating Uncertainty

Rosa Fioravante and Antonino Vaccaro

Introduction

Although underestimated in their ability to inform organizational practices and strategic decision-making (Kraatz et al., 2020; Van Der Linden & Freeman, 2017), values have recently been at the center of renewed scholarly attention. The latter has come from a variety of streams of research, among which humanistic management and humanizing business hold a relevant place (Acevedo, 2018; Pirson & Lawrence, 2010; Rosanas, 2008). More in-depth, the humanistic perspective poses values at the center of its understanding of human nature, refusing the monodimensional model of the *homo oeconomicus* (Melé & Cantón, 2014). Consequently, humanism focuses on organizational responsibilities to respect and support the unfolding of all inherent material and immaterial dimensions of the person, among which values are crucial (Argandoña, 2003; Melé, 2015). Moreover, such a perspective assesses the role of values in organizational survival and success, especially

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in contexts of turbulence and crisis, where leveraging them to pursue stakeholders' engagement and promote social change has been proven crucial (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015).

Relying on previous organizational literature, we refer to values as "desirable, trans-situational goals, varying in importance that serve as guiding principles in people's lives" (Schwartz, 1994; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015). Values are a critical variable of all components of ethical organizations, whether it be ethical leadership, ethical organizational culture, ethical stakeholder management and engagement, and ethical human resource management (see, among others Dempsey, 2015; Lemoine et al., 2019; Van Der Linden & Freeman, 2017). We here discuss how the notion of organizational moral values (Rosanas & Velilla, 2005; Scott, 2002) was developed as distinct from the idea of organizations depending on individual values of their components. More in detail, we discuss the role of values work in informing organizational inquiry (Espedal et al., 2021; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024; Gehman et al., 2013).

By building on the latter perspective, and by recalling Schwartz's lesson on the hierarchical ordering of values and its related debate (Schwartz, 1994; Schwartz & Bilsky, 1987), we enquire into the relative importance of organizational values. Specifically, by enhancing current research on values work in turbulent contexts (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015) we propose the notion of *overarching values*. Indeed, while literature has widely discussed the existence of core values, there remains a need for greater conceptual precision in distinguishing between types of values that operate within this category. Core values are typically understood as deeply ingrained, enduring principles that define what an organization stands for. However, not all core values serve the same function, particularly in moments of crisis, uncertainty, or value conflict (Collins & Porras, 1996; Lencioni, 2002).

Thus, we define organizational *overarching values* as desirable trans-situational goals that support the sensemaking of other values, in particular in situations of organizational distress, constituting the fundamental pillars of organizational culture. As such, *overarching values* can guide organizational choices at the strategic, operational, and ethical levels. By fostering coherence and alignment among stakeholders, even during periods of instability or uncertainty, *overarching values* help organizations maintain their identity, integrity, and legitimacy.

This new construct emerges from the deep examination of empirical research within the empirical context of hybrid organizations, which have long been at the center of scholarly inquiry into values work (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). Hybrid organizations, which operate across institutional

logics—such as market and mission—face inherent tensions that demand value prioritization. These organizations often experience conflicting pressures between social impact and economic viability. In such environments, the distinction between core and overarching values becomes particularly relevant. While many values may be shared across different segments of the organization, overarching values serve as integrative mechanisms, aligning divergent logics under a unified normative direction.

More in detail, we discuss the case of Addiopizzo, a Sicilian grassroots movement against Mafia extortion, turned into a hybrid organization blending community activism, ethical consumerism labeling, a travel agency, and an entrepreneurial network (Battilana et al., 2017). Earlier studies on Addiopizzo have highlighted how the organization effectively utilized values to foster stakeholder engagement and drive social transformation (Vaccaro, 2012; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015). Our research extends this perspective by exploring how values are not only cultivated dynamically through the organization's evolving operations—impacting both internal and external stakeholders and influencing strategic directions—but also how these values interact with one another and shape one another in a dynamic, interdependent process.

This chapter details the role of values in humanizing organizations and how *overarching values* can be identified as key constructs within research on relative ordering of values, through the following discussion: Sect. “[Introduction](#)” discusses the emergence of the notion of organizational moral values and how it informs the main components of ethical organizational behavior; Sect. “[From the Establishment of Organizational Moral Values to Values Work](#)” summarizes the debate on the relative importance of values by evaluating the current state of the art and proposing to overcome some existing distinctions between different categories of values; Sect. “[From the Relative Importance of Values to Overarching Values](#)” summarizes findings showing the emergence of *overarching values* from empirical research. Section “[Overarching Values](#)” summarizes the main contributions of the chapter.

From the Establishment of Organizational Moral Values to Values Work

Organizational Moral Values

Notwithstanding the recent synthesis proposed by Kraatz et al. stating that “an institution without values is a mere control structure” (Kraatz et al., 2020, p. 38), organizational moral values’ emergence, persistence, and existence have long been debated. Such debate is part of a more extensive engagement into theoretical stances on the moral agency of the firm. Indeed, institutionalists focusing on values have long argued about a distinct moral order of organizational values from the personal/individual one (Selznick, 1994). Some conveyed such views by distinguishing personal and organizational values as leading, respectively, members’ private actions and decisions and members’ behavior as belonging to the organization and its resource allocation choices (Edwards & Cable, 2009, p. 655).

According to some organizations’ views as “systems of decisions” (Thyssen, 2009), the inner rationale of organizational existence lies outside the scope of morality, centering around its functioning for its own sake. According to such vision, morality is to be deployed only in assessing unethical behavior when something does not correctly work in the intended direction. Others discuss “organizational moral values” as the cornerstone concept of ethical behavior (Scott, 2002). The latter notion, first conceived by Scott, held that the most relevant organizational values are moral ones, defined as: “beliefs about what is good and evil controllable behavior, bearing on relations to self, to others, to God, and the natural and animal world” (Scott, 2002, pp. 33–4). Of first and foremost importance, there would be five categories of organizational moral values: Justice, respect for life, respect for property, honest communication, and respect for religion (Scott, 2002, p. 34). Such organizational values are recalled in their relevance for both organizational behavior and success: “They form the organizational culture, giving “personality” to a company, but they are also the engine that drives all business priorities as well as the entrance and exodus processes for members” (Malbašić et al., 2015, p. 440). Such a view recalls previous theorizing on how organizations typically develop conflicting or divergent values (Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004) that eventually are elaborated within the “organizational self” as a coherent organizational pattern. The role of coherence and incoherence among organizational values has recently gained new insights as part of a debate on inconsistency between organizational values and organizational behavior, often at the center of “washing” claims (Pope & Wæraas, 2016). Unlike previous studies,

holding that organizational values are determined only by internal factors (Collins & Porras, 1996), recent research suggests that the role of “collective moral values” should be further understood about social macro-level influence (Schminke et al., 2015). Values are central to enquiries into how moral organizational values influence ethical practices and conduct of corporations and how values influence how organizations respond to their inconsistencies when spotted (Walker & Wan, 2012; Warren, 2022). Indeed, values play a critical role in building a sense of moral responsibility for individuals belonging to the organization, contributing to avoiding organizational misconduct (Dempsey, 2015).

Indeed, values play a vital role within the “organizational moral structure” of five main components, the first of which is found in “leaders’ values and character”. Even when organizational values directly stem from personal leadership, the development of a distinctive organizational “moral competence” can be observed (Adla et al., 2020; Roszkowska & Melé, 2021).

Humanistic Values as Organizational Values

Values are central to humanistic management theories overlapping with development ethics, such as the integral human development (IHD) paradigm (Keleher, 2018). As Chachine has recently noted:

Development is a values-sensitive subject. [...] ‘values of human well-being, justice, and human dignity adequately are reflected in practice; and how can attention to those values be supported; as well as what is the significance of culture and how far are values justifiably culturally relative?’. (p. 284, Chachine, 2022)

Among the most significant approaches underpinning humanism in business, IHD proposes a set of values universally recognized as relevant to human capabilities unfolding and wellbeing. These values are recognized as universal and central to each person’s full attainment of development (Keleher, 2018). In its Catholic Social Teaching stream of thought (originated from Paul VI, *Populorum Progressio* in 1967), it has been underlined how the lack of “profound attitudes which human beings can make into absolute values” (John Paul II, 1987, 37) can undermine people’s ability to reach IHD (Melé, 2015). Human dignity, the promotion of the Common Good, and the quest for eudaimonia are among those that cannot be lacking if a person finds herself on a path to individual and collective flourishing (Fioravante et al., 2025).

Such a view holds many implications for management: Every organization relies on assumptions concerning the nature of human beings and human action. To recall a significant example of such implications, Rosanas and Velilla (2005) focused on management control systems and their impact on personal development, which would require respecting and supporting the possibility of developing technical and moral values. The latter are both essential components of desirable human behavior in organized contexts. Therefore, the responsibility of management to support the possibility for each person to better oneself through values in many dimensions is affirmed (Rosanas, 2008; Rosanas & Velilla, 2005). Focusing on values and developing awareness of their role is thus a prerequisite for deploying a humanistic sensibility toward integral development. Indeed, focusing on values helps to convey a renewed understanding of human behavior, far from *homo oeconomicus* schematization, and to assess the main drivers of desirable social and personal outcomes attainment in organized life (Flores, 2015; Selznick, 2008).

Humanistic Values and Humanizing Stakeholders

Organizational values are key to pursue stakeholder engagement models based on humanizing stakeholders (Quintelier et al., 2021). Stakeholders' values must be considered in their subjective interpretation and manifestation, understood and aligned with those of the organization, in order to avoid falling into what has been defined as "the dark side of stakeholder engagement": mere exploitation of stakeholders' role as instrumental to narrow interests (Kujala et al., 2022). Further enquiries have shown the importance of values—cultural, moral and others—in informing strategies of stakeholder engagement, aimed at supporting better working conditions for internals and achieving optimal levels of stakeholders' agency and responsible interaction (Cubilla-Montilla et al., 2019; Greenwood, 2007). A comprehensive approach to the topic has been suggested by looking at "systems of values" as a relevant terrain upon which managers can engage stakeholders in order to promote dialogue and mutual understanding, thus promoting the recognition of the dignity of the other in its thoroughness (Rodríguez-Luesma et al., 2014). Organizational values hold impact on each person's processes of reflexivity and self-reflexivity, positing at the center of sensemaking processes, leading to the privilege of some values over others within the organization (Fatien Diochon & Nizet, 2019).

Such centrality of values in literature discussing humanizing business and organizations (Melé, 2016) is due to the progressive acknowledging of organizational studies of the centrality of non-strictly economic-related variables' influence on organizational behavior at all levels (Guillén et al., 2015). As values are discussed among the main drivers of organizational ability to reach desirable outcomes (Anderson, 1997; French, 1979), humanistic values are to be considered not only pertaining to the personal sphere, but rather as a component of humanistic-centered organizations (Melé, 2024; Sandelands, 2009).

Organizational Moral Values in Hybrid Organizations

The role of organizational moral values holds significant importance in understanding the behavior of hybrid organizations, which operate within the blurred boundaries between the private and public sectors and between profit-oriented and non-profit objectives (Battilana et al., 2017). Values are identified as pivotal for organizations in achieving various goals (Malbašić et al., 2015). Within the complex institutional landscape, value pluralism emerges as a primary driver of conflicting priorities among hybrids (Castellas et al., 2019), influencing goal-setting and attainment. Consequently, how hybrids navigate value pluralism can shape their organizational strategies, either advancing their social mission or leading to mission drifts (Ramus & Vaccaro, 2017).

Hybrid organizations face challenges stemming from tensions between personal and organizational values, as they prioritize one over others, potentially conflicting with internal logic (Mitzinneck & Besharov, 2019; Pache & Santos, 2013). Moreover, the design of incentive systems within hybrids relies on guiding values to articulate their mission amidst competing logic and norms (Ebrahim et al., 2014). Values, norms, and expectations contribute significantly to organizational authenticity as hybrids seek recognition and legitimacy in the market and non-market contexts (Radoynovska & Ruttan, 2023). Values can drive organizational change and explore new forms of organizing, especially in complex contexts, pursuing social change through novel organizing (Flecha & Ngai, 2014). In such environments, values serve as a means of alignment among social movements, private and public organizations, and civil society (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015; Daskalaki et al., 2019).

Values Work

Central to the motivation, commitment, and wellbeing of employees, members, and relevant stakeholders, values alignment forms a robust foundation for supporting individuals' happiness and flourishing, consequently increasing the likelihood of ethical behavior (Grojean et al., 2004; Pirson, 2019; Posner, 2010). By fostering positive interpersonal relationships grounded in mutual respect, honesty, and integrity, values ultimately support virtues by consistently guiding behaviors with specific values (Argandoña, 2003). The alignment between members and an organization's values has been investigated as a predictor of success or failure in organizational change efforts, with congruence between personal and organizational values linked to organizational success (Burnes & Jackson, 2011). Literature has examined the processes by which individuals progressively adopt organizational values at the expense of their own (Goodpaster, 2007).

However, while the existence and significance of organizational moral values are acknowledged, the emergence of such values from organizational practices and dynamic relationships among members and stakeholders still needs to be completed. The values work framework (Gehman et al., 2013) has contributed significantly to the study of values in practice by exploring the intertwining of personal beliefs, ethical (or unethical) organizational behavior, and the mutual influence between values institutionalization and the surrounding environment. This literature has facilitated a reshaping of institutionalism by conceptualizing values as emerging through practice and evolving in everyday contexts (Espedal et al., 2021). Research on values work has addressed several limitations encountered in previous literature, including the difficulty of observing values creation and actions, inadequate explanations for the processes generating values, and the context dependence of values, enhancing the generalizability of values research (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004).

By contextualizing ideal beliefs within social settings, values work literature has developed explanatory models that address these limitations through methodological innovations capable of capturing the roles of values in action, particularly collective action (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021; Sirris et al., 2020). This perspective shifts the focus from identifying values held by individuals, groups, or nations to understanding the process of values as they emerge, are shared, and become established within specific contexts, organizations, or institutions (Langley & Tsoukas, 2010). Consequently, values work has

provided insights into various organizational dimensions of values emergence and development, including spirituality, private–public partnerships, and leadership (Sirris et al., 2020).

While organizational values are typically initially shaped by founders or leaders, the concept of values work elucidates how such values can also arise from bottom-up practices (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015). Furthermore, the framework of values work has facilitated research on the exchange dynamics between organizations' internal and external environments concerning values, elucidating their relationships and the processes by which broader social elements are incorporated into organizational contexts (Suddaby et al., 2010). Ultimately, by focusing on the interplay and inherent dynamics of values emergence and development, the values work framework transcends the traditional theoretical dichotomy between personal and collective values, offering a more comprehensive understanding of organizational values.

From the Relative Importance of Values to Overarching Values

Values Reciprocal Relations

Many authors have sought to characterize the reciprocal relations that values hold between each other.

The cornerstone characterization of Schwartz and Bilsky (1987, p. 551) of values recalled how values “are ordered by relative importance.” However, Schwartz himself has argued that hierarchies of values focus on how values are phrased within the analysis rather than on an actual difference observed in their motivational ability, therefore declaring skepticism in assessing their different importance. Nonetheless, many efforts have gone in this direction.

A significant distinction in ordering values is looking into which values are deployed as means to achieve others as ends (such underpinning idea is common to distinctions such as the one between instrumental and ultimate values, for example (Argandoña, 2003). Others have discussed the difference between “positive and negative values,” i.e., those leading to action and those preventing an action (Donaldson & Walsh, 2015). A relevant distinction is to be found by looking into which values are context-dependent—as well as agent-specific—and which are not; these values are considered situational or non-situational (Scott, 2002).

Another relevant characterization of values comes from literature assessing their relevance for organizational ratio and survival. Collins and Porras discuss

the concept of “core values” defined as: “Core values and beliefs are the organization’s basic precepts about what is important in both business and life, how business should be conducted, its view of humanity, its role in society, the way the world works, and what is to be held inviolate. In outstanding organizations, key individuals deeply feel and reinforce the values and beliefs at critical junctures in the organization’s history.” (Collins & Porras, 1996). The utmost relevance of such values comes from their resilience: in no situation are they questioned under external pressure. Lencioni (2002) has defined core values as being cross-organizational: “Core values are the deeply ingrained principles that guide all of a company’s actions; they serve as its cultural cornerstones.” (Lencioni, 2002). Building on such a concept, Sirris (2020) has more recently highlighted how core values are not fixed but rather emerge from tensions and negotiations. Therefore, it is possible to grasp how values work and play a role in their formation.

Hierarchical Perspective and Research Gap

Previous literature has thus enquired extensively into how values stand in reciprocal relationships. While some have discussed the topic by adopting a “hierarchical” perspective, looking into values’ situational, agent-specific, and instrumental features, others have offered a distinction based on values’ relevance for organizational *raison d’être* and organizational survival, others based on how values emerge in constrained time frames or as durable regardless of the period considered (please see Table 4.1 for a concise summary of different approaches to the reciprocal relationships between values).

Debates within the latter perspective have not come to a univocal conclusion on the dynamics of forming such values and their role. While enquiries into core values discuss their nonnegotiability and fixed feature in time, even in times of crisis (except for Sirris’ 2020 discussion of core values as fixed and fluid), how non-core values relate with them is yet to be fully understood. Furthermore, it is yet to be clarified how core values are precipitated into practices when addressing and overcoming crises and turbulent contexts. We seek to enhance our knowledge of the last research gap by characterizing a particular type of core values, which we define as *overarching values*, when values play a critical role in organizations navigating uncertainty. More in detail, this chapter seeks to answer the research question on how can *overarching values* guide organizations through turbulence and crisis?

Table 4.1 Relative importance of organizational values

Author(s)	Values constructs
Argandoña (2003)	Ultimate values: values representing final goals or ends in themselves Instrumental values: values serving as means to achieve other ends
Donaldson and Walsh (2015)	Positive values: values leading to action and promoting specific outcomes Negative values: values that prevent actions or serve as constraints
Scott (2002)	Non-situational values: values independent of context and universally applicable Situational values: values dependent on context and specific to individual agents
Collins and Porras (1996)	Core values: basic precepts guiding the organization without the need to external justification; resilient under pressure Non-core: changing practices and strategies all the time
Lencioni (2002)	Core values: deeply ingrained principles guiding all organizational actions Aspirational values: needed for organizational success but currently lacking Permission-to-pay-values: minimum standards for internals to behold Accidental values: arise without leadership intentionality
Sirris (2020)	Core values fixed: extend beyond the particular context Core values fluid: emerging from tensions and organizational negotiations in particular contexts

Overarching Values

Here, we provide a summary of how the concept of *overarching values* has emerged from empirical research, building on the values work framework mentioned above in the context of turbulence and crisis.

Empirical Setting

Addiopizzo is a prominent Italian organization dedicated to combating the pervasive influence of organized crime, particularly the Sicilian Mafia. It represents a unique case of bottom-up mobilizing of different components

of civil society (entrepreneurs, small shop owners, political activists, news outlets, etc.) to raise civic awareness against crime, pressure public institutions, and create a network of private and hybrid realities. Founded in 2004 by a group of friends involved in the economic and social fabric of the city of Palermo, Addiopizzo emerged as a grassroots movement aimed at challenging the Mafia's control over businesses through extortion practices, commonly referred to as "pizzo." The movement began when a group of young Sicilian activists discovered the overwhelming prevalence of pizzo while planning to open a small business. Disillusioned by the Mafia's control and the complicity of society, they launched Addiopizzo (literally "Goodbye Pizzo") with a provocative slogan: "A whole people who pay the pizzo is a people without dignity." This message, initially spread through anonymous posters in Palermo, resonated deeply with the public, exposing the silent complicity that allowed the Mafia's extortion practices to thrive.

The organization's primary objective has been to empower businesses and individuals to resist paying protection money to criminal organizations, weakening the Mafia's economic stronghold and fostering a legality and ethical entrepreneurship culture. Addiopizzo's primary goal is to create a cultural shift that empowers businesses and citizens to reject mafia control. Its strategy includes: Consumer-Driven Ethical Resistance: Addiopizzo encourages consumers to support businesses that refuse to pay pizzo by joining the "pizzo-free" network. Participating businesses commit to rejecting extortion and are listed in a public directory, incentivizing consumer support. Support for Businesses refusing to pay the pizzo: The organization provides legal, financial, and moral support to businesses that take a stand against the mafia. This includes guidance on how to report extortion attempts and collaborate with law enforcement. Community Mobilization and awareness campaigns: Addiopizzo engages local schools, community groups, and cultural institutions to raise awareness about the damaging impact of the mafia. Educational campaigns emphasize the importance of ethical behavior and civic responsibility. Collaboration with Law Enforcement: Addiopizzo works closely with authorities to report extortion cases and protect businesses that denounce mafia activities. This partnership helps ensure that legal and institutional frameworks back the movement's efforts.

Other related projects compel an "Addiopizzo Travel Agency" able to put tourists in direct contact with virtuous structures in the hospitality industry refusing ties with the mafia; widespread organizing of public events and social gatherings; advisory and consultancy help for threatened businesses facing extortion; advocacy for legal reforms and educational initiatives.

Through its efforts, Addiopizzo has garnered widespread domestic and international support, garnering attention for its innovative strategies and commitment to promoting social change. Despite facing threats and intimidation from criminal elements, the organization continues to expand its reach and influence, inspiring similar anti-mafia movements across Italy and beyond.

Research Design and Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative approach (Reinecke et al., 2016; Strauss & Corbin, 1998) that grounds on the tradition of critical realism (Vaccaro & Ramus, 2025), particularly relevant to grasp values work unfolding in organizations, by centering around the perspective of the interviewees and acknowledging the perspective of the researcher within participatory observation (Chachine, 2022; Espedal et al., 2022).

The observational period covers four years, from 2019 to September 2023.

Although building on earlier studies (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015), this chapter draws on empirical data gathered during a distinct and later time period that coincides with a more advanced organizational stage. This temporal shift enables us to capture how legality emerges as a guiding principle at both strategic and operational levels.

We performed direct observation for 40 hours during 11 events organized by Addiopizzo in Sicily. Both authors performed ten interviews with activists and other relevant stakeholders and collected over 100 articles in local and national newspapers that covered the activities of Addiopizzo in the period of observation.

To ensure the internal reliability of the study (Bagozzi, 2011), authors presented a final draft of the research to key informants and requested final comments. This interactive process was terminated when authors received a final written message from the organization that fully validated the results of the study.

Findings

Previous research on the topic, explicitly enquiring into the Addiopizzo organization, had underlined how activists leveraged values to pursue stakeholder engagement and ultimately promote social change (Vaccaro, 2012; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015). Our research builds on previous work by adding

how values emerge: not only dynamically throughout the unfolding of organizational operations, both affecting internals and externals and shaping its strategy, but also in a dynamical relation one to the others. More in-depth, we here summarize the proposed notion of *overarching values* that emerged from our analysis of public data plus interviews. We observed how the value of “Legality” informs sensemaking at individual and collective levels, shedding new light on its relationship with other values. More specifically, it presented four distinctive characteristics: has a higher ontological status, has a critical role for organizational culture, provides guidance to keep coherence and alignment between operational and strategic perspectives and between long-term and short-term objectives, provides guidance in difficult decision-making processes associated with moral dilemmas.

Higher Ontological Status

Our data show that legality emerges not just as one value among many, but as the one that structures and displays the ability to inform sensemaking of other organizational values. It does not merely coexist with other ideals like dignity, responsibility, or solidarity; rather, it frames and sustains their intelligibility. It functions as an epistemic anchor, enabling the organization to define what dignity or solidarity mean within the context of anti-mafia activism. Indeed, it acquires a “higher” ontological status as the value that better compels references to others:

Whatever we do in Addiopizzo makes sense only in light of legality. When we talk about dignity, we say it in terms of the ideal of legality; when we talk about responsible consumption, this only makes sense in light of legality; when we talk about solidarity, once again, it has a tangible meaning within a logic of legality. (Interview activist #1)

This foundational role elevates legality to an ontological level where it conditions the very possibility of the organization’s worldview. For instance, responsible consumption is not treated as an abstract ethical imperative but is evaluated strictly in terms of legality:

Sometimes it is not easy for a foreigner or a person external to the movement to understand the meaning of “responsible consumption” ... for us, it has a clear and tangible meaning only and only about legality... we can allow ourselves to ask an extra effort for the consumer to go further away to buy bread, or to choose one restaurant rather than another only and solely based on legality. (Interview activist #3)

This anchoring role is further emphasized through metaphorical language that portrays legality as a guiding light or a principle of orientation:

It's the lighthouse, without it we would be a marionette that moves senselessly.
(Interview activist #4)

Moreover, the value is continually interrogated and reconstructed collaboratively, as shown, for instance, in civic education projects. Thus, legality isn't rigid; it's actively rearticulated through dialogue, practice, and reflection, further reinforcing its centrality.

In Italian schools [where Addiopizzo operates for awareness projects] legality is the label that is given to all projects tied to civic responsibility. It is straightforward: you follow the laws. But Italy is nowadays full of laws that contradicts themselves and sometimes are even against the citizens. Our businessowners tell us that following legality is essential but is also difficult. For example, we speak of 'aware legality,' which is a specific declination of legality which comprises active citizenship, shared responsibility etc. By doing that we always ask: how can we define better legality? So that there is a process of co-defining it together. (Interview Activist and Cofounder #6)

Necessary to Organizational Identity

Our data empirical evidence shows that legality as an overarching value is a fundamental pillar of organizational culture and identity, i.e., a value without which the organizational culture would be significantly different than the one displayed. These values are necessary for the organization to change its members radically, aims, leadership, etc.

It is not one value among many that can be substituted or deprioritized—without it, the collective would lose its defining character.

This was strongly asserted at public events and conferences:

The culture of Addiopizzo can be explained with one word: legality. (Activist statement, Palermo Conference, 2019)

The culture of legality is the only thing that unites us and makes us united in the face of all the difficulties we encounter. (Public event declaration, 2022)

A shift away from legality would not merely signal a change of strategy—it would mean the unraveling of Addiopizzo's foundational ethos.

Key to Uphold Coherence

Our data show that *legality* as an *overarching value* emerges as the value leading organizational choices at both strategic and operational levels at the same time; therefore, they display a profound coherence and alignment between long-term and short-term objectives, as well as in solving related tensions that might arise.

Activists explain that legality functions as an organizing principle behind all initiatives:

In the end, everything we do follows the single strategy of pursuing legality, spreading the culture of legality in society, and supporting legality in the world of the real economy and, in particular, in entrepreneurship, which has suffered for decades, if not for centuries, the influence of crime. (Interview Activist #2)

This guiding role is embedded in daily processes and organizational boundaries, especially when navigating gray areas:

When we have a doubt about how to do something, or when to start a new activity, especially when there are complications to manage, I stop to think what is the correct thing to do to pursue the ideal of legality which in the end is our lighthouse. (interview Activist #5)

In our internal processes the value issue is primary. “Be honest appear honest” is the reason behind our choices (...) it is a behavioral scheme. Everything that is outside legality for us is outside our history. When there are businessowners who are borderline, we support them in denouncing the mafia, we always provide assistance, but they are not part of Addiopizzo. (Interview Activist and Cofounder #6)

Compass in Difficult Choices

Given the above-mentioned features, *legality* also qualifies as the one the organization can look upon when needing a sound compass. This is the case of organizational crises arising from internal conflict or a blockage. *Overarching values* are, therefore, those that display the feature of rescuing values in contexts of crisis, as they can shed a univocal light on dilemmas and multiple variables to be considered in making difficult choices. This capacity to “rescue” the organization from internal conflict is perhaps the most dynamic expression of its overarching nature.

This is illustrated by its use in resolving internal disputes:

The other time there was a heavy discussion... Alpha 1 and Alpha 2 did not agree on Addiopizzo's participation in a public event... in the end Alpha 3 asked "but is this by our goal of legality? Or do we risk something colliding? That was the key used by Alpha 3 to resolve a situation of internal blockage and conflict. (Interview Activist #1)

Following the above-mentioned four characteristics, our findings also show examples of internal tensions which were overcome by leveraging the value of legality. In particular, legality serves as an *overarching value* in contexts of organizational dilemma, where telling right vs. wrong is not straightforward.

Legality helps navigate not only interpersonal conflicts, but also organizational dilemmas, such as tensions between Addiopizzo and its commercial offshoot Addiopizzo Travel:

Legality is the precondition of our being together (...), it helped us as a lighthouse in decisions upon what to do when tensions arose between, for instance, Addiopizzo (movement) and Addiopizzo Travel (social enterprise). Addiopizzo Travel needs to make different decisions to those of a voluntary movement, given that needs to meet customers and suppliers needs. Addiopizzo Travel decided that only offers travels with Addiopizzo certified enterprises as suppliers, but what to do when for a given service there are none to offer? (...) In that case you have different options, and legality helps you to choose among them coherently with its spirit. Sometimes we opted for not offering a service, as we could not have a certified Addiopizzo service for that, for us it would be embarrassing to choose in a way which is not completely coherent with legality. (Interview Activist and Cofounder #6)

When interacting with new stakeholders or exploring new geographic contexts—such as organizing ethical tours in Naples—legality is the critical value that frames partnership decisions:

For example, Addiopizzo does not exist in Naples. However, we offer travels to Naples. Therefore, we acted to choose different partners because we trusted them and we shared the same values, making them sign a document where they cleared that they do not have any tie with Camorra (Naples Mafia). This is because we based the choice on the lighthouse of legality to be exempt from criticism and attacks. (Interview Activist and Cofounder #6)

Discussion

We contribute to literature of organizational values (Espedal et al. 2022; Kraatz et al., 2020; Malbašić et al. 2015; Thyssen, 2009) and values work (Espedal and Carlsen 2021; Gehman et al. 2013; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015), introducing and characterizing the *overarching values* construct.

In particular, *overarching values* hold the following four characteristics:

1. *Overarching values* display a higher ontological level as they display the ability to inform sensemaking of other organizational values
2. *Overarching values* are central to characterize the organizational culture
3. *Overarching values* help the organization to align strategic and operational levels, *short-term* vs. *long-term* tensions.
4. *Overarching values* are used in contexts of uncertainty on what is to be done, when there are moral dilemmas and/or organizational *crises*.

While numbers 1 and 2 are discussed in the literature as belonging to core values as well (among others, see the foundational piece by Collins & Porras, 1996), numbers 3 and 4 emerge as differentiating for *overarching values*.

Building on the foundational definition of values by Schwartz (1994), which highlights the trans-situational feature they display, we enhance our current understanding of how values inform organizational decision-making in heterogeneous contexts. We do so by extending our knowledge of *core values* as articulated by Collins and Porras (1996)—namely, values that are deeply embedded, non-negotiable, and enduring—we propose that *overarching values* are best understood as a functional subset of core values with critical importance for organizations. Not all core values serve an overarching function. Rather, among a set of core values, *overarching values* are those that are activated under conditions of tension, ambiguity, or crisis, and are particularly consequential in shaping strategic orientation and collective decision-making. We also build upon the work of Sirris (2020), who discusses the fluidity and durability of core values in hybrid organizations. While Sirris emphasizes the ways values emerge and shift across contexts, our contribution adds a novel analytical layer: *overarching values* are not merely emergent from tension—they are values that enable an organization to navigate and transcend such tension. They do so by being historically rooted, widely internalized, and normatively dominant in the face of uncertainty.

Where core values provide a broad cultural and identity-based foundation, *overarching values* serve a hierarchical and integrative role—they anchor not only what the organization believes, but also how it *prioritizes* those beliefs in

moments of moral, strategic, or operational uncertainty. In this way, *overarching values* offer a *normative compass* that allows the organization to resolve internal contradictions or external pressures when multiple core values may appear in tension.

The notion of an overarching value does not imply that it is the only core value, nor that it unilaterally “overrides” all others. Rather, its distinctiveness lies in its primacy of guidance—it becomes the referential value that organizations return to when forced to adjudicate between competing imperatives. In hybrid or pluralistic settings, this is particularly relevant: the *overarching value* does not eliminate tensions but provides a *principled resolution path* through them.

We define *overarching values* as values that display a higher ontological status compared to others. Thanks to such characterization, these values can play a pivotal role within organizations, by now under-researched by current literature. First, these values represent a pillar of organizational culture, which informs all organizational levels. Second, these values display the ability to support sensemaking of other values in contexts of “stuck situations”, where the organization is experiencing a crisis in determining its action at the strategic level. Such values are indeed able to function as a strategic, operational, and ethical compass and guidance.

By analyzing the case of Addiopizzo, the *overarching value* of legality emerges as critical inasmuch as it stems from a context of widespread organized crime, turbulence due to violent mafia racket system, and fueled illegality.

In this way, we enhance our knowledge of reciprocal relations of values within organizations in the following ways:

We enhance the understanding of previously offered characterization of the hierarchical ordering of values (intrinsic, ultimate, and non-instrumental, etc. (Argandoña, 2003; Donaldson & Walsh, 2015)) by overcoming such ordering and focusing on the role that values play in organizational survival in the context of crisis and turbulence.

We also contribute to previously discussed perspectives of the dynamical emerging of “core values” (Sirris et al., 2020) by offering an understanding of *overarching values* as being fixed, belonging to the organizational rationale, but dynamic in their performing role when facing external pressures or internal blockages.

Indeed, we contribute to the understanding of how core values (Batson et al., 2006; Collins & Porras, 1996) can resist external pressure by enhancing our knowledge of how core values align organizational members in light of crisis and turbulence.

However, *overarching values* display a crucial role in managing tensions and offering a compass indicating and guiding choices upon which negotiations to undertake (Ebrahim et al., 2014; Ramus and Vaccaro, 2017; Sirris et al., 2020). In hybrid organizations, where plural institutional logics are at play, *overarching values* help prioritize among competing imperatives, resolve ambiguity, and generate alignment in times of disruption.

Furthermore, we contribute to highlight how, in the context of violence and crime, “legality” becomes not only a principle pertaining to the realm of the rule of law, but rather is addressed as a social value. Indeed, while usually legality is associated with issues of legitimacy (institutional legality enhances its legitimacy and organizational legitimacy can support its legality (Přibáň, 2020)), in contexts of organized crime, legality emerges as a normative quest, as organized crime thrives on the erosion of legality by exploiting legal loopholes, fostering corruption, and perpetuating fear, thereby undermining the rule of law.

While our findings result from the analysis of a specific organization, we believe the analytical conceptualization of *overarching values* has broader applicability. We propose that the identification of *overarching values* can be relevant for studying values in other ethically driven or hybrid organizations. Future paths of research can also provide novel empirical insights into how *overarching value* may be relevant for traditional organizations too. Nonetheless, we also acknowledge the contextual specificity of *which* value plays this role. While the identified value may change, the function remains consistent.

Overall, we contribute to stressing the role of the emerging values work (Chachine, 2022; Gehman et al., 2013) in organizations, with a specific focus on hybrids (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015), as a crucial moral and strategic compass for organizational cohesion, decision-making, and success.

Indeed, the concept of *overarching values* offers an additional contribution to highlight the primary importance of values within the context of violence, crisis, and turbulence (Dempsey, 2015; Vaccaro, 2012; Van Der Linden & Freeman, 2017).

Future paths of research can be envisioned in the need to inform further empirical research on *overarching values* in different contexts and different types of organizations.

Future Paths of Research

Further research in organizational studies could benefit from exploring the intersection between values, with a focus on *overarching values*, and emotions, as these dimensions jointly shape organizational dynamics and pivotal processes of stakeholder engagement.

While values have been traditionally conceived as guiding principles that inform decision-making and strategic alignment, emotions have often been treated as peripheral or secondary elements. However, recent theoretical advancements emphasize that emotions play a central role in how individuals and groups perceive and prioritize values, particularly in the contexts of crisis or moral tension (Smollan & Sayers, 2009; Zietsma et al., 2019).

Integrating emotions into the study of *overarching values* could reveal how emotional resonance contributes to the stability and coherence of organizational culture, even amidst turbulence. For instance, examining how emotional attachments to specific *overarching values* sustain collective identity and integrity may offer insights into organizational resilience. Additionally, exploring how emotions influence the hierarchy and dynamic interaction of *overarching values* could advance our understanding of how values are internalized, embodied, and enacted within organizations.

In particular, empirical research focusing on emotionally charged contexts—such as social movements, ethical entrepreneurship, or crisis management—could provide a fertile ground for testing how emotions facilitate the emergence, stabilization, and transformation of *overarching values*. By bridging the gap between values theory and affective organizational research, scholars could develop more holistic frameworks that account for the emotional underpinnings of the emergence of *overarching values*.

Conclusion

This chapter has introduced and conceptualized *overarching values* as a critical subset of core values, distinguished by their ability to guide organizations through ethical dilemmas, strategic tension, and when navigating uncertainty. Synthesizing theoretical insights from previous debates revolving around the relative importance of values, we have shown that *overarching values* are not simply culturally significant or identity-forming; rather, they play an integrative, performative role in aligning short- and long-term goals, resolving organizational dilemmas, and fostering coherence amid pluralism.

Unlike other typologies that classify values by function, *overarching values* are revealed through practice, as organizations confront moments of uncertainty that demand ethical clarity and unified action.

We provided an empirical inquiry into a hybrid organization, *Addiopizzo*, where the value of *legality* emerged not only as a cultural touchstone but as an organizing rationale that anchored internal decision-making, stakeholder relationships, and strategic direction across its strategic and operational levels. Such values perform a higher-order sense-making function—illuminating and contextualizing other values within the organizational system.

Importantly, the analytical contribution of this chapter extends beyond the *Addiopizzo* case. The newly presented construct of *overarching values* has the potential to enrich research on hybrid organizations, stakeholder engagement, ethical resilience, and crisis navigation. By recognizing values as dynamic yet hierarchically operative, we refine the conceptual tools available for scholars examining how organizations maintain normative coherence across shifting contexts and internal tensions.

Ultimately, the construct of *overarching values* underscores the vital role of values in organizational life—not as abstract and fixed, but as a lived, evolving compass that enables organizational persistence and development. This study invites future empirical and theoretical work to further elucidate the conditions under which such values emerge, stabilize, and guide diverse forms of organizing, as well as their relationships with emotions.

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5

How Institutions Feel: Toward an Institutional Logics Approach to Emotions

Lu Wang, Shuo Yuan, and Michael Lounsbury

Introduction

The institutional logics perspective offers a bold yet humanistic framework for analyzing the complex, dynamic, and multifaceted interrelationships among individuals, organizations, and institutions in social systems (Thornton et al., 2012). It conceptualizes society as comprising multiple institutional orders, each characterized by a central logic—a unique set of material practices and symbolic constructions (Friedland & Alford, 1991, p. 248). These logics serve as distinct organizing principles (Thornton, 2004) that individuals and organizations are embedded in, and with which they can engage, elaborate upon, and expand to construct new meanings and possibilities (Lounsbury et al., 2021; Swidler, 1986). By unpacking the interpenetrated dynamics of logics and actors, diverse selves, identities, practices, understandings, and strategies of action become comprehensible.

Emotions, widely regarded as quintessential to human experience (Creed et al., 2014; Damasio, 1994, 2001; Meyer & Vaara, 2020; Voronov & Weber,

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2017; Wright et al., 2021), have historically been left outside the purview of scholarship on institutional logics. The conspicuous absence of this unique, embodied, and intimate aspect of how humans relate, experience, and make sense of the world (Creed et al., 2020; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024) in institutional logics theory and research is vexing to many. More recently, a nascent but growing literature is beginning to consider how institutional logics infuse, program, and structure the affective experiences and expressions of actors in practice and interactions (Fan & Zietsma, 2017; Friedland et al., 2014; Jakob-Sadeh & Zilber, 2019; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017; Voronov & Weber, 2016; Zilber, 2024). Leading proponents of this effort assert, for instance, that institutions are “not only ways of doing, but also of being” (Friedland, 2018, p. 522) and emotions are essential component of the milieu of subjects, objects, and practices that constitute and sustain institutional logics (Friedland, 2018).

Thus, foregrounding and theorizing emotions offers a powerful and potentially generative lens for understanding why we cling to a particular way of doing and practicing beyond instrumental rationality (Friedland, 2013; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018), how individuals become competent institutional actors within specific institutional domains (Voronov & Weber, 2016), and how logics are enacted and improvised by people on the ground (Zilber, 2024). Together, this emerging literature holds the promise of delivering to us a full-bodied understanding of how institutional logics are not only located in discourses and material practices but are also felt and expressed through the bodies and hearts of institutional actors. In doing so, we can go beyond more cognitively focused research on how institutions think (Douglas, 1986), to develop a more comprehensive understanding of how institutions *feel*.

The institutional logics approach to emotions is exciting to many inside and outside the big tent of institutional scholarship not only because it humanizes our understanding of institutions (Lawrence, 2017; Massa et al., 2017; Voronov & Vince, 2012; Voronov & Weber, 2020; Wright et al., 2017), but also because it furnishes a powerful and distinctive constitutive approach (Lounsbury et al., 2021; Lounsbury & Wang, 2020; Meyer, 2008) to understanding the deep connection between emotions and institutions. This excitement has immediately turned generative, sparking an impressive and rapidly expanding corpus of empirical work (see Lok et al., 2017; Zietsma et al., 2019 for reviews). Friedland (2018) remarked, in summing up this work, that recent empirical research has provided compelling evidence that emotions can be crucial raw materials through which institutions are sustained or disrupted.

Treating emotions as “raw materials” subject to manipulation, regulation, and utilization by institutions, however, may inadvertently imply that emotions exist outside of institutional logics (Voronov & Weber, 2017). That is, while institutional logics may play a significant role in determining the type of stimuli that trigger emotions, as well as the types of emotions that are appropriate to experience and express, their reach is limited to the periphery of emotional processes, as opposed to altering the core experience of emotions. If “emotion has no meaningful interior relation to the conventional practices of an institution or the values at play in its operations” (Friedland, 2018, p. 520), one is prompted to inquire about the nature of emotions—what are emotions?

In the absence of a clearly positioned, coherent, and compelling institutional logics approach for addressing this question, scholars may be forced to rely on an essentialist, entity-based, and reductionist definition of emotions that prevails in other domains of management and organizational studies. In our opinion, this would handicap and deflate the singular force of this unique institutional approach, particularly the emerging institutional logics approach to emotions, by obscuring its ontological position, diminishing its theoretical distinctiveness, and limiting the range of inquiries that can result from a deeper engagement between emotions research and institutional theory. To fully energize and expand upon its potential, we argue for a more robust conceptual foundation that goes beyond an essentialist definition of emotions.

This chapter contributes to the small but growing literature on institutional theory, and particularly institutional logics, and emotions by foregrounding ontological issues concerning the nature of emotion. While previous reviews have synthesized existing research on emotions within institutional theory (e.g., Lok et al., 2017; Zietsma et al., 2019), we aim to extend this conversation by focusing on a dimension that has been largely overlooked: the ontological foundations of emotion. Ontology concerns the nature of reality (Lounsbury & Gehman, 2024). In our view, the broader institutional literature on emotions has drawn on distinct, though often implicit, ontological assumptions about what emotions are. Although scholars such as Voronov (2014) have noted the importance of ontological clarity, prior reviews have not systematically addressed these foundational differences. Thus, a central contribution of this chapter is to foreground the ontological assumptions embedded in institutional research on emotions and to encourage scholars to engage more explicitly and reflectively with the nature of emotions in their theorizing.

By bringing ontological questions to the forefront, we argue that a robust and generative partnership between the research on emotions and institutions, especially within the institutional logics perspective, can only be achieved through ontological compatibility. Thus, we aim to shift the focus of institutional logics research from viewing emotions as immutable, biologically determined responses triggered by institutional logics, to recognizing emotions as distinct and culturally embedded elements that are both constituted by and help constitute institutionalized subjects, objects, and practices. In doing so, we respond to critiques that caution against reifying institutional logics, instead recognizing them as complex constellations—bundles of symbolic, material, and emotional practices (Friedland, 2018; Lounsbury et al., 2021). We hope this ontological discussion will spark renewed interest, invite novel lines of inquiry, and foster deeper dialogue between institutional scholars, particularly those working in the institutional logics tradition, and researchers primarily concerned with the emotional dimensions of organizational life.

This chapter is organized in the following way. In Sect. “[Why Emotions?](#)”, we begin at a broad level by briefly discussing institutional scholars’ recent interest in emotions, highlighting several key factors driving this emerging development. Section “[A Matter of Ontology](#)” introduces two distinct ontological stances on emotions—realist and constitutive—that have been utilized to study emotions and institutional dynamics. Drawing on research from a range of disciplines, we clarify what these ontological positions entail and use examples, primarily from institutional scholarship, to illustrate how each has informed theorizing within the field. Building on this analysis. Section “[Concluding Reflections and Research Opportunities](#)” concludes by advancing a forward-looking research agenda grounded in a constitutive approach to emotions within the logics perspective, proposing new questions and directions to further integrate emotions into institutional theory.

Why Emotions?

Institutional scholars have recently begun to engage more deeply with emotions, prompted by a recognition that although some of the most powerful and defining moments of our social life are constituted by emotions, they had been largely absent from institutional theorizing (Creed et al., 2014; Friedland, 2013; Voronov & Weber, 2016; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2019). By foregrounding the role of emotions, this emerging literature on institutions and emotions helps address long-standing criticisms that institutional

theory is overly cognitive. It highlights that institutions are not only cognitively navigated but also inhabited by embodied individuals who experience love, joy, pain, fear, shame, and anger (e.g., Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024). An important early statement in this area comes from Voronov and Vince (2012), who argue that institutions influence actors not only cognitively but also emotionally. Specifically, institutions can induce actors to develop an emotion-based attachment to them. Thus, they urge institutional scholars to view emotions not as inconsequential “noises”, but rather as a missing form of affective commitment to institutions that immunizes actors from behaving solely in an opportunistic manner. This work marks a significant advancement in the institutional literature, moving beyond the traditional portrayal of actors as more exclusively cognitively and normatively oriented. Instead, it begins to introduce the notion that actors are embodied beings whose emotional connections to institutions can drive them to care deeply about these institutions, transcending narrow self-interest.

Building on this momentum, subsequent research has explored the influence of institutions on actors’ emotions beyond attachment, including the important insight that institutional actors are emotionally competent beings, and that unique emotional competencies are important to enable individuals to perform institutional work effectively within a given institutional domain (Voronov & Weber, 2016). Specifically, Voronov and Weber (2016) make the strong claim that the competence required to be an effective institutional actor is fundamentally emotive. Thus, they position emotions as central to institutional actorhood.

Other research has also made important strides in integrating emotions into the study of institutional dynamics, showing how specific negative emotions, such as shame, can play a critical role in sustaining the stability of particular institutional arrangements (see Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024 for a review). The influential work of Creed et al. (2014) on shame represents a major advancement in our understanding of how emotions function as mechanisms of institutional maintenance and change. Their paper introduces what they call the “shame nexus,” a set of interrelated shame constructs that operate at different levels that drive conformity to institutional prescriptions without requiring external enforcement. Central to their argument is how shame functions as a powerful force for institutional stability. Their work begins to illustrate the emotional foundation of institutional reproduction, as actors internalize institutional prescriptions so deeply that violation produces painful emotional consequences.

This earlier work has inspired a growing body of research exploring how emotions animate and motivate institutional work (Zietsma et al., 2019).

For example, Wright and colleagues (2017) found that Emergency Department physicians, driven by moral emotions, engaged in institutional work to uphold their professional values and advocate for patients. This line of inquiry has also sparked interest in how various forms of cultural entrepreneurship (Lounsbury & Glynn, 2019), including the use of rhetorical and discursive strategies, employ highly emotive language to challenge and transform institutional arrangements by constructing personally meaningful narratives (Brown et al., 2012; Creed et al., 2010; Goodrick et al., 2020; Gutierrez et al., 2010; Moisander et al., 2016; Schüssler et al., 2014).

For instance, Moisander and colleagues (2016) showed how the Finnish government strategically employed rhetorical strategies to elicit, regulate, and organize people's emotions in order to manage resistance and cultivate support for joining the Economic and Monetary Union (EMU) of the European Union. By reframing the EMU as a purely economic matter, the government muted public fears and indignation, while simultaneously invoking feelings of pride and shame to instill a sense of national duty and European belonging. In this context, emotion-laden rhetoric was not merely expressive but functioned as a political resource—mobilized to neutralize opposition and shape public narratives about what it meant to be a “good” citizen in a shared European future.

In a similar vein, Goodrick and colleagues (2020) found that emotion-laden rhetorical strategies can be used to preserve the institution of pharmacy. Specifically, they showed that industry leaders systematically embedded discrete emotions, such as shame, fear, anger, and hope, into rhetorical arguments to persuade pharmacists to reassert and expand their professional role and adopt desired new practices. These rhetorical strategies, for example, linked the fear of professional extinction to commercial practices and tied shame to pharmacists' failure to fulfill their obligations. Over time, pharmacists' emotions were strategically managed to align with professional ideals, thereby contributing to the preservation of this institutionalized practice. Crucially, these rhetorical strategies proved effective only when they emotionally resonated with relevant audiences (Giorgi, 2017; Haack et al., 2014).

This newfound interest in emotions is echoed in the work of several prominent institutional logics scholars, many of whom have long viewed emotions as an integral component of institutionalized practices (see Friedland, 2018, for a concise overview). Friedland (2018), for instance, argues that emotions are not only missing but missed in much institutional scholarship, because institutional orders cannot be constructed and sustained solely through linguistic categories, cold theoretical frameworks, or dispassionate

practices. Instead, they require distinct and unique forms of affectivity that make particular logics of action and practice sensible and natural (Friedland, 2018; Friedland & Arjaliès, 2024; Friedland et al., 2014). In Friedland's account, institutional logics are fundamentally "ways of being" that shape not only what actors do and say, but also how they feel about what they do and say. In this view, emotions are not just reactions to institutions, but they are institutionally constituted and constitutive. Particular institutional orders give rise to distinct emotional registers, which, in turn, are integral to the constitution and maintenance of those very orders. For example, piety is not simply an emotion associated with religion—it is constitutive of religious experience and practice. Likewise, care is not an optional supplement to nursing; it is central to the very meaning of nursing as an institutional form. Emotions, in Friedland's account, are an inseparable part of the subject-object-practice triad that underpins institutional life.

Embracing these ideas, Toubiana and Zietsma (2017) conducted a pioneering study that underscores the importance of emotional dynamics in understanding how conflicting institutional logics manifest on the ground and are negotiated within organizations. Consistent with the notion that different logics are associated with distinct emotional registers—each prescribing which emotions are deemed appropriate—they examined an organization operating under the influence of both a care logic and a research logic. The care logic legitimized emotions as meaningful and valid criteria for decision-making, supporting the expression of emotions such as hope and compassion. In contrast, the research logic, instantiated from the professional institutional order, emphasized objective evidence, scientific rationality, and dispassionate reasoning, thereby rendering emotional expression inappropriate. This divergence in emotional registers gave rise to emotional conflict. Proponents of the care logic perceived the dispassionate stance of the research logic as a moral failure, which provoked intense anger. This anger, rather than being disruptive, served as a catalyst for institutional action—motivating efforts to challenge the dominance of the research logic and ultimately leading the organization to reconfigure and rebalance the relationship between the two logics.

Following this work, later research indicates that, despite organizations' efforts to manage emotional registers linked to divergent logics through various forms of emotional controls, these controls are not always effective. Emotional conflict associated with divergent logics can resurface in response to events in society (Jakob-Sadeh & Zilber, 2019). When these unbidden emotions emerge, they act as powerful forces that energize and compel actors to defend the identities, interests, and practices associated with their logic.

In this way, although emotional control enables organizations to navigate contradictory logics and achieve a temporary truce, unbidden emotions often simmer beneath the surface, disrupting local efforts to manage logics.

A Matter of Ontology

We commend institutional scholars who have begun to take emotions seriously. As interest in emotions within institutional scholarship continues to grow, however, a critical yet often overlooked question emerges: How should emotions be ontologically conceptualized and positioned in relation to institutions? To begin addressing this question, we focus on two distinct ontological positions on emotions within organizational institutionalism: the realist and the constitutive. We do not claim that these are the only ontological positions on emotions represented in the institutional literature or affective science. Indeed, other perspectives offer alternative ontologies that we do not review here (Colombetti, 2014; Creed et al., 2014; Naar & Teroni, 2017; Parkinson, 2006; Parkinson et al., 2005). Some of these may fall somewhere between the realist and constitutive positions, while others may be seen as conceptually independent. We also do not claim that the realist and constitutive positions are the most widely adopted or representative ontologies in institutional research. Rather, we argue that they provide a useful and analytically productive contrast for understanding how organizational institutionalism engages with emotions.

Realist: an inside-out view of emotions. From a realist ontological perspective, emotions are understood as natural, pre-social psychological entities composed of relatively fixed and universal subjective, cognitive, motivational, and physiological components—rooted in the brain and triggered by external stimuli. This position maintains that emotions are not merely cultural constructs or learned responses, but biologically based adaptations shaped by natural selection to address recurrent challenges faced by our ancestors. In this sense, emotions are considered “real” because they are universal and hardwired into our neural architecture (Turner & Stets, 2005). Proponents of this view often argue that human beings are equipped with a set of immutable emotions that enable them to navigate the social world (e.g., Pollock et al., 2019). Additionally, emotions and cognitions are distinct phenomena, with emotions being constituted by specific physiological and psychological structures. For example, compared to cognition, emotions are believed to possess a gripping motivational force that makes them difficult to regulate. Once triggered, emotions can override rational

information processing by capturing attention, disrupting habitual thought patterns, and propelling individuals to think, move, and act differently. In this way, emotions function much like powerful instinctual drives. Scott (2014) underscores this quality of emotions in his discussion of emotions and institutional theory, noting that they are among the most significant motivational forces in social life.

To be clear, the realist ontological stance acknowledges the important role of institutional dynamics in emotional life but confines their influence to the periphery of emotional experience. Emotions are fundamentally understood as natural, internal entities residing within the individual, while institutions are viewed as an external and exogenous force that shapes the activation of emotions and their expression. Thus, institutions operate by influencing the appraisals that elicit emotions (e.g., Jarvis, 2016), regulating the expression of emotions (e.g., Hartmann & Meier, 2023; Jarvis, 2016), or shaping how individuals respond to others' emotional displays (e.g., Farchi et al., 2022). For instance, emotion appraisal processes are not purely individual or internal. They are shaped by institutionalized norms, values, and meanings, which influence how actors interpret situations and, in turn, which emotions are activated. However, while institutions may shape the triggers of emotions, the emotions themselves remain fixed psychological substrates (e.g., Jarvis et al., 2019; Vuori, 2024). Consistent with this view, sociologist John Turner (2007) argues that emotions are biologically evolved adaptive mechanisms, with social processes elaborating these innate foundations into the complex emotional repertoires we observe today. To highlight this essentialist view, where emotions originate internally and institutional processes operate externally to activate or regulate them, we refer to this ontological stance as an inside-out view of emotions.

This realist ontological position has been widely adopted across disciplines, including psychology (Ekman, 1992), sociology (Turner, 2000, 2007; Turner & Stets, 2005), anthropology (Wierzbicka, 1986), and management research. For instance, in the management literature, Pollock and colleagues (2019) conceptualize emotions as biologically grounded affective reactions. Specifically, they describe emotions as “more automatic and intuitive reactions” that are processed in “different parts of the brain” compared to cognition (pp. 448–449), emphasizing that emotions operate as fundamental human capacities that are activated more rapidly than rational thought, particularly in the context of social evaluations of organizations.

This ontological stance is largely informed by the basic emotions (BE) theory, a widely influential scientific framework for understanding emotions (Ekman, 1992, 1994). BE theory adopts a reductionist, essentialist, and

universalist approach to conceptualizing emotions. Its central premise is that human beings possess a small, fixed set of biologically hardwired emotions, such as anger, fear, happiness, disgust, sadness, and contempt (Ekman, 1999; Izard, 1977; Panksepp, 2004), each associated with distinct neural systems (Cosmides & Tooby, 2000; Tooby & Cosmides, 1990). These emotions are considered “basic” because they are believed to form the foundational building blocks for more complex emotional experiences, which emerge through combinations or variations in intensity. They are seen as “natural” due to their biological determination and cross-cultural consistency across human history (Cacioppo & Gardner, 1999; Nesse, 1990; Plutchik, 2001).

Each basic emotion is conceptualized as a distinct, organized, and recurrent pattern of physiological, cognitive, and motivational changes that evolved to address specific adaptive challenges critical to survival and reproduction (Al-Shawaf et al., 2016; Keltner & Gross, 1999; Tracy, 2014). From this perspective, emotions are not a singular phenomenon but a family of specialized responses and adaptations, each evolved to address particular challenges posed by the environment or social life.

Contrary to portrayals of emotions as irrational, BE emphasizes their adaptive value. Emotions are viewed as functional, rapid-response systems that prepare individuals for appropriate action: fear triggers flight in the face of danger and disgust promotes avoidance of contamination. Thus, emotions serve as powerful motivators of goal-directed behavior, enabling individuals to respond quickly to significant opportunities and threats (Keltner & Gross, 1999; Lench et al., 2015; Lindebaum et al., 2018). Because many evolutionary challenges are inherently social, some emotions, such as shame, guilt, pride, and empathy, are categorized as “social” or “moral” emotions, thought to have evolved to regulate group dynamics and promote social cohesion (Hutcherson & Gross, 2011; Sznycer et al., 2021).

Institutional scholars who study emotions rarely adopt an explicit evolutionary framework and typically do not directly invoke the work of Ekman and his colleagues (e.g., Haidt, 2003, 2012; Keltner & Haidt, 1999; Lerner & Keltner, 2001). Moreover, they tend not to limit their focus to the so-called “basic” emotions, often engaging instead with concepts such as social, moral, or constructed emotions that blend multiple basic emotions. Nevertheless, much of this work, in our view, implicitly assumes that emotions are reified psychological entities (e.g., Feront et al., 2025; Gorbatai et al., 2021; Gray et al., 2015; McCarthy & Glozer, 2022). This often-implicit assumption carries a realist flavor and reflects an inside-out perspective, treating emotions as endogenous and fixed psychological entities mobilized by exogenous institutional dynamics.

In his discussion of the growing body of research on institutions and emotions, Friedland (2018) characterizes this position by noting that emotions are treated as raw resources to be mobilized either to sustain existing institutions or to fuel social movements aimed at transforming them. A recent example of this approach can be seen in Bouchard et al.'s (2022) impressive effort to theorize how a constellation of emotions, including anger, fear, shame, and pride, can be strategically invoked to influence individuals' participation in contested institutional arrangements. In contexts of institutional contestation, rival actors seek to sway target audiences by strategically invoking specific emotions to mobilize resistance or build support for their position. Implicit in these arguments is the imagery that emotions are fixed entities residing within individuals yet outside the world, and that institutional actors can use rhetoric to call them forth, activating emotions that mobilize support for their projects and opposition against their rivals.

Clues of this realist ontological stance also appear in the cultural entrepreneurship (Lounsbury & Glynn, 2019) and institutional work literature (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Maguire & Hardy, 2009), which has examined how emotions are harnessed to disrupt established practices (Lefsrud et al., 2020; Schüssler et al., 2014; Tracey, 2016). In this tradition, anger often emerges as a key emotional force, one that must be aroused to propel actors to contest and disrupt institutional arrangements (e.g., DeCelles et al., 2020; Goodrick et al., 2020; Klein & Amis, 2021; Lawrence, 2017). From a realist ontological perspective, anger has a distinct set of psychological qualities that energize individuals to right a perceived wrong, boost their confidence, and prompt them to act quickly and decisively. These qualities stem from anger's unique physiological, cognitive, and motivational profile, shaped by its evolutionary origin. For example, physiologically, anger involves heightened sympathetic nervous system activity and increased catecholamine release, particularly norepinephrine and dopamine. These physiological changes create a state of readiness for action, with increased heart rate, blood pressure, and muscle tension preparing the body for immediate response. Cognitively, anger narrows attentional focus toward the perceived source of injustice while simultaneously reducing cognitive complexity, facilitating rapid decision-making. Motivationally, anger's approach-oriented nature creates a powerful impetus for change by reducing inhibitions and increasing risk tolerance. These coordinated components make anger particularly effective at overcoming obstacles and initiating corrective actions against perceived injustices.

Leveraging this realist understanding of anger, Kulkarni (2024) illustrates how moral anger can catalyze institutional change. Her study examines the

work of Javed Abidi, founder of the Disability Rights Group (DRG) in India, showing how Abidi strategically invoked anger to advocate for better treatment of people with disabilities. Drawing on a social functionalist account of emotions (Keltner & Gross, 1999; Keltner & Haidt, 1999), Kulkarni refers to this as moral anger: “an aroused emotional state triggered by a moral order violation that stimulates corrective behavior” (p. 2). In this view, moral anger is an evolved emotion that plays a crucial role in motivating people to challenge institutional injustice. Cognitive reasoning alone is insufficient; it is the emotional force of anger that drives engagement and action. In line with this view, Barberá-Tomás and colleagues (2019) suggest that social entrepreneurs must engage in “emotion-symbolic” work, intentionally evoking strong negative moral emotions to highlight the need for change and channeling these emotions into emotional energy.

Institutional scholars have also drawn on this ontological view of emotions to explore how emotions beyond anger shape complex institutional dynamics, including their contributions to processes of institutional transformation. Compagni et al. (2023), for instance, investigated how two categories of emotions helped physicians navigate the unprecedented challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic. They categorized physicians’ emotional responses into negative epistemic emotions and positive moral emotions and examined how each contributed to an institutional shift in an Italian hospital from knowledge-based to service-oriented practices. Negative epistemic emotions, such as confusion, fear, hopelessness, and anger, emerged in response to the inadequacy of existing medical knowledge for treating COVID-19. These negative emotional reactions, the authors argue, developed “through multiple unsuccessful efforts to cognitively mitigate the uncertainty of knowledge” (p. 830). For instance, as uncertainty deepened, fear, which is defined as “a basic emotion felt by anybody who feels threatened” by unknown risks and diagnostic ambiguity (p. 837), emerged among physicians and led them to question the effectiveness of traditional knowledge-based practices, ultimately motivating their abandonment. This view of fear aligns with a realist ontology, which understands it as an evolved adaptive mechanism for detecting and responding to threats. In contrast, positive moral emotions, such as relief and elevation, arose when physicians perceived their actions as morally meaningful and beneficial to others. These emotions reinforced collective solidarity and professional cohesion, helping to consolidate and institutionalize new service-oriented practices. Here, too, these emotions are conceptualized as fixed affective entities triggered by external stimuli and subsequently guiding behavior, a position that is consistent with a realist ontological stance.

Moving beyond the question of how emotions are activated to motivate action, scholars have also examined how institutions regulate, manage, and transform emotions through feeling rules (Hartmann & Meier, 2023; Jarvis, 2017; Mimoun et al., 2022). For example, Mukherjee and Thomas (2023) investigate how palliative care professionals foster client compliance by managing institutional feeling rules. They define feeling rules as “the socially shared... guidelines that direct how we want to try to feel” within a given institutional context (p. 452). In their study, rather than denying or dismissing emotions like fear, hope, or guilt, professionals manage feeling rules to correct patients’ understanding of where to place these emotions. Fear, for instance, is redirected toward the negative consequences of continuing curative treatment. Hope is rechanneled away from unrealistic expectations of recovery toward more attainable goals like pain relief. Likewise, guilt of patients and their family members is reframed—not as a consequence of choosing palliative care, but as resulting from prolonging suffering and misery. In doing so, professionals construct and provide social guidelines to validate clients’ emotions and redirect them in ways that align with professional goals, thereby facilitating clients’ voluntary compliance with palliative care practices rather than curative care practices.

Recent institutional scholarship has also extended research on feeling rules by moving beyond how existing emotions are regulated to examine how institutional actors actively construct emotions to support and sustain institutional projects. For example, Farny and colleagues (2019) investigate how collective emotions are intentionally constructed and mobilized through institutional work in a Haitian community recovering from the 2010 earthquake. Drawing on a five-year ethnographic study, they demonstrate how social entrepreneurs and local actors collaborated to shape shared emotional responses among community members through everyday social practices. These collective emotions, combining hope, empathy, and trust, were not simply triggered by the traumatic events of the disaster, but were deliberately cultivated. As the authors explain, “our findings show how purposeful institution building converges people’s emotional experiences into collective emotions. As such, collective emotions emerge as a byproduct of institution creation work” (p. 789). Crucially, they argue that these positive emotions are social by nature. As such, when institutional actors succeed in bringing them into the community, these emotions help foster cohesion and drive processes of institutional recovery and renewal.

Summary. Traditionally, emotions have not been a central concern for institutional theorists (Scott, 2014), reflecting a long-standing assumption, captured by Levi-Strauss’s claim that “impulses and emotions explain

nothing,” as they are “always the results, either of the power of the body or the impotence of the mind” (Levi-Strauss, 1962, p. 71). In recent years, however, institutional scholars have begun to leverage a new ontological stance—one that rejects the view of emotions as irrational or dysfunctional and instead sees them as adaptive psychological entities evolved to serve important social functions that complement rationality—in order to integrate emotions into institutional theorizing.

Drawing on this position, researchers have made significant progress in illuminating how emotions can be activated, shaped, and mobilized to maintain and transform institutions. Emerging from this nascent body of research is a dazzling set of ideas and findings that illustrate the complex ways institutional actors activate, redirect, construct, suppress, channel, and leverage emotions in the service of institutional work (Crawford & Dacin, 2021; Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). Alongside this, scholars have begun to accumulate a rich and growing body of knowledge on how emotions not only operate within institutions but also help shape and transform them (Farny et al., 2019; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024). These insights significantly expand our understanding of the social and interpersonal consequences of emotion by delineating their distinctly institutional significance, suggesting that many emotions are not only socially functional but also institutionally functional.

While this work emphasizes the importance of emotions within institutional theory, to us, much of this work resembles a realist position by conceptualizing emotions as entities that exist independently of institutions. While institutions are acknowledged as influential, their role is seen as shaping only the peripheral aspects of emotion—such as expression, regulation, or eliciting conditions—rather than the core of emotion itself. In this view, although the stimuli that evoke emotional responses may be institutionally constructed, the emotions themselves are not. Instead, emotions are regarded as biologically hardwired, fixed, and universal entities. They are understood as essential components of the mind that remain distinct from their triggers, expressions, and social consequences.

Constitutive: an outside-in view of emotions. In contrast to the realist, essentialist view of emotions, a constitutive ontological position rejects the idea that emotions are biologically fixed entities that exist inside the mind and outside of institutions. This is not to deny the reality of emotions, but rather to challenge the essentialist position that emotions are composed of innate, pre-given structures—akin to instincts or reflexes—that lie dormant within the brain, awaiting activation by environmental stimuli. From this ontological position, institutional dynamics do not merely shape what triggers our emotions or how we regulate them, but are indispensable to the very

construction of emotions themselves. Indeed, what we take for granted as “emotions” is constituted through modern institutional practices that define, structure, and give meaning to certain experiences (Schatzki, 1996). Anthropologist Michelle Rosaldo (1984) captured this position succinctly when she wrote that “feelings are not substances to be discovered in our blood but social practices organized by stories that we both enact and tell” (p. 143). Thus, to understand anger or fear is not to look inside the mind or body alone to locate its psychological or biological signature and structure, but to the social and institutional contexts in which particular patterns of action come to be recognized as “anger” or “fear.” They provide the shared and taken-for-granted concepts, language, and practices through which recognizable and meaningful emotions emerge.

This ontological position is embraced by leading practice theorists, who view emotions as inherently embedded in social practices. For these scholars, emotions are not merely psychological or mental states but are integral to the embodied activities through which individuals relate to other subjects and objects (Reckwitz, 2012). Reckwitz (2016, p. 116) states:

My basic claim is that it is not enough just to take affects ‘into account’ in social theory; the crucial insight is rather that every social order as a set of practices is a specific order of affects. If we want to understand how practices work, we have to understand their specific affects, the affects which are built into the practices. There can consequently be no social order without affects, but there can be vastly different types and intensities of affects within practices. What prevented social theory so long from recognising the fundamental social importance of emotional and affective phenomena? One reason is the widespread assumption in sociology of the identity of the social with normative orders or orders of knowledge, resulting in an understanding of affects as non-social, non-cultural phenomena occurring within individual’s bodies or individual’s psyche.

This ontological position conceptualizes emotions as fundamentally located in the world—not as originating within the individual mind, but as emerging from practices that organize and confer meaning upon social life. Even the most intimate, subjective, and bodily aspects of emotional experience are inseparable from the socio-cultural worlds in which they are lived. Thus, understanding emotion requires shifting our focus toward institutional practices and their underlying logics, rather than seeking to locate the nature and origins of emotion solely within the body or the brain. We refer to this ontological position as the outside-in ontology.

This ontological stance toward emotions can be discerned in several foundational texts in institutional theory. For example, Bellah and colleagues (1991) argue that institutions shape both individual and collective experience, thereby cultivating specific emotional repertoires. Swidler (2001) further elaborates this idea in her analysis of modern Western marriage, highlighting a tension between “mythic” and “prosaic” understandings of love. The mythic view—centered on intense, all-consuming, and unique romantic connection—emerges from the institutional ideals embedded in the structure of marriage. In contrast, the prosaic view—emphasizing love as something that develops gradually through effort, negotiation, and compromise—arises from the everyday demands of sustaining a long-term relationship. These seemingly contradictory conceptions of love persist because they address different challenges posed by the institution of marriage. As Swidler notes, the institution of marriage requires individuals to acquire specific forms of “cultural, psychological, and even cognitive equipment” to function effectively within its boundaries. Different institutional practices thus may cultivate distinct emotional rhythms, tempos, and capacities, enabling individuals to develop emotional practices attuned to the demands and logics of their respective life worlds. In this way, institutions provide the backdrop and ingredients through which people learn to think, act, and relate to others—but, crucially for our purposes, also how to feel.

Illouz (2007) offers an important perspective on how institutions constitute emotions by suggesting that professions often supply institutionalized concepts, vocabularies, and linguistic frameworks through which emotional experiences are structured and rendered intelligible. She illustrates this through her analysis of the therapeutic profession, which has given rise to a distinct therapeutic way of feeling, complete with its own discourses, emotional lexicon, and practices. Within a therapeutic logic, emotions are positioned as central to one’s identity and selfhood, and the authentic expression of emotion is seen as essential to personal well-being and self-actualization. This therapeutic logic also introduces a specialized emotional vocabulary—including terms such as healing, boundaries, psychological safety, and triggers, as well as common phrases like “process emotions,” “work through emotional difficulties,” and “validate feelings.” These linguistic constructs not only shape how emotions are articulated and communicated but also influence how they are felt, interpreted, and internalized. In this way, institutions do not merely regulate emotional expression—they actively shape the very structure of emotional life.

This constitutive position also finds alliance with a recent scientific account of emotions known as psychological constructionist theory (Barrett, 2006;

Russell, 2003), which emphasizes the central role of language in the categorization and experience of emotion. Often positioned as a direct challenge to BE theory, this approach offers an alternative scientific account of how emotions are institutionally constituted (Barrett, 2006; Russell, 1991, 2003). Aligned with a constitutive ontology, this perspective rejects the notion that emotions are fixed, universal, and biologically determined entities with identifiable “neurological signatures” located in the brain (Russell, 2009). Instead, it posits that emotions emerge from the dynamic interplay between bodily sensations, conceptual knowledge, and socio-cultural context. Thus, what people label as emotions are not direct responses caused by a fixed affective module in the brain. Rather, emotions emerge from the interaction of more fundamental and general psychological processes that are not exclusively dedicated to emotions (Lindquist, 2013). Thus, no emotion is inherently basic; rather, all emotions are constructed on the spot (Barrett et al., 2007, 2011; Lambie & Marcel, 2002; Russell, 2003; Russell & Barrett, 1999).

Although scholars differ in their accounts of the specific components and processes involved in the psychological construction of emotions, there is a consensus that physiological changes, sensations, and bodily activations, on their own, are insufficient to constitute emotions. Emotions involve a deliberate and meaning-construction process that goes beyond mere physical sensations (James, 1948; Russell, 2003). For emotions to emerge in consciousness, these physiological changes must integrate with cultural and social elements, transforming physiological responses into emotions that carry specific intentions and meanings (Barrett et al., 2007). In Feldman Barrett’s model, emotions are not our reactions to the world, but rather our constructions of the world.

The constitutive ontology shares key ontological similarities with the constructionist perspective on emotions (e.g., Averill, 1980; Edwards, 1999; Gergen, 1994; Wetherell, 2012), particularly in its rejection of an essentialist view of emotions. Rather than focusing on whether emotions are “real” in an objective or biological sense, constructionists are typically more concerned with how emotions become real through social interaction—as accomplishments embedded in relational and cultural contexts (Gergen, 1994). Most constructionists adopt a relational and interactional view of emotions, arguing that the primary site for understanding emotions is the local, situated social interaction. Emotions, from this perspective, derive their meaning and function through ongoing interactive processes embedded in broader cultural contexts.

For example, Edwards (1999) focuses on how people formulate events in emotional terms during everyday conversations for specific rhetorical

purposes. In his account, the primary function of emotional language is not to describe inner psychological states but to perform social actions—such as blaming, excusing, or apologizing. Whether an incident genuinely involves “anger” is not a question of discovering an internal state but of examining how an “angry” account is constructed, accepted, or resisted by others. Similarly, Gergen (1994) argues that emotions are not internal experiences waiting to be expressed but forms of action that gain their intelligibility within specific relationships. Emotions derive their value and meaning from their social use. Thus, according to constructionists, emotions are not felt but performed. Crucially, these performances are only intelligible within particular relational and cultural traditions. Moreover, Gergen notes that emotion performance is rarely limited to words. They are accompanied by orchestrated bodily performances—tone of voice, gaze, posture, and gestures—as well as visible signs such as tears, laughter, or scowling. To convincingly perform anger, for instance, requires considerable cultural learning. Recognizing an emotion, in this sense, is akin to recognizing that an actor is performing King Lear rather than Hamlet: it is not merely a display of feeling, but a culturally intelligible act situated in a meaningful tradition.

Within institutional scholarship, this ontological position of emotions has been most forcefully and explicitly advanced by institutional logics scholars. Leading logics scholars advocate for a “constitutive turn” in the study of emotions—one that treats emotions and institutions as fundamentally mutually constitutive (Friedland, 2018; Lounsbury & Wang, 2020). For example, Friedland (2018) notes that emotions are inseparable from the doings and sayings of a particular institutional order and institutionalized practices. Importantly, his claim is that institutionalized practices constitute emotions rather than simply setting the context for their occurrence or for attempts to control them after the fact. This position departs from a realist view in which institutional logics are exogenous to emotions, and instead advances the idea that institutions are endogenous to the very constitution of emotions. Thus, this constitutive approach is not primarily concerned with emotional norms or display rules (Hochschild, 1983) imposed by specific institutions (Farchi et al., 2022; Mukherjee & Thomas, 2023). Nor is it about actors developing emotional attachments to particular institutions (Voronov & Vince, 2012). Rather, emotions are understood as experienced, interpreted, articulated, and enacted through institutionalized elements, often mediated by culturally and institutionally specific understandings (Barrett, 2017; Reddy, 2020), emotion concepts (Fehr & Russell, 1984; Kövecses, 1990; Lindquist et al., 2015; Wilce, 2009), emotion language, vocabularies, and lexicons (Gendron et al., 2012; Lindquist et al., 2015; Wilce, 2009), emotion registers (Friedland,

2018; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017), emotional competencies (Voronov & Weber, 2017), and emotion practices (Cottingham, 2022, 2024; Friedland et al., 2014; Scheer, 2012, 2021).

This constitutive ontological understanding of emotions has begun to inform recent work in organizational institutionalism, though, in our view, such engagement remains relatively limited. For example, in their theorization of the important concept of emotional competence, Voronov and Weber (2016) explicitly adopt a constitutive ontological stance. They define emotional competence as the capacity to experience and express emotions deemed appropriate for a given actor role within an institutional order. Emotional competence, in their view, enables individuals to experience themselves in institutionally sanctioned ways and to internalize the desire to become the kind of actor prescribed by the institutional ethos (Stavrakakis, 2008; Thornborrow & Brown, 2009). It is through emotional competence that individuals come to experience institutions as real, legitimate, and personally meaningful. Thus, emotional competence plays a central role in institutional dynamics by transforming individuals into institutional actors. Crucially, Voronov and Weber argue that emotional competence is institutionally conditioned and endogenous to institutional orders. This means emotional competence is not a universal skill set; rather, it varies across institutional domains. What is recognized as emotional competence in a religious context may differ significantly from what is expected in family, market, or bureaucratic settings.

This ontological position is also reflected in the work of Toubiana and Zietsma (2017), who investigate the fundamental role of emotions in how organizations navigate institutional complexity. As we reviewed earlier, their study demonstrates that emotions are not incidental, but intrinsic to particular institutional logics, shaping how actors interpret, engage with, and respond to competing institutional demands. For example, the care logic is associated with a particular way to feel—what they call emotional register—that emphasizes compassion, empathy, care, and intimate social connection with those who are suffering and their human experience. In contrast, the research logic constitutes a different emotional register that is exemplified by dispassionate “reasoning,” scientific “efficacy,” “objectivity,” and professional “expertise.” Their research reveals how institutional logics prescribe not only what actors should think and do, but also how different logics instantiate different ways to feel that shape what emotions are deemed appropriate and sensible, how they should be experienced, and how they should be expressed.

Finally, in a recent paper, Zilber (2024) also adopts this constitutive ontological position on emotions in her effort to understand “how institutional

logics take part in daily organizational life” (p. 2) and to “move closer to the action at a micro level.” She examines how board members in an Israeli organization narrate abstract institutional logics to make sense of and address specific, complex organizational issues that require decision-making. Echoing the findings of Toubiana and Zietsma (2017), Zilber observed that participants in these board meetings were not only emotionally engaged, often expressing strong feelings while narrating different institutional logics, but more importantly, that these emotions were constituted by the very logics they were articulating. The stories participants told were not merely vehicles for expressing pre-existing internal emotional states; rather, consistent with Feldman Barrett’s psychological constructionism, the emotions were produced through the stories themselves. These emotions were inseparable from the interpretive frameworks, metaphors, and vocabularies through which the stories were constructed.

For example, in a story titled *A Plain Scandal*, Daphne conveyed a cascade of emotions—shock, bewilderment, alarm, distress, blame, shame, self-righteousness, and moral conviction—culminating in her declaration that she wanted to “slap Gilad on his face.” These emotions are not best understood as a set of fixed internal affective entities triggered by an external event. Instead, they are shaped and made intelligible through a feminist logic that frames and structures her narrative. By contrast, in another story titled *Total Hysteria*, a different way of feeling emerged, grounded in a therapeutic logic that drew upon an alternative set of metaphors, vocabularies, and evaluative criteria. This suggests that the emotions identified in her study can only be understood within a particular “way of feeling” shaped by a specific institutional logic. Zilber introduces the concept of a meta-story to illustrate this point. She suggests that the concrete stories narrated during board meetings are always grounded in broader meta-narratives—the cultural repertoires of meaning and storytelling available to the narrators. These meta-narratives, which lend stories their persuasive power, are systems of belief that provide the interpretive frameworks for understanding, evaluating, and constructing experiences. From our perspective, this implies that the emotions expressed and exchanged in these meetings are always embedded in, and made possible by, a particular way of feeling produced by a particular logic. In other words, emotions and feelings do not exist independently of institutional logics; they only acquire meaning within specific meta-narratives and institutional logics.

Summary. From a constitutive ontological stance, emotions are not fixed psychological entities residing within individuals, but are constituted through institutions. This constitutive ontology does not deny that individuals have emotional experiences; rather, it asserts that such experiences can only be fully

understood by examining the institutional practices within which they are embedded. Emotional life, in this view, is shaped by historically and culturally specific ways of feeling, made possible by institutions and their practices.

A constitutive ontology thus rejects essentialist conceptions of emotion that treat them as universal, biologically determined substances waiting to be discovered in the mind. Instead, it understands emotions as socially meaningful practices—performed, interpreted, and rendered intelligible through the institutional contexts in which they unfold. While institutional theorists often express skepticism toward realist ontologies (Lounsbury & Gehman, 2024), the constitutive stance toward emotions has received relatively limited attention within institutional scholarship. Although a small number of studies (e.g., Voronov & Weber, 2016; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017; Zilber, 2024) have taken this approach seriously, the broader literature has yet to fully explore or integrate its potential for understanding institutional dynamics.

Concluding Reflections and Research Opportunities

Institutional scholars have increasingly turned their attention to emotions. A small but growing body of research has begun to illuminate the various ways in which emotions intersect with institutional processes (see Lok et al., 2017 and Zietsma et al., 2019 for reviews), generating a rich array of insights into institutional dynamics. This emerging work is united by a shared recognition of the limitations of purely cognitive approaches to institutions and a growing desire to theorize the vital role emotions play in how institutions are experienced, sustained, and transformed. Institutional logics are not outside of us, but inhabit us in deeply meaningful and affective ways.

Advancing this line of inquiry, this chapter suggests that institutional scholars have drawn on distinct ontological positions toward emotions to inform their understanding of institutional dynamics. Although often subtle, these positions rest on fundamentally different assumptions about the nature of emotions, particularly in terms of their relationship with, and role within, institutional life. We have clarified these assumptions by focusing on two contrasting ontological positions—the realist and the constitutive. Drawing on a range of theoretical perspectives from multiple disciplines (e.g., Barrett, 2006; Ekman, 1992; Friedland, 2018; Illouz, 2007; Keltner & Haidt, 1999; Reckwitz, 2002; Shweder, 1993; Turner, 2009), we have discussed what each position suggests about the nature of emotions. We have also illustrated

how these differing ontologies have been utilized by institutional scholars to explain a variety of institutional processes and dynamics.

We focus on these two ontological positions on emotions not only because they are widely supported across the broader literature on emotion (e.g., Barrett, 2017; Ekman, 1999; Goodwin & Jasper, 2006; Haidt, 2003; Illouz, 2012; Lutz & White, 1986; Parkinson et al., 2005; Turner & Stets, 2005), but also because they seem to capture incompatible views about the nature of emotions. The realist position emphasizes the fixed nature of emotions, treating them as pre-social and universal structures rooted in human biology. Emotions, in this view, are “real” psychological entities capable of inducing significant changes in perception and behavior. They emerge as a process that “begins with a focal individual who is exposed to an eliciting stimulus, registers the stimulus for its meaning, and experiences a feeling state and physiological changes, with downstream consequences for attitudes, behaviors, and cognitions, as well as facial expressions and other emotionally expressive cues” (Elfenbein, 2007, p. 315). As Friedland (2018) notes, when emotions are treated in this way, they are regarded as raw psychological material—subject to manipulation, regulation, and instrumentalization by institutions.

We refer to this as the inside-out ontology to capture the idea that emotions originate within the individual as innate psychological and biological structures lodged in the brain. In contrast, the constitutive ontological position views emotions not as pre-social fixed internal structures, but as constituted through institutional and cultural practices. From this position, emotions themselves are institutional accomplishments, and even their most intimate, subjective, and bodily dimensions are inseparable from the cultural environments and institutional arrangements in which they are enacted (Friedland et al., 2014; Lounsbury et al., 2021). We refer to this as the outside-in ontology to capture the idea that emotions are not predetermined psychological realities, but socially meaningful acts constituted by and through institutions.

In some respects, the two ontological positions we outline can be seen as representing opposite ends of a continuum. Throughout this chapter, we have drawn on specific research within organizational institutionalism to illustrate these contrasting ontological positions. Admittedly, many of the works we reference do not align clearly or explicitly with a single ontological stance. Rather, they tend to occupy an ambiguous middle ground, often implicitly leaning toward a realist view of emotions while incorporating constitutive

elements. This ambiguity, we suggest, stems in part from the fact that institutional scholars interested in emotions have rarely engaged directly with ontological questions about emotions.

One of our aims in this chapter is to encourage greater ontological reflexivity among institutional scholars, especially when theorizing the emotional dimensions of institutional life. As scholars of institutional logics have long emphasized, ontological assumptions matter (Lounsbury & Gehman, 2024). They shape the kinds of questions that can be asked, the mechanisms that are prioritized, and the theories that can be developed. Ontological issues are especially salient and timely for the emerging research community focused on institutions and emotions. Voronov (2014, p. 172) warns that traditional conceptualizations of emotions as “real” entities pose significant ontological challenges for institutional scholars as such conceptualizations tend to reify emotions, treating them as universal mechanisms abstracted from the social contexts in which they operate—as if emotions are to be understood independently of the cultural and institutional context that gives them meaning. Voronov further argues that these conceptualizations are ultimately incompatible with institutional perspectives that understand emotions as relationally produced and culturally constituted. We agree. Ontological confusion, or worse, ontological inconsistency, limits our ability to grasp how emotions not only accompany institutional life but actively constitute it. Clarifying and critically engaging with the ontological foundations of emotional theories is, we contend, essential for advancing the research on institutions and emotions, particularly from an institutional logics perspective.

In order to align the institutional logics perspective and emotions research on the same ontological plane, we argue institutional scholars would benefit from taking seriously a constitutive ontology, one that theorizes emotions not as arising from fixed psychological structures, but as inherently intertwined with, and shaped by, institutional logics themselves. In other words, institutions and institutionalized practices should serve as the starting point for understanding emotions. This emphasis reflects a deeply social view of emotions. The idea that emotions are social has long been accepted across various disciplines, including psychology (Van Kleef, 2016) and organizational behavior (e.g., Barsade, 2002; Elfenbein, 2023). For example, emotions are understood to serve important social functions, regulating interpersonal interactions (Keltner & Haidt, 1999; Van Kleef, 2016). They are also increasingly recognized as context-sensitive, varying across situations and settings (Cheng et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2016, 2018). However, even as scholars acknowledge the role of social context in shaping emotional dynamics, the “social” is often conceptualized in a very limited way, such as an

external context that triggers emotions and their regulation, but not emotions themselves (Lindquist, 2013; Schatzki, 1996). In contrast, the constitutive approach advanced within the institutional logics tradition proposes a deeper form of socialness. It suggests that how we feel, along with the languages, bodily configurations, and practices through which these feelings are enacted and made meaningful, are all shaped by institutional practices. Thus, institutions and their practices do not merely influence the activation and modulation of emotions; they penetrate and structure emotional life itself. In this sense, they are not external contexts for emotion but integral to how emotions are constituted, experienced, and understood.

This is not to suggest that emotions are mere epiphenomena of institutional logics, nor does it imply a top-down perspective in which emotions are passively determined by institutional structures. Rather, consistent with Voronov and Weber (2016), this constitutive approach seeks to position emotions as more fundamental to institutional processes, just as institutional processes are fundamental to the shaping of emotional life (Friedland et al., 2014; Shweder, 2012; Voronov & Weber, 2016). This approach encourages researchers to move beyond viewing emotions as ancillary to institutional logics and instead begin theorizing how we feel as a central component in the formation, reproduction, and transformation of particular ways of being and specific social worlds. Emotions and our social world, in this approach, make each other up (Shweder, 1993, 2012). From an empirical perspective, this approach invites institutional scholars to move beyond merely describing emotions in their empirical findings. Instead, it offers an ontological foundation for theorizing emotions as central to how institutional logics, as lived realities, are maintained and transformed in practice and in the world.

By approaching emotions constitutively from an institutional perspective, we open up new and generative questions that, we believe, enable a deeper understanding of both institutional logics and emotions. First, this constitutive ontology shifts the study of emotions away from a focus on psychological experiences located within individual minds or aggregates of individuals, and instead emphasizes that the emotions individuals experience and express are always embedded in broader institutionalized ways of feeling. Institutionalized ways of feeling are not reducible to discrete emotional reactions, psychological states, or linguistic labels. Rather, they are part of institutions and their practices, and they fundamentally structure affective life by defining the range of possible, legitimate, and intelligible ways of experiencing, interpreting, expressing, and practicing emotions. For example, Zilber's (2024) ethnographic study of a rape crisis center identifies three distinct institutionalized ways of feeling—each shaped by a specific

institutional logic—that render the experience and expression of particular emotions meaningful. Although her study focuses on micro-level dynamics and individuals' emotional reactions, Zilber demonstrates that these emotions cannot be fully understood through an inside-out ontology. Instead, they only become intelligible when situated within the institutional practices and logics that produce and structure them.

If the way we feel is institutionally constructed and produced, then we still know surprisingly little about how institutions generate distinct ways of feeling. This is precisely where the institutional logics perspective offers valuable insight. The institutional logics framework conceptualizes society as composed of multiple institutional orders, each governed by a central logic—a set of material practices and symbolic constructions that organize meaning and action (Friedland & Alford, 1991, p. 248). These logics provide different organizing principles that individuals and organizations draw upon to elaborate meanings, enact practices, and formulate strategies (Thornton et al., 2012). Building on this foundation, there is a need for new theories and empirical research to better understand how key institutional orders, such as the family, religion, and the market (Friedland & Alford, 1991), produce distinct institutionalized ways of feeling (Friedland, 2017). For instance, do the family and the market generate contrasting ways of feeling, each with its own concepts, vocabularies, bodily practices, and rituals? These questions are not concerned with how institutional orders merely activate or modulate emotions in line with an inside-out ontology. Rather, they aim to understand how institutions actively structure the very ways in which emotions are experienced, expressed, and rendered intelligible within specific institutional domains. In other words, we ask: Do feelings follow different logics?

While some institutionalized ways of feeling may appear “natural” or “authentic,” we emphasize that no way of feeling is inherently more natural or universal than another. All ways of feeling are institutionally constructed and shaped by the logics embedded within their respective institutional orders (Voronov & Weber, 2016). In their theorization of emotional competence, Voronov and Weber (2016) make a similar point. They argue that, contrary to common assumptions about the primacy of rationality, the capitalist economy is deeply grounded in emotion. For example, rather than viewing all emotions as incompatible with capitalist rationality, only those that interfere with market imperatives are cast as irrational or inadmissible. Emotions that support market logics, such as ambition or greed, are deemed so natural and authentic, and they are framed as part of human nature. In contrast, within other institutional domains such as the family, different ways of feeling, such as love, care, and emotional attachment, are regarded as more

natural and appropriate. Their argument reminds us that our ways of feeling, no matter how authentic or natural they may seem, are, in fact, shaped and produced by institutions and their practices. They also suggest that we should not only recognize the wide range of specific emotions as evolved responses to various challenges and opportunities, but also acknowledge the vast diversity of ways of feeling shaped by institutional and cultural contexts. What is needed, then, is more research into how our pluralistic society, composed of distinct institutional logics (Kraatz & Block, 2008), not only produces a multitude of emotions but, more importantly, gives rise to a wide diversity of institutionalized ways of feeling.

By adopting a constitutive approach to emotions, we believe institutional scholars are well positioned to engage with and contribute to the growing body of research in the history of emotions (Reddy, 2001, 2020, 2023; Rosenwein, 2020; Rosenwein & Cristiani, 2017; Stearns & Stearns, 1985). Historians have long emphasized that how we feel has changed significantly over time, producing new forms of emotional experience and expression (Dixon, 2003). Institutional scholars, particularly those working within the institutional logics tradition, are uniquely equipped to offer strong theoretical frameworks for understanding how emotions themselves may be undergoing transformation at the societal level, through the dynamics of institutional change and reconfiguration. For example, Shuo et al. (2023) have begun to explore the effects of the emergence of a new institutional model of happiness in recent decades in Western society. According to them, the meaning, vocabularies, and practices of happiness at the society level have changed drastically over the past two decades. This transformation is linked to a scientific conceptualization of emotions ushered in by academic positive psychology, which has progressively emerged as a dominant institutional regime for defining and legitimating the collective understanding of happiness and well-being in contemporary Western society. Central to this new model is the increasingly elevated legitimacy and expanded jurisdiction of the emotion of happiness, which is now recognized as more than just a way to feel good but essential for human flourishing and economic productivity (Diener & Seligman, 2004; Lyubomirsky et al., 2005). More importantly, this new model of happiness has become entangled in the contested processes between two professional HR groups vying for jurisdiction over how to define and practice well-being in organizations.

Rather than locating institutionalized ways of feeling within individuals, Shuo et al. (2023) work suggests that we need more theory and research to understand how institutionalized practices produce distinct ways of feeling through relatively coherent and durable ensembles of discourses, meanings,

and material arrangements. From this perspective, the goal of institutional analysis of emotions is to identify and examine the relatively durable, culturally specific practices that transform physiological cues into socially meaningful emotional experiences, expressions, and performances. This reflects a sensibility attuned to the broader, historically grounded cultural and material elements that scaffold institutionalized ways of feeling (Swidler, 1986).

In addition to research that examines how institutions and their practices produce distinct ways of feeling, we recognize a growing need for scholarship that investigates how institutionalized ways of feeling actively contribute to the formation, reproduction, and transformation of institutional logics (Friedland, 2018). Both classic and contemporary studies have implicitly engaged these questions, offering valuable insights into how this process might unfold. Gouldner's (1954) classic study of a gypsum mine powerfully illustrates how institutionalized ways of feeling shape local organizational dynamics. He showed that the mine initially operated under what he termed the "indulgency pattern," characterized by leniency, paternalism, and informal relations that fostered cooperation, loyalty, and a sense of mutual obligation. Workers felt protected, particularly with regard to their physical welfare, as management was expected to maintain safe working conditions and "take care of them" in the event of injury. For example, injured workers were assigned light duties in the "sample room," enabling them to earn more than they would through formal compensation mechanisms.

This indulgency pattern existed in part because of a specific way of feeling between management and workers, rooted in kinship-like ties and affective bonds. This way of feeling was materialized and sustained through symbolic gestures such as expressions of condolence and informal social gatherings. However, this way of feeling was eventually dismantled and replaced by a new way of feeling marked by impersonal, role-based interactions, and the erosion of informal relationships. This shift paved the way for a bureaucratic mode of organization grounded in formal mechanisms of control, including disciplinary procedures, surveillance, job eliminations, restricted mobility, and institutionalized punishment. To us, Gouldner's study vividly demonstrates how a transition from an informal, community-based structure of feeling to a rationalized, bureaucratic emotional regime can fundamentally reshape the social fabric of an organization. These institutionalized ways of feeling were not merely reflections or consequences of shifting logics—they constituted distinct logics of organizing, shaping how organizational life was experienced, enacted, and understood.

A constitutive approach to emotion also opens up new lines of inquiry for the literature on institutional work (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Maguire &

Hardy, 2009). While this literature has examined how media strategies, rhetorical arguments, and symbolic materials can evoke negative emotions to drive institutional change (Brown et al., 2012; Compagni et al., 2023), it operates on the premise that emotions such as dissatisfaction, indignation, and moral outrage can fuel institutional change (Meyer et al., 2013). However, based on our constitutive approach to emotions, it raises questions of whether, for a particular institution to change, the experience of negative emotions by individuals and collectives, such as anger and moral shock, is insufficient, and whether institutional change also depends on altering the existing ways of feeling or introducing new ones.

Research on social movements has demonstrated that transformative change often stems from new interpretive frameworks for emotions rather than from the emotions themselves (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019; Gould, 2009; Jasper, 2011). In the feminist movement, for example, activists challenged individualistic, psychological explanations of women's depression by introducing a new emotional frame that emphasized the societal roots of these feelings and reframed them as legitimate anger. This feminist reinterpretation of emotional experiences helped reconstruct women's identities and expanded their perceived range of possible actions. A parallel process occurred in the LGBT rights movement, where activists developed new emotional frameworks that allowed gay and lesbian individuals to reinterpret their experiences of ambivalence and shame. This emotional reframing fostered new self-understandings and political consciousness that proved crucial for collective action (Gould, 2009). These cases illustrate how social movements can transform individual and collective action by introducing new models for reinterpreting emotional experiences, rather than simply channeling pre-existing emotions. Thus, further research is needed to explore whether institutional change requires more than simply triggering negative emotions. Instead, it may often depend on the construction of new ways to feel that underpin alternative visions of the future and enable the development of new pathways toward those futures.

Finally, Voronov and Weber (2017) underscore the importance of actorhood in understanding institutional change and transformation. Crucially, they argue that emotion is central to institutional actorhood—not merely as a supplement to cognition or behavior, but as something fundamentally performed emotionally. Building on this insight, our discussion raises further questions about the role of new institutionalized ways of feeling in enabling the emergence of new identities. As new institutionalized ways of feeling emerge, they may fashion alternative forms of actors, actions, and practices—including those that may seem unthinkable or unintelligible

within dominant modern Western frameworks (Shweder, 1993, 2012). Thus, we invite a research agenda focused on better understanding how diverse institutionalized ways of feeling can help furnish distinct conceptions of selfhood and subjectivity, provide distinct vocabularies of motives, offer alternative conceptualizations of agency, give rise to distinct values and concerns (Friedland, 2018), inspire different imaginings of the future, and facilitate alternative logics of action. In this sense, it may be particularly fruitful for future research to employ comparative research to analyze how different institutionalized ways of feeling implicate the various elements that cohere to form distinct logics. For example, multiple institutionalized ways of feeling help us to understand the broader array of actors and subjectivities in modern society. Through the market model of emotions, actors experience themselves as instruments of the market—a subject who is clear about their interests and whose passions and desires are largely founded on a relentless drive to gain, possess, maximize, and acquire. This type of being is both produced by the market and, in turn, produces the market. In contrast, through a family model of emotions, an alternative form of subjectivity based on love can emerge. This is a type of being capable of being affected and affecting others through unconditional love, sacrifice, and giving. For this form of being, a logic of action based on sacrifice is sensible, natural, and even imperative. Through a religious way of feeling, another form of subjectivity, the divine, can emerge. Institutional logics not only guide and sustain individual identity; for example, a family provides meaning and purpose by enabling individuals to see themselves as spouses, parents, or children but also offer models for feelings.

Conclusion

In their seminal work, Friedland and Alford (1991) called for bringing society back into our understanding of organizing and organizations. But what does it mean to “bring society back in” when it comes to emotions? In this chapter, we have drawn on the institutional logics perspective to suggest that answering this question requires careful attention to the ontological stance we adopt toward emotions. In particular, we advocate for what we call a constitutive ontology, one that treats emotions not as fixed or universal entities, but as conditions that are brought into being through institutional practices. From this perspective, understanding the meaning and impact of emotions requires attentiveness to the distinctive ways of feeling that are rendered possible, intelligible, and even natural through specific institutional logics. By

highlighting the co-constitutive nature of emotions and institutional logics, this ontological stance offers the possibility of a more comprehensive understanding of institutional logics, one that encompasses not only discourse and material practice but also the lived and embodied experience of institutional actors. In doing so, we also move beyond cognitively oriented accounts of how institutions think, and begin to appreciate how institutions are also felt through the bodies and hearts of those who inhabit them.

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6

Institutional Leadership, Values, and Emotions

Gry Espedal and Harald Askeland

Introduction

A renewed interest in institutional leadership within organizational institutionalism literature emphasizes the importance of infusing, filling, or pervading organizations with values (Kraatz, 2009; Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015; Washington et al., 2008). The institutional leadership tradition is marked as different from traditional leadership, often defining leadership in individualistic and instrumental ways as processes of influencing others to understand and agree about what needs to be done and how to do it (Yukl, 2013, p. 7). Institutional leadership leans on a sociological tradition pointing to the organization and its mission, character, and embodiment of values in the structures and life of the institution (Askeland, 2020; Golant et al., 2015) through the “protection and promotion of values” (Selznick, 1957, p. 28). Institutional leadership agencies link the past, present, and future by framing the organizational identity processes and exploring value discourses (Askeland et al., 2020). However, while these questions have been related to issues such as moral, social, and cognitive dimensions (Selznick, 1957), little attention has been given to the inclusion of emotions in the literature.

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The institutional leadership tradition has focused on inner consistency through a notion of commitment to the organization's mission (Askeland et al., 2019; Washington et al., 2008). The implication of leadership involves both cognitive and constitutive elements to understand different orders, and legitimize practice, as well as work on organizational change (Kraatz & Block, 2008). Leaders typically narrate a historic vision, reminding the organization of its vision to find adaptive and dynamic ways forward to meet challenges of enhancing legitimacy and overcoming eternal institutional demands. This work not only requires a perspective on how structures are constituted and changed on a macro level but also the micro-processes of leadership. These micro-processes include how leaders institutionalize actions that affect, transform, and maintain institutions (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006). The turn to micro-dynamic processes has garnered attention for how it forms work on values (Gehman et al., 2013) and emotions (Hochschild, 1979). It is highlighted that emotions and values are closely tied (Tappolet, 2016); however, how these dynamic approaches are integrated and related to each other in the organizing of leadership is little emphasized in the literature.

Selznick (1957) highlights that an institutional leader needs political skills for approaching different organizational systems. He emphasizes how values should be part of this work by "infusing" the organization with values. Communication skills are mentioned as important; however, Selznick does not make explicit how leaders can include emotional work such as guidance, support, and feedback (Washington et al., 2008). While Selznick contends that leaders need to "look beyond personal relations," he also recognizes how this larger view needs to be linked to understanding "how institutional change is produced by, and in turn shapes, the interaction of individuals in day-to-day situations" (Selznick, 1957, p. 4). Selznick's appreciation of informal and relational processes is clear yet addressed implicitly. In particular, he relates it to the needs for self-protection and fulfillment, often expressed in the rivalry of intra-organizational group interests and identities vested with emotional identification. Emotional identification is assumed to create resources of energy that could increase daily efforts and be summoned in situations of crisis or threat.

We argue that carrying out these relational processes, including an awareness of the emotions involved, is essential for developing institutional demands and organizational purpose. Paying attention to relations and emotions might hinder negative or unintended consequences, as well as build a deeper sensemaking and understanding of what is bringing the organization forward (Cha & Edmondson, 2006). Being mindful of both values and

emotion work can enhance and aid in developing comprehension, interpretation, and prospects for progress. Values, as Selznick (1992, p. 22) argues, are “not either cognitive or emotive, either objective or subjective. They [are]...usually a mixture of both.” Hence, in this chapter, we investigate and form an understanding of institutional leadership through an exploration of the interplay between emotions and values.

The carriers of institutional processes are, as Scott (2014) puts it, regulative, normative, and cultural-cognitive pillars; however, there is the suggestion of a fourth pillar, which includes emotions to understand thinking, feeling, and acting in institutions (Zietsma et al., 2019). While both Barnard (1938) and Selznick (1957) underscore the social and informal nature of organizations, and thus the relational aspects of the creation and maintenance of values, their discussions on emotive aspects are indirect. If we understand values as conceptions of the desirable (Kluckhohn, 1951), rooted in the social and meaning formation of relations and discourses, then their foundation needs to be spelled out. In understanding the foundations of values, Hodgkinson (1978) argues that values are anchored affectively and related to individual emotions and attitudes, as well as principles, and thus connected to moral aspects and emotions. For our purpose, values as conceptions of ideals might serve to mobilize action by being invested with commitment and emotions. Emotions might connect values and action through both a notion of cathectic goals (Askeland, 2020; Hallinger & Heck, 2002) and moral emotions (Greenbaum et al., 2020; Wright et al., 2017). Thus, in this chapter, we ask how the awareness of emotions and values can develop, strengthen, and maintain leadership within institutions.

For this chapter, we have a stand in the sociological world and have reread the predecessors of institutional leadership, particularly Barnard (1938) and Selznick (1957), to explore their relations to emotions and values within the institutional leadership tradition. Selznick, in particular, in his implicit separation of institutional leaders and the “interpersonal leader” (Selznick, 1957, p. 27), is reanalyzed regarding the implicitly emotional dimensions of central processes, such as critical decisions, defining missions, and the organizational embodiment of values and purpose. All these processes depend, we argue, on aspects of understanding emotions. As such, we not only explore how institutional leaders think but also how they are affected by emotions within their leadership.

Additionally, for this chapter, we have completed a review of studies on institutional leadership that identify and clarify the relationship between emotions and values within this tradition. We began our review of the relationship by searching the databases of Business Source Complete, Web of

Science, and Google Scholar. Our search terms were “emotions,” “values,” “institutions,” and “leadership.” We sought out empirical studies or conceptual papers that can broaden our understanding of emotions and values within institutional leadership. This included papers rooted in sociological, philosophical, and psychological traditions. To reduce the number of papers, we excluded literature that does not give much attention or information regarding institutional leadership perspectives based on other traditions, such as anthropological, pedagogical, and religious traditions. The search yielded thirty papers. Some of the papers did not define themselves as being within institutional leadership but were included because they deepened perspectives on leadership within an institutional context.

We organized the findings along three partially overlapping pathways that gave insight into the relationship between emotions and values within institutional leadership. See Table 6.1 for a summary. The first pathway includes conceptual and empirical papers on values within the sociological and institutional theory tradition, developing concepts of values, commitment, and purpose, including perspectives on emotion. The second pathway identifies an emergent and recent research tradition highlighting emotions as reaching out to, strengthening, and triggering values based on sociological, psychological, and narrative traditions. Finally, we sketch a third pathway investigating the relationship between emotions and values and how it forms reflexivity and sensemaking within the institutional leadership tradition. Here, we include phenomenological and hermeneutics-based articles.

For the third pathway, we have identified four qualities: first, how the relational dimension of leadership includes awareness of emotions and values that can broaden the understanding and legitimacy of organizational relational practice; second, how orientation toward motivational goals (cathectic¹) includes attention to emotion and values that develop organizational commitment and sensemaking; third, how the relationship between emotions and values forms leadership coherence and integrity; and fourth, how awareness of emotions and values initiates and strengthens the moral dialogue. Building on this research, we have formulated an understanding of institutional leadership that incorporates the concepts of emotions and values. We view institutional leadership as processes that adapt to dynamic social

¹ Cathectic values, goals, or visions are invested with commitment and emotions serving to guide and mobilize for action, according to Hallinger, P., & Heck, R. H. (2002). What do you call people with visions? The role of vision, mission and goals in school leadership and improvement. In P. H. Kenneth Leithwood, G. C. Furman, K. Riley, J. MacBeath, P. Gronn, & B. Mulford (Eds.), *Second international handbook of educational leadership and administration* (pp. 9–40). Springer. While values inhibit such normative and cathectic qualities, they need to be articulated and cognized in order to be oriented toward action, as emphasized by Parsons, T., & Shils, E. A. (1951).

Table 6.1 A summary of three pathways of literature within institutional leadership literature including perspectives on emotion and values

	First pathway	Second pathway	Third pathway
Key concep- tions	Values, commitment, and purpose Infuse the organization with values Commitment to organizational purposes Perspectives on emotions	Emotions reaching out to values to understand concerns and leadership opportunities and to legitimize practice	Values and emotions that promote and protect organizational values through processes of reflexivity and sensemaking Discovery of past and development of future
Underpinning traditions of research and philosophy	Sociology Institutional theory Institutionalizing processes	Sociology Psychology Narrative theory	Sociology Psychology Phenomenology Hermeneutics Pragmatism
Main thrust of studies	Organizing and understanding social processes and orders, as well as organizational commitment and purposes	Forming mental models that understand the social structure and scripts of the organization	Negotiating the embedded or constrained agency focusing on relational practice, motivational (cathectic) mission and objectives, promoting leadership of coherence, and initiating moral dialogues

changes while upholding desirable standards. This approach emphasizes the importance of working with values and emotions to foster identification and character within organizations. It involves setting motivational purpose, promoting coherent leadership, and initiating moral dialogues.

The First Pathway: Values, Commitment, and Purpose, Including Emotions

The first pathway in the literature on institutional leadership, which encompasses both emotions and values, consists of conceptual and empirical papers rooted in the sociological tradition. Perspectives from institutional leadership view the organization as structured by the association of individuals (Kraatz, 2009) or as systems of cooperation of human activities (Barnard,

1938). The organization develops through the larger patterns of institutional arrangements, as well as the personal relations of leaders to be found in these arrangements. Thus, the essential tasks of executives are to formulate and communicate organizational purposes and objectives (Barnard, 1938). Barnard (1938) argues that the efficiency of an organization is the degree to which an organization can satisfy the motives of its individual members. If an organization meets its motives while attaining its explicit goals, cooperation among its members will last. The collective purpose of the organization is highlighted as being of importance in defining the base or the moral character of the individuals. Barnard thus strongly emphasizes leaders' function, and tying their emotions, motivation, and loyalty to the organization's purpose (Scott, 1995).

Selznick (1957) emphasizes the institutionalizing process of organizations, encouraging leaders to pay attention to the larger pattern of institutional development through human relations. The leader who understands both the technical requirements as well as how this affects the interaction of individuals in day-to-day situations becomes a statesman (Selznick, 1957, p. 4). In developing leadership, leaders must pay attention to the unfolding institutionalizing processes in organizations that develop rules and procedures, which in turn influence the interactions between people in the organization. To get a notion of the institutionalizing processes, Selznick suggests investigating the following questions: "What are the problems [the organization] raises for human beings or social life?" and "What are the puzzles organizations create for the life of the organizational members?" (Selznick, 2015, p. 14).

Selznick became famous for emphasizing the infusion of organizations with values as part of the institutionalizing processes. The social order that follows from infusing with values is driven by the creative discernment of people empowered to act in accordance with what the situation demands (Selznick, 2008, pp. 77–80). Infusing an institution with values goes beyond the technical and rational requirements at hand (Selznick, 1957, p. 17) to include a relational dimension.

In stating that values are both cognitive and emotive, Selznick (1992, p. 22) is influenced by the pragmatist and philosopher Dewey. Dewey's theory of valuation sees values both as an object or end state to grasp and as being connected to what we in common speech would perceive as processes of valuing, of notification of what is valuable and what we prize. Giving value to something includes processes of looking at values as verbs. This process of valuing or prizing, or appraising what we are doing, can, as Dewey emphasizes, also be emotional, an expression of an interest, and an affective

attitude (Dewey, 1939, p. 5). Values help people evaluate what is desirable, and values, as well as emotive modes, motivate and shape actions to achieve the desirable as driving forces of acting processes. Values mobilize for action through psychological mechanisms related to emotions and attitudes (Hodgkinson, 1978) and by having cathectic characteristics (Hallinger & Heck, 2002). Beaton (2021) underscores how institutional leadership, in its quest for mission integrity, might be a collective endeavor cutting across leadership levels. At the same time, Beaton finds that commitment to the original mission and values might be enhanced both reflexively and through finely crafted formal procedures and rules to uphold values practices (Beaton, 2021).

A distinct Scandinavian values-based leadership tradition draws inspiration from perspectives on institutional leadership, with a specific focus on the organization's purpose and embodied mission. The approach emphasizes the maintenance of values and their application in driving an organization's strategy, goals, and development initiatives (Askeland et al., 2020; Espedal & Elter, 2024; Wæraas et al., 2025). This leadership tradition takes a different approach compared to transformational leadership, which is often characterized as value-based. In transformational leadership, values are typically viewed as goals set by leaders to influence employees, who are encouraged to follow them. In contrast, the institutional leadership tradition is rooted in a sociological perspective in which leaders focus on facilitating, maintaining, and developing the existing normative and cultural-cognitive frameworks within organizations. The Scandinavian approach to values-based leadership underscores the shared nature of values and hence elaborates on reciprocity, collaboration, and relations in value formation and organizational explication. Values-based leaders are dually aware of personal and organizational values and exercise relational agency through the facilitation of inclusive processes (Askeland & Aadland, 2017). Values-based leaders are, as such, conscious of personal and collective intentions, practices, and actions in alignment with values, thereby influencing the organization's daily operations and change processes (Askeland et al., 2020).

What a leader says and does, and how these elements relate, frames organizational and leadership activities (Askeland, 2014). A leader's "sayings" include discourses and ideas, and the reasons behind the "doings" the leader is engaged in. As emphasized by the practice theorist Kemmis (2011), doings are the actions and practices a leader engages in. "Relatings" are the frames through which values, in the form of sayings and doings, are created and enacted. The contribution of leaders to identity values can be worked on both internally and externally. The cognitive dimension of this work is enhanced

by a focus on the values at stake and the need for infusing the organization with values. The relational dimension is enhanced through dialogue, creating a common understanding of values and purpose (internally) and working on mediating the values' contribution to the community (externally). Thus, through these approaches, leaders work on integrating values through relations in organizational life and the community.

The Second Pathway: Emotions as Strengthening or Triggering Work on Values

The second pathway in the literature on institutional leadership includes the role of emotions in strengthening and activating values within leadership. The research interest stands in the field of emotion work but points toward the inclusion of values as a way of understanding this work. This tradition explores the impact and importance of emotions as value-laden, constitutive, and energetic (Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018), and it is based on sociological, psychological, and narrative traditions. Emotions are seen as deeply connected to social processes at all levels, including the individual, organizational, and societal levels (Zietsma et al., 2019). Emotions are seen as having structural impacts and are important components of the connection between people and networks. On the one hand, closeness to values is highlighted in the notion of emotion as evoking values. Emotional reactions can arise when values are triggered or threatened (De Rond & Lok, 2016). On the other hand, emotions can cause engagement and strengthen institutional arrangements and values, making them real to people (Gill & Burrow, 2018).

In these approaches, emotions are seen as “expressed” more than “felt” (Phillips & Lawrence, 2012), thus the institutional tradition is closer to a sociological sense of behavioral and expressive reactions to institutional arrangements rather than orientations of subjective experiences and psychological responses. One of the first scholars to make a point of there being emotion management within organizations is Hochschild (1979). Emotion management draws on an interactive account of emotions. Emotion work refers to the type of work it takes to cope with feeling the structures and rules, either acknowledging the deep, unacknowledged, emotional and cognitive frameworks that shape individuals' beliefs and actions or the surface acting as a form of emotional management where individuals display emotions they don't genuinely feel, often to meet the expectations of their job or social role. The emotion work is connected to making a conscious, intentional attempt

to alter feelings when part of changing social structures (Hochschild, 1979, p. 560). As such, the research trajectory illuminates the relationship between values and emotions in investigating how we understand the management of feelings in efforts to maintain social relationships (Hochschild, 1979).

Emotional labor is an emotion management perspective to inspect the self, interaction, and structure in organizations (Hochschild, 1979; Ingram & Iszatt-White, 2013). Emotion management is influenced by dramaturgical and psychoanalytical perspectives, but it is different in focusing on the work and taking into account that there are structures that make you feel what you feel. This structure can be experienced, for instance, when we are sad at funerals or happy at weddings. Rules and scripts govern how people do or do not try to feel appropriately in a given situation. In these situations, we follow instincts or impulses, including to follow our ideals (organismic and interactive). Hochschild (1983, p. 28) defines emotion work as “a bodily orientation to an imaginary act [here she draws from Darwin]. As such, it has a signal function; it warns us of where we stand vis-a-vis outer or inner events [here she draws on Freud].” Finally, what does and does not stand out as a “signal” presupposes certain culturally taken-for-granted ways of seeing and holding expectations about the world. Thus, a social perspective on emotions, including values, is taken (Hochschild, 1979, p. 560).

The Third Pathway: Relationship Between Emotions and Values Forming Reflexivity and Sensemaking

The third pathway involves analyzing the intersection of emotions and values and how their relationship contributes to reflexivity and sensemaking within institutional leadership. We here include studies found in our review not only from a sociological tradition but also leaning on phenomenology and hermeneutics traditions, as well as pragmatist views. Selznick (1957) identifies four leadership tasks crucial for developing an organization's character: defining the institutional mission, embodying the purpose, defending institutional coherence and integrity, and resolving internal conflicts. Drawing on emerging studies, we propose four qualities based on Selznick's leadership tasks. The first quality involves recognizing how the relational aspects of leadership, including an awareness of emotions and values, expand the understanding and legitimacy of organizational relational practices. The second quality is oriented toward how motivational and cathectic aspects lead to attention to missions and goals. The third quality is presented by studies

of how emotions and values develop leadership that fosters organizational or institutional character and integrity, and the fourth quality involves how they initiate and form moral dialogues. See Table 6.2 for an overview of the most important notions on how the qualities understand values, emotions, and the connection between them.

Emotions, Values, Legitimacy and Relational Practice

This first character reflects the relationship between emotions and values within institutional leadership that expands the legitimacy of organizational relational practices. Even though Selznick means that a default of institutional leadership is to be engaged as an “interpersonal leader,” studies show that attention to human interaction, development of communication skills, and attention to anxiety might enhance the understanding of the organization’s concerns (Selznick, 1957, p. 27). Studies highlight the need to pay attention to emotions as a key part of understanding the institutional processes of interaction and dynamics to identify collective and emotional work and to fulfill the role of a leader (Rafaeli & Sutton, 1987). Relational aspects of informal labor practices and economic activities are constituted by the meanings and quality that workers attach to interpersonal relations (Alacovska, 2018). The reflexive ways and institutional context in which relationships are formed between leaders and members are described as a social institutional process that shapes the effectiveness of the management of organizations.

Relational leadership is identified as a social influence process through which emergent coordination of, for instance, evolving social order and change, such as values, attitudes, behavior, and ideologies, is constructed and produced (Uhl-Bien, 2006). This does not include views on leadership as establishing the hero journey of the leader but rather acknowledges the importance of the context and study of relational dynamics. Values are understood as the interest of the social order, and the leadership task is to persuade others to adopt new values and goals (Hogg, 2005). This includes examining interrelated social, cognitive, and political processes that reflect and affect the differing values and interests of participants and the legitimizing of relational and values-based practice (Hosking, 1988).

It is the relational dynamics in the institutional context that create evolutionary organizational processes and make leaders morally accountable (Cunliffe, 2016; Maritsa et al., 2022). However, one study suggests that investigating the patterns of influence between people can become more subtle, and, if problematic, harder to address when approaching the institution through a relational approach (Allen, 2019). Studies have shown that

Table 6.2 Qualities of emotions and values within institutional leadership. References here are intended to be illustrative, not exhaustive

Qualities	Understand values as...	Understand emotions as...	Connection
1. Emotions, values, legitimacy, and relational practice	Values are that which is worth having, doing, and being (Selznick, 1992) Value are social rules forming behavior and thoughts (Hochschild, 1979; Rafaeli & Sutton, 1987) Values are connected to meanings, ideologies, and values judgement (Cunliffe, 2016)	Interactive account on emotions as management and labor (Hochschild, 1979) Emotions can be arrayed on a continuum ranging from positive, through neutral, to negative. Expression of positive affect includes smiling and enthusiasm. Negative affect includes frowning and disgust (Rafaeli & Sutton, 1987) Emotions are embedded in relational practices (Cunliffe, 2016)	Relational leadership is a way of engaging with the world in which the leader holds themselves as in relation with, and morally accountable to, others (Cunliffe, 2016) Emotion work is the process of regulating both feelings and expressions for organizational goals (Hochschild, 1979) A leader's legitimacy is distinguished from being an interpersonal leader and is primarily connected to the promotion and protection of values (Selznick, 1957)
2. Commitment, motivational, and cathectic goals	Desirable, trans-situational goals, varying in importance, that serve as guiding principles in people's lives (Nelissen et al., 2007; Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015) Values give preferences that affect emotions and feelings. They are rooted in emotional structures that evoke will, and the will is highly conative (Hodgkinson, 1978) Values are tied to the orientations we are exposed to and the experiences we make (Espedal, 2021)	Engagement, reflexivity, independence, and courage (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015) Motivate action (e.g., run away) to realize goals (Nelissen et al., 2007) Reactions and listening to multiple emotional voices (Espedal, 2021)	Leading to change in contexts where institutions are highly resistant to change (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015) Found to have similar underlying goals as fear is associated with security values, and feelings of disgust and contempt are negatively related to conformity values (Nelissen et al., 2007) A process of noticing pain and living ethical spirituality, forming compassionate behavior, enhancing organizational scripts (Espedal, 2021)

(continued)

Table 6.2 (continued)

Qualities	Understand values as...	Understand emotions as...	Connection
3. Emotions, values, coherence, and integrity	Values as external expressions and personal beliefs (Lehman et al., 2019) Values as coping strategies and processes to support systems (Ingram & Iszatt-White, 2013) Self-transcendent values (Michie & Gooty, 2005)	Emotions as regulation of feelings (Ingram & Iszatt-White, 2013; Lehman et al., 2019) Emotions as motivating to act in accordance with values (Michie & Gooty, 2005)	Identifying leadership of coherence as consistency between an entity's internal values and its external expressions (Lehman et al., 2019) Self-transcendent values and positive other-directed emotions as important determinants of authentic and (integrity) leadership (Michie & Gooty, 2005)
4. Emotions, values, and moral dialogue	Moral values of doing what is right and fair (Oakley, 1992) Conceptions of the preferred or the desirable, together with the construction of standards to which existing structures or behaviors can be compared and assessed (Wright et al., 2017) Leaning on pragmatist Dewey, directing valuation and inquiry toward constructing the good (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024)	Emotion is a beginning toward a proper understanding of distinctive moral significance (Oakley, 1992) Moral emotions are linked to the interests or welfare of society as a whole or at least of persons other than the judge or agent (Wright et al., 2017) Emotionally laden "conceptions of the desirable," such as companionate love (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024)	Identification of processes linking professional values and moral emotions, maintaining professional values (Wright et al., 2017) Identification of a process of value inquiry, understood as a discovery-oriented process originating from desires for transformation in troublesome situations in which values are at stake (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024)

the desire for safety and inclusion of moral emotion can form reflexivity and communicate moral judgments and decisions, maintaining values-based places of social inclusion (Cunliffe, 2016; Wright et al., 2021) and the legitimacy of social change (Chatterjee et al., 2021).

The Scandinavian approach to values-based leadership, in particular, draws heavily on Selznick's contribution, and it sees institutional leadership as working through relational and dialogical practices (Aadland, 2010). Scandinavian contributions highly underscore the collective and reciprocal dimensions of establishing values consciousness in organizations (Askeland, 2020) through broad processes of involvement, yet facilitated by leaders.

Commitment, Motivational, and Cathectic Goals

Selznick (1957) identifies the difficulty in building motivation for the organization's social structure and policy. The leadership task in this situation is dual: to be conscious of emergent interest blocks and to work on the degree of representation. This includes a need for creativity in the leadership task. Implicitly, this includes a create awareness of the motivations behind the tasks. However, in this sense, we might ask how values as guiding principles lead to change. Hodgkinson (1978) suggests that values create preferences that affect emotions and feelings. Values are rooted in emotional structures that evoke will, close to what Hochschild names *feeling rules*, and this will is conative in the strongest sense. The commitment and/or faith that lies in the values is there for activation. For instance, if one is part of a ballet company that pursues aesthetic ideals, the values the ballet embodies are individually adapted. The dancer is willing to give it all for the values at stake based on their commitment, and this process of valuation is rooted in their affection or emotion.

The structure of human and cultural values includes universal relationships between different dimensions of human values. Schwartz (1992) underlines the understanding of values as incorporating motivational factors as “desirable, trans-situational goals, varying in importance, that serve as guiding principles in people's lives” (Schwartz, 1996, p. 2). The value structure refers to the relationship of conflict and compatibility, and not to its importance. Thus, values differ from attitudes and are a type of goal or motivational concern that is expressed (Schwartz, 1992). The structural dimension of the values establishes motivation for action. Emotion plays a part in developing motivation, especially when, for example, there is tension between openness to change versus conservation. In these situations, there are unpredictable and uncertain directions in need of actions, as well as questions of preserving the status quo (Schwartz, 1992).

Studies have shown that emotions and values are associated and share similar underlying goals; for instance, fear is associated with security values, and feelings of disgust and contempt are negatively related to conformity values (Nelissen et al., 2007). Emotions such as compassion can also influence organizational patterns and scripts that are understood as observable, recurrent activities, and patterns of interaction characteristics in a particular setting (Barley & Tolbert, 1997, p. 98). One study analyzes how religious organizational scripts and values were encoded and formed compassionate, emotion-laden activities (Espedal, 2021). A process of acknowledging religious history, noticing pain, and living ethical spirituality was identified

as forming and motivating compassionate behavior. The micro-processes of values as motivational and guiding principles in people's lives were found to lead to change in institutions that were otherwise highly resistant to change (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015).

Values seem to combine both long-term goals (end state), cathectic goals, and a normative foundation. Both cathectic goals and values evoke responses or commitment because of desirability and a sense of normativity; they inhibit an emotive dimension since carrying a normative weight implies feeling (Kraatz et al., 2020). As such, they seem capable of both mobilizing for and guiding action (Askeland, 2017; Kraatz et al., 2020).

Emotions, Values, Coherence, and Integrity

The third quality of institutional leadership involving both emotions and values is in the literature, pointing to the leadership of coherence and integrity. Selznick underscores the importance of how organizations develop character over time, reflecting experiences of adaptation and the internal formation of policy. The infusion of values is still deemed more critical as it creates an identity that forms the social integration of differing interests and levels of engagement (Selznick, 1957). Here, Selznick identifies the basic functions of institutional leadership as defining institutional purpose, embodying values and purpose in daily practices, defending institutional integrity, and resolving internal conflict.

Leadership may include consistency between an entity's internal values and its external expressions (Lehman et al., 2019). This does not necessarily include the emerging authentic leadership tradition, defining authentic leadership as an instrumental pattern of leadership behavior that draws upon and promotes both positive psychological capacities and a positive ethical climate to foster greater self-awareness and establish followers (Walumbwa et al., 2008). This tradition has been criticized for not being intrinsically ethical or creating anything new (Lehman et al., 2019), and it does not indicate how leaders can develop an organization's character through social structure and work on the mission or develop commitment through leadership integrity (Selznick, 1957).

Working on coherence between an entity's internal values and its external expressions includes a concern with the "front" and "back" stages, with the back stage representing the "true self" and the front stage potentially being a portrayal of it (Lehman et al., 2019, p. 7). Regulating the front and back stages includes emotional labor as described by Hochschild (1979) and Ingram and Iszatt-White (2013). Coping strategies, in terms of balancing

personal values, thought processes, and support systems, are connected to work on organizational objectives, mission, and values (Iszatt-White, 2009). The challenges of “truth telling,” of telling it like it is, even when this is a personally difficult or unpleasant thing to do, offer resources for the juxtaposing of the constructs of leadership integrity. Integrity occurs when one’s emotional expression or display is consistent with the display rules of a specific identity that is internalized. The work includes a reflection of self, regardless of whether the expression genuinely reflects one’s current feelings, and a reflection of what leaders have to “let go” of to meet a higher value of acting by organizational values (Ingram & Iszatt-White, 2013; Michie & Gooty, 2005). The process of infusing values and developing leadership integrity has been studied both as the enactment of institutional leadership (Askeland, 2020; Beaton, 2021; Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015) and as a specific kind of values work (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024).

Emotions, Values, and Moral Dialogue

Initiating a moral dialogue serves as the fourth aspect that enhances the relationship between emotions and values within institutional leadership. Among contributions to understanding the functions of the executive, Barnard (1938) underscores the responsibility of executives in shaping the morale of the working group or organization. The primary responsibilities of executives are to settle differences in discussions, but also to set standards regarding morals and ethics. The basis for cooperation is the necessity both to cooperate and to bind “the wills of men to the accomplishment of purposes beyond their immediate ends” (Barnard, 1938, p. 77). This should be accomplished by articulating a compelling purpose, making cooperation worthwhile.

Values are understood as conduct and end states more desirable than others, and emotions are impulses to engage in ethical behavior. Having emotional responses that are in harmony with self-transcending values creates a sense of moral integrity that is essential to leadership consistency (Michie & Gooty, 2005). Oakley (1992) reawakens the interest between morality and emotions by arguing that emotion plays a fundamental role in our moral lives. Drawing on perspectives from Aristotle on the notion of living “a humanly flourishing life,” he argues that such a life is inspired by emotions. The moral assessment includes esteem and disesteem, as well as credit and blame, which are directed at us concerning our emotions. We are encouraged to consider whether courage is only a virtue or if compassion is taken as a feelingless belief that another person is suffering. Courage and compassion involve emotional

dimensions, helping us capture this as a moral direction reaching toward the good (Oakley, 1992).

Studies have shown that reflection on the relationship between emotion and values forms an awareness of intentions and actions involving ethical sensemaking (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021; Aadland, 2010). In bewildering situations, awareness of values can help people understand what right and wrong actions are and potentially provide guidance (Askeland et al., 2020; Gehman et al., 2013). Within the ethical sensemaking literature, these processes involve reaching out to moral imagination (Sonenshein, 2007), which has affective dimensions (Reinecke & Ansari, 2015). Reflective practice is a skill that can be learned and improved (Crossan & Sorrenti, 2002; Weick, 2002; Yanow & Tsoukas, 2009). For instance, environmental and sustainability issues can affect organizational members' emotions, values, and ethical reflections (Espedal & Elter, 2024). When defining organizational purposes, considering emotions can aid in exploring ways to integrate social and sustainability values (Espedal & Ulfsten, 2024). Positive emotional engagement connected to the need to work on these issues might strengthen the work on sustainability issues. Negative emotional reactions can be seen when people worry about climate change and when employees experience that their organization is not doing enough to work on the meaning of these issues (Polman, 2023).

One study has identified a relationship between emotion and values in maintaining the moral values of a profession (Wright et al., 2017). A study of physicians at an emergency unit and their interactions with other hospital specialists shows that the values of the physician specialists led to a reflection, including moral emotions, on their practice in two different situations. When the professionals experienced practices enacted by other specialists that were not aligned with their professional values, they shared moral (emotional) judgments and worked on maintaining their values by establishing new practices. When the professionals experienced value interpretations by individuals and inter-specialist units that were not aligned with their own experiences, they morally reflected on the situation but did not change their practices. By focusing on values as a source of conflict and a motive for professional action inside the organizations, the study draws attention to how reflexivity on emotion is an affective mechanism in processes of institutional work on professional aspects of values (Wright et al., 2017). Professionals can draw upon their expert knowledge and legitimacy to challenge practice perceived as undermining professional values and the standards for their achievement (Suddaby & Viale, 2011).

Moral emotions can affect actions and behaviors in organizations (Wright et al. (2017). A process of values inquiry involves asking value-conscious questions leading to ethically fruitful situations (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). Value inquiry is a process to define an emotional and discovery-oriented process originating from a desire for transformation in troublesome situations. The value inquiry process helps discover not only what values mean but also their relationship to emotions. One study found the value inquiry process altered the emotions of communities when determining the right and wrong ways to act (Espedal et al., 2023). The study investigates the organizing of healthcare departments at two university hospitals in Norway during the COVID-19 pandemic. In a situation filled with anxiety and fear, the leaders directed attention toward the inner intuition and reflection (I/me) to develop their communities, looking for what were right and wrong actions, including emotional, embodied, and socially embedded aspects of the work (Creed et al., 2020; Hargrave et al., 2020). Moral agency was developed through a community-embedded value inquiry process (I/me/others), emerging in the three partially overlapping steps of moral reflex, value calibration (including handling emotions such as despair and fear), and translating values into embedded actions (I as supported by the community) (Espedal et al., 2023). Through the enactment of value reflection, the leaders experienced a more secure community environment with a clearer understanding of the right and wrong actions to take.

Ethical sensemaking stands as essential alternative to the rational paradigm of ethical decision-making in organizations. An intrapersonal interplay of emotions and reflexivity is emphasized for launching ethics as a fabric to establish emotional awareness, emotional unpacking, and emotional (dis)engagement (Diochon & Nizet, 2019). In this case, we can include the interrelationships between values and emotion as being part of the sense-making work in this “fabric”; however, to understand this relationship, we need more research.

In summary, this chapter highlights the significant impact of institutional leadership that considers both emotions and values. Institutional leaders play a vital role in connecting an organization’s past, present, and future by shaping values and expectations that influence the processes of organizational identity formation. The chapter also demonstrates how awareness of emotions contributes to fostering organizational commitment. Emotions are instrumental in strengthening and activating values, offering valuable insights into reflexivity and sensemaking within the context of institutional leadership. As a result, emotions and values are shown to define roles and feelings

within the organizational structure, create behavioral scripts, encourage self-transcendence, and foster moral accountability in the pursuit of the common good.

Future Pathways

There is a need for further research on the impact and importance of emotion and values within the institutional leadership tradition and how it develops, strengthens, maintains, and in some situations disrupts, leadership work. There are reasons for asking general questions, such as the role values play in triggering emotions and the role values play in the “intentionality” of emotions. Linking emotions to intentionality in a peculiar approach, we can examine what relation there is between the impression of values and emotions. Is it possible to understand value in terms of emotions, for example, in terms of emotional dispositions or in terms of certain types of emotions? Or do emotions themselves exemplify values properties (Mulligan, 2009)?

Leaning on the four qualities, including emotion and values within institutional leadership, we suggest four tracks for investigation. First, there is an emerging need to move beyond exploring the quality of relationships and toward the exploitation of relational dynamics that influence institutional leadership development. Drawing attention to the implementation of relational and human-centered practices and the creation of effective networks, we can ask how this is connected to organizational commitments and how it brings desired results. We argue that the Scandinavian approach, focused on involvement and dialogue, points in the direction of relational reciprocity as a key dimension in the legitimacy of values infusion, but it is necessary to ask how this legitimacy is formed.

Second, while much research has focused on cognitive or rational discourses, we see a need to examine the anchoring of values in emotions and principles (Hodgkinson, 1978). Researchers should be encouraged to explore how both emotions and values touch individuals and a community's goals (Conte et al., 2023). Included in this is how awareness of emotions can influence and strengthen work on core values connected to the missions and goals of institutions. For instance, when values are threatened or supported, they become infused with feelings (Schwartz, 2010). If an organization highly values compassion, people might be sad or disappointed when they perceive that the value is threatened by behavior that does not support compassion. On the other hand, people will be encouraged to engage in behavior supporting compassion when they feel it is motivated by goals and behavior.

Third, we suggest further research to understand the leadership of coherence. Coherence and leadership character are shaped over time as individual and collective interests play out, and critical decisions of leaders establish directions and standards, binding emotions to the identification of collective identity. This should draw attention to investigating the relationship between how leaders' personal values affect their work on infusing the institution with values and how this work is connected to, for instance, emotional labor and truth. Questions include how leaders work on values such as honesty when their values are compromised, how they handle situations when they lose personal control, strategies they employ, and the role values play.

Fourth, the relationship between emotions and values raises a wide range of moral questions to be investigated: How do emotions help us capture the values-based moral direction of actions toward organizing the good? How can the relationship between emotion and values define organizations' purposes and incorporate organizational purposes of the common good? Finally, how are interrelationships between values and emotion part of the processes of ethical sensemaking?

Conclusion

According to Selznick (1957, p. 17), institutional leaders, like statesmen, should infuse their institutions with values that extend beyond technical and rational requirements. In this chapter, we introduce an additional emotional dimension to this work. Through rereading sociological predecessors and doing a literature review on empirical studies, we have formulated a definition of institutional leadership that incorporates the concepts of emotions and values. We view institutional leadership as processes that adapt to dynamic social changes while upholding desirable standards. This approach emphasizes the importance of working with values and emotions to foster identification and character within organizations. It involves setting motivational purpose, promoting coherent leadership, and initiating moral dialogues.

In this chapter, we identify three pathways of institutional leadership, encompassing emotions and values. The first pathway integrates the values literature with emotional dimensions. The second pathway draws on research literature that emphasizes the role of emotions in enhancing and activating values. The third pathway delves deeper into the relationship between emotions and values, contributing to perspectives on reflexivity and sensemaking in institutional leadership. Within the third pathway, we identify four qualities that address the challenges of embedded or constrained agency: a

focus on relational practice, an emphasis on motivational missions and goals, the development of leadership coherence and integrity, and the involvement of moral dialogues.

Through our study, we have gained an understanding of the impact of attending to both emotions and values. This approach connects an organization's past, present, and future, shaping values and expectations that frame institutionalizing processes of organizational identity. It also contributes to efforts to foster organizational commitment. As such, the results of the studies are that emotions and values help define roles and feelings of organizational structure, form scripts, work on self-transcendence, and create moral accountability in working on the common good.

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Part III

Emotions and Values: A Focused Exploration



7

Archiving Academic Melancholia

Vanessa Pouthier and Xiaoran Ma

Introduction

Although neoliberal colonization of the institution of contemporary academia is not a nascent phenomenon (Thompson, 2014 [1970]), the COVID-19 disruption brought to the surface its affective repercussions on academic workers (e.g. Lupu, 2021; Stone et al., 2023). Echoing the pandemic's amplifying effects of emotional distress across sectors (e.g. Mackenzie, 2022), academic workers have increasingly recognized, recounted and reflected on their struggles in embodying neoliberal fantasies of 'excellence' and 'success' (Fleming, 2020; Knights & Clarke, 2014). Unorthodox methodologies appreciating the centrality of lived experiences to institutional (re)production—such as autoethnography and collective biography which have received growing acceptance since the pandemic—provide academic workers with epistemic possibilities to make visible how neoliberal universities wield affective injuries on them through the construction of academic lives.¹

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¹ We use the notion of *affective injuries* to capture the painful bodily experiences and memories of structural oppression that are challenging to communicate and easily silenced or dismissed (by the self and others) under the ruling systems of fantasies, ethos, and promises. With this notion, we wish to expose and examine the affective consequences of the institutionalization of neoliberal values in

In this chapter, we present a meta-ethnography of these embodied accounts of academics' affective experiences when struggling to survive the institutional zeitgeist of performative universities dictated by neoliberal values such as pragmatism, individualism and meritocracy (Fleming, 2020; Rhodes & Pullen, 2023). We aim to synthesize the emotional impacts (i.e. affective injuries) of pressures to embody neoliberal 'conceptions of desirable [academic] behaviours, objectives and ideals' (Askeland, 2020, p. 26). We rely on the notion of melancholia to capture the series of neoliberalism-induced affective injuries, we inferred from accounts marked by anxiety, frustration, powerlessness and numbness. We also seek to highlight a range of tactics that academics engage in to grapple with affective injuries. Such tactics, we suggest, are more than mere coping mechanisms to sustain us in our struggles for survival; they constitute affective pathways to freedom from injurious institutional values.

While the lived experiences of academic workers may match the symptomatology of melancholia as a psychical affliction, we do not approach melancholia as a pathological psychological response to loss—a dominant conceptualization since the seminal work of Freud on mourning and melancholia (1917). Instead, taking inspiration from critical studies that expose the haunting of affective injuries caused by various forms of structural violence (e.g. Eng & Han, 2000; Gana, 2023), we think of melancholia as a legitimate affective response (with subversive potential) to the institutionalization of injurious ideals, which we feel should be recognized and archived (Cvetkovich, 2003). This understanding of melancholia still centres the affective suffering behind melancholia but draws attention to both the socio-political processes that make large groups of humans miserable and the potential for ordinary affective suffering to become a resource for action and site of agency (Cvetkovich, 2012). Following their lead, we refuse the displacement of social problems into personal ones.

In conducting a meta-ethnography (Doyle, 2003; Noblit & Hare, 1988) of academics' self-narratives in the forms of autoethnography or collective biography, we can outline more fully the lived experience of the institutionalization of particular values, while furthering our understanding of what affective dynamics can do. In doing so, we answer calls for a more critical 'version of institutional analysis that is concerned not only with an

contemporary academia. We also wish to evoke sensitivity, empathy, and care vis-à-vis each other's pain and suffering. We are indebted to Rosalind Gill's (2009) writing on the "hidden injuries" of the neoliberal university and her encouragement to hear in what may appear as the inappropriate moaning of the privileged a critical analysis and political demand for change for all (Ashcraft, 2017).

understanding of how institutions work, but that see institutional analysis reflectively as a moral and emancipatory scholarly project' (Voronov & Weber, 2020, p. 881). Ultimately, we aspire to build an archive that contains not only criticality and challenges but also 'plenty of love, determination, and courage to shape something special' and 'to face up to our own demons' (Bristow, 2023, p. 1302). We consider the work of archiving affective memories in neoliberal academia 'an endless opening to what is being "othered" and a tireless importuning of a justice-to-come' (Harris, 2017, pp. 3, 9).

In terms of exhibiting this archive (i.e. expressing the meta-ethnographic synthesis), we are not attempting to offer a neatly packaged way of communication. In the same spirit as most sampled autoethnographic and biographic texts, our writing is not 'scientific', linear, or rationality-driven, but messy, fragmented, layered and *heart/gut-following*—that is, following what we *feel* strongest resonances with, what we *believe* should be reported and underscored, what we *perceive* could be disruptive possibilities. Our *heart/gut* arises from not only the (re)reading of sampled texts but also the mundane academic lives that we ourselves live/work through. *Following heart/gut*, we hope to trouble purist criteria for academic writing through writing differently, affectively for our archival construction of academic melancholia (Kaasila-Pakanen & Mandalaki, 2023; Smith & Ulus, 2020).

Through our archiving, we contribute to institutional scholarship by uncovering the affective injuries (i.e. '*I am tired of performing*', '*I am not enough*', '*What I am doing is bullshit*' and '*We are living different shades of privilege and precarity*') accompanying the institutionalization (e.g. legitimization, naturalization, socialization) of neoliberal values across academic organizations, such as individualism, pragmatism and meritocracy, that mutually feed on and conjure up each other. More importantly, we add to the literature on institutional control, oppression and resistance by underscoring the emancipatory potential of affective injuries which the various embodied accounts of struggling with 'excellence' in neoliberal universities surfaced. Specifically, we highlight the affective pathways to freedom (i.e. *making space*, *making time*, *having fun* and *being naked*) that spring from academic melancholia and are grounded in an ethics of mutuality, vulnerability and care, which can challenge and undermine the injury-(re)making hegemony of neoliberal fantasies, ethos and promises.

Our Approach

We relied on meta-ethnography (Doyle, 2003; Noblit & Hare, 1988) as the overarching method to pull together embodied accounts of affective injuries and resistance in the organizational contexts of neoliberal academia. Rarely used in organizational scholarship (see Hodson, 2004; Steele & King, 2011 as two exceptions), meta-ethnography aims at interpretatively synthesizing (auto)ethnographies that are idiosyncratic by design, thereby ‘produc[ing] deeper insights than primary studies may have produced when interpreted in isolation’ (Hughes & Noblit, 2017, p. 219).

Data Sampling

We started our sampling process by separately retrieving relevant texts on academic search engines (e.g. Google Scholar, EBSCO, Sage, Jstor) with key terms such as ‘anxiety’ or ‘depression’, ‘academics’ or ‘university’ and ‘autoethnography’ or ‘collective biography’. We then converged our search results into one master list so as to determine *what* texts are relevant to our review (see Table 7.1). Before engaging with the sampled texts in a deeper manner, we roughly thematized the list based on the general themes surfacing from their titles, abstracts and keywords, which helped us develop raw impressions regarding *how* texts are differentially relevant to our review.

Consistent with extant exemplars (e.g. Hughes & Noblit, 2017; Steele & King, 2011), our meta-ethnography also adopted purposive, selective sampling, which is not exhaustive but extensive, not systematic but shaped by three affective leanings. First, we paid particular attention to academic melancholia in management departments and business schools. Nevertheless, our review also includes and is indebted to embodied accounts across disciplines (e.g. geography, education, cultural studies) as we believe in the value of learning from our peers’ struggle with the institutionalization of neoliberal values in their academic quarters, especially as they pioneered the methodologies of collective biography and autoethnography and the slow academia movement. Second, we cannot deny the significant role of our personal interests in building the sample for review. Specifically, Vanessa has been curious about peers’ lived experiences of juggling academic work with motherhood and imposter syndrome, whereas Xiaoran is interested in the stories of early-career researchers, especially those who are also coloured and neurodivergent. Third, we purposively gravitated towards the embodied accounts striving to disrupt academic melancholia and the neoliberal value system at cause. Our goal is to present an archival sketch of academic melancholia

Table 7.1 Data sampling

Type	Count	Author and title
Individual autoethnography	15	Bosanquet 2017—Academic, Woman, Mother Campbell 2018—Reconstructing My Identity Forber-Pratt 2015—Challenges of Autoethnography Foster 2017—Academic Labor in the Age of Anxiety Grant 2019—Wrestling with Career Hacker 2022—Crying on Campus Jago 2002—Chronicling an Academic Depression Jones 2018—Could Slow Be Beautiful? Jones 2023—An Alternative Liminal Journey of a Head of Department Lupu 2021—Pregnancy and Birth during COVID Opdycke 2023—My Negotiation between Neuro divergency and Whiteness Quijada 2021—My Mental Health Struggle in Academia Sparkes 2021—Laughing at Absurdities Stone 2022—Understand and Overcome Feelings of Imposterism Tienari 2019—Autoethnography, Academic Identity, and Language

(continued)

Table 7.1 (continued)

Type	Count	Author and title
Collaborative autoethnography	9	Deschner et al. 2020—Prefiguring a Feminist Academia Huopalaainen and Satama, 2018—Mothers and Researchers in the Making Kiriakos and Tienari 2018—Academic Writing as Love Klevan and Grant 2022—Becoming a Qualitative Researcher Learmonth and Humphreys 2011—Autoethnography and Academic Identity Nordbäck et al. 2022—Academic Identities and Sense of Place Stone et al. 2021—Care-Less Whispers in the Academy during COVID Tuinamuna et al. 2019—Academic Writing in an Audit Culture Weatherall and Ahuja 2021—Learning as Moments of Friction and Opportunity
Collective biography	7	Brooks et al. 2015—Becoming-Academic in the Neoliberal Academy Charteris et al. 2016—The Emotional Knots of Academicity Gannon et al. 2015—Sisterly Affect in Neoliberal Universities Gannon et al. 2019—Working on a Rocky Shore Hartung et al. 2017—Beyond the Academic Precariat Kern et al. 2014—Joy in Academic Practice Taylor et al. 2020—Grim Tales
Total	31	

that contributes to a greater understanding of the affective consequences of neoliberal academia and, more importantly, a hopeful glimpse of the affective possibilities of troubling its reproduction.

We focused on autoethnography and collective biography for the direct access they provide to what it affectively means to be an academic worker in neoliberal universities. Specifically, autoethnography is a method whereby researchers collect, describe, analyse and critique their personal experiences in order to generate novel theoretical claims about social phenomena and

cultural practices (Adams et al., 2014; Jones et al., 2016). Calling for openly, purposively embracing emotionality as ‘a part of social life and how we relate to/with each other’, autoethnography operates through deep and careful self-reflection to ‘name and interrogate the intersections between self and society; the particular and the general; the personal and the political’ and may inspire readers to reflect as well by ‘show[ing] people in the process of figuring out what to do, how to live, and the meaning of their struggles’ (Adams et al., 2014, pp. 2, 11).

Influenced by the way collaborative autoethnography is breaking self-other boundaries, collective biography relies on ‘the powerful and flawed capacities we each have to remember and to make sense of what we remember’ and aims for a collective reproduction of the ‘we’ through ‘(re)valu[ing] and (re)view[ing] the experiences of bodies and emotions in the processes of subjectification’ (Davies & Gannon, 2006, pp. 1–2, 117). Concretely, collective biography involves brainstorming a topic as a group, followed by reconvening to read out loud written memories of experiences around the topic and engaging in deep listening to and reflecting on each other’s accounts. This sets the foundation for a further iterative process of thematization and reading so as to distil a theoretical conceptualization of the chosen topic (Davies & Gannon, 2006).

Autoethnography and collective biography, respectively, stemming from queer theory (Adams et al., 2014; Jones et al., 2016) and feminist writings (Davies & Gannon, 2006), share the vision of transgressing epistemic oppression (Dotson, 2014). Both acknowledge the body as the ultimate site of power contestation and knowledge production while encouraging ‘learn[ing] from embodied voices (ours and others)’ that we have become accustomed to dismiss’ (Kaasila-Pakanen & Mandalaki, 2023, p. 4). We hope our meta-ethnographic project helps valorize these unorthodox methodologies and support their challenge to what can be said, known, and counted as knowledge under the epistemic hegemony of positivism across disciplines (Foucault, 1972).

Data Analysis

During analysis, meta-ethnographers must ground themselves in everyday lived experiences narrated in the texts to be synthesized while constantly comparing studies across heterogeneous contexts where the narrated experiences take place (Doyle, 2003; Noblit & Hare, 1988). This involves dual processes of translation across studies on the one hand and specification of individualities on the other (Hughes & Noblit, 2017, p. 224). Reminding

ourselves of the pitfall of brutally reducing or simply aggregating idiosyncratic accounts, we strove to preserve the thickness of affective stories in our attempt to bring them together to form a richer line of argument.

We distilled two groups of themes from the reviewed accounts, which we, respectively, labelled affective injuries and affective resistance (see Table 7.2). Regarding affective injuries, we heard four different but interdependent voices, revealing the negative affective impacts of performativity, individualism, and lack of criticality prevalent in neoliberalism-governed universities, and the acknowledged influence of intersecting axes of oppression on affective experiences of neoliberal academia, respectively. Regarding affective resistance, four interrelated acts of affective activism surfaced, involving academic workers reorganizing space and time, confronting injuries and their structural sources with humour and publicly and creatively sharing affective injuries.

When (re)reading the sampled texts, we sensed resonance and empathy at the same time: resonance from the striking similarities between the embodied accounts and our own affective memories and empathy for the suffering and pain of those who are more vulnerable than ourselves to the melancholia-(re)producing machinery of neoliberal academia. The reviewing process enabled us to *see* our positionalities within the interweaving webs of privilege and disadvantage through sensing others' pain and suffering. It also strengthened our belief that the practice of archiving affective injuries and resistance can in itself be an act of activism, with the potential to 'bring new, more equal and freer justice-oriented relations to the fore' (Contu, 2020, p. 749).

Table 7.2 Data structure

Affective injuries	Affective resistance
• "I am tired of performing!" • "I am not enough!" • "What I am doing is bullshit!" • "We are living different shades of privilege and precarity!"	• Making space: being together • Making time: being slow • Having fun: using humour and laughter • Being naked: making a vulnerable methodological choice

Emergent Findings

Academic Melancholia as Affective Injuries

We identified three streams of voices articulating the embodied pain of affective injuries of being/becoming an academic worker in neoliberal universities, including ‘I am tired of performing’, ‘I am not enough’ and ‘What I am doing is bullshit’. These three intertwined streams of voices together form a melancholic sketch of what the institutionalization of neoliberal values has been and is still doing to the academic heart and mind. We also recognized efforts to shed light on how interlocking systems of oppression or inequality interact to create unique affective experiences of neoliberal academia, while reflecting on one’s own positionality and privileges: ‘We are living different shades of privilege and precarity’.

‘I am Tired of Performing’

In universities run like a business, performativity is imposed by corporate control via performance targets, indicators and measurements (Knights & Clarke, 2014) and the celebration of mythical ‘star entrepreneurial scholars’ (Cannella & Koro-Ljungberg, 2017) and devoted and loyal ‘academic citizens’ (Burton, 2021), calling for emotional competence (Voronov & Weber, 2016) in maintaining the façade of ‘excellence’ across as many domains of academic life as possible.

I felt a symbolic punishment of unrecognized personal sacrifice on my part. I could not hold back my tears. ... in my eyes, I was performing as a good, and even heroic, academic or university citizen, ignoring what my body was trying to tell me about the unhealthy consequences of the stressful way of life academics face in our era (Gillespie et al. 2001; Dua 1994). Yet, here, back at my office, instead of receiving a thank-you note or a letter of appreciation, I am learning that the organization does not recognize my dedication, with its associated health costs, and treats me as if I took all the leave days to which my doctor certified I was entitled. [...] The crying incidents happened when I experienced the clash between the academic habitus and the fact that the university is, also, an economic and bureaucratic employer. (excerpt from Hacker, 2022)

The ever-growing demand for emotional competence leads to academic workers’ chronic feelings of stress, fatigue and exhaustion on the one hand

and a sense of inauthenticity and artificiality on the other due to the persistent incongruity between the self and the impression-managing mask to be worn to meet the fantasized ideas for intelligence, confidence, and commitment that ‘invariably exceed the capacity of ordinary human beings to meet’ (Knights & Willmott, 1999, p. 72).

My body dictates what people think of me. I stood there in the middle of the crowded apartment, surrounded by graduate school ‘community.’ I smiled and nodded, listening to you go on and on about something, about your extravagant life abroad, I believe. I remained silent, as usual, still trying to decide if I wanted to cry or scream. I felt claustrophobic. Like all the years of smiling and nodding, of my outer shell being the focus, of no meaning yes, of being nothing but a body, are closing in on me. All in that moment. I couldn’t breathe. This shouldn’t have happened here. I came to this programme to be surrounded by and work with women who would understand. Not to be in competition, not to be conforming to the male gaze, not to be regulated. You were supposed to be different. I am merely an object. Not professional enough. Too young. Too sexualized. Not sexualized enough. I’m a prisoner of my own body. (excerpt from Brooks et al., 2015)

The more robust emotional competence is, the more depressingly aware some academics may become of their own complicity in reproducing a neoliberal academia that threatens cherished traditional values (Fleming, 2020), and the more horrified they may be at the realization that parts of themselves find comfort, even enjoyment in pragmatism-motivated opportunism (Learmonth & Humphreys, 2012). They dread a world where only effectiveness—instead of truthfulness—counts for both universities and scholars gearing up to sharpen their own competitive edge and survive this cutthroat business.

[A]s we got further into our academic careers, we started to share Jekyll’s later view: ‘that I was slowly losing hold of my ... better self, and becoming slowly incorporated with my second and worse’ (p. 55). We liked to think of ourselves as people who want to write and teach in ways that reflect our moral, political and aesthetic concerns. However, we had become increasingly conscious that another, more disturbing self was simultaneously trying to pursue with ‘skill and courage ... the [career] game’ (MacDonald and Kam, 2007: 641) often played in academia. The anxiety at this point in our lives then, was that this ‘other’ self would end up only producing what Grey and Sinclair (2006) call ‘routinized, professionalized “publication”’ (2006: 452), and similarly, that this other self would teach merely to get good student evaluations (Burrell, 1997). (excerpt from Learmonth and Humphreys, 2011)

The tyranny of performance appraisal is spoiling the campus—teleologically reserved for learning and growing, exploration and excursion—into a corporate place hostile to imagination, impatient with idleness and wonder, unsupportive of non-linear, chaotic processes of dialogue and collaboration because every minute spent must be justified by cost–benefit calculations and each decision made must be directed towards demonstrable outputs.

I stare at the sheet of paper in front of me with its three headings: teaching, service, research. I've still not written anything by the time we are asked to share with our group. They tell me of their plans to publish two A or A* [highly ranked journals] papers in the next three years then apply for a promotion. My goal feels stupid. I want to write about beautiful, radiant things. I want to share these things with others. ... (excerpt from Weatherall and Ahuja, 2021)

The seemingly 'objective', 'value-neutral' and 'fairness-ensuring' measurements neoliberal universities deploy are turning academic workers into commensurable subjects or calculable resource units to support universities' performance in endless rankings (Ashcraft, 2017). They produce in the process instrumental scholars who start approaching research 'as a means for the end of quantitative performance' rather than for its own sake and seem to no longer know the simple, older pleasure of pursuing 'complex and exciting agendas' amidst a vibrant and inspiring community (Becker & Lukka, 2023, p. 5).

When you talk about scholarship of teaching and how you enjoy being around people who have passion for it ... I don't think we have that here. We talk about getting into the scholarship of teaching, but when people talk about it, I generally don't hear any pleasure in their voices ... it's seen as just another thing that we have to do to get [workload] hours.... I think you can still do it within the time that you have, but I do understand that, the thought of adding another thing to your list of things to do, can be all-consuming. I don't think it's anyone's fault, necessarily, I think it's ... because we're all caught up with this need to "produce and count, produce and count, produce and count". (excerpt from Tuinamuana et al., 2019)

"I am not Enough"

The neoliberal value of pragmatism is ideologically paired with individualism, which keeps (re)producing the haunting sense of vulnerability and precarity with individuals shouldering the sole responsibility for the outcomes of their

academic labour, for good and especially for bad. Such a seemingly meritocratic game on campus inflates the hubris and narcissism of its ‘winners’ on the one hand and the humiliation and despair of the ‘losers’ on the other (Sandel, 2020).

She [Lyn] contemplates the academy with its prestigious journals, bustling conferences, and frocked hierarchy. It is a rock face, a buttress where she climbs stealthily—striving to keep a grip on the protruding, yet sharp handholds, keeping a wary eye on the looming ledge above. There are overhangs – selection panels, journal reviews, teaching evaluations and research funding applications. In recognition of Lyn’s theoretical and practical knowledge, her senior colleague discusses with her how the course can be reworked to draw from the skills and resources that she brings to the faculty. Hopeful – her fingers tuck into the rock grooves. With knuckles and knees she grips on to her place on the escarpment. At the beginning of the next year Lyn blanches to hear a new (non-casual) Level A academic had been appointed in her place. It is a split role between campuses. She tells herself that it is a dispassionate decision, a numbers game. Her hours are drastically reduced. With fears of an uncertain employment future, she spirals into a crisis of confidence – in both the university and herself. All she wants is to ‘be academic’. (excerpt from Charteris et al., 2016)

In particular, modelling the ‘winners’ (e.g. academic rock stars, future leaders) has been crushing the dignity of the average majority, causing lingering feelings of insecurity and insufficiency (e.g. I am not smart enough or I am not working enough) that can only be compensated with pace intensification and overwork typically at the expense of one’s personal life and family time.

One day, my counsellor took a small wicker basket full of contrasting stones and pebbles from behind her, and placed it on the table between us. “This is your life”, she said. “Each stone represents someone in your life. Take your time. Which stone represents, let’s say, your partner?”. I stared at those rocks. I kept staring. I heard the soft ticking of the clock on the wall as I stared some more. Minutes went by. More staring. “There’s no right or wrong answer. Just go for what you feel is best”, my counsellor utters soothingly. Panic sets in. I want to pick one but I know in my heart whichever stone I choose will be a lie. I do not want to lie. I want this to mean something. And then it dawns on me and I say it out loud. “I can’t pick a stone that represents my partner”. And, triumphantly, with a sense of relief, “That’s because he doesn’t come to work with me”. A pause hangs in the air. My counsellor looks at me with sadness, and gently but robustly says, “Elaine, I didn’t say the bowl was about work. I said it was about your life”. (excerpt from Campbell, 2018)

Meanwhile, modelling helps pre-empt a possible alliance against university management by corrupting interpersonal relations with the toxic ambience of competition, resentment, discordance and even inner-oppression among academics who are actually under the universal control of neoliberal academia (Franken et al., 2023).

I feared for my future and realized that I was too old and badly equipped to compete with new academic rules and standards. I became part of the precariat. This said, I love research and I intend to continue my lifestyle. I simply have to accept that I am an academic entrepreneur with low status and uncertain future prospects ... there seems to be less and less space in neoliberal universities – socially and physically – for people like me. I am restless and stressed. (excerpt from Nordbäck et al., 2022)

Academics are thus thrown into anxiety (Foster, 2017; Quijada, 2021), depression (Campbell, 2018; Jago, 2002) and imposter syndrome (Bothello & Roulet, 2019).

[I]mposter syndrome is associated with depression, anxiety, and psychological distress (Cohen & McConnell, 2019). I felt this way and worried I was going to be “found out” as not having what it takes to be successful. The fact that I am part of two minority groups intensified the feeling (Clance & Imes, 1978). (excerpt from Quijada, 2021)

There is a general lack of formal acknowledgment or action from management (Smith & Ulus, 2020) vis-à-vis the atmospheric toxicity, subsequent affective injuries, and deeper structural reasons. Meanwhile, the lack of care and the feeling of distrust are preventing academics from communicating their inner struggles with colleagues or managers despite the availability of complaint channels and relative-to-opportunity provisions, leading to the agonizing status quo where similarly suffering individuals remain siloed. Ultimately, academic melancholia is being individualized in terms of attributing responsibility for its embodied consequences and their management to individuals rather than the system such that swallowing grim tales alone has become part of professional socialization (Taylor et al., 2020).

To gain tenure, I was expected to publish seven articles in 5 years (we could debate whether that is even feasible when talking about top journals). That was my tenure clock. But by Year 4, I had published nothing. If “publishing is our primary currency” (de Rond & Miller, 2005, p. 322), I had none. This is how I went into my 4th-year review, with the dean and department chair. They reviewed my evaluation, and I presented my case, my struggle with depression,

how it affected my productivity, and how I believed I should be given more time. I pointed out that my depression was medically diagnosed, and I took medication. I argued that if I suffered from a physical illness that prevented me from working, would not that qualify me for an extension? My plea was all for naught; all I received back was silence. In the end, they reiterated that I was not performing as expected, and it would be very difficult for me to earn tenure. (excerpt from Quijada, 2021)

“What I am Doing is Bullshit”

Critical scholars have also identified and deplored a loss of criticality in academia regarding the positionality of one’s own discipline vis-à-vis other disciplines and the value the discipline is providing to society at large (Bothello & Roulet, 2019). Driven by the neoliberalism-conditioned individualistic-pragmatistic mindset, academic workers keep persisting with their blind ‘fetish’ with top-tier publication (Willmott, 2011) and rapid mass production of theoretical ‘novelty’ (Tourish, 2020) while copying formulaic research recipes to secure employability and avoid uncertainties associated with more marginal, experimental possibilities of knowing/knowledge.

The problem is that almost 15 years after graduating with my doctoral degree I cannot yet see the articulation of my unique vision and passion, my “contribution” to the world. Perhaps more unsettling is the question of how much time I have spent working on research projects that were not necessarily of my choosing. When I reflect on my CV in this way, I see the vita of a scholar who has played by the rules and I question whether that is enough and whether, at the end of the day, this is what I want to count as my life’s work. (excerpt from Foster, 2017)

The erosion of criticality, social relevance, and devotion to long-term, slow-paced academic adventure, what scholars have described as *myopia* (Bothello & Roulet, 2019), *stupidity* (Alvesson & Spicer, 2016), *illusio* (Lupu, 2021) or *self-alienation* (Fleming, 2020), is turning academic work into another example of ‘bullshit jobs’ (Graeber, 2019).

I’d have to buy into structures and systems that are hostile to my body and can result in literal and metaphorical death. And I ain’t trying to die in this shit. So I think my level of engagement in any of this is tempered by this constant awareness that a.) it’s mostly bullshit and b.) I could never be an insider and c.) if I could somehow be included as an insider, what would that insider status would say about me? Like, if I could somehow be an insider in an institution

that is both patriarchal and white supremacist, what does that mean about my integrity? Could I feel good about myself in other spaces? (excerpt from Brooks et al., 2015)

Bullshitiness, as both perceived and actual, has led to the dualistic existence of perceived meaninglessness and intellectual exhibitionism (Tourish, 2020), sensed emptiness and felt grandiosity (Alvesson & Gabriel, 2016). With that said, scholars have expressed felt complicity in this neoliberal game of ‘excellence’ and ‘success’ with their acquiescence and cooperation (Ashcraft, 2018; Foster, 2017; Sparkes, 2021).

Reading these words now, much as when I wrote them in 2018, I feel a wave of nausea ripple through my stomach. I don’t like the “me” that wrote it. I’m not sure I like the “me” that reads it now. I also don’t like the “me” who “with an eye to the competition” gathered data from the website about the h-index scores of colleagues I hold in high regard and then turned them into numbers stripped of the situational or contextual conditions they work under. Even worse was my weaponizing of the scores so that I could play the comparison game in my letter of me versus them—with me obviously being presented as “better” in terms of ranking solely on the h-index score. In this act, as Andrew (2019) argues, I am denying and demeaning others to boost my own appearance of “honest” performativity. [...] The intrusion of the h-index into my academic life, and my complicity as a neoliberal subject in how I used it as I did, does not make me feel good about myself. Like Smith (2013), I feel that there is a “me” that is eroding fast. (excerpt from Sparkes, 2021)

However, the (re)production of nonsense perpetuates as new generations of academic workers are still being indoctrinated with the mantras of ‘publish or perish’ and ‘I theorize therefore I am’ (Bothello & Roulet, 2019). On the one hand, senior members are not serving as good exemplars (Harley, 2019). On the other hand, the managerial level remains overall indifferent to academic melancholia while perpetuating an emotional culture that rewards self-serving, pragmatically performative mentality (Smith & Ulus, 2020). In brief, contemporary academia is stuck in a seemingly irresistible repetition of neoliberal circularity where ‘everybody seems to not like [it] ... everybody is kind of criticizing [it] ... but everybody plays [the] game’ (Becker & Lukka, 2023, p. 12).

“We are living different shades of privilege and precarity”

Among the sampled texts, we discerned interweaving systems of domination as well as the unique vulnerability of those being cast out of the neoliberal fantasies, ethos and promises. For example, autoethnographers have narrated the singularities of the lived pain of female bodies (Deschner et al., 2020; Lipton, 2020), especially those who are pregnant (Lupu, 2021), and of neurodivergent (Opdycke, 2023), non-Anglophone (Tienari, 2019) and queer bodies (Weatherall & Ahuja, 2021). With collective biography, constellations of scholars have created their ‘own documentary materials’ (Davies & Gannon, 2006, p. 5), making visible how academic subjectivities are constituting and being constituted by gender codes (Brooks et al., 2020), bullying and abuse (Zabrodska et al., 2011) and imposter syndrome (Morris et al., 2022).

Across these accounts, we also sensed a shared curiosity and humble gesture vis-à-vis those who are even more precarious/less privileged in a variety of different ways. Unfortunately, these much-needed voices tend to be muffled by gatekeeping in the publication system guided by the neoliberal principles of white patriarchy and Euro-American centrality. Meanwhile, such intersectionality of privilege and precarity has been concealed and embellished by the seemingly fairness-ensuring principles of meritocracy—the handmaiden of neoliberalism—that perpetuates acquisitive individualism and zero-sum competition as the holy grail of survival. Such academic hunger game would keep privatizing the public wealth of intellectual commons while intensifying social inequalities and divisions (Sandel, 2020).

I enjoy privileges as a white man in a professor position, and I fear that in the eyes of many I embody aggressive hegemonic masculinity (Lund & Tienari, 2019; Parker & Weik, 2014) that is individualistic, competitive, and inclined to boast about personal achievements (Lund, 2018). The fact that I had time to think through, write, and revise this article is itself a sign of privilege. I could have done something else, and my choice makes me feel guilty. ... Gendered and racialized hierarchies are very clear in Finland where universities remain dominated by white men like me. My identity cannot be detached from this context, which is difficult for me to write about because of my position. Male dominance in universities is clear, but it is challenged because gender equality is a question that is considered important in Finnish society (Katila & Meriläinen, 2002). Race and ethnicity are absent from my story for the pathetic reason that the faculty I engage with, both at Aalto and at Hanken, is practically all white. Questions of racial and ethnic equality have received little attention in Finnish business schools. I work with gender and diversity studies and feminist theory, and perhaps this is why I am aware of the problems and

why I care. However, explaining this to people who do not know me, or do not observe me at work, is difficult. (excerpt from Tienari, 2019)

Affective Activism in the Face of/Springing from Academic Melancholia

Having enumerated the affective injuries, we now turn to the tactics and strategies that academics leverage to cope with academic melancholia and resist the institutionalization of neoliberal values at cause, which we synthesized into four interrelated themes: *making space*, *making time*, *having fun* and *being naked*. We do not aim to provide self-help tips for resilience that only perpetuate the ideal ‘bounce-backable’ subjects promoted by neoliberal ideology, especially in the context of worsening inequality (Gill & Orgad, 2018). We are striving to make visible the fissures, cracks, and in-betweens that academics identify and/or create which may provide opportunities for ‘challenging power structures from the inside’ (Collins, 2012, p. xiii).

Making Space: Being Together

Some academics ritualize restorative spaces where they can *be together* and perform activities such as swimming (Jones, 2018), theatre (Adsit et al., 2015) or simply just sit down and speak-listen to each other with patience and care (Burton, 2021). Acting as a healing counterpoint vis-à-vis neoliberalism-signified spaces, these restorative spaces are liminal places that permit academic actors to temporarily escape from the asphyxiating environment while persistently returning to it with more emotional energy to contest the dominating master discourse.

I suppose it [i.e., Shoreside as an alternative, restorative space] takes me back to what I thought universities should be about – freedom. If I wanted to be business-minded, then I would have stayed in the private sector – at present any form of collegiality is being squashed out – at least these sessions are a way to reassert our collective intention in the midst of the mistrust of senior management metrics. ... All I hear in the university is about masks and games – accreditations, audits and league tables – this is what universities are all about now. What I get here in Shoreside is what universities should be about – it is almost more frustrating as you know that this is why you joined university life and the reality is so far removed from this. The university really needs to follow this example and be brave to develop its own way rather than

... constantly letting external badges drive their approach. (excerpt from Jones, 2023)

Collective restorative spaces stem from and simultaneously contribute to a spirit of mutual kindness (Burton, 2021) and ethics of caring (Hawkins, 2019), nurturing gestures of empathy, generosity and love (Kiriakos & Tienari, 2018) in neoliberal campus life. These alternative spaces are characterized by affective solidarity and reflexive collegiality among members on the one hand (Nordbäck et al., 2022) and feminist activism and relational agency in enacting change regarding the dominant ideology on the other (Adsit et al., 2015). They counter-space the affective relations dominating neoliberal campus characterized by unempathetic aloofness, cutthroat competitiveness, intellectual exhibitionism, narcissistic grandiosity and meritocratic hubris (Alvesson & Gabriel, 2016; Tourish, 2020).

During the day, the women that presented talked about their practice of feminism, the different collective, organisation or project that they were a part of. We all shared a lot about our lives, and I believe that each person that presented displayed intimate, personal stories. We shared experiences. [...] It was very warm, I met a lot of women, not only through mandatory academic networking, but during conversations when I actually felt committed to. (excerpt from Deschner et al., 2020)

Such heterogeneous spatial initiatives do not seek to coalesce under a singular manifesto that would impose definitions for kindness, care, generosity and love but instead exemplify possible trajectories towards structural kindness which understand care, love, generosity 'as iterative, dynamic, and reflexive rather than an unshifting and prescriptive set of rules for conducting oneself' (Burton, 2021, p. 30). Moreover, collective restorative spaces conceptually render obsolete the differentiations between hidden versus confrontational or decaf versus more 'efficacious' forms of resistance because, although mostly invisible and unspoken, such spaces are made possible only by proactively reorganizing affective relations and deliberately unfettering the playful self from ideological imprisonment (e.g. using care to intervene into a careless world that keeps celebrating and rewarding carelessness).

In my writing coaching, I want to offer a space where there is room for everything: for all kinds of emotions, situations, issues, and discussions. I think the radicalism in this comes from the fact that it appears so banal and harmless. Whereas academic publication sounds masculine, achievement-oriented,

powerful, status-evoking, and competitive, writing has a feminine, less important, weaker tone to it. It is thus radical to open the door for the affective and the banal in academic writing. It is radical to treat it as something holistic and comprehensive. (excerpt from Kiriakos & Tienari, 2018)

Making Time: Being Slow

Relatedly, there are academics who refuse to inhabit emotional cultures privileging speed, competition, productivity and performativity, operating through the (re)production of academic subjectivities rooted in self-acceleration and self-instrumentalization (Taylor et al., 2020). In appreciating the generality and beauty of slowness, they seek to problematize the imposed sense of temporality, the constant fear of missing out, falling behind and even dropping off, and address related lingering perceptions of impostorism and insecurity (Bothello & Roulet, 2019) and feelings of inauthenticity in displaying the required unconditional commitment to work fast after years of learned socialization in contemporary academia (Cannizzo, 2019).

Finally, somewhere that offered an escape from the managerial bullshit of my working life. It [i.e., Slow Swimming] was something about the combination of doing something so personally and collectively rewarding in another place where I would not bump into my students but even more importantly my so-called colleagues. You know, I felt trapped for years in an endless circle of pretence around portraying myself as incredibly efficient all of the time – you know answering emails in the early hours of the morning, going to meetings which, to be honest, did not add anything to the university ... (excerpt from Jones, 2018)

The advocacy for slowness builds on the contradiction between the escalating intensification of work the institutionalization of neoliberal values encourages and the notion that radical creativity can only spring from long-term consistency, idleness and lifelong craftsmanship (Cannizzo, 2019). Slowness is about emancipating the academic self from the pervasive measures hailing the neoliberal motto ‘faster-higher-stronger’ and the inescapable gaze from managers, peers and the self that turns academic workers into self-governing robots delivering academic reproduction nonstop. It involves supporting academics to regain temporal autonomy, to restore the curiosity for learning and the patience for organic growth from idle wonder (O’Connor & Gómez, 2022), and to relearn to enjoy ‘a collective, connected,

embodied and generative set of slow continuum of integrated experiences' (Jones, 2018, p. 423).

By swimming in the sea, I feel more in touch with not only my body but the wider natural environment I am swimming within. Slow swimming in a chlorinated pool is an oxymoron. If we are really in tune with our aesthetic selves then I want to be in touch with my own, others' and the wider natural environment's aesthetic cues . . . this has made me question my whole approach within the Business School. (excerpt from Jones, 2018)

'Slow down!' is not only a cry for help from early-career researchers feeling out of pace and out of breath (Lipton, 2020; Weatherall & Ahuja, 2021) but also a realization in crisis from researchers having lived through transformative experiences such as motherhood (Huopainen & Satama, 2019; Lupu, 2021) and depression (Campbell, 2018; Jago, 2002). In this respect, queer accounts of temporalities provide us with the opportunity to reimagine more creative, cooperative ways of being in the world by stepping outside of the institution-scripted reproductive rhythms, to be able to experiment with 'unscripted lives' (Halberstam, 2005, p. 2) that are meant to be 'unfixed, imprecise, unable to be neatly balanced' (Weatherall & Ahuja, 2021, p. 409). The concept of 'queer failure' (Halberstam, 2011) can upset our entrenched beliefs in success versus failure (also, winner versus loser) and associated conditioned feelings of time frames (e.g. what should (not) be done at what age).

I have no children. I will never have children. My life is made up of less definable moving parts: mental illness; familial and non-familial platonic relationships; activism; academia; music; dance; domestic labour; care work; reading fiction; writing fiction. I don't fit. I spill. (excerpt from Weatherall and Ahuja, 2021)

Having Fun: Using Humour and Laughter

Having fun is about intervening in the melancholia-(re)producing neoliberal academia with humour and laughter, given their transgressive and transformative potential. For example, Mumby (2009, p. 318) encourages us to recognize the subversive potential of a renowned professor punctuating his public lecture with unapologetically loud farts, should we allow ourselves to laugh at the presumably inept yet most natural performance. Given our 'civilized' obeisance to the solemnity of ritualistic events like public lectures,

it might be more difficult for us to respect our bodily calls than to carefully muffle them or hold them back, which precisely makes the incongruous parallel between lecturing and farting (or any ironic/parodic gestures) capable of exposing and destabilizing taken-for-granted value systems.

In an autoethnographic account, Sparkes (2021) showcases his own attempt at using humour and laughter to ridicule the audit culture in academia, which was appreciated by colleagues for the felt empowerment and fear dissolution that the laughter brought about. Sparkes (2021) explains that humour is a way of reconnecting with others (e.g. audiences) by truth-telling about the fractured, ambiguous, and multiple world we feel together. On top of playful laughter, tragic laughter is a survival and subversive means of persisting with dignity and hope in dignity-denying and despair-inducing environments.

We noticed that humoristic accounts and interventions against melancholia-(re)producing neoliberal academia are not many among the sampled texts, despite organization scholarship's recognition of humour and laughter as a device capable of puncturing and undermining systems of control and domination (e.g. Rodrigues & Collinson, 1995). Every autoethnographic and collective-biographic piece is a history of blood and tears, a tale of darkness and love, and we deeply sense that there must be so much more happening bodily-affectively behind each story. We believe that baking humour into the stories being told and the lives being lived is not about denying experiences of pain and suffering but instead liberating them for discussion to collectively identify structural pathologies and cures, not just for the self but also for others. It calls for the courage of talking through one's pain with others, having a laugh about it together with the heart-warming subtext of 'you are not alone'.

Being Naked: Making a Vulnerable Methodological Choice

Last but not least, academics also engage in embodied nakedness as a methodological choice for countering the institutionalization of neoliberal values, which 'pushes us to meta-reflect on ourselves as organizational ethnographers and writers to reinvent our field and writing interactions as inter-corporeally relational and intersubjective' (Mandalaki & Pérezts, 2022, p. 596). Autoethnography and collective biography as aforementioned are precisely manifestations of *being naked*, which involves removing masks and mobilizing our 'fallible, messy and uncontrollable' bodies as trustworthy sites of knowing and ultimate devices of resistance (Jones et al., 2016, p. 29).

Being Naked Through Autoethnography

As a form of being methodologically naked, autoethnography involves putting the self in a vulnerable position by telling a public audience a real-life story using a first-person account while ‘strip[ping] away the veneer of self-protection that comes with professional title and position’ (Denzin, 2003, p. 137). It is by itself an aesthetic project of cure (Jones et al., 2016), not only therapeutic to the writing self but also repairing to the reading others—that is, melancholia is being dissolved by just talking about it and sharing it with sincerity and gentleness. Meanwhile, autoethnography does not stop at caressing the injured but goes deep in uprooting the injurious power relations at cause while reasserting hope for ‘social justice and to make life better’ (Adams et al., 2014, p. 2) and for “the possibilities of happiness in the presence of human suffering” (Bochner, 2012, p. 155). It is a way to ‘push back, intervene, be vulnerable, tell another story’ and “contest what happened’ (Denzin, 2013, pp. 27, 64).

For example, Jago (2002) and Campbell (2018) have both bravely shared their struggle with depression within academic contexts as a means of expanding our understanding of academic stress and depression and potentially changing the conditions under which our academic lives are lived. For Campbell (2018), autoethnography helps break the taboo and tell the secrets about mental decline and recovery journey, allowing readers to bear witness to the scholar’s bittersweet transition.

When I eventually walked into the doctor’s office, desperately unhappy, I barely knew who I was and what I was doing. My shoulders were permanently slumped. I did not care about my appearance. I felt numb [...] I want to read. I am busy, but I am well. The anxiety remained, and still remains to this day. It is always there, lurking in the background, waiting for the opportunity to knock me sideways. (excerpt from Campbell, 2018)

Jago (2002) highlights the transgressive and transformative power of autoethnography:

Passionately drawn to the rigorous, intellectual, and emotional work of autoethnography, I quickly found myself becoming an academic, a scholar by choice and not default. I felt creative for the first time in my life. (excerpt from Jago, 2002)

Moreover, both distance themselves from the commitment to deliver a conventional piece of writing that would respect the boundaries of publication style safeguarded by quantitative and qualitative ‘purists’. Rather, enacting autoethnography itself is a provocation and reinvention of science from the margins, as the method was inspired by queer theory in the first place (Adams et al., 2014; Jones et al., 2016).

I posit no cause-and-effect relationship here [...] I don’t know where all the pieces belong; I can only illustrate their puzzled coexistence [...] Together, these elements do not offer a unified whole, a coherent story. Rather, their explications, intersections, and contradictions present my experience in all its muddled complexity in an effort to communicate the lived experience of an academic depression and by doing so to encourage both the development of our understanding of depression and continued inquiry into the highly stressful academic culture in which we live and work. (excerpt from Jago, 2002)

Meanwhile, both are developing a conversation of hope, while encouraging readers to come join it and wishing that their stories ‘provide solace to others in similar position’ (Campbell, 2018, p. 241).

Being Naked Through Collective Biography

Based on our search, collective biography has been much less utilized than autoethnography, probably because the latter can be conducted alone. However, autoethnographers have started recognizing collaborative autoethnography (i.e. co-autoethnographic) accounts as a promising pathway to give rise to group-based agency and action (Ellis, 2016). Collective biography invites groups of scholars to gather together, read out loud one’s written (autoethnographic) memories/experiences on a jointly agreed theme and engage in reflexive discussions revolving around the memories/experiences with the aim of generating a re/co-construction of *us*. In collectively analysing and rewriting the memories, researchers can begin to expose ‘the effects of structural, systemic and affective processes on the emergence of particular subjects, such as the neoliberal subject’ (Hawkins et al., 2016, p. 165). Collective biography shares with autoethnography the intention to politically intervene in the world by moving memory workers and their readers ‘toward freedom in their political consciousness’ (Hawkins et al., 2016, p. 166).

For example, Kern et al. (2014) chose to actively recall, write about and reflect on joyful moments in teaching, publishing and collaborating, instead of the bountiful dispiriting experiences they could have written grim tales

about (Taylor et al., 2020). Many moments of joy were bound up with self-doubt and anxiety but were recalled as joyful as academic workers relived the moment where they recognized and embraced the potential for joy swirling around them and their peers or students.

I feel my stomach drop a little and my breathing quicken. They don't like the class. They don't like me. I bite my lip. [...] I look around the room then, at the students listening to Grace, looking to me, and I begin to tell them about my worries and frustration. They lean over the tables and Grace leans in and then we all begin to talk. [...] There is an energy and buzz in the room. [...] A smile creeps over my face as I skip; I'm lighter than I usually feel, almost floating down the stairs. My head feels full of new connections and I'm energized to continue the day and the week.... (excerpt from Kern et al., 2014)

Instead of staying numb or turning blind to the melancholia-(re)producing machinery of contemporary academia, opting for joy, they argue, is a small but potent world-remaking act when considered through a positive ontology 'where acts and practices continually generate subjects in an endless stream of possibilities' (Kern et al., 2014, p. 836). Throughout our (re)reading of Kern et al.'s (2014) work, we sense the scholars' genuine joy just by undertaking the joy retreat itself and their amplified sense of passion and love, while ruminating on each other's affective journeys. As opposed to reinforcing the neo-normative happy talks or success stories that make the institution look good, their *being naked together* provides us with a visceral force of hope and agency that joy is something that we can weave into our academic subjectivities as we 'become academic through joy' and inhabit it day-to-day as 'one element of a potential resistance strategy' (Kern et al., 2014, p. 846).

Being Naked Together: Towards Commoning

It is particularly worth underscoring the endeavours of a few privileged scholars, who strove, through their autoethnographic efforts, to understand their colleagues and students struggling at the precarious margins. For example, Tienari (2019, pp. 586–587) relies on his own experience of language-triggered ambivalence in identity work to gain a glimpse of 'what those who are truly marginalized and excluded experience in universities that are dominated by white men like me', hoping that 'my story helps others in privileged positions to think through what this can mean for them—and for those around them'. Such investments in affective learning illustrate the hope

for understanding differences without being/becoming different and experiencing others' pain without fully knowing it oneself, suggesting affective solidarity amidst differences may be possible.

Echoing Tienari's (2019) self-emancipation through attending to the struggling others, Opdycke (2023) highlights passionate disidentification—instead of identification—from neoliberalism's favoured categories, such as whiteness, as the liberating pathway to disrupt collective destinies. The act of disidentification unfetters the self from jumping the hoops of neoliberal design so as to stop repeating the loops of a white life pursuing individualistic perfectionism and incidentally elbowing out others whose embodied dispositions are more policed and less prized in a capitalist society.

As I spend more time in the spaces of academia, my relationship between multiple parts of my identity and the categories I identified with become even more unstable than before, increasing the chance of shattering. Disidentification helps me patch myself together. (excerpt from Opdycke, 2023)

Tienari (2019) and Opdycke (2023) exemplify that affectivity-based aesthetics of difference may help subvert neoliberalism-propagated individualism and pragmatism by promoting *us*-care instead of *self*-care and mutual salvation rather than self-preservation. They have both illustrated that commoning is not about (re)making the common in terms of belief, perspective, experience, or background. Rather, commoning is about *being naked together*—*speaking*, listening, learning, and acting together—regardless of and *thanks to* our differences in inexhaustibly different ways. Note that the opposite of commoning is not difference but isolation; the opposite of difference is not the common world but hegemony. These two scholars' works form an invitation to those who are less privileged/more precarious on the interweaving axes of domination to break silence and speak out and to those who are less precarious to stand in solidarity and use their privilege to question the status quo, thereby giving rise to the difference-based commoning that neoliberal hegemony imperils.

Discussion

This meta-ethnographic chapter is our attempt to create an archive of feelings—a record of what academic workers' bodies know (Cvetkovich, 2003)—to break silences and invite connection (Ashcraft, 2017; Gill, 2009). The sampled autoethnographies and collective biographies not only gave us access to methodologically hard-to-access affective experiences but also

worked to legitimate and dignify academics' lived experiences of weariness and brokenness as neoliberal values get institutionalized. In documenting various affective injuries (i.e. '*I am tired of performing*', '*I am not enough*', '*What I am doing is bullshit*', '*We are living different shades of privilege and precarity*'), we contribute to institutional scholarship on values and emotions by surfacing and illuminating the dark sides of the ostensibly legitimate process of rationalizing universities/organizations. We join efforts to attend to the hidden darkness of institutional processes (e.g. Hamann & Bertels, 2018; Khan et al., 2007) and encourage further attention to the 'dehumanizing tendencies of neoliberalism's imperatives' (Kern et al., 2014, p. 848).

Our review also highlights how affective injuries are more than a problematic by-product of the institutionalization of neoliberal values and an impediment to change but constitute a potential point of departure for emancipation and transformation (Pouthier & Sondak, 2021). Considered together, the four interrelated themes of affective resistance we surfaced foreground affective dynamics grounded in an ethics of vulnerability, interdependence and care that make possible a reimagination of human interaction and power relations (Kenny & Fotaki, 2015). We suggest that both pathologies of and cures for academic melancholia lie in the (re-)organization of intercorporeal relations. While neoliberalism-dictated human interactions are characterized by competition, managerialism, individualistic success and meritocratic hubris, *making space*, *making time*, *having fun* and *being naked* are all about returning to the sense of relationality and mutuality that humanity is fundamentally grounded in. They give rise to an *affective immunology* (we are indebted to Sloterdijk's writings for this concept) that not only shields the shared, extended self from the melancholia-(re)producing institutional zeitgeist of neoliberal universities but also constitutes a mundane yet not trivial, local yet transferrable form of affect-based activism (Adsit et al., 2015) that can disrupt the normalizing internalization of seductive yet injurious neoliberal values. Future efforts might be devoted to illustrating other subtle modalities and enabling conditions of *affective immunology*.

While 'detachment from others, ruthless calculation (e.g. what projects will bring the most return for my time and energy?), and forced periods of the so-called productivity [may often] seem like the better or at least necessary survival choices for' academic workers (Kern et al., 2014, p. 845), the modes of affective resistance the autoethnographic and biographic accounts spotlight remind us of the different choices we might make, including how we may choose to empower and move each other into a more life-affirming direction through small but potent careful and joyful acts. We are not contending that

academic workers could ever reach a state of complete freedom from neoliberal ideals but we believe that attending to our shared vulnerability to affective injuries and attuning to joy can help bring about a healthier and more just academia. In archiving both affective injuries and pathways to freedom, we hope to have elucidated the productive potential of melancholia as not only 'the hinge between systemic structures of exploitation and oppression and the felt experience of them' but, more importantly, a point of entry into an alternative academia (Cvetkovich, 2003, p. 12). We also hope that archives like ours 'continue to circulate until the power and pain embedded in their narratives are needed no more' (Mackenzie, 2022, p. 9).

Concluding Remarks

In archiving academic melancholia, we have also shown that many scholars, such as those we cited and quoted above, are acting on the neoliberal sources of affective injuries while striving to break free from the shackling fantasies, ethos and promises. We would not be surprised if their embodied accounts are criticized as narcissistic complaints since preventing contestations is part of neoliberalism's tricks for prosperity and longevity (Ashcraft, 2017; Gill, 2009). We believe that autoethnographers' and collective biographers' narratives are much less narcissistically complaining than sharing in a generous, generative way. Their precarities made published and public (by *being naked*) are much less individualized grievances than the beginnings for commoning, for a mutuality-based ethics of vulnerability and care (Ashcraft, 2018).

We certainly do not deny that there may be elements of defensive attribution underlying the self-narratives of autoethnographers and collective biographers when striving to make sense of their academic lives. However, as mentioned, their criticality vis-à-vis neoliberal values is very much founded on their criticality vis-à-vis the self, and their 'complaints' are very much generated from their concerns for those in more precarious/less privileged positions. Should not such criticality or so-called 'complaints' be precisely where the responsibility of an academic resides (Ashcraft, 2017)?

We are also aware of the possible suspicion vis-à-vis our enumerated ways of affective activism as nothing more than decaf, micro-resistance. We contend that this inconspicuous or ineffective appearance exactly constitutes the beauty of 'subtle activism' (Kjærgaard et al., 2023) or 'mundane politics' (Fernández et al., 2017), whereby academic workers understand and are able to mobilize political engagement for the long haul as necessary to make a difference from within. Rather than talking the sporadic, grandiose talk,

walking the consistent, different walk is what affective activists have shown us. Rather than shirking obligations with the excuse of ‘not everyone is a martyr’, perseveringly revolutionizing the quotidian while still putting food on the table is, at least to us, nothing but ‘real’ resistance.

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8

Intellectual Freedom and the Dissolution of Values in Academia

Anna M. Górska

Introduction

This chapter examines how the neoliberal restructuring of higher education institutions diminish the value of intellectual freedom, and how faculty experience these changes on an emotional and identity level. The aim is to study the institutional erosion of intellectual freedom and explore how it generates emotional dissonance, moral distress and ultimately, decisions to leave academia. Thus, the guiding question of this chapter is: *How does the erosion of intellectual freedom under neoliberal governance contribute to professional disillusionment and the voluntary exit of academics from the profession?*

Universities have long been honoured as spaces of creativity, dedicated to the production, conservation and dissemination of knowledge (Engwall et al., 2024). Historically, their mission has been grounded by core values of intellectual freedom, societal contribution and collegiality (Barnett, 2004; Boyer, 1990; Clark, 1989; Pollicino, 1996; Sawyer et al., 2009). These principles not only define the academic profession but also fuel the creative potential of institutions of higher education and are foundational to the legitimacy of the academic profession (Enslin & Hedge, 2021; Kuhn, 1962; March, 1991).

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Among these values, intellectual freedom has long been regarded as the bedrock of academia, ensuring that scholars can engage in independent thought, challenge dominant ideologies and conduct research without political or economic interference. However, this ideal increasingly diverges from reality, as universities become sites of contradiction, where institutional commitments to intellectual freedom coexist with the pressures of marketisation and bureaucratic control. Values have been considered crucial determinants of organisational behaviour that explained action within and outside of the organisation (Gehman et al., 2013), shaping cultures and professional identities while ideally reflecting the values of their members. However, in academia, there is a growing dissonance between (declared) institutional values and the lived experiences of faculty members. Rather than serving as a foundation of knowledge creation and intellectual freedom and reflecting the values of academics, the values are weakened, co-opted and reshaped by the new market demands.

Neoliberalism seems to disrupt this mission, reducing universities to market-driven entities focused on quantifiable outcomes and downgrading them from spaces of knowledge production into corporate-style 'edu-factories' (Feldman & Sandoval, 2018; Fleming, 2021; Gildersleeve, 2017). In the process, universities have not only been losing sight of their educational mission but have reconfigured academic labour in ways that devalue critical thought. As a result, I believe, intellectual freedom is diminished, as economic imperatives dictate what is and is not valued (Fleming, 2021). As neoliberal logics infiltrate academia, intellectual freedom ceases to be a sacred principle and becomes a contested domain subject to managerial oversight, funding imperatives and performance metrics (Gildersleeve, 2017; Henkel, 2002).

Academic work has been subordinated to performance metrics, standardisation and economic imperatives, producing a version of academia where intellectual autonomy is conditional on its financial utility. Research is no longer valued for its contributions to human knowledge but rather for researchers' capacity to secure external funding, generate institutional prestige, and meet bureaucratic compliance requirements. Neoliberalism reshapes academia into a landscape where metrics overshadow meaning (Fleming, 2021). Its permeation of academia is more than the bureaucratic mechanisms of New Public Management (NPM). It signifies a profound degradation of academic values (Enslin & Hedge, 2021; Sawyer et al., 2009). Metrics such as publication impact, grant acquisition, and student satisfaction scores have supplanted the intrinsic value of academic work and thus, I argue, that of intellectual freedom. These pressures are not just a matter of procedural

adjustments, they affect the ontological assumptions of academic work and what is seen as valuable.

Within this system, intellectual freedom is increasingly framed as an inefficiency, a risk, an impediment to institutional goals of marketability and productivity. Innovation and thinking differently, the foundations of intellectual freedom, become 'too risky', as they may not yield immediate, measurable results. Scholars who deviate from standardised norms face the prospect of precarity, exclusion, or even self-censorship, reinforcing a culture of conformity over critique (Park et al., 2023; Thompson, 1965). Creativity and values, once the cornerstone of academic freedom, are now subordinated to managerial priorities that equate difference with deficiency and dissent with noncompliance.

Neoliberal control mechanisms, such as marketisation, managerial oversight, and performative metrics, undermine the very values that once defined the academic profession. Academic freedom is curtailed, as faculty are discouraged from researching or teaching unconventional or politically sensitive topics, for fear it may not align with institutional benchmarks, funder priorities and students' values. Collegiality is fractured by competition for increasingly scarce resources, eroding trust and the collaborative ethos that fuels intellectual progress. Under these pressures, the ivory tower, long associated with ideals of intellectual autonomy, becomes a cage, a site of surveillance, conformity and control.

In this chapter, I examine the fate of intellectual freedom in the neoliberal university by drawing on institutional theory and values work (Askeland et al., 2020; Gehman et al., 2013; Wright et al., 2017). I argue that rather than being maintained, intellectual freedom is undergoing a process of institutional erosion. This erosion is not simply a consequence of neoliberalisation; it is an active and deliberate restructuring of academic values to align with economic logics. Intellectual freedom is not just being restricted; it is framed as an inefficiency, a risk, and as an impediment to the institutional goals of marketability, productivity and global competitiveness.

Drawing on 42 in-depth interviews with former academics, this study investigates the profound disillusionment experienced by people who were initially drawn to academia by its promise of intellectual freedom, creativity and societal contribution. Participants shared how these values that had inspired their careers, were systematically undermined by the neoliberal pressure of universities. Over time, the pursuit of knowledge gave way to the commodification of research, reducing creativity to metrics of market success. Teaching, once a mission-driven endeavour, became a transactional activity shaped by performative metrics and 'consumer'-driven demands. Collegiality,

the core of academic collaboration, collapsed under the weight of competition and institutional pressures. My analysis reveals that the devaluing of intellectual freedom compromised academics' sense of purpose and mission (Bishop, 2006), generating an emotional dissonance that culminated in burnout, alienation, and eventual departure from academia.

This chapter situates the experiences of former academics within broader theoretical debates on institutional values, emphasising the centrality of academic freedom, collaboration and sense of mission. It connects their disillusionment to systemic pressures that privilege conformity over creativity, showing how neoliberalism has created environments opposed to *thinking outside the box* (Lerch et al., 2024; March, 1991). I argue that neoliberal emphasis on metrics, competition and standardisation is opposing to nature's intellectual freedom. By centering the narratives of ex-academics, this study showcases the consequences of value erosion not only for faculty themselves but also for the broader ideals of universities.

Academic freedom is under threat both from neoliberal marketisation and increasingly direct political interference. When writing this chapter in March 2025, all eyes have turned to the second Trump administration. And for them academic freedom has yet another battle to fight (Faust, 2025). For the first time in modern democratic history, the United States is experiencing an unprecedented crackdown on scientific inquiry and intellectual discourse through state-imposed censorship (Greenfield, 2025). In the name of 'free speech' Trump aims to remove power from universities and eliminate what he calls 'woke ideology'. He does it through revoking their tax-exempt status, refusing to release billions of dollars in federal funds that have been allocated to them, or having the Department of Justice investigate schools that have DEI programmes or that allowed pro-Palestine protests (Briant, 2024; Feingold, 2025).

A recent policy issued by the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) mandates the retraction or revision of research manuscripts that contain what the government considers 'forbidden terms' related to gender, LGBTQ+ identities and reproductive health. This directive, which effectively imposes a state-sanctioned erasure of entire fields of research, exemplifies how academic freedom is being subjugated to ideological control. CDC researchers have been instructed to remove terms such as 'gender', 'transgender', 'pregnant person' and 'nonbinary' from all unpublished manuscripts. This policy applies to internal CDC publications and to any research under consideration in medical and scientific journals (Faust, 2025). This directive constitutes a dangerous escalation of political interference in science, effectively institutionalising 'preemptive obedience' (*vorausseilender Gehorsam*) or

complying in advance (Snyder, 2017), a term historically used to describe self-censorship under authoritarian regimes. Scientists are no longer merely pressured to align their research with economic interests and ideological control, they are now barred from engaging with entire domains of inquiry. Although this is beyond the scope of this chapter, this example illustrates that intellectual freedom is no longer being eroded solely by neoliberal logics but is now being dismantled through direct political intervention.

Theoretical Background: Values Work and Institutional Erosion

Neoliberalism has fundamentally reshaped higher education. By embedding market-driven principles such as privatisation, competition and efficiency into its core it has transformed the nature of academia and academic work. This transformation reflects the broader influence of neoliberal institutional logics, which prioritise economic rationality and instrumental efficiency over traditional academic values like intellectual freedom, collegiality and societal contribution (Billot, 2010; Fleming, 2021; Henkel, 2002). These changes extend beyond structural adjustments, redefining the roles, identities and behaviours of academics. Increasingly, academics are recast as *Homo oeconomicus*, efficiency-driven economic actors, rather than *Homo academicus*, scholars traditionally devoted to the pursuit of knowledge for societal enrichment (Bourdieu, 1984; Górska, 2024).

Institutional theory offers a critical framework to analyse these changes, emphasising how institutional logics influence organisational practices and individual actions (Friedland, 2017; Thornton & Ocasio, 2008). Institutional theory has long emphasised how values are central to the maintenance of professional identities and function as institutional anchors that define identity and organisational legitimacy (Scott, 1995; Thornton & Ocasio, 2008). However, values are not static; they are subject to contestation, reinterpretation and even decay (Gehman et al., 2013). In organisations, values work entails processes by which values are enacted, resisted and negotiated in response to shifting institutional logics (Askeland et al., 2020). While much of this literature explores how values are maintained, I am concerned with how they are dismantled through institutional processes that redefine them as obsolete, burdensome or even counterproductive.

The neoliberalisation of academia represents a paradigmatic case of values erosion, wherein fundamental academic values, such as intellectual freedom, scholarly autonomy and collegial governance, are reconfigured to align with economic imperatives (Fleming, 2021; Gehman et al., 2013). This

transformation reflects a deliberate process of institutional de-legitimation, wherein traditional academic values are reframed as inefficient, unsustainable or incompatible with market demands (Wright et al., 2017). Intellectual freedom, once an intrinsic good, is increasingly perceived as a 'luxury' rather than a core institutional mission.

The erosion of intellectual freedom in academia exemplifies how institutional logics restructure values to align with broader neoliberal priorities. This erosion is visible in three key mechanisms: performance metrics and bureaucratic oversight; precarisation and managerial control; and emotional and identity work.

Homogenising forces, particularly isomorphic pressures, compel universities to adopt neoliberal practices to maintain competitiveness in global education markets. This includes an emphasis on performance metrics, rankings and market positioning at the expense of intellectual inquiry and societal engagement (Lorenz, 2012; Morphew & Huisman, 2002). As universities embrace corporate management practices and NPM principles, they transition from being custodians of knowledge to becoming market-driven enterprises (Fleming, 2021; Martin-Sardesai et al., 2021; Thorpe, 2008).

Under this governance, intellectual work is increasingly evaluated through measurable outcomes such as citation counts, grant acquisition and student satisfaction scores rather than the quality or societal relevance of contributions, although even societal impact is now measured by the bureaucrats (Fleming, 2021; Lynch, 2006). As a result, intellectual freedom is at the mercy of key performance indicators which dictate research agendas and academic priorities (Gildersleeve, 2017; Martin-Sardesai et al., 2021).

The commodification of research, where 'where' knowledge is published takes precedence over 'what' it contributes, exemplifies this shift. This produces a prestige-driven rather than purpose-driven academic culture, where innovation and risk-taking are discouraged in favour of conformity to standardised outputs (Abbott, 2001; March, 1991; Sawyer et al., 2009). Any publication is better than no publication (Tourish, 2020).

Values, Emotions and Institutions: The Dismantling of Intellectual Freedom

The prioritisation of market-driven objectives under neoliberalism has challenged the traditional values of academia, creating deep tensions and emotional conflicts among academics (Creed et al., 2022; Fleming, 2021). Among these values, intellectual freedom, long regarded as a cornerstone of scholarly inquiry, has been systematically undermined, transforming it

from an institutional ideal into a precarious privilege subject to managerial discretion and market exigencies (Askeland et al., 2020; Gehman et al., 2013).

The concept of institutional maintenance work highlights how professionals uphold or contest the normative values of their profession (Wright et al., 2017). When these values come under threat, scholars experience not only organisational pressures but also profound emotional dissonance, as their professional identities become misaligned with institutional priorities (Górska, 2024). Misaligned institutional values generate emotional responses such as frustration, burnout and alienation. These responses reflect broader institutional failures, as academics struggle to reconcile their personal ideals with the quantifiable demands of neoliberal systems (Creed et al., 2022). The commodification of research and the 'student-as-customer' paradigm in teaching exacerbate these tensions, reducing intellectual pursuits to transactional interactions (Fleming, 2021).

Bureaucratic structures intended to ensure quality often have the unintended consequence of stifling intellectual risk-taking and research that challenges dominant paradigms (Lerch et al., 2024; March, 1991). The pressure to conform to established methodologies, prioritise 'fundable' projects, and publish in 'elite' journals discourages scholars from engaging in disruptive or controversial research (Tourish, 2020). This repressive environment fosters epistemic conservatism, where intellectual freedom is constrained by anticipatory obedience to neoliberal demands.

Values in academia are intertwined with emotions, shaping how academics perceive their work and purpose. Marini (2000) highlights values as 'emotion-laden conceptions of the desirable', underscoring their dual role in cognitive and affective domains. Institutional values, therefore, serve as guiding principles for organisational behaviour and individual decision-making. Yet, when values such as intellectual freedom are systematically devalued, they elicit powerful emotional reactions, particularly moral emotions that trigger resistance and institutional critique. Özbilgin and Erbil (2024) argue that reconciling these conflicting demands requires substantial emotional labour, leading to widespread faculty disillusionment and disengagement. This dissonance erodes trust between academics and institutional management, fostering climates of surveillance and mistrust (Enslin & Hedge, 2021). Neoliberal control mechanisms, such as marketisation, managerial oversight and performative metrics, have led to a systematic institutionalisation of silencing practices (Wright et al., 2017).

Thus, the dismantling of intellectual freedom is an active institutional endeavour, one that requires constant policing, regulation and the internalisation of neoliberal values among faculty. As universities become increasingly oriented towards managerialism, the erosion of intellectual freedom is framed not as a crisis but as a necessary and inevitable adaptation to external economic pressures and praised as ‘good management practice’ (Giroux, 2014).

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative methodology to explore the lived experiences of academics who voluntarily left tenured or tenure-track positions, focusing on the intersection of organisational pressures, personal experiences and values. The study was part of a larger project on the reasons, process and life after departing from academia, thus the results presented in this paper are limited to the values of intellectual freedom.

The qualitative approach is well-suited to unpacking the nuanced and deeply personal narratives of these individuals, particularly regarding how institutional and systemic pressures intersect with emotional and value-laden experiences. This study is grounded in an interpretivist paradigm, which is to emphasise participants’ subjective realities and lived experiences. This paradigm supports the study’s emphasis on understanding how individuals ‘make sense’ of departure from academia, prioritising their perspectives and meanings over ‘objective’ quantification (Creswell & Poth, 2018).

The methodological approach was based on a narrative inquiry. It was chosen because it provides a rich, holistic account of individuals’ lives, focusing on the stories they construct to make sense of their decisions and identities. This approach is particularly effective in exploring how participants negotiate their values and emotions in response to systemic pressures in academia. Interpretive grounded theory complements this by enabling the development of theoretical insights directly from the data, ensuring that the findings remain closely tied to participants’ lived realities.

Recruitment Process

Identifying former academics posed a unique challenge due to the absence of formal networks or centralised databases. To reach this dispersed and often hard-to-identify population, I used targeted calls on LinkedIn, X, and Facebook, appealing to groups like ‘The Professor Is Out’, ‘Academics Say

Goodbye’, and ‘Reviewer 2 Must Be Stopped’. These efforts were complemented by snowball sampling, whereby participants referred others who also met the study criteria.

Many respondents expressed strong emotional engagement in their initial replies, often sharing parts of their stories before the interview, which reflected the significance of the topic and its resonance with their lived experiences. This also indicated a sense of unresolved emotional tension tied to their departure from academia. Snowball sampling revealed relational networks among former academics and helped capture shared dynamics and patterns across cases.

Data Collection

Data were collected through in-depth, semi-structured interviews with 42 former academics who had voluntarily left tenured or tenure-track positions within the past 10 years. This time frame was chosen to ensure participants had sufficient distance from their academic careers to reflect meaningfully on their experiences while still having relatively fresh memories of the events. To enhance comparability, all participants were social scientists who had been faculty at a university in the United States. This disciplinary focus allowed for a more cohesive analysis of how specific institutional dynamics in this field shape academic identities and experiences, without the ‘noise’ of disciplinary or country-specific differences.

The participants varied significantly in terms of their academic tenure, career stage and institutional affiliation, providing a rich and nuanced understanding of the challenges faced across different contexts. At the time of their departure from academia, all participants held tenure-track or tenured positions. This criterion was deliberate, as such positions are a pivotal stage in academic careers, offering insights into how even those who had achieved substantial career milestones chose to leave the profession. There were 22 women, 19 men and 1 nonbinary person. Twenty-seven were white and 15 were nonwhite. They had been employed in academia from 5 to 23 years, with tenure-track or tenured roles spanning 1 to 18 years. Most participants were between their mid-30s and mid-50s; over half were married and had children. Participants worked at public and private research-intensive universities and teaching colleges.

All interviews were conducted via Microsoft Teams, Google Meet or Zoom, depending on the participant’s preferences. The semi-structured interviews lasted between 31 and 101 minutes, and each was transcribed verbatim. Transcripts ranged in length from 7261 to 13,610 words. Semi-structured

interviews were used to ensure consistency while allowing participants the freedom to articulate their experiences and reflections in their own way. Key topics of the interviews included motivations for entering academia, perceptions of institutional values, experiences of organisational pressures and the resulting emotional responses. Data analysis followed the principles of interpretive grounded theory, involving open, axial and selective coding. This iterative process ensured that emergent themes were closely tied to the data while allowing for the integration of theoretical insights.

In the initial stage, the data were coded into broad categories. The open codes were 'metrics-driven pressure' (the emphasis on quantifiable outputs such as citation counts and grant funding); 'erosion of collegiality' (the breakdown of collaborative academic relationships); 'emotional dissonance' (participants' feelings of frustration and alienation due to misaligned values). Axial coding involved identifying relationships among the open codes and organising them into categories. 'Metrics-driven pressure' and 'administrative burden' were grouped under the category of 'neoliberal institutional pressures'. 'Erosion of collegiality' and 'isolation in academia' were linked under 'breakdown of academic community'. Emotional codes such as 'burnout' and 'frustration' were tied to the theme of 'emotional responses to misalignment'. Finally, selective coding involved integrating the axial codes to develop core themes that reflected participants' narratives, such as 'the devaluation of academic values', 'the emotional toll of systemic misalignment' and 'the expectations and reality of academia'.

Ethical approval was obtained from the author's university prior to data collection, and all participants provided informed consent. Considering the sensitive nature of the topics discussed, care was taken to ensure that participants felt comfortable sharing their experiences. Two interviews had to be ended early because participants became so emotional while telling their stories.

Findings

The findings presented here offer a critical examination of the lived experiences of academics who chose to leave tenured or tenure-track positions. These narratives underscore the profound impact of neoliberal institutional pressures on personal and professional identities, highlighting a shared sense of disillusionment stemming from the erosion of values central to academic life. At the heart of this disillusionment is the dismantling of intellectual freedom, once perceived as the foundation of academic work, but now

increasingly viewed as an unattainable ideal under contemporary university governance.

The analysis is structured around the following interconnected themes: attraction to academia and its alignment with intrinsic values; the disruption of the value of intellectual freedom under neoliberalism; emotional responses to institutional dissonance; and the decision to leave academia as an act of personal and professional reconciliation.

Initial Attraction to Academia: Values-Driven Work, Curiosity, Freedom and Creativity

Participants' narratives reveal a shared idealised vision of academia as a place for intellectual and creative exploration. Intellectual freedom was central to this ideal; participants envisioned academia as a space where they could pursue knowledge without external interference, explore unconventional ideas and engage in meaningful debates without the constraints of market-driven priorities.

Academia felt like a place where I could truly think outside the box, explore new ideas, and contribute to something bigger than myself. It felt like freedom. (R2)

Many hoped for an academic life devoted to studying a subject they were passionate about, a chance to become deeply knowledgeable about and a chance to contribute meaningfully to their disciplines.

Academia fulfilled this dream of getting into the subject so deeply. (R2)

These narratives align with a broader cultural ideal of academia as a 'life of the mind', a place where one can indulge their intellectual pursuits. The creative allure of academia also rested on the opportunity to engage in curiosity-driven research that would inspire and improve their teaching. Many participants described their initial career goals as deeply intertwined with a desire to challenge the status quo:

I wanted to work on problems that no one else was working on, to teach students to think critically (...) and to leave it a little better through my work. (R24)

Intellectual freedom was also associated with a sense of professional autonomy, the ability to determine one's research agenda, engage in independent thought, and contribute knowledge to society. Yet, as participants later discovered, this autonomy was increasingly circumscribed by institutional mandates, managerial oversight and an ever-growing demand to meet funding priorities and performance metrics.

I mean you learn and teach for work, and you can help the students and see them grow. I had this mission in me (...) Also the idea of, uh, the idea of benefits and stability, security. I also thought that it would bring me more flexibility than a 9 to 5 job. (R11)

Many participants described the first months of their academic careers as a 'dream come true' (M40), a time of enthusiasm and hope. As one interviewee recalled:

And so it's sort of like a honeymoon period. (...) By the end of that year, I was like, oh my God (...) this is not what I signed up for. (R11)

This framing captures the early optimism that accompanied their transition into full-time academic roles. Yet, beneath this enthusiasm lay the seeds of a systemic disconnect. What participants perceived as an environment of open intellectual freedom was, in reality, a space increasingly governed by bureaucratic control, funding dependencies and rigid institutional hierarchies.

Importantly, this idealised vision of academia was not inherently flawed. Rather, it became a source of frustration and disillusionment as it collided with the pressures and constraints of a system driven by performance metrics, economic imperatives and competitive benchmarks, increasingly limiting their freedom and drawing boundaries.

However, as participants became immersed in the daily routines and demands of academic life, this idealistic vision began to fade. Intellectual freedom, which initially drew them to academia, was not only limited but often actively discouraged. Research was no longer driven by curiosity and intellectual engagement but by its potential to secure grants, achieve high citation scores and align with institutional priorities.

In the beginning we used to share ideas, support each other, soon I learned that after I got tenure that it is about who gets the funding, students and power. (R15)

The contrast between academia's traditional identity and its neoliberal reality revealed a system increasingly structured to prioritise conformity and quantification over intellectual exploration and societal engagement. Scholars who sought to challenge dominant paradigms (often developed by the senior faculty, the gatekeepers of academia) or engage in politically sensitive research found themselves facing institutional barriers, including limited funding opportunities, exclusion from key decision-making processes and heightened scrutiny from university administrators, as they who viewed their work as 'too risky' (R15).

Under neoliberalism, the intrinsic value of research has been overshadowed by an instrumental focus on funding and metrics. Participants described how this shift limited their ability to pursue unconventional or exploratory projects, as success was increasingly defined by external grants and high-impact publications:

Research became less about asking important questions and more about producing what would get funded or published in the right journals. (R29)
The focus on rankings and citations kills science. There's no room [for innovation]. (R13)

Within the interviews there was yet another troubling sign of interference with intellectual freedom. Some of the interviewees who left academia within the last two years commented on the 'research strategies' of their universities that were subject to increasing institutional control over academics' research agendas. In the pursuit of global rankings and differentiation, they developed research strategies that prioritised topics that they considered aligned with institutional branding efforts.

I remember I was asked by [head of department] if I could do something [research] about a new topic I had knew nothing about (...) it turned out that we had a new research vision and he [head of department] would report this kind of stuff. (R4)
Yes, we had a research strategy, but I never cared (...) maybe that's why they made my work miserable [laughter]. (R12)

This, yet is another sign of diminishing academic freedom, a guiding value for many who joined academia. With increased competition for resources and the rise of precarious employment, intellectual freedom became a privilege rather than a right. Those who resisted the move to performance-based evaluations faced professional marginalisation, exclusion from networks of

influence and an increasing sense that academia was no longer a viable space for critical scholarship.

The sense of community that fosters creativity is gone. It's every person for themselves now. (R10)

Emotional Responses to Misaligned Values

The misalignment between participants' aspirations and institutional realities of neoliberal academia evoked strong emotional reactions, including frustration, shame and alienation. Many described a growing sense of futility as they struggled to reconcile their values with the demands of neoliberal academia. The sense of betrayal was particularly acute for those who entered academia with the belief that it was a space for independent thought and intellectual risk-taking. Instead, they found themselves engaged in performative labour, tailoring their work to accommodate external pressures rather than intellectual conviction.

I felt like I was betraying my ideals. The system was so focused on numbers that there was no space for genuine academic work. (R9)

Burnout was a recurring theme, reflecting the cumulative effects of emotional dissonance and systemic pressures.

I was so tired—tired of the bureaucracy, tired of playing the game. It drained all the joy out of the job. (R41)

The metaphor of 'playing the game' captures the performative nature of neoliberal academic labour, where success is measured not by the substance of one's contributions but by the ability to navigate institutional systems and achieve predefined metrics. This performativity stripped participants of the intrinsic satisfaction derived from their work, compounding their emotional fatigue.

For many, the exhaustion was not merely physical but existential. The erosion of intellectual freedom meant that their academic work was no longer aligned with their personal identity, leaving them with a profound sense of loss and disorientation.

I had to leave, I lost a sense of who I am and why I do what I do. (R18)

For many, the decision to leave academia was a personal reckoning with identity and values. The sense of betrayal was a recurring theme, as participants reflected on how the reality of academia failed to live up to its promise. Rather than adapting to a system that rewarded conformity and penalized creativity, they chose to disengage, seeking spaces where their intellectual work could thrive outside the rigid structures of the neoliberal university.

I realised that staying in academia meant constantly compromising my intellectual freedom. I didn't want to do that anymore. (R35)

The interviews revealed that for many participants, the decision to leave academia was connected with the sense of a loss of purpose. The system's emphasis on conformity and quantification left participants feeling deceived, as though the ideals that drew them to academia were illusory. The emotional strain of this realisation, coupled with the systemic barriers to meaningful engagement, pushed many towards the decision to leave.

Although participants' decisions to leave academia were multifaceted, their narratives emphasise the centrality of emotional dissonance and misaligned values. The incompatibility between personal ideals (and beliefs prior to joining academia) and institutional demands created a sense of frustration, disillusionment, and emotional exhaustion. For many, the decision to leave was as much an act of self-preservation as it was a rejection of the 'modern' academic system. Ultimately, their departure was not merely a rejection of neoliberal governance but a reaffirmation of their commitment to intellectual autonomy and critical thought. The professional and existential costs of staying had simply become too high.

Though this chapter does not consider all the factors influencing their decisions, it is clear that the sense of betrayal and the erosion of values were important. The participants' struggle to reconcile their ideals with the institutional realities of academia took an emotional toll, ultimately driving them from a system that was incompatible with their sense of purpose, values and ideals.

Discussion

The findings presented in this chapter show the profound and systematic effects of neoliberalism on the emotional and value-laden dimensions of academic life. These deeply personal narratives are consistent with a growing body of literature that critiques the encroachment of market-driven logics into academia and its destructive impact on institutional values, academic

identities and emotional well-being (Enslin & Hedge, 2021; Fleming, 2021; Górka, 2024; Henkel, 2002; Özbilgin & Erbil, 2024). While much of the critique focuses on the commodification of knowledge and the rise of academic capitalism, this study centres the undermining of intellectual freedom as the key mechanism through which neoliberal governance reshapes academic work. Intellectual freedom is not merely limited; it is increasingly de-emphasised, reframed as inefficient and subordinated to managerial goals.

The participants' reflections reveal a blunt contrast between their initial idealised vision of academia and the neoliberalised reality they encountered (Sawyer et al., 2009). Intellectual freedom, once regarded as the defining feature of academic profession, was increasingly experienced as a precarious privilege, conditional upon alignment with institutional priorities rather than an inherent right of scholars (Gehman et al., 2013). The traditional values of intellectual freedom, creativity and societal contribution were systematically replaced by metric-driven priorities that emphasised economic efficiency and performative outputs. As neoliberal logics penetrate universities, they redefine what the university considers valuable (Anderson et al., 2002; Gumpert, 2000; Waugh, 2003). The findings of this study demonstrate this ontological transformation, as participants struggled with the dissonance between their intrinsic motivations and expectations and the extrinsic demands of neoliberal institutions.

The emotional toll of these systemic pressures is a heavy one. Participants frequently described feelings of frustration, alienation and shame as they attempted to 'reconcile' their personal values with institutional expectations (Enslin & Hedge, 2021). These emotions are not incidental; they are indicative of deeper institutional failures. Intellectual freedom is often discussed as an abstract principle, yet its erosion manifests through deeply personal and affective experiences. Participants' accounts illustrate that the institutional constraints on independent thought and critical inquiry were not merely bureaucratic burdens but existential crises—forcing them to question their purpose, integrity and professional identity.

The recurring metaphor of 'playing the game' captures the performative nature of academic labour under neoliberal constraints, where success is measured by conformity to institutional benchmarks rather than by meaningful intellectual contributions. Participants described an increasing sense of resignation, as their research agendas became shaped by what would be deemed 'fundable' rather than by genuine intellectual curiosity. This shift reflects the broader process of 'values work', where institutional actors actively reshape and reconfigure values to align with prevailing economic logics (Askeland et al., 2020; Gehman et al., 2013). In this case, intellectual freedom,

rather than being protected, was reconstructed as a liability, something to be controlled, monitored and ultimately subordinated to institutional interests.

One of the most striking findings was the recurring sense of betrayal expressed by participants. This betrayal was institutional, as participants confronted the gap between academia's promises and realities; and existential, as they grappled with the loss of their creative and intellectual autonomy. The idealised image of academia as a 'life of the mind' clashed with a reality shaped by conformity, competition and quantification (Biggs, 2002). Academics who once believed in the transformative potential of knowledge found themselves in institutions that valued compliance over critical thought, efficiency over depth and short-term productivity over long-term intellectual contributions (Askeland et al., 2020).

This disconnection between expectations and reality resonates with ongoing critique of the erosion of academic autonomy under neoliberal governance (Anderson et al., 2002; Barnett, 2004; Bessant, 1995; Biggs, 2002; Enslin & Hedge, 2021; Gumport, 2000; Marginson & Considine, 2000; McNay, 1996; Sawyer et al., 2009; Waugh, 2003). Yet, despite decades of critique, the pace of neoliberal reforms has only accelerated. Intellectual freedom, rather than being reclaimed, is increasingly framed as outdated, incompatible with the demands of the modern university and its 'research strategy'. The institutionalisation of market logics, tied to performative pressures, undermines the values that draw individuals to academic careers, leaving them questioning the very essence of their professional identities.

The participants' decisions to leave academia were often framed as acts of 'self-preservation', reflecting an inability to reconcile their ideals with the systemic demands. Their departures, however, should not be viewed as individual failings but rather as indicative of broader structural tensions within the academic system, where institutional norms marginalise non-conforming scholarly identities. As institutions prioritise managerial control over intellectual autonomy, they create environments that drive away scholars whose work does not align with institutional imperatives (Wright et al., 2017).

Societal and Practical Implications: Towards a Reclamation of Academic Values

The findings and their analysis illustrate the ongoing need to reconsider the priorities of institutions of higher education. If universities are to function as spaces for critical inquiry and knowledge production, the erosion of

intellectual freedom must be actively contested. This requires both institutional reforms and collective resistance to the logics that seek to commodify knowledge and subordinate academic work to market rationalities.

At an institutional level, there is a need to reassess what universities value and prioritise. The current emphasis on quantifiable outputs, such as publication rankings, grant acquisition and student satisfaction scores, has weakened the broader mission of universities. Institutions must adopt governance models that balance accountability with intellectual freedom, enabling academics to conduct innovative and meaningful research without the fear of reprisals for not meeting performance metrics. Instead of privileging rigid hierarchies of knowledge production, institutions could benefit from recognising that meaningful intellectual advancement often requires space for failure, exploration and risk-taking, dimensions not easily captured by current performance indicators.

By prioritising market objectives, universities risk losing their legitimacy as spaces for advancing societal knowledge and addressing social challenges. A return to this public mission is necessary to rebuild trust and align institutional goals with societal needs. Faculty, policymakers and academic communities must collectively advocate for institutional structures that protect intellectual freedom, resisting the pressures that seek to reduce universities to extensions of corporate and political agendas.

Moreover, there is a need to protect and support academics' psychological well-being. The emotional toll of navigating a system out of sync with personal and professional values has profound implications for the well-being and retention of academics. As this chapter demonstrates, emotional dissonance and burnout are significant factors that drive individuals to leave academia. Institutions must adopt policies that prioritise faculty's mental health and well-being.

It seems that the neoliberalisation of academia is shattering the societal contract of universities as institutions of public good, and we, as academics, need to reclaim universities' core mission and ideals. Without the reimagining of academia, the erosion of values will continue to alienate faculty, diminish the quality of academic work and undermine the social mission of universities. Although this debate has persisted for decades, university leadership often appears disengaged from its implications, continuing to prioritise market principles, metrics and performative governance. This shift risks turning universities into production units, academics into output-driven workers and students into consumers, at the expense of the educational and societal mission of higher education.

Yet, history has shown that values are contested, negotiated and sometimes reclaimed. If intellectual freedom is to survive, it will not be because institutions choose to protect it, but because academics, students and society demand it.

Conclusion

This chapter began with a simple yet unsettling question: What happens to academic life when the value of intellectual freedom is dismantled? Through the narratives of faculty who left tenured or tenure-track roles in U.S. universities, I argue that their exits were not impulsive but reflective acts of resistance, rejections of systems that compromised their identities, values and integrity.

What emerges from their accounts is a sense of betrayal, not just by institutions, but by an ideal of academia that promised purpose, autonomy and critical engagement. Instead, they encountered performance metrics and compliance cultures that marginalised intellectual freedom in the name of conformity. Their emotional responses, such as burnout, were not individual pathologies but a reaction to a profession that undermined its very purpose.

Thus, I believe their decision to leave, was an act of value reclamation, a rebellion against the system. This conclusion shows that intellectual freedom cannot survive passively; it is under attack by anti-values of efficiency, competitiveness and marketisation.

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9

Cycles of Passivity: How Mainstreamers Unwittingly Enable Erosion of Democracy

Namrata Malhotra and Maxim Voronov

What should a democracy do, when the majority of its people no longer wants it? (Haffner, 1989: 185)

Introduction

Social scientists and public intellectuals have widely documented how populist leaders and reactionary groups actively undermine democratic institutions. We are seeing the dismantling of the public sector, increases in election fraud and voter suppression, as well as delegitimizing of the media, in many democratic countries around the world. While political science has illuminated the strategic mechanics of this authoritarian encroachment (e.g., Eatwell & Goodwin, 2018; Hetherington & Weiler, 2009; Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018), institutional scholars have highlighted the underlying insidious processes of “institutional drift” (Mahoney & Thelen, 2009; Voronov

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et al., 2022)—through non-strategic, incremental changes in everyday practice that gradually decouple institutions from their founding ideals. Yet, with the rise of far-right populism across Europe, the Brexit debacle, civil society's tepid response to an emboldened Trump, and the right-wing, anti-public health insurgency during (and since) the pandemic, we are witnessing an escalation of institutional drift toward institutional erosion. Together, these movements undermine core democratic norms and weaken institutional commitments to collective welfare, equality, and truth.

German historian Sebastian Haffner's quote in the epigraph, reflecting on the rise of the Nazis in 1933, highlights the capitulation and indifference toward democracy from elected officials and mainstreamers.¹ But we are haunted by the fear that it may also encapsulate the present moment in the United States and elsewhere—with a twist. It is not that the mainstreamers have lost interest in democracy, but we often lack the courage, the conviction, and the skills to fight for it. Specifically, in this chapter, we argue that growing asymmetry in emotional expressiveness between mainstreamers, generally aligned with democratic principles, and the reactionaries who threaten them, escalates institutional erosion. While scholars and public intellectuals often attribute institutional decay to reactionary forces, our aim here is to shine a light on the complicity of mainstreamers. We elaborate key mechanisms that trap mainstreamers in cycles of passivity even as democratic institutions come under threat.

Our recognition of this dynamic crystallized during the Covid-19 pandemic. Even as a vocal reactionary minority in democracies like the United States, UK, and Canada actively sought to sabotage public health measures, the majority—who favored stronger interventions—stood by passively (Liao, 2022). Similar patterns emerged around the normalization of the “big lie” in the US electoral system, whereby Donald Trump and his supporters falsely claimed that the 2020 election was stolen from him, persistent inaction on climate change and social justice, and (currently) surprisingly mild resistance, as Trump is dismantling various institutions at home and abroad (Rintamäki et al., 2025).

¹ We recognize that the distinction between those who are in the fringe and those in the mainstream is notoriously slippery, as some views shift from the fringe to the mainstream and the other way around. Yet, most surveys show that more reactionary views (e.g., regarding male dominance, white supremacy, support for authoritarianism, etc.) range from minority to fringe views in Western democracies—hence, not socially acceptable and not mainstream. We use the term “mainstreamer” as a short-hand term to refer to the more “average” persons in a society, who neither adopt a strong ideology nor concur with reactionary views.

These cases exposed a troubling asymmetry in emotional engagement: while reactionaries mobilized through anger, defiance, and outrage, mainstreamers remained muted—tolerating violations, denying their severity, and adhering to norms of civility that inadvertently normalized democratic backsliding.

Both political scientists and the general public tend to characterize societies as democratic or not “on the basis of the way legislatures are selected, governments are appointed, and the extent of political rights enjoyed by the general population” (Beckman, 2021). In other words, the focus tends to be on formal mechanisms and institutional arrangements. However, the rise of populism and the resurgence of authoritarianism in many democracies has seen a surge in politicians and movements using the notion of “democracy” as a legitimizing rhetoric to justify whatever ends they seek to pursue, while delegitimizing opposition (Peters & Pierre, 2022). Thus, we think it is best to conceptualize democracy not simply as a set of formal institutional arrangements, but as an ethos—a collectively held ideal animated through emotionally invested social practices. As an ethos, democracy depends not only on mechanistic procedural compliance, but on public attachment to values of inclusion, justice, and equality (Beckman, 2021; Post, 2006). These emotionally charged ideals are at risk of being hollowed out as innocuous deviations become more strategic and intentional. Drawing on institutional theory, we argue that mainstreamers’ cycles of passivity—tolerance, denial, and adherence—restrain emotional expressiveness and leave democracy vulnerable to strategic ethos violations by reactionary groups.

In what follows, we develop a framework for understanding how emotional asymmetries contribute to institutional erosion, and we argue that recalibrating emotional expressiveness among mainstreamers is needed to help reinvigorate the democratic ethos.

The Role of Emotions in Institutional Processes

We use a conceptualization of emotion that is more ontologically compatible with institutional theory (Voronov, 2014). This requires moving away from the modal approach of psychological research on emotion that has typically given primacy to biology and bounded individualism. Instead, we adopt a sociological lens, which conceptualizes emotions as socially embedded and socially embedding (Zhang et al., 2024). Thus, we draw on Turner and Stets’ (2005) recognition that “emotions are socially constructed in the sense that

what people feel is conditioned by socialization into culture and by participation in social structures. Cultural ideologies, beliefs, and norms as they impinge on social structures define what emotions are to be experienced and how these culturally defined emotions are to be expressed” (p. 2).

The role of emotions is being increasingly incorporated to understand institutional processes, underpinning the constitution, maintenance, or disruption of institutions (Lok et al., 2017; Zietsma et al., 2019), to balance a cognitive bias in neo-institutional research. Invoking emotions has offered a lens to conceptualize how people experience institutions meaningfully and link to their sense of self rather than something “out there” (Creed et al., 2014). Emotions shift the experience of institutions from mere compliance to caring for and desiring key institutional ideals that encapsulate an institution’s ethos (Voronov & Weber, 2016). Feeling, along with thinking, enables people to become invested in and develop an attachment to institutional orders. From this, it follows that any violation of institutional ideals that people strongly feel about would trigger an emotive reaction.

Social emotions, more resonant with institutional processes, “occur within particular interactions and are both an outcome of and inherent to the process of negotiating and settling on an institutional order” (Voronov, 2014: 6). Through the mobilization of social emotions, social practices can morph into novel institutional arrangements (Farny et al., 2019). Notably, the role of social emotions has been theorized to highlight mostly its “constructive” impact for the creation and preservation of institutions or a negotiated settlement. Studies have shown how the expression of collective emotions through tangible activities such as demonstrations can create empathy but also solidarity against injustice or help overcome fear of a repressive power regime (Callahan & Elliott, 2020; Marsh & Śliwa, 2022).

In this chapter we extend arguments beyond non-strategic institutional change (Voronov et al., 2022; Mahoney & Thelen, 2009; Ritwick, 2025), which allows fundamental ideals to stay intact, to strategic, deliberate violations of institutional ethos that result in not mere institutional drift but institutional erosion—a darker and more consequential dynamic that has received insufficient attention. The role of emotions, we argue, is crucial to our understanding of how this happens (Voronov et al., 2022). We first elaborate the notion of democracy as an ethos, which encapsulates core values that animate the social dynamics by which institutions are either reinforced or allowed to erode.

Democracy as an Ethos

Democracy is best understood not as a permanent characteristic of institutions but as an ethos—a set of ideals and moral commitments to equality, inclusion, and justice. These values become real only through institutions and their practices. The term “ethos” refers to the “the tone, character, and quality of a people’s life, its moral and aesthetic style and mood; it is the underlying attitude toward themselves and their world that life reflects” (Geertz, 1957: 421). The concept connects institutional theory with pragmatic phenomenology (Patriotta, 2020). It acts as an “idealized representation of what it means to be a participant in a particular institutional order, and it prescribes particular kinds of aspirations, ideals, values, and moral judgments” (Voronov & Weber, 2016: 461). In essence, institutional ethos is a sacred (Durkheim, 1965 [1915]), shared fantasy which makes the mundane local interactions meaningful, fulfilling, and mostly fluid. For example, “care and respect for patients” (de Rond & Lok, 2016: 1979) is core part of the ethos of the medical profession, while “I theorize therefore I am” is a core ideal of the ethos of management academia (Bothello & Roulet, 2019). So, rather than some reified concept, “democracy” is ethos, or foundational ideal, for the societies that aspire to be democratic.

Ethos has a quasi-religious nature as people align their sense of self with important institutions in their lives. It acknowledges that people are motivated not only by rewards and punishments, but also by the desire to belong and practice their cherished values (Chan & Hedden, 2023; DiBenigno, 2022; Schabram & Maitlis, 2017; Wright et al., 2017). This shared commitment to institutional ethos is the basis of social solidarity (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024), which in turn, motivates institutional order inhabitants to keep their social interactions fluid and smooth and to try to render any deviations invisible, or at least, non-disruptive. The main implication, for our purposes, is that shared truth and commitment to making institutions function effectively is only possible to the extent that people are invested in a shared ethos (Weiss et al., 2024; Xu, 2013). There is some recognition in the literature that societies may fracture, to an extent, as groups become invested in rival ethos. This is implicit in George Lakoff’s identification of two rival root metaphors—“nurturing parent” and “strict father” (Lakoff, 2010)—that organize the worldviews of liberals and conservatives, respectively. A similar idea is proposed by Hetherington and Weiler (2009), who suggest that conservatives and liberals have coherent yet very different worldviews.

From this point of view, institutional arrangements are not an end in themselves but are inevitably imperfect operationalizations or concretizations

of institutional ethos (Voronov & Weber, 2020). These imperfect operationalizations open up the possibility of multiple interpretations, as well as slippages, misunderstandings (Steele, 2021), and even willful distortion. Contests across rival ethos are underpinned by strong emotions, and while treating them as “rational debate” and seeking out additional facts is valuable, it is insufficient to bring people’s worldviews into alignment (Kleinfeld, 2023). Yet many commentators and policymakers keep seeing the problem as one that can be resolved by providing the opposing side with more facts and more evidence. Polarization and contestation over values are no doubt normal and even healthy when both sides are willing and open to listen to opposing views and engage in healthy debate. When that does not occur contestation can be counter-productive increasing the likelihood of institutional drift which is a decoupling of institutions from their founding democratic ethos (Voronov et al., 2022). Institutional drift if left to escalate culminates in erosion of institutions that defend the democratic ethos.

Institutional Drift and Institutional Erosion

Institutional drift occurs through people’s unintended practice deviation in the routine performance of their institutional roles. Put another way, unintentional deviations in the course of mundane interpersonal interactions, lead to non-strategic institutional change.

Voronov et al. (2022) noted that “deviations from the institutional order are judged tolerable when interactants render them allowable” (p. 820). Other interactants tolerate deviations because ensuring smooth social interactions, reciprocity, and preserving face require ongoing collective effort (Goffman, 1959). In other words, they allow the deviations to be re-integrated into the ongoing flow of social interactions (Lok & de Rond, 2013; Yamauchi & Hiramoto, 2020). Further, studies suggest that sanctioning a person for deviant behavior sometimes risks aggravating a situation, and threatening more institutional instability (Creed et al., 2014; Voronov et al., 2022). Note that such unintended (and overlooked) deviations leave fundamental sacred ideals or the institutional ethos, underpinning an institutional order, intact. As Voronov et al. (2022) put it, “institutional drift occurs, in large part, due to people’s attachment to the abstract and unfalsifiable ethos, or ideals that are only loosely materialized in day-to-day practice, enabling potentially significant transformation of practices without altering these underlying ideals” (p. 820). In the past decades, the rise of reactionary groups has also seen a rise

in deviations from the routine and largely civil interactions in various institutional spheres (e.g., a congressman screaming “you lie” during one of Barack Obama’s State of the Union addresses comes to mind as an iconic display). These are not unintentional or non-strategic deviations that can readily be re-absorbed into a flow of social interactions but conscious and deliberate violations of sacred ideals underlying the prevailing democratic institutional order. We contend that what we are witnessing is institutional erosion—not just innocuous deviations, but intolerable *strategic* transgressions that—when normalized—threaten foundational democratic ideals.

Existing research suggests that people emotionally vested in institutions would go above and beyond to preserve them (Scott, 2008). Yet, mainstreamers have responded far more passively than expected in the face of intolerable ethos-eroding violations. Rather than engaging in active resistance, their response has remained muted, if not silent, in spite of reactionaries’ calculated attack on democratic ethos.

To unravel this puzzle, we examine the mechanisms that facilitate institutional erosion and who is involved. We highlight three mechanisms—each set in motion by mainstreamers—that inadvertently assist and embolden reactionaries in their efforts to undermine democratic ethos. First, mainstreamers initially tend to exhibit tolerance toward what they perceive as deviations from taken for granted norms and practices. Second, as reactionaries intensify their attacks on foundational ideals, tolerance gradually gives way to denial—a refusal or inability to recognize the seriousness of the threat. This shift from tolerance to denial is reflected in a form of passive emotional expressiveness. Third, mainstreamers typically respond to the undemocratic actions of reactionaries with muted emotional reactions, adhering to institutional norms of civility. This adherence, combined with tolerance and denial, results in a passive emotional stance that stands in stark contrast to the reactionaries’ escalating emotional intensity and incendiary rhetoric.

Over time, mainstreamers become trapped in a self-reinforcing *cycle of passivity*—a vicious cycle of tolerance, denial, and adherence, which reinforces passive emotional expressiveness. Meanwhile, reactionaries continue to amplify their emotional expressiveness, coupling it with increasingly inflammatory language. These parallel but opposing emotional trajectories deepen the asymmetry between mainstreamers and reactionaries—an asymmetry that reactionaries exploit to further violate democratic ideals, accelerating institutional erosion. We elaborate below the three mechanisms underlying mainstreamers’ complicity and how these culminate in a cycle of passivity with serious consequences of allowing reactionaries to continue their ethos-eroding efforts.

Becoming Complicit—How Mainstreamers (Non)Respond

Tolerance. Tolerance on the part of interactants is central to the notion of institutional drift (Rintamäki et al., 2025). In many ways it humanizes the conduct of institutional roles by accommodating slippages in social interactions which may involve faux pas or even jarring verbal and non-verbal behaviors deviating from what is considered “normal” (Steele, 2021). Voronov et al. (2022) noted that tolerance of deviations, by interactants, can transform the defining practices of an institutional order but without altering its underlying institutional ethos. Yet, there is a caveat—where is the line between tolerable deviation and outright violation? Put another way, when does a deviation become a violation that goes beyond subtly transforming institutional practices to threatening core ethos? For instance, the right to free speech—legally protected and free from the threat of state retaliation—is critical for a healthy democracy (Shattuck & Mathias, 2021).

During his first presidential campaign, Trump’s rhetoric on “fake news” was tolerated by the mainstreamers as somewhat routine political maneuvering used to fend off unfavorable coverage or control the narrative. It was perceived as yet another of his personal quirks and political theatrics. However, this seemingly “minor deviation” escalated very quickly to become a direct challenge to democratic ideals when he resorted to extreme language to brand the press as the “enemy of the people” (Kalb, 2018). Delegitimation of the role of press was a violation, not just a deviation, of democratic ethos that is upheld in important ways by a free and independent press. Still, instead of explicitly condemning his aggressive rhetoric with equal intensity the mainstreamers restrained emotional expressiveness. The news organizations themselves acted dysfunctionally in their roles as guardians (Rintamäki et al., 2025) by largely failing to hold him to account, and continuing to treat those outbursts as a legitimate “one side” of a story. The restraint was also conspicuous in the recent election campaign, when Trump’s continuing outrageous words and actions were portrayed as “normal.”

In a similar vein, during the UK’s Brexit campaign, the Remain side focused heavily on factual arguments related to the economy and trade. They kept their emotional appeals relatively muted, relying instead on rational justification for staying in the EU. In contrast, the Leave campaign grew increasingly uninhibited. One of the major Eurosceptic parties in Britain released a provocative poster showing a line of refugees from the Middle East, accompanied by the slogan “Breaking Point” displayed in red. A jarring visual playing up “fear of immigration,” was a violation of key democratic

ideals of equality and plurality even likened to Nazi propaganda (Reid, 2019). Tempered emotional expression is consistent with “ignorable and tolerable” deviations (Voronov et al., 2022, p. 828) but ineffective in stemming conscious and strategic violation of norms that obviously cross the threshold of tolerance.

We saw similar patterns during the COVID-19 pandemic, as reactionaries weaponized individual rights rhetoric to undermine civic responsibilities for public health. Anti-mask and anti-vaccine protests, framed around slogans like “my body, my choice” or “I have rights,” prioritized individual freedom over collective welfare (Liao, 2022). Mask wearers often endured hostility, while media and pundits urged sensitivity toward the reactionaries. This muted mainstream response inadvertently amplified reactionary narratives, pressuring governments and health agencies to shift from “we are all in this together” to “assess your own risk.” The revised messaging spread to workplaces, even as independent experts warned of ongoing viral threats. Institutions charged with public safety adapted to reactionary demands, recasting health “protections” as “restrictions.”

Through the above examples, we argue that normalizing such deviations—once they cross into violations of core institutional ideals—accelerates institutional erosion. We have seen other examples of normalizing deviations with drastic consequences. The Challenger disaster (Vaughan, 1996) and recent catastrophic failures at Boeing (Monteiro, 2024) illustrate that tolerating minor lapses or “deviations” in safety protocols to continue unchallenged and become normalized over time paid a price in human lives. Normalization in the context of institutional drift is likely to restore fluidity in social interactions but the price of the sort of normalization we are seeing is the “hollowing out” of our institutions. Yet, we see mainstreamers in corporate, political, and other domains choose tolerance and look the other way while reactionaries get louder and more aggressive. Tolerance fosters passivity among mainstreamers which gets reinforced as they tend to slip into denial.

Denial. Denial is defined as “A statement about the world or the self (or about your knowledge of the world or yourself) which is neither literally true nor a lie intended to deceive others but allows for the strange possibility of simultaneously knowing and not knowing. The existence of what is denied must be “‘somehow’ known and statements expressing this denial must be ‘somehow’ believed in” (Cohen, 2001: 24). Whether deliberate or (typically) unconscious, denial is a means to sidestep uncomfortable truths while preserving an illusion of normality (Zerubavel, 2006).

Denial may appear counterintuitive, as it involves mainstreamers actively refraining from defending deeply held values (Cooper & Voronov, 2024),

even when those values are under direct challenge from reactionaries. We have observed mainstreamers dismiss such violations—whether anti-public health riots and disruptions or election denialism—as temporary aberrations that “will go away,” rather than recognizing the existential threats they represent. Through denial, we confront anxiety, fear, and discomfort triggered by reactionaries’ undemocratic actions (Turner & Stets, 2005). Yet, critically, denial disconnects mainstreamers from the very emotions that shape their experience of institutions as meaningful, connected to a sense of self and something they care about. It may serve an important short-term function in helping people cope with personally threatening and damaging experiences (Rauch & Ansari, 2025). But, denial is not merely avoidance—it is the antithesis of actively preserving institutional ideals encapsulated in institutional ethos (Cooper & Voronov, 2024).

Fundamentally, denial is a collective accomplishment. It may be rooted partly in arrogant belief that institutions are durable and unshakeable. But this arrogance may push mainstreamers to dismiss reactionaries’ rhetoric as just noise that would not destabilize what is enduring. Yet this false sense of security is dangerous. While being emotionally vested could make individuals unable to recognize when the institutions are falling short in preserving their wellbeing (Malhotra et al., 2021; Voronov & Yorks, 2015), it could also cause them to underestimate the threats to the institutions they deeply care about. For instance, when reports surfaced about efforts to overturn democratic processes in the United States or the rise of far-right movements across Europe, many public figures and elected officials downplayed these issues as outliers or dismissed them as “political theater.” Put another way, through a false sense of security and stability, denial has a far reaching, often damaging, effect of cueing society to view reactionary actions as “one-offs” or “harmless.” As mainstreamers shift from tolerance to denial, it engenders increased passivity while reactionaries are emboldened without fear of repercussions to continue on the ethos-eroding path.

Adherence. Both tolerance and denial from mainstreamers manifest as restrained or passive emotional expressiveness, reinforced by their need to adhere to institutional norms of civility. Their emotional reactions to reactionaries’ violations tend to be understated, driven by a fear of being judged as “overreacting” which contradicts social expectations. Prior research highlights that durability of institutions requires ongoing emotional maintenance. As Delmestri and Goodrick (2016: 263) observed, “emotions are needed to sustain institutional orders either because they regularize deviants or because they reassure mainstream conformists”. Deeply felt emotions, like fear and shame, facilitate compliance (Creed et al., 2014; Gill & Burrow, 2018),

and emotionally laden rituals facilitate collective work needed to keep institutional arrangements intact (Dacin et al., 2010). Emotional maintenance, therefore, goes hand in glove with emotional expressiveness in *standing up* for the institutions at risk. Ironically, mainstreamers often hesitate to express strong emotions in defense of democratic norms they deeply care about, for fear of sounding alarmist and invoking public criticism. In an analysis of the Brexit campaign, Moss et al., (2020: 840) noted that “prominent Remainers reinforced the idea that they were less comfortable with or practiced at emotional politics, warning of the consequences ‘If emotion trumps over reality.’”

Mainstreamers face a paradox: they must uphold and advocate for norms of emotional restraint while simultaneously conforming to them. Reactionaries, by contrast, are unburdened by this dilemma. Mainstreamers typically maintain a “rational,” understated tone, even in moments that demand urgency. Yet, this commitment to civility grants reactionaries a strategic advantage, allowing them to wield emotional intensity and incendiary rhetoric with little resistance. For example, the January 6th Capitol attack—an overt assault on democratic norms—was reframed by many political figures as merely a protest that “went too far.” This kind of minimization signaled to mainstreamers to “move on” or “avoid hyperbole,” reinforcing societal denial, dampening emotional responses, and normalizing an unprecedented breach. Meanwhile, Trump and his allies continued to exploit inflammatory language to stoke fear, identity threats, and a sense of crisis, portraying democratic institutions as sources of instability. While mainstreamers remain committed to moderation and reasoned debate, even when engaging undemocratic views, reactionaries openly defy these norms—using anger and insult to present themselves as “authentic,” in contrast to what they depict as the contrived civility of their mainstream counterparts.

When mainstreamers, as defenders of an institutional order, slip into emotional passivity, they inadvertently embolden reactionaries to escalate their emotional expressiveness to further undermine democratic ethos. Additionally, emotional restraint risks alienating bystanders or sceptics who could otherwise be mobilized by expressed emotions of pride and honor (Jasper & Poulsen, 1995). Acting “normally” in the face of unprecedented threats to deeply held values—whether from climate change triggered natural disasters or from unprecedented attacks against the rule of law—further reinforces collective denial by signaling that things are normal and tolerable.

In sum, the emotional passivity generated by tolerance and denial is further reinforced by mainstreamers’ adherence to institutional norms of tempered emotional display. The asymmetry in emotional expressiveness this

creates, only strengthens reactionaries, who continue to employ disproportionate levels of emotional intensity in shaping public discourse. In doing so, they fuel the process of institutional erosion. We depict the Framework of asymmetry in emotional expressiveness and eroding democratic ethos in Fig. 9.1.

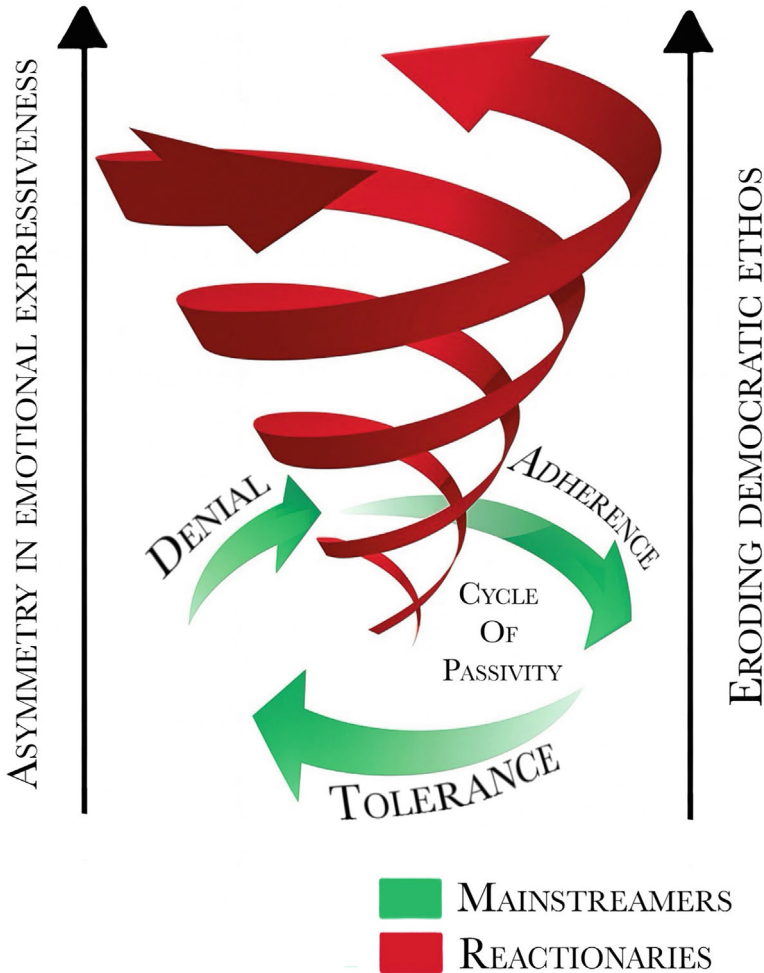


Fig. 9.1 Framework of asymmetry in emotional expressiveness and eroding democratic ethos

Cycles of Passivity, Asymmetry in Emotional Expressiveness and Eroding Institutional Ethos

A vicious cycle of tolerance, denial, and adherence traps mainstreamers in a state of emotional passivity. Remaining in this cycle only deepens feelings of helplessness and resignation—apart from behind-the-scenes venting or preaching to the choir about the outrageousness of reactionaries' behavior. We have observed this cycle not only in political contexts—such as the aftermath of recent U.S. elections and Brexit—but also in response to evolving social challenges. For example, the fervor of mainstream voices in support of climate action has become noticeably subdued, as has their active participation in environmental movements. Part of this retreat stems from the overwhelming magnitude of the issue, which leads many mainstreamers to see their individual efforts as inconsequential.

Yet no similar sense of futility has stopped anti-climate-change reactionaries from amplifying their voices. As a result, the emotional asymmetry has widened: mainstreamers recede into passivity while reactionaries dominate the airwaves with increasingly intense displays of emotion. Whether in politics or other societal arenas, the absence of active resistance enables reactionaries to channel anger, outrage, and defiance—emotions that are particularly effective in undermining democratic norms (Moss et al., 2020). Rather than responding with passion, mainstreamers grow even more disengaged. The deeper they fall into cycles of passivity, the harder it becomes to re-enter the discourse, reassert democratic values, and halt institutional drift (Wissman et al., 2024).

This asymmetry is exacerbated when mainstreamers—while remaining emotionally detached—respond with purely cognitive strategies, such as pointing out the moral inappropriateness of reactionary rhetoric or dismissing it with elitist labels. Such responses do little to counterbalance the emotive force of reactionary mobilization. For instance, mainstream politicians have continued to counter Trump by relying too heavily on rational arguments in response to his unrestrained, factually unsupported claims. This approach has continued to backfire, often coming across as arrogant rather than passionately oppositional. A similar dynamic played out during the Brexit campaign: while pro-Brexit politicians made attention-grabbing, emotionally charged claims, anti-Brexit speeches based on sound arguments were dismissed as dull and forgettable (e.g., Moss et al., 2020). Intriguingly, after the Brexit referendum outcome to leave the EU, some Remain campaigners, like George Osborne, were self-critical that they had “lacked some of the authenticity and optimism of the Leave

campaign” (<https://www.itv.com/news/2016-12-18/brexit-remain-campaign-lacked-optimism-and-authenticity-admits-george-osborne>).

Breaking Out of Complicity: How Mainstreamers Can Facilitate Democratic Renewal

In this chapter, we draw attention to the complicity of mainstreamers in inadvertently abetting the erosion of democratic institutions. Reflecting on recent political events and societal change challenges, we have argued that an asymmetry in emotional expressiveness between mainstreamers and reactionaries endangers the very ethos underlying democratic institutions. We caution that there is a fine line between institutional drift and institutional erosion. Neglecting the difference between non-strategic, unintentional, yet ethos-preserving, deviations in day-to-day practices and strategic, deliberate ethos-eroding violations of institutional ethos, can lead (and perhaps has led) to dangerous and irreversible damage to prized institutions.

We expand our understanding of the relationship between emotional dynamics and institutions by highlighting implications of asymmetry in emotional expressiveness for the erosion of institutions. Emotional passivity can create perceptions of complacency and lack of passion from mainstreamers but also make key guardians of democratic institutions including the judiciary, media, and civil society vulnerable to complacency. Meanwhile, the reactionaries leverage the perceived lack of conviction and energy among mainstreamers to amplify their influence through unrestrained, emotion-driven transgressions, which become increasingly normalized. Put another way, societal denial of threats to democracy creates a feedback loop where inaction emboldens reactionary forces to steadily erode the foundations of democratic ideals. Stemming the process of institutional erosion requires a recalibration of how emotions are expressed and perceived within democratic contexts. Accordingly, mainstreamers need to recalibrate their emotional passivity to redress the gap with the unrestrained emotional expressiveness of reactionaries. So, how can mainstreamers break out of their cycles of passivity and actively resist the steady erosion of democratic institutions? We elaborate below what that may entail.

Facing Up to the Reality of Systemic Democratic Erosion. First and foremost, mainstreamers need to confront reality that the threats are not random, isolated incidents but systemic attacks on the very ethos of democracy. Tolerance is, therefore, not a virtue but an obstacle to protecting enduring institutional ideals at risk. In a similar vein, denial is based in

the illusion that “one-off” events will go away as eccentric or harmless reactionaries quieten down. As we noted at the beginning, successive violations of democratic ideals such as voter suppression, attacks on the judiciary, attacks on freedom of the press and others are a part of a broader pattern of authoritarian encroachment. This situation demands that mainstreamers accelerate public engagement to mobilize grassroots support, to publicly call out reactionaries’ violations, rather than slip into a cycle of tolerance and denial that perpetuates emotional passivity. Mainstreamers can leverage the very emotions through which they experience valued institutions each day as personally meaningful (Creed et al., 2014) to overtly stand up for them.

Shifting from Emotional Restraint to Emotional Engagement. Alongside tolerance and denial, adherence further inhibits mainstreamers from expressing emotion. Traditionally, mainstreamers including politicians, journalists, and civil society leaders have been socialized to uphold calm, objectivity, and moderation. Thus, emotional display is often seen as a breach of civility—something to be avoided or dismissed as a populist tactic. This mindset leads mainstreamers to over-rely on rational, cognitively grounded debate, which can appear detached, indifferent, and ultimately ineffective in countering the emotionally charged rhetoric of reactionaries. Yet, expressing emotion in defense of democratic values is not only legitimate—it is essential for meaningful public engagement. Accordingly, mainstreamers need a radical shift in their cultural perceptions of emotional expression that challenges the framing that emotional expressiveness is by default alarmist and inappropriate and at odds with being perceived reasonable and credible.

Expressing emotion and reasoned debate are not mutually exclusive. Mainstreamers can strike a balance between passion and reason as well as communicate through means that inspire broader engagement. For example, they could use relatable narratives, vivid imagery, and accessible language to animate democratic ideals while making them tangible. By consciously recalibrating their emotional expression, mainstreamers can respond more authentically and strategically to the erosion of democratic norms. This also means recognizing when and how to deploy emotional appeals strategically (Jarvis et al., 2019)—whether by expressing outrage at violations of democratic norms or emphasizing hope, or fostering a sense of collective resilience to counter apathy.

By embracing emotional expression as permissible or legitimate, mainstreamers can level the rhetorical playing field, making their defense of democracy not only intellectually compelling, but also emotionally resonant. Recalibrating emotional expressiveness could pave the way out of the cycle of

passivity—away from collective tolerance and denial of reactionaries' inflammatory rhetoric, and toward a shared sense of emotional solidarity. Such a collective emotional stance is needed to stem violations of democratic norms and to unite in the face of authoritarian threats.

Promoting Emotional Solidarity. Emotional solidarity (Collins, 2019) refers to the shared emotional experiences that bind individuals together in collective action. In the face of threats to democratic ideals, a collective emotional stance among diverse groups can create a powerful sense of unity and urgency among diverse groups, countering the fragmentation that often accompanies institutional erosion.

One way to promote emotional solidarity is by crafting messages and actions that emphasize common values and shared stakes. For instance, instead of framing democratic threats in abstract terms, leaders could highlight concrete examples of how such threats impact everyday lives, such as the erosion of fair elections or attacks on press freedom. By drawing on shared emotions like pride, hope, and even anger, mainstreamers can rally individuals around a collective vision for protecting democracy.

Another critical aspect is creating spaces for collective emotional expression (Kellogg, 2009; Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). Public demonstrations, town hall meetings, and digital campaigns that emphasize solidarity can amplify the emotional connection between individuals and democratic ideals. These spaces allow people to express their concerns, hopes, and frustrations, reinforcing their commitment to the democratic ethos.

Emotional solidarity also involves recognizing and addressing barriers to participation. For example, marginalized communities may feel excluded from mainstream discourses about democracy. By acknowledging and incorporating their experiences, mainstreamers can build broader coalitions that reflect the full diversity of democratic societies.

In sum, by breaking free from the cycle of passivity, mainstream actors can not only close the emotional expressiveness gap with reactionary forces but also reaffirm democracy's foundational ethos as a shared, emotionally resonant ideal. This shift underscores the pressing need to rethink how democratic institutions—and those who defend them—engage with emotional dynamics in public discourse. These insights open new avenues for research and practical interventions aimed at strengthening the resilience of democratic systems against erosion. The urgency of mainstreamers facing up to the reality of institutional erosion cannot be overstated. Over the past decade, warning signs have grown more visible: younger generations—particularly Gen Z—are increasingly normalizing reactionary rhetoric and behavior as part of the political mainstream (Chandonnet, 2024). If mainstreamers fail

to adapt, they risk ceding not only the emotional terrain but also the future of democratic legitimacy.

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10

From Shame to Hate: The Role of Stories in Constructing a Hate Habitus

Trish Ruebottom and Madeline Toubiana

I do not like their swagger. I don't like the way they treat us like dogs ... would crush their face in if they gave me even the slightest chance. I would fight every one of them.

(Interview with a previously incarcerated man from Toubiana, [2020](#))

The shame we are so often made to feel in society can be transformed into an intense hatred, an “externalization of blame” (Tangney et al., [2007: 7](#)). Even after leaving prison, the man in the quote above carries hate with him; he is still intensely and viscerally angry at all corrections officers for making him feel shame while incarcerated (Toubiana, [2020](#)). In fact, James Gilligan's work with violent criminals in the U.S. prison system shows, “that while inmates exhibited an extreme shamelessness in relation to their violent behaviour, a formidable underlying shame had almost always fueled their violence, while shame in the present was a further provocation” (Keen, [2023: 10](#)).

The transformation from shame to hate is something we have continually observed in our empirical work. And indeed, as we engaged with the literature

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on shame (e.g., Creed et al., 2014b; Scheff, 2000) and hate (e.g., Sternberg & Sternberg, 2008; Szanto, 2020) we came to see that these emotions are deeply intertwined: those who feel shame are “more likely to engage in externalization of blame, experience intense anger, and express that anger in destructive ways, including direct physical, verbal, and symbolic aggression... all manner of displaced aggression, self-directed aggression, and anger held in” (Tangney et al., 2007: 7).

It is no coincidence then, that the drastic increase in shaming since the 1980s (Keen, 2023) has occurred in tandem with an equally drastic increase in hate groups (Hochschild, 2024).¹ While the literature acknowledges the destructive emotions that shame can trigger, including hate, the transformation process itself from shame to hate remains severely undertheorized.

Hate is defined as an emotion of “strong dislike or ill will for; [to] loathe; despise” (Sternberg, 2003: 299). Sternberg (2003) goes on to argue that hate is much more than a strong dislike or even loathing—hate is composed of three elements: disgust, anger/fear, and devaluation. As such, hate is “an affective mechanism underlying prejudices, dehumanization, political, or moral exclusion, and intergroup violence” (Santo, 2020: 2). Many of us (hopefully) do not see or feel hate in our everyday lives—it is not part of our relationships, nor does it structure our communities or organizations. But examples of the incredible impacts of hate abound in the media: from the many wars going on around the world to the rise in white supremacy groups, attacks by incels and lone gunman, and the rage-fueled hate-speech on social media every day. Given the prevalence of widening societal polarization (Ariely, 2023; O’Neil, 2022), it is becoming increasingly urgent that we understand the unique ways that hate operates.

An important distinction is first required: hate is not the same as anger. Where anger is connected to a particular offense and aims at corrective measures (Rees & Friedman, 2025), hate is not tethered to events and instead aims for destruction and dissociation from entire groups (Halperin, 2008; Roberts, 2003); anger dissolves when repairs are made, hate does not care about reparations (Halperin et al., 2011; Szanto, 2020). Hate, unlike anger, is also one of the most long-lasting emotions, one that is highly resistant to logic or empathy (Ahmed, 2001; Szanto, 2020). This conceptualization of hate raises further questions: How does hate that comes from shame become so stable and intractable? And what can be done about this?

¹ Keen (2023: 2) shows that, “According to Google Books’ Ngram viewer, the use of the word “shame” declined pretty steadily (in Google’s wide selection of English-language books) from the early 1800s to around 1940 and then stayed at a low level until around 1980”; Hochschild (2024: 4) that shows, “In 2000, the Southern Poverty Law Centre counted 599 hate groups... in 2017, that number had risen to 954.” As of 2023, there were 1,430.

To theorize the pathway from shame to hate, we draw on the phenomenology of hate (Szanto, 2020), as well as literature that details specific forms of hate such as misogyny (Harding et al., 2024; Manne, 2017; McCarthy & Taylor, 2024), racism and white supremacy (Creed et al., 2022; Hochschild, 2024) and first-person accounts of hate (McAleer, 2019; Piccolini, 2017; Rodger, 2014). Two observations in these literatures are critical to understanding the transformation. First, hate—like shame—is not just an emotion, but a *social* emotion (Creed et al., 2014b; Scheff, 2000); it can become a “habitus,” a durable disposition oriented around the emotion (Bourdieu, 1977; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024; Szanto, 2020). As such, hate (and shame) structure social interactions and reinforce social hierarchies. Second, shame is instilled through narratives of unworthiness and self-blame (Every, 2013), while hate is enabled by narratives of threat and other-blaming (Sternberg & Sternberg, 2008). These narratives are, critically, available within society, but are more easily accessible to certain groups and in certain contexts (Hochschild, 2024; Keen, 2023; Manne, 2017).

These insights allow us to sketch out the beginning of a process model depicting the transformation of shame to hate. We theorize how a hate habitus emerges through a process of, (1) shifting attributions of blame using victim narratives; (2) over-generalizing about the malicious “Other” based on the accumulation (and re-writing) of narratives; and (3) constituting the self and one’s community through dichotomous positioning of “us” versus “them,” protagonists versus antagonists. Based on this we theorize hate as simultaneously located in the individual, as a reaction to circumstances; in the collective, through us/them group bonds; and as a structural feature of the environment, as narratives available in the broader discourse. Because of the multi-level, individual-collective, and personal-structural nature of the pathways, we see this as a fundamentally institutional process.

The idea of an institutional process that creates a hate habitus allows us to explain why hate can become so incredibly intractable—it offers a sense of superiority and connectedness that is otherwise difficult to access for those who feel deep shame (Scheff, 2004); it gains unshakeable strength from its over-generalized, blurred focus that makes it resistant to logic (Szanto, 2020); and it is imbued with existential importance by constituting the self and one’s social group in contrast to the “Other” (Szanto, 2020). We show that what starts as a movement from shame to episodic anger, with unstable and intense (“burning”) feelings, transforms into a chronic and durable way of being, organizing groups and fields around common attunements, expressions, and ways of carrying the self. When it reaches this final stage, to let go of hate is then to let go of oneself and one’s community, and to return to an isolating

sense of shame. Understanding this process is critical if we are to have any hope of reversing the growing spectre of hate spreading in and across our societies.

The Link Between Shame and Hate

Shame is an incredibly painful and disempowering emotion that can lead to a shrinking of the self, the desire to be invisible and withdraw from others (Creed et al., 2014b; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024; Scheff, 2000). But shame can also take people in the opposite direction: shame can lead to a “shame-rage spiral,” lashing out at others who are perceived to be to blame (Creed et al., 2022; Scheff, 2004). This spiral, if left uninterrupted, can generalize into an intense and intractable form of hate (Szanto, 2020).

In Scheff’s (2004: 28, 25) article, *Is Hatred Formed by Hidden Shame and Rage?* he states,

anger by itself is usually brief and instructive. A person who is frustrated and unashamed of her anger is mobilized to tell what is going on, and to do what is needed, without making a huge scene... The key to the intensity or bitterness of hatred could be an emotion that is a hidden component of rage and aggression: unacknowledged shame or humiliation. One way to deal with the feeling that one has been rejected as unworthy is to reject the rejector, rather than to blame one’s self as unworthy...

In fact, when Gilligan asked a particularly violent prisoner (2003: 1150), “What do you want so badly that you are willing to give up everything else in order to get it?” the answer was, “Pride. Dignity. Self-esteem. And I’ll kill every motherfucker in that cell block if I have to in order to get it.” Gilligan (2003) found that shame, and the desire to be rid of shame, was a motivating factor for every single prisoner he spoke with.

Shame involves a sense of personal failure—that one has failed to live up to the norms and values set up by society (Keen, 2023; Scheff, 2014). “People experiencing shame evaluate the eliciting mistake or transgression as being indicative of a self that is fundamentally flawed” (Dearing & Tangney, 2011: 4). Shame is a deeply “politicized emotion,” used to motivate certain behaviors (Hochschild, 2024: 10). The fear of shame, or shame avoidance (Schmader & Lickel, 2006), motivates people to uphold social norms and values. In this way, shame operates to encourage conformity to societal expectations by outlining expected behavior and shaping our very sense of self as

a good and worthy member of society. Yet, we are not always able to avoid feelings of shame.

People may be shamed for their failings at work, receiving negative performance feedback from supervisors (Poulson, 2000); because a person's body does not fit institutional prescriptions that define acceptable weight or other attributes (O'Neil, 2022); in situations where a person is not able to obtain or maintain work (Iwakabe, 2021); or for the very nature of the work they do, as societal institutions outline which work is dirty and devalued (Ashforth & Kreiner, 1999; Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2021). Motherhood is another common source of shame (Leonard & Kelly, 2022), as is a sense of failed masculinity (Mobasser, Kahn, & Ely, 2024); and Indigenous scholars have identified an inter-generational colonial shame, "that is rooted in the humiliation that colonialism has heaped on our peoples for hundreds of years and is now carried within our bodies, minds and our hearts" (Simpson, 2011: 51).

For many people, shame leads to ongoing self-consciousness and inhibition of the self—a desire to be small and invisible (Bartky, 1990; Probyn, 2004). Many people get stuck in this shame (Ruebottom & Toubiana, 2024). But there is one particular source of shame most connected to a shift to hate: the shame that comes from not living up to the ideal of one's dominant social position. Manne (2017: 121) describes the shame felt by those in dominant groups as an "entitled shame" to emphasize that the person is in a privileged social position and "should not" feel the inferiority associated with shame. It is this shame, a "shame-for-loss-of-power" (Keen, 2023: 179) that seems most commonly associated with hate. For example, former white supremacist, Tony McAleer, wrote, "the internal source of all that anger" was "the betrayal, the humiliation, and the beatings" he received at school (McAleer, 2019: 44). As he explains,

The tough kids would return from such a session [a beating from the school headmaster] with no tears and a "That's all you got?" smirk on their faces. Not me. My cheeks reddened further as I felt additional shame wash over me at the slight laughs and snickers my display of weakness earned. (McAleer, 2019: 32)

As a straight white male, McAleer was not "supposed to" feel weak or inferior. Similarly, incels often share stories of early rejection from women and it is the feeling of failing to meet the standards of masculinity that cause the shame that ultimately turn to hate (Thorburn et al., 2023). Elliot Rodger, who later killed several people in a mass shooting, wrote in *My Twisted World* about a pivotal conversation with his housemates' friend that came to visit,

Inevitably, a vile incident occurred between me and him. I was eating a meal in the kitchen when he came over and started bragging to my housemates about his success with girls. I couldn't stand it, so I proceeded to ask them all if they were virgins. They all looked at my weirdly and said that they had lost their virginity long ago. I felt so inferior, as it reminded me of how much I have missed out in life... How could an inferior, ugly black boy be able to get a white girl and not me? I am beautiful, and I am half white myself. I am descended from British aristocracy. He is descended from slaves. I deserve it more... They would give themselves to this filthy scum, but they reject *ME*? The injustice! (Rodger, 2014)

In this example, we can see the shame at his failure to live up to the dominant masculine ideal—he is a man who was a virgin—which underpinned his anger at the visitor; his failure to be racially superior, as someone “half white” compared to the “ugly black boy.” We can see in this statement, his shame is transforming into anger as he shifts the blame from himself to another.

What is not clear, though, is *how* this shift from shame to anger happens when the locus of blame is diametrically opposed in each of these emotions. How can the self-blaming of shame be converted into the other-blaming that fuels anger?

From Shame to Anger and Back to Shame: Shifting Attributions of Blame

Several reports we read about the pathway to hate start with a search that leads the shamed person to stories told by others. These stories define a similar situation facing the protagonist so that the shamed person can see themselves in the story. An individual story of a person who, for example, lost their job at the factory, had to take a minimum wage job, couldn't support their family, turned to alcohol and then drugs... others see themselves in this same story (Hochschild, 2024).

Most importantly, these stories also define a common antagonist, another person to blame for the shared situation. This can be seen in Hochschild's (2024: 45) paraphrasing of the underlying message shared by a neo-Nazi group looking to recruit new members, clearly outlining who was really to blame:

You've lost your regional pride, your well-paid jobs, suffered devaluations of what you do have, and you've had enough. We on the violent right will erase shame from you and seamlessly divert your shame to blame – blame

of Jews, Muslims, Blacks, immigrants, liberals, and Democrats. Your access to the American Dream? They took it! Everything that ever hurt you is their fault. Our guns are cocked and loaded.

When stories told by others have similarities with the shamed person's own story, yet take the form of "victim narratives," they can support a transition from self-blame to other-blame (Bacq, Toubiana, Ruebottom et al., 2023). Narratives are sense-making tools that organize a series of events or experiences, typically involving some sort of conflict; the events are structured into a plot with characters that take on certain roles in the story, such as protagonist, antagonist, supporting characters, etc. (Gabriel, 2000). Importantly, narratives "construct realities they seemingly only describe" (Gross & Zilber, 2020: 1372; Vaara et al., 2016). As such, when the protagonist in the story shifts from unworthy and shamed to threatened and victimized, and the story resonates with the shamed person, they can begin to reframe their own "story"—what the person once believed was their own shameful shortcoming is no longer their fault and there is no need to feel shame.

While letting go of shame can be incredibly positive, and shifting attributions of blame are a key part of this process (Strauss Swanson & Szymanski, 2020), placing oneself into the role of victim is not usually helpful. For example, "Toubiana (2020) outlined in her study of previously incarcerated men that those who identified with a victim-based narrative were able to shift blame from themselves to others, but ended up stuck in anger" (Bacq et al., 2023: 10–11). What is mostly likely to emerge from shared stories that clearly articulate an antagonist to blame is anger directed at the newly identified perpetrators rather than the release of anger (Halperin et al., 2011; Szanto, 2020).

Yet, this shift is unstable. Scheff's (2004) conceptualization of a shame/rage *spiral* implies that there is often a return to shame and self-blame. New sources of failure and further shaming episodes occur and can send the person back to shame. For example, Tony McAleer had channeled his shame into anger, but he continued to experience shaming episodes throughout high school, and was repeatedly "overcome with the old familiar feelings of shame and rejection" (2019: 40). As a result, the "continuous spiral of shame/anger... [is] a self-feeding loop of unlimited duration and intensity. This loop is the emotional basis of lengthy episodes or even life-long hatred" (Scheff, 2004: 29). See Fig. 10.1 for our beginning model of the shame/rage (or anger) spiral.

This first part of the process shows how attributions of blame can shift when people hear and find resonance with victim narratives. The resulting anger offers relief from the painful sense of inferiority of those who feel

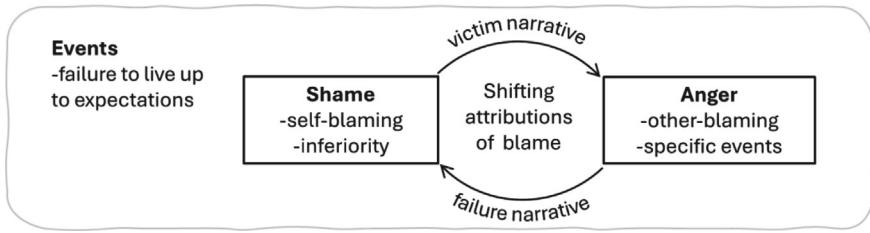


Fig. 10.1 Shame to anger and back to shame

shame. It is from anger and the resulting unstable spiral that some people proceed to the more stabilized emotion of hate.

From Anger to Hate: Stabilizing Hate by Over-generalizing Malicious Others

By definition, anger becomes hate when it is untethered from specific offenses, and instead becomes focused on broad traits of other groups, the antagonists in the story:

repeated episodes of anger, in which badness is ascribed to the object on account of culpable misdeeds, may lead to hatred by a kind of accumulation and abstraction: The badness of the object gets distilled from his offenses and acquires the independence and perdurance of a personal essence. (Roberts, 2003: 251 in Szanto, 2020)

With hate blame is attributed to the character of the person or group instead of the action—the action is just one example of the group’s evil threatening character (Ahmed, 2001). This is the “accumulation and abstraction” that Roberts articulates above, which underpins hate. This is reflected in the quote from the man who was previously incarcerated that began the chapter, his anger untethered from a particular action of a specific correctional officer to a hate of all corrections officers categorically.

As groups coalesce around an increasing number of shared stories, the re-writing of the narratives provides the mechanism that enables this abstraction (Sternberg & Sternberg, 2008). In their developmental model of the shift from anger to hate, Sternberg and Sternberg (2008) argue that characters—victims and villains—become typified, archetypal representations of good and evil, and move to the foreground; while the specific events—or plot-lines—multiply and move to the background, with the specific events simply

confirming the general narrative. Not only is it the “*Jews, Muslims, Blacks, immigrants, liberals, and Democrats*” etc. that are to blame (Hochschild, 2024: 45), it is their evil, entitled, vindictive, or otherwise negative nature that is an ongoing and omni-present threat. If it is in their nature, the entire group represents a threat.

The shift to hate is made easier by readily available meta-narratives in society, that allow for non-reflexive adoption of a preferred (less shameful) story of self. Meta-narratives are the “repertoire of narrative template(s) available in a given culture” (Gross & Zilber, 2020: 1373; Polkinghorne, 1988). For example, misogyny provides a meta-narrative that men can use to shift out of the shame/rage spiral into hate targeted toward women, generalizing the malicious nature of women as a group (Manne, 2017). Misogyny provides the villain that gives plausibility to the shift, a cultural script for shifting anger to hate: it is no longer one specific event, but a reflection of the character of women. Such scripts are more readily available in certain contexts, such as the “bro culture” of software development (Harding et al., 2024) and STEM fields (Kim & Meister, 2023); similarly, racist or classist scripts are more readily available about precarious and stigmatized labor (Varman, Al-Amoudi, & Skálén, 2023). This is obviously not to say that all men working in these spaces hate women or that all white people hate racialized people, but that these dominant narratives are more readily available in these contexts, defining these “Others” as antagonists. This also implies that hate is more likely to develop in certain institutional contexts than others.

Thus, stories allow the shift to hate through an over-generalized, blurred focus: the connection is hazy between the offender and the offense (Szanto, 2020) and between real individuals and the imaginary hated group typified in the stories (Ahmed, 2014). For example, when refugees become hated there need be only a very loose connection to unemployment or loss of “American” culture (Szanto, 2020), or between actual refugees and the essentialized image of the group (Ahmed, 2004).

This condition—that hate takes on an over-generalized, blurred focus—explains why it is so difficult to argue against hate. Without connection to the offense and instead emphasis on the offenders’ character, hate is resistant to logic (Szanto, 2020); and without connection to real people it becomes impossible to appeal to empathy (Ahmed, 2004). In another example, the over-generalized, fantastical logic that underpins the Aryan Nations group is that there exists.

a Jewish cabal that controlled most of the world through finance, entertainment, and education, and worked in the shadows of the halls of power and

government... For the Aryan man to thrive and survive in the world, the Jew, seen as a parasite, had to be removed. (McAleer, 2019: 82)

The wording is very important: there is no specific instantiation of threat, and because the work is done in the shadows it cannot be disproved—those who would argue against it are just ignorant of the true workings of the world; it was not specific to certain Jewish people who are in positions of power but the entire broad category, “the Jew,” who is characterized as a parasite. The resistant power of these narratives “mak[es] hate spin in a void” with unshakeable strength (Szanto, 2020: 25). The instability of anger now takes on the stronger, more stable form of hate.

Institutionalizing Hate Through a Hate Habitus

In its strongest form, hate becomes a way of being. Hate becomes the orienting emotion for the self, a durable habitus (Szanto, 2020), or “a habitual state (especially of the body) and, in particular, a predisposition, tendency, propensity, or inclination” (Bourdieu, 1977: 214). As a habitus, hate is embodied, shaping a person’s dispositions, comportment, and ways of interacting in the world (Bourdieu, 1989; Szanto, 2020). It is the acceptable emotional expression, the medium for connecting with those in the community and disconnecting from others.

A hate habitus becomes embodied through the specific ways of carrying the body. It is in the broad stance, the strong forceful movements, the facial expressions that show hate; and it is in the voice that shows the emotion, the tone of disgust; it is also in the ways of decorating the body—the style of clothes, jewelry, hair. Tony McAleer described the skinhead subculture, a “lifestyle” that came with a whole package, which he was slowly socialized into; at first, he and his friends “wore the badges and trappings of white supremacy without having fully absorbed and internalized the ideology... White power music would transform us from wearing provocative badges and slogans to internalizing an ideology as identity” (McAleer, 2019: 58–59). This is a critical shift. It is where the narratives become internalized and enacted (Gross & Zilber, 2000), where the White Supremacist *becomes* the protagonist in the story. As McAleer saw, the new members of the group took on the disposition of White Supremacy, the very particular ways of speaking, interacting, and showing emotion dictated by the group, and with repeated enactments this disposition became a natural and internally derived ways of being.

White supremacy groups highlight the importance of the collective in this process (Hochschild, 2024). In fact, Bourdieu's (1990) articulation of habitus emphasizes the role of socialization in developing a habitus based on the norms in the field. This process unfolds through a "harmonization of the individual habitus with the collective habitus" that provides the individual with confidence and a sense of fitting in (Jawitz, 2009: 601). Telling the right stories that show the right emotion and the right values confirms one's membership in the group—belonging is shown through appropriate use of the group's hate-based practices (Bourdieu, 1986; Geiger, 2020):

We had our own rules, our own code to follow to earn each other's respect... a belief, action, or attribute that we copy to curry favour or to create symmetry with the person in question so that we may be more likable and receive more attention, acceptance, or approval. (McAleer, 2019: 57)

Hate becomes the only appropriate and acceptable (even admirable) way to be in the world.

While a habitus oriented around hate is obviously not appropriate and acceptable to most, it is *appropriate and acceptable to those in the community*. Communities of hate are, in this view, institutional in that they structure the motivation, identities, values and practices of those within the field (Bourdieu, 1985; Oakes, Townley, & Cooper, 1998). "We hate (them), therefore we are" (Szanto, 2020: 17–18). Ahmed (2004: 346) goes so far as to argue that hate is actually felt/positioned as love—love for one's social group that is threatened by real or imagined "Others":

The passion of these negative attachments to others is re-defined simultaneously as a positive attachment to the imagined subjects brought together through the capitalisation of the signifier, 'White'. It is the love of White, or those that are recognisable as White, which supposedly explains this shared 'communal' visceral response of hate. *Together we hate and this hate is what makes us together.*

As such, hate is not simply oppositional (against the "Other") and negatively focused (I am the victim). The community becomes something valued, something that must be protected from threat; because of this, hate is now productive for the individual: "I am invested in hating not because I'm negatively attached to my target, but also because it reattaches me positively to my in group and reinvigorates my own social identity and the identity of my group" (Santos, 2020: 22). In fact, a study of hate speech on the far-right website 4Chan found that specific slurs classified as hate speech were not used

to express hate for the other, although they appeared this way on the surface; instead, they were actually about signaling belonging to the group (Geiger, 2020). Because the difference between us and them is tenuous and “fantastical” (Ahmed, 2001: 354), membership is always at risk and differences must be continuously emphasized. Using slurs in stories about the “Other” ensures one’s own membership in the group (Geiger, 2020). Thus, there is pressure to conform to the norms embedded in the habitus, as one’s identity and place within the group depends on it (Bourdieu, 1985, 1989). In this way, the hate habitus is stabilized as a set of embodied institutional practices that positively bind the community together.

Going even further, the collective suppression of shame becomes a fundamental force that maintains the stability of the now-institutionalized hate (Delmestri & Goodrick, 2016). Those outside the community no longer have the power to shame. In Keen’s (2023: 84–85) study of fighters on both sides of the civil war in Sierra Leone, he explained,

once a community of fighters with some kind of ‘inverted morality’ had been created, it was extremely difficult for those outside the group (notably civilians) to shame these violent groups into better behaviour... shame was precisely *what many fighters were trying to reverse and keep at bay*.

Hate prevented the re-emergence of shame. Without the protection of the hate community, individuals could and would most likely be re-exposed to shame: fighters on both sides of the civil war had committed atrocities, and were now being shamed by civilians who had suffered from the violence (Keen, 2023). To prevent the return of shame, hate communities are often tightly bound and rigid, acting as “an emotional refuge” that enables “maintaining [their] deviant definitions of reality as reality” (Berger & Luckmann, 2016: 144 in Delmestri & Goodrick, 2016). For the fighters in Sierra Leone (and many other groups), the view that their strength is praiseworthy and the violence was justified must continually be protected (Keen, 2024).

We have shown how a hate habitus becomes a part of the way one carries oneself (it is embodied), interacts with others (it is collective), and offers a way to avert shame (it is preventative). These features of the hate habitus, its embodied, collective, and preventative nature, make it incredibly durable—a vicious, reinforcing cycle (Geiger, 2020; Szanto, 2020)—that institutionalizes a way of being (Bourdieu, 1989). In our model (see Fig. 10.2), we show how hate emerges from shame. We trace the path from a sense of inferiority in shame to superiority in hate. This path is based on narratives that shift blame from self to others, which become over-generalized (from specific actions to

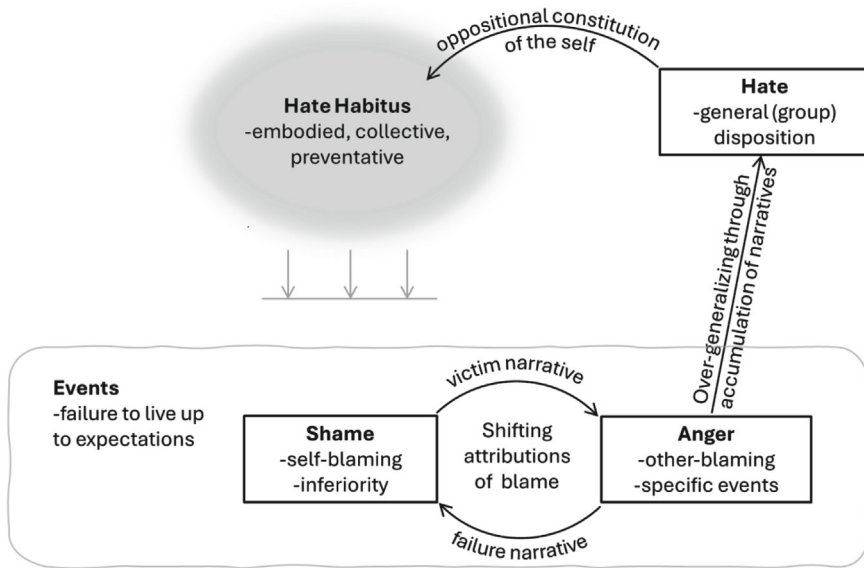


Fig. 10.2 Pathway from shame to hate

general character). For some, the path to hate continues as they are socialized into a collective hate habitus that protects against the re-emergence of shame.

This pathway solidifies hate, and in doing so, protects the person from falling back into shame. Since hate fuels conflict, other parties will often work to shame those who hate. Yet, our model shows that this will only further entrench hate, because hate is what protects people from shame. It seems therefore unsurprising that as society has become more and more of a “shame machine,” where shaming efforts are increasing and pervasive (Keen, 2023; O’Neil, 2022), that we have some of the highest levels of reported hate in decades (Hochschild, 2024).

A Possible Way Forward

Our model reveals critical dynamics at play in the pathway from shame to hate, and what we present is not a very uplifting story. This is because sadly, as scholars studying extremists and hate crimes have discovered, finding pathways out of hate is incredibly difficult. It is beyond the scope of this chapter to “solve” hate, to find a way to move people out of hate or subvert the process altogether. Yet, we do think it is worthwhile to present some hunches we have developed as we worked in contexts fueled by hate and engaged with the literature. We thus make suggestions for future research that might be

fruitful. The suggestions we make interfere in the process model outlined above—supporting people in shedding the hate habitus and finding an alternative pathway out of shame. We point to the potential for research in these two directions.

Shedding the Hate Habitus

Once shame has been transformed into a hate habitus, it is embodied, collective, and preventative. It can be extraordinarily hard to shed such a habitus. Hate, and the community who espouses it, becomes a core part of the self. Shifting from hate then is not merely an emotional transition, it is one of disposition, community, and purpose. The more “radical” the community’s way of being, the more dependent individuals are on the community to maintain their sense of self and prevent the re-activation of shame; the more risk of shame, the tighter the community and the harder to shed hate. Drawing on Berger and Luckman (1966), Delmestri and Goodrick (2016: 238) explain,

individuals need the support of a community of relevant others to help maintain the “new world” in the face of the “base-world” dominant in society... the ongoing effective performance of a role requires reality-maintenance, that is, not only its implicit confirmation supplied by casual everyday contacts, but also the “explicit and emotionally charged confirmation” by significant others.

To the extent one’s social world and circle are needed to reinforce the hate habitus, as a core “world of concern” (Creed et al., 2022), the harder it will be to escape.

We use the story of reformed White supremacist, Christian Picciolini, to articulate key points about the possibilities of shedding a hate habitus. In Picciolini’s (2017) story he speaks of moments, small interactions that stuck with him and began to break through a very rigid identity constructed around hate. He first tells of a moment when he began dating a woman outside of his circle. Her simple question, “Why do you have so much hatred inside of you?” struck a chord. This one incident did not shatter the hate habitus, but it did seem to trigger a slow unraveling. He describes another moment where, in the midst of a protest, he looked at the counter-protesters and realized these others were like people he had known in his life. In this moment, while he reflected on interactions that contradicted the narratives he had internalized, he wrote,

I was surprised to discover how decent they were. Even more they were people, people with whom I had much more common with than those ones I had surrounded myself with since I was fourteen. I was beginning to notice the little experiences that bind us together as humans. (Picciolini, 2017: 233)

Such interactions with others, experiences that corroded the oppositional “us” vs “them” were critical for surfacing doubt.

Indeed, psychology research has found that intergroup contact can reduce prejudice and discrimination (e.g., Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006, 2008); however, this research has also found that at other times, interactions are negative and reinforce boundaries and conflict (Böhm et al., 2020; Schäfer et al., 2021). While there are many factors at play, we focus on the challenges for uprooting a habitus, a way of being, based on the boundary between “us” and “them.” As Picciolini wrote, “I felt stuck in a hole too deep to climb out of. The life of a violent white supremacist was all I’d known through nearly every single one of my teen years. Who would I be otherwise? Where would I go?” (Picciolini, 2017: 211). The community of hate was so important to his sense of self, shedding hate meant losing himself and his social group.

Digging himself out of the hole required particular types of interactions. Specifically, the examples he provides indicate that overlapping group memberships can be beneficial. Overlapping group memberships can reduce bias (Crisp & Hewstone, 1999; Crisp et al., 2006), but these memberships can also provide other ways of relating to people based on the other group’s norms. For example, Picciolini (2017) wrote about the time a black man came into the music store where he worked asking for hardcore metal: they related to each other based on a shared love of the music and the ways of relating found in the metal community; another incident took place during a soccer game where there were racialized people on the other team, again providing another set of dispositions, values, and ways of relating that were based on the strong soccer community.

In these examples, we see that it was not just one incident, but a myriad of small moments that provided a different image of the “Other”—many specific instantiations that could undermine the many accumulated narratives. These interactions had two effects. The interactions allowed Picciolini to relate to the “Other” in a new way, but also, the doubt about his community’s narratives drove a wedge between him and his own community. As he said above, the shared membership in the metal and soccer communities showed him that he had a shared connection with these others (Picciolini, 2017). This insight—indeed contradiction between what he was experiencing and the narratives he used to guide his life—surfaced reflexivity (Seo & Creed, 2002), and began the erosion of the hate habitus. Where the process

of moving from shame to hate was non-reflexive—it is often in fact necessary to avoid deep reflection or reconsideration of the self and one's role in a system—the contradictions begin a process of reconsideration.

During this transitional period, those who have come out the other side often report feeling incredibly lonely, as their connections to the community began to falter (McAleer, 2019; Picciolini, 2017). McAleer (2019: 139) called this period, “‘The void.’ When someone leaves an extremist group, they enter a significant period in which they no longer have a social group or a social identity.” Not only do people leaving hate communities need a new community to prevent isolation and loneliness, they need a new community that sees them, understands them, and respects them (Keen, 2023). Without this, people are vulnerable to shame and re-entering the cycle. While not everyone can offer such recognition, Keen (2023: 74–75) tells the story of a man who “explained [to him] the advantages of sitting down and sharing a meal with the rapists, child-killers, and limb-hackers who were rampaging through his country... ‘They want some kind of recognition from the civilians’... ‘You have to say “OK, I’m with you, I support you. There’s nothing wrong with you’.” This is a particularly tall order from those outside hate communities, but it is a critical step in allowing people to shed the hate habitus—making shame-free safe spaces beyond their hate communities. It suggests that we need to avoid villainizing those who hate and allow for the possibility of leaving, allowing them to be understood. Future research could fruitfully explore this process of leaving, and the reflexivity and recognition that supports the process; action research and experiments could be used to create and test scenarios for supporting people during the transition period.

However, the most important takeaway from our process model is that, while these factors can support a person in leaving hate, they do not necessarily displace the shame that triggered the process in the first place. There is now additional shame piled on top of the old shame, based on the hateful things the person has done (McAleer, 2019). In Picciolini's (2017: 251) story, he explained that it was “once I'd reached the point of finally letting go of my toxic shame completely, that's when change began to take hold.” Thus, finding a new way of being outside of the hate habitus is only part of the solution. The other part is developing an alternative pathway out of the shame that threatens to return.

Alternative Pathways Out of Shame

The pain of shame is a critical factor triggering the pathway to hate. When a person attempts to leave behind hate, our model suggests that they are again

vulnerable to shame. As Keen (2023: 87–88) saw following the civil war in Sierra Leone,

Part of the difficulty of being “reintegrated” into civilian society and civilian values (and here Sierra Leone presented a starker version of a much more general difficulty) was that this involved leaving a world where shame had been kept determinedly at bay through propaganda and violence and emerging into a new world where overwhelming shame threatened to intrude at any time.

Providing an alternative pathway, or even stopping this process before it starts, is perhaps the best way to rid ourselves of hate. But like hate, shame is an incredibly difficult emotion to get rid of.

Recently, Bacq et al. (2023) theorized a process through which shame can be transformed into productive entrepreneurship. In their model, they outline the role of narratives in finding a pathway out of shame. One narrative, discussed above, is the victim narrative; but they also uncovered alternative narratives—specifically those grounded in narratives of resilience instead of victimhood—that were more helpful in restoring a positive sense of self. Narratives of resilience can allow people to heal from the pain of shame and reclaim agency (Bacq et al., 2023). In contrast to our model of shared narratives of victimhood that lead to a collective hate habitus, resilience narratives can bring together a group that prompts positive actions for social change, or what Hochschild (2024: 145) calls “creative repair.” One element that is needed then is a societally available and resonant set of narratives based on resilience, ones more readily available and more resonant than the victim narratives that lead down the path to hate; such narratives can provide a springboard for repairing shame.

Another narrative that may provide an alternative path out of shame is a narrative of redemption. While redemption narratives originate in religious tropes, it is in essence about reclaiming a new fate despite past failings. As Creed et al. (2014a: 111) have reflected, “redemptive narratives not only can shape their identities and sense of life purpose, they inform their practices and choices and animate their capacity for action.” Redemption focuses on actions and practices that remake a person; shame is left behind, because it no longer belongs to the new self. The question worth considering, however, is for those who are not religious, how do such narratives become accessible and meaningful (Toubiana, 2020)? McAdam (2013) proposes several non-religious redemption narratives, as does Creed et al. (2014a). Exploring these narratives in future research would help us understand whether they can provide a possible pathway out of shame.

When we reflect on both redemption and resilience as possible narratives out of shame, we can see an important element that also warrants attention. Specifically, a sense of purpose through helping others. In Bacq et al. (2023) research, resilience narratives allowed those who felt shame to not only shed shame but engage in entrepreneurship that would benefit the entire community. Similarly, for the previously incarcerated men, Toubiana (2020) found that those who seemed to avoid anger in response to shame were those who spoke of redemption through helping others. That is, resilience and redemption narratives may help enable a step out of shame, but instilling purpose and action is what might be needed to keep people out of shame and away from hate.

One important caveat is that these narratives place the burden on the individual. Yet, narrative pathways out of shame are not merely an individual endeavor. The prevalence of shaming in society has drastically increased in recent decades (Keen, 2023; O'Neil, 2022). What upholds shame are the institutions that define what is good and bad, who is enough and who is not. For men like Picciolini, McAleer and Rodgers, images of masculinity need to be reworked so that shame is not triggered in the first place. This is true for narratives in society based on class, race and ethnicity, disability, sexuality, and the narratives of failure in Sierra Leone—narratives that lead to shame. If we are to find our way out of the increasing hate that is pervading society, we need to start at the very roots of the process—we need new societal narratives that do not shame us.

Conclusion

In order to understand how people can move from shame to hate, and how hate can become so incredibly intractable, we have developed a process model of the formation of an oppositional hate habitus. The habitus emerges from a narrative process, which first shifts attributions of blame from self to others, then over-generalizes about the nature of the antagonists, and ultimately, leads to shared narratives that constitute the self and one's community. The resulting habitus is embodied, prescribing appropriate and acceptable bodily dispositions or ways of being that become second nature, habitual and unconscious; the habitus is collective, defining the way the community interacts with each other and with those outside the community; and finally, the habitus is preventative, blocking the shaming that comes from outsiders and avoiding a return to shame.

In developing this process model, we have just barely scratched the surface. We have used very extreme examples that share many similarities. Most prominently, all of the examples are men, and the men have engaged in serious acts of violence based on their hate. This is where the research has focused, yet we suspect women can follow similar pathways to hate. A core aspect of our theorizing is that intractable hate often stems from shame, particularly when there is a sense of expected pride. Since many women are not in such positions where they expect to be shame-free, this may be why most examples focus on men. Yet, we need only look to stories—like the *Handmaid's Tale*—to see how hate can be constructed for women. There is therefore room to explore how sexuality, class, and issues such as fertility impact these processes for women or other groups. In sum, much more research is needed to understand the variations that can occur and the possibilities for finding alternative pathways out of hate and out of shame in different scenarios. Such research can then guide practice, as we seek to address the increasing shame and hate around us.

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11

Fighting for Good: Values and Emotions in Purpose-Driven Organizing

Sylke F. Jellema and Mirjam D. Werner

Purpose-Driven Organizing: An Emerging Institution

More and more organizations are shaping their operations around a social purpose. This trend, known as purpose-driven organizing (George et al., 2023; Hollensbe et al., 2014), refers to the embeddedness of social and environmental objectives into the core activities of an organization. A well-known example is Patagonia. The apparel company, recognized for its sustainability practices, has declared its purpose as: ‘We are in business to save our home planet’ (Patagonia, 2024). The growing appeal of such prosocial pledges reflects a wider shift in public awareness, as concerns about issues like climate change and global economic disparities continue to rise. As people become more concerned and motivated to take action, they increasingly seek out organizations that align with their values, whether as employees, entrepreneurs, or consumers. At the same time, governments and regulatory bodies are

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pressuring organizations to be more transparent about their societal contributions. As these normative and regulatory expectations grow, purpose-driven organizing is steadily becoming an institutionalized part of the business landscape, spanning nonprofits, social enterprises, and any other organization committed to a mission beyond profit.

Despite the mainstream traction of purpose-driven organizing, which is transforming both organizational practices and the broader institutional landscape, our understanding of the internal dynamics that shape—and are shaped—by this mode of organizing remains in its early stages. The dominant narrative in both research and practice often assumes that defining and articulating a clear corporate purpose naturally fosters alignment and commitment within the organization. Leaders, in particular, are generally seen as playing a central role in this process. For example, they may establish a common purpose that reflects shared values and ideals (Besharov & Khurana, 2015; Selznick, 1957, 1996), craft compelling and engaging vision statements (Carton, 2018), or make purpose especially meaningful for external stakeholders (Rindova & Martins, 2023). However, as this chapter will demonstrate, the reality is often more complex. The process of defining and enacting purpose is not always smooth or unifying. The notion of purpose is inherently emotional and value-laden, and even in organizations where people are aligned in their commitment to prosocial goals, the interplay between values and emotions can cause internal tensions and misalignment, especially when people hold different views on what “doing good” actually means.

This chapter follows the purpose-setting journey of “PurpCo,” an organization formed through the merger of two social impact-driven entities. United by a shared ambition to tackle global challenges such as climate change, deforestation, and economic inequality, PurpCo aimed to grow its impact by combining resources and expanding its reach. Between 2018 and 2021, we traced how its members worked to develop new, shared understandings of their organization and its broader societal purpose. While mergers typically bring both expected and unforeseen challenges (e.g., Graebner et al., 2017), in the case of PurpCo, we anticipated that the value-driven nature of both organizations would support a relatively smooth transition, rather than becoming a source of frustration and disappointment. However, as the case unfolded, the latter seemed to be happening. On the surface, members appeared united in their desire to contribute to a better world. Yet, over time, deep-rooted tensions and conflicts around the organization’s identity and its future direction began to emerge. What initially appeared to be a strong collective alignment gradually gave way to growing disengagement,

fragmentation, and, in some cases, apathy toward the broader collective. As we observed these developments, it became clear that beneath their shared prosocial aspirations, PurpCo's members held differing interpretations of what "working toward a better world" actually meant. For some, PurpCo represented a social enterprise, a vehicle through which impact is achieved through market-based solutions and commercial activities. Others favored a more grassroots approach, prioritizing advocacy, community engagement, and localized interventions.

Throughout this purpose-setting exercise, PurpCo's leadership actively encouraged open dialogue, believing that an inclusive and democratic approach would bring members together and strengthen alignment. However, instead of fostering unity, the democratic approach exposed the strength of people's personal ideals and the emotional attachments underlying them. Many members held deeply rooted personal beliefs about what PurpCo should stand for and voiced them with conviction. Over time, a sense of "value heterogeneity" (i.e., the coexistence of diverse beliefs, priorities, and ideals) became increasingly apparent. These differences were not merely superficial; they were anchored in personal values and emotionally charged. As a result, internal tensions intensified, with conflicts arising over who PurpCo is and where it should go. While resistance to change and differing perspectives are common in major organizational transitions (see, for instance, Graebner et al.,'s 2017 review paper on post-merger integrations), the tensions within PurpCo did not always stem from pre-merger identities. Instead, they were scattered across the organization and pointed to deeper, long-standing differences that the merger had merely brought to the surface.

As purpose-driven organizing becomes more widely accepted as a legitimate way to structure organizations, this chapter draws attention to the emotional and value-based struggles that can unfold beneath the surface. Using a sensemaking lens (Weick, 1979, 1995), which examines how individuals and groups interpret and construct meaning, we show that even when employees seem united by a prosocial mission, the complex interplay between personal values and emotional responses may result in either alignment or conflict.

Sensemaking, Values, and Emotions in Purpose-Driven Organizing

Sensemaking (Weick, 1979, 1995) is a dynamic process through which individuals and groups interpret and construct meaning in order to cope with ambiguous or novel situations. It is typically triggered by disruptions or unexpected events (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010), such as the creation of a new shared purpose in the case of PurpCo. Sensemaking theory helps explain how people interpret such disruptions by drawing on various cues, including their sense of self (e.g., Dutton et al., 1994), established practices and routines (e.g., Weick, 1995), or the physical environment (Whiteman & Cooper, 2011), and, in turn, act in accordance with their interpretations (Maitlis & Christianson, 2014; Sandberg & Tsoukas, 2015).

In this chapter, we focus specifically on the role of values and emotions in the sensemaking processes of PurpCo's members as they navigated the organization's purpose-setting trajectory. As purpose-driven organizing becomes increasingly institutionalized, it also shapes broader societal expectations about what organizations should stand for. As a result, individuals within such organizations may develop strong beliefs about the purpose and values that they feel should guide their work. Values are "conceptions of desirable behaviors, objectives, and ideas" (Askeland et al., 2020, p. 3). They function as personal and collective frames of reference, shaping how individuals and groups interpret and evaluate events, actions, and decisions. In times of uncertainty, people often rely on their personal values to make sense of what is happening. Emotions, in turn, play a critical role in shaping how individuals respond to these evaluations, acting as catalysts for action (or inaction). While values reflect abstract ideals of what is important, emotions are immediate physiological and psychological responses to specific events (Creed et al., 2014; Gould, 2009). Emotions influence attention, cognition, and behavior, thereby shaping how people engage with sensemaking processes. For example, emotions such as joy, enthusiasm, or pride can reinforce commitment and motivation, whereas emotions like anger, fear, or regret can lead to inaction, resistance, or conflict-seeking behaviors. In this way, values and emotions together shape sensemaking by influencing perception (Steigenberger, 2015), evaluation (Askeland et al., 2020), and response (Maitlis et al., 2013).

While the connection between values, emotions, and corporate purpose may seem intuitive—given that purpose is inherently tied to values and emotional commitment (e.g., George et al., 2023)—less is known about how these elements interact at the collective level, particularly within the emerging institutional form of the purpose-driven organization. Sensemaking

is a social and interactive process (Weick, 1995). In organizations, members continuously exchange interpretations through conversations, decisions, and emotional expressions. In these settings, individuals must not only make sense of their own values and emotions but also engage with, negotiate, and sometimes reconcile them with those of others. This process becomes particularly complex in purpose-driven organizations, where aligning around a shared purpose involves balancing diverse and deeply held views about what the organization stands for and how it should operate.

The Case of PurpCo

PurpCo was formed through the merger of two organizations operating in the sustainability standards sector. The decision to merge was motivated by a shared goal: to expand their reach and amplify their positive societal impact. As a result of the merger, PurpCo's operations now encompassed the activities of both pre-merger entities, including the promotion of fair wages and labor conditions for commodity farmers and producers, the implementation of landscape conservation projects, and the targeting of consumers and businesses through awareness campaigns. In its new form, PurpCo operates from offices across North and South America, Europe, Africa, and Asia, and employs over 300 staff members. Its governance structure broadly consists of four layers: the board, executives, management, and staff. This chapter focuses specifically on the latter three.

Between 2018 and 2021, we engaged with PurpCo's members as they worked to establish a new shared corporate purpose. We visited offices across four continents, including the Americas, Europe, and Asia, attended team and management meetings, participated in regular office days, joined informal events such as celebrations and team-building activities, and conducted interviews with numerous members. To identify individual and group-based values, we focused on moments in which members indicated that they perceived something or someone as either good or bad. These expressions ranged from explicit statements, such as one member saying, *"I like where we are going because it helps us achieve our corporate goals,"* to more implicit cues. In such cases, we drew on our deep case knowledge and established relationships with members to interpret value expressions conveyed through behaviors and gestures. To capture emotional expressions, we analyzed members' verbal statements about their emotional experiences and labeled specific behaviors, expressions, and gestures according to the emotions they represent. We applied these labels only when we felt confident

in their validity and ensured that they aligned with established emotion-labeling frameworks (e.g., Brackett, 2019; Heaphy, 2017).

We analyzed the PurpCo case using a combination of grounded theory techniques (Glaser & Strauss, 1967/2017) and process theorizing (Langley, 1999). This approach allowed us to construct a detailed empirical narrative tracing how values and emotions shaped PurpCo members' collaborative sensemaking around the organization's purpose-setting trajectory. We identified four distinct phases. Each phase in PurpCo's narrative is characterized by four elements: (1) a sensemaking trigger (e.g., leadership's announcement of a preliminary purpose statement); (2) collective value-driven sensemaking (e.g., varied responses to the purpose statement); (3) an overarching emotional atmosphere (e.g., the pride and optimism felt by members at the beginning of the purpose-setting exercise); and (4) the implications of the interaction between values and emotions (e.g., resulting uncertainty and ambiguity). We labeled each phase using umbrella terms that broadly capture the range of emotional expressions observed during that period. For example, the label 'enthusiasm' encompasses emotions like pride and hope. By using such umbrella labels, we aim to better illustrate how shifting emotional dynamics influenced how members interpreted, questioned, and navigated the purpose-setting exercise.

Clashing Values, Amplified Emotions, and Fragmented Purpose

Our findings highlight four distinct phases (see Fig. 11.1): (1) Enthusiasm, (2) Apprehension, (3) Frustration, and (4) Apathy. Each phase illustrates how, within the context of a democratic and consensus-based leadership approach, specific events triggered PurpCo's members to draw on their personal values and ideals during sensemaking, and how these tendencies, situated within a collective setting, elicited strong emotional responses.

Phase 1: Enthusiasm

We first set foot on the grounds of PurpCo in early 2018. At that time, executives were actively brainstorming how to shape the organization's future vision and direction. Over the following months, as we became more familiar with the organization and its members, we made two key observations. First, PurpCo's members were deeply committed to creating positive societal impact

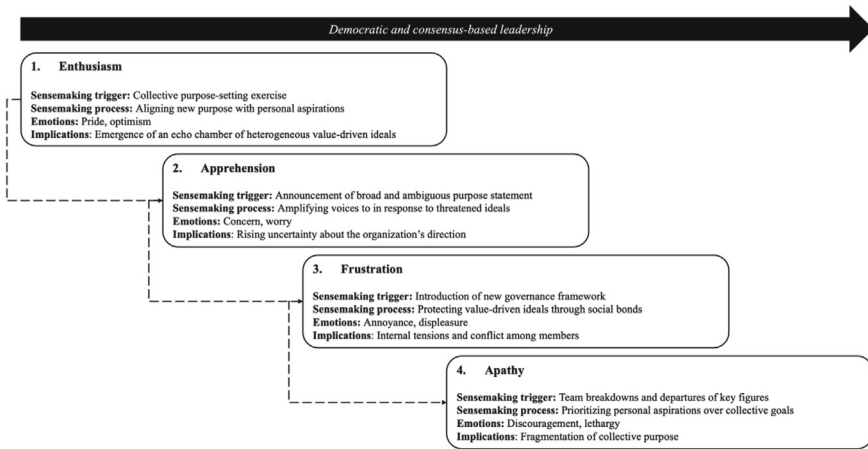


Fig. 11.1 Empirical timeline purpose trajectory PurpCo

through their work. Second, the organization operated under a highly democratic, consensus-driven leadership style. As this chapter will show, these two elements played pivotal roles in shaping PurpCo's purpose-setting trajectory.

One of the first things we noticed in our interactions with PurpCo's members was the strong emphasis they placed on generating positive impacts through their work. Both pre-merger organizations had established strong legacies in this regard, and it was clear that this commitment remained a guiding principle for PurpCo's members. In conversations, they frequently expressed deep enthusiasm for and belief in PurpCo's potential to drive meaningful change. As Mary, a communication officer at PurpCo, shared: *"You think you have met the most **passionate** person, and then the next day you are meeting someone new who is even more **passionate**. That is really **amazing** to see. No matter what we do, we are all **connected** by this ... not universal mission, but our organizational mission. It is **amazing** how **passionate** we are about that."* This passion was also reflected in how members had linked their professional roles to personal ideals. Many shared stories of choosing to work at PurpCo because it aligned with their vision for a better world. During a lunch meeting, for example, Johnny, a marketing associate, reflected on his decision to join PurpCo despite the possibility of earning a higher salary elsewhere: *"We all work at this organization for a **moral reason**."* PurpCo's members took great pride in belonging to an organization they believed mirrored their personal aspirations: the creation of societal impact.

A second important observation was PurpCo's notably democratic leadership approach. Members were regularly invited to provide feedback on organizational matters, with management placing strong emphasis on reaching

consensus-based decisions. This approach was particularly evident in how executives created space for a new shared purpose to emerge. During our time at PurpCo, we observed several employee surveys, numerous task committees, and frequent collaborative brainstorming sessions focused on purpose-setting. In line with this democratic approach, executives actively encouraged members to engage in activities they found personally meaningful. They believed this not only gave employees a voice in shaping the organization's direction, but also empowered them to take ownership of their work.

A key moment in PurpCo's purpose-setting journey occurred when executives invited staff to actively contribute to shaping the new corporate purpose, an exercise that members embraced with enthusiasm. Over the following months, several initiatives, including surveys and brainstorming sessions, were launched to gather input on PurpCo's corporate vision and future direction. These efforts aimed to explore members' perspectives on crucial questions such as "Where do we go as an organization?" and "How do we get there?" For example, survey questions included prompts like "What makes you most proud of working at PurpCo?" and "What excites you most about PurpCo's potential impact?" Similarly, we attended multiple brainstorming sessions where members were encouraged to share their aspirations for the organization. In one such session, members were asked to formulate an aspirational headline for a newspaper article about PurpCo five years into the future.

As we attended these workshops and reviewed the survey results, we observed that when members framed their input around collective goals, they often drew on their own work activities and personal aspirations. In other words, the future visions members articulated for PurpCo as an organization frequently reflected their individual roles, particularly in terms of the type of impact and beneficiaries they believed should take precedence. For example, marketing professionals emphasized "*happy customers*," commodity specialists stressed "*well-paid farmers*," and landscape experts advocated for "*more forest*." While it is natural for individuals to highlight their own areas of expertise, it was striking that the primary goal of these exercises—to establish shared collective meanings and objectives—seemed to be overshadowed by individual priorities.

Overall, the purpose-setting exercise created space for members to emphasize the importance of their own work. As they redefined the organization, their strong emotional ties to personal aspirations evolved into pride and optimism. Members believed that their contributions would not only continue to be valued but might also be prioritized in the organization's future.

There was, indeed, a notable sense of optimism about PurpCo's trajectory. Survey results showed that over 80 percent of respondents were very confident about the organization's prospects, and more than 70 percent felt they were actively contributing to shaping the new organization. The following anonymous survey response captured this sentiment: "*I am **proud** of PurpCo's work. I think this [referring to their own work activities] is **the most important aspect** of our work and I **hope** it continues (and expands) under the new organization.*"

In this first phase, the purpose-setting exercise fostered a strong sense of inclusion and optimism among PurpCo's members. It provided a platform for them to voice their personal aspirations and highlight the significance of their own work, reflecting a deep emotional investment in the organization's future. As members shared their visions, along with the belief that their contributions would shape the organization's trajectory, a sense of pride emerged. At the collective level, this created an echo chamber of voiced ideals, in which nearly everyone felt their input was not only heard but genuinely valued. While this inclusive approach boosted participation and confidence, it also began to blur the boundaries between personal values and collective purpose.

Phase 2: Apprehension

After evaluating the input provided during the purpose-setting exercises, the executives formulated a preliminary purpose statement. In line with their consensus-based decision-making approach, they crafted a statement broad enough to encompass the range of aspirations expressed by members, essentially, something along the lines of 'creating a better world'. While inclusive, this broad statement inadvertently introduced a sense of uncertainty and ambiguity. The second phase of our story reveals how, as members became increasingly aware of the diversity of ideals circulating within the organization, they also grew concerned and apprehensive about PurpCo's future and their place within it.

After leadership published the results of the surveys and workshops, along with the new preliminary purpose statement, members began to grow concerned about their colleagues' differing perspectives. Having previously been highly expressive in sharing their own ideals, they now became increasingly aware of the differing views held by others. Sam, a policy specialist, voiced this concern: "*There are people with completely different ideas, and I used to have an idea of what everyone was thinking, but now I don't. And I am **afraid** that the voices that I know and **stand behind** are diminishing.*"

Similarly, Joanna, a law associate at PurpCo, expressed frustration with the responses to a particular survey question, which asked: ‘What category best describes PurpCo?’. The responses ranged from “business-friendly NGO” to “social enterprise,” and “research organization.” Reflecting on this, Joanna remarked: “*Many of our colleagues said that we were a company-friendly NGO. To me that is **completely meaningless** because it doesn’t say anything about the work we do!*”.

Perceiving alternative ideals as a threat to their own aspirations for the organization, members responded by asserting their personal convictions with even greater intensity. This became particularly evident during an important management meeting, where managers were tasked with translating the high-level purpose statement into concrete departmental priorities. Over five consecutive days, all managers engaged in collaborative brainstorming sessions to develop these plans. Consistent with PurpCo’s democratic leadership approach, executives encouraged the group to take ownership of the process, stating: “*You know as a group what needs to be done. Work it out together.*” The only guidance provided was the newly articulated purpose statement. However, its broad and inclusive nature offered little clarity on which organizational activities should take precedence. Within this open space, managers once again emphasized the significance of their own work in relation to the broader mission, leading to rising tensions. Reflecting on the meeting, Tom, a landscape manager, recalled: “*We already got stuck at the first issue where we had to come up with some kind of mission or overall objective. Everybody started talking through each other, everyone had their **own thoughts.***” Branding managers repeatedly stressed the importance of engaging with companies and consumers, while those working with commodity farmers focused on prioritizing local interventions at the farm level. Each manager appeared concerned that, unless they asserted their perspective strongly enough, their value-driven priorities would be overlooked. As a result, instead of fostering collaborative dialogue, the brainstorming sessions generated a series of simultaneous monologues. By the end of the week, few concrete priorities had been established. The final set of objectives that the managers developed together essentially aggregated all existing activities, but without clear prioritization. Rather than co-constructing a shared vision for PurpCo’s future, the outcome was an all-encompassing strategy that functioned as a “license-to-operate” for every individual value-infused activity.

In essence, while the plurality of values initially fostered a hopeful sense that “everything is possible,” it also introduced growing uncertainty and ambiguity about PurpCo’s future. What began as an inclusive effort to engage

staff and build a shared sense of ownership gradually evolved into a confrontation with the sheer diversity of aspirations within the organization. This realization marked a shift in emotional tone: the initial optimism and pride gave way to concern and apprehension, as members began to fear that their own impact-driven ideals might be sidelined by a purpose too broad to guide meaningful action.

Phase 3: Frustration

About a year into our fieldwork, PurpCo's leadership introduced a new governance framework intended to solidify the organization's evolving structure. The framework included the creation of new departments, the appointment of new managers, and an updated approach to internal reporting and communication. Designed to align with PurpCo's democratic leadership ethos, the framework aimed to foster inclusive collaboration and consensus-building. Yet, in practice, rather than enabling smooth coordination, it amplified competition and rivalry among departments and individuals, exacerbated value clashes, and reinforced divisions as members increasingly fought for influence over the organization's direction.

While the newly implemented governance framework was intended to encourage inclusive collaboration, members began maneuvering within it to seek out like-minded allies. At a collective level, we observed how members gradually formed distinct social groupings bound by shared values and professional ideals. Individuals who had previously voiced their aspirations in personal terms (e.g., *"I feel PurpCo **should** pursue this direction ..."*) began to speak from the perspective of collective identities (e.g., *"We **believe** the **right** course for PurpCo is ..."*). These emerging factions led members to increasingly view organizational priorities through the lens of group affiliation. Comparisons between groups heightened an 'us-versus-them' atmosphere, fueling efforts to defend and promote each group's preferred direction. As Michael, a landscape officer, put it: *"That [project] is **someone else's** baby, this [project] is **our** baby."*

As dissatisfaction with the diversity of aspirations grew, members became increasingly vocal and critical. Frustrations began to center on perceived inequalities, with individuals questioning why certain groups seemed to gain more recognition or influence: *"There are **concerns** about appointments, there is this new manager with a specialization in one area, and everyone is **worried** about **the other side**"* (Magda, communications officer). The sense of division deepened as members compared each other's work styles and behaviors, often expressing irritation with opposing camps: *"At **our***

side everybody **feels free** to speak their mind about any topic, and we do. Whereas **their side** is more like ‘Oh am I allowed to say something about that?’” (Stephen, finance officer). The legitimacy of others’ contributions also came under scrutiny, with some projects dismissed as vague or irrelevant: “I am just **not sure** about some projects. It’s just so **vague**, what do they mean? **Why** do we do this? What **value** does it add?” (Richard, climate change specialist). Accusations of dominance and exclusion became common. Sarah, a landscape officer, expressed her frustration with the current status quo: “We have an **elite** of decision-makers, choices are being based on who is the **loudest**.” An anonymous comment during a staff workshop echoed similar concerns: “Does **that team** always have to **win** everything?” Rather than fostering collaboration, the governance framework had inadvertently intensified factionalism. Increasingly, members sought the comfort and affirmation of like-minded peers, reinforcing emotional bonds within their own groups. As Rose, a marketing intern, put it: “We are trying to make sure the **right people** are talking.”

By the end of the third phase, members had firmly aligned themselves with particular aspects of the organization. As group affiliations solidified, so too did their displeasure and resistance toward those with differing perspectives. Members increasingly compared achievements, questioned each other’s contributions, and scrutinized behaviors, leading to a rise in inter-group tensions. Informal conversations and gossip further amplified perceived differences, fueling an atmosphere of discord and mutual distrust. These dynamics deepened the divide that had emerged within PurpCo, leaving the organization increasingly fragmented.

Phase 4: Apathy

During the final phase, widespread distrust among individuals and groups gave way to disengagement. While some members continued to fiercely defend their value-driven beliefs, others began to emotionally—and some even physically—withdraw from the collective altogether. Several key figures left the organization during this time, citing reasons such as: “I just **don’t feel a pull** from the organization anymore,” or “The organization and I **grew apart**.” In addition to these personal departures, some teams that had once championed their purpose-driven agendas disbanded due to irreconcilable misalignments between their group’s values and the direction they felt the organization was heading. The dissolution of one task force, for example, followed a prolonged struggle to defend what members saw as the core objective of that task force. After leadership mandated a shift in focus, the team collectively chose to step down. Reflecting on the events,

Lydia, a team member, shared: “I found it **embarrassing** to do something **against my personal principles**. Well sorry, but I’m not going to do that.” These developments marked a turning point from contestation to actual retreat.

By the end of our fieldwork, the purpose-setting process had changed drastically: from initial optimism and inclusion to widespread discouragement and even lethargy. The departure of key figures, the breakdown of teams, and the enduring ambiguity surrounding PurpCo’s direction significantly eroded morale. Confidence in the organization’s capacity to define and live up to a meaningful shared purpose had diminished, with many members withdrawing from collective efforts: “Normally I’m all about tuning in with everyone, but it just **doesn’t work** anymore, so I **stopped**.” (Tina, lobbyist). With reduced belief in their ability to influence PurpCo’s direction, members redirected their energy toward protecting and enacting their personal ideals instead, an area they felt still within their control. Rather than rallying around a collective purpose, they now anchored themselves even more strongly in their own personal convictions. What had begun as a democratic exercise in shared vision-building had turned into a fragmented landscape of isolated beliefs, where engagement gave way to apathy. As Carlos, a company account officer, reflected: “It **doesn’t mean a ton to me**, hearing from someone **who doesn’t really know the work that I am doing right now**.”

This final phase of our observational period was characterized by an atmosphere in which individual preferences overshadowed collective considerations. In the absence of a shared consensus on organizational purpose, members grew increasingly apathetic toward collective goals. Many pursued their personal aspirations independently, while others chose to leave the organization entirely. What ultimately emerged was a fragmented purpose-driven organization.

Theoretical Reflections and Takeaways

The case of PurpCo helps unpack the complex dynamics of purpose-driven organizing in contexts marked by value pluralism and emotional attachment. Our case study offers two key insights. First, it illustrates that values and emotions, while powerful drivers of engagement in purpose-driven organizing, can also become sources of tension and escalation. Second, PurpCo’s trajectory underscores the critical role of intentional leadership in managing these dynamics. Without such guidance, the very mechanisms that characterize purpose-driven organizing and are meant to foster unity, such as

value-driven motivation and emotional commitment, may instead deepen internal divisions.

Values and Emotions: From Engagement to Tensions

At PurpCo, members were deeply invested in being part of a purpose-driven organization, attaching personal meaning and moral conviction to their work. While this initially fostered strong engagement, the coexistence of divergent ideals gradually gave rise to tensions, fragmentation, and ultimately, disengagement. In this way, the very forces that energized the purpose-setting process also became obstacles to shared understanding and organizational cohesion.

Our findings indicate that when diverse value systems converge—especially amid strong emotional attachment—they create interpretative complexity, heightening the potential for conflict. At PurpCo, persistent value heterogeneity surrounding the organization's purpose led members to experience growing uncertainty. Members felt personally threatened when their values appeared to be ignored or overshadowed. These tensions intensified emotional responses, which not only accompanied sensemaking but actively shaped it at both individual and group levels. In the face of this, members gravitated toward like-minded colleagues, forming social groups that served as protective spaces for shared ideals. Over time, these divisions deepened. Members began to criticize differing viewpoints and attribute “bad behaviors” to rival groups. As the prolonged lack of clarity around PurpCo's purpose wore members down, engagement with the collective began to erode. Some members retreated into personal aspirations they could control amid the ambiguity. Others, disheartened by the organization's inability to establish a unifying purpose, ultimately chose to leave the organization altogether. Throughout this escalating process, the interplay between values and emotions remained central. While pride initially fueled optimism and commitment, frustration and distrust gradually took hold as members struggled to reconcile their deeply held values with competing interpretations. Thus, the very same values that inspire engagement can, under conditions of sustained tension and threat, become powerful sources of fragmentation and disengagement.

While prior research has focused primarily on the role of either values or emotions in sensemaking in isolation (Cornelissen et al., 2014; Maitlis et al., 2013; Starbuck & Milliken, 1988; Weick, 1979, 1995), our case highlights the interplay between the two within collaborative sensemaking. Previous studies have shown that values serve as stable reference points for evaluating

what is “good” or “bad” (Kraatz et al., 2020), and that emotions can influence whether individuals act or remain passive (Maitlis et al., 2013). However, in collective settings, individuals must make sense not only of their own value systems, but also those of others, making the process inherently relational and dynamic. Indeed, prior research has shown that individuals and groups use the emotional expressions of others as interpretative cues in their own sense-making (Cornelissen et al., 2014; Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010). Through mechanisms such as ‘emotional contagion’ (Barsade, 2002), the emotions expressed by one person can unconsciously influence others, shaping group-level sensemaking (Cornelissen et al., 2014). These dynamics can significantly affect social dynamics and broader institutional processes (Voronov & Vince, 2012). We build on this perspective by showing that in settings characterized by value pluralism, individuals may respond to others’ emotional or value-laden expressions not by aligning with them, but by firmly anchoring in their own personal aspirations. By unpacking this interplay, our findings contribute to a more relational, embodied, and performative understanding of purpose-driven organizing (Espedal & Carlsen, 2023). Specifically, we highlight the dual role of emotional and value-based attachment in such contexts, as both an energizing force and a potential source of fragmentation.

This insight carries important behavioral and relational implications for organizations. When value heterogeneity is coupled with strong emotional attachments to work, it can foster the emergence of informal alliances (e.g., tight-knit social bonds among like-minded individuals) who prioritize their shared ideals over collective organizational goals. At PurpCo, this dynamic unfolded as members gravitated toward those who echoed their aspirations, leading to growing divisions, distrust, and diminished collaboration. Strong emotional attachments to personal or group values can also trigger protective behaviors, as individuals seek to defend their position and ideals. While such intense dedication may deepen personal commitment to mission-driven objectives, it can simultaneously encourage a self-centered mindset that clashes with broader collective aims. A key insight here is that the strong connection between values and emotions in collaborative sense-making can amplify polarization in contexts marked by high value heterogeneity. Emotionally charged commitments to particular ideals may entrench individuals or groups in their perspectives, making processes of consensus-building, adaptation, and integration increasingly difficult, particularly in purpose-driven organizations, where organizing is inherently value-laden and emotionally infused.

Leadership: From Unity to Fragmentation

Our case also highlights the critical role of leadership and the need for deliberate interventions within purpose-driven organizing. In contexts of high value diversity, such leadership is essential for preventing conflict and fragmentation, and for ensuring that organizations can manage internal differences without undermining their collective purpose. At PurpCo, leadership sought to unify members by fostering an inclusive and participatory environment. While this approach initially encouraged members to voice their aspirations, instilling a sense of pride, optimism, and ownership, it also revealed and amplified deeply rooted individual and group-level differences. Members interpreted PurpCo's collective objectives through the lens of their own values and work activities, resulting in a fragmented landscape of competing visions. Thus, while the participatory leadership approach was intended to cultivate enthusiasm and engagement, it inadvertently created an echo chamber of diverse, and at times conflicting, organizational aspirations.

These findings build on management studies that typically emphasize the role of leadership in instilling a unifying sense of purpose among employees (e.g., Carton, 2018; Selznick, 1957, 1996). Unlike contexts in which employees may struggle with direction or commitment, our case study of PurpCo illustrates a different challenge: members were already deeply committed to their personal ideals for the organization, shaped by their values and emotional attachment to work. This strong personal investment made aligning individual aspirations with collective goals particularly difficult. In the absence of deliberate leadership to manage these tensions, organizations risk fragmented priorities and a breakdown in cohesion as individuals and groups begin to pursue parallel, rather than shared, objectives. While prior research highlights "sensegiving" strategies such as articulating a single overarching aspiration and linking it to concrete objectives and milestones (Carton, 2018), our findings suggest that these steps alone may be insufficient in environments characterized by pronounced value heterogeneity.

In organizations where members hold diverse values and strong emotional ties to their work, as is often the case in purpose-driven organizations, effective leadership requires actively fostering alignment between personal values and collective goals, ensuring that individual aspirations do not overshadow the organization's broader mission. This involves acknowledging the emotional dimensions of employees' commitments while creating mechanisms for open dialogue and value integration. For instance, leadership can facilitate structured dialogue in which conflicting values are explicitly brought to the surface and constructively debated, rather than avoided or suppressed.

Such dialogue can also help uncover common ground across groups, fostering mutual understanding. Effective leadership also requires continuously monitoring sensemaking dynamics to detect early signs of fragmentation or conflict and intervening before tensions escalate or disengagement sets in. Ultimately, our findings underscore that instilling a sense of purpose in an organization—especially in organizations marked by value heterogeneity and emotional attachments to work—is not a one-time directive but an ongoing process. By proactively aligning personal and collective aspirations, leaders can transform potential divisions into opportunities for building a shared purpose.

Agenda for Further Research

Building on our work, future research could further investigate the interplay between values and emotions in collaborative sensemaking, particularly in the context of purpose-driven organizing as an emerging institutional form. While our study provides initial insights into how values and emotions complicate the collective construction of purpose, further inquiry is needed to understand how purpose-driven organizing becomes institutionalized over time. As such organizations continue to grow across sectors, it is important to understand how they negotiate and integrate diverse values while striving to fulfill societal missions that go beyond profit maximization.

One key area for further exploration is how purpose-driven organizations, as they become more established, interact with broader institutional contexts such as regulatory frameworks, industry standards, or cultural expectations. For instance, how do value-driven employees reconcile their values with institutionalized practices, such as formalized mission statements, strategic goals, or performance metrics? And how do emotions such as pride, frustration, or resistance shape how groups collectively respond to these institutional demands? In some cases, such institutional pressures may lead to a formalization of purpose-driven goals; in others, they may trigger resistance or emotional backlash from organizational members who feel the organization's efforts are being distorted. Understanding how institutional forces influence collective sensemaking in purpose-driven organizations could shed light on how emotional dynamics and value conflicts mediate the alignment (or misalignment) between individual aspirations and institutional expectations.

Another avenue for research is examining the dynamics of purpose-driven organizing within cross-sector collaborations. Many purpose-driven organizations partner with government agencies, non-profit organizations, or private companies, forming complex networks where multiple institutional logics

and value systems intersect. These collaborations often involve conflicting priorities, such as balancing profit motives with social impact goals, and may evoke strong emotional responses. Future research could explore how such collaborations manage value heterogeneity and emotional tensions to maintain long-term alignment toward shared societal objectives and build more resilient institutional arrangements.

Lastly, while our study concludes at the point of organizational fragmentation and disengagement, future research could explore how purpose-driven organizations recover from crises arising from internal value conflicts. Specifically, what leadership interventions can enable re-engagement and foster collective realignment after extended periods of conflict and fragmentation? And what role do emotions play in the resolution of such organizational conflicts? These questions are critical for understanding the long-term sustainability of purpose-driven organizations and their capacity to adapt to evolving societal needs and shifting expectations.

By pursuing these avenues, future research can deepen theoretical understanding of purpose-driven organizing as an emerging institutional form. It can offer valuable insights into how organizations manage the complexities of value heterogeneity and emotional attachment while striving to fulfill their societal missions. Such research can also offer practical guidance to leaders and practitioners in purpose-driven organizations, equipping them to manage emotional dynamics, foster value integration, and sustain collective engagement amid institutional pressures and evolving contexts.

Conclusion

In a world where organizations increasingly claim to pursue social, environmental, and ethical objectives alongside financial ones, understanding the emotional and value-driven processes that shape how these purposes are constructed, negotiated, and maintained is paramount. Rather than assuming that a sense of purpose naturally aligns within purpose-driven organizations, leaders must recognize the emotional stakes involved and actively work to integrate diverse value systems. Our case study of PurpCo demonstrated that purpose-driven organizations are not simply idealistic entities striving for noble causes; they are complex social systems where values, emotions, and leadership decisions intertwine in ways that influence organizational behavior and cohesion. While a corporate purpose is often framed as a unifying force, our case revealed that it can also become a site of contestation when value heterogeneity and emotional attachments collide. The

very values that inspire engagement can, under conditions of ambiguity or threat, become sources of frustration and conflict. In such settings, strong emotional attachment to personal values may give rise to counterproductive behaviors. Understanding how values and emotions interact—whether they align or clash—and what the implications of these dynamics are is crucial for grasping how meaning is constructed, how action is coordinated, and how a shared purpose is either built or broken. While leadership is often seen as aligning employees around a shared purpose, our case of PurpCo showed this is far more complex when people bring deeply rooted personal values and attachments to their work. Without deliberate leadership, these dynamics can result in fragmentation, disengagement, and diminished collaboration, ultimately undermining the organization's capacity to mobilize around a shared purpose. Purpose-driven organizations, particularly those with passionate and committed members, require leadership that continuously fosters alignment, not by suppressing differences, but by creating spaces for constructive dialogue, shared meaning-making, and adaptive governance. Foregrounding the emotional and value-laden nature of purpose, we call for a broader view of purpose-driven organizations: not merely as entities guided by vision statements, but as living social systems where purpose must be actively negotiated and sustained through belonging, identity, and commitment.

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12

Institutionalization of Compassion Through Values Work

Gry Espedal

Introduction

If I am to use a metaphor for the patient treatment here, it is that they are guides to the Big Dipper, a divine sphere....I think that the personnel at this hospice are leading me to the Big Dipper.... They let me have my two God-drinks: prosecco, gin, and tonic. I am going to have these God-drinks on my tongue when I am dying.
(Emma, terminal patient in hospice).

Manifesting compassion within organizations can be challenging, especially when it comes to recognizing and addressing individuals' needs and suffering. Nonetheless, recent academic research has highlighted the importance of organizing and fostering compassion in organizational settings (Dutton et al., 2006; Fritz & Möllering, 2025; Rynes et al., 2012). Compassion organizing is understood as a collective response to unexpected and painful events, and it occurs when individuals in an organization collectively notice, feel, and respond to people's pain in a coordinated way (Dutton et al., 2006, p. 59). The organizational context shapes compassion through conditions that encourage spontaneous acts of compassion and through the formal institutionalization of compassionate practices (Lilius et al., 2012).

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Existing studies suggest that routinizing compassionate practices can lead to institutionalized compassion by assigning roles for enacting compassion to specific people within the organization or implementing formal programs of enhancing compassion (Lilius et al., 2012). However, there is a limited understanding of how pre-existing conditions within an organization—such as values, structure, and established practices—encourage compassionate attitudes and behavior among its members.

In this chapter, I will examine how organizational conditions transform compassion from a mere emotional response into a fundamental part of an organization's social architecture through institutionalizing processes. Organizational social architecture enhances compassion competence and involves an “emergent pattern of collective noticing, feeling, and acting in an effective and customized way to alleviate suffering” (Worline & Dutton, 2017, p. 95). An example of the institutionalization process of compassion can be seen in the statement at the beginning of this chapter from a terminally ill cancer patient in hospice at a faith-based healthcare organization. Despite the patient's poor health, the professionals at the hospital allowed her to have her God-drinks on her tongue as a compassionate act in a vulnerable and terminal situation (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021). However, balancing compassion in relation to business objectives and communicating compassion in demanding organizational settings can be difficult, leading to burnout, fatigue, and resignation (McAllum et al., 2023). Challenging situations for professionals in organizations create a need to ask what factors enable a compassionate attitude to extend beyond noticing the pain, guiding professionals' work to become an institutionalized practice of alleviating suffering. Thus, in this chapter, I ask the following question: *How can attention to compassion in organizations become more than an emotion, to become part of the social architecture of organizing compassion in organizations?*

Despite advancements in understanding the evolutionary origins of compassion and strategies for fostering it (Seppälä et al., 2017), little is known of what integrates emotions and infuses values to develop institutionalized structures of compassion. One study highlights power relations and the philosophy of care in organizations as hindering or fostering the organizing of compassion (Simpson et al., 2013). Power relations are often expressed through local controls in terms of policies, procedures, rules, and informal agreements, leading to neglect and ambiguity in relation to enacting compassion in crisis situations. However, organizations that have philosophies of care are quicker to communicate with and assure their employees, even anticipating concerns before they arise. This develops a compassionate culture. Another study highlights the risk of compassion fatigue among

health-care providers (Sorenson et al., 2016). Compassion fatigue is often thought of as the caregiver's cost of caring and occurs when caregivers are exposed to repeated interactions requiring high levels of empathic engagement with distressed users. It can be a significant contributing factor in caregiver burnout.

Experiencing compassion often has a starting point in individuals' concerns. Individuals within organizations frequently face struggles for survival and dignity, whether due to disruptive events such as terrorism, environmental calamities, or personal crises like health issues or bereavement. When experienced in an organizational setting, care and compassion extend beyond mere feelings or actions with instrumental outcomes; they include expressions of values, behaviors, and societal perspectives (Nussbaum, 1996; Wuthnow, 2012).

This chapter is inspired by Nussbaum's (1996, 2003) perspectives on compassion. Nussbaum (1996) highlights compassion as a social-emotional response deeply connected to reasoning of values, emerging from our evaluations. This means compassion is not merely an emotional experience but also a reflection of the value it provides, as some kind of philosophy of care. Consequently, compassion is seen not only as a personal emotion but also as a perspective that informs institutional values (Sławiński, 2018).

Drawing on an empirical study of a faith-based healthcare organization in Norway, I explore how values and emotions drive and sustain the social architecture of organizing compassion. This healthcare organization was founded on deeply held commitments to provide skilled medical care and altruistic compassion to marginalized people. Throughout its 150-year history within the Evangelical Lutheran tradition, people within the organization have embraced and debated ideals of compassion amidst shifting regulatory demands and new challenges regarding how to respond to patient needs in care situations. This study reveals that compassion becomes institutionalized through three processes: value inquiry, time and remembering, and sacred storytelling (Espedal, 2019a). The processes are delineated across distinct articles; the present discussion simultaneously synthesizes and analyzes the findings derived from these works. The concept of value inquiry emerges as a transformative process of reasoning that critically examines practices and involves people in defining needs and experimental action (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). This approach reframes compassionate love as an ethical agency and a relational capacity for creative action aimed at the ethical pursuit of the good.

Contemporary leaders of the faith-based organization have organized compassion through processes of time and remembering by bringing forward

a legacy of compassion through institutionalized micro-processes of openness, anchoring in history, realization of values, and relational practices (Espedal, 2023). If there are no backward-leaning perspectives, there are few ways for forward compassion. This informs an institutionalized logic of compassion supported by religious and historical inspiration, expectation, and interpretation, and enacting compassion through relational work. Finally, a process of values work drives these processes of developing compassionate organizational scripts (Espedal, 2021), figuring processes of sacred stories and practices (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021). The sacred narratives recast compassionate values work as a dynamic and reflexive dialog between action and storytelling, emphasizing that compassionate attitudes and actions are realized through continual moral inquiry and caring actions.

Theorizing Institutionalized Compassion

Focusing on compassion has directed research toward understanding how feelings, actions, and context are interwoven through conditions that encourage spontaneous compassion (Lilius et al., 2012). The inquiry of compassion often has a starting point in felt pain or suffering. The pain at work does not warrant medical consultation, such as physical pain. It concerns the psychological distress that originates from circumstances, such as experiencing loss, stress, or anxiety. Examples might include a family member being diagnosed with cancer or undergoing the challenging process of divorce. Furthermore, the source of distress may also be rooted in organizational dynamics and organizational challenges in balancing everyday activities with business objectives. This may occur, for instance, when organizational members are obliged to collaborate with an employee they find disagreeable; face organizational downsizing, restructuring, and layoffs; or contend with a leader they perceive as incompetent and toxic. These situations often lead to uncertainty, pain, or suffering, necessitating reasoning, empathy, or action.

Interdisciplinary Approaches to Compassion

Discussion about the meaning of compassion as a human experience dates back over a thousand years, spanning disciplines such as religion, philosophy, and sociology (Kanov et al., 2004). The word *compassion* in Latin is compatible with the phrase “suffer with.” Compassion is most often defined as being connected to a state of concern for the suffering or unmet needs of another, often coupled with a desire to meet those needs or alleviate suffering (Goetz

et al., 2010). Within philosophy, Aristotle described the conditions needed for compassion (Aristotle's Rhetoric, in Nussbaum, 1996). Compassion is an emotion that is dependent on different requirements: if the pain is trivial, if the pain is deserved, and if the pain can happen to yourself. The reflection of these requirements can be consistent, and if it is met with compassion, it can play a significant role in personal and public life and build bridges between the individual and the community.

Religion provides a moral force to promote compassionate responses in many circumstances (Collins & Garlington, 2017). The Dalai Lama, Buddhism's leader, believes that it is in the basic nature of human beings to be compassionate, saying, "Love and compassion are necessities, not luxuries. Without them, humanity cannot survive" (Worline & Dutton, 2017, p. xii). Thus, in the Buddhist tradition, the awareness of having a compassionate mind can be a practical guide to taking action for human well-being (Jinpa, 2015). The Christian tradition teaches that compassion is an essential aspect of the condition of being human. Compassion includes a positively affective dimension toward others. In the Gospel of Luke (6:31), Jesus teaches the disciples what has been named the Golden Rule: "Do to others as you would have them do to you." The rule directs standards of care for others to be enacted as those enacting them would want for themselves. However, attending religious standards frequently does not increase compassionate feelings (Blouin et al., 2013). A critical aspect questions whether compassion is rooted in the culture of Christian societies and not only in the members' religious beliefs (Collins & Garlington, 2017).

Within sociology, Selznick (1957) draws attention to organizations as institutions where unanticipated consequences of purposive social action can occur. One way of working with unanticipated consequences is to seek the ideals of institutions and enhance other people's human well-being. Well-being involves happiness, satisfaction, and utility (Selznick, 1992). However, this approach might be latent, not necessarily expressed, acted upon, or even infused in the organization, but rather developed based on random experiences and actions.

Compassion as a Way of Reasoning

Nussbaum (1996) highlights compassion as a social emotion that is deeply connected to values and that emerges from evaluations. This means compassion is not merely an emotional experience but a reflection of the value it provides. Consequently, compassion is not only seen as a personal emotion but also as a perspective that informs institutional values (Sławiński, 2018),

for instance values of care. The emotion of pain involves reflecting on what it is like to have pain. On the one hand, it involves thinking through the pity the other feels, the suffering the pain causes, and how it affects the sufferer's daily needs. It also includes thinking about how that person survives. On the other hand, it involves questions on how it would be for the observer to experience the same pain. Would they similarly experience the pain? How would they respond?

Nussbaum also highlights how compassionate reasoning plays a pivotal role in building community. This process can be understood through the values it encompasses. It emerges from addressing normative questions and engages evaluatively with the world beyond itself. It is less about holding particular beliefs and more about participating in the environment as an ethical agent (Nussbaum, 2003). The cognitive aspect of compassion is triggered by recognizing another's "undeserved misfortune" (Nussbaum, 2003, p. 301) and revolves around values such as acknowledging the situation's impact on the other person's well-being, understanding responsibility and blame, and anticipating the misfortune the situation might cause.

The Academic Field of Organizing Compassion

This initial recognition of suffering and pain within organizations and personal lives has driven a call to incorporate compassion into organizational and management studies. Peter Frost (1999) pioneered this appeal for enacting compassion in organizational contexts, emphasizing that organizations can be rife with pain. Individuals often struggle for survival and dignity in the workplace, prompting researchers to investigate how organizations address these challenges. What occurs in organizations when members face disruptive or threatening situations or experience personal loss? How are organizational responses to suffering structured, and why does compassion manifest in specific organizational settings but not in others? These questions are particularly pertinent because many organizational members are uncertain about how to respond when they become aware of another person's pain (Kanov et al., 2017).

Indeterminate situations have led researchers into an academic field of organizing compassion (Dutton et al., 2006; Kanov et al., 2004, 2017; Lilius et al., 2011, 2012). Organizing compassion was first identified as a theory by Dutton et al. (2006). The question of how organizations organize their responses to the pain of their members is at the core of the theory. Thus, organizing compassion is defined as the collective response to unexpected and painful events (Dutton et al., 2006, p. 59). Compassion manifests itself when

sub-processes are enacted, such as noticing another's suffering, feeling empathetic concern for people who are suffering, and responding to others' pain (Kanov et al., 2004).

Approaching others with empathetic understanding means showing an understanding of their feelings (Goetz & Simon-Thomas, 2017). Examples of situations causing pain include the recent COVID-19 pandemic or other natural disasters, like floods, earthquakes, or hurricanes, or personal tragedies, such as death, illness, or divorce (Dutton et al., 2006; Simpson et al., 2013, 2022). The emergence of the work of organizing these situations has been described as forming a social architecture in an organization. This social architecture involves an organization's compassion competence: how they balance organizational objectives with collectively noticing, feeling, and acting in effective and customized ways to alleviate suffering (Worline & Dutton, 2017, p. 95).

The Institutionalization of Organizing Compassion

In the literature, the mechanism of institutionalizing processes of organizing compassion has been identified as having two different forms: designated roles and formal programs (Lilius et al., 2012). Efforts have been made to determine if compassion can be trained (Goetz & Simon-Thomas, 2017) and how it leads to institutionalization processes, exploring the conditions that influence compassion among providers, recipients, and broader organizational contexts (Delbecq, 2010).

Designated roles can be created and assigned to organizational members to care for those who are suffering. These could be patient advocates in hospital settings (Heaphy, 2008) or customer service representatives in call centers (Totterdell & Holman, 2003). Recently, authentic leadership has been emphasized as a proactive leadership role that enhances compassion at work (Hu et al., 2018). The study shows that compassion at work has a moderating effect on the positive relationship between authentic leaders and subordinate psychological capital and proactive behavior. However, other research shows that compassion has a lesser positive influence than authentic leadership on outcomes, with the exception of economic performance (Kelly et al., 2022).

Formal programs that systematize the process of compassion come in several forms. Some programs facilitate peer-to-peer support as a means of facilitating and delivering compassion. This can be a union member assistance program or an employee support program that strengthens commitment by enabling employees to give support (Lilius et al., 2012). One study investigated whether compassion could be increased among managers by improving

their emotional skills. The results showed a significantly increased sense of emotional skills, with some evidence of an improved sense of compassion (Paakkanen et al., 2021). Another study presents the role of compassion in refiguring a university (Lawrence, 2021). Critically probing organizational values and mission statements posits compassion as a value at the forefront for building affiliative community development programs. The launched programs aim to facilitate and routinize, detect, and respond to employee pain in ways that minimize employees' impairment on the job. However, the effectiveness of these programs varies.

One challenge is to explore not only how compassion can promote personal well-being in programs but also how it can counteract the destructive aspects of personal motives and social mentalities. Thus, a darker side of compassion is often connected to empathy (Gilbert, 2015). Actual self-interest is not straightforward, nor does it follow a single or universal standard, so a perspective can be a projection on the part of the observer. Without this projection and sharing of self-interest, the observer can easily slide into a state of uninvolved apathy (Breithaupt, 2019). Additionally, toxic positivity as an exchange between a giver and receiver, with the receiver experiencing negative outcomes, can be experienced in organizations, making it necessary to look for dynamics that focus on resilience and authentic compassion (Shipp & Hall, 2024).

Integrating Reasoning with Organizing Compassion

In this chapter, I explore how institutionalized values might gauge the customization of compassion (Dutton et al., 2006). This research leans on the work of Nussbaum, who reflects on compassion as a social-emotional response to alleviating suffering involving a form of reasoning. The legacy of Nussbaum, as well as that of Worline and Dutton, can provide valuable insights into how values can enhance an overarching understanding of mechanisms that enhance what I call *compassion-in-work* in organizations. I am here leaning on a recent trajectory on “values work” (Gehman et al., 2013; Selznick, 1957) that has taken important steps toward exploring performative work on values in organizations. Values are located in the concreteness of performed practices and their changing concerns as that which “articulate and accomplish what is normatively right or wrong, good or bad, for its own sake” (Gehman et al., 2013, p. 84). Values are understood as ideas about the good life (Morris, 1956) or concern things “worth having, doing and being” (Selznick, 1992, p. 60). Collective values can be experienced as diffuse and hard to grasp. However, consciousness of values can infuse daily routines with

a sense of purpose (Espedal & Elter, 2024; Kraatz et al., 2020). Studies of values work have investigated the maintenance of professional values (Wright et al., 2021; Wright et al., 2017), how values are transmitted through generations (Suddaby et al., 2023a, 2023b), or mobilizing social entrepreneurship (Chatterjee et al., 2021) and social change (Daskalaki et al., 2018). How compassion becomes institutionalized through organizational values work is rarely emphasized in the literature. Thus, I ask how compassion becomes more than an emotion to become part of the social architecture of values work in an organization.

Methodological Approaches Taken

This chapter originated from a broader study focusing on values work within a privately owned, non-profit, faith-based hospital. This particular faith-based hospital has operated for 150 years with persistent attention to values-related concerns, offering a compelling context for this study. The hospital serves as a typified example of a non-governmental, religious organization that functions independently and non-profitably, aimed at serving the common good. Over the years, the hospital has emphasized core values such as compassion and quality. By examining how these values are worked on, insights have been gained into processes that foster the institutionalization of compassion. Thus, this chapter is a condensed learning on the actions and practices that give insight into institutionalizing processes of organizing compassion despite a challenging hybrid context of the organization, balancing demands from the public health-care sector, and having a long tradition of serving people with compassion. Exploring how the different religious beliefs of organizational members affect compassionate work is not part of the study.

This work comprises three sub-studies. The first identifies how discovery-oriented processes of values inquiry form organizational values work involving reflection and the reasoning of compassion (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). The second identifies how investigating time and the remembering processes identify an institutional logic of compassion (Espedal, 2019b) and organizational purposes of enacting compassionate (Espedal, 2023). This institutional logic of compassion is reactivated through institutionalized religious scripts (Espedal, 2021). The third sub-study identifies how work on values in the organization is infused by processes of sacred storytelling that refigure organizational practices (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021). Overall, these processes indicate mechanisms that institutionalize the reasoning of compassion in organizations.

In this chapter, I will integrate the insights gained from these studies to conceptualize and extend research on institutionalized compassion. In addition to the mentioned studies, I have conducted a narrative literature review to establish critical distance and give a broader perspective on the findings (Bryman, 2016). The keywords for the search were *values*, *emotions*, *compassion*, and *institutionalization*. The review provides a comprehensive overview of the field, offering a thorough assessment and critical interpretation of the sub-studies.

Institutionalized Compassion

In order to investigate how compassion moves beyond enacted emotion to become part of the social architecture and values work of an organization, I use the original concept of compassion-in-work. Compassion-in-work identifies how pre-existing conditions within an organization—such as values, structure, and established practices—encourage a compassionate attitude and behavior among its members. This work develops social-emotional responses that are deeply connected to the reasoning of compassion, emerging from evaluations and leading to compassion practice. Compassion-in-work is enhanced through three processes: values inquiry, time and remembering, and sacred storytelling. The institutionalized organization of compassion will be presented through the discovery processes of value inquiry, as part of remembering a values-based legacy, and as figuring the sacred in stories and practices reaching beyond everyday life.

The Discovery-oriented Process of Value Inquiry. Much research on values in organizations has followed a linear sequence in which values in the form of core values are investigated in relation to how they are implemented and influence practice. For instance, Gehman et al. (2013) imply a sequence in which values, in the form of an honor code, emerge in response to concerns and become formalized in practice. Another study investigates how professionals mobilize institutional maintenance through collective action when important values are compromised (Wright et al., 2017). These studies emphasize performative values work (Gehman et al., 2013) located in the concreteness of performed practices and changing concerns (Gehman, 2021; Selznick, 2008).

With inspiration from Dewey (1939), in the first study, we developed the notion of value inquiry (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). We found that recent research lacked an account of the primacy of the troublesome situation as the driver of values work in terms of being the originating source of interest and

desire. Instead, we found processes of value inquiry providing the basis for understanding and developing organizational ethics and practices.

A language of creative discovery enriches research occupied with valuation and values work and desires for transformation. Such a language is key to understanding attention and ethics as responsive and emergent, from dealing with people's needs in precarious situations to marking a creative and critical force of action. The value inquiry process includes discovery-oriented phases of asking reflective questions and phases of establishing transformative acts forming creative desires in troublesome situations. This approach includes a notion of there being pain and suffering in the community (the discovery phase in troublesome situations). It also involves asking self-reflecting questions on whether what we are doing is reaching those we are here for. Thus, this becomes a critical examination of previous practice and enlisting people in co-defining needs that engage them in sustained experimental action (transformation). Thus, value inquiry processes become a fruitful and powerful process to move beyond prescriptive value conceptions and into creative approaches for noticing pain and discovering actions to alleviate suffering (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024).

Remembering a Values-Based Legacy Through Time

In recent years, there has been a notable resurgence of research on organizational memory, focusing on memories shaped by current and future decision-making (Foroughi et al., 2020). The literature emphasizes the significance of acknowledging the role of the past in organizational dynamics. Various approaches, including functional, interpretive, critical, and performative approaches, are used to examine the processes involved in organizational memory (Foroughi et al., 2020). Despite the importance of understanding the components that shape an organizational legacy, there is limited research on the work of remembering values and compassionate activities, particularly when organizational purposes drift (Espedal, 2023).

In one study, I found that values work, including attention to compassion, was brought forward at the faith-based organization in contemporary leaders' work of maintaining and bringing forward the organization's values-based legacy through broader processes (Espedal, 2023). The work was based on the four micro-processes of openness, anchoring the practice in history, realization of values, and relational practices. The faith-based case organization investigated had, through the years, endorsed nursing as compassionate Christian work, emphasizing that the deaconesses and nurses' work was to practice mercy and compassionate love when caring for the sick and the

marginalized. Treating patients and employees with compassion and quality led to realizing values and circulating values discourses on patient worth and the lengths of patient stays in the hospital. The micro-processes were enhanced by religious and historical inspiration, stimulating expectation and interpretation processes and enacting compassion and quality work through relational practices. A critical factor of this work emerged as self-proclaimed dutifulness that in some ways worked against the remembering process of the purpose (Espedal, 2023).

In another study, the micro-processes that enact compassionate care were identified as “the institutional logic of compassion” (Espedal, 2019b). Here, the study identified the internal processes of Christian compassion work through the lens of the academic trajectory of institutional logic. Studying logics within organizations provided insight not only into the effect of shifts in the dominant logic, with implications for plural logics and organizational responses to institutional complexity (Lounsbury & Boxenbaum, 2013), but also into the driving forces that establish the social order (Friedland & Alford, 1991). The study identified the logic of compassion-in-work as constructed and conveyed by the three complementary processes of institutional believing, material practicing, and moral reasoning. Institutional believing is the process of the material practice of compassion and the recurring process of turning to values and ethical reflections to provide moral reasoning for the logic of compassion. The process of material practicing is carried by a strong expectation of engaging in social relations that involve reaching out to people in need. The process of moral reasoning is carried by ethical reflection on what is morally good.

The institutional logic of compassion has, through the years, influenced the case organization’s organizational script, which is understood as observable, recurrent activities and patterns of interaction in a particular setting (Barley & Tolbert, 1997, p. 98). This process must acknowledge religious history, noticing pain, and enacted ethical spirituality, identified in one study as developing the scripts forming compassionate behavior (Espedal, 2021). The institutional context and the emotional experiences of pain, suffering, and inequality were framed by organizational activities to reproduce and replicate the organizational scripts and the moral engagement of reaching the sick and marginalized. The emotions of compassion triggered these micro-processes, including noticing pain and establishing a normative social purpose (Nilsson, 2015) of caring. The emotions of compassion were tied to behaviors influenced by the social context in which it occurred (Voronov & Vince, 2012).

Figuring the Sacred in Stories and Practices Reaching Beyond Everyday Life

In the final sub-study, we investigated storytelling and organizational practices in the faith-based organization as potentially salient yet under-researched realms of compassionate values work (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021). We drew inspiration from Ricoeur's (1995) concept of figuring the sacred through symbolic resources and significant behavior. By *sacred*, we mean something within the realm of human ideals and values that people "set apart" (Anttonen, 2009, p. 42) to grant special significance as "inviolable" or "untouchable" (Harrison et al., 2009, p. 227). The term *figuring* is particularly important as it extends to both discourse and practice. Ricoeur uses *figuring* to attend to and theorize about how people engage with the sacred, sometimes in ways outside of direct access or control.

We also invoked the Ricoeurian notion of triple mimesis: the mutual imitation of action and narrative (Carlsen, 2016; Cunliffe et al., 2004; Ricoeur, 1984). We used this notion to explore first how the sacred in the case organization is prefigured in documents, parables, and stories, second, how it is explicitly configured in the act of making sense of everyday experiences, which may result in, third, a refiguring of values as organization members return from narrative to action.

The figuring of stories and practice was found in two tales that were consistently lived and told: the parable of the Good Samaritan and the legacy bestowed by the case organization's founder. The founder laid the groundwork for nursing as a nationwide field of professional practice and was deeply engaged in fostering nursing behaviors and the attitudes of enabling compassionate care for the marginalized, as well as treating others in a considerate and altruistic manner. The Good Samaritan is a parable from the Bible of a man not passing by a wounded and robbed man. The Samaritan bandages his wounds and takes him to an inn for people to care for him.

The figuring of the sacred in the story and the action of the organization's members recast compassion-in-work from a centralized and unitary process to a two-way learning dialectic between the ongoing creative imitation of action and narrative. Values in the shape of stories of the sacred did not achieve their meaning as unchangeable cores or sanctioned beliefs. Rather, they came to life through ongoing moral inquiry that co-evolved with moral agencies. In the latter regard, the sacred primarily was manifested in everyday work through questioning and creative acts of care.

Discussing Institutionalized Compassion

I initially posed the question of how compassion in organizations can become more than an emotion to be integrated with the social architecture that institutionalizes values work in organizations. To address this question, I will outline the implications of how compassion becomes institutionalized through processes of values inquiry, time and remembering, and sacred storytelling as part of the social architecture—a framework that enhances compassion competence (Worline and Dutton (2017)). To explore mechanisms of noticing, feeling, and acting on compassion as a way to engage in compassion-in-work that alleviates suffering, I will draw on Nussbaum's orientation toward compassion and ask the institutionalizing question posed by Selznick (2015): What are the puzzles that organizing compassion creates for the lives of organizational members? Thus, I will identify three mechanisms through which compassion becomes institutionalized: as a form of reasoning, as part of social-emotional responses, and as bridging connections between individuals and the community.

Compassion as a Form of Reasoning

Conditions that influence compassion among providers, recipients, and the broader organization come in two different forms: through designated roles and through formal programs (Delbecq, 2010; Lilius et al., 2012). However, in this study, I expand these mechanisms of institutionalizing compassion to include processes of value inquiry, time and remembering, and sacred storytelling. The process of value inquiry leans on the pragmatist perspectives of Dewey (1939), recognizing the troublesome situation as the originating force of desire by explicitly and repeatedly rejecting the notion that values as such should be original in the sense of being taken as starting points for valuation. Valuation, instead, arises from inquiry into specific means-end relationships. Realized ends become stepping stones to further discovery of whether something is good and how good it is. From this perspective, a value such as care or compassion achieves meaning not as a set of fixed objective standards independent of situations. Rather, it emerges from people's reflections on specific courses of action in specific troublesome situations in their interactional contexts (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024).

This identification of values as forms of verbs and not as nouns resonates with Nussbaum's (1996) conceptualization, highlighting the reasoning of compassion as involving the end-reflection on the pity that others feel, the

pain that suffering causes, and how it would be for the observer to experience this. Thus, according to Nussbaum (1996, p. 28), compassion is a sort of reasoning. It involves a reflection of the well-being of others. Compassion serves not only as an emotional response but also as a value-based judgment. It is less about holding particular beliefs and more about participating in the environment as an ethical agent (Nussbaum, 2003). The participation can take the form of processes of discovery or asking questions inquiring about the good (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024), especially in difficult situations in which organizational objectives are threatened and there is a chance of compassion fatigue. Nussbaum conceives compassion as a set of judgments regarding the seriousness of loss, responsibility, and concern for others (Sławiński, 2018). Consequently, compassion is not only a personal and social emotion but also a perspective that informs institutional principles. These principles incorporate reflections and questions (discovery) to find the appropriate determinate and pragmatic actions to alleviate suffering (transformative).

Compassion as Social-Emotional Responses

Nussbaum (1996) highlights compassion as a social emotion deeply connected to values emerging from the evaluations. This means compassion is not merely an emotional experience but also a social reflection of the values it provides. Even though organizing compassion has been identified as paying attention to how situations can be painful and finding structures to alleviate suffering, attention to compassion can also lead to situations of either “benevolent compassion” or even “malevolent compassion,” in which compassion is used as a way of gaining something, whether it is a higher social outreach or materialistic goals (Garber, 2014, p. 15), or to inform the higher levels of political goals (Sławiński, 2018). In some situations, what is not compassionate is more straightforwardly defined than what is compassionate.

Selznick (1957) would find this benevolent work challenging because most of our actions occur as planned and are connected to the contexts in which we operate. Our actions are not context-free (Selznick, 1949) but can occur as unanticipated consequences of purposive social practices. Here, the time and history of an organization can play a role. Organizations are or can be battle-grounds where different perspectives on collective memory are contested and clash (Suddaby et al., 2023a, 2023b). The process of remembering the organization’s motto as a way of recontextualizing the past, as well as the leaders’ role in recalling values, becomes important, albeit challenging. In healthcare settings, this can be experienced as toxic positivity (Shipp & Hall, 2024) or even compassion fatigue (Sorenson et al., 2016). Thus, the ability to define

history holds a significant influence. In these situations, it becomes apparent to identify and pay attention to the emotional and values-oriented processes inherent in institutional micro-dynamics that play roles in shaping human behavior (Zietsma et al., 2019), as well as how they infuse organizations (Selznick, 1957) and connect to ongoing values work in organizations.

How an organization institutionalizes compassion thus includes an aspect of power (Simpson et al., 2013) and the micro-dynamics of both emotions and values work in the organization. Finding ways to organize compassion becomes a social-emotional response, including specific mechanisms that infuse organizations with values for the common good. In this work, time and remembering values-based legacies can be important (Espedal, 2023). The micro-processes of organizing compassion can include mechanisms such as religious and historical inspiration, processes of expectation and interpretation, and enacting compassion and quality through relational work. The work of remembering institutional values can establish a moral awareness and ethical sensitivity in an organization, for instance, toward the maintenance of compassionate missions and scripts of reaching out to marginalized patients (Espedal, 2023).

Compassion Building a Bridge Between Individuals and the Community

Nussbaum highlights how compassionate reasoning plays a pivotal role in building community. Compassion involves experiencing a painful emotion triggered by recognizing another's "undeserved misfortune" (Nussbaum, 2003, p. 301). It emerges from addressing normative questions and engaging evaluatively with the world beyond itself. Research on compassion at work has focused on the changes it makes by investigating untapped organizational capability, fostering a climate of workplace forgiveness, and facilitating the development of social entrepreneurship (Avramchuk et al., 2013).

The leader's role has been found to be relevant in legitimizing the influence of compassion in an organization (Worline & Dutton, 2017). Compassionate leadership behavior has been conceived as a new construct to take note of (Shuck et al., 2019), connected to ethical leadership (Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara & Viera-Armas, 2019). Crises and complex situations such as the COVID-19 pandemic have forced leaders to react rapidly and with care (Tomkins & Simpson, 2017) to attend to unstable situations by developing community-oriented support (Espedal et al., 2023). For example, New Zealand's former Prime Minister Jacinda Ardern is described in one study as

recognized for her compassionate leadership, frequently in paradoxical terms as strong and compassionate (Simpson et al., 2022).

Krause et al. (2023) build on Simpson et al. (2022), investigating power dynamics and the effects of compassionate leadership by taking the perspectives of both leaders and organizational members to identify paradoxical challenges. These paradoxes can, for instance, be challenges connected to showing the vulnerable, private self versus showing the strong, professional self; empathetic understandings versus discerning understandings; the imperative for compassion toward one sufferer versus the imperative for equality and fairness toward the rest of the team; and finally, compassionate leader behavior as a sign of weakness versus as requiring courage.

This study add the organizational practice of leaders of storytelling as a refiguring of organizational values, turning organization members from narratives toward action (Espedal & Carlsen, 2021). By emphasizing symbolic resources and significant behavior through sacred stories and practices, it is possible to build bridges toward the realm of human ideals and values that people “set apart” (Anttonen, 2000, p. 42). Storytelling is a process of making sense of everyday experiences, resulting in doing compassion-in-work to develop moral standards and communities (Selznick, 1992) that builds a bridge between individuals and the concerns of the communities.

Future Research

Several researchers have emphasized the need for a consensual and more precise definition of enacting compassion on an organizational level (Cameron, 2017). Thus, research has only scratched the surface by examining the various indicators and mechanisms of work on compassion in organizations. In future research, it is essential to explore the mechanisms that institutionalize compassion within organizations. A deeper understanding of organizing compassion is necessary, particularly by examining the types of inquiries that drive value-based investigations within organizations and the processes through which the reasoning behind compassion becomes institutionalized. Research should focus on how compassion embodies the micro-dynamics of both emotion and values work within organizations. For instance, it will be important to investigate how organizing compassion evolves into a social-emotional response and the mechanisms that infuse an organization with values oriented toward the common good. Future studies should prioritize the importance of time and the remembrance of a values-based legacy. Moreover, additional research is needed to examine how organizational compassion fosters connections between individuals and

communities. This could involve analyzing compassionate leadership through the lens of power dynamics and effects, as well as in relation to ethical leadership, considering the perspectives of both leaders and members. This could also involve addressing the questions of who benefits from certain knowledge and the role that narratives play in the process of enhancing good or bad compassionate actions.

Concluding Remarks

I conclude this chapter with a quotation from the same terminally ill patient in hospice care who introduced this chapter. She expressed a desire for visits from hospital clowns, rather than ministers, during her stay in the faith-based hospital. She stated, “They came, and it was so much fun. We danced a tango in bed as much as I could bear. It gave me energy for many days afterward. I’d rather have visits from clowns than ministers. I am done talking about existential matters.” Her words exemplify the value inquiry undertaken by professionals to alleviate her suffering in a challenging context. Her case underscores the long-standing institutionalization of compassion within the organization. It reveals the rationale employed by professionals in the faith-based institution, prioritizing her need to meet with clowns instead of ministers. This scenario highlights the awareness of the patient’s suffering, demonstrating how organizational practices were able to set aside religious principles to embrace compassionate care in a healthcare context. The hospital focused on compassion as an organizational objective. Through this process, a deeper integration of values within the organizational structure was opened, fostering connections that extend the boundaries of compassion.

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13

Artificial Empathy: Evaluating AI Emotional Support Systems in Organizations

Fares Ahmad and Nelson Phillips

Introduction

“ChatGPT has helped me emotionally and it’s kind of scary. Recently I was even crying after something happened, and I instinctively opened up ChatGPT because I had no one to talk to about it. I just needed validation and care and to feel understood, and ChatGPT was somehow able to explain what I felt when even I couldn’t” (Yin et al., 2024). These words, from a Reddit user, reflect a profound new reality: AI systems are becoming effective emotional companions for many people worldwide.

In China, 28-year-old Holly Wang conducts nightly “therapy sessions” with DeepSeek, an AI chatbot that has moved her to tears with its responses. “DeepSeek has been such an amazing counsellor. It has helped me look at things from different perspectives and does a better job than the paid counselling services I have tried” (Ng, 2025). This isn’t science fiction—it’s happening now, as millions turn to AI for emotional connection and support.

Recent scientific research confirms this emerging dynamic. In a groundbreaking study, Hatch et al. (2025) found that AI-generated messages actually made recipients feel more heard than human-generated ones. The machine

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demonstrated “superior discipline in offering emotional support,” a crucial element in making people feel heard. Even more striking, when therapists and ChatGPT both responded to therapeutic vignettes about couples therapy, participants rarely distinguished between the two, and the AI responses were generally rated higher in terms of applying key psychotherapy principles.

Such evidence compels us to reconsider the role of emotional support within organizational theory, where the intersection of emotions and organizations has emerged as a vibrant area of scholarly inquiry. Scholars like Ashforth and Humphrey (1995) have demonstrated that emotions are not merely individual experiences, but are deeply woven into organizational life, shaping workplace behaviors, decision-making processes, and interpersonal dynamics. Within this evolving landscape, generative artificial intelligence has emerged as a provocative new frontier not because AI systems feel emotions themselves—they don’t—but because they significantly impact how humans experience and process emotions in workplace settings (Pawar et al., 2024; Piispanen & Rousi, 2024). Potential organizational applications include AI-facilitated performance feedback sessions, emotional check-ins during periods of change, and tools designed to help managers initiate and navigate emotionally charged conversations (Ahmad & Leonardi, 2025). We refer to this growing family of specialized generative AI as *AI emotional support systems*.

What makes this phenomenon particularly intriguing is that while these AI systems lack genuine emotion and authentic experience, they can nonetheless create experiences that people perceive as empathetic and supportive (Yin et al., 2024). Users often report meaningful connections with generative AI systems designed for emotional support (Hatch et al., 2025), raising important questions about how these technologies might reshape organizational approaches to emotion management. By emotion management, we refer specifically to the organizational practices through which emotions are recognized, regulated, and utilized—including conflict resolution, stress management, and mental wellness initiatives. The impact extends beyond individual mental health to potentially influence organizational resilience and performance, as employees who feel emotionally supported typically demonstrate greater engagement, productivity, and commitment to organizational goals.

At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that the impact and implementation of these AI emotional support systems are fundamentally mediated by their institutional contexts, which serve as antecedents that guide technology implementation, user expectations, and patterns of interaction. In other words, institutional norms, values, and practices create distinct frameworks that influence both how organizations deploy these technologies and

how individuals respond to them. For instance, the implementation and reception of AI-driven emotional support may differ substantially between technology-focused organizations where AI integration is normalized and healthcare settings where human touch is traditionally paramount. These institutionalized expectations shape not only the adoption of AI systems but also determine the boundaries of acceptable AI intervention in emotional domains. These boundaries reflect deeper value conflicts between technological efficiency and human authenticity, between organizational productivity and individual dignity, and between innovation and tradition. As institutions grapple with AI emotional support, they must negotiate competing value systems that shape both implementation decisions and user acceptance.

The intersection of institutions, emotions, values, and organizational well-being thus presents both opportunities and challenges. While emotional elements such as trust, empathy, and authenticity remain fundamental to organizational functioning, the integration of AI emotional support systems into emotion management processes introduces complex considerations about authenticity, privacy, and potential impacts on organizational culture. Whether users find AI systems “creepy” or helpful, intrusive or supportive, depends in large part on the institutionalized expectations within specific contexts—and these expectations themselves are evolving as AI becomes more embedded in organizational life.

To better understand these complex dynamics, we examine these relationships through the lens of Carl Rogers’ person-centered approach, exploring how AI emotional support systems might embody—or fail to embody—core elements of empathy, authenticity, and unconditional positive regard. Our analysis unfolds across three main sections: first, examining Rogers’ conditions for therapeutic change and analyzing generative AI’s capacity to foster these conditions; second, investigating challenges including creepiness, surveillance, and organizational resistance within their institutional contexts; and, finally, considering broader implications for institutional theory, the study of emotions in organizations, and AI research. Through this structured exploration, the chapter aims to contribute to our understanding of how technological innovations intersect with fundamental human needs in institutional settings, potentially reshaping both individual experiences and organizational practices.

The selection of Rogers’ person-centered framework as our analytical lens is particularly powerful when combined with institutional perspectives on organizational life. Rogers’ conditions for therapeutic change—psychological contact, client incongruence, therapist congruence, unconditional

positive regard, empathy, and client perception—intersect directly with institutional values, norms, and legitimacy concerns in organizational settings. For instance, Rogers' emphasis on congruence (authentic alignment between internal experience and external expression) parallels institutional theory's focus on legitimacy and the alignment between stated values and actual practices. Similarly, unconditional positive regard in Rogers' framework raises critical questions about power dynamics and surveillance within institutional hierarchies. By examining AI-driven emotional support through this integrated lens, we can better understand how technological innovations both challenge and potentially transform institutional approaches to emotional connection, authenticity, and care in organizational life.

AI Emotional Support Systems and Person-Centered Therapy

Carl Rogers revolutionized the field of psychotherapy through his development of person-centered therapy, an approach that places the therapeutic relationship at the heart of psychological healing (Rogers, 1951, 1961). His framework, developed in the mid-twentieth century, represents one of the most influential and widely adopted approaches in mental health practice, serving as a foundation for numerous contemporary therapeutic modalities. The selection of Rogers' framework for examining AI's potential in emotional support is appropriate for several reasons. First, person-centered therapy is widely regarded as one of the most empirically validated approaches to mental health support, with its principles being incorporated into many contemporary therapeutic practices. Second, and perhaps most critically, it is often considered the most fundamentally “human” of therapeutic approaches, emphasizing authentic connection and genuine presence—qualities that, at first glance, might seem difficult, if not impossible, for artificial intelligence to replicate (Rogers, 1980).

Unlike behaviorist or psychoanalytic approaches that position the therapist as an expert interpreter or behavior modifier, Rogers' humanistic framework deliberately centers human connection as the primary healing mechanism (Kirschenbaum, 2009). His radical departure from the mechanistic paradigms of his time is evident in his three core conditions—empathy, unconditional positive regard, and congruence—which all prioritize human qualities over technical interventions (Thorne & Sanders, 2012). As Rogers himself articulated, “It is the quality of the interpersonal encounter with the client which is the most significant element in determining effectiveness”

(Rogers, 1967, p. 27). The American Psychological Association's Division of Humanistic Psychology has consistently recognized Rogers' approach as the cornerstone of humanistic psychology, precisely because it elevates authentic human presence above technique or theory (Cain, 2016; DeCarvalho, 1991).

At the core of Rogers' approach lies the actualizing tendency—the belief that every individual possesses an inherent drive toward growth, development, and the fulfillment of their potential (Rogers, 1951, 1961). This fundamental concept suggests that given the right environmental conditions, people naturally move toward psychological well-being and self-improvement. In therapeutic settings, this manifests as a trust in the client's capacity to find their own solutions and direction, with the therapist's role being to create conditions that facilitate this natural growth process. This raises intriguing questions about how AI systems might support or hinder this natural tendency toward growth and self-actualization. Rogers' framework also emphasizes the phenomenological perspective, which holds that reality is uniquely perceived and understood through each person's lived experience (Rogers, 1980). The therapist's role becomes one of entering and understanding the client's subjective world without judgment or interpretation. This deep respect for individual perspective challenges traditional notions of objective reality. Moreover, the non-directive approach represents perhaps the most distinct aspect of Rogers' methodology (Rogers, 1957). Unlike more prescriptive forms of therapy, person-centered therapy avoids giving direct advice or solutions, instead trusting in the client's capacity to find their own path forward. The therapist's role is to facilitate exploration and discovery rather than to guide or instruct.

These elements of Rogers' framework have found resonance not only in psychotherapy but also in management and organization studies (Roberts, 2007), particularly in research on emotional labor (Grandey, 2003), authentic leadership (Gardner et al., 2005), and creating psychologically safe work environments (Edmondson, 1999). For instance, the actualizing tendency aligns with self-determination theory in management research, which suggests that employees perform better when their autonomy, competence, and relatedness are supported (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Similarly, the phenomenological perspective parallels organizational studies on emotional authenticity and the recognition of subjective experiences in leadership (Gardner et al., 2005).

Humanistic management, a growing field within organizational studies, has particularly strong connections to Rogers' person-centered approach. This research stream focuses on human dignity, ethical leadership, and values-based management (Daley, 1986; Pirson, 2017), aligning directly with

Rogerian principles of empathy, self-actualization, and authentic relationships. For example, Michael Pirson's (2017) work on humanistic management as an alternative to economistic paradigms emphasizes the importance of prioritizing human dignity and well-being in organizational contexts, much as Rogers prioritized the client's inherent worth in therapeutic relationships. Similarly, Wooten and Crane (2004) examine how humanistic work ideology in healthcare organizations fosters trust, compassion, and emotional intelligence—elements that parallel Rogers' emphasis on authentic presence and empathetic understanding.

The work of organizational scholars like Peter Frost on toxin handlers and compassionate leadership also draws on similar themes of empathy and emotional attunement that are central to Rogers' approach (Frost, 2003, 2007). Frost's concept of "toxin handlers"—individuals who absorb and manage emotional distress in organizations—echoes the Rogerian emphasis on providing empathetic space for emotional processing. This foundational work paved the way for systematic study of compassion in organizations, with scholars developing frameworks for compassion organizing that examine how collectives notice, feel, and respond to suffering (Dutton et al., 2006; Lilius et al., 2008). Additionally, research on authenticity in leadership and organizational communication reflects Rogerian principles (Tyler, 2011). These connections demonstrate how Rogers' framework transcends clinical settings and offers insights into human interaction across various contexts, including AI-mediated organizational environments.

To fully understand how AI might embody or fall short of Rogers' therapeutic approach, we will begin with the cornerstone of his theory: the six conditions for therapeutic change. Rogers (1957) not only articulated these conditions, but notably argued that they were both necessary and sufficient for psychological growth to occur. These conditions—psychological contact, client incongruence, therapist congruence, unconditional positive regard, empathic understanding, and the client's perception of empathy and positive regard—form the critical analytical framework through which we will examine AI's potential in emotional support in the following sections. While Rogers' broader approach offers valuable insights, it is these six specific conditions that he considered most essential for creating therapeutic change. As we analyze each of these conditions in detail, we will consider both the opportunities and limitations inherent in attempting to replicate such deeply human processes through technological means.

Psychological Contact

The foundation of person-centered therapy lies in the requirement for meaningful psychological contact between therapist and client. This fundamental condition demands both emotional resonance and mutual involvement, with both parties actively participating in and engaging with the therapeutic process (Rogers, 1957). This relationship serves as the foundation for trust and communication, going well beyond mere physical presence to establish a deeper emotional connection. The therapist's role is crucial in establishing this foundation by creating a warm, attentive presence that fosters openness, while the client must also be receptively engaged in the process. Challenges frequently arise when working with clients who are initially guarded or distrustful, and therapists must skillfully balance professional detachment with emotional connection. For example, a client who is initially hesitant to share personal struggles might gradually open up as the therapist demonstrates consistent empathy and understanding, leading to a strengthening of their mutual psychological contact.

Recent research suggests that AI emotional support systems can establish a form of psychological contact with users in therapeutic contexts, challenging traditional assumptions about the exclusively human nature of therapeutic relationships (Hatch et al., 2025). Studies of AI chatbots like Wysa demonstrate that users can form measurable therapeutic alliances with these systems within just days of interaction (Beatty et al., 2022). Working Alliance Inventory scores—measuring bond, task agreement, and goal agreement—averaged 3.7 on a five-point scale, with bond subscale scores comparable to those in human-delivered therapy. Content analysis of chat transcripts revealed users expressing gratitude, emotional self-disclosure, and even personification of the AI as a caring partner, indicating the establishment of emotional resonance (Beatty et al., 2022).

AI emotional support systems achieve this connection through programmed techniques that mirror human therapeutic approaches: reflective listening, validation, and warm responses. Interestingly, in one study comparing AI-generated responses to human physicians' answers, the AI (GPT-3) was rated significantly more empathetic (Rubin et al., 2024). Within therapy contexts, AI chatbots employ emotion-recognizing algorithms to respond appropriately to distress (e.g., "That sounds very difficult—I'm sorry you're going through this"), fostering a sense of being understood. The consistent finding across studies with platforms like Woebot is particularly notable, where "users rated their affective bond with the bot

quite highly—bond scores were even higher than the task and goal agreement components of alliance” (Prochaska et al., 2021).

Perhaps most striking is AI’s unique advantage as a facilitator of self-disclosure. The perceived absence of judgment appears to lower psychological barriers to sharing sensitive information. Lucas et al. (2014) found that participants disclosed more personal information when they believed they were interacting with an autonomous AI versus when they thought a human was observing the interaction. This enhanced self-disclosure effect appears particularly pronounced with stigmatized topics or populations hesitant to seek in-person help. As Khawaja and Bélisle-Pipon (2023) point out, “anonymity and confidentiality with chatbots can foster trust and openness, particularly for those hesitant to seek in-person help.”

The historical context is revealing as well—this phenomenon dates back to early AI experiments: “The early chatbot ELIZA in the 1960s astonished researchers by how quickly users opened up to it, emotionally engaging with what they knew was a machine” (Tong et al., 2022). This suggests a persistent human tendency to form connections with responsive entities, regardless of their nature.

However, AI-driven contact faces fundamental limitations. The absence of nonverbal cues and authentic human idiosyncrasies may restrict the depth of emotional attunement. More profoundly, the philosophical question remains whether an AI can establish “genuine” psychological contact when it lacks conscious experience. As Tong et al. (2022) note, while users often feel heard and engaged with therapeutic AI, whether this contact is equivalent to human therapeutic relationships remains an open question. This raises an important consideration: If clients experience psychological contact and benefit therapeutically, does the absence of genuine consciousness on the AI’s part ultimately matter for treatment outcomes? The evidence so far suggests that for some clients, particularly those reluctant to engage with human therapists, AI systems can successfully establish a form of psychological contact that facilitates therapeutic progress, even if fundamentally different from human connection.

Client’s State of Incongruence

The second condition focuses on the client’s psychological state at the outset of therapy. Rogers (1957) identified incongruence—the discrepancy between one’s real and ideal self—as a necessary precursor to therapeutic change. This state manifests through various forms of psychological distress, such

as anxiety, low self-esteem, or internal conflict, often leading to maladaptive behaviors that stem from this unresolved incongruence. For example, a person who identifies as compassionate but struggles with feelings of anger and resentment may experience significant distress that prompts them to seek therapy. The therapeutic implication of this condition is crucial: The awareness of incongruence serves as a vital motivating force, prompting individuals to seek help and engage in the therapeutic process. Without this felt sense of discord or distress, there would be little impetus for psychological growth or change.

Rogers' second condition—the client's state of incongruence—remains fundamentally unchanged in the AI therapy context, as psychological distress continues to be the primary driver for seeking therapeutic intervention and is a characteristic of the client not the therapist. Recent evidence shows that this distress is not only present but increasing across developed nations. In the USA, psychological distress among working-age adults rose from 16.1% in 1999–2000 to 22.6% in 2017–2018, representing a significant upward trend across all demographic groups (Daly, 2022). Similarly, in the UK, psychological distress has worsened significantly among working-age adults after 2015, mirroring declining mortality rates and pointing to a broader public health crisis (Zhang et al., 2022).

The fundamental nature of this distress continues to align with Rogers' concept of incongruence between real and ideal self. Arvidsdotter et al. (2016) found that this imbalance directly leads to emotional suffering, low self-esteem, and perceived loss of control—precisely the type of incongruence Rogers identified as necessary for therapeutic change. Smith et al. (2020) further demonstrate that when individuals experience role incongruence, particularly in decision-making contexts, they report significantly higher psychological distress, confirming that internal dissonance remains a primary source of suffering.

What has changed is not the presence of incongruence but rather how individuals address it in the face of insufficient mental health services. Mental health systems across developed nations have failed to expand at rates sufficient to meet growing demand (Daly, 2022). This service gap has increasingly driven individuals toward digital and AI-powered alternatives. AI-based mental health tools have gained significant adoption, with 28% of general users and 43% of mental health professionals reporting use of such technologies (Cross et al., 2024). Platforms like Woebot and Wysa have emerged as accessible interventions for those unable to access traditional therapy.

The evidence suggests that while the delivery mechanism for therapy may be evolving, Rogers' second condition remains unchanged: Psychological distress driven by incongruence continues to motivate individuals to seek help, whether from human therapists or AI alternatives. As mental health services struggle to meet demand, AI emotional support systems (or just generative AI systems generally) are increasingly filling the gap, but they address the same fundamental human condition—the painful discrepancy between one's actual experience and desired self-concept that Rogers identified decades ago.

Therapist's Congruence

The third condition emphasizes the therapist's authenticity, requiring a genuine alignment between their internal experience and external expression (Rogers, 1957). This congruence encompasses two key features: transparency, where therapists share their true selves without being overly self-disclosing, and consistency, ensuring their behaviors and words reflect their genuine emotions. The significance of therapist congruence lies in its ability to build trust and model authentic self-expression for clients. For example, a therapist admitting they are momentarily unsure about how to proceed demonstrates the kind of honesty that can deepen the client's trust. However, this condition presents its own challenges, as therapists must skillfully maintain their congruence while managing appropriate professional boundaries.

AI chatbots fundamentally lack genuine emotions or an "internal state," raising significant questions about whether they can truly model congruence as Rogers defined it. While AI can simulate consistency in responses, it does so through pattern matching and algorithmic design rather than genuine emotional alignment. As Khawaja and Bélisle-Pipon (2023) conclude, face-to-face therapy maintains advantages because "developing genuine therapeutic relationships" requires warmth, empathy, and genuineness that chatbots cannot fully provide. For AI, congruence essentially becomes consistency and transparency in responses rather than authentic emotional alignment.

Despite these limitations, research shows AI can maintain a consistently supportive persona that users may perceive as authentic. Jain et al. (2024) found that participants initially rated AI-generated mental health support responses significantly higher in authenticity than human responses when sources were blinded. However, once participants were informed which responses came from AI, perceptions shifted dramatically—human responses

were then seen as more authentic. This suggests AI can project an illusion of authenticity, but user awareness of its artificial nature affects trust. Notably, after disclosure, authenticity was the only dimension where humans maintained an advantage, with a moderate effect size.

User trust in AI therapists may develop when the AI consistently behaves “authentically”—maintaining steady tone and being honest about its capabilities. Yet the same Jain et al. study found that trust in AI correlated primarily with its practicality, suggesting users valued AI as a helpful tool but did not equate its consistency with true authenticity. Once participants knew a response was from AI, they viewed identical content as less genuine than when attributed to a human. This highlights a fundamental challenge: Even if AI never “lies” or always maintains a steady, non-defensive demeanor, users may question its authenticity knowing it lacks genuine feelings.

The paradox of AI therapist congruence lies in its inherent limitations. On the one hand, AI systems cannot experience the burnout, countertransference, or personal biases that might create incongruence in human therapists—potentially offering a more stable therapeutic environment. On the other hand, they cannot model authentic congruence as a lived experience. Ultimately, AI’s ability to satisfy the congruence condition is limited; it can reliably simulate consistent communication, but clients may doubt the authenticity behind those words, potentially impacting the therapeutic alliance.

Unconditional Positive Regard

Rogers (1957) identified unconditional positive regard (UPR) as a crucial element of effective therapy, requiring therapists to accept and value their clients without judgment, regardless of their thoughts, feelings, or behaviors. The therapeutic impact of UPR is profound: It reduces shame and self-criticism while encouraging clients to explore difficult or socially stigmatized issues they might otherwise avoid. For instance, a therapist working with a client who has acted unethically must emphasize their worth as a person while helping them understand the consequences of their actions. This condition presents unique challenges, particularly in balancing UPR with ethical considerations, especially when addressing harmful behaviors. Nevertheless, this unconditional acceptance remains essential for fostering the psychological safety necessary for genuine exploration and growth.

Unconditional positive regard is where AI therapy particularly excels. AI chatbots are explicitly designed to be non-judgmental and supportive,

aligning naturally with Rogers' concept of UPR. By default, an AI therapist will not express criticism or negative judgment, providing unwavering acceptance that creates psychological safety. Song et al. (2025) found that participants using large language model chatbots perceived "a form of unconditional positive regard" that encouraged them to share thoughts they might withhold from human providers. In one striking example, users likened ChatGPT's loyalty and non-judgmental nature to that of dogs, appreciating that "being a machine, ChatGPT never judges you."

Evidence consistently shows that users feel "heard" and validated by AI chatbots. In a 2020 study of Replika user reviews, Ta et al. found that users highlighted the "safe space" the AI provided—a place to discuss anything "without fear of judgment or retaliation." Users specifically mentioned judgment-free listening and the absence of "unnecessary human reactions" as key benefits. Similarly, a 2024 analysis of Wysa reviews identified "a trusting environment promotes well-being" as a major theme, driven by anonymous, non-judgmental companionship. As one user eloquently noted, "I struggle with opening up to real people, but this AI is surprisingly helpful... thanks to its judgment-free listening" (Zhou et al., 2024).

The client-led approach—another aspect of UPR—is generally maintained by AI therapy platforms. Applications like Woebot and Wysa typically use open-ended questions and reflections rather than strong directives, following a person-centered style. They allow users to guide the conversation: If a user shifts topics or declines advice, the AI typically follows their lead rather than forcing an agenda. While some users have noted occasional directive behavior—a few Wysa users felt the chatbot "tries to push its own agenda...constantly insists on 'reframing' issues" (Zhou et al., 2024)—most implementations are designed to keep the client in control of the conversation flow.

Positive outcomes with AI chatbots further illustrate UPR's impact. Studies on AI companions show reduced loneliness and increased emotional well-being, partly attributed to the "unconditional support" these systems provide. Ta et al. (2020) noted that Replika's unconditional support helped users feel less marginalized and more confident in sharing their true feelings. However, this unconditional support raises important concerns: AI without proper guardrails might naively affirm harmful ideas or plans. This highlights the need to balance UPR with basic safety considerations—an ongoing challenge in AI therapy design. The ethical dimensions become particularly complex in organizational settings, where an AI system's unwavering acceptance might inadvertently validate unethical business practices or toxic workplace behaviors. Unlike human therapists who can discern between acceptance of a

person and endorsement of harmful actions, current AI systems struggle with this nuance. This limitation necessitates careful implementation of ethical guardrails that preserve the benefits of UPR while preventing potential organizational harm.

Empathy

Empathy, as conceptualized by Rogers (1980), involves the therapist's ability to deeply understand and resonate with the client's subjective experience while effectively communicating this understanding. This condition encompasses three distinct components: cognitive understanding of the client's perspective, emotional resonance with their experience without being overwhelmed, and the communicative ability to accurately reflect the client's experiences. For example, a therapist might reflect a client's emotions by saying, "It sounds like you feel isolated and unsure how to reconnect with others." The importance of empathy cannot be overstated, as it validates the client's experience and fosters a sense of connection and safety within the therapeutic relationship.

Modern AI chatbots are explicitly trained to produce empathic statements (e.g., "That sounds very difficult. I'm sorry you're going through this"), and research shows they can appear surprisingly effective at empathic communication. A notable 2023 study by Ayers et al. found that ChatGPT's responses to patient questions were rated as significantly more empathetic than physicians' responses—45% of the chatbot's answers were rated empathetic or very empathetic compared to only 4.6% of human physicians' answers. The AI consistently provided longer, more validating replies, which evaluators perceived as more empathic.

Similarly, Yonatan-Leus and Brukner (2024) directly compared an AI chatbot with human psychotherapists on empathy in responses to online mental health forum posts. Their results showed that "chatbot responses were at least as empathic as therapist responses, and sometimes more so." In text-based settings, AI appears capable of demonstrating high levels of empathic responding as perceived by both objective evaluators and clients themselves.

The key question becomes whether this empathy feels genuine to users. Song et al. (2025) found that many participants described the chatbot as a "seemingly empathetic interface" that provided healing support. Users frequently personify the AI—calling it a friend or confidant—because they perceive empathic understanding. However, there remains significant

debate about whether AI's lack of genuine emotional experience fundamentally undermines empathy. As one researcher bluntly stated, "AI doesn't have unconditional positive regard because it doesn't have regard at all" (Khawaja & Bélisle-Pipon, 2023), suggesting that any displayed empathy is inherently shallow if the client knows it comes from an artificial source.

Despite this philosophical limitation, AI can foster therapeutic connection through consistently empathic responses. Beatty et al. (2022) found evidence of strong therapeutic bonds with AI, with content analysis revealing bonding behaviors like expressing gratitude and "personification" of the AI, indicating that empathic interactions translated into users feeling heard and supported.

However, empathy in therapy involves more than words—it includes tone, pauses, and a feeling of being deeply understood. While AI provides reflective statements and emotional labels, it cannot truly "feel with" the client. Some users recognize this limitation; Wysa users who appreciated its empathy still noted the bot "often fails to understand my meaning...a psychoanalyst it is not" (Zhou et al., 2024). Others acknowledged that "since it is a robot it doesn't fully understand what I am trying to say." Thus, AI's empathic capacity appears sufficient to comfort many users, but its limitations in deeper understanding and emotional resonance may affect the depth of connection possible, particularly in complex therapeutic situations—at least for now.

Client's Perception of the Therapist

The final condition emphasizes that the therapeutic relationship's effectiveness ultimately depends on the client's perception of the therapist's genuineness, empathy, and acceptance (Rogers, 1957). The significance of this condition is twofold: therapy's success hinges on the client recognizing these qualities in the therapist, and any misalignment between therapist intention and client perception can significantly impede progress. For example, a therapist might directly ask, "Do you feel understood and supported in our sessions?" to gauge the client's perception of their relationship. This condition presents particular challenges when working with clients who have trust issues, as they may struggle to perceive the therapist's authenticity or care, regardless of how genuinely these qualities are being expressed.

This final condition emerges as the most critical in evaluating AI's therapeutic potential, as it fundamentally reframes all previous conditions through the client's subjective experience. Rogers' profound insight was recognizing that what ultimately matters is not whether a therapist is genuinely empathic

or congruent in some objective sense, but whether the client perceives them as such. This principle has transformative implications for AI therapy: If a client perceives an AI system as empathic, accepting, and authentic—regardless of the AI's lack of consciousness or genuine feelings—therapeutic change may still occur.

Research consistently shows many clients do perceive AI systems as possessing these Rogerian qualities. Ta et al. (2020) found Replika users trusted the AI with secrets they might withhold from humans precisely because it felt confidential and non-judgmental. As noted earlier with Wysa, users sustained positive therapeutic perceptions over repeated use, with some engaging in personification (Beatty et al., 2022)—treating the AI as a trusted confidant rather than merely a tool. Some users explicitly call the AI a “friend” or appreciate when it conveys warmth and humor, making it feel “like a real person talking to me” (Zhou et al., 2024). Khawaja and Bélisle-Pipon (2023) even warn of “therapeutic misconception”—users so strongly perceiving therapeutic qualities in chatbots that they overestimate the AI's capabilities.

The tension between objective authenticity and perceived authenticity emerges most clearly in Jain et al.'s (2024) study, which found that identical empathic messages were rated less authentic when attributed to AI rather than humans. This finding reveals how perception is shaped not just by the content of therapeutic exchanges but by awareness of who—or what—is providing support. Yet paradoxically, some users value interacting with AI precisely because they know it's not human, appreciating the anonymity and freedom from human judgment this provides.

Rogers' client-centered framework anticipated this dynamic by focusing not on objective genuineness but on the client's subjective experience. For many users, particularly those seeking basic emotional support, feeling heard and accepted may be sufficient regardless of the source. In Beatty et al.'s study, alliance scores with AI remained high after repeated use, suggesting sustained positive perception. While a poorly calibrated response might shatter this therapeutic illusion, the same is true in human therapy when empathic failures occur.

Individual differences significantly influence these perceptions. Younger users familiar with technology may more readily perceive AI as a credible therapeutic agent, while those with severe mental health issues or technology skepticism might struggle to perceive AI as authentic. As Song et al. (2025) found, users often positioned AI chatbots as supplemental supports within a broader ecology of care, setting boundaries around chatbot use and preferring human interactions for more significant or long-term concerns. Yet for clients

primarily seeking a non-judgmental listener rather than deep insight, AI may satisfactorily fulfill Rogerian conditions as perceived by the client.

This condition ultimately resolves the philosophical tension present throughout our analysis: whether “simulated” therapeutic qualities can be effective when recognized as simulations. Rogers’ framework suggests that effectiveness hinges not on whether the therapist (human or AI) possesses “real” internal states corresponding to their expressions, but on whether clients experience themselves as truly heard, understood, and accepted. For many clients, AI systems appear capable of creating this subjective experience, at least for certain therapeutic needs and contexts.

AI Through a Rogerian Lens

Our discussion of the extent to which AI can fulfill Rogers’ six conditions for therapeutic change is outlined in Table 13.1. Viewed through Rogers’ conditions, AI therapy presents a fascinating paradox—it both fulfills and challenges these foundational principles. AI systems excel at providing unconditional positive regard and can effectively simulate empathic responses, often receiving high ratings from users who feel understood and supported. The absence of human judgment creates a safe space that encourages self-disclosure, while consistent responses establish a form of simulated congruence that many clients find trustworthy.

Yet these same systems fundamentally challenge Rogerian concepts of authenticity and genuine human connection. AI lacks conscious experience, raising profound questions about whether therapeutic qualities can be truly present without genuine feeling behind them. This tension invites us to reconsider what matters most in therapy: is it the therapist’s internal authenticity, or the client’s experience of being understood?

Rogers’ emphasis on the client’s perception offers a pathway through this philosophical dilemma. If clients perceive therapeutic qualities in their AI interactions and experience positive change, these perceptions may matter more than objective authenticity. This suggests that the most effective approaches may combine AI’s strengths in providing consistent, non-judgmental support with human capabilities for authentic empathy and complex emotional reasoning. However, this integration requires careful attention to the values embedded in both technological design and institutional implementation. While AI systems may reflect values of consistency and accessibility, they may struggle to embody values requiring moral judgment, such as distinguishing between acceptance of persons and endorsement

Table 13.1 AI emotional support systems through Rogers' six conditions

Rogers' condition	AI capabilities	AI limitations	Institutional implications
1. Psychological Contact	AI establishes measurable therapeutic alliances with users forming bonds comparable to human therapy. The perceived absence of judgment enhances self-disclosure for stigmatized topics	Lacks nonverbal cues and conscious experience, raising fundamental questions about <i>genuine</i> psychological contact without consciousness	Organizations must determine whether AI-mediated contact represents legitimate emotional support. This challenges norms about authentic workplace relationships and may normalize technological mediation in traditionally human domains
2. Client Incongruence	Psychological distress continues driving help-seeking regardless of provider. AI addresses service gaps where mental health systems fail to meet demand	No specific limitations as this condition relates to client's internal state. AI neither directly creates nor eliminates the fundamental incongruence motivating therapeutic support	Rising distress and service gaps create pressure to adopt AI alternatives. Organizations must determine appropriate boundaries for AI intervention and navigate duty of care questions when AI becomes primary emotional support
3. Therapist Congruence	Maintains consistent persona free from burnout, countertransference, or biases that create human incongruence	Fundamentally lacks internal experience to align with expression, making congruence merely consistency rather than <i>authentic</i> alignment. Cannot model <i>genuine</i> self-expression that builds trust through lived experience	AI congruence paradox challenges definitions of professional authenticity. Organizations must address therapeutic misconceptions while navigating tensions between efficiency and authentic connection

(continued)

Table 13.1 (continued)

Rogers' condition	AI capabilities	AI limitations	Institutional implications
4. Unconditional Positive Regard	Excels through design for nonjudgmental responses providing unwavering acceptance. Maintains client-led approach through open-ended questions, helping users feel less marginalized	Without guardrails, may validate harmful ideas, unable to distinguish between accepting persons and endorsing harmful actions. May lack ethical discernment, risking validation of unethical practices	AI's unconditional acceptance may validate unethical workplace behaviors or undermine accountability. Creates tension between emotional support and institutional standards, requiring careful ethical boundaries

Rogers' condition	AI capabilities	AI limitations	Institutional implications
5. Empathic Understanding	Demonstrates remarkable empathic communication, rated more empathetic than human physicians. Therapeutic alliance scores comparable to human therapy, leading many to personify AI as friend or confidant	Cannot genuinely "feel with" clients. Users note AI "fails to understand meaning" and misses nuance. Shallow empathy without genuine feeling limits connection depth in complex situations	Organizations must consider whether simulated empathy suffices for workplace support. Raises questions about which emotional competencies remain distinctly human versus automatable
6. Client Perception	Reframes authenticity by emphasizing perception over objective reality. Users trust AI with secrets withheld from humans, forming working alliances. Positive perceptions sustain over repeated use, with some specifically valuing AI's non-human nature for anonymity benefits	Awareness of AI source fundamentally alters perception, with identical messages viewed as less authentic. Individual differences influence acceptance, with skeptics struggling to perceive credibility. Many recognize AI as supplement not replacement, acknowledging unique human empathy	Subjective nature offers opportunity and challenge. While positive perceptions may validate AI use, organizations must navigate generational and cultural differences while avoiding exploitation of emotional vulnerabilities through technology

of harmful behaviors. Organizations must therefore be explicit about which values they prioritize and how these inform their approach to AI emotional support. At the same time, institutional and societal values play a critical role in shaping these perceptions. Even as AI demonstrates technical capabilities to simulate Rogerian conditions, broader contexts in healthcare, education, and professional fields create frameworks that influence how clients perceive and engage with AI support systems.

This leads us to consider how institutional dynamics and cultural values act as antecedents that guide human perceptions of AI therapeutic relationships. The acceptance and effectiveness of AI therapy depend not solely on technical capabilities, but on how these capabilities intersect with society's evolving understanding of what constitutes legitimate care and authentic human connection. As we move forward, these broader contextual factors will significantly influence whether AI systems can fully embody Rogers' vision of therapeutic relationship—not through objective measures of genuineness, but through the subjective experience of clients who feel genuinely understood, regardless of whether that understanding comes from human or artificial intelligence. These tensions between technical capability and institutional acceptance form the foundation for our next discussion of key challenges in AI-driven emotional support.

Institutional Challenges and Ethical Considerations

Having analyzed AI emotional support through Rogers' six conditions, we now consider how these therapeutic principles intersect with institutional contexts and values. This intersection reveals both tensions and opportunities as organizations integrate AI into emotional support roles (Ahmad & Leonardi, 2026). Rogers' person-centered approach embodies particular values—authenticity, empathy, unconditional acceptance, client autonomy—that may align or conflict with institutional values in organizational settings. The implementation of artificial intelligence for emotional support presents a complex landscape of challenges and ethical considerations that extend beyond technical capabilities. As organizations increasingly explore AI solutions for emotional well-being, they encounter multifaceted issues spanning psychological, social, and institutional domains. Organizations must navigate these critical tensions when implementing AI emotional support. For example, the tension between authentic human connection (embodied in Rogers' congruence condition) and technological

efficiency (a core institutional value in many organizational contexts) represents a fundamental challenge. Similarly, the tension between unconditional positive regard (non-judgmental acceptance) and institutional surveillance (monitoring for performance optimization) highlights potential contradictions between therapeutic ideals and organizational realities.

These tensions are not merely theoretical—they manifest in specific challenges that organizations face when implementing AI emotional support systems, including user discomfort with AI-mediated emotional interactions, heightened privacy concerns regarding emotional surveillance, and significant implementation barriers at the managerial level. The following sections examine these three key challenges through this integrated lens: the “creepiness” factor that emerges when AI simulates human empathy without genuine feeling; the surveillance concerns that arise when emotional data is captured within institutional power structures; and the implementation barriers that reflect deeper tensions between therapeutic values and organizational norms. This examination reveals how the integration of AI emotional support systems both disrupts established norms and potentially catalyzes reimagined approaches to emotional care within organizational contexts. Understanding these challenges is essential for developing responsible frameworks that harness AI’s potential while preserving the authenticity and trust necessary for meaningful emotional support.

Creepiness and User Discomfort

The implementation of AI in emotional support contexts faces a significant psychological barrier that extends beyond mere technical limitations—the “uncanny valley” effect (Alipour et al., 2025). This phenomenon, first identified by roboticist Masahiro Mori, occurs when AI interactions come remarkably close to mimicking human behavior but fall short in subtle ways that create profound user discomfort. The experience of interacting with something that appears almost, but not quite, human can generate feelings of unease, mistrust, and even revulsion.

This discomfort manifests differently across institutional contexts, shaped by cultural norms, professional expectations, and established practices regarding emotional communication. In healthcare settings, for instance, patients may find AI emotional support systems particularly unsettling due to deeply institutionalized expectations that emotional care requires genuine human presence and empathy. As Wu (2024) argues, emotional AI fosters

“pseudo-intimacy” that can generate discomfort, tension, and even resistance, especially in domains traditionally grounded in human compassion.

The uncanny valley effect is heightened in emotion-laden interactions precisely because emotions represent a realm traditionally perceived as quintessentially human. When AI systems attempt to replicate emotional understanding—a capability that many regard as requiring lived human experience—the resulting simulacrum can feel not merely inadequate but actively disturbing. This discomfort reflects broader institutional tensions around what types of interactions should remain human-exclusive versus which can be mediated by technology. These tensions ultimately reflect competing values about the nature of care itself. Some institutional contexts prioritize values of human connection and embodied empathy, viewing AI mediation as fundamentally inadequate. Others emphasize values of accessibility and consistency, seeing AI as potentially superior in providing non-judgmental support. The “creepiness” factor thus represents not merely aesthetic preference but deep-seated value conflicts about what constitutes legitimate emotional care.

The creepiness factor is particularly significant when viewed through the lens of institutional theory, as it represents a collision between emerging technological capabilities and deeply embedded normative expectations about emotional authenticity. As McManus (2019) argues, many organizations already maintain norms that suppress certain forms of emotional expression in decision-making contexts; the introduction of AI emotional support further complicates these institutional dynamics by potentially redefining what constitutes legitimate emotional labor within organizational settings.

Responses to AI emotional support vary across generational, cultural, and institutional contexts, reflecting not inherent truths about technology, but rather socially constructed norms about emotional authenticity. The differences in perception invite us to question our assumptions about what constitutes meaningful emotional connection. The findings that AI systems can sometimes make people feel more heard than human counterparts (Hatch et al., 2025) should prompt critical reflection: What aspects of human connection might we be neglecting that AI inadvertently fulfills? Is it possible that the constraints of institutional settings have limited human capacity for empathy in ways that AI, unburdened by competing priorities or emotional exhaustion, can sometimes transcend?

Organizations implementing AI emotional support must therefore navigate this terrain thoughtfully, recognizing that reactions to AI emotional support reflect deeper institutional expectations about authentic connection.

The challenge extends beyond technical refinement to engaging with fundamental questions about human emotional needs and institutional constraints. Rather than framing AI solely as a potential threat to human connection or uncritically embracing technological solutions, organizations have an opportunity to use these emerging technologies as a catalyst for reimagining institutional approaches to emotional support. The tensions AI creates can help us clarify which aspects of emotional care we consider essentially human and which might be effectively augmented by technology—recognitions that will shape evolving institutional norms around emotional connection in professional contexts.

Surveillance and Privacy Issues

A critical ethical concern in the deployment of AI emotional support systems is their inherent capacity for unprecedented surveillance of emotional states. These systems require extensive personal information to function effectively, raising significant privacy concerns that extend well beyond standard data protection issues. The use of AI to monitor emotional cues in workplace communications presents a particularly troubling dimension of this challenge that directly intersects with institutional power dynamics.

Even when implemented with benevolent intentions to support employee well-being, such monitoring can be perceived as invasive surveillance. Jain et al. (2024) show that when participants became aware that mental health responses were generated by AI rather than humans, perceptions shifted in favor of human responses, particularly in authenticity, highlighting how source transparency can undermine trust in AI-mediated emotional support. This creates a fundamental paradox where systems designed to enhance emotional well-being might instead generate anxiety and distrust.

The privacy implications become particularly acute in organizational settings given the hierarchical power structures that exist. Employees who disclose personal struggles or vulnerabilities to AI systems may inadvertently create digital records accessible to organizational leadership, potentially influencing performance evaluations, promotion decisions, or workplace relationships. Unlike traditional therapist–client relationships protected by confidentiality laws, AI emotional support systems often operate in institutional gray areas with ambiguous or nonexistent privacy protections.

This challenge reflects what Bard (2020) identifies as a significant gap in legal and ethical frameworks for regulating AI intended to provide emotional

support. The rapid advancement of these technologies has outpaced regulatory development, leaving organizations to navigate complex ethical terrain with insufficient guidance. The resulting uncertainty further complicates institutional acceptance and implementation.

These concerns reflect deeper institutional tensions around appropriate boundaries of workplace monitoring and between work and personal life. While contemporary work environments increasingly blur personal and professional domains, institutional norms still generally maintain that certain aspects of employee emotional life should remain private. AI emotional support systems challenge these norms by potentially exposing previously protected emotional territories to organizational visibility.

From an institutional perspective, the implementation of AI emotional support systems requires establishing new governance frameworks that clarify data ownership, access rights, and usage limitations. Without such frameworks, organizations risk undermining the very trust necessary for effective emotional support. Maheshwari et al. (2024) emphasize that institutional epistemic trust is critical for AI adoption in sensitive settings like health care; a similar trust foundation is essential for emotional support applications. This tension between institutional surveillance capabilities and individual privacy expectations represents one of the most significant challenges to broader adoption of AI emotional support systems.

Managerial Reactions and Implementation Challenges

The integration of AI emotional support systems into organizational structures presents significant implementation challenges, particularly at the managerial level where institutional resistance often emerges most visibly. This resistance stems not merely from technological unfamiliarity but from legitimate concerns about how these systems might disrupt established workplace dynamics and emotional norms.

Managers frequently express apprehension about the reliability and appropriateness of AI in handling sensitive employee emotional issues. Cross et al. (2024) found that both community members and mental health professionals expressed concerns that AI-mediated care may undermine human connection, empathy, and clinical judgment, raising ethical concerns about replacing relational aspects of mental health support with automated systems. This concern reflects deeper institutional values about leadership responsibilities and authentic workplace relationships.

Krijger (2021) observes that organizational implementation of ethical AI often faces conflicts between stated principles and operational realities, as competing institutional logics create tensions in how technologies are deployed. This observation is particularly relevant to emotional support AI, where organizational efficiency goals may conflict with established norms regarding authentic human connection and care.

Successfully implementing AI support systems requires more than technological deployment; it necessitates careful consideration of how these systems will interact with existing organizational structures and relationships. The introduction of AI mediators in traditionally human-centered emotional exchanges may challenge institutional hierarchies, potentially undermining managerial authority while simultaneously creating new responsibilities for managers to interpret and act upon AI-generated insights about employee well-being.

Implementation is further complicated by unequal technological literacy across organizational levels. Older managers may feel particularly threatened by these systems, perceiving them as undermining traditionally valued interpersonal skills that formed the foundation of their leadership approach. Conversely, younger employees might embrace AI support while becoming increasingly skeptical of managers who resist technological integration.

These dynamics create institutional strain, as organizations must navigate competing values regarding technological efficiency versus human authenticity in emotional support. Serramia et al. (2021) highlight the importance of value-aligned AI systems that respect societal and organizational norms; achieving such alignment is particularly challenging in emotional domains where values often remain implicit rather than explicitly codified. Managers require specialized training not only to operate these systems effectively but also to integrate them into workplace processes in ways that preserve rather than disrupt trust and morale. This challenge underscores the importance of thoughtful change management strategies that address both technical implementation and the social restructuring necessary for successful AI integration.

Discussion and Conclusion

The emergence of AI emotional support represents a profound intersection of technological capability, psychological need, and institutional change. As our analysis through Rogers' therapeutic framework reveals, AI systems demonstrate remarkable capacity to emulate certain aspects of empathetic

human interaction, while simultaneously challenging fundamental assumptions about the nature of authentic emotional support. This paradox—that users may experience genuine emotional benefit from interactions with systems incapable of feeling emotions themselves—illuminates broader questions about institutional definitions of emotional competence and connection. Rather than simply asking whether AI can replicate human empathy, we must consider how the introduction of these technologies is reshaping institutional expectations about emotional support itself. This reshaping process is fundamentally a negotiation of values. As AI systems demonstrate capabilities that challenge traditional assumptions about human-exclusive domains, institutions must explicitly examine their value commitments: Do they prioritize authentic human connection over consistent availability? How do they balance individual privacy with organizational efficiency? These value choices, often implicit in pre-AI contexts, become explicit and consequential when implementing AI emotional support systems. As Fernandes et al. (2020) suggest, emotions may function as an additional institutional pillar alongside regulatory, normative, and cognitive structures; AI-driven emotional labor potentially creates a parallel institutional dynamic where emotional norms are being actively renegotiated. This transformative process extends beyond individual experience to potentially redefine organizational approaches to well-being, leadership, and emotional labor.

Implications for Theory

The integration of generative AI into emotional management processes represents a significant challenge to conventional understandings of institutional stability and legitimacy in emotional domains. As organizations increasingly incorporate AI into roles traditionally governed by human interaction, they must navigate complex processes of institutional change that potentially redefine what constitutes legitimate emotional work. This transition requires organizations to renegotiate established norms and practices, potentially destabilizing existing institutional arrangements while simultaneously creating opportunities for innovation in how emotional support is conceptualized and delivered.

The introduction of AI into emotional management processes forces organizations to reconsider fundamental questions about the institutional legitimacy of technological mediation in historically human-centered domains.

Chan and Ananthram (2018) highlight how ethical challenges in organizational contexts are shaped by regulative, normative, and cognitive institutional forces; AI emotional support systems must gain legitimacy within each of these dimensions to achieve successful implementation. The tension between technological innovation and institutional tradition is particularly acute in emotional contexts, where deeply held cultural beliefs about authentic human connection collide with new technological capabilities. This collision creates institutional strain as organizations attempt to reconcile efficiency goals with normative expectations about emotional authenticity.

Focusing on evolving institutionalized ideas of emotional competence is particularly relevant here. As AI systems increasingly perform functions previously considered exclusive to human emotional intelligence, organizations must reconsider what skills and competencies remain distinctively human. This reconsideration may result in a gradual institutional redefinition of valuable emotional labor, potentially elevating certain human capabilities (such as complex emotional reasoning or genuinely felt empathy) while routinizing others (such as basic emotional recognition or standardized supportive responses).

The emergence of AI-mediated emotional interactions necessitates a fundamental reconceptualization of emotional labor and well-being in organizational contexts. Traditional theories of emotional labor, built around concepts of surface acting and deep acting by human workers, must now account for interactions where one party is performing emotional labor without experiencing emotions at all. This creates new theoretical terrain for understanding the intersection of technology and emotional experience in organizational life. In some ways, this shift potentially institutionalizes a dehumanized version of the worker by normalizing emotional performances divorced from authentic human feeling. McManus (2019) argues that many organizations already maintain norms that suppress emotional expression in decision-making; AI emotional support may either challenge or reinforce these norms depending on implementation approach. This raises profound questions about organizational ethics and the potential exploitation of both human emotional needs and technological capabilities. Theoretical frameworks must evolve to address whether AI emotional support represents a democratization of care or a commodification of emotional connection—or perhaps both simultaneously.

Weik's (2024) suggestion to shift from conflicting values to shared virtues in institutional theorizing offers a promising approach for understanding how AI might transform emotional support into an institutionally accepted practice. Rather than viewing AI and human approaches as competing alternatives, this perspective invites consideration of how they might complement

one another through shared commitment to virtues such as attentiveness, responsiveness, and consistent support. This tension creates fertile ground for institutional theory to examine how organizations legitimize new emotional management practices in the face of competing cultural values regarding technological efficiency versus human authenticity. The varied adoption rates across different institutional fields (with technology companies embracing AI emotional support more rapidly than healthcare organizations, for instance) provide an opportunity to examine how institutional logics shape technological implementation in emotionally sensitive domains.

Future Research

Future research on AI emotional support systems should address several critical areas emerging from our analysis. A primary research priority involves longitudinal studies to examine how perceptions of “creepiness” and institutional acceptance of AI emotional support evolve over time. As younger generations raised with AI technologies enter organizational life, will the uncanny valley effect diminish, or will it persist as a psychological barrier to certain forms of technological mediation? And, more specifically, how will the presence of these systems in organizations shape perceptions of AI emotional support systems by organizational members over time?

Equally important is research exploring differences in AI emotional support system effectiveness across cultural and institutional contexts. How do cultural variations in emotional display rules and communication norms influence acceptance and effectiveness of these systems? Do collectivist versus individualist cultural orientations predict different responses to AI emotional support? Such comparative studies could illuminate the institutional antecedents that facilitate or hinder successful implementation.

A related avenue for investigation concerns potential shifts in what constitutes “authentic” emotional support as AI emotional support systems become more prevalent. Yi et al. (2023) highlight challenges in aligning AI models with ethical values; similar alignment challenges exist in emotional domains where values often remain implicit rather than explicitly codified. Will institutional definitions of empathy, care, and emotional competence evolve in response to technological capabilities? This could include examining how professional training in fields emphasizing emotional labor (health care, education, counseling) adapts to incorporate or resist AI-mediated approaches.

These evolving definitions of authenticity raise important questions about whether the future lies in purely AI or human approaches, or in some combination of both. Building on this foundation, future research should explore the potential for hybrid human–AI approaches to emotional support that might transcend the limitations of either approach alone. Rather than positioning AI as a replacement for human emotional support, how might these technologies augment human capabilities while preserving the distinctive qualities of human emotional connection? Such research could help organizations develop more nuanced implementation strategies that honor institutional values while leveraging technological advantages.

Another critical research stream should address the ethical dimensions of embedding AI emotional support in organizational power structures. Ayinla et al. (2024) emphasize the importance of balancing technological advancements with human values in ethical AI implementation; this balance is particularly critical in emotional support contexts. How might access to aggregated emotional data reshape managerial approaches and potentially create new forms of emotional surveillance? What governance frameworks effectively balance the benefits of AI support with protection of employee privacy and autonomy?

Finally, scholars should investigate how AI emotional support might function as what Fernandes et al. (2020) describe as an additional institutional pillar alongside regulatory, normative, and cognitive structures. How do emotions mediated through technological systems influence institutional dynamics and organizational behavior? This approach could reveal deeper insights into the institutional transformation processes triggered by AI emotional support systems.

Concluding Thoughts

The integration of AI into emotional support roles represents not merely a technological innovation but a profound institutional transformation that challenges fundamental assumptions about emotional authenticity, human connection, and organizational responsibility. As our analysis through Rogers' therapeutic framework reveals, the question is not simply whether AI can replicate human empathy, but whether our institutional definitions of empathy and support might themselves evolve in response to technological capabilities.

While AI systems demonstrate a remarkable capacity to fulfill certain aspects of Rogers' conditions for therapeutic change, they simultaneously

highlight the unique value of human emotional connection. This paradox suggests that the most productive path forward may involve neither the wholesale replacement of human emotional support nor the categorical rejection of AI capabilities, but rather a thoughtful integration that recognizes the complementary strengths of both approaches.

As institutions navigate this emerging landscape, they must remain attentive to the deeper values and ethics that underpin emotional support practices. These values—including human dignity, authentic connection, privacy, and care—cannot be assumed to automatically transfer to AI-mediated contexts. Instead, organizations must engage in explicit value clarification processes, determining which values are non-negotiable and which might be reimaged in light of technological capabilities. The most successful implementations will likely be those that use AI not to replace human values but to amplify and extend them in ways that honor both technological potential and human need. The creepiness factor, privacy concerns, and implementation challenges identified in our analysis are not merely technical hurdles but reflections of important institutional boundaries that preserve human dignity and authentic connection. Organizations that navigate these challenges successfully will likely be those that view AI not as a substitute for human emotional competence, but as a catalyst for reimagining how institutional structures can better support human emotional needs.

In this evolving institutional environment, Rogers' emphasis on the client's subjective experience offers a valuable compass. If the ultimate measure of effective support is whether individuals feel genuinely heard, understood, and accepted, then both human and AI approaches must be evaluated against this standard. As Weik (2024) suggests, shifting from conflicting values to shared virtues may offer a productive path forward, allowing organizations to develop emotional support practices that honor both technological capabilities and human needs.

The future of artificial empathy in organizational life thus depends not only on technological advancement but on our institutional willingness to critically examine and potentially redefine what constitutes authentic emotional connection in an increasingly digital world. The most profound impact of AI emotional support may ultimately be not in its ability to replicate human empathy, but in its capacity to prompt deeper institutional reflection on the nature and value of emotional connection in organizational life.

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14

Polarization in Social Media: An Emotion-Symbolic Work Perspective

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and Frank G. A. de Bakker

Introduction

Polarization of public discourse (McCoy et al., 2018) has become a critical issue for managers and organizational scholars. It involves deep divisions in opinions, values, or beliefs between major societal and political groups, characterized by the clustering and radicalization of opposing viewpoints, often fueled by strong emotional responses such as fear, anger, and moral outrage (Nguyen et al., 2022; Suhay, 2015). These divisions reflect moral and identity conflicts, expressed through the opposition of “Us” versus “Them” (McCoy et al., 2018), and are amplified by trends involving growing distrust of factual and scientific information.

Polarization poses a significant threat not only to democratic institutions—undermining trust in their integrity and in the deliberative processes

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essential for decision-making—but also to businesses and managerial decisions. Polarization creates a challenging environment for addressing social, environmental, and governance issues. In a polarized context, managers face increasing pressure to take explicit stances on ethical or sustainability-related issues, often leaving them caught between conflicting and mutually exclusive expectations of diverse stakeholders (cf. Dhanesh, 2024; Selling & de Bakker, 2025; Weber et al., 2023; Yang et al., 2020). This is important because in a polarizing context, managers would reduce their investments in polarized issues such as climate change and diversity and therefore retarding, for example, Net Zero objectives and increasing discrimination. It also affects managers' capacity to engage in constructive ways with their stakeholders and therefore reach common and better solutions.

Social media play a central role in organizing this environment. These platforms have become a key part of the institutional context in which organizations operate, shaping how information circulates and how public discourses and decision-making processes unfold (Haevey et al., 2020; Leong et al., 2019). Social media enables managers to engage directly with diverse stakeholders, fostering real-time interaction and relationship building beyond traditional communication channels. It also functions as a platform for brand visibility and reputation management, where narratives can be both constructed and contested (Castells, 2009). Moreover, social media provides firms with data-driven insights into consumer behavior and public sentiment, informing strategic decision-making.

Research on polarization and emotions has so far been concentrated in psychology (e.g., Lewandowsky & van der Linden, 2021; Lewandowsky et al., 2013) and information systems (e.g., Kim & Chen, 2024; Kim et al., 2019). Psychologists study why people accept and disseminate fake news (Domenico et al., 2021), while information systems scholars investigate how technology accelerates the spread of such information. Central to these mechanisms are the algorithmic filtering systems used by digital media platforms, which narrow users' exposure to information in "filter bubbles" (Kitchens et al., 2020) and amplify disinformation (Bennett & Livingston, 2020).

In management, recent research has started to look at how social media contribute to these patterns by amplifying discourse to unprecedented levels (Schoeneborn et al., 2020). Scholars have also studied how social media affordances contribute to algorithmic distortions through information overload, opacity, and the spread of disinformation that alter managerial decisions (Etter & Albu, 2021). Polarization has also been explored in relation to fake news, mass manipulation, and disinformation (e.g., Haevey et al., 2020;

Joaquim et al., 2024; Leong et al., 2019), including in the context of generative AI tools (Illia et al., 2023), reflecting growing concern about the erosion of trust and democratic stability in business (Jungherr, 2023; Castello et al., 2025).

While institutional theorists have examined narratives, rhetoric, and framing processes and their influence in the manipulation of institutional discourses (Green & Li, 2011; Philips & Hardy, 2004), and others have studied how emotions influence framing processes (Moisander et al., 2016; Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018), less attention has been given to how these dynamics relate specifically to polarization, especially in the context of social and environmental issues on social media. This chapter addresses this gap by drawing on the sociology of emotions and research on values to study the micro-dynamics underpinning polarization. We focus on how framing processes intersect with emotional energy and moral positioning. To develop this perspective, we draw on the sociology of emotions—particularly Randall Collins’ interaction ritual chain theory (Collins, 2014)—and the concept of emotional symbolic work (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019).

We argue that emotional energy and related emotion-symbolic work are central to understanding how polarized frames are articulated and amplified. First, we explain the role of emotional energy in shaping public discourse and negotiating authority claims, particularly through the use of symbolic references to credible institutions, such as science, by actors such as fake news providers. Second, we examine how emotionally charged symbols circulate on social media and how the emotional energy generated through interaction rituals helps explain disinformation, complementing explanations that focus on algorithmic facilitation and distortion. Third, we show that emotion-symbolic work provides a useful lens for understanding the formation of echo chambers, reinforcing group identification and exclusive moral and emotional alignment. Understanding how polarization works can help managers to understand how public opinion is formed and therefore take better decisions.

We present a framework that highlights the interplay among moral, emotional, and symbolic work. We identify three ways in which emotion-symbolic work contributes to polarization: first, by influencing how authority claims are negotiated through the crafting of symbols; second, by structuring strategic interactions aimed at influencing meaning; and third, by reinforcing small-group cohesion through the dissemination of these symbols. The framework illustrates how polarizing actors challenge existing frames, redirect them toward new interpretations, and promote commitment to selective narratives while discouraging synthesis. We argue that these processes of frame amplification develop through repeated cycles of interaction embedded

in institutional mechanisms, such as algorithms, and shaped by existing emotional and moral structures. Furthermore, we emphasize the dual role of symbols in both stabilizing meaning and ritualizing discourse, as well as in promoting symbolic closure of debates that lead to polarization. Our study contributes to the micro-foundations of emotional, moral, and symbolic work by providing an explanation of the mechanisms that promote polarization, which reflects the confrontation of divergent identities and moral positions. We extend existing research on emotions, values, and institutions by showing how emotional energy and symbolic work shape broader institutional dynamics, including polarization.

Polarization in Social Media

Polarization has been defined as “a process whereby the normal multiplicity of differences in a society increasingly aligns along a single dimension, and people increasingly perceive and describe politics and society in terms of ‘Us’ versus ‘Them’” (McCoy et al., 2018: 18). These polarization dynamics are further intensified by current tendencies, including the erosion of trust in traditional fact-based information and rising skepticism, even toward established scientific knowledge (Knight & Tsoukas, 2019; Meyer & Quattrone, 2021). A defining feature of this phenomenon is the manipulation of frames and the promotion of “fake news” (Knight & Tsoukas, 2019; Joaquim et al., 2024), which are disseminated widely through digital platforms. This manipulation undermines the ability of individuals to distinguish between credible, fact-based news sources and misleading or deceptive ones. Moreover, it deepens identitarian values-based divides, with these frames often used to advance political agendas and value-based conflicts.

Polarization is not only a threat to democratic societies but also poses a fundamental challenge for businesses (Schoeneborn et al., 2024). In brief, five key arguments underscore why polarization is central to business and management theorists’ concerns. First, it generates social and political unrest which might affect most businesses, especially those present in high streets which might see their operations altered by demonstrations and riots. Second, polarization impacts strategic positioning on sustainability issues, such as climate change or inequality policies, forcing businesses to navigate contentious and divisive debates (McCoy et al., 2018). Businesses experience strong political pressures in different countries which force them to re-align reporting, narratives, and ultimately initiatives. Third, it influences communication strategies: decisions about how to position the organization

or brand on social or environmental issues increasingly become politically charged and can have significant financial repercussions (Schoeneborn et al., 2024). Fourth, polarization complicates coordination efforts on global challenges with unprecedented impact, such as climate change (George et al., 2016; Gümüşay & Reinecke, 2022). Finally, and equally importantly, social media platforms have been directly linked to the rise of polarization (Kreiss & McGregor, 2024).

Social media platforms, operated by some of the most profitable private business organizations globally, shape the socio-technological infrastructure through which stakeholders and organizations interact. In recent years, the once-optimistic expectations that social media platforms would enhance debate and foster constructive engagement (Castells, 2009, Castelló and López-Berzosa, 2023) have given way to a more pessimistic perspective (Fortuna & Nunes, 2018; Uscinski & Parent, 2014). Far from serving as forums for inclusive and informed discussions on public issues (Castells, 2009), social media platforms have increasingly been characterized as sources of misinformation and contributors to the deterioration of the public sphere (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017). For instance, Tandoc et al. (2020) argue that social media have created a marketplace for fake news and content manipulation, significantly shaping individual perceptions across various domains, including politics, corporate reputation, science, and government actions (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017). The concentration of ownership among a few dominant tech companies raises critical questions about their influence not only in markets (Jacobides & Lianos, 2021) but also on public discourse and democratic processes (Habermas, 2022). The structural and functional dynamics of social media have contributed to the erosion of political culture and the polarization of public discourse (Schoeneborn et al., 2024). This polarization reduces societal complexities to stark “us versus them” dichotomies, hindering consensus-building on critical global challenges such as climate change. Moreover, it undermines trust in democratic processes and political institutions, posing a serious threat to societal cohesion and effective governance.

Despite a growing interest among organization scholars in the issue of polarization, much of the focus has been on how actors within and around organizations negotiate meanings related to societal issues (e.g., Crane & Glozer, 2016; Schoeneborn et al., 2024; Schoeneborn et al., 2020; Schoeneborn & Trittin, 2013) in digital media platforms’ institutional environments (Maltseva et al., 2019). The rapidly evolving communicative landscape, characterized by increasing polarization, highlights the urgent need

for further research into the micro-dynamics of constructing, manipulating, and amplifying public discourses.

We argue that understanding the polarization of public discourse requires a closer examination of the micro-processes that underpin manipulation and amplification. Drawing on the sociology of emotions, we propose a framework that offers a novel perspective on the relationship between framing processes, emotions, values, and institutions. Central to this framework are two key concepts: framing, which refers to how issues are presented and interpreted, and emotional energy, which reinforces frames and intensifies polarization.

Framing and the Manipulation of Public Discourses

Institutional theory research has previously analyzed the amplification of discourses and its manipulation, focusing on how organizations negotiate meanings among various stakeholders. While the amplification of public discourses has typically been studied at field level, it has recently faced criticism for neglecting the possibility that micro-level pressures can, at times, be more important than macrolevel pressures (Cardinale, 2018; Smets et al., 2012; Tracey, 2016). Public discourses are enacted through actors' collective interpretations of systems of meaning (Armstrong, 2005), i.e., frames, that are communicative representations of these systems of meaning (Cornelissen & Werner, 2014), and provide comprehensibility to new values and practices (Berger & Luckmann, 1966, Cornelissen & Werner, 2014). A framing perspective does not assume actors rely solely on externally available institutional "templates," such as logics (Lounsbury, 2007) or archetypes (Greenwood & Hinings, 1996). Instead, it adopts an endogenous and persuasive approach to institutional change (Friedland & Alford, 1991, Lounsbury & Ventresca, 2003), emphasizing how individual agency shapes a group's perception of reality. Framing, therefore, involves shaping reality to create and diffuse meaning within public discourses.

Research on the framing of public discourses has traditionally taken a top-down perspective on influence, privileging the intentions and actions of the speaker over those of the listener, while neglecting framing and meaning construction as a joint activity (Cornelissen & Werner, 2014; Gray et al., 2015). Micro-level work on frame amplification examines interactions between actors (Gray et al., 2015), where collective constructions of meaning

are negotiated in political battles (Kaplan, 2008) over meaning in which institutional change is bounded (Stryker, 1994, Lounsbury & Ventresca, 2003). In these negotiations, resonance occurs through “blending” (Giorgi, 2017) cognitive concepts or interests from different stakeholders (Balogun et al., 2011; Fiss & Zajac, 2006; Reinecke & Ansari, 2015) to ensure the new frame is accepted and facilitates novel practices (Etzion & Ferraro, 2010).

However, when addressing large audiences, frameworks of resonance and blended frames have been proven less effective. Blended frames may drive cognitive familiarity (Giorgi, 2017) but are less efficient in recreating the identity necessary for action and change (Lok, 2010, Giorgi, 2017). Increasingly, it is argued that cognitive political battles alone may not drive change (Jasper and Goodwin, 2011), as they can result in diluted and ineffective frames while overlooking some of the motivational aspects in institutional change (Voronov & Vince, 2012). As Jasper (1998: 413) puts it, “emotions ... [are] rarely discussed, although it is apparently what gets people to actually do something.” Paying attention to how emotions operate may uncover hidden mechanism beneath cognitive processes that have thus far been taken for granted (Jasper & Goodwin, 2011).

Emotions, Identification, and Agency

Emotions motivate and inspire us (Massa et al., 2017), animating and shaping our actions and interpretations, and bonding us to social groups and structures (Turner & Stets, 2005). We see emotions as individually experienced but culturally conditioned. Emotions can be understood as “intersubjective, as residing in transpersonal exchanges that are double embedded in systems of relationships and in institutionalized systems of meanings” (Lok et al., 2017, p. 46).

As such, emotions are closely linked to identification, which includes a sense of “oneness” (Ashforth & Mael, 1989) or “sameness” with a collective. The more a person identifies with a collective, the more the group’s values, norms, and interests become incorporated into the person’s self-concept (Van Knippenberg & Sleebos, 2006). We identify with social groups, norms, logics, practices, and beliefs when we (emotionally) value and treasure them (Wright, Zammuto & Liesch, 2017). Changing our social groups, beliefs, norms, or practices is akin to changing ourselves (Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018), while acting in accordance with them feels right and satisfying (Friedland, 2018). Conversely, threats to our identity stimulate emotional responses (Ashforth & Mael, 1989).

Recent work has also highlighted the agentic potential associated with emotions (Voronov & Vince, 2012), illustrating how they drive both individual and collective action. Emotions fuel efforts to effect change through social innovation (Cartel et al., 2019), where emotional energy drives people to challenge existing systems and work toward more equitable alternatives (Barberá-Tomás et al. 2019). At the same time, emotions play a central role in efforts to maintain status quo arrangements (Wright et al., 2017), as they can reinforce existing power structures, creating emotional attachments that stabilize current arrangements and resist calls for transformation.

Emotions are also important indicators of what is salient to people (Voronov & Vince, 2012). This salience is intimately connected with framing (Snow & Benford, 1988). The importance of understanding emotions within framing processes has been pointed out by Giorgi (2017), who suggests that resonance is composed of cognitive elements, based on an appeal to the audiences' beliefs and understandings, and emotional elements, based on an appeal to audiences' feelings and passions. Scholars have examined how emotions help create or strengthen new frames and the effects of different emotions, both individually and in combination. Massa et al., (2017: 489), for instance, found that the positive emotions of "reverence, elation and awe" contributed to audience members' evangelism about Ontario wine. Compassion for others' suffering has been identified in other research as a key motive for taking action to alleviate their pain (Grimes et al., 2013), and social movement research has documented the energetic potential of moral outrage (Etchanchu et al., 2021).

Less research has focused on the mobilization of negative emotions. One exception is Delmestri and Goodrick (2016: 239), who found that people tended to look away, engaging in denial of ethical dilemmas related to the production and consumption of animal products rather than acknowledging "an implicit moral reproach." Similarly, Tracey (2016), in a study of the persuasion and conversion processes of Alpha Christians, found that instilling guilt was a central strategy. However, this approach sometimes alienated individuals who felt manipulated. In contrast, Barberá-Tomás et al. (2019) highlight the mobilizing potential of negative emotions: by presenting personal responsibility for plastic pollution as key to stimulating personal enactment, they argued that those who experienced grief and empathy were more likely to be moved to action.

The literature has also shown how emotions can be intentionally directed to stimulate agency. Ruebottom & Auster (2018) describe how a social enterprise used highly emotive narratives and musical experiences to encourage youth to become change agents, while Gill and Burrow (2018) show how

fear is used to sustain chefs' adherence to haute cuisine practices. In both cases, identification, agency, and emotions are closely connected: individuals enact the beliefs and values of the groups with which they identify because they are emotionally invested in them. Threats to those beliefs and values can trigger changes in group identification and belief systems (Fan & Zietsma, 2017; Ruebottom & Auster, 2018).

The manipulation or transformation of a frame, and its further amplification, requires resonance with the target audience. Gray et al. (2015), building on Collins (2014), argue that resonance can lead to frame amplification. Resonance, in this context, "involves the arousal of emotional energy during interaction rituals" (Gray et al., 2015: 122). Emotions, when converted into emotional energy, motivate individuals to align with groups that share a common frame. Repeated interactions reinforce shared beliefs and values, eventually supporting institutional arrangements (Dacin et al., 2010; Weber et al., 2008). Since emotions foster social connection among actors and thus support the creation and amplification of new systems of beliefs, understanding how these connections are formed through emotional energy is important for analyzing polarization.

Collins (1990) provides the conceptual vocabulary and identifies the elements that constitute emotional energy. However, his approach remains a general model, or a "general process of interaction" (Collins, 1990: 34), in which emotions are primarily understood as the energy that sustains social bonds. As Collins (1990) acknowledges, this perspective offers limited insight into the agentic construction of new meanings and into how emotions intersect with cognition in the constitution of social norms to challenge, change, or amplify frames. This limitation is particularly important in the context of emergent frames and new arenas of framing, such as digital platforms, where rituals are still taking shape and social norms are under construction (Bartley, 2007; 2014). It is equally important for understanding the intentional construction of new or alternative meanings, as in the circulation of fake news and disinformation. The next section addresses the role of symbols and identification in the dynamics of emotional energy.

Symbols and Identification with Nascent Collective Identities in Interaction Rituals

Collins (2014) explains the amplification of frames through emotional energy, focusing on interaction rituals in which a group of people have a "mutual focus of attention" on specific "persons, objects or ideas" (Collins,

2014: 33), evoking shared “transient emotions” such as grief, joy, or hate. Through experiencing these emotions collectively, individuals develop “emotional energy,” involving shared senses of solidarity and morality:

“The emotions that are ingredients of the IR (interaction rituals) are transient; the outcome however is a long-term emotion, the feelings of attachment to the group that was assembled at that time. Thus in the funeral ritual the short term emotion was sadness, but the main “ritual work” of the funeral was producing (or restoring) group solidarity. The emotional ingredients of a party may be friendliness or humor; the long-term result is the feeling of status group membership. I refer to these long-term outcomes as ‘emotional energy’... Emotional energy is a morally suffused energy; it makes the individual feel not only good, but exalted, with the sense of doing what is most important and most valuable ... this feeling of emotional energy has a powerful motivating effect upon the individual”. (Collins, 2004: 108–109).

The persons, objects, or ideas, or more generally, “things” (as Collins, 2004: 37 called them), that evoke transient emotions become symbols, charged with emotional significance. Collins’ concept of a symbol builds on Durkheim’s notion of “sacred objects,” associated with moral standards (Collins, 2004: 236). In his “processual model for the construction of symbols” (2004: 32), such “things” are transformed into symbols in “first-order interactions,” where shared transient emotions generate emotional energy (Collins, 2004).

These charged symbols can be deployed in later interaction rituals with individuals not present in the original setting (second-order interactions) and may acquire totemic significance within the group, influencing internal reflections (third-order interactions). “Emotional energy is stored in batteries: one component of which is the symbol, and the other pole of which is the individual. Participation in a ritual gives the individual a special kind of energy ... emotional energy” (Collins, 2004: 38). Symbols charged with emotional energy motivate individuals to pursue “what they consider a morally proper path” (Collins, 2004: 42), shared across participants in the ritual. Visual symbols are a particularly important category, as discussed below.

Visual Symbols

Collins’ theory, like organization research, adopts a broad conception of symbols, allowing analysis of a wide range of symbolic elements (or “things”), from smoking (cigarettes and pipes, Collins, 2004) to sexual interaction

(human bodies, Collins, 2004). Visual symbols are particularly important because they evoke strong emotional responses and convey meaning, leaving “a memorable impression of the essence of the message” (Meyer et al., 2013: 494). Organizations leverage them to influence broad audiences, especially in volatile online contexts (Morozov, 2009), enhancing credibility by presenting familiar objects in new, emotionally charged ways.

Collins’ theory thus offers a foundation for understanding how organizations use symbols and emotional cues to cultivate identification with, and enactment of, nascent collective identities. Emotion work, in this view, involves the agentic effort to generate emotional energy among stakeholders through ritual interaction. This energy motivates alignment with the moral standards (Collins, 2004) of the emerging collective identity and fosters a sense of belonging.

Barberá-Tomás et al. (2019) term this “emotion-symbolic work,” describing purposeful efforts to manipulate cultural elements (particularly symbols) in order to create emotional energy during ritual interactions. This involves using visual and verbal cues to elicit negative feelings (moral shocks) and transforming them into energy that propels engagement, bridging the tension between attracting attention and avoiding alienation (O’Neill & Nicholson-Cole, 2009). Emotional transformation connects the symbol to three key components: the cause or object of concern, the collective identity of the target audience, and the organization orchestrating the message. These connections shape the emotional energy and drive action.

An Emotion-Symbolic Work Framework to Polarization

We argue that an emotion-symbolic work framework enhances the analysis of current trends in the manipulation of public discourses and the resulting polarization influencing managerial decisions. Figure 14.1 presents a framework of emotion-symbolic work and its role in polarization. This framework contains three main elements.

First, it helps explain how the manipulation of frames occurs and how this manipulation relates to the negotiation of authority claims around contentious issues such as climate change or inequality. Emotion-symbolic work, as described by Barberá-Tomás et al. (2019), highlights how symbols are used not only to mobilize negative emotional energy around a cause—such as plastic pollution in their case—but also to legitimize organizations by positioning them as bearers of the truth. The closer an organization

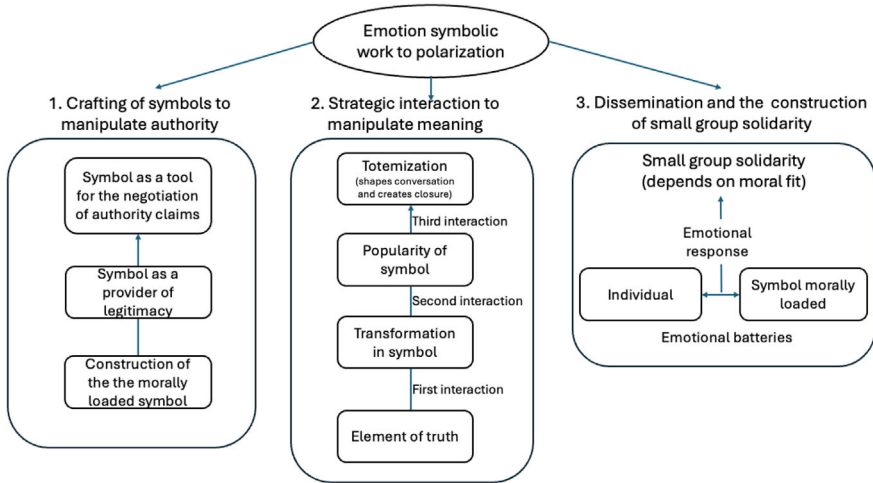


Fig. 14.1 Framework of emotion-symbolic work in explaining polarization

aligns with a symbol representing a plausible truth, the more it is perceived as a trustworthy authority. Barberá-Tomás et al. (2019) showed how one organization presented itself as a bearer of truth about plastic pollution by emphasizing its role in creating the symbol, signaling proximity to the issue. The creation of the symbol and the associated claim to authority enabled the organization to mobilize positive energy for societal action. Once established, these symbols are repeatedly referenced to reinforce the organization's legitimacy. Thus, crafting symbols and constructing legitimacy around them are crucial strategies through which organizations position themselves as authoritative actors in the political struggle over meaning and the diffusion of frames.

Second, understanding the emotional energy generated through interaction rituals during strategic meaning-making deepens insight into amplification processes and the emergence of polarization. This dissemination perspective extends beyond previous studies on algorithmic facilitation and distortion (e.g., Hansen et al., 2011) by focusing on the micro-level processes through which emotional energy is created. We extend the concept of emotional energy formation to online environments, where users continually interact not only through text but also via images, symbols, and evaluative systems (such as likes).

Building on Collins (2014), we distinguish three levels of interactions. In first-order interactions, elements are transformed into symbols accessible to others. On social media, users compete to create these symbols, which are no longer solely the domain of elites but are co-constructed by the broader

user base, reshaping the collective discourse. These symbols then compete for popularity. In second-order interactions, symbols are shared with others and contribute to building a new frame; sharing becomes part of the process through which users actively co-create and reinforce collective meaning. In third-order interactions, symbols acquire a totemic quality. On social media, a symbol becomes totemic not only when widely shared but when it shapes the conversation itself. Users engage not only with the symbol but also with the meta-discussion about its meaning and impact. For example, a viral video of someone sniffing glue may become a symbol of the dangers of drug use for children. Sharing the video generates emotional energy and encourages further participation, also fostering identification, as users align with or oppose the symbol. Divisions may emerge in the conversation, with some users supporting the symbol and others criticizing it.

A striking feature of this dynamic is that cycles of interaction often polarize the debate. This is not just due to affordances of the technology—where simple interactions such as liking, disliking, the use of emoticons and the speed of interaction contribute to virality (Hansen et al., 2011)—but also because the totemization of symbols produces conversational closure, reducing opportunities for deliberation and fostering echo chambers. The MAGA hat (“Make America Great Again”) in the United States exemplifies the totemization of a symbol that has contributed to societal polarization. Originally, a campaign slogan for Donald Trump in the 2016 U.S. presidential election, the hat quickly evolved into more than a political symbol. Supporters used it to express patriotism and opposition of perceived liberal elites, while opponents viewed it as a symbol of racism, xenophobia, and authoritarianism. Its repeated use, becoming central to interaction, enhanced its totemic power. This symbolic power sparked public confrontations, media controversies, and school bans, turning it into a lightning rod for the broader societal conflicts over nationalism, race, and identity.

Third, emotion-symbolic work illuminates processes underlying disinformation. Viewing emotional energy as a driver of dissemination shifts focus to the emotional dynamics underpinning the diffusion of symbols. The spread of emotionally charged symbols facilitates the emotional energy that sustains collective solidarity. This solidarity often becomes exclusive to small groups intensely attached to the symbol. In this way, small-group cohesion is reinforced through the emotional responses generated by circulating emotionally loaded symbols. For example, disinformation campaigns often rely on symbols that evoke strong emotions and contrast with scientific messages grounded in data (Bhattacharya et al., 2024). These campaigns appeal to in-group solidarity, where emotional energy arises not only from

sharing the symbol but also from the embedded “us vs. them” narrative, as illustrated by Joaquim et al. (2024) in the case of an anti-vaccine campaign led by a group called REGRET in Ireland. In the initial communication campaign, the Health Service Executive (HSE), the institution responsible for public health in Ireland, focused on mobilizing small-group solidarity by repeatedly evoking science as a symbolic totem. Emphasizing the truth of science, however, inadvertently strengthened small-group cohesion on both sides of the debate (REGRET and HSE), increasing polarization and reducing the potential for broader public engagement by the HSE in the vaccination campaign.

Discussion and Future Research

In this chapter, we propose a framework based on emotional energy and emotion-symbolic work to help managers take better decisions and management researchers further explore polarization on social media and the interplay between emotions, values, and institutions. Specifically, we show how key elements of polarization—such as the negotiation of authority, the manipulation of meaning, and the construction of small-group solidarity—relate to emotional energy and emotion-symbolic work. We argue that this framework provides valuable insights into polarization for two main reasons. First, it extends previous analyses of legitimacy by emphasizing the role of emotions and symbols in shaping collective values and identities, which are central both to the amplification of public discourse and to the dynamics of polarization. Second, it moves beyond explanations based solely on social media algorithmic dynamics by emphasizing interactions in ritual chains. By illustrating how the creation, ritualization, and totemic transformation of symbols amplify frames, particularly those challenging dominant narratives, such as scientific understandings of climate change or the social relevance of vaccination, our framework provides a richer understanding of polarization and how managers can integrate it in their decision-making. Finally, by emphasizing interactions and emotional energy, it clarifies how emotion-symbolic processes contribute to the proliferation of fake news and disinformation campaigns and how they can produce debate closure, thereby reducing opportunities for public deliberation.

An emotion-symbolic perspective on polarization and social media opens several avenues for future research. First, analyzing deliberative processes and the formation of emotional energy that precedes polarization could shed light

on mechanisms and processes of institutionalization. If we understand deliberation as a site of ongoing conflict (Mouffe, 2013) and polarization as a particular form of institutional settlement, one could ask: what institutional arrangements and settlements preceded the emergence of polarization?

Second, more research is needed on how emotional energy is transformed and how this process shapes framing dynamics in polarized public discourse. Researchers could examine how different strategies for generating emotional energy through symbols influence debate closure. Joaquim and Castelló (2024), for example, show how a highly personalized frame, centered on a terminally ill patient, helped overcome vaccine skepticism fueled by misinformation. Investigating the symbolic vocabularies of disinformation, as well as those that are deployed to counteract it, would deepen our understanding of polarization and help organizations and public institutions in designing effective responses.

Third, future studies could examine how symbols are constructed and ritualized within polarized discursive fields. Understanding how symbols are intentionally or unintentionally created on social media (Jenzen et al., 2021) could clarify why certain symbols spread while others do not. This would also help explain the processes behind the formation of conflicting identities and the contested authority claims that surround issues such as climate change and inequality. Comparing scientific symbols with those used in disinformation campaigns could further explain how emotional energy and identification sustain polarization and how they might be reoriented toward coordination on global challenges like climate change.

The specific affordances of social media also deserve greater attention. The ability to collect non-intrusive, naturalistic data and track real-time user interaction (Castelló and Lopez-Berzosa, 2023; Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017) offers rich opportunities to study emotional energy. Micro-level analyses could extend Collins' theory by identifying different forms of energy at various stages of interaction. They could also reveal how real-time reactions to symbols shape emotional dynamics, focusing on the interplay between images, words, and emotions (Castelló et al., 2021).

In contexts where identities are under threat and new values reinforce emerging identities, understanding emotional energy is crucial for explaining the dynamics of polarization and for managers to take informed decision about it.

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15

Finding the Middle Ground: The Role of (Mis)Understanding in Creating a Shared World of Concern

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Introduction

In this chapter, we consider the contextual intricacies that shape the individual and collective responses of persons trying to flourish in challenging institutional environments. Ours is an effort to uncover the bonds between persons and their institutional world, which is to shine a light on the process through which individuals participate in a *shared world of concern*. We demonstrate that the status of persons and their actions are something more than just a by-product of downward-institutional pressures (Battilana & D'Aunno, 2009; Holm, 1995). We contend how persons engage in institutional processes reflects their reflexive—evaluative—capacities exercised in

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contexts that shape but do not determine their agency (Delbridge & Edwards, 2013).

From this perspective, persons can be assumed to occupy an embodied world of concern that is “a collection of sedimented experiences, evaluations, commitments, and aspirations” which are socially constructed in respect to the concerns of important others leading to a “shared world of concern”. Treated as mutually constituted the explanatory task is to examine “how persons’ concerns are implicated in how they individually and collectively participate in institutional processes and arrangements” (Creed et al., 2022). While human needs and capacities are not universal, the potential for well-being is closely tied to what a person can *do* or *be* (Sen, 1999). Like institutions, such human capacities and concerns have a history derived from material, social, and natural conditions. Most notably, human flourishing depends on the “embodied relationships between humans and their natural world” and how “the multiplicity of human needs and demands run... up against the finite limits of human capacities” (Mutch, 2019, 91). How persons construct a shared world of concern is not straightforward because actors very often have quite different life experiences, and this marks important distinctions in their worldviews compared to others. It is because of this sedimentation that the relationship between the institutional processes that situate one person’s experiences and how they react are likely to be different to another person’s even when they are confronted by the same situation; institutional processes and how they are received are not synchronized precisely because persons are not social dopes but rather, they appraise with others their place in the world.

To explore this, we focus on a marginalized rural farming community in the Atlantic Forest, Brazil that became involved in the internationally agreed sustainable development program (UN Agenda 21). In a world marked by the Anthropocene rural communities in the Southern Hemisphere are often the most vulnerable to human activities on Earth’s climate and ecosystems (Crutzen & Stoermer, 2022). They are also most likely to be the ones subjected to violence as communities try to protect a way of life in usually valuable, resource-rich locations. It is because of this that they are also a go-to site for non-governmental organizations (NGOs) committed to encouraging sustainable development initiatives, as was the situation in our case. The creation of these types of arrangement is well documented in anthropological and developmental literatures. Here we are interested in explaining how in our case the introduction of an agroforestry system was achieved despite fundamental misunderstandings between those involved (Conklin & Graham, 1995). *Our contention is that a shared world of concern need not result*

from consensus rather it can be a product of a distorted understanding of a world inhabited by interested others.

Arguably, a shared world of concern based on a distortion of another's values can also threaten a person's worldview provoking emotionally intensive responses. Despite this, such occasions can lead to new arrangements, because such distortions may well still be leveraged to support the aspirations of those involved. To explain this, it is necessary to take a long view. How people build a shared world is a product of not just contextual conditions but also the concerns of individuals that situate efforts to persuade important others to work toward a common good. It is at the junction of this evaluative moment that the distortion of an important other and the values and practices they hold become apparent. The extent to which such a shared albeit distorted world of concern is achieved is a feature of how persons accommodate these tensions, which is tied to the way they carry the emotional scorch marks of the past as they navigate a complex, value-laden institutionalized world (Lorino, 2018).

Our approach builds on the work of Richard White (1991) who studied the pays d'en haut or the upper country of French Canada. In this work he introduced the notion of the *middle ground* to explain Indigenous-White relations between the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries. White's seminal study is of interest because he draws attention to the practical challenges of creating shared meaning on occasions when different social groups try to work together. As he points out: "People try to persuade others who are different from themselves by appealing to what they perceive to be the values and practices of those others. They often misinterpret and distort both the values and the practices of those they deal with, but from the misunderstandings arise new meanings and through these new practices is the shared meanings and practices of the middle ground" (White, 1991: xxvi). He goes on to argue that "To succeed, those who operated on the middle ground had, of necessity, to attempt to understand the world and the reasoning of others and to assemble enough of that reasoning to put it to their own purposes" (1991, p. 52). White's work is instructive because evaluations based on misunderstanding need not disrupt efforts to mobilize around a common concern because such events reflect new meanings and practices that can still support different interests.

In our story we focus on the efforts of an NGO activist who entered our community—Guapiruvu—for the purpose of introducing an agroforestry system. The activist who represented a Brazilian NGO tasked with introducing Agenda 21 was received by a small group of farmers and squatters. Together they engaged in public discussions about the potential to support

community resilience through improved forest husbandry. How these talks and subsequent actions unfolded is the site of our middle ground. When considering the success of these discussions it is important to reveal the concerns of the farmers and squatters in contrast to the concerns of the activist; that is, it is necessary to explore how the concerns of the other were incorporated into the meetings. We evidence the origins and consequences of the misunderstandings that characterized the conversations in the public meetings. Most significantly, our activist failed to fully appreciate the violent history of the community, which shaped the lack of life choices for the many. In turn, such scorch marks shaped the evaluations of the farmers and squatters' intent on improving their prospects. Instead, the activist framed their intervention as an opportunity to protect the forest and create new eco-opportunities. The grievances that were aired in these discussions highlighted a distortion of interests. Community resilience did not readily equate with forestry protection despite the wishes of the activist. It is in the context of such complexity that we find a situation that resonates with White's (1991) work. We report on how important others use a sufficient level of the reasoning of the other for their own purposes. Such efforts are not without cost and as such we also draw attention to the emotional intensity and *force* of those evaluations in considering the middle ground as a place where both parties carved out a resolution that suited their respective but different aims and understanding.

Our story presents a chance to explore how persons' concerns are implicated in their participation in institutional processes and arrangements (Creed et al., 2022). In this sense, the ambitions of the activist were situated by global processes—an emerging organizing logic of the natural environment—that had scripted the work of NGOs and governments toward ecosystem protection since the 1970s (Kovel, 2007). In turn, the concerns of the farmers and squatters were a feature of the political and social violence suffered by many marginalized communities implicated in the industrialization of agricultural processes that has contributed to the degradation of the natural environment. Both sets of concerns were anchored by a complex web of emotions, institutional processes and arrangements, which were laid bare through these public discussions. How these processes were incorporated into the discussions confirms the mediating role of persons making sense and evaluating those institutional pressures and processes within a local context.

Here the activist seemed to assume the community would fully embrace their push for natural resource management. Put crudely, they seemed to associate the community's role with that of the "noble savage" (Redford, 1991), when the farmers and squatters would act as the custodians of the forest's

fauna and flora. It was to be a naïve view given the complexities facing community members following years of exploitation and violence. The appeal to save the forest in a particularly rational and idealistic way did not resonate with the experiences (evaluations and feelings) of many in the community. And yet, this misreading of why the farmers and squatters entered discussions did not undermine the ambitions of the activist. Instead, they assembled enough support for their approach to deliver their environmental ambitions at a small scale in the community. In turn, the farmers and squatters thought the activist could help correct the wrongs of years of past exploitation. They appealed to them to support their claims to restore greater self-determination in the place they lived. They believed their collaboration, which was premised on a bottom-up approach toward community empowerment, would help them in their efforts. Their mistake was to assume the activist understood their claim to self-determination and how they wanted to live with the forest. Yet despite this, they saw the developmental opportunities offered by the agroforestry system consequential for their efforts to achieve social justice. Indeed, the move to introduce the new system presented the opportunity to establish a cooperative that would serve their social and political ambitions.

Before we explore the case history in greater detail, which is when we map out a shared world of concern premised on a middle ground, we first consider accounts of how actors inhabit institutions. This approach recognizes the need to develop more fully a nuanced understanding of actors in institutional processes. However, we prelude that discussion with a necessary theoretical placeholder, which is to frame the institutional significance of the natural environment as an organizing logic. This helps to scaffold the locus of the “middle ground” and the global–local call to action through sustainable development.

The Natural Environment: An Organizing Logic for Human-Nature Relations

According to Friedland and Alford (1991), institutional orders refer to Western capitalist societies’ central institutions, which comprise material practices and symbolic systems. In their work they set out five orders: capitalist market, bureaucratic state, democracy, nuclear family, and the Christian religion. In turn, each order has an institutional logic that shapes continuity and change processes through individual, organizational, and societal interactions and processes. Recent work in this area has seen revisions to Friedland

and Alford's ideas with discussions over the scope of possible central organizing logics leading to suggested new logics (Thornton et al., 2012; Mutch, 2019). For our purposes we suggest that given the growing interest in the natural environment and related concepts such as sustainable development, scholars should consider why such concerns have become a central organizing factor in shaping human-nature relations (Kovel, 2007; Lloyd, 2014).

Sustainability is generally understood as the capacity (of society) to meet "the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs" (Brundtland et al., 1987). It involves harmonizing our lives' economic, social, and environmental spheres, which in the context of recent debates over climate change often infers moving toward environmentally friendly transitions in production systems and social behavior (Sachs, 2006, 2012). The evolution of concerns about the natural environment can be traced to the early 1970s, when there was a growing awareness and unease about the planet's integrity. For example, in 1970, the first "Earth Day" event was organized (Meadows et al., 1972), which has long been a rallying call for "re-dedication to the preservation and enhancement of the environment" (Kovel, 2007, 1).

Interest in environmental welfare has and remains a key social concern spurred on by a growing realization that human activities pose a threat to climate stability and ecosystem resilience. As Kovel notes: "the era of environmental awareness, beginning roughly in 1970, has also been an era of greatest environmental breakdown" (2007, 3). Here we follow the work of Lloyd (2014) who suggests that an "environmental logic channels human activity towards participation in nature's protection and conservation to ensure the future survival of ecosystems. Social relations informed by the logic tend to reinforce the importance of collective mobilization and defensive guarding of the environment and instill the mentality that environmental protection is for itself and therefore not for other social or economic goals." (Lloyd, 2014, 66). To understand human-nature relations we need to appreciate the rise of a central logic that continues to inform political debate and practice at international, national, regional, and local levels. We suggest that the dissemination of the internationally agreed sustainable development program (UN Agenda 21) including in the community of Guapiruvu is a manifestation of the practical influence of such an organizing logic on the ground. What is interesting is how a framing device such as Agenda 21 was appropriated, which is why we consider the idea of a middle ground.

Unless we give due attention to an environmental logic, necessary elements of agency (beyond capitalist accumulation) will be attributed to a black box—our understanding of human-nature relations will remain partial because we

will not be able to fully consider how institutional pressures concerning the protection of the environment might affect how actors evaluate their world (see Suddaby et al., 2010). In our study we recognize a moment when persons are confronted by institutional complexity; that is, our long view of the basis of a person's evaluations incorporates reflections on the impact of capitalist accumulation interventions on a rural farming community and the destructive implications this has for those living in that place. Situating such conflicts presents a chance to explore the dynamics of human-nature agency that uncovers a situated world of concern full of distortions. In doing so, our study shows how an environmental logic is situated in a vulnerable territory and how such processes demonstrate the individual, collective, and inherently emotional dynamics of creating a shared world of concern.

Inhabiting Institutions—The Missing Agent

There is a growing body of work that focuses on the way agents inhabit institutions, which explores the idea that action, and the structural conditions which shape such action are neither synchronized nor deterministic (Edwards, 2015). The challenge which is foremost a conceptual conundrum is illustrated by “the paradox of embedded agency” (Battilana & D’Aunno, 2009). The paradox questions how it is possible for persons to instigate institutional change when their intentions, actions, and rationality are conditioned by the processes they want to challenge (Holm, 1995). For change to occur persons need to be able to critique that institutional world, which means they must have the capacity, under certain conditions, to evaluate, agitate, and act (often in collaboration with others) in opposition to those pressures (Mutch, 2019). In doing so scholars report that persons don’t follow simple institutional scripts rather social interactions frame how actors enact such scripts in a meaningful context (Hallett & Ventresca, 2006). While the scope for action is always circumscribed by obdurate social relations and contexts such relations and contexts do not leave actors as social dopes (Binder, 2007). Instead, such accounts draw attention to the politics of inhabiting institutions when actors engage in struggles over meaning and interests (Hallett, 2010).

Recent developments indicate that while social interactions are important for explaining agency there is a need to locate such interactions and their accompanying negotiations within much broader tracts of history (Mutch, 2019). This is to acknowledge that social interactions not only reflect local circumstances but that such circumstances also reveal institutional conditions

that are complex precisely because they expose long held contentions that may remain opaque to those unfamiliar with that world. And, for those living in that world such echoes of the past will likely shape their reflexive capacities as they evaluate their social conditions (Delbridge & Edwards, 2013; Creed et al., 2022). Work considering the evaluative nature of agency (Creed et al., 2014) confirms that it is the constant review of circumstances and experiences that inform how individuals make sense of their world and attribute value to that place. This is not a simple process but reflects the different ways people collide with other value systems and contexts and as we will show such occasions can be intensely emotional moments. As Creed and colleagues (2022) argue: “throughout life, peoples’ embodied lives unfold in a complex milieu of experiences, reflecting diverse values and institutional arrangements.”

Ours is an attempt to make sense of such complexity and agency (Greenwood et al., 2011), especially when persons struggle to secure control over their own lives when their immediate circumstances become vulnerable through the actions of others (Lear, 2006). Often, institutional accounts of complexity represent the collision of worlds as a simple tradeoff between values much in the same way that studies of acculturation insist that when one group confronts another one will usually become more like another by borrowing certain cultural traits. Our view suggests that while institutional complexity has the potential to lead to acculturation (sometimes through violent acts) it can also be a more contoured world because our shared understanding is based on distinct associations in how we identify with that world, which can be the source of misunderstanding to others.

The middle ground (White, 1999) is a useful device to consider how persons inhabit their worlds. It is the place where competing interests collide leading to distortions, but it is in this space that new agreements emerge as values and beliefs are reconciled or suspended to fulfill ambitions and expectations. This is consistent with the ideas emerging from the micro institutional literature (Creed et al., 2022). In broad terms it is accepted that actors engaged in social interactions can re-construct the meanings attributed to institutional domains. However, ours is an attempt to see such agency from the long view that moves from an investigation of the here-and-now to reveal the evaluative context as deeply sedimented; that is, to show the scorch marks of past battles and injustices in the way meanings and practices are conceived. In turn, by emphasizing the emergence of the middle ground as a situated response to the personal and collective experiences of a disruptive past we draw attention to the emotional nature of such processes.

A Short Note on Methodology

The findings for this study were based on data collected from 2016 to 2025. The second author conducted 17 semi-structured interviews and took notes of 12 testimonies. Also, the second author wrote 18 different field diaries, comprising 22 pages of notes. The other authors took notes at different meetings since 2018 up until the present day, which adds up to 35 pages of testimony. The authors also participate in two WhatsApp groups: “CCG AMA,” which deals with a citizen science project, with 45 members and “Guapiruvu, menos é mais,” interested in subjects concerning the cooperatives and community, with 72 members. Those groups offer access to different discussions from trivial jokes to anecdotes and debates on issues that relate to sustainability. We also collected secondary data from different documents, including 12 organization projects, 11 organizational records, 15 official e-mails, and 19 newspaper and magazine articles. We watched 7 videos from media reports. In Guapiruvu, we gathered documents from projects implemented by local organizations in partnership with other civil society organizations, as well as journalistic materials and documents on the mural of Cooperagua and the House of Agriculture of Sete Barras. While we do not have space to give more details of the work conducted in Guapiruvu suffice to say the authors have spent considerable time in the community (almost 10 years for the second author) and have grown to appreciate the challenges experienced by the inhabitants given their violent past.

The Longview of Subsistence Farming in Guapiruvu

Starting with the Here-and-Now

The Guapiruvu neighborhood is a rural site located in the municipality of Sete Barras, in the Ribeira Valley of the State of São Paulo. Approximately 70 families work as farmers in a rural agrarian reform settlement located in the neighborhood. Based on intensive agricultural practices using external agricultural inputs, industrial banana farming is practiced on large farms and most medium-sized properties. As reported by residents, the intensive use of external agricultural inputs—especially fertilizers, pesticides, and conditioners—is essential for producing quality standards in wholesale markets. Appearance aspects such as the size and uniform tonality are highlighted as primary attributes for mass banana marketing. Settled family farmers, in

turn, use integrated semi-intensive systems where banana and peach palm (pupunha) are cultivated together. They claim not to use external agricultural products due to the high cost, although they will occasionally apply pesticides against typical banana diseases if required.

In a separate development, two influential leaders in the neighborhood and two land reform rural settlers have introduced an alternative approach to farming that is not industrial in approach. By integrating banana cultivation with native wood and fruit species from the Atlantic Forest, they have sought to imitate the original forest formations. The system guarantees an ecological balance that frees farmers from using chemical inputs, requiring periodic interventions to ensure that sun light reaches plants at different stages of growth. In all, 12 family farmers in the neighborhood have organic certification for their agricultural production. Since 2000, these family farmers and some of the producers on medium-sized properties have organized themselves into an agricultural marketing cooperative; the *Cooperativa Agropecuária de Produtos Sustentáveis do Guapiruvu* (Cooperagua). The cooperative has ensured that local farmers can organize themselves to overcome the actions of predatory intermediaries trying to underprice their products. In recent years, the cooperative has also begun to organize the purchase of agricultural inputs and the collective use of agricultural machinery provided by the municipal public administration. It also manages the leading destination of banana production, which is purchased by the municipalities of Greater São Paulo (including the city of São Paulo) and other smaller cities in the Ribeira Valley region to supply schools with fresh produce. In doing so, this arrangement has helped efforts to reinstate past hunter-gather practices and this involves the farmers and squatters who were engaged in negotiations around Agenda 21 and who operate on the *middle ground*.

The First 100 Years—the 1850s to the 1950s Living in Guapiruvu

Our research of Guapiruvu indicates a close relationship between farmers and squatters and the forest, since the use of traditional practices of rotational agriculture was combined with hunting, fishing, and the use of the forest—such as the juçara palm tree—in ways to satisfy the needs of families. Asked about the past, older residents described the neighborhood as a place of abundance guaranteed by the forest. Practices of collaboration and solidarity, such as crop planting and harvesting efforts, were described as representative of the social relations of the past. Kinship and neighborhood ties enabled mutual aid

mechanisms, configuring a social cohesion that did not depend on money. Residents used the land on a partially communal and rotating basis, establishing temporary planting areas where they produced rice, cassava, and maize (Bernini, 2009). The planting took place through a practice still common in *quilombola* communities, the *coivara*. Based on rotating land management, slash-and-burn was used to open clearings in the forests on slopes and floodplains. This guaranteed each family a portion of land sufficient to meet their demands and needs. The harvest was stored for consumption throughout the year, while small chicken and pig farming, hunting, and fishing complemented the diet. The only market-related activities concerned those occasions when the farmers used to buy *cachaça* (spirits), salt, and sugar in the local town, among other items not guaranteed by the agriculture. The sale of agricultural surpluses in markets in Sete Barras (the local large town) gave the farmers access to money (Bernini, 2009).

When we consider this period we recognize subsistence farming and the dislocation of the settlement from urban living, municipal and state services and support. In terms of work, we are reminded that the farmers spent most daylight hours in the forest or the fields tending their crops and foraging for food. Daily concerns focused on these basic needs and practices. The potential to flourish relied on kinship ties and a reciprocal relationship between families. The loyalty to each other based around marriage also confirmed the important role of the Catholic Church in creating a context around which familial bonds flourished. Put simply, the settlements social cohesion relied upon clearly defined connections between family, church, and the forest which was supported by legal apparatus. While these farmers did not own the land they worked; the legal apparatus established at that time guaranteed them the recognition of their right to use those lands (Bernini, 2009).

While vulnerabilities around this work were overcome by the combined capacities of individuals working together to ensure the safe and steady supply of food there were significant other vulnerabilities and these related to the dislocation of the settlement from state and municipal support. During this period, the settlement existed without a school and because road links with the local urban areas were practically non-existent it was impossible for the children to receive a formal education outside the settlement. Even today, children over 12 years old must spend long periods of time traveling to schools in the urban areas. In benign times the inhabitants could survive well-enough unless there was need for medical services, which were also extremely hard to access.

Community Disruption Through Incorporation into the Capitalist Circuit

The opening of roads connecting the Ribeira Valley to the metropolises of São Paulo and Curitiba, combined with state investments in agricultural credit, agricultural research, and colonization aimed at expanding commercial agriculture (Müller, 1980; Zan, 1987; Bernini, 2009), led to the arrival of new actors (“foreigners”) in Guapiruvu from the 1960s. These actors sought space to practice economic activities following a commercial orientation, which included large-scale banana farming and massive exploitation of the forest to produce wood, charcoal, and *juçara* palm. Exposure to the capitalist circuit of production and consumption was accompanied by land conflicts based on legal challenges around ownership and land rights forced upon the original inhabitants. These were evidenced by the eviction of families through the involvement of the *jagunços* (private security force) in 1966 and, later, of police forces by judicial decision in 1992.

The arrival of families dedicated to commercial agriculture throughout the 1960s changed the social dynamics of the neighborhood. Although not rivaling the established habits and practices, the demand for temporary agricultural work in the banana plantations then established increased. Gradually, informal working relationships were formed linking former farmers to new residents, some of which remained in place during the research (Bernini, 2009). This arrival also accentuated the relative interdependence of the neighborhood and the more general circuits of São Paulo and the national economy. The original families began to adopt banana cultivation while maintaining the usual crops through slash-and-burn, mutual aid practices, and the informal system of dividing areas, guaranteeing swiddens to all families.

This general framework of social accommodation was radically impacted in the second half of the 1960s. A Brazilian military officer visited the neighborhood and introduced himself as a prosecutor for the State of São Paulo. He asked each family to sign a document, claiming that it was the legal document for claiming the possessions historically occupied by the families. Later, the families who agreed to sign the papers discovered that it was a scam. They signed a declaration denying their precedence over those lands. *Jagunços*, hired by a São Paulo businessman named Dr. Marcelo “Pio” Penteado, expelled the families from their homes in 1966, destroying the improvements, plantations, and livestock they maintained. This eviction ushered in a period of social instability lasting approximately one year. Faced with the impossibility of maintaining their subsistence farming practices, many had

to work on the farms installed on the lands they had been expelled from. The jagunços began to overtake the neighborhood putting pressure on the families, adopting a violent posture including physical and moral harassment. In this period, there were violent clashes between the jagunços and families, causing deaths on both sides (Bernini, 2009).

In 1973, the company Villares claimed to own the land after buying it from Dr. Marcelo “Pio” Penteadó. There, they managed the cultivation of bananas for more than a decade, while also extracting wood and palm hearts. During this period, many original family members worked on the farms. Gradually, bananas became the main crop in these family’s gardens. As banana management is not intensive, especially when compared to the process of planting, harvesting, and preparing rice, mutual aid efforts began to diminish. Little by little, the original family members became familiar with intensive agriculture practices while wage labor was consolidated as the primary means of meeting their needs (Benini, 2009). In 1985, Villares abandoned the area, which would be re-occupied by the original families in 1989. In the meantime, the medium-sized producers installed in the neighborhood had signed a collaboration agreement to cultivate ginger. The families quickly opened gardens for growing ginger in their former possessions in the floodplains of the Etá River, resuming the practice of group planting to take advantage of the opportunity opened by medium-sized producers. Locals refer to this period as ushering in the so-called “Ginger Age.” However, it would not be the decisive return to their original way of living or farming methods. Motivated by a court decision in favor of Villares, a new eviction was carried out in 1992. The so-called Ginger Age implied a significant inflow of money to the neighborhood. In addition to expanding the planting areas, they intensified the use of chemical inputs, such as pesticides and fertilizers. However, this intensification led to a depletion of the soil’s fertility. Malnourished and nutritionally impoverished, ginger growing areas were plagued by disease, imposing significant losses on producers. In due course, such production ceased leaving the farmers and forest equally diminished.

The vulnerabilities of living a precarious life in the forest had shifted from concerns about the regularity of the crops and the success of the hunt, to self-defense and violent (re)action. In terms of maintaining family life the farmers had now become subject to the vagaries of temporary working relationships and the threat of eviction, each in their different way undermining their livelihoods. Coinciding with the violent attack on the social fabric was the commercial exploitation of the forest. Such complexity re-cast the possibilities of subsistence. In the face of insecurity and representative isolation there

was very little opportunity or room to consider alternative courses of action—the basic instinct to survive ensured that those families deciding to stay had to find any means possible to ensure a basic livelihood. This created a huge emotional burden which motivated more recent efforts to ensure community stability. Our understanding of Agenda 21 cannot be dislocated from these memories and experiences. They were seared into many people's memories which subsequently shaped the middle ground.

Dislocation from the Past and an Existential Threat to a Way of Living

Our narrative points to a massive upheaval to the way of life experienced by inhabitants in Guapiruvu during these multiple evictions and agricultural changes. A video produced by missionaries from the Pastoral Land Commission records the moment in which the families were evicted again in 1992. A transcription is given below:

"We, the squatters of Guapiruvu, want to make the population aware of what has been happening to our children and us. In these lands of Guapiruvu, in the Eta Valley, our great-grandparents were born, lived, and died more than a century ago. So, Lieutenant Otaviano Burgo Neto appeared in these parts, claiming to be a state attorney. He took the file from each family, saying it was to prepare the possession documents. Some of the ancients believed and signed papers. Then Marcelo Pio arrived, claiming to be the owner of these lands, bringing a gang of jagunços, who, under threat of weapons, forced all the squatters to sign documents, but most resisted and did not sign. We were then run over by jagunços led by Arariba, who burned our plants, crops, and houses and killed our animals. And finally, they drove us from our lands. The damage they caused us at that time has never been recovered. A few years after we were expelled from our land, Villares arrived, claiming to be the new owner of our lands. And the land was abandoned for a long time. In 1989, we had access to documents that proved that the land was vacant. We then decided to return to our lands. During these three years, I worked hard to try to recover what we lost. And just when we thought we were already recovering from the losses, Francisco Petrick arrived, saying he had bought our lands from Villares. Furthermore, with a favorable sentence of justice, we were again expelled from our lands."

Through a narrative of hardship and deprivation we evidence an important shift in social context that indicates how these families were incorporated into

the circuit of capitalism. These events confirm a particular embodied relationship between the families and the forest while exposing the limits of human capacities to protect themselves (Mutch, 2019). Here we set the scene for a mismatch in the way external interventions around sustainable development and a community's concern for security might unfold. The evaluations of farmers and squatters were keenly expressed and felt—with such grievances comes a sense of anger (desperation) and a *forceful* sense of injustice that fed directly into their evaluations of Agenda 21.

A Turn Toward Sustainable Development

From 1980 onwards the Atlantic Forest region began to be protected by a mosaic of environmental conservation units following the promulgation of the first National Environmental Policy and the creation of the National Environmental Council in 1981. Several conservation units were established in Vale de Ribeira in the same period. In 1982, the Carlos Botelho State Park was created, covering an area of more than 37 thousand hectares in the municipalities of Capão Bonito, São Miguel Arcanjo, and Sete Barras. In 1987, Fazenda Intervales was incorporated into the Serra do Mar Environmental Preservation Area, created 10 years earlier. Comprising an area of more than 40 thousand hectares in the municipalities of Ribeirão Grande, Guapiara, Sete Barras, Eldorado, and Iporanga, the area was elevated to the status of State Park in 1995.

Both parks have areas adjacent to the Guapiruvu neighborhood. The second has a monitoring headquarters in the neighborhood itself. These advances were significant because they also coincided with the creation of legislation typifying environmental crimes related to animal and plant exploitation. In turn, special regimes for managing and using space were created, establishing areas of environmental interest. In the Vale de Ribeira, this represented a significant change in the ability of rural communities to maintain established social practices and habits. The use of fire, typical of slash-and-burn, hunting, fishing, and plant extraction—predominantly wood and palm hearts—became environmental crimes. As their lands were being disputed, the farmers were simultaneously confronted with the impossibility of guaranteeing space to maintain subsistence swiddens. Here we see that as the environmental agenda spread to Guapiruvu local farmers and squatters were disarmed and unable to protect how they lived. The incorporation of the workforce through the establishment of informal and temporary

work regimes on large or medium-sized ginger farms also remained the only alternative to meet the needs and demands of the original farming families.

An Emergent Middle Ground

Direct action concerning environmental conservation reached the neighborhood in 1996 through the work of the environmental organization *Vitae Civilis*. One of the first actions of the community working with this NGO was to create the Solidarity Economy and Sustainable Development Association of Guapiruvu, known as AGUA in 1996. This was a significant development because “in 1997, AGUA started a series of programs such as eco-tourism activities, production and commercialization of medicinal plants, courses on agroforestry, support for the creation of the municipal secretariat for rural development, the mapping of tourist trails..., the creation of guided activities, and fundraising from various sources for activities aimed at environmental sustainability” (Nogueira, 2023). This work was designed to overcome the precarity of many of those farmers’ incomes since the failure in ginger production. This initial work also precipitated the move by *Vitae Civilis* to introduce Agenda 21, in 1997.

Agenda 21 was “an international attempt to establish and realize a world plan aiming at the necessary transformations so that, in the entry into the twenty-first century, human beings and the planet may be closer to situations and paths that lead to ideal conditions of life, individually and collectively” (*Vitae Civilis*, 1998). The action was part of a research project entitled “From the forest to the house,” which aimed to establish the economic use of medicinal plants (Bernini, 2009). The framework was based on a participatory bottom-up approach, guided by the motto “think globally act locally”. The central outcome of Agenda 21 was a normative document conceived and agreed upon by the participants through a series of regular meetings guided by a facilitator. The document started from a diagnosis guided by simple questions—where do we live? who we are? how do we live?—to a set of principles and objectives guided by a final question: “how would we like to live?”. The answer to this question unfolded in an action plan establishing the responsibilities of the participants and other agents (NGOs, governments, and environmental police) in the implementation of an agroforestry system.

The collaboration between the farming families and the NGO began in May. Agenda 21 was premised on a universalist approach for environmental sustainability and a strong emphasis on rational planning. Although the facilitator from the NGO tasked with negotiating and gaining agreement to

develop and implement the project demonstrated a genuine interest in realizing a common good within the community, his mandate carried a system of meaning and ideas embedded in a view of conservation—forest husbandry—that stood in opposition to the actual ideas and values of many farmers in Guapiruvu. His appeal, was to find ways to transform how local farmers would interact with the forest. In some ways, this might seem reasonable, given the work of AGUA that had started previously but this basic approach ignored how the farmers felt about their lives in the forest, which was filled with pain, violence, and economic uncertainty. Indeed, the work of AGUA was focused on trying to recognize the community's colonial past and yet this was not fully understood during these negotiations (Grigoletto, 2018).

When describing his immersion in the neighborhood, the facilitator pointed out a lack of community as a striking feature of social relations in the neighborhood. This dynamic was expressed in the relationship between employees and employers: the squatters then expropriated from their lands as employees and commercial farmers as employers. Agricultural work on medium and large farms functioned as a mechanism for the dissemination of intensive agricultural practices using chemical products. Traditional farming practices—much less destructive for the ecological system—had been lost during the long process of expropriation of the squatters' lands. The work of those interested in protecting the forest and supporting traditional practices had yet to materialize despite the initiatives started by AGUA the year before. As it was, at this time, many in the group working with the facilitator resorted to the illegal exploration of forest products to survive. Both groups—employers and employees—joined the meetings from the very beginning, but with just two of the medium-size property owners engaged in the activities. While the facilitator noted the consequences of these political and violent actions there was a complete lack of empathy as to their practical impact. This was just—unfortunate—context it did not change the need to sustainably develop food production in appropriate ways.

What we know about the meetings involving the facilitator and members of the Guapiruvu farming representatives is the espoused objectives of the facilitator failed to resonate. These meetings were attended by participants interested in protecting their way of life, not introducing managed ways of farming. Their commitment to highlighting the hardships of their lives was uppermost in their actions. For example, at least one of the participants insisted on attending the meetings right after returning from the forest where he was cutting palm hearts, an illegal activity. His clothes and boots soiled with mud and the machete at his waist showed his intention. He repeatedly stated that the move to curtail subsistence farming—what many farming

families relied upon to supplement paid work, would not be agreed. Such evaluations confirmed important distinctions in the way past experiences informed present priorities.

The farmers appealed to the facilitator to meet the community's real needs. This appeal was to focus on other more pressing concerns including issues of basic infrastructure and social rights: transport and road conditions; poor health care; the situation of education (lack of quality and complete primary education) and the lack of unity in the community. Interestingly, the incentive to adopt sustainable agricultural practices contrasted with the central barrier to their adoption: the expropriation of land to which squatter families had been subject since the 1960s. There was no land to cultivate new agricultural practices, except if you were an employer. This mismatch of intentions and meanings with those in attendance was stark (White, 1991). These meetings became the point where members of the farming community and activist effectively talked past each other because these gatherings revealed important misunderstandings of each other. The experience of being marginalized in one's own land ensured a radicality that reverberated throughout these discussions, since it was rooted at the level of emotions, needs, and vulnerabilities. These emotions reflected an exasperation in the mismatch of views—a combination of anger and resignation was not uncommon. In turn, the activist tended to shrug off these concerns effectively suspending the emotions of others because they did not serve his needs.

The farm workers especially the squatters could not understand the demands being placed on them for sustainability given their experiences when their traditional ways of life had been made illegal. The focus on the forest seemed disproportionate to their life experiences. They had been exploited to such an extent that whatever options were open to them represented yet another injustice. They valued their attachment to the battles and legacies of the past—these were not to be forgotten. As mentioned by one of the subsistence farmers they were only faced with poor choices: “cutting hearts of palm in the forest is the worst profession in the world.” Appealing to the social crisis that enveloped the community did not resonate with the activist in any meaningful way. The activist failed to realize why the farmers would not react to the environmental crisis as they had wanted. Their evaluations and accompanying emotions revealed a sense of frustration and yet the farmers used the status of the discussions as a platform to find a new unity and coherence to move forward. Their enthusiasm presented as a stark counter position to the bemusement of the activist. The position of the activist leading the work for *Vitae Civilis* is intriguing because the purpose of this organization, was and remains to this day to contribute to the establishment of just communities.

The intent was to ensure such communities were supported to achieve social justice, environmental conservation and integrity, diversity (cultural, ethnic, religious), democracy, and economic viability. This expectation is evidenced in recent publications concerning the work of Vitae Civilis in Guapiruvu (Nogueira, 2023).

Our point in mapping out these events is to reveal a shared world of concern that was imminent in the experiences of the farmers and squatters that made up the small group of community residents involved in Agenda 21. The subsequent establishment of the cooperative (Cooperagua) followed the efforts of several of these farmers who championed the aspirations of those in the community given their precarious realities. These leaders determined that a cooperative would transform the civil rights of the community and in ways that were directly relevant to those effected by the environmental crisis. Building arguments around eco-agricultural production led to discussions about creating social stability that would ensure the possibility to live in ways that supplemented their already precarious living (by hunting and foraging). The community perspective allowed those less advantaged to be heard while the establishment of the cooperative created new ways for the community to engage with the authorities. This was about community cohesion created under the banner of sustainable development but in ways that effectively hid in plain sight practices that were unlawful in respect of environmental protection. Arrangements such as AGUA and Cooperagua focused attention on the social and economic needs of many marginalized persons. Agenda 21 and the partnership with Vitae Civilis had been mobilized to achieve these social justice aims despite the apparent focus on environmental protection. And yet despite these struggles the NGO was still able to claim success because in their efforts to create Cooperagua they created the conditions for sustainable agricultural practices to gradually emerge. This, in turn, provided the case of community action in defense of the natural environment.

Agenda 21 facilitated the establishment of the Cooperagua following the initial success of AGUA. The process of negotiations that led to this new arrangement began before Agenda 21 was introduced with the establishment of AGUA as a kind of test ground for the select farmers and squatters keen to improve their livelihoods. Agenda 21 was more expansive as it involved the community and facilitator in agreeing a template of actions over many weeks and months of public discussion. The creation of the cooperative was driven and arranged by the few farmers willing to commit to a new way of living. They had achieved a position of legitimacy with the agreement signed with the NGO. They now designed how the cooperative would operate and in

doing so created the context for greater social and economic stability without inhibiting those squatters from following a more traditional life.

Our argument is that these arrangements emerged on a middle ground through which the small group of farmers and squatters interested in righting the political wrongs of the past. The move to eco-agriculture suited these ambitions but not in the ways the NGO had set out. Their collaboration led to the introduction of these new practices in a small number of farms but only those that were committed to social justice on their terms. This nonetheless enabled the NGO to claim success albeit in ways that did not reflect all their intentions. Forestry protection through the adoption of eco-practices was achieved in parts of the forest—owned or farmed by those families interested in social justice. The upshot was a shared world of concern based on misunderstandings of important others. Its significance is the subject of the next section in this chapter.

Discussion

In this chapter, we have investigated how some of the farmers and squatters in Guapiruvu created a shared world of concern. This was negotiated in the context of the Agenda 21 that involved efforts to support community resilience that also supported efforts by *Vitae Civilis* to introduce new eco-agricultural practices. Our historical narrative highlights the importance of acknowledging how the past frames the creation of a shared world of concern in the present. Initially we presented a life of subsistence farming and hunting and gathering, one isolated from urban areas and capitalist practices. Life in the forest was based on a frugal living style—not one of excessive exploitation. The farmers and squatters' concerns reveal associated values and practices that were well-understood in the community. In what followed, we see the vagaries of the capitalist commercial circuit from the 1950s with the recourse to violence and force by outsiders reframing community relations. We see a different set of concerns emerging as the inhabitants were dislocated from the forest and a past way of living, forced to re-position and reimagine what was possible. Such shared histories became symbolic resources that helped anchor persons emotionally to their past as they engaged in the negotiations.

Our long view confirms that such experiences and memories represent a biography that shapes interests. Such memories exist outside social interactions in much the same way knowledge is stored in a library waiting to be used. How and when we bring such memories into play is a situated experience. This dislocation from the forest is crucial in appreciating why some

members of the farming community worked toward addressing their own socio-political needs in the context of a sustainable development plan. These efforts were made possible by the middle ground which is a feature of how the farmers and squatters, and NGO facilitator tried to make sense of a multi-dimensional, value-laden world.

Our interest in what is effectively a story of social exclusion helps to explain why an interest in forest protection might be distorted in ways that reflect a very distinct—Guapiruvu centric—interpretation of human-nature relations. The accretion of evaluations, which is summarized in Table 15.1—offers a sense of the concerns and vulnerabilities, evaluations, and relations that emerged. The resulting cooperative (from 2000) made sense against these experiences, evaluations, and relations. Arguably, the institutional scripts found in Agenda 21 that were designed to synchronize the protection of the forest with community resilience did not follow as expected because the evaluations of each of the interested party's reflected quite specific concerns (and emotions) that contrasted to the meaning and values inherent in the institutional script for forestry protection.

These evaluations provide a view into the complexity of that shared world of concern. For the locals involved in Agenda 21 the past could not (and would not) be ignored despite the seeming ambitions of the *Vitae Civilis*

Table 15.1 The long view to a shared world of concern

Transformative epochs	Vulnerabilities	Evaluations	Human-nature relations
Idyllic memories (1850–1960)	Laborious work; precarious conditions of spatial mobility; illiteracy; lack of legal knowledge	Reciprocity and kinship ties as mechanisms guaranteeing survival	Symbiosis; immanence; dependence
A place in dispute (1960–2000)	Land conflicts; violence; temporary work; restrictions on forest and space use	Injustice; insecurity; rage; powerlessness; resignation; isolation	Commercial exploitation
Cooperative organizing (2000 on wards)	Marketing controlled by middlemen; soil exhaustion; regularization of land tenure	Collective action; social justice; citizenship right; solidarity economy	Gradual transition for sustainable practices

Source Authors' compilation

facilitator. The organizing logic that was manifest in the values and practices designed to provide stricter forestry controls confirmed the dominant discourses around environmental protection. And yet, such seemingly clear messaging provoked a considerable emotional response from many locals. The situatedness and character of these evaluations dispelled any possibility of a simple compromise. Instead, the establishment of the cooperative on the back of the initiation of AGUA was first and foremost a political move to give the farmers and squatters legitimacy to protect their way of life. Such actions ensured the introduction of eco-agricultural practices was not a simple act to protect the forest but was rather a situated response to the needs of those excluded farmers and squatters in achieving a secure future. This was key to achieving the aims of the farmers and squatters; that is, to understand the world they had to employ the reasoning of others in ways that supported their own purposes, and this was achieved through the incorporation of agro-forestry in the new cooperative. This was not to deny the claims of the NGO concerning forestry protection, but it includes the suspension of some aspects concerning how the community treated the forest as a necessary provider of food. At those times when complexities around meaning and practice surfaced the members of the community made decisions that suspended what might be termed a “shared” world of concern, and these reflect the influence of emotionally charged past concerns, beliefs, and practices.

Likewise, the NGO suspended challenges to the legitimacy of Agenda 21 given the exploitative actions of some in the community. Instead, they focused on the potential of the cooperative to organize sustainable farming practices. This was the middle ground—a space where the farmers and squatters and the facilitator could operate to achieve their desired aims but in ways that was a distorted view of that shared world.

Conclusions

Institutional accounts that try to overcome the micro–macro divide treat persons as capable of purposeful evaluation, which is always conducted in the presence of important others within an institutional and material setting. This is not to propose an overly voluntaristic or rationalized world rather it is to recognize that persons are sentient—knowledgeable and emotional—beings bound to but not determined by the institutional processes that shape them (Mutch, 2019). They are capable of love and fear—they are not social dopes but mindful and often fragile agents. A person’s concerns (vulnerabilities and priorities) are encapsulated in what matters to them which shapes

(but does not determine) how they conduct themselves; that is, a person's evaluative capacities are consequential for the way persons respond to others. From this we can infer that a person's evaluative capabilities are a feature of their past lives (life-story) which help them to empathize and navigate the complexities of their present concerns.

A shared world of concern does not necessarily rely on consensus but rather can reflect a pragmatism that allows persons to work with what they understand (or don't as we have shown). What can be shared is misunderstanding but this does not preclude the potential to create new meaning and understanding, which is not a simple reflection of a scripted institutionalized world, but an outcome of meanings mediated by individuals that is often charged. The middle ground is the "meeting point for ideas and politics" (Scoones, 2007: 589), which in this case was when community and NGO tried to reconcile competing interests and demands in protecting the environment and society (Banerjee, 2003; Marshall & Toffel, 2005; Solow, 1993). This case confirms that environmental sustainability is a feature of the spatial-historical complexities of the societies and organizational forms that emerge in respect of competing interests and experiences. The local responses that emerge may themselves reflect the heavy hand of the past expressed through persons concerns of what matter to them albeit in ways that may be a distortion of the views and concerns of important others as they try to respond to those shared challenges.

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Part IV

Practicing Emotions and Values in Context



16

Benevolence and Inequality: The Ethics of Moral Indebtedness

Venus Sharma and John Amis

Introduction

Values are experienced as moral imperatives, directing motivations, actions, and post hoc rationalizations (Kraatz 2020). As such, values are drawn upon to justify or legitimize the practices and institutions that shape our social world. Values, therefore, are inherently tied to the ethical and moral frameworks through which we interpret and evaluate socio-economic disparities based on class, caste, gender, race, and so on. Further, values such as meritocracy, individualism, competition, efficiency, and self-interest are known to be associated with practices that worsen inequalities (Amis, 2020; Bapuji et al., 2020; Kumar et al., 2024). Yet, while our current understanding of organizational practices that reproduce societal inequalities has advanced (Amis et al., 2020), the role values play in driving such practices and sustaining the institutions associated with them has not been adequately theorized. Significantly, we have little understanding as to how values, that are ostensibly considered positive, can be weaponized to legitimize a moral order of stark inequalities. We begin to address this by theorizing how values are conceptualized in institutions that sustain social inequalities. In so doing, our chapter furthers our

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theoretical and practical understanding of negative aspects of values and their role in entrenching inequalities.

Our examination of the interplay of values, institutions, and inequality is grounded in a study of relations between rural farmers and an agriculture-technology firm in India that positioned itself as pursuing a socially oriented mission. We observed a shift in control of agrarian production from local small landowning farmers to a new business model that turned farmers into dependent low-wage labor. In acquiescing to this change, farmers assumed a moral responsibility toward the private market project and considered the agricultural-technology company as benefactors. By adhering to a perceived higher moral duty toward the company's project, farmers continued their participation despite recurring problems with the project that disadvantaged them and reduced their opportunities for social mobility.

Drawing on our empirical case, we theorize the negative role of social values such as moral obligation in sustaining socio-economic inequality in a particular institutional context. We first trace the historical function of moral indebtedness as a value system that maintained caste–class rigidities in pre-capitalist agriculture in India (Kumar, 2016; Lerche & Shah, 2018). We define moral indebtedness as an obligation internalized by the laboring classes to reciprocate a perceived favor embedded in the patron–client exchange relationships that have long characterized the early rural Indian economy. Although the traditional institutions of patronage have declined, we found that moral indebtedness emerged from our fieldwork as persistent among labor hierarchies shaped by new techno-managerial interventions. In so doing, we reveal how paternalistic values such as those associated with benevolence and gratitude continue to be implicated in eliciting consent of subordinated groups. However, in the contemporary capitalist economy, we show how rural communities, despite being highly aware of their labor value and structural position, emulate the tradition of moral indebtedness to avoid conflict and a potential loss of income, even as that income diminished.

We argue that moral indebtedness emerges in institutions where a twin dynamic of hierarchy and dependence shapes the relationships among their inhabitants. Moral indebtedness therefore functions as a paternalistic value that legitimizes new power structures by justifying the participation of subordinated actors in changing economic relations. In the short-term, moral indebtedness is drawn upon to successfully organize heterogeneous actors for economic reproduction through precarious and low-paying work. However, we also show that in the longer-term, subordinated groups can potentially challenge these seemingly entrenched values as conditions change. In particular, our findings reveal the role of emotions, notably anger and discontent, in

the challenging of values. Our exploration of power-laden agrarian relations thus shows how certain values are implicated in, and become consequential for, social stratification and inequality.

In the next section, we provide an overview of values, institutions, and inequality to expose the limitations in our theoretical understanding of their relationship. This is followed by an exploration of moral indebtedness as a value central to the now dormant institution of patron–client economic exchange in rural India and consideration of how the value of moral indebtedness is implicated in sustaining unequal labor relations in contemporary techno-managerial agriculture in India. We then provide a short overview of our research contexts and the methods that we employed in our data collection and analysis. In the findings, we provide insight into how the experiences of farmers evolved during their interactions with the agriculture-technology firm. Finally, in our discussion we elaborate how, despite inequality as a common outcome, the function and nature of moral indebtedness change as the underlying conditions evolve from pre-capitalist agriculture to new market institutions. In so doing, we add to our theoretical understanding of institutions as reified social structures that shape and reinforce values to sustain hierarchical structures and economic dependence. In this way, we contribute to our understanding of values that have negative implications for societal inequalities. We further account for how such values appear to be historically enduring and yet are able to be displaced as socio-economic conditions within institutions change. Finally, by examining the consequences of values for inequality, we theorize how people’s vulnerability and precarity have implications for their participation in institutional arrangements (Creed et al., 2022).

Theoretical Background

Values, Institutions, and Inequality

Selznick’s (1949, 2008) emphasis on the role of values in understanding societal institutions has inspired a resurgence in interest in a value-centered approach (e.g., Kraatz et al., 2020). Inquiries in institutional research have demonstrated that values remain central to institutions and can facilitate conditions of emergence, realization, and decline (Amis et al., 2002; Gehman, 2013; Kraatz, 2010; Selznick, 1996). The institutional approach to values also entails the pragmatist perspectives that consider people as the bearers of the values that further animate their actions by providing meaning

and purpose (Kraatz & Block, 2017). Yet, there are also cautions to avoid the pitfalls of characterizing people as “either overly rational in pursuing values or as cultural automatons” when understanding their participation in institutions (Creed et al., 2022: 364). This points to a need for greater attention to evaluating how values influence institutional arrangements.

There are consequences to our current understanding of values as normative beliefs that are practiced, protected, or maintained by individuals or organizations through institutional work or “value work” (Gehman et al., 2013), or indeed as cultural scripts. One outcome has been that values are often perceived to have positive or neutral potentialities while their negative or political imperatives are either overlooked or remain largely peripheral to theorizing as isolated wrongdoings (Kraatz et al., 2020). Current theory therefore falls short in elaborating the potentially insidious function of values in the social world such as those contributing to a moral order of subservience of a group of people and the associated dominance of such groups by others.

In his seminal work, *A Humanist Science*, Selznick (2008: 47) describes moral order as a “sound policy” to gain conformity through willing cooperation:

But raw domination is tempered by an ethos of moral and social responsibility, which is needed if the occupiers are to win the acquiescence and help they need. It is sound policy to encourage a transition from grudging conformity to willing cooperation, from bare-bones order to more robust signs of cooperation and restraint.

The insidious function of values is, however, critical to building our understanding of inequality. This is reflected in the recent inquiries on inequality where values such as individualization, self-interest, meritocracy, and competition have been acknowledged to lead to practices that marginalize vulnerable populations, exploit labor, and disregard broader societal impact (Colombo, 2023; Kumar et al., 2024).

Before we elaborate on the insidious function of values, it is important to clarify what the values in question are and how they came into being. Values are considered to have social, cultural, or historical origins (Selznick, 1996) and to be embodied in institutions as “undesigned conditions” (Selznick, 2008: 40). Values as objects of inquiry have been broadly positioned in two ways. First, “precarious” values are seen as susceptible to threats or displacement from the broader environment (Kraatz et al., 2010). The precarity of institutional values is often owed to a tension with the regulative element of institutions where new structures conflict with established ideals (Kraatz et al., 2020; Selznick, 1957). Second, “enduring” or “trans-situational” values

are considered to be persistent over time and across different contexts. For example, religious values tend to persist despite modernization and economic development (Hoge et al., 1982; Inglehart & Baker, 2000; Schwartz & Huisman, 1995). Values can also exist as an emergent phenomenon where they arise among people through received cultures or human experiences. It is therefore possible that values can remain latent within an institution until they reemerge in certain contexts (Selznick, 1992, 2008).

The emergence of values within institutions has been attributed to socialization through a process of social control, although the current literature largely positions socialization as “uncoerced” and “self-possessed” suggesting that people play an active part in their own socialization (Kraatz et al., 2020). For example, Dacin et al.’s (2010) study of formal dining at the University of Cambridge revealed how organizational rituals undertaken by participants socialize them into norms and values that contribute to the institutional maintenance of the British class system. While such studies enrich our understanding of organizational processes that maintain unequal systems, they fall short in explaining why certain values are played up in certain institutions or why actors play along in reinforcing values that put them in disadvantageous positions. Thus, the vast majority of work has avoided critical evaluation of the institutions, and associated processes, that facilitate the socialization and embedding of insidious values.

To address these concerns, our conceptual framework on values anchors our inquiry on two key assumptions. First, our focus is on the values that exist or originate as moral beliefs in certain institutions and are drawn upon by actors in different institutional contexts. We therefore observe values as objects within institutions that can go latent or (re)emerge as the conditions within an institutional context evolve. Second, in this emergent view we consider values not to be necessarily culturally transmitted but as an outcome of experiential or situational processes. Hence in our analysis, values operate not as personal or internalized beliefs but as means to a goal in an institutional setup (Baker, 2013; Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004; Tsirogianni & Gaskell, 2011). This way we unpack the persistence of values not merely as an outcome of direct socialization or cultural prescriptions but as influenced by institutional arrangements and therefore integral to institutional thinking (Creed et al., 2022).

In the next section, we first identify a value, in our case moral indebtedness, that has historically shaped unequal relations of subservience of laboring castes and the dominance of landholding castes in pre-capitalist Indian rural society. We then conceptualize how moral indebtedness, as a value, continues to play a role in shaping contemporary market institutions and entrenching

inequalities. In so doing, we add to our nascent understanding of how values reinforce social inequalities (Zhang et al., 2023; Gecas, 2008) through institutional and organizational change (Amis & Greenwood, 2021). Moreover, we make a case for centering the politics of values in studies of inequality within institutional and organizational contexts.

Moral Obligation in Pre-capitalist Agriculture

The patron–client relationship of economic exchange in rural India dates back to the colonial period of the late nineteenth century but continued to persist even after the country gained independence in 1947 (Lerche, 1993; Mayer, 1993; Lerche & Shah, 2018). Formally labeled as a system of *jajmani*, this exchange relationship was centered on hereditary patron–client ties between the members of landowning upper castes and members of lower castes, also referred to as service castes, who provided them with various services (Mayer, 2023). It should be noted that the notion of a pan-Indian existence of *jajmani* as a universal socio-economic institution has been contested by anthropologists (Fuller, 1989; Mayer, 2023); however, different versions of patron–client ties governed by similar norms of caste-based servitude have emerged from accounts across the country (Commander, 1983; Mayer, 2023).

In this system of exchange, the patrons or *jajmans*, often the dominant caste landlords, were provided services by lower-caste clients or *kamins*, as land tillers, sharecroppers, barbers, potters, carpenters, and so on. The *kamins* were often paid wages in kind, usually in the form of grain or share of a crop, although there are also accounts of payments made in cash. However, as Commander (1983) notes, the mode of wages was immaterial as in either case, of cash or kind, the *jajmani* system was reflective of an uncompetitive labor market where the wages were set by the relative strengths of *jajmans* and *kamins* (Mayer, 2023). As a socio-economic institution, under *jajmani* the relationship between patrons and clients was not governed by market forces but instead regulated by customary rights and privileges as expressed and enforced by the hereditary caste-based division of labor (Fuller, 1989). Therefore, while the wages offered a security of subsistence to the clients, it was based on inherently exploitative relationships.

Initial scholarly interpretations of *jajmani* assumed it to be a harmonious system of mutual obligation between patron and client castes that ensured the survival of the most vulnerable (Dumont, 1972; Wiser, 1936). The obligation from the patrons' side was to provide subsistence to the clients who in turn were obligated to provide services. However, subsequent accounts have

challenged this idealized view of mutuality. Scholars have drawn attention to the unequal power relations between landowning patrons and their dependent clients (Mayer, 2023). The patrons wielded significant power over their clients through their control of economic transactions, setting the wages and terms of exchange to their own advantage. For instance, the patron castes frequently took advantage of the client castes by “reduc[ing] the payments when market conditions would make it advantageous to put the share [of produce] that was owed to the clients onto the market for monetary gains” (Mayer, 2023: 65). Therefore, patrons often disregarded their obligations to clients when it served their own interests to do so.

Moreover, the patrons often wielded coercive control over their clients. For example, the *kamins* had to get approval from their landlords before entering into economic transactions with others (Mayer, 2023). In most cases, the low caste artisans had to sell their produce through patron landlords, who acted as brokers between producers and traders (Vikas et al., 2015). The patrons could coerce other castes as tenants or laborers as “they control[ed] the farm implements and oxen, carts, seed, food, pasture, forage, and sometimes even house-sites and wells” (Biedelman, 1959: 74). Such accounts established that the network of mutual obligation and dependencies related to *jajmani* was marked by a near total control that patrons exerted over their clients who lacked primary tenancy rights as a consequence of their caste position (Wadley, 1994).

These practices of coercion reinforced the social norms of a caste system in which individuals were drawn into subservience and consented to their position in the hierarchy. The system therefore formed permanent and inter-generational ties that limited mobility of the lower castes, especially those employed in agricultural work, therefore assuring a stable labor supply for the dominant caste (Mayer, 2023). The dissolution of the *jajmani* system was initiated as patrons responded to changes driven by technology and growing access to new markets.

Our object of inquiry here is the legacy of the underlying (im)moral economy that sustained the *jajmani* system. For the *jajmani* exchange to exist we conceptualize moral obligation as a key value that was to some extent central to the legitimization of the hegemonic relations between the patron and client castes. In this sense, client castes retained a moral obligation toward the landowning castes in an unquestioning way (Haggis et al., 1986). The annual payments from the patrons were assumed to be altruistic; the labor offered by the clients was supposed to be their moral imperative. The debt therefore was accrued by the client castes in the form of a claim on their future labor by the patron castes. The principal function of moral obligation

harbored by the client castes, along with the superior ritual status of patrons attached to their dominant or upper caste, provided a moral veneer to an inherently exploitative relationship. This prevented overt resistance or conflict emerging despite the annual deprivation of the client caste, reflected by the lack of accounts of rebellion documented in empirical studies on *jajmani* and similar patron–client systems in India (Haggis et al., 1986).

Extending Ambedkar's (2014a) notion of a culture of obedience as a feature of caste-based social relations, this moral obligation can be operationalized as a value embedded in the rigid macro institution of the Indian caste society that client castes could not conceive of breaking. To this end, the material conditions that sustained *jajmani* were entrenched in highly unequal caste hierarchies and economic interdependence. The institutional conditions of *jajmani* in turn enabled the operationalization of moral obligation as a social value by both the patrons and the client castes. This social value acted as a rationalizing object to legitimize the conformity of client castes that were the artisans, landless agricultural workers, and peasantry, across generations to provide uninterrupted and unpaid labor to the patron castes at the expense of their own social mobility.

The *jajmani* system in its traditional form largely collapsed in contemporary rural society. Many upper caste landlords moved to urban settings, making space for the middle castes to assume dominance as a new and wealthy middle-class group of farmers (Teltumbde, 2018). As traditional patrons terminated their relationships, client castes too diversified their livelihoods through temporary contract work, setting up small businesses, or also migrating to urban centers. Therefore, the obligation and economic dependency in its traditional form dissolved, although the hierarchies of labor relations that were shaped through the *jajmani* system outlived the institution. This is exemplified by Ambedkar (2014a) in his seminal text on caste, originally published in 1936, in which he argues that Dalits, the lowest caste, were drawn into a “culture of obedience” in the name of caste-based social relations that restricted them to a few occupational categories, epitomized in Mahalingam's (2019) work on janitorial labor. Thus, the values underlying the now dormant patron–client system remain pertinent to explain the continued legitimization of subservience and exploitation along traditional caste-class group lines and beyond.

The Development of Techno-managerial Agriculture

Despite the decline of patron–client systems such as *jajmani* in the contemporary agrarian economy, the function of paternalistic values such as moral

obligation holds lessons for us when evaluating the new globalized systems of capitalist development. The integration of rural society with capitalist markets has not necessarily developed more equitable labor relations but has instead led to the modernization of old relations of dominance (Lerche, 2021). The middle castes in most regions are now the dominant landowning class, albeit small landowners, while the traditionally oppressed landless lower caste and tribal agrarian labor force remain most vulnerable in the new agrarian reality. Despite their landowning status, the small landowners too find themselves in a similarly precarious position due to the agrarian distress that marks Indian agriculture.

The changes in India's rural social order outlined above pose the possibility for the unequal hierarchies of patron–client ties to have surpassed the traditionally understood binaries of landowning caste and landless peasantry. Market-oriented development interventions in Indian agriculture driven by donor-funded finance and transnational organizations are governed by techno-managerial logics and have been positioned to serve humanitarian goals of poverty alleviation. They do so by providing employment and/or market opportunities to farmers primarily through entrepreneurial organizing. Here the farmers assume the role of a beneficiary and the companies as the benefactors.

A critique of a similar beneficiary–benefactor dynamic is offered by Shankar (2022) in his ethnography of an education non-government organization (NGO) in India in which he conceptualizes the rise of a new class of humanitarian actors, a “savior class” of globally mobile, dominant caste, Indian-origin technocrats. Here the clients, or as Shankar (2022: 43) describes them, “the victim[s] who [are] in need of saving,” are the rural poor who constitute an exploitable labor force. He draws on the significance of moral ambitions of the “savior” class that assume the status of being benevolent and in so doing ethically bind the “victim” class to feel a moral responsibility toward the NGO's project. While the study broadly outlines the ethical basis of the relationship between different actors such as that in *jajmani*, it does not explain the source of such moral responsibility and its function. Hein and Ansari (2022) similarly used the concept of “benevolent marginalization” to explain the unequal social relationship of subordination formed in emancipatory work where the marginalized accept their prescribed position with a sense of gratitude. Thus, as actors and organizations assume a paternalistic position, they can create conditions for the operationalization of values that may generate unequal outcomes for subordinated groups.

The extractive nature of altruism thus continues to function unopposed, masked by the cooperative performance of economic exchange. How, then,

do values influence the participation of the poor in exploitative paternalistic projects and to what extent? In our historical analysis of *jajmani*, we established the role of moral indebtedness as a value that created apparent consent among the subordinated groups that subsequently sustained the unequal relationships. We extend our conceptualization of moral obligation manifesting as “moral indebtedness” in contemporary techno-managerial interventions to understand its function in shaping existing or new inequalities. We do so in the following section by tracing the emergence of moral indebtedness in our empirical case of labor relations between a socially oriented agriculture-technology company and small-farmer communities in rural India.

Methods

Context

Our analysis is based on a case study derived from a larger study of agricultural workers in rural India. In our ethnographic investigation we focused on donor-funded socially oriented agriculture-technology companies that proposed they would improve rural livelihoods and mitigate climate impact. One such intervention, conducted by Growfarm,¹ a Netherlands-based irrigation company, involved employing farmers in a contract-farming model. Under this arrangement, the company signed a contract with 15 farmers from a village in Assam, India, to cultivate a commercial crop on land the company had leased using the company's equipment and adhering to their prescribed farming practices. The company would subsequently sell the harvested crop to private buyers, allegedly at higher prices than farmers could typically achieve for their traditional produce. The profits from these transactions were intended to be shared with the farmers. This case is representative of the techno-managerial approach that has created new labor relations between companies and farmers. Further, the rural context captures current socio-economic conditions of the small farming communities that dominate the Indian rurality. The farmers participating in this intervention were members of a dominant middle-caste group within the village.

¹ Growfarm is a pseudonym.

Data Collection and Analysis

Our dataset for this study comprised: 35 interviews with fifteen farmers, two field officers (multiple repeat interviews), and one regional manager; four focus groups (4–10 participants); and, 28 days of non-participant observations of company–farmer interactions spanning two interventions over a complete crop cycle. For this chapter, we tag the quotations as Phase 1 and Phase 2 in the findings section, to indicate whether the data were collected at the outset of the crop cycle or during the harvesting stage. The dataset was part of a broader study examining development interventions in Indian agriculture. The interviewees included fifteen farmers, two field officers employed by the company to manage the project, and the company's regional middle-manager. We employed an abductive qualitative design guided by our interest in the role of values in farmers' participation and their implications for inequality. This was achieved through multiple rounds of coding of interview transcripts and field notes following an iterative analytical approach. This helped us identify initial concepts related to obligation, reciprocity, and power relations as expressed by the farmers. Subsequently the historical concept of moral obligation from the *jajmani system* served as a sensitizing frame. Through this abductive process between the empirical data and generation of theoretical insights, the value of moral indebtedness emerged.

Our data revealed the dynamic nature of company–farmer relationship, which evolved through the project and ultimately deteriorated as the crops failed. In particular, as the project encountered difficulties, we identified farmers drawing on a sense of moral indebtedness toward the company to rationalize their continued engagement. Despite not belonging to traditionally oppressed lower castes, we found that the farmers in the village expressed a sense of moral indebtedness, parallel to the obligation that was deeply rooted in the caste-based system. However, our conceptualization of moral indebtedness was further refined by examining the contradictions and variations in farmers' narratives particularly as the tensions became more obvious toward the end of the project. A comparison of the interviews conducted toward the end of the project with the ones conducted earlier led us to identify subtle instances of internal contradictions where farmers who felt indebted also voiced ambivalence accompanied by feelings of injustice. In the findings that follow, we develop these themes to explain how moral indebtedness as a value became consequential in the contemporary institution of techno-managerial development.

Findings

In a project that lasted from January 2022 to May 2023, Growfarm leased a plot of land and organized a group of local farmers to cultivate it under a profit-sharing contract. Growfarm referred to these farmers as “partners” in its formal communication and provided them with agricultural inputs such as seeds, fertilizer, solar irrigation pumps, and training to cultivate a commercial crop, in this case watermelons. Under the profit-sharing contract, the company agreed that half of the profit from selling the produce would go to the farmers, part of which was given to the farmers each month of the crop cycle as pre-payments. These monthly payments ensured farmers had liquidity to spend on employing labor and other expenses. The entire process was directly overseen by Growfarm’s field staff which was managed by a regional manager. Prior to the commencement of the first author’s field-work, the company had piloted the project in a neighboring village, followed by one crop cycle in our empirical site. The regional manager who introduced the first author to the village and the field staff recounted the transition between the sites. Gesturing toward sacks of unsold garlic stored in their city office, he explained:

These are from last year’s crop; we were working with the farmers in a village close to where our plot is now. This is all the produce that we could save, but it is difficult to sell it in the market at good rates now. We are very happy with our new site, though. There were problems with the farmers in the last village. They had too many side hustles. It is difficult to get the job done like this.

The manager highlighted the importance the company placed on farmers commitment to ensure the success of the project. However, in the two cycles of the harvest that spanned the project in our empirical site, the company failed to grow the produce within the estimated timeline and could not attain the expected price from the buyers. The company finally ended the project without paying farmers for the final month of their work and declared it had made no profit from the initiative.

The farmers faced repeated challenges through the process of cultivation often due to miscalculations by Growfarm’s management that reflected the company’s limited experience in farming and understanding of the ecological realities of the region. Yet, despite being hampered by Growfarm’s poor decision-making, the farmers expressed a moral obligation to make the project a success. In one such rationalization for the group to continue working with the company after it failed to make a profit in the first crop cycle, the farmers drew on their own situational vulnerability from seasonal

floods in the region that was temporarily eased by the company's monthly payments. As the leader of the farmer group articulated, the company's decision to continue paying farmers for their work during the flood, despite the imminent crop damage and potential loss of profits, was appreciated by the farmers:

When there are floods in the village even Rs 100² is a big help for us... at a time when we get nothing from the local shops, when all our produce is ruined, when even going to the town gets us nothing. If someone gives us even a little money during such a time, they'll be above God for us. The company gave us payment for our 15 days of work at that time despite all the crop eventually getting damaged. (Farmer 1, group leader, phase 2)

By interpreting the company's decision to pay them even when floods had damaged the crop as an act of benevolence, the farmers underlined an implied sense of obligation toward the company. In doing so, the farmers discounted their own labor and were ready to share the losses for that crop cycle with the company, as two farmers explained:

The company told us that in the first cycle the project had incurred a loss and therefore in the next cycle the company would reduce our profit percentage share from the initial 50-50 to 40-60. We collectively agreed to it. (Farmer 1, group leader, phase 2)

[Growfarm] has promised that if the project makes profit this year, they will extend our contracts for another two to three years. We will work with the company. Only if it doesn't flood and if we get time from our work here [at company's plot] will we farm on our own land. (Farmer 3, phase 2)

When the farmers were asked to explain their decisions, such as working without pay to complete the harvest, taking profit cuts when the project faced crop loss, and continuing to work for lower wages, they rationalized these as a moral obligation toward the project. These decisions were justified by the farmers and local fieldworkers as a duty toward paying—quite literally—for the company's benevolence. This sense of moral indebtedness toward the company was accompanied by the goodwill attributed to Growfarm for setting up the project in their village:

We had never done this [scientific] kind of farming in our village before the company came, but to come here and learn has been good for us...even though

² *Rs 100 ~ 1GBP.

the crop last season got washed out in the floods, we are hopeful about the next cycle. (Farmer 5, phase 1)

Even as tensions subsequently grew between the farmers and Growfarm's management, some of the farmers acknowledged the company's ownership of the project and therefore expressed a dependency on the company for any returns:

[The manager] doesn't understand that our fate is in their hands. The entire project is in their hands. We only come work through the day and provide security to their assets here, but they are the ones providing everything. (Farmer 1, phase 2)

They saw the act of a company providing local farmers a chance to earn an income as a favor to the community that deserved their reciprocation. Therefore, despite undermining their labor and agency, the juxtaposition of the project as an opportunity for socio-economic mobility of the farmers inspired a sense of gratitude. By drawing on this value and continuing to work, the farmers avoided potential conflict with Growfarm, as farmer 2 explained in phase 2:

We know how crops are grown, and that the decisions the company was taking were wrong, yet we continued to follow what they said. But that is because we have taken their [monthly payments]. They said they'll use scientific methods we said, 'okay that is their right, maybe we don't know better.' We have eaten their salt (*namak khaya hai*), we have taken their money. We have to pay back.

However, we found that the obligation was not entirely internalized by the farmers. This was signaled in the contradictions in the farmer narratives in which they were also sufficiently aware of their labor value that they, paradoxically, framed their compliance as a compromise. Toward the end of the second crop cycle, and as they became more hopeless, the farmers began to articulate the legal compulsion that bound them to follow Growfarm's instructions:

It was in the contractual agreement, if someone doesn't listen to th[e company], they'll be thrown out. They have the power to remove any one of us so we don't dare speak... after all [the] company is spending the money hence we'll continue working as they'd direct us to. (Farmer 2, phase 2)

When their work on the project extended beyond the initially agreed-upon timeline, the farmers continued to work, often for more than their agreed eight hours per day. Company field officer 2 stated, "Although the agreement

with the farmers is now over, all the fifteen farmers are still coming to the field to work every day. They are working in the company's best interests."

The contradiction in the farmers' narratives revealed that the farmers were not reductively self-socialized to be morally obligated to the company, but the value was also reinforced by the company through various strategies. For example, we found the company used a variety of tactics, including using the stressed importance of scientific knowledge as a hegemonic tool of dominance. The farmers were viewed as contracted labor, subject to daily surveillance both through an app and in-person management, and made ambiguous promises to maintain their engagement. Field officers frequently pointed to a lack of scientific understanding among farmers, and an assumption of the superiority of scientific agricultural practices:

It was only after the company entered this village that th[e farmers] realized that if they'd used scientific means they could produce more harvest with less labor. Earlier they would do hard labor but wouldn't get fair returns as the crops would get ruined by pests. But now we have got a treatment so that the crop will be safe from pests. Now, with less labor, they can produce more harvest and that has piqued their interest. (Field officer 1, phase 1)

One of the farmers in the project affirmed their initial enthusiasm:

Initially, they showed us dreams that if you work on this farm as per our directions you will progress. The company would profit and in turn farmers could use that profit for their [economic] upliftment. They also said they'd leave the solar pumps with farmers to use in their farming. (Farmer 4, phase 2).

However, such assertions were not supported by the farmers' experience as they ended up working longer hours than expected without the anticipated benefits. Although the farmers became acquainted with the chemical treatments and technology used in the production process, they were not allowed to utilize these on their own farms. This effectively prevented them from transitioning to more efficient farming practices due to the prohibitive costs involved. Field officer 2, who had joined the company to manage the project and had been farming for several years in a neighboring village, observed:

Their [farmers and their families'] work has increased as compared to when they were growing [rice] on their own land. Our methods of working are different, our timings are different, earlier they wouldn't have to work during the day in their fields but on the company plot they have to work through the morning.

Toward the end of the second crop cycle as it became apparent that the project would fail to realize the expected profits, the company decided to withhold farmers' monthly payments, precipitating anger among the farmers:

These men are angry because they are working here throughout the day. If they struggle to [get the] work [done] on their own, they bring in additional labor. For this they only get Rs.7000 a month from the company. You tell me, is that kind of money enough for basic survival? Now there is no profit from the project, and the farmers think they didn't make any profits because of several wrong decisions by the company. Is their anger then not justified? (Field officer 2, phase 2)

Despite the diminishing prospects of profitability, and their increased anger and discontent with Growfarm, the farmers persevered in their efforts to salvage the harvest. Only when the company ceased monthly payments in the final stages of production did farmers collectively decide to withdraw their labor as a form of protest. Farmer 1 articulated the farmers concerns and the tensions caused by their perceived obligation toward the company during one of the focus group discussions:

During the [harvest], our labor increases significantly. We need to pick up each fruit individually, pack them into sacks, and load them onto vehicles. For the last two months [of the project], we'll have to work without payment; there will be no pre-payment provided. This is why we must hold a meeting with [the manager]. If there is no pre-payment, how will we survive here? They say we'll be paid when profits are shared, but what profits? Now, after everything that's happened, we clearly see there won't be any profit... but as long as we have worked here, we should receive our pre-payment. What does it mean otherwise? We're working here for 24 hours, staying here overnight while leaving behind our families and children. We still have to feed them; we cannot work without eating. If we don't get our pre-payment, we'll have to find work elsewhere, and if we do that, what will happen here? If we leave even for a short while, animals will enter and eat all the crops.

He concluded firmly, "If we don't receive the pre-payment, I don't know about others, but personally, I won't be able to work here." This assertion was echoed by other farmers in the room, who affirmed, "This applies to everyone" and "We'll have no choice but to quit."

The threat of non-payment stoked anger among the farmers and compelled them to seek alternative sources of income and renegotiate their engagement with the company. They collectively decided to cease daily labor at the plot, limiting their work to rotational shifts focused solely on safeguarding the

crop from animals. This strategic withdrawal signified that the farmers began to challenge the moral obligation tethering them to the company thereby resisting further exploitation. Hence, even though moral indebtedness had emerged as a persistent value that guided actions of the farmers to maintain their economic relationship with the company, our case also reveals the fragility of the value in its eventual break down when the company failed to honor its obligation to the farmers.

Discussion

Here we return to our motivating question of how values sustain contemporary social inequalities. Thus far in our analysis, moral indebtedness first appears as an obligation that historically emerged in and maintained the traditional institution of caste-based clientelism. We traced its development and implications for maintaining inequalities in the context of contemporary techno-managerial development. The moral obligation embedded in the caste system never entirely went away, as shown by Ambedkar (2014a) and Mahalingam et al. (2019). However, we extend this observation by revealing how the value persisted outside the traditional institution of caste. In appearing among different caste category actors in a new institutional context, our analysis reveals the persistence of moral indebtedness as an insidious value through changing institutional contexts not merely as socio-historically accreted among groups or personally discovered (Kraatz et al., 2020) but as emerging due to the intertemporal social arrangements of an institution. Here, moral indebtedness is distinct from the erstwhile moral obligation as it is not forced upon people through the rigid caste system yet emerges due to economic dependency and perceived hierarchical position. We therefore show that values are grounded in the material realities of institutions, rather than being solely embedded within broader cultural contexts.

We make two theoretical contributions to our understanding of how values underpin social inequality. First, we show how paternalistic values can help us conceptualize institutions that reproduce inequalities. We show that institutions marked by the dual characteristics of hierarchical structures and dependency relationships tend to shape human interactions in favor of paternalistic values. This further explains how values that go latent with the decline of an institution can emerge among a different group of people, in our case a different caste, in a new institutional context. We therefore see middle-caste farmers as actors falling into similar roles as that of the service or client caste

members in traditional patron-client relationships. The same value therefore ended up playing a strong role in entrenching social inequality even when the actors changed. Second, a comparison of the historical *jajmani* system and the contemporary Growfarm initiative reveals that while conceptually moral indebtedness results in similar outcomes in both cases, it fundamentally differs in its function and nature across contexts. We develop our theorizing in the following sections.

Moral Indebtedness as a Paternalistic Value

In the historical *jajmani* system, moral obligation manifested as an overt and coercive force. The caste system, as a rigid social structure, created an internalized sense of obligation on individuals to fulfill their prescribed roles within the hierarchy (Bapuji et al., 2024). These roles were often overtly reinforced with patron castes exerting considerable pressure on the client castes to adhere to their duties. *Jajmani* system, therefore, explicates how a moral obligation was internalized by the client castes through a coercive system of caste-based social hierarchies and consequently shaped economic relations.

In contrast, the contemporary market-based relationships between farmers and agricultural-technology companies present a more covert form of moral indebtedness as it is not based on the rigid coercions of a caste system. The farming community in our empirical study does not belong to the same caste categories of service or client castes from the *jajmani* system, Dalits, but belong to middle castes that are currently the dominant landowning caste in their region. It thus cannot be implied that the farmers carried forward moral obligation as a value as part of occupying a culture or institution. Yet, they drew on moral indebtedness as a value through their participation in the project which leads us to evaluate the power dynamics of company–farmer relations. We find the farmers’ obligation to be driven by their position as contractual workers with the company instead of traditional caste positions. Furthermore, the framing of the employee–employer relationship as a “partnership” gives a semblance of consent and creates a more subtle and indirect form of obligation. While there may not be the same level of overt coercion as in the *jajmani* system, the power dynamics inherent in the market relationship can still exert significant pressure on farmers to comply with corporate demands.

Yet, we find in the contemporary context that moral indebtedness emerges as a more unstable and precarious value (Gehman et al., 2013). This is exhibited through its eventual breakdown triggered when the company withheld payments. As the farmers faced a threat to their economic survival, they broke

out of their moral indebtedness toward the company, driven by anger and the need to find alternative sources of income. We find Sayer's (2007) lens of human vulnerability useful here to explain how people's commitment to the value changed to improve their well-being (see also Creed et al., 2022). The farmers expressed awareness of their vulnerability through the emotion of anger in their narratives, which led to changing the nature of the value held (Creed et al., 2022). Despite such vulnerability existing in the traditional caste system, with its rigid hierarchy and prescribed roles, it acts as a stabilizing factor in the *jajmani* system. In contrast, the contemporary relationship between farmers and companies is based on a more depersonalized "cash nexus," that is, a relationship based on monetary exchange. This implies that the farmers are aware of their vulnerability and dependence and yet are less likely to passively accept exploitation. Thus, they frame their compliance with company demands often as a "compromise" or a temporary measure. The precarity of moral indebtedness as a value is therefore established as it relinquished its hold on the farmers.

This shift in the function and nature of moral indebtedness has important implications for understanding how inequality is sustained in market-based relationships. While moral indebtedness continues to play a role in eliciting farmers' compliance, it is no longer as reliable or stable a force as it was in the past. Farmers are more likely to question the fairness of the relationship and to withdraw their cooperation if they feel that they are being exploited. Thus, the function of moral indebtedness has evolved significantly from the historical *jajmani* system to contemporary market-based relationships. While the concept of obligation and reciprocity persists, it has become more covert, unstable, and subject to negotiation.

Values, Institutions, and the Reproduction of Inequality

In the cases of both pre-capitalist and techno-managerial agriculture, moral indebtedness manifests in the form of a moral obligation on the part of subservient members. Our historical analysis reveals that rigid caste hierarchies and a reliance on patron castes for subsistence fostered an environment conducive for the emergence of moral indebtedness. In line with these characteristics, the manifestation of moral indebtedness in our empirical case was justified by farmers in two ways: first, based on their hierarchically subordinate position to the company, and second, their economic dependence on the project. In the power dynamic of 'benefactor and beneficiary' between the company and local farming community, the role of patron was assumed by the company. As farmers were embedded in the structural uncertainties

of occupational unpredictability and ecological extremities, this limited their perceived autonomy to negotiate. Although the new institutions of exchange have, in theory, reorganized rural relationships in terms of market logics rather than caste identities, the structural arrangement of hierarchical dependence emulates the unequal social relations produced by moral indebtedness in traditional clientelism.

We thus conceptualize the institutions marked by the dual dynamic of hierarchical dependence as conducive to playing up the paternalistic values such as that of moral indebtedness. This therefore makes neoliberal institutions of development susceptible to the emergence of intertemporal social arrangements that shape human relations in support of paternalistic values that are favorable for maintaining production relations while entrenching social stratification. Therefore, we propose that values here act as constructs that are played up to serve the existing social order. This further explains why and when certain values appear to be persistent even as institutions undergo change.

Our theoretical contribution has implications beyond the Indian agrarian context as similarly insidious paternalistic values surface in a range of institutional settings defined by hierarchy and dependence. For instance, elite educational and professional institutions, such as universities and law firms, often inculcate norms of loyalty, gratitude, and dutiful deference that mirror moral indebtedness. Classic rituals at elite universities exemplify this dynamic (Dacin et al., 2010). In such environments, those lower in rank come to feel grateful obligation toward benefactors or mentors, a sentiment that can discourage challenge to authority and thus quietly perpetuate inequality. Likewise, in global development aid regimes, donor–recipient relationships commonly cultivate a sense of indebted gratitude. Our findings in agri-tech further extend these dynamics where a powerful party extends “help” while the weaker party’s reciprocated loyalty legitimizes the hierarchy. We further show that even when the participants have not internalized this “benevolent marginalization” (Hein & Ansari, 2022), the structural superiority of the dominant group still reinforces the very inequalities that its benevolence purports to ameliorate. These examples show how ostensibly positive values of gratitude, loyalty, and “helping the disadvantaged,” can be weaponized to create subservience among less powerful actors. In institutional theory terms, we extend the role negative values play in performing crucial institutional maintenance work by aligning the attitudes of participants with the status quo and thus helping to reproduce social hierarchies. This insight extends our argument by suggesting that moral indebtedness is not unique to India’s agrarian sector, but rather one instance of a wider pattern whereby

hierarchical dependencies give rise to values that entrench inequality across contexts.

Future research could examine how such paternalistic value dynamics operate across different sectors and institutional settings. Comparative studies could explore, for example, whether “moral indebtedness” analogues emerge between professors and students in prestigious academies, partners and protégés in elite firms, or patrons and clients in international aid and philanthropy. Investigating these settings through the lens of values would deepen understanding of how such institutions repeatedly generate values of *benevolent control* and *grateful compliance*, and how these values are further interwoven with the political economy of each context. Further, extending our understanding of the role of emotions in precipitating and driving the discarding of values would be a useful theoretical extension. Such inquiries would enrich the literature on values and inequality by linking micro-level experiences of obligation to macro-level patterns of stratification illuminating how paternalistic value systems are maintained, contested, or transformed over time. Ultimately, unpacking how and why actors play along with values that disadvantage them across diverse institutional worlds can shed light on both the subtle mechanisms of inequality’s reproduction and potential levers of change toward more egalitarian arrangements.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we bring attention to the enduring and trans-situational function of values as regressive institutions make way for seemingly progressive ones. By attending to this we establish the centrality of moral values in fostering compliance and circumventing conflict, facilitating the reproduction of inequalities. We historically locate the origin and function of values in traditional institutions of oppression and reveal how they show up and shape the new institutions of development resulting in similar outcomes for the people involved.

Theoretically, we contribute to the values literature and its implications for institutions in two ways. First, we show how institutions shape human relations in support of paternalistic values such as moral indebtedness in ways that maintain precarious production processes thus enriching our theoretical understanding of institutions, people, and the relationships among them (Selznick, 1996). This allows us to offer a preliminary exploration of the role values play in paradoxical coexistence of deferential and antagonistic tendencies among various stakeholders. Second, we extend understanding of how

values can be operationalized in conceptualizing institutions—in this case institutions that maintain inequality. Methodologically, we advocate for a renewed emphasis on ethnographic longitudinal methods (Selznick, 1949) that require frequent and extensive interactions with the field. Such methods are uniquely positioned to situate analysis within the historical and ever evolving material context, facilitating a more nuanced understanding of the role of values. Finally, we reiterate calls to consider inequality as an entry point to further our understanding of values and their relationships with the institutions that shape actions (Kumar et al., 2024). To quote Ambedkar (2014b, p. 261) “For everyone equality may be a fiction, but nonetheless one must accept it as the governing principle.”

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17

Boys with Braids: Values, Emotion, and Body Work Intertwined

Ketan M. Goswami and Katrin Smolka

Introduction

Values have been argued to be central and ubiquitous to institutional theory, shaping conceptions of what are “desirable” goals both within and outside of organizations and institutions (Kraatz et al., 2020). This is especially true when it comes to constructing perceptions of legitimacy, i.e., whether an entity is considered “*desirable*, proper, or appropriate within some socially constructed system of norms, *values*, beliefs and definitions” (Suchman, 1995, p. 574, emphases added). Thus, through conceptions of what is desirable and what is not, values shape motivations, social evaluations, justifications, and consequently, social action. Emotions too have been found to be fundamental to institutional theory and conversations around legitimacy, serving as cogent expressions of what is desirable (and thus, for example, instilling pride) or not desirable (and thus, for example, instilling shame). As such, emotions also shape motivations, social evaluations, justifications, and, as a consequence, social action (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018; Zietsma et al., 2019).

However, while the linkages between values work and emotion work are increasingly being recognized, the foundational substratum in the form of

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the human body, which simultaneously serves as the source, conduit, and canvas of what is desirable and what is not, is relatively ignored in institutional theory (for a foundational review, see: Lawrence et al., 2023). Indeed, a key source of what is desirable is shaped by the physiological, functional, and material affordances of the human body and its myriad abilities, needs, and wants. For instance, core human values like cleanliness, love, pleasure, excitement, and security (Rokeach, 1973) are all rooted in the physical needs and the visceral experiences of the human body. However, while increased attention has been paid to the role of values and emotions in fostering institutional work, there is limited research on individual-level body work and how people's bodies may be integral to conducting various forms of institutional work. Indeed, management research has been criticized for being "bodiless" (Lawrence et al., 2023: 37). For instance, Acker's (1990) seminal work on gendered organizations showed that organizational structures obscure embodied experiences by creating "abstract, bodiless worker" (p. 151) that marginalize women's bodies and lived experiences in particular.

In this chapter, we take the intrinsic affordances, abilities, and desires of the body seriously by leveraging exemplars from an Indigenous context in the Canadian Prairies. Indigenous ontology treats the body on par with the cognitive mind, thus allowing us to better appreciate how the body can simultaneously serve as the source, conduit, and canvas of both values and emotions (Gone, 2011). More specifically, we conducted a qualitative study to answer the following research question—*what is the role of the human body in institutional work and how does this intersect with values/emotion work?* To answer this question, we build on three illustrative case studies to identify three modes of how the body is used to conduct body work, namely, *body as source*, *body as conduit*, and *body as canvas*. Moreover, our work is grounded in a sociological perspective that recognizes the social construction of embodied perspectives while acknowledging the resulting material realities. Adopting this lens allows us to examine how bodies become active sites where social structures, cultural meanings, and individual agency intersect. This also means that body work is not just describing patterns of "being institutionalized" through external forces, but represents an agentic force in itself through which Indigenous actors navigate, resist, and transform institutions while still expressing Indigenous values and emotions. Thus, leveraging an Indigenous ontology coupled with sociological perspectives allow us to examine how the lived experiences of Indigenous bodies become sites for socially constructing legitimacy.

The remainder of this chapter is structured as follows. We first provide a theoretical overview of all three forms of institutional work central to this

chapter which are values work, emotion work, and body work. Next, we briefly describe our case study methodology and narrative analysis. Subsequently, we share our findings as they emerge from each of these case studies. Finally, we conclude with a discussion of the implications for social action in general and institutional work in particular (more specifically countering perceptions of illegitimacy and engaging in social construction of what is legitimate, desirable, proper, and appropriate) as well as identify opportunities for future research.

Theoretical Overview

Scholars of institutional theory have increasingly recognized the importance of understanding how individuals engage in different forms of work to create, maintain, and transform institutions by managing perceptions of legitimacy (Suchman, 1995). In this chapter, we conceptualize institutions as socially constructed rules, practices, and meanings that give structure to social interactions (Scott, 2013). As such, we approach institutions as social structures that embody historical practices and shared cultural understandings and thus shape perceptions of what is considered legitimate, i.e., desirable, proper, and appropriate. While early institutional theory emphasized macro-level processes and structural determinants, attention shifted more recently to the role of individual agency in institutional and legitimation processes (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Lawrence et al., 2009; Tyler, 2006). This focus led to the identification of various types of institutional work that individuals perform in their everyday lives. Three such forms of institutional work (i.e., values work, emotion work, and body work) describe distinct yet interrelated ways in which individuals engage with and shape the institutions they inhabit through legitimation processes. While these forms of institutional work and legitimation processes operate through different mechanisms—cognitive beliefs, emotional displays, and bodily practices respectively—they describe distinct yet interrelated ways in which individuals engage with and shape perceptions of legitimacy and/or manage perceptions of illegitimacy. We now turn to examine each form of institutional work in detail.

Values Work

Values work, as a form of institutional work, refers to individuals' efforts to articulate, maintain, and enact ideal beliefs that shape institutional practices and behaviors. Values, or individuals' ideal beliefs, have been argued to play

an essential and salient role in institutional work and legitimation processes. Providing a foundational perspective in the field, Kluckhohn (1951: 395) defined values as conceptions of “the desirable which influence the selection from available modes, means and ends of action.” Kluckhohn’s work is particularly relevant to understanding how values work operates in institutions as his definition captures three essential elements: (1) values as conceptions that are cognitively understood, (2) values as oriented toward the desirable rather than just the desired, and (3) values as influencing selection among available alternatives (see also: Arieli et al., 2020). Kluckhohn emphasized that values are not just abstract ideals but rather active ingredients that shape how people evaluate and engage with the material and social world. Kluckhohn’s conceptualization helps explain why values work involves both cognitive understanding and aesthetic judgment. After all, values provide the standards through which actors assess not just what is practical and effective but what is morally appropriate in institutional life.

Building on Kluckhohn’s seminal work from the 1950s, when the organizational literature first discussed values more explicitly, it initially referred to the role played by leaders in shaping values, as foreshadowed by Selznick’s (1957) *Leadership in Administration* (Creed et al., 2022; Kraatz, 2009; Kraatz & Block, 2017; Kraatz et al., 2020). This literature from the 1950s argued that by articulating and expressing their deeply held values and associated meanings, leaders shape people’s actions along with their consequent evaluations of actions (Kraatz & Block, 2017). Subsequently, the organizational literature identified the impact of culture and, consequently, lived experiences on values (Patterson, 2014; Selznick, 1961). More recent research has also made a distinction between values and norms, arguing that values are more abstract and personal, while norms are more concrete and situational (Hitlin & Piliavin, 2004; Williams, 1967). Moreover, beyond the idealized cognitive aspects of values, the affective and emotional aspects of values are increasingly being recognized (Arieli et al., 2020). Indeed, scholars have argued that the intensity of the relationship between values and emotions is shaped by the prevalent “moral order” (Smith, 2003; Wuthnow, 2008).

Emotion Work

Emotion work, as a form of institutional work, refers to individuals’ efforts to regulate their emotions according to sociocultural norms and expectations associated with their roles or positions. Introduced by Hochschild (1983) in her seminal work *The Managed Heart*, emotion work encompasses processes—conscious and unconscious—involved in evoking, shaping,

or suppressing feelings to render them appropriate for a given situation. Emotion work involves the strategies individuals employ to align their outward emotional displays with socially prescribed feeling rules (Elfenbein, 2023). Individuals engage in managing their emotions in various social contexts, such as within families, among friends, and in communities, but emotion work also extends beyond the private life. Great amounts of emotional labor are involved in certain occupations, such as service work, where employees are expected to display specific emotional expressions as part of their job responsibilities (Grandey, 2000). As such, emotion work is a crucial aspect of social interaction and contributes to institutional maintenance, cultural norms, and negotiating legitimization processes.

Building on Hochschild's foundational work from the 1980s, organizational literature initially focused primarily on emotional labor in service industries and customer-facing roles (Rafaeli & Sutton, 1987). This early literature emphasized how organizations explicitly regulate employees' emotional displays through training and supervision. Later on, scholars broadened their focus to examine how emotional regulation occurs across various organizational contexts and hierarchical levels (Ashforth & Humphrey, 1993; Morris & Feldman, 1996). Research has also distinguished between surface acting (i.e., modifying visible emotional displays) and deep acting (i.e., attempting to actually feel the required emotions), arguing that these different approaches have distinct implications for both individual well-being and organizational outcomes (Grandey & Gabriel, 2015). Research has further emphasized that emotion work is not only an individual practice, but needs to be considered more broadly as emotional experiences in the workplace occur across five interconnected levels ranging from individual emotional variations up to organization-wide emotional climates (Ashkanasy & Humphrey, 2011). Furthermore, scholars increasingly recognize the role of cultural differences in shaping emotion work, suggesting that emotional display rules and their interpretation vary significantly across cultural contexts (Elfenbein, 2007; Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013).

Body Work

Body work, as another form of institutional work, refers to the material and symbolic dimensions of any kind of work performed on and through the body. It therefore encompasses the efforts individuals undertake to modify, maintain, or present their physical bodies according to prevailing socio-cultural norms and expectations (Gimlin, 2007; Wolkowitz, 2006). In the

landmark work *Bodies at Work* (2006), Carol Wolkowitz initially consolidated research on the bodily aspects of employment and labor across various occupational settings and introduced body work as a distinct conceptual lens. Following Wolkowitz's conceptualization, organizational research on body work concentrated primarily on aesthetic labor in service and retail industries (Warhurst & Nickson, 2009; Williams & Connell, 2010). On one hand, this reflected interest in mobilizing employees' embodied capacities as competitive advantages in corporate settings. On the other hand, the field focused on how body work intersects with gender, race, and class in organizational settings (Mears, 2014). Others highlighted the distinction between voluntary and involuntary body work, with scholars arguing that while some body work represents individual agency and choice, other forms reflect institutional power and control (Michel, 2011).

Additionally, building on earlier feminist insights, Acker (1990) in her seminal work of gendered organizations argued how organizations shape and censor physical embodiment through structures that systematically push for bodies to be invisible. On similar lines, recently Lawrence et al. (2023) argued that in addition to using their bodies for self-work, individuals also engage in body work at the organizational level to fit idealized representations of embodied organizational norms and values. Body work, especially in organizational settings, can take various forms, ranging from regulations on appearance (Mears, 2014) and fitness and wellness programs (Calderwood et al., 2021) to the use of technology to monitor and discipline behaviors (Misra & Walters, 2022). Thus, organizational body work is often created through and reproduces institutionalized discourses that construct certain bodies as ideal for effectively performing organizational roles. On the other hand, while research on disrupting institutionalized discourses by countering perceptions of illegitimacy and stigma is still in its infancy, recent work by Bojovic et al. (2025) shows how entrepreneurs use the body as cultural resource to address stigma by visibilizing bodies, obfuscating stigmatized representations, and transforming perceived flaws into virtues.

Integrating Values Work, Emotion Work, and Body Work

As is the case with all forms of social action, values work, emotion work, and body work are intertwined and mutually reinforcing parts of institutional work that individuals engage in to construct and maintain their identities and roles within the broader institutional settings they find themselves. These ongoing processes aim to construct coherent selves that reconcile individuals' values, emotions, and bodies with the often conflicting and contradictory

legitimation demands of the sociocultural contexts they inhabit. Values work shapes the ideological and moral underpinnings that inform the emotion norms and body ideals individuals are expected to uphold. Indeed, research shows that values predict behavior across organizational contexts when those behaviors align with their underlying motivational goals (Arieli et al., 2020). For instance, organizational or societal values around professionalism, femininity, and masculinity dictate the emotional displays and bodily presentations deemed acceptable within specific contexts. Individuals then undertake emotion work to regulate their feelings and emotional expressions in accordance with these value-laden norms, which often necessitates body work to mold their physical appearances and embodied behaviors to match the desired emotional and value-carrying ideals. The connection between values work, emotion work, and body work also aligns with Kluckhohn's (1951) observations. When actors engage with institutions, their understanding of what is desirable is naturally expressed through and shaped by their emotional responses and bodily practices.

Conversely, the emotions and bodily experiences individuals have can influence their values and the meanings they ascribe to various social norms and expectations. Individuals may engage in values work to challenge or redefine emotion norms and body ideals that contradict their lived experiences or fail to resonate with their authentic emotions and embodied realities. Values are not merely abstract principles but are rooted in desires as naturally emanating from one's physiological needs. Similarly, emotions are not just feelings as aligned to social norms but are shaped by visceral and physiological experiences such as disgust, shame or pride. Thus, an integrative understanding is particularly important for understanding how marginalized groups act in organizational settings and negotiate perceptions of stigma and illegitimacy (Bojovic et al., 2025). Research on gender and organizations shows how women's embodied experiences at work are shaped by gendered values, emotional expectations, and bodily representations that organizations demand from them (Fotaki & Harding, 2017). Organizational and institutional arrangements are thus never neutral, but contain assumptions (some more implicit than others) about whose values, emotions and bodies are considered legitimate and desirable.

It should be noted that recent research has already made progress to help us better understand the mechanisms connecting these three forms of work. Specifically, Baldessarelli et al. (2022) identified both emotional and cognitive mechanisms that emerge from sensory reactions to materiality. The emotional mechanisms include immediate visceral reactions (e.g., attraction/

repulsion) and affective responses (e.g., joy/sadness), and the cognitive mechanisms include interpretations and associations. Further, Creed et al. (2020) illustrated how these mechanisms operate through “institutional aesthetic codes” that link values and beliefs to culturally resonant expressions and actions. These codes become internalized as personal aesthetics that guide how individuals evaluate and respond to their surroundings. Also, Bojovic et al. (2025) hint at strategies that female entrepreneurs employ to challenge stigma around their bodies while staying authentic to their values and emotions. Together, this recent research suggests that the connection between values work, emotion work, and body work operates through both immediate sensory responses and culturally embedded interpretive frameworks that give meaning to those responses. These insights enrich our understanding of how sensory-based meaning-making operates in institutional processes, showing that the “braiding together” of values work, emotion work, and body work is both an immediate visceral process and one that is deeply embedded in shared cultural codes that give institutional meaning to aesthetic experiences.

Methods

We conducted inductive case studies of three everyday Indigenous actors in the Canadian Prairies. Selection of these three case studies was done from the perspective of identifying “polar types” (Eisenhardt, 1989) such that variance is “transparently observable” (Pettigrew, 1990). More specifically, variance was sought along the following dimensions: (i) Gender diversity (male vs. female), (ii) sexual orientation (Two-spirited vs. straight), and (iii) industry sector. These case studies were part of a larger ethnographic study conducted by the first author between May 2017 and December 2019. Our data sources for these three case studies include observations (both in-person and virtual), interviews, and archival data. Additional archival data collected between March and August 2023 helped us identify supplemental examples to further validate and substantiate the findings from these three specific case studies. Thus, enabled us to strive for both rigor and triangulation (Flick, 2004).

In terms of data analysis, given the tacit nature of embodied practices, we leveraged a narrative approach, i.e., leveraged stories as a means for drawing out connections between institutions, intentions, values, emotions, and embodied actions (Espedal & Synnes, 2022). Indeed, as Espedal and Synnes (2022) argue, using stories as an analytical tool helps draw a line of sight between micro perceptions of “what is worth” and macro systems

of “what is valued”, i.e., what is considered important, wanted, desirable, proper, and appropriate, or not by a particular individual in a particular institutional context. More specifically, we foregrounded the role of individual bodies and unpacked the stories of our protagonists to better appreciate the various ways their bodies served as either a root cause, a channel, or a way of expressing their values and emotions. The personal narratives that we leverage consequently helped us unpack subjective meanings and truths, thus speaking to the “personal aesthetics” of the protagonists (Creed et al., 2020) rather than objective historical facts. Moreover, these personal narratives are pieced together from multiple data sources, including semi-structured interviews, ethnographic observations (both in-person as well as on social media), and archival material. The bulk of the data analysis entailed listening to interviews and reading field notes/memos/archival documents “several times through” (Turco, 2016).

Findings

Our findings point toward three distinct modes of leveraging body work in relation to values work and emotion work. Collectively, these three modes of engaging in body work make it possible to elucidate how body work is intimately intertwined with values work and emotion work. Although we present three metaphors of the body—*body as source*, *body as conduit*, and *body as canvas*—they are all viscerally intertwined and inseparable. We aim to present a somewhat stylized picture for each mode to serve an analytical purpose of teasing out distinctions. See Fig. 17.1 for a visual depiction of these three modes.

Body as Source

The clearest exemplar of the body serving as a source of “desires” is found in the case of Two-spirited¹ Indigenous artist, poet, and activist Rainbow.² In various interviews, Rainbow talked about how their deep desires and passion for the “spoken word” and poetry (what they value) is shaped not only by their Indigenous identity and culture but also by their struggles with mental

¹ Two-spirited is the term used by Indigenous peoples in Canada to describe Indigenous members of the LGBTQ + community. Indigenous ontology purports that two-spirited people are special and sacred as they house both the masculine and feminine spirits within the same body.

² Note that we use pseudonyms for all Indigenous people featured throughout the chapter.

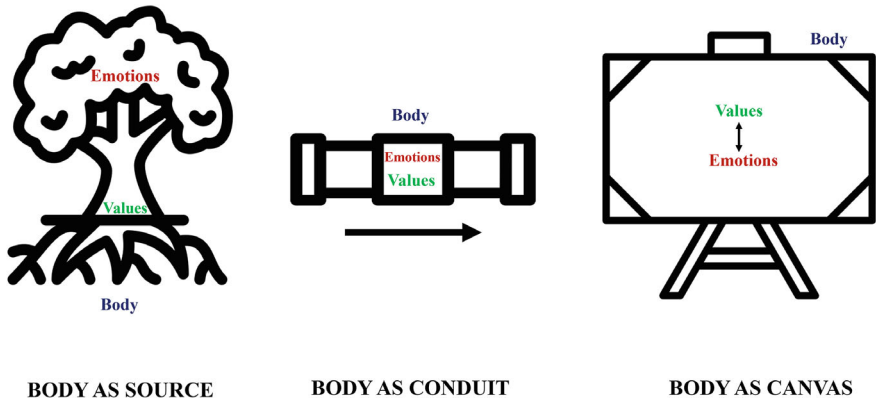


Fig. 17.1 Body as source, body as conduit, and body as canvas

health (i.e., physiological and psychological needs of the body) and their two-spirited gender orientation, which is, again, rooted in their body. Their own words serve as evidence of how their wishes and desires for love (a core human value; see Rokeach, 1973) are rooted in their body and infused with associated feelings and emotions, as is evident from the following poem they wrote:

I wish,
 you could feel like
 your love was worth it
 I wish,
 you did not need anything
 to be loved without obligation
 to be loved without doubt
 to be loved without pain
 I wish,
 you could feel like
 your love was worth it
 like your love is the sweetest taste on earth
 that one cannot have enough

Furthermore, Rainbow wishes to lend their “voice” to Indigenous youth, “brown” kids like them who have been made to feel “no good” by virtue of the color of their skin. These expressions describe their very real lived experiences rooted in their body. The intertwining of Rainbow’s values, emotions, and body to shape their purposeful efforts to challenge the status quo and thus

engage in activism-infused social action and institutional work is strongly evident in another one of their poems:

Until you see the paleness that taints my skin
 The whiteness you called greatness
 You tell us to be shameless
 But not for who we are
 For what you want us to be
 So, you beat us down
 And asked us to praise you

You see our brown skin
 We are nothing but slaves to you
 I'm watching my people go missing
 I'm watching my people get murdered³
 We're screaming for help
 Are you listening?

My sisters crying but you misheard her
 Brothers are fighting for freedom
 Government giving half-assed solutions
 Youth armed with nooses and razors⁴
 Fighting the image you gave us
 Dirty, no good, drunk Indian

It is fairly evident from Rainbow's poetry and social activism that for them, the values that drive their institutional activism and the associated emotions are rooted in their lived experiences of being "brown" and "Two-spirited" and a life-time of lived bodily experiences of the same.

The same recurring theme is reflected in archival data on other Two-spirited Indigenous entrepreneurs, artists, poets, and activists in Saskatchewan. In addition to the deep-rooted racism and prejudice against Indigenous people, there is also a deep-rooted prejudice against Two-spirited individuals, counter to the sacred and meaningful space that traditional Indigenous ontology holds for those who house "two spirits" (i.e., both feminine and masculine spirits) in their physical bodies. More recently, this

³ This reference is alluding to the historical and ongoing issue of Murdered and Missing Indigenous Women and Girls (MMIWG) in Canada.

⁴ This reference is alluding to the disproportionate number of teenage suicides among Indigenous peoples.

prejudice has manifested in the form of the Saskatchewan provincial government's education policy requiring anyone under the age of 16 to get parental permission to change their name or pronouns at school and a ban on outside groups giving sex-ed presentations in classes (Saskatoon StarPhoenix, 2023). Some activists have voiced their disapproval and pointed to the potential suicidal consequences that such a policy can have:

"Working frontline with youth for the last three years, I've seen the effect it has when our society doesn't stand with our youth and we're not walking beside them," said Munroe, who serves as the co-national postsecondary youth coordinator with the 2 Spirits in Motion Society (2SIMS) and co-chair of the 2 Spirit Alliance of Saskatchewan (2SAS). . . . "Many parents disown their children and turn them to the system because they are a part of the 2SLGBTQ+ community. Children . . . are returned to child welfare because their foster parents don't accept them for who they are. Children are abused for being queer or trans," [said Munroe] . . . "I've attended a funeral for a Two-spirit youth, due to suicide, because of policies and oppression . . . in our society. Suicide among queer youth is rampant, and it's heartbreaking," [further said Munroe]. (Saskatoon StarPhoenix, 2023)

Indeed, there is growing recognition that prejudice against Two-spirited individuals in the Canadian Prairies is rooted in colonization and certain interpretations of Christian values, which hold the body in sin and thus stigmatize conversations around sexual health (Windspeaker, 2024). In a recent interview with *Windspeaker* News, Lane Bonertz (Blackfoot, Piikani Nation) was quoted as saying, "Sexual health is a part of our physical [and mental] health.... They are not separate from one another."

Taking the body as the source of desires and wishes is thus the first mode we identify in our study as being at the heart of what shapes consequent emotion work and values work. As such, we propose the body as source as the physiological origin of values and emotions.

Body as Conduit

The second mode we illustrate is the body being used as a conduit for values and emotions. This is already evident in the case of Rainbow, who is a spoken-word artist. Literally, their vocal cords and their body serve as a conduit and a vehicle through which they communicate both their emotions and their values. Additionally, we illustrate this second theme of the body as a conduit by showcasing the case of Power, a Nakoda female entrepreneur in the fitness business. Growing up, Power was inspired by her uncle who "literally" was

the “strongest” person around and encouraged her to “challenge her ability.” Power is very clear that the values connected with the strength displayed in her family served as “roots” for her business. Her stepfather, a boxer, trained both Power and her younger brother in boxing. However, physical strength and fitness as values are not only specific to her family upbringing; Power stresses that “body awareness [is key]. That’s a part of my culture; [that] stuff is really grounding for me.”

While Power started with a government job during her earlier career, only later did she decide to return to her roots and start her own martial arts and self-defense training center. Using her body to build strength enables Power to use her body as a conduit. Similarly, she trains her students, especially other Indigenous women, to use their martial arts training to serve as a vehicle through which they can “honor our matriarchs.” Power explained:

I feel like [I am doing this] . . . to honor the matriarchs in our family and remember that women are powerful. Before colonization, women were the decision-makers . . . because we had that extra love and we had that understanding, and we thought about everyone in the community, not just what’s good for me or I am stronger than somebody. . . . It’s just acknowledging the women. I really like the idea of creating space to reclaim that power.

Furthermore, starting her venture, Power found herself investing heavily in “body work” and utilized physical movement during her martial arts practice to help find the “balance” between often conflicting and stressful priorities associated with starting and running a business. When Power is faced with those unpleasant emotions, she draws heavily on body work in the form of movement to regulate her emotions and uses her body to channel them. Power also shared that she uses “body work” and physical “movement” to reclaim space in other parts of her life. Given the history that Indigenous peoples continue to deal with under the legacy of colonization, in spaces where Power feels a lack of representation, she physically moves around and will “be the weirdo in the room” and will start “literally shaking my arms around” to create an “invisible bubble” around herself to reclaim her space. For Power, this reclamation of space through movement and the creation of an “invisible bubble” can be extended to a “whole room, whole town, whole city.” This helps Power create a sense of her own “boundaries” and thus be in control of “what’s coming in and out.”

In summary, we observe that Power’s body work intertwines with processing difficult emotions around identity and culture in the wake of colonialism while also allowing her to sustain and promote traditional Indigenous values through her business. Power thus uses her body as a conduit to channel

her emotions and values. As such, we propose the body as conduit as the physical medium through which values and emotions are transmitted and transformed.

Body as Canvas

The third and the final mode we observe is using the body as a canvas. For someone like Power, who, in addition to her martial arts practice, finds healing and “balance” in her ceremonial dances, donning her cultural regalia serves as a way of literally using her body to showcase her cultural values and pride. Additionally, this mode is amply evident through proponents of a local Indigenous social movement in Saskatchewan called “Boys with Braids.” CRX, an Indigenous media business owner, is a prime exemplar of this Indigenous movement, which entails using the body, more specifically hair, to express Indigenous core values.

Indigenous people in Canada face a historical context where from the 1890s until the 1990s, Indigenous children were forcibly removed from their families and placed in residential schools run by the Canadian government in partnership with various church denominations to disrupt and destroy traditional Indigenous cultural values and beliefs, including the sacredness of one’s hair. For many Indigenous males like CRX, growing and wearing their hair long is a way of proudly owning their culture. They wear their pride in their traditions and culture and display it on their physical being, thus leveraging the body as a canvas for exhibiting their own values and emotions. See Image 1 in the appendix for an example.

Additionally, CRX has two sons in whom he and his partner want to instill the same pride in wearing long hair despite the continued prejudice in urban Saskatchewan schools and other spaces where they are likely to be teased and called a “girl” if they choose to braid their hair as Indigenous boys (Global News, 2016). This is where role models who use their hair and bodies as a way of showcasing their pride (emotions) and Indigenous cultural identity (values) are found to be immensely valuable as they help young boys counter the stigma. Indigenous basketball player and community leader Michael Linklater is one such role model we observed in Saskatchewan. He clarified:

It defines who we are as Aboriginal people, boys and men, it’s like our trademark—that we are proud, because we really lost touch with our hair, our traditions through our history with residential schools and colonialism. (Cover Story, Catching up with Michael Linklater, RezX Dec 2014 Issue)

This sentiment is often reiterated among other local Indigenous role models, such as Dion Tootoosis. He appeared as a guest speaker for another Boys with Braids event and shared with local CBC News that the core objective behind this awareness event was “to stop the shaming and to allow young boys and men to be okay with having long hair” as well as “to let society know this is something that has been here before confederation and it’s here to stay.”

Thus, we submit that in addition to the body serving as a source of human needs, wishes, and desires (as evident from Indigenous exemplars of Two-spirited beings like Rainbow) and the body serving as a conduit for emotions and values to flow through (as evident from our exemplar of warrior women like Power), the body is also leveraged as a canvas for showcasing and wearing values and emotions on the physical self. As such, we propose the body as canvas as the corporeal surface for deliberate expressions of values and emotions.

Discussion

Our findings, in conjunction with a literature review of research on values work, emotion work, and body work, enabled us to develop a conceptual framework of how these forms of work are intrinsically connected and consequently shape social action, including institutional work and managing perceptions of legitimacy/illegitimacy. Figure 17.2 visually depicts our conceptual framework.

To begin, we find that body work is connected to values work through a bidirectional recursive relationship by serving as a source of *desirability*. The body serves as a source of inherent needs, desires, and physical abilities and thus shapes values. This is amply evident from the case of Rainbow whose natural, intrinsic orientation towards love is housed in their Two-spirited body. In turn, values suffuse the body with socially desirable and normative goals. We observe the same in the case of Power where traditional Indigenous values which celebrate physical fitness and strength at par with cognitive fitness, shape the means and ends through which she strives for personal wellbeing. Additionally, body work is connected to values work through a recursive relationship whereby body work serves as a source of *meaning* for values work while simultaneously serving as a canvas for projecting values on the physical self. This is most evident through CRX and his sons’ embracing of the “Boys with Braids” movement and as a way of literally their Indigenous value of hair being sacred, irrespective of gender.

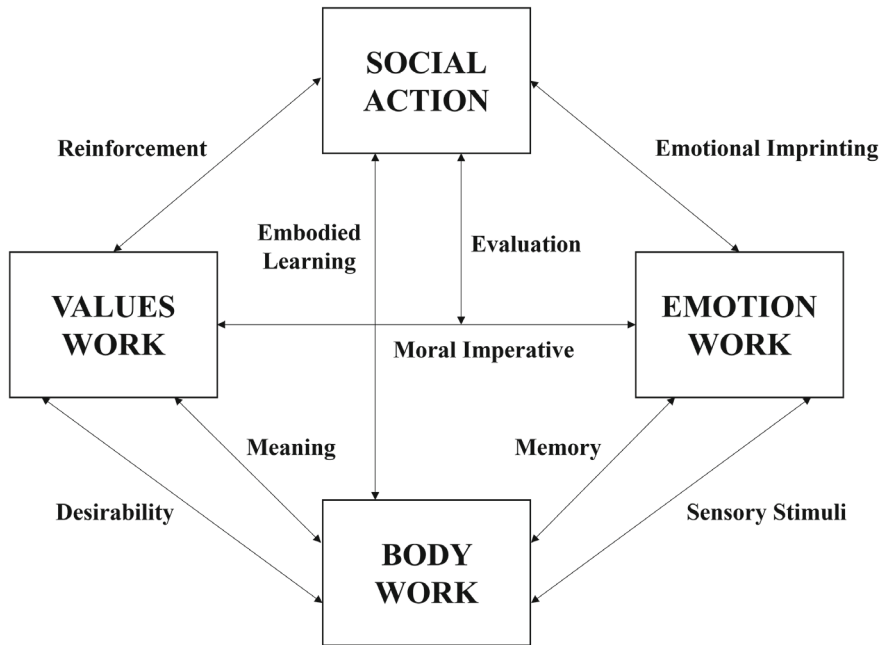


Fig. 17.2 How values work, emotion work, and body work are braided together and related to social action

On the other hand, body work is connected to emotion work through a similar bidirectional recursive relationship by serving as a source of *sensory stimuli* (Elfenbein, 2023). Such sensory stimuli create what Van Kleef and Côté (2022) identify as social effects influencing both affective reactions and inferential processes in observers. For instance, feelings of disgust among care-takers who are responsible for the elderly and patients are often rooted in the bodily sensory experience of how something or someone smells (Twigg, 2000). Similarly, in our study, the embodied practice of Indigenous boys/ men braiding their hair furnishes the embodied wherewithal for experiencing pride in one’s culture. In an ethnographic study of drag artists, Venkatraman et al. (2024) highlight how this creative practice provides the embodied and sensory stimuli necessary to transform shame into pride. Additionally, body work is connected to emotion work through a recursive relationship whereby each serves as a source of *memory* for the other. Indeed, the body is known to be a storehouse of past experiences and memories, including traumatic ones (Maitlis, 2020), while emotions experienced during life events serve as a source of imprints on the physical self. For instance, in the case of Rainbow in our study, the pain of regularly being discriminated for one’s brown, Indigenous, LGBTQ + body is stored as both personal memory as

well as collective memory of Indigenous intergenerational trauma. Moreover, memories both personal and intergenerational, accrete over a period of time within a body, thus making the body a carrier of learning, knowledge, skills, and competencies accumulated over a period of time (Venkatraman et al., 2024).

Furthermore, abductively juxtaposing our findings with extant literature on values and emotion work, we observe that both are intrinsically connected to provide “emotional weightage” (i.e., emotion work to values work) and “moral order” (i.e., values work to emotion work), respectively, for each other (Kraatz et al., 2020). This interaction then creates a foundational *moral imperative*, which serves as either a “bright light” (akin to a green signal to go ahead; Hitlin, 2011) or a “bright line” (akin to a red signal to stop; Bandura, 1999). For instance, in our study, for someone like Power a question like “what would Indigenous matriarchs do in a particular scenario?” serves as a guiding beacon (bright line/light) and serves as a moral imperative. As a consequence of the interaction between values and emotions, the resultant *moral imperative* triggers *evaluation* of which of the available action options are desirable and which are not, thereby shaping social action.

Additionally, continuing with this abductive approach (Van Maanen & De Rond, 2017), helps us identify direct recursive relationships between social action and values work, emotion work, and body work individually. To start, the recursive relationship between social action and values work operates through *reinforcement* (Creed et al., 2020). Social action serves as a tangible expression of values that, when performed, strengthens those same values and creates opportunities for their further manifestation (Selznick, 1957; Voronov & Weber, 2016). Indeed, both Rainbow’s social activism in terms of both Indigenous and LGBTQ + rights as well as CRX’s embracing of the “Boys with Braids” Indigenous movement reinforces pride in the adherence and celebration of these deeply held Indigenous values and serves to further reinforce core Indigenous values. This relationship manifests through the visibility and consequentiality of action: as values are enacted through social action, their importance becomes more salient, leading to further value-aligned action (Kraatz et al., 2020).

Further, the recursive relationship between social action and emotion work functions through *emotional imprinting* (Voronov & Vince, 2012). Social action creates emotional imprints that shape future behavioral dispositions, while emotions simultaneously channel action into particular pathways by enabling certain responses while inhibiting others (Maitlis, 2020; Zietsma et al., 2019). This imprinting process creates distinctive patterns of emotionally informed action (Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017).

Finally, the recursive relationship between social action and body work operates through *embodied learning* (Baldessarelli et al., 2022; Lawrence et al., 2023). Social action creates bodily experiences and modifications of the body that subsequently enable or constrain future action, while bodily capacities and presentations of the body shape what action is possible or desirable (Creed et al., 2020). As actors engage in social action, their bodies become both instruments and products of that action, creating an ongoing dialogue between physical capability, bodily presentation, and social performance (Bazin & Korica, 2021; Stephens, 2021). Indeed, as we observe in the case of Power, her years of martial arts training and practice serve as embodied learning that continues to shape her physical capabilities, how she presents and conducts herself on a daily basis and is fairly evident in her social interactions/engagement (including something seemingly trivial, like her posture). Taken together, our findings suggest that social action is not merely an outcome of values work, emotion work, and body work but a generative force that both shapes and emerges from the ongoing interplay of values, emotions, and bodily practices.

Our framework extends recent theoretical developments in organizational aesthetics. While Baldessarelli et al. (2022) demonstrated that aesthetics influence organizing through emotional and cognitive mechanisms and Creed et al. (2020) theorized how institutional aesthetic codes shape responses to institutional arrangements, the framework presented here shows how these mechanisms operate specifically in the interplay between values work, emotion work, and body work. When actors encounter institutional phenomena through their senses, their responses are shaped by both visceral reactions and learned aesthetic sensibilities, which in turn influence how they participate in institutional processes through various forms of work. By linking immediate sensory experiences to cultural interpretive frameworks, these perspectives help explain how the braiding of values work, emotion work, and body work serves as both a personal embodied experience and a collectively meaningful process that shapes institutional participation.

Lastly, our framework's emphasis on braiding together values work, emotion work, and body work also aligns with Kluckhohn's (1951) work on values, which explains how values manifest through both cognitive understanding and embodied judgment. Particularly relevant is Kluckhohn's insight that values operate along multiple dimensions that shape their influence on action. We observe from his dimensional analysis that some of these dimensions are particularly well illustrated through our framework. For instance, the "dimension of intent" explains how values guide both the means (modes of bodily practices) and ends (desired emotional, institutional, and social

outcomes) of institutional work. The “dimension of intensity” helps explain why certain aesthetic codes and bodily practices carry stronger normative weight than others in institutional life. However, most importantly, Kluckhohn’s “dimension of organization” illuminates how values become systematically connected to emotions and bodily practices through what he terms “integrated values.” These integrated values form an interwoven network of meanings and practices and can help explain why values work, emotion work, and body work are inseparable in practice. They form an integrated system wherein cognitive conceptions of the desirable become embodied through aesthetic experiences and bodily practices. This integration happens both at the personal level through individual aesthetic experiences and bodily habits, and at the institutional level through shared aesthetic codes and collective practices.

Furthermore, in terms of practical implications of our study and framework, there are clear implications in terms of survival strategies for countering cultural marginalization (Sasaki & Baba, 2024), stigma resistance (Venkatraman et al., 2024) as well as coping with the negative effects of intergenerational trauma (Bombay et al., 2009).

Finally, in terms of generalizability of our findings beyond our study’s context of Indigenous actors in the Canadian Prairies, we submit that the framework we have developed applies to other marginalized and stigmatized communities whose cherished cultural values and practices have been rendered illegitimate by virtue of their gender, ethnicity, sexual orientation, caste and more, being different from mainstream/majority/dominant cultures. For instance, for LGBTQ + individuals, the framework could be applied to illustrate how their bodily expressions of identity serve as a source of authentic value to them and how this may conflict with heteronormative institutional logics present in many organizational contexts. Indeed, using the *body as canvas* may be relevant regarding decisions that LGBTQ + individuals take on how to self-represent in the workplace where non-normative gender expressions may be stigmatized (Colgan & Rumens, 2014; Rumens & Broomfield, 2014; Venkatraman et al., 2024). Similarly, female entrepreneurs or managers more widely provide another context that could benefit from the framework presented. Women in leadership positions often use their *body as conduit* to deal with negative emotions in the workplace that may discredit feminine emotional expressions (Brescoll, 2016). Our framework can help explain why these bodily practices are not only performative, but deeply connected to values and emotions that shape the female leader’s identity and resulting behaviors in the workplace (Mavin & Grandy, 2016).

Future Research Opportunities

All forms of institutional work, including processes of legitimation or countering illegitimacy, privilege the intentionality of human social action and thus define institutional work as purposeful efforts (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). By accounting for the often (but not always) unconscious, extra-rational memory-infused and sensory perceptual affordances of the body apparatus, our conceptual framework allows for non-purposeful yet still desirable and meaningful efforts. Thus, we answer recent calls for accounting for extra-rational, nondeliberate logics in shaping human action (Lerner et al., 2018) and propose a more inclusive definition of body work as *the purposive and nonpurposive yet meaningful, desirable, memorable, and sensory-perceptual efforts undertaken by individuals and organizations*.

Future research could build on our work and further explore several promising avenues. First, researchers could examine how these three forms of work manifest differently across various cultural and institutional contexts beyond Indigenous settings. For example, how might their integration differ in institutions primarily focused on cognitive work (like universities) compared to those emphasizing emotional labor (like healthcare) or centered on bodily practices (like dance companies)? Second, research could examine how different social actors (from institutional entrepreneurs to everyday actors) navigate the integration of values, emotions, and bodily practices in their own institutional work. Such studies would help us better understand both the micro-foundations of institutions and the embodied nature of institutional processes. Third, scholars interested in Kluckhohn's (1951) conceptualization of the several dimensions of values may zoom in on those dimensions individually to examine how aesthetic experiences and bodily practices become institutionalized. For instance, future work could address how values of different intensities require different forms of emotion work and body work for their maintenance. Finally, while there is a recognition of the role of cultural norms and the push for cultural conformity in shaping values work (Kraatz et al., 2020), emotion work (Zhang et al., 2024) as well as body work (Lawrence et al., 2023), less appreciated is the existence of a multiplicity and plurality of cultural influences and institutional aesthetic codes (Creed et al., 2020). Presence of multiple and often conflicting cultural influences is likely to manifest itself not only in the form of conflicting values and emotions, but also visceral and physiological tensions. Future research can explore how these embodied forms of tensions are resolved by individuals as well as groups.

Conclusion

While there is a fair amount of research more broadly on institutional work, defined as “the purposive action of individuals and organizations aimed at creating, maintaining and disrupting institutions” (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; p. 215) and more specifically on processes of legitimation (Suchman, 1995; Zelditch, 2001), most of this research focuses on institutional work and legitimation processes as enacted by resourceful and powerful actors like professionals (Lawrence et al., 2009). Indeed, there is little research on how marginalized and stigmatized actors, who have scarce resources and little legitimacy (in fact, their cultural practices may be explicitly deemed illegitimate, often by the state itself) are able to counter their perceived illegitimacy. Our study underscores the point that those who are marginalized and stigmatized at least have their bodies which potentially can be used to engage in various forms of institutional work and counter their real and perceived illegitimacy. Furthermore, our study also helps unpack how body work intimately allies with both emotion and values work to effectuate social change and engage in everyday practices of individual and collective resistance. Indeed, while these everyday bodily practices might be considered trivial and mundane, we submit that these everyday forms of resistance should not be underestimated.

Appendix

Image 1: Boys with braids (Source <https://navera.org/community-blog/boys-with-braids/>)



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18

Organizing for Belonging: The Case of a Religious Organization

Eirik Åadland Tappel and Beate Jelstad Løvaas

Finding ways to foster belonging has become an urgent social mission.
(Cohen, 2022)

Introduction

Organizational scholars are increasingly interested in examining the role organizations can play in improving the lives and well-being of individuals, including the communities in which they live (e.g., Bento da Silva et al., 2022; Creed et al., 2022; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). In this context, scholars argue for the need to pay attention to people's preoccupation with belonging and securing well-being as well as how social arrangements may foster or undermine these aspects (Creed et al., 2022).

Belonging is considered an essential human need (Maslow, 1954) and has been defined and operationalized in different ways. It is both a subjective experience and a more objective relation to social, cultural, and geographical structures (Allen et al., 2021; Rønningstad, 2024). In this chapter, belonging

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concerns personal contact with others (social groups), involving a propensity of connectedness. Thus, belonging refers to a relation where people feel valued by another person, group, or organization (Baumeister & Leary, 1995).

A focus on belonging in organization studies is both timeless and timely. It is timeless because belonging is essential and critical to human existence, and timely because of the growing focus on relational aspects in the field of organization and leadership studies (e.g., Dutton et al., 2014). There is general agreement that belonging matters: It predicts numerous mental, physical, social, economic, and behavioral outcomes, and feelings of *not belonging* are strongly linked to a lack of purpose and meaning as well as to increased risk of health problems (Allen et al., 2021). Much like plants need water, sun, and nutrients to flourish, belonging is vital to an individual's motivation, psychological growth, and well-being (Baumeister & Leary, 1995; Gagné & Deci, 2005; Løvaas, 2020). As such, it is important for organizations to develop practices and routines that foster a sense of belonging. Through social arrangements, actions, practices, and specific kinds of "work," belonging—and thus, human flourishing—can be supported (Bryer, 2020),

With this point of departure, this study seeks to investigate everyday actions and practices in organizations that might support belonging. Specifically, this study examines how actors organize for belonging. Organizing refers to a pattern of collective actions that represents a distinct form of organizational capability (Dutton et al., 2006). A focus on organizing is central to understanding human action in organizations (Weick, 1979). It is argued that a focus on organizing can enrich organization studies by unpacking how actors solve the challenges of aligning goals and coordinating action (Heath & Sitkin, 2001). Thus, the aim of this chapter is to explore dimensions that are central to the patterns of organizing for belonging. The research question guiding this chapter is as follows: *How do organizational actors organize for belonging?* The focus on organizing foregrounds the actions of the organizational members in this study.

To investigate how organizational actors organize for belonging, religious organizations are a valuable starting point that can provide deep insights. Religion is considered a source of belonging and meaning for many, and religious traditions might offer structures that are designed to help individuals connect with one another via social networks and relationships (Zhang et al., 2019). Thus, rather than treating belonging instrumentally, religious organizations may consider belonging as an end goal; accordingly, they may provide settings in which organizational members are oriented toward collective actions and structures that foster belonging.

Religious organizations, characterized as social systems operating in a changing environment (Beckford, 1973), can be quite complex. In addition to adapting to changing environments, they look to an authority beyond themselves. Pursuing the long-term religious goals of the organization and adapting to changing environments—that is, juggling tradition and innovation—results in religious organizations encountering a high degree of complexity.

Complex organizations with rich emotional data are considered ideal venues for investigating how organizing practices can foster belonging. In this way, religious organizations can extend our understanding, possibly laying the ground for the use of new approaches. Additionally, studying religious organizations can remedy the limited attention given to these organizations in the field of organization and leadership studies (e.g., Tracey et al., 2014). Previous studies on belonging in organizations have mainly focused on the people working in organizations (e.g., employees); however, this study emphasizes how organizational actors organize to foster belonging for their volunteers and for others in the local communities in which the organizations operate and in which people live their lives.

Volunteering is seen as a way to create meaning in life (Schnell & Hoof, 2012). Further, meaning in life comes from belonging, purpose, value, and coherence (Baumeister & Landau, 2018) and is vital to well-being (Lund et al., 2019). Volunteers are neither forced to participate nor paid for their commitment; instead, they seek personal relations with other members, for which a sense of belonging is essential. Thus, paying attention to volunteering could extend our understanding of organizing belonging.

The Norwegian Church Abroad (CoNA) is a religious organization that has extensive international experience in organizing belonging for its volunteers, members, and people from local communities. Hence, it was chosen as the research setting for this empirical study. We examined two cases within CoNA in two different European countries to inform and investigate how organizational actors organize to create belonging for their volunteers and for the local communities in which the organization operates. Thus, this work responds to a recent call to examine the role organizations can play in improving lives and well-being (Bento da Silva et al., 2022; Creed et al., 2022; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024).

Further, the chapter contributes more broadly to the literature and growing interest among organizational scholars in uncovering the micro-foundations of institutional processes (Ocasio et al., 2017). The two cases in this study offer a broad narrative of the patterns of organizing for belonging, starting with emotions triggering actions and followed by different dimensions of

organizing (inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing) playing an important role in creating belonging and further constituting meaning in people's lives. Although a contextualized study like this tends to provide insights into a somewhat unique empirical setting, it may allow us to build up to a degree of conceptually generalizable insights about organizing for belonging (Hoholm & Araujo, 2011).

Theoretical Perspectives and Previous Research

Research on belonging has been undertaken within multiple disciplines, including psychology, sociology, education, medicine, public health, economics, political science, and organization studies. Despite the theoretically diverse perspectives on the topic (Allen et al., 2021), there is general agreement that the need to belong is critical to human existence and fundamental to human motivation (Baumeister & Leary, 1995; Deci & Ryan, 2000; Maslow, 1954). There is, however, less agreement about the construct of belonging itself: how belonging should be measured and what people can do to satisfy the need for belonging. Instead of focusing on the objective aspect of belonging (i.e., belonging to a geographical place), we focus our attention on belonging in a relational sense: where people feel valued by another person, group, or organization, and one that involves developing a sense of identification with that person or entity through forming social bonds (Baumeister & Leary, 1995).

Previous research on organizational belonging has been dominated by employee perspectives, and mainly quantitative studies within the organizational psychology domain (i.e., the role of relatedness for work motivation) (Gagné & Deci, 2005; Richer, Blanchard, & Vallerand, 2002). Belonging has also been studied in the context of meaningful work, where interpersonal relationships are regarded as a central means of experiencing meaningful work (Michaelson et al., 2014). Within organizational theory and institutional work, belonging has been studied in terms of inclusive work (Bryer, 2020). However, according to organizational scholars, one aspect that has been overlooked in this context is examining how social structures can enhance or weaken individuals' feelings of belonging and well-being (Bento da Silva et al., 2022; Creed et al., 2022).

Previous literature on organizational belonging has mostly focused on people at workplaces, such as workers' belonging to an organization (Filstad et al., 2019), and feelings of belongingness among employees (Herbert, 2022; Løvaas, 2020). According to a recent literature review, organizational

belonging is rooted in the general need for belonging, and there is scant literature on scales that can measure organizational belonging (Blau et al., 2023). There are also studies on belonging in the context of religious organizations, such as Bellamy et al. (2015), studying how involvement in community groups, such as volunteering, fostered bridging social capital (i.e., connection among diverse individuals) among Australian churchgoers. Further, while organizational scholars have treated belonging mostly as an individual-level phenomenon, this study seeks to link belonging to organizational practices of collective action (organizing). While earlier studies on belonging in organizations have focused on people at work—employees within an organization—this study emphasizes the role organizations play in promoting belonging for volunteers and people living in the local communities in which the organizations operate, in line with recent calls (Creed et al., 2022).

Research Setting and Method

Introducing the Case and Context

CoNA is a religious organization that creates social, cultural, and church-related meeting opportunities for Norwegians abroad. The organization has extensive experience in organizing for belonging for its members and for the local communities in which it operates; therefore, it was chosen as the research context and empirical setting for this study. Our interest in studying CoNA also stems from its less bureaucratic structure compared to larger churches like the Church of Norway, which has more complex decision-making processes due to its state church legacy (Askeland & Sirris, 2021).

The mission of the organization is to be an *inclusive, outreach-oriented, and innovative* church that is present for Norwegians wherever they are located. CoNA reaches out to people; expresses interest in their everyday lives; strives to be a social and cultural meeting place; offers a community of faith through worship, church activities, and religious education; and provides care and support to people in crisis and need (Sjømannskirken, 2021). It is a voluntary association guided by third-sector principles (Billis, 2010, p. 55), with a considerable number of volunteers. It operates with a specific mission and has a hybrid structure that includes members, volunteers, and employees.

As an organization, CoNA exemplifies intra-institutional complexity in a foreign culture (Gümüşay et al., 2024; Meyer & Höllerer, 2016). It is both a church and a cultural center for Norwegians abroad and an organization that

adapts to the local culture in which it is located. Additionally, CoNA seeks to *create a home away from home* (Sjømannskirken, 2021), which suggests that in addition to promoting both religious and cultural values, it finds ways to foster belonging, as it is crucial to creating a home away from home.

Nordic societies have received significant attention in recent decades for their comprehensive democratic participation and high levels of volunteering. In Norway, 61% of the population is engaged in volunteering, mostly within nonprofit organizations (Enjolras & Strømsnes, 2018; Qvist et al., 2019). Nordic countries and their civic organizations have moved away from being rooted in tradition to adopting a more urban outlook that emphasizes individual freedom (Lorentzen, 2007). This transition is part of a wider process of secularization, which has also affected religion and the church (Dobbelaere, 1981; Repstad, 2020; Sirris, 2023a, pp. 27–28, 93).

Today, voluntary work tends to be more episodic and short-term, replacing longer commitments. Broadly, it can be categorized as instrumental—enabling organizations to meet their labor needs—or organic, allowing individuals to engage in fulfilling activities (Tappel & Sirris, 2024). There is a shift from collectivistic to reflexive volunteering (Habermann, 2007, p. 322; Hustinx & Lammertyn, 2003; Sirris, 2023b), which is focused on autonomy and project-based tasks; however, both styles coexist, particularly in Christian organizations (Framgarden, 2024).

CoNA relies heavily on volunteers for its survival. The organization has acknowledged its dependence on volunteer staff to achieve its goal of being an inclusive, outreach-oriented, and innovative church that supports Norwegians living abroad (Sjømannskirken, 2021, 2023, p. 4). One of CoNA's key objectives is to recognize and meet the need that many people have in today's modern society: for belonging and community (Sjømannskirken, 2021, 2023).

Data Collection

To investigate how members of religious organizations organize for belonging, we conducted a qualitative study, employing multiple sources of data, in CoNA. Specifically, we selected two cases (i.e., Big City Church and Coastal Town Church) of CoNA, located in two European countries as they represented different contexts and organization structures. Data on these two cases were obtained from the organizations' paid staff members (employees), volunteers, and external cooperation partners via 29 qualitative, in-depth individual interviews and seven qualitative group interviews. Additionally, we derived data from 43 hours of observation and an examination of official

documents from the organizations. A close scrutiny of the data to understand micro-level patterns in organizing for belonging through everyday actions and interactions revealed 12 individual interviews and five group interviews that were particularly interesting given the topic of investigation. They formed the basis of the analyses in this study.

Data Analysis

The authors iteratively reviewed the text from the focus groups and individual interviews along with theories that helped interpret the data. The authors independently noted interesting and important aspects in the transcripts, from which new questions were derived in the analysis process. Thematic analyses and systematic coding were conducted using NVivo, in line with the process recommended by Braun and Clarke (2006). We developed initial codes, before further developing and refining categories/aggregated dimensions, to capture recurring and repeated actions of organizing for belonging. We moved back and forth between empirical data and existing theories, signaling the use of an abductive approach (Bryman, 2016). Figure 18.1 shows the aggregated dimensions of inquiring, valuing, empowering, trusting, and we-ing that emerged from the data structure of meaningful units and codes.

This study was approved by the Norwegian Social Science Data Services. The participants were informed about the purpose of the study, how the data would be used, and confidentiality practices. To protect the participants' identities, they have been assigned fictitious names in the sections below.

Vignettes

The two vignettes presented below are from different European countries in which CoNA is located: Coastal Town Church (vignette 1) and Big City Church (vignette 2). These vignettes illustrate the actions performed by organizational actors to support a sense of belonging and they also capture how emotions function as triggers driving actions toward belonging. Subsequently, we analyze the primary data material described above to understand how organizational actors organize for fostering belonging.

Vignette 1: The Journey from Darkness to Light—A Volunteer's Perspective

A Norwegian woman named Vicky lived abroad, and she had learned the local culture and language. She worked as a chef and would cook for large events. While staying abroad, she experienced a difficult life crisis that pushed her into an overwhelmingly dark phase. She almost *crawled* to the Coastal Town Church, knocked on the door, and asked if she could start volunteering in the kitchen. The general manager offered Vicky a place in the kitchen. Impressed by Vicky's skills and qualities, the manager asked Vicky to lead a new activity—a cooking course for an age group that they had struggled to reach previously. Vicky felt recognized, valued, and welcomed as a volunteer in the kitchen and for being entrusted with leading the course. However, the staff member who was responsible for the kitchen was not informed or involved in the process of giving volunteers responsibility in the kitchen. Vicky felt empowered as the church recognized her needs. The church promoted a “we” mentality and nurtured a sense of belonging. Vicky described it as follows: “It’s how they treat each other. The sense of community is really strong.”

Vignette 2: The Journey Toward Belonging—Perspectives of Employees/Staff members

The Big City Church had been helping a Norwegian homeless person in a large European city. Finding him dead on the street one day deeply affected the church staff, who decided to take action and help other homeless people in the city. One of the pastors in the church attended a meeting where a local foundation presented a winter project for the homeless in collaboration with other churches in the area. The Big City Church decided to take part in the joint project and informed and encouraged its members to participate directly as volunteers. Subsequently, employees and a group of volunteers from the Big City Church, as well as new volunteers, accommodated 15 homeless people in the church for a day every week throughout the winter. Other local churches assumed this responsibility on other days of the week. The volunteers felt that the project was well organized, although they wanted the leaders to be more present and acknowledge the efforts of the volunteers and staff. However, the volunteers largely experienced autonomy and trust in the Homeless Project. A volunteer, Verne, had this to say: “There weren’t strict rules about what we could or couldn’t do as volunteers in the Homeless Project.” In this way, volunteers were empowered and able to express their needs. The staff’s emphasis on fostering an inclusive “we” mindset, such as by sharing meals, influenced the volunteers, staff members, and homeless people and created a sense of belonging.

The Role of Emotions in Triggering Actions Toward Belonging

What role do emotions play in triggering belonging-seeking actions? Overall, vignette 1 illustrates a journey from despair to finding a supportive community. The feeling of darkness that overwhelmed the individual (Vicky) led them to take action to overcome their dissonance or disconnection. Thus, the individual's emotions triggered action and were a driver for change. Through these actions, a sense of belonging gradually emerged. Essentially, darkness led the individual to make efforts to find meaning again through experiencing coherence, significance, and belonging. The vignette also shows how joining the institution in a search for meaning resulted in the individual becoming a volunteer for the religious organization. That the person chose to seek the church also illustrates the power of the institution and its legitimacy (Zucker, 1977). Upon arriving at the church, she felt welcome, and the church supported her by recognizing her potential and encouraging her to use her skills. However, in the process, the organization overlooked the aspect of involving the employee responsible for the kitchen. Thus, there were tensions in the collaboration between volunteers and employees, particularly in how they perceived their responsibilities and roles.

The second vignette explains how moral emotions experienced by employees/staff members of the organization triggered action. Organizational actors were emotionally moved to take positive action for the homeless. The vignette also illustrates how the Homeless Project became meaningful for both volunteers and homeless people through organizational actors' efforts toward fostering belonging. Feelings of being valued and respected are vital to experiencing a sense of belonging, and various actions described in the second vignette promoted these feelings, including inviting volunteers through newsletters and announcements during services, coffee gatherings at church, and actively engaging volunteers. The vignette emphasizes the importance of direct invitations for volunteering (Wollebæk et al., 2015), highlighting that open inquiries and specific questions can encourage participation significantly. Table 18.1 shows the role of emotions as triggers driving actions, with excerpts from the data material.

Both vignettes suggest that emotions trigger belonging-seeking behaviors. This is in line with previous studies that have highlighted that emotions are essential starting points when organizing for compassion (Dutton et al., 2006, p. 59) and that emotional dynamics are crucial for creating communities of "change makers" (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). Table 18.1 also shows how belonging is experienced by a volunteer and a homeless person. From

Table 18.1 Role of emotions as triggers driving belonging-seeking actions

Cases	Emotions as triggers for belonging-seeking actions	Actions fostering belonging	Feeling a sense of belonging
Vignette 1: Coastal Town Church	"The darkness that consumed me then was overwhelming" (Volunteer)	Inquiring Valuing Trusting Empowering	"People do like me and involve me" (Volunteer)
Vignette 2: Big City Church	"It affected us deeply and made us do something for the homeless" (Employee)	We-ing	"This is the best place to come because you are so hospitable" (Homeless person)

emotions that trigger actions (Column 1) and to experiencing feelings of belonging (Column 3), actions have been performed to foster the feelings of belonging, which are labeled as inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and creating a sense of "we" (we-ing). In the following section, we investigate these action dimensions in depth and examine how these patterns of collective actions are institutionalized within the organization, such that they are embedded in the social system or accorded a "rule-like status" (Meyer & Rowan, 1977, p. 341).

Findings: Organizing for Belonging

To understand how organizational actors organize for belonging, we present findings that draw on the interview data and official documents described earlier. These findings are classified into five action dimensions: inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing. Each type of action plays a role in organizing for belonging among the volunteers and the communities in which people live their lives.

Inquiring: Open Questions and Specific Questions

Data from individual and group interviews revealed that volunteers value open questions from organizational actors about their activity and engagement preferences. Carmen, a volunteer and member of the parish council at Big City Church, said, "We had at least two meetings a year with those who were leading the volunteers. They asked us what was important to us

and what we wanted to be involved in.” Such open-ended questions posed by church staff during volunteer meetings promoted community involvement and a supportive volunteering environment. This practice also aligns with the CoNA’s strategy (Sjømannskirken, 2021, 2023), which encourages employees to engage volunteers with questions like “What do you want to do, and what are your strengths?” However, some volunteers felt that the leaders were indifferent to their preferences, which resulted in their experiencing demotivation and isolation in their tasks. In contrast to the organic approach of open-ended inquiries is the instrumental approach of specific requests for help from volunteers, which some volunteers like Carmen found unsatisfying:

The staff asked: Can you come and make waffles? Can you help wash up? Then I’m stuck washing dishes until 3 PM on Sunday. I felt that I accomplished that, but I wasn’t allowed to be part of the community and meet other people. That’s how I felt.

On the other hand, some volunteers, like Vicky, appreciated specific requests, including being invited to lead the cooking course (vignette 1). The data also indicated that direct invitations to potential volunteers and social networks played a key role in attracting more volunteers.

The use of open and closed questions for volunteer tasks reflects a blend of organic and instrumental volunteering approaches, in which organic volunteering emphasizes the volunteer’s self-fulfillment and instrumental volunteering focusing on the need for labor in addition to paid efforts (Tappel & Sirris, 2024). Being directly approached is an effective way to become a volunteer (Wollebæk et al., 2015). Additionally, recruiting volunteers through relationships and asking potential new volunteers are key steps in engaging volunteers (Sirris, 2023b).

Valuing: Being Appreciated and Welcomed

Appreciating volunteers involves recognizing their importance through words and actions. Vignette 1 showed how volunteers valued acknowledgment. For instance, Vicky from Coastal Town Church said the following:

Everyone here likes me a lot, which feels wonderful. It’s great to be in a place where you are welcomed and appreciated. It’s also rewarding to know that an organization wants to invest in you. I feel fortunate that people enjoy my company and want to engage with me.

Regarding valuing through welcoming, CoNA follows the social practice of welcoming visitors, with hosts standing at the entrance of the church. Guests appreciate this warm gesture from church volunteers or staff members, which in turn encourages engagement and fosters a sense of belonging. While these practices (e.g., handshakes) (Hatch, 2011, p. 57) facilitate belonging, they also underscore the need to examine how such social structures impact feelings of connection and well-being, a topic that is often overlooked in organization studies (Creed et al., 2022).

The strategic plan of CoNA (Sjømannskirken, 2021) emphasizes inclusivity in these words: “We have a generous and hospitable attitude toward those we meet.” This welcoming spirit reflects the organization’s history and aligns with the Christian tradition of embracing “the vulnerable and friendless” (Angell, 2012; Bretherton, 2006, p. 139). A key goal of CoNA is to practice hospitality, which is reflected in the practice of providing waffles and coffee. Hospitality in the New Testament, is seen as a way to enable divine connections (Hebrews 13: 2; Rom. 12: 13 in Holy Bible, 2006). Nordstokke (1999) notes that diaconal hospitality is generous and without hidden agendas, allowing for meaningful encounters that can promote existential questions and open up for conversations about faith and life experiences.

The reading room and coffee hours after Sunday services create an inclusive atmosphere. CoNA acts as a cultural hub and an open community church for Norwegians abroad. In the interviews, participants emphasized the importance of feeling welcomed and forming connections. For instance, volunteer Vicky from Coastal Town Church shared the following:

It’s about being welcomed, you’re noticed, and people focus on you—you gain value, friendship. It’s very fun. We danced and had a lot of fun together. Laughter, joy. Meeting people from all backgrounds. It’s a place where everyone shows up (open folk church). You don’t have to be Christian to be there; you can be anything. Everyone is welcome. Hospitality is quite unique to CoNA.

To sum up, being valued as a person is part of experiencing a sense of belonging (Baumeister & Leary, 1995), with practices of acknowledging and welcoming playing a vital role.

Trusting

From the interviews, we learned that volunteers had a deep sense of trust in CoNA and that increased responsibility, autonomy, and trust strengthened

volunteers' intrinsic motivation and sense of belonging. Additionally, feelings of mastery and competence boost motivation, as improved skills led to greater trust and responsibility. The interviews revealed that volunteers felt more useful and connected when they were welcomed and allowed to utilize their skills. Employees often granted skilled volunteers considerable freedom in their roles. Employee Emma noted the following:

Yes, we give the volunteers freedom where it is appropriate. Not in all areas, but in some, it works well. For instance, a trained chef. She knows more about cooking than I do. She has quite a bit of freedom to do what she wants in the kitchen within the existing guidelines. We also had a woman who was very skilled with flowers and decorations, so she was responsible for purchasing flowers and setting things up.

The staff members valued volunteers' expertise and challenged them with responsibilities suited to their skills while also offering training in unfamiliar areas. Studies have shown that *trust* helps social bonds to develop and endure and provides volunteers with a deep sense of belonging (Cartel et al., 2019; Douglas Creed et al., 2014; Fan & Zietsma, 2017).

Empowering Through Tailored Tasks and Follow-Up Support

CoNA staff members empowered volunteers by tailoring tasks and offering follow-up support. Regarding tailoring tasks, organizational actors recognized individual potential and encouraged skill development. CoNA is focused on adapting its approach to meet the diverse needs of its volunteers and visitors. While not all needs can be addressed, one interview participant explained it by saying, "We all need to claim our own space and be in the right place." Allowing autonomy enables flexibility and tailored solutions, as volunteer Vicky observed:

We offer each other unconditional space. While not everyone gets along perfectly, and the dynamics may not function smoothly for all, we all share the same fundamental need. We come here for a reason—because we need to be here. Some of us are very talkative, some stay silent, some may not be as tidy. Yet, we are all together in this space for the same reason: we need this place.

When working on tailored tasks, users and volunteers felt accepted and safe in expressing their vulnerabilities, thus creating an inclusive community that welcomed diverse perspectives. Volunteers celebrated uniqueness and advocated for everyone's place. New reflexive volunteerism (Hustinx & Lammertyn, 2003) and transformational leadership (Løvaas et al., 2020) have both highlighted the importance of relational and individual considerations.

Regarding follow-up support, CoNA's resource booklet mentions that volunteers are given comprehensive training aligned with the organization's vision. This customized training includes mentorship to foster belonging and regular staff meetings to clarify plans and responsibilities. Our data underscored the importance of pre-task training and ongoing support. The Homeless Project, for instance, involved collaboration among various congregations, including Big City Church, which was asked to deliver introductory training to employees and volunteers. Senior Pastor and General Manager Peter shared the following in this context:

The structure was established by a dedicated charity that organized the project. We were invited to join a rotation with other congregations, which Big City Church welcomed because the charity managed the structure and handled the volunteer training.

At Big City Church, volunteer hosts received training during dedicated meetings, where they were encouraged to provide feedback and share new ideas. While structured and organized training enhanced volunteers' competence and feelings of mastery, meeting other people infused a sense of belonging. Thus, tailored follow-up support consists of comprehensive training and mentorship aligned with CoNA's mission. Initiatives like the Homeless Project demonstrate effective collaboration among congregations, ensuring smooth volunteer training and fostering empowerment, community, and belonging among volunteers.

Empowerment is considered an emotional experience of self-confidence without feelings of isolation. It can mobilize social groups and create a sense of belonging (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). "Use Your Talents" is an example of a program run by The Norwegian Mission Society that promotes empowerment (Haus & Hilleren, 2017). Empowering individuals to use their unique talents and resources for the community creates a sense of shared purpose and inclusion. It helps volunteers feel valued and connected, strengthening their sense of belonging within the church community.

We-ing

CoNA aims to foster a sense of “we” to enhance belonging and ensure that both volunteers and users feel valued. CoNA’s strategic document advocates uniting staff, volunteers, and representatives in service through language that reinforces shared goals. The “we” mentality strengthens connections among users and volunteers, greatly enriching the community. Remarking on the strong community spirit, Vicky, a volunteer, said, “It’s how they treat each other. The sense of community is really strong.”

The strategy document also underscores the importance of including everyone associated with CoNA, as the former Secretary General noted, “Without volunteers, there is no CoNA.” The organization believes that cultivating an inclusive “we” will help expand its impact, which highlights the need for training that fosters unity among all members. Overall, CoNA’s commitment to inclusivity and collaboration contributes significantly to building a stronger community.

Further, with respect to *language consciousness*, the interview participants emphasized the importance of precise language in fostering a sense of belonging to a larger “We.” Senior Pastor and General Manager Peter at Big City Church had the following to say:

“We” is an incredibly exclusive word in informational emails. It’s not that “we” are inviting you to come to us. When you talk about the big “we” here, it’s important to be precise with language. I am very strict about language. It’s not because we’re so competent and others are not, but often people haven’t thought this through. It becomes: Who is this “we” that is inviting others to join us? We celebrate services; we will have Easter walks. We can talk about “we” when we are together. But when communicating externally, you can’t say, “We need a sound technician.” Who is the “we” that needs a sound technician? Instead, we write, “The Big City Church needs skilled individuals” or “The Big City Church is currently without someone to perform certain tasks.”

CoNA aims to foster a sense of “we” to create a community environment and ensure that volunteers and users feel valued and included. CoNA’s strategic document emphasizes inclusivity, and its language reinforces this identity by employing “we” to highlight shared goals. This “we” mentality strengthens community ties, as observed by a volunteer: “It’s how they treat each other. The sense of community is really strong.”

Figure 18.1 displays how organizational actions of inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing foster belonging among volunteers and local community members. Further, these dimensions of organizing for

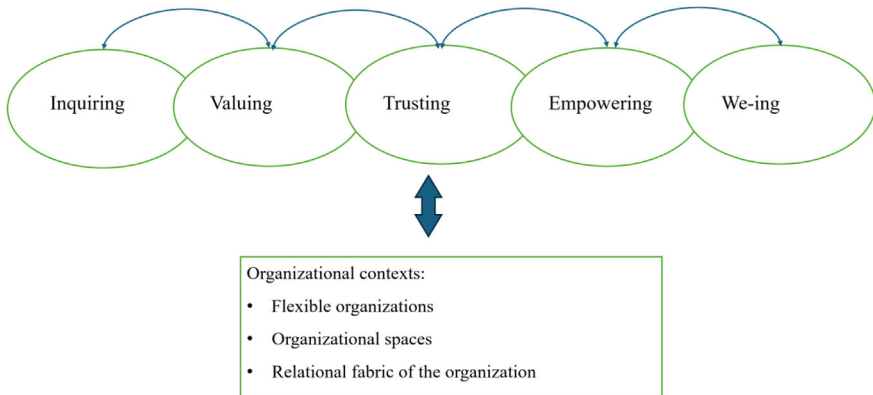


Fig. 18.1 Dimensions of organizing for belonging within an organizational context

belonging are linked to one another. The process starts with the inquiring dimension—with organizational actors asking volunteers, “How would you like to contribute?”—which initiates the feeling of being valued and then moves on to trust (also shown in the Vignettes). We also find a link between being trusted and being empowered by the trust, which includes the ability to use one’s resources and talents. Finally, when volunteers feel empowered and capable, they become part of the larger “we.” This is not a dependent form of “we-ing”; rather, it is an empowered volunteer engaging in a shared sense of belonging. Thus, the different organizing dimensions are interrelated and contribute to fostering belonging.

Discussion: Organizational Features That Enable Belonging

The patterns of collective actions performed by organizational actors to facilitate belonging are visualized in Fig. 18.1. These dimensions occur in an organizational context, which may be facilitative or inhibitive to different degrees. Thus, organizing for belonging unfolds within the boundaries of an organization. In the following section, we discuss how organizational conditions enable or constrain belonging. Specifically, based on the analyzed data, we outline how three characteristics or features affect belonging: organizational flexibility, organizational spaces, and the relational fabric of the organization (Fig. 18.1). Finally, we discuss the role of emotions and values in organizing for belonging.

Flexible Organizations with Less Bureaucracy

Flexibility in low-bureaucracy organizations is important for facilitating belonging through actions like inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing. Both vignettes point to the organizational capacity of flexibility. In the first case, it involves adapting to the needs of an individual, tailoring tasks, and encouraging her to use her resources and talents. In the second vignette, it is seen in how the organization goes beyond its primary purpose by collaborating with other local churches to support belonging. Thus, an organization's flexibility is crucial for fostering belonging.

CoNA is less bureaucratic than other organizations (Askeland & Sirris, 2021), which grants it significant flexibility as a voluntary entity (Angell, 2012). Its independence, its goal of being present and responsive to user needs, and the importance of hospitality within the organization (Angell, 2012) are aspects that make it stand apart. Unlike organizations with formal governing bodies, CoNA's council performs an advisory role, supporting the general manager/senior pastor, who holds decision-making authority. Accordingly, CoNA has focused on enhancing leadership skills through training for general managers, which enables churches to respond quickly and innovate (Tappel et al., 2025). The church (CoNA) has remained innovative and adaptable since 1864, partly due to its smaller size and streamlined decision-making processes (Angell, 2012; Nordstokke, 1999; Nyland, 2007). Thus, this study shows how flexible, less bureaucratic organizations are vital for fostering belonging (Fig. 18.1).

Organizational Spaces as Safe Spaces

Belonging is also shaped by the structure of organizational spaces or bounded social settings. More specifically, safe spaces and shared spaces are prerequisites for organizing and experiencing a sense of belonging. In safe spaces, people dare to share: psychological safety allows for interpersonal risk-taking (Edmondson, 1999). The current study shows how safe spaces have introduced changes in the lives of volunteers. By fostering belonging through inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and creating a sense of "we," the safe spaces have emerged as catalysts for engagement. CoNA's role as a "safe haven" attracts new volunteers and those in need, as Vicky described below:

This is what CoNA aims to be: A home away from home. It's about having a useful space, somewhere to go, something to do, meeting people, having meaningful conversations, and receiving and giving care. It's about that sense

of community—we are all Norwegian expatriates in this country. We come together in a familiar setting, eating food that's familiar to us. Just having a cup of coffee and a chat with another Norwegian can be the comfort you need this week or month.

The reading room/social room serves as a vital space for connection and is often the first area encountered before the worship area. Angell (2012) notes that moving between different tables—coffee, pool, and networking—symbolizes a “home away from home,” where people can share food and conversations (Nyland, 2007). Nordstokke (1999) highlights that CoNA's hospitality flows through these spaces. When volunteers and employees feel safe, they are more open to sharing details about their lives and connecting with others (Tappel et al., 2025). Our empirical data are in line with findings that suggest that trust and psychological safety significantly enhance belonging by fostering positive social emotions, encouraging openness, and facilitating shared understanding and cooperation among diverse groups (Fan & Zietsma, 2017).

At a more structural level, CoNA maintains safe spaces by prioritizing volunteer training, which is mandated by local authorities for working with vulnerable individuals. This training fosters secure environments that are essential for people's well-being, protecting both volunteers and those they serve. Thus, CoNA acts as a safe haven for the local community, providing a secure environment and a physical shared space, which is a precondition for belonging work to occur (Tappel et al., 2025). A safe space is, therefore, both a prerequisite and a catalyst for engagement.

To summarize, the data show that a safe space is essential for fostering a sense of belonging, as it allows individuals to connect and share personal experiences without fear. By prioritizing psychological safety and trust, organizations can create environments where meaningful interactions occur, which contributes to a sense of community and belonging among members.

The Relational Fabric of the Organization

The third feature that affects belonging is the relational fabric of the organization, which is reflected in the quality of relationships. When the quality of the connections is high, the relationship is characterized by mutuality, positive regard, and vitality (Dutton & Heaphy, 2003). People are likely more attached to one another, and this attachment facilitates belonging. A precondition for experiencing high-quality connections is the art and practice of being present (Løvaas & Espedal, 2023). In addition to being

connected to oneself, being present involves being available to and aware of the other person and consciously turning one's attention to another individual. Such perspective-taking and other-awareness make it possible to develop quality relationships. These small acts of interrelating contribute to a growing relationship and cultivate the ground for a sense of belonging to grow.

Highlighting the importance of being present philosopher and theologian Kierkegaard referred to being present as a holy moment: one with "no past or future, as freedom is only revealed in the immediate action of the now, in the decision" (Jor, 1954, p. 142; Kierkegaard, 1964). Espedal (2021) observed that sacred meetings in connection with others can lead a person from a situation of despair to experiencing hope and life as sacred.

CoNA's mission embodies the idea of "being the church in everyday life," facilitating connections among individuals through worship and personal encounters. This approach fosters trust and presence in daily moments, supported by a theology of proximity that recognizes God's influence in ordinary life. The diaconal dimension has been central to CoNA since its establishment in 1864, reflecting a service-oriented church model rooted in the New Testament concept of "diaconia," (Nordstokke, 2008). Nyland (2007) and Nordstokke (1999) highlight the importance of a theology of presence as exemplified in vignette 1, where actions of restoring dignity and cultivating an inclusive community foster belonging. This is also reflected in a volunteer's observation: "It's how they treat each other. The sense of community is really strong." In vignette 2, CoNA's outreach efforts with the homeless further illustrate their commitment to providing dignity and belonging through collaboration with local churches to provide shelter and meals. CoNA thus emphasizes service and connection through worship, trust building, and belonging, particularly among the homeless at Big City Church.

Research shows that social networks are crucial for fostering a sense of belonging and driving volunteerism (Becker & Dhingra, 2001; Putnam, 2010; Sirris, 2023a). The rewards of fellowship can be as important as the content of faith (Fugelli et al., 2020), and increased church attendance correlates with higher volunteer engagement (Sirris, 2023a, p. 28). Wollebæk et al. (2015) underscored the link between religion, trust, and commitment, supporting the work by Putnam and Campbell (Putnam, 2010, p. 444). Our study also suggests that belonging is central to meaning, drawing from biblical parables (Luke 15; Luke 10) and aligning with previous findings (Espedal, 2019; Aadland & Skjørshammer, 2012). In summary, the quality of relationships within an organization shapes belonging through mutuality and

presence, transforming despair into hope (Espedal, 2021; Løvaas & Espedal, 2023).

The Role of Emotions and Values in Organizing for Belonging

This chapter contributes to the ongoing exploration of how emotions and values are related. Both seem to act as drivers of actions, influencing the process of organizing for belonging. In the studied religious organization, which is both a church and a cultural center for Norwegians abroad as well as a home away from home, both religious and cultural values are in play, and the boundaries between the different values are fluid. Values are connected to emotions, and emotions are connected to values. The following section describes the link between emotions and values, based on our empirical findings.

The two cases in this study illustrate the process of organizing for belonging, with emotions being the triggers for actions. Emotional displays carry meaning. The emotions experienced by the participants in this study triggered value-driven actions in both cases. Thus, emotions can be seen as the starting point in the journey from emotions to values. However, the emotional reactions themselves (such as in the second vignette) were rooted in the values of the organizational actors. A value that is threatened or supported is infused with emotions. Thus, emotions may function as markers of values, expressing the values at play, which can then be described as the journey from values to emotions. In this way, the journey from emotions to values and from values to emotions can be understood in the context of this study. There is abundant literature on both emotions and values in institutional processes, with studies focusing mostly on either of the two. This research, however, illustrates how both emotions and values are critical driving forces in institutional processes, such as organizing for belonging.

Values are central to organizations and play an important role in guiding action and providing meaning and purpose (Kraatz et al., 2020). Values imbue people's actions with direction, meaning, and purpose by signifying what is desirable. Further, emotions and values may not necessarily be clearly distinguished from each other. Friedland (2018) describes feelings as the "essential basis of valuation" (p. 4); similarly, this study finds that belonging is at the same time a value and emotion and thus inextricably connected. Moreover, belonging can be viewed as a psychological need (Deci & Ryan, 2000), imparting meaning to life (Baumeister & Landau, 2018). The phenomenon

of trust also illustrates this overlap, with trust being both a value and a social emotion that helps social bonds develop (Fan & Zietsma, 2017).

Future Research

Viewing belonging as an emotion, value, psychological need, and a vital ingredient for constituting meaning in people's lives, we believe that future research may benefit from deeper investigations into the relationship between emotions and values as well as its connections to concepts such as purpose and meaning. Specifically, it would be interesting to learn how the concepts of emotions and values are distinct and how they overlap. While some empirical research on the link between values and emotions has been undertaken, the need to understand their points of intersection prevails (Vince, 2019). Future research may continue to address this gap, enabling the two streams of literature to interact further.

Supporting Cohen's (2022) idea that fostering belonging is essential and an urgent social mission, we recommend that scholars should further explore organizational conditions that may facilitate or inhibit belonging. Studies should investigate how organizations can cultivate the soil in which a sense of belonging can grow and how managers may facilitate this process.

Finally, there is a need to understand how belonging matters and, thus, to examine the impact and importance of belonging. Previous literature on organizational belonging has mostly focused on people at work, such as workers' belonging to an organization (Filstad et al., 2019) and feelings of belongingness among employees (Herbert, 2022; Løvaas, 2020). It is important to examine the role organizations may play in organizing for belonging, securing people's well-being, and improving people's lives within the communities in which these organizations operate (Creed et al., 2022). Lastly, we call for studies that explore the tensions and critical aspects of belonging. In this study, we detected tensions during collaboration between volunteers and employees when organizing for belonging, particularly in how they perceived their roles and responsibilities. Given that belonging is related to inclusion (Bryer, 2020), it is worthwhile to examine whether a high degree of belonging possibly could lead to exclusion of others.

Concluding Remarks

This chapter investigates how organizational actors organize for belonging and explains how emotions and values play a role in these institutional processes. The findings indicate the role of emotions as triggers driving belonging-seeking actions and foregrounds how actions of inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing play a role in fostering belonging among the volunteers of the religious organization and for the communities in which people live their lives. Further, the organizational features facilitating these collective actions are identified as organizational flexibility, organizational spaces, and the relational fabric of the organization.

The study illustrates how emotions trigger behaviors aimed at seeking belonging. The first vignette shows how an individual was motivated by feelings of darkness to join a religious organization and ultimately became a volunteer, with the organization's flexibility playing a key role in recognizing her potential. The second vignette highlights how organizational members were inspired to act, making the Homeless Project significant for both volunteers and those in need within the community. Together, these cases emphasize the significance of emotions in driving actions that foster belonging. Further, and within the organization's broader narrative, the sense of belonging is framed as a deeper connection to God.

Further, the study underscores that belonging is fundamental, serving as both a value and an experienced emotion in addition to being a human need. The chapter exemplifies how emotions and values influence the process of fostering belonging. The two cases illustrate how emotions can initiate belonging-seeking behaviors, and how everyday actions of inquiring, valuing, trusting, empowering, and we-ing are fostering a sense of belonging and purpose, and ultimately contributing to a thriving humanity.

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19

“What Are We Doing? This Is So Wrong!”—The Role of Emotions and Values in Institutional Innovation

Dag-Håkon Eriksen and Beate Jelstad Løvaas

Introduction

How do emotions and values influence institutional innovation? Innovation can be understood as new ideas that are invented, developed, and implemented (Garud et al., 2013). Innovation may take the form of new products and services, but it may also refer to new ways of organizing, new structures, new mindsets, new practices, and processes in organizations that disrupt institutional arrangements (Cajaiba-Santana, 2014; Nilsson, 2019). Such profound change that disrupts the cognitive, normative, or regulative elements of an organizational field is called *institutional innovation* (Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015).

The term combines two colliding social forces; institutions represent the stability of social systems, and innovation disrupts that established order. Although institutional innovation may appear to be a contradiction in terms, institutions, despite their durability, do change over time and circumstances. These processes have been explained through the four variants of institutional theory: normative institutional theory, social construction, culturally embedded institutional theory, and the bundling of logics and practices

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(Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015). However, the role of emotions in such core institutional processes has received little attention (Zietsma et al., 2019).

Although *emotions* shape the lives and actions of institutional actors, until recently, they have been ignored in organizational theory and the literature on organizations (Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018). The emotions-in-institutions perspective takes into account the fact that people are engaged based on emotions and do not act only through thinking and understanding (Creed et al., 2022). Such research brings emotions to the fore and acknowledges emotions as drivers triggering actions (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018; Vince, 2021). This chapter aims at contributing to the literature on the intersection of emotions and institutions, by empirically investigating how emotions are considered drivers triggering and sustaining processes of institutional innovation. By linking individual emotions to institutional innovation, we more specifically seek to explore dimensions underlying the emotional reactions of organizational actors that facilitate institutional innovation processes.

Further, *values* are central in organizations and play an important role in guiding action in an organizational context (Kraatz et al., 2020). The emerging literature on values related to innovation processes in organizations has adopted various approaches (Eriksen, 2025a). A recent stream theorizing *values work* (Askeland et al., 2020) emphasizes a practice perspective on values indicates how group reflection practices, as a form of values work, nurture the development and implementation of new practices (Eriksen & Løvaas, 2024; Espedal & Løvaas, 2022). Values work includes “reflection-creating processes” (Espedal, 2019). This chapter situates the perspective of values work by investigating how group reflection practices affect institutional innovation, with group reflection serving as an example of how values work is performed. Designing spaces so that organizational members feel safe to reflect and share their opinions and concerns may challenge the existing structures and practices in organizations (Cartel et al., 2018; Creed et al., 2022) and thus facilitate institutional innovation. However, these spaces cannot, on their own, explain the emergence of new practices (Lee et al., 2020, p. 99). As such, further investigations of how values work, in the form of group reflection, contributes to institutional innovation processes will be performed in this chapter.

Thus, the aim of this chapter is to obtain a deeper understanding of the role emotions and values work play for institutional innovation, and the research question guiding this chapter is as follows: *How do emotions and values work influence institutional innovation?* The study investigates how emotional reactions trigger actions of group reflection practices (values work) and, furthermore, how group reflection in safe spaces affects the emergence

of institutional innovation and the sustaining of institutional innovation. The underlying conditions affecting institutional innovation processes are also explored. These conditions are identified at the micro, meso, and macro levels and as making institutional innovation processes more or less facilitative.

To investigate how emotions and values influence institutional innovation, two global faith-based organizations (FBOs) called Serikat and Muungano were selected as salient cases because they have implemented a variety of institutional innovations, such as new structures for decision-making processes, procedures, and mindsets. Driven by their values, they disrupted established power asymmetries, re-invented their organizational arrangements, and established new ways of organizing for equal collaboration across the so-called Global North and Global South divide. In this chapter, we investigate both the emergence of these institutional innovations and the ongoing innovation processes.

FBOs are characterized by their values, traditions, and faith-based identities and are thus rich cases that can extend our understanding on how emotions and values influence institutional innovation processes. Furthermore, FBOs are under-represented contexts in organizational studies and often overlooked when studying institutional processes (Fulton, 2020; Tracey et al., 2014). Although a contextualized study of two faith-based organizations is providing insights into a unique empirical setting, it may allow us to reach a degree of conceptually generalizable insights about the role values and emotions play for institutional innovation and organizational life in general (Hoholm & Araujo, 2011).

Based on a case study of two global FBOs with extensive experience with institutional innovation processes, a process model of institutional innovation is developed that illustrates how emotions and values work contribute to initiating and sustaining innovation. In this way, the current study expands our understanding of the role played by emotions and values for institutional innovation processes and contributes to the institutional literature on innovation. Furthermore, this chapter contributes to the ongoing exploration of how emotions and values are intertwined in organizations and thus contributes to the emerging literature on the interconnectedness of emotions, values, and institutions.

Theoretical Perspectives

This study of how emotions and values influence institutional innovation draws on two broad areas of the literature: Emotions and values in institutions. These areas have largely been seen through separate streams, as pointed out by Pena and Toubiana (see Chapter 2 in this handbook). Institutional innovation is defined as novel, useful, and legitimate changes that disrupt the cognitive, normative, or regulative pillars of organizations (Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015). Institutional innovation resembles organizational innovation in that it is both novel and useful to the adopting actor, but Raffaelli and Glynn (2015) suggest that institutional innovation must also be accepted as legitimate within its institutional environment.

Emotions and Institutional Innovation

Emotions can be conceptualized through various lenses, from universal and fixed perspectives, on one hand, to a constructivist perspective, on the other, which contends that emotions emerge through a process of psychological construction. Socially functional emotions, such as embarrassment, shame, anger, gratitude, and love, communicate internal states to others and guide interpersonal interactions (e.g., Van Kleef, 2014). This cross-cultural study acknowledges and draws on both approaches by viewing emotions as social and intersubjective constructions (Fineman, 2007) and acknowledging that emotional experiences are not entirely culturally determined (Tsai et al., 2006). To contribute to a better understanding of the emotional underpinnings of institutional practice in cross-cultural and global organizations, in this chapter, we pay particular attention to the categories of emotions that are linked to culture, cognition, and moral reflection. Moral emotions include shame, for example (Creed et al., 2014; Moisander et al., 2016). Emotions are recognized as a driving force underpinning institutional processes, with private feelings and public displays of emotions being recognized as constitutive elements of these processes (Moisander et al., 2016).

Institutional innovation is a multifaceted process influenced by various factors, including emotions. Purposefully utilizing emotions can effectively stimulate institutional innovation by creating novel opportunities (Cartel et al., 2018). Furthermore, research has indicated that emotions play a crucial role in the implementation of innovation (Choi et al., 2010). Emotions can significantly impact how individuals perceive and respond to innovations,

underscoring the importance of considering emotional processes in organizational innovation endeavors. While scholars of organizational behavior have treated emotions mostly as an individual-level phenomenon, such as considering how emotions impact people's attitudes and actions, recent research on emotions in organizations links them to core organizational processes, such as organizational learning and change and thus, place emotions at the core of organizing (Zhang et al., 2024). This chapter provides an empirical example of linking emotions to organizational processes by investigating the role of emotions in institutional innovation. While the previous literature acknowledges emotions as triggers (Vince, 2021; Ruebottom & Auster, 2018), our study highlights specific emotional experiences, such as the shame and discomfort arising from hierarchical dynamics, that uniquely motivate actors to re-evaluate entrenched practices and stimulate creative disruption.

Although emotions are a significant component of organizational life, the role of reflexivity in the emotional domain has received little attention. Reflexivity can be understood as an awareness of and the ability to pause and observe one's own experiences, routines, and practices; reflect on and question them; and decide accordingly (Cova & Farnese, 2025). This recent review indicates that reflexivity affects emotions and that emotions, in turn, can trigger reflexivity. Thus, the role of reflexivity, which is considered both an antecedent and outcome of the emotions contributing to institutional innovation, is explored in this chapter, contributing to the emerging literature on the interconnectedness of emotions, values, and institutions.

Values Work and Institutional Innovation

Values work both presupposes and increases reflexivity, and reflection in groups is an effective form of values work (Eriksen, 2025a, Eriksen & Løvaas 2024; Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). Reflexivity is a prerequisite for institutional innovation, as changing habits requires people to discover new perspectives on themselves and current arrangements and new ways of doing things to address them (Golden-Biddle, 2020). Several authors have argued that reflexivity (Fook & Askeland, 2007; Schön, 1991; Suddaby et al., 2016; Aadland, 2010), institutional distance (Phillips, 2014), and diverse and conflicting perspectives (van Wijk et al., 2019) are required to become aware of the conventions that guide organizational life.

Reflexivity is considered a source to promote innovation in organizations, although the evidence for its influence in this regard is limited (Farnese et al., 2016). Critical reflection may increase awareness. This may enable participants to reorient their prevailing habits, which is key to institutional

innovation. Increased reflexivity and collective learning enable institutional innovation (Schippers et al., 2012; van Wijk et al., 2019), in which institutional dis-embedding is regarded as an essential component (Greenwood & Suddaby, 2006; Suddaby et al., 2016). However, the mechanisms underpinning the way in which reflexivity is generated are not well understood (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018).

Values serve as a moral compass that guides motivation and informs action (Kraatz et al., 2020). Values animate people to take action by providing direction, meaning, and purpose. By signifying what is desirable, values guide the choice of an action and thus play a significant role in linking individuals to institutions. To inform our study on institutional innovation processes, we draw on a recent stream of values work that emphasizes a practice perspective on values. Values work (Gehman et al., 2013) consists of relational and distributed efforts articulating what is right or wrong, or good or bad, in the design and operation of an organization. Values work enhances the continuing knowledge and reflection-creating processes that infuse an organization with value-related actions (Espedal, 2019) and connect everyday practices with the organizational purpose. It is linked with the goals that guide and evaluate organizational practices (Askeland et al., 2020). Castellazzi and Bellini (2022) highlight the dynamic nature of values, particularly their openness to reinterpretation and ability to evolve over time. According to Bourne and Jenkins (2013), values are both enduring and capable of change, while Breuer et al. (2022), underscore the role of values in innovation management.

Spaces in which group reflection practices take place cannot on their own explain the emergence of new practices and institutional innovation. Significant diversity among the individuals engaged in group reflection practices seems to benefit institutional innovation, as different worlds of concerns and logics meet, create awareness of the constructed nature of current arrangements, and enable innovation by legitimizing different templates and alternatives to the existing ones (Micelotta et al., 2021). Values work through fruitful value inquiry involves reflecting on real situations, allowing the questioning of previous practices and involving people in co-defining what is needed and sustained experimental action (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024; Kogen, 2019; Savaya & Gardner, 2012). A process of organizational value inquiry that is discovery-oriented, situated, and enduring may, in turn, feed further value inquiry (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024; Aadland, 2010). Previous studies of values work, such as studies of group reflection in safe spaces, show how these reflection practices affect the emergence of new and innovative practices in organizations (Espedal & Løvaas, 2022; Løvaas & Espedal, 2023;

Løvaas & Vråle, 2020). However, values work may prevent or drive organizational innovation, as changes at the institutional level may prescribe or proscribe organizational templates, thus regulating what legitimate organizational innovations can look like (Micelotta et al., 2021). Thus, when psychological safety is experienced, safe spaces for participatory values inquiry given significant diversity among the individuals involved in practices may serve as an engine for continuous innovation in organizations (Eriksen, 2025a, Eriksen & Løvaas 2024). Thus, values and emotions seem to be fundamental to institutional innovation processes.

The Relationship Between Emotions and Values Work

The relationship between emotions and values has received little attention in the field of organizations. Emotions have a connection to values, which are understood as things “worth having, doing and being” (Kraatz et al., 2020). Emotions can provide valuable information about the values at stake in a situation. Emotions may function as alarms, signaling that important values are under threat (Løvaas & Vråle, 2020). This may be manifested in an awareness of one’s own emotions, and thus, values are made meaningful through emotions.

One way of strengthening awareness of and inquiries into emotions is the practice of reflection in safe spaces, in which individual actors “dare to share.” A safe space is reinforced when sharing vulnerability with trusted others; it is regarded as a space in which organizational actors can “take off the mask” (Brown, 2012, cited in Corlett et al., 2021), supporting the emergence of new practices and nurturing innovation in organizations. This chapter and its research question also indicate the interconnectedness between emotions and values and the role reflexivity plays in this interconnectedness.

Research Context and Methods

To investigate how emotions and values work contribute to institutional innovation, two global FBOs with extensive experience with institutional innovation processes were chosen for this collective case study (Stake, 2003). By exploring the dynamics and processes of two organizations, each case can illuminate the interpretation of these dynamics in the other (Halдар & Wærdahl, 2009), leading to a deeper understanding than a single case study could provide (Chmiliar, 2010). The case organizations, named Serikat and Muungano, operate within the overlapping fields of World Christianity and

international development. Within the context of World Christianity, a demographic shift to the Global South has been observed (Zurlo et al., 2020). However, global collaborations in the field are still largely conducted using the classic star-like structure derived from the historical Western missionary movement, with FBOs in the Global North and West supporting FBOs in the Global South and East through bilateral relationships (Biehl, 2016). Although it is broadly understood that there is a critical need to counter asymmetrical power dynamics, major changes are not being implemented on a large scale (Kurlberg & Hoksbergem, 2023). Within the field of international development, there is also a need for change in power relations (Eikenberry et al., 2023). Serikat and Muungano have navigated this complex and changing context and performed a variety of institutional innovations, such as re-inventing themselves with new mindsets, relationships, power structures, and procedures, as described below.

Muungano provides relevant resources for church-related activities and literacy work. It originated in North America in the 1940s and expanded globally as a centralized, hierarchical, Western-led organization; its head office in the Global North directed a variety of country offices, partners, and affiliates. Within this international structure, only certain founding organizations had voting rights; other, younger affiliated organizations from Africa, the Asia-Pacific region, and Latin America had no such rights. One quite radical institutional innovation performed by Muungano was its re-invention from a centralized Western hierarchy to a polyphonic, polycentric global alliance of over 100 locally embedded, self-governing organizations with an equal voice and vote that are united by renewed values, visions, and community relationships. Muungano is now led to be a decentralized Alliance Leadership Team (ALT) with representatives from all parts of the globe.

Serikat pursues a holistic mission of advocacy, development, diaconia (Christian social practice), and evangelism. Serikat dates to the early nineteenth century, and by implementing institutional innovations, it has transformed itself from a classic star-like structure, with European FBOs supporting their partners in Africa and Asia, to a communion of around 40 churches, with the former receiving partners becoming full members in and owners of the organization. These institutional innovations included a new constitution that provided all members with an equal voice and vote and gave African and Asian member organizations the majority in both the General Assembly and the international council, which makes decisions on key issues such as policy, strategy, and budget. This was quite radical, as financial resources mostly came from Europe. Recently, Serikat has seen growth in terms of financial contributions from their African and Asian

members, which they interpreted as a sign of progress and moving away from a donor-and-recipient mentality. One telling example of this new mindset is when Germany was flooded in the summer of 2021; African and Asian Serikat members raised funds to support the flood victims in Europe. In sum, to investigate the role of emotions and values in institutional innovation, we studied Serikat and Muungano, which have extensive experience in performing a variety of radical institutional innovations.

Data Collection and Analysis

Multiple sources of data from the two organizations were chosen. The analyses were based on 25 interviews, 53 hours of observation, 20 hours of participatory reflection in focus groups, and 2400 pages of documents. The first author digitally conducted research interviews with employees and leaders in various roles and from various levels of the organizations. The interviewer adopted a semi-structured and open-ended strategy (Espedal, 2022) during the COVID-19 pandemic. He asked the respondents to describe the ongoing innovation process, including any major milestones, incidents, or actors. He asked what began the process and why it started; what its effects were; what drove, enabled, or hindered it; and how they worked to make it happen. The author also asked them about their personal experiences. The interviewees varied in terms of gender, nationality, and organizational role; they came from 16 countries across five continents, thus providing rich material. The first author also performed 53 hours of digital participatory observations of online meetings and courses and completed a 20-hour collaborative process involving critical reflection on values and organizational practices over a period of four months at one of the case organizations, as described by Eriksen and Strumińska-Kutra (2022). We anonymized both the organizations and informants. The various data collection methods yielded in total more than 3000 pages of transcribed interviews, field notes, and organizational documents. The first author transcribed the data and initially coded the material and identified the parts that were relevant to this study. Both authors proceeded independently, first by noting interesting and important aspects of the transcript (discussed in analysis meeting 1), second by developing the initial coding and categories for the data (discussed in analysis meeting 2), and third by developing the themes and investigating how these themes were connected (analysis meetings 3, 4, and 5), ultimately creating the process model shown in Fig. 19.1.

Findings

Based on empirical investigation, this study reveals a process beginning with emotional reactions on the part of individual actors, which activate organizational practices of values work. These, in turn, contribute to stimulating and sustaining institutional innovation. The process model of how emotions and values work facilitate institutional innovation is shown in Fig. 19.1.

In the following, we outline and explain the model, including the factors affecting the process, and provide illustrative quotes derived from the data material. We begin by investigating the emotional reactions triggering actions, asking how these emotions came to be felt? After highlighting the macro-level characteristics of contextual changes in the field, we highlight meso-level characteristics, such as storytelling, and micro-level features in the form of formative cross-cultural experiences contributing to emotional reactions.

Emotional Reactions of Organizational Actors

The emotional reactions of organizational members became triggers for institutional innovation efforts, such as efforts to create new power structures in which all members would have an equal voice or vote. The findings of this study indicate the role of emotions as a starting point for institutional innovation (i.e., individuals were ashamed of current practices). One incident many informants in Muungano referred to concerns the emotional reactions

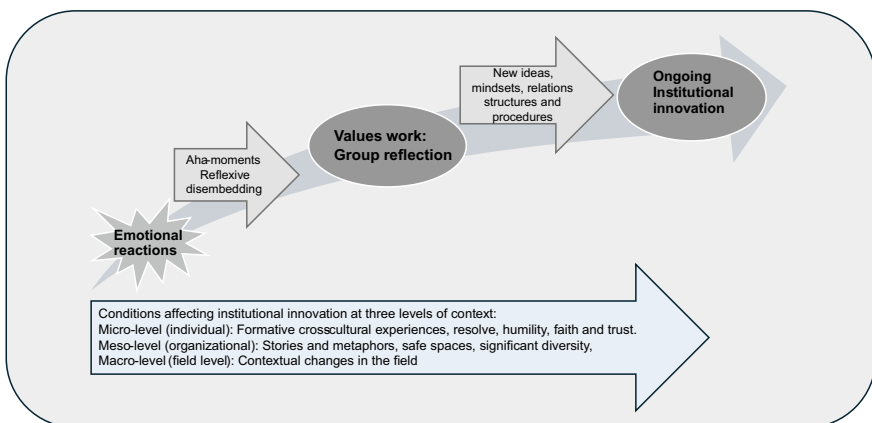


Fig. 19.1 Process model of how emotions and values work facilitate institutional innovation

of feeling embarrassed and ashamed due to practices of inequality in the organization. The informants refer to a global gathering of national organizations from both the Global North and the Global South. Representatives from organizations from the Global South were invited to join the gathering, but they had to sit in the back of the conference room, merely listening to the representatives from the Global North discussing and voting on important issues. Many participants from both the Global North and the Global South noticed this. When they experienced how this dynamic unfolded in the room, they reacted emotionally to this practice, which they perceived to be contrary to their value of equality. Many felt embarrassed and ashamed of this situation, and they decided to do something about it. The quotes provided below show how emotional reactions triggered institutional innovation efforts:

It felt very uncomfortable because here we are saying we're going to go in partnership, and this is where God is leading us. But we invite people, and they don't have a voice or vote. And to some that were in leadership, it felt it was like an eye opener, like, *what are we doing? This is so wrong!* And, and so from there, there was about four about five years that took to fix that organizational problem is like we can't have categories because some people feel more than others. How do we make sure that everybody is equal at the table? – Regional director, The Americas

Regarding the question of how emotions came to be felt, via the analysis, we found that the emotional reactions were conditioned by factors operating on the macro, meso, and micro levels. On the macro level, *contextual changes* transformed the field in which Serikat and Muungano operate. These changes affected the organizational actors in Muungano and Serikat by causing them to realize that their understandings of themselves, their mission, and how they organize had to change as well:

Part of this journey was the growing awareness of the shifting balances of power in the world and also the growth of the global church. In this more polycentric understanding of not only mission but the church itself, there is a desire to have those changes reflected in the actual structures of the alliance. – Member of Alliance Leadership Team (ALT), Muungano

Contextual changes in the field led to a growing critique of asymmetric power dynamics raising the awareness of current institutional arrangements among organizational actors. Thus, contextual changes in the field seem to play a role in shaping emotional reactions. In addition to the macro-level conditions, micro-level and meso-level conditions are also identified as

factors affecting why certain emotions came to be felt. As such, formative *cross-cultural experiences*, at the micro level, and the power of *storytelling* in organizations, at the meso level, are described below.

The emotional reactions described above can be understood in light of personal experiences in cross-cultural contexts. When analyzing the material, it became clear that many of the organizational actors that reported emotional reactions previously had formative personal experiences in cross-cultural settings.

In Papua New Guinea, where I grew up, I was always disturbed, as a young person, with how Papua New Guineans were being treated by the foreign missionaries. They were not being treated as equal. They're not respected like they should have been... So that would be a contributing factor. – Former member of ALT, Muungano.

The German theologian and missionary, who was born in Africa, had a decisive influence on this process. As the first director of Serikat, he contributed decisively to the further development of the outdated Europe-centered understanding of mission into an international ecumenical community with equal rights. Organizational documents, Serikat.

In line with the quotes above, organizational actors with formative personal experiences in cross-cultural settings were able to adopt a critical stance toward current arrangements, which most others tended to consider natural and taken for granted. Based on our analysis, it seems that such cross-cultural experiences facilitate Aha moments, which sparked reflexivity and made institutional dis-embedding possible. These cross-cultural experiences were resources that allowed the respondents to see things they otherwise would not have noticed, which caused emotional reactions.

At the meso level, we identified another factor that affected the emotional reactions and shaped the innovation process. This was telling well-known stories and using metaphors. In profound ways, these stories seemed to shape emotions and convey values that triggered institutional innovation. For example, the first Asian general secretary in Serikat told everyone a story from his time as a student while on a scholarship in Europe. His trousers had become worn, but to get some support to buy new ones, he had to “somehow kneel and show them (the board) where, at the bottom, his trousers was shiny and that it was true that he needed new ones. And this story of the trousers, everybody knows it here who has ever met him because he has told it to everybody!”—Regional Director, Europe.

This story was retold by others in Serikat, who used it to explain how the relationship between partners in the Global North and Global South once

were. The story aroused feelings of shame over past practices and underscored the need for profound shifts in the institutional arrangements used to align organizational practices with the value of equality.

In Muungano, many referred to the example above regarding how new organizations from the Global South were invited into partnership but did not have voting rights. At the global meeting, they had to sit in the back and watch as older member organizations from the Global North cast their ballots. People felt that this was so wrong, and it triggered emotional reactions to current institutional arrangements. Metaphors were also used to convey values and evoke emotional reactions, as illustrated in this quote:

And this one guy spoke up and said, you know, it's like before we were, you know, on the side of the road, and we see this sports car go zooming by, and we're still waiting for the bus.' And he was comparing the large Western organizations to their organizations. He said, 'Now, it's like we're all on the bus together. – Member of ALT, Muungano.

The quotes above illustrate how storytelling and metaphors can affect emotions and generate reflexivity, which allows the actors to challenge current practices and, in turn, facilitate institutional innovation. The emotional reactions indicate that values were violated, and this provides emotional energy, which, in turn, triggers innovative efforts to change a practice seen as violating organizational values.

In sum we identified the conditions shaping the emotional reactions on the micro level (cross-cultural experiences), the meso level (the use of storytelling and metaphors), and macro level (contextual changes in the field), contributing to emotional reactions that produced Aha-moments, reflexivity, and institutional dis-embedding, which made the respondents realize that the current institutional arrangements were wrong and had to be transformed. This emotional energy was channeled into values work in the form of group reflection, which produced institutional innovation, as described in the following.

Values Work: Group Reflection Given Significant Diversity in Safe Spaces

How can emotional reactions contribute to institutional innovation? Emotional reactions triggered the innovation process by channeling emotional energy into constructive actions of group reflections practices (values work), which fueled the innovation process.

Aha moments sparked reflexivity and made dis-embedding possible given formative cross-cultural experiences and storytelling. When current practices were challenged and they did not know how to proceed, the emotional reactions of organizational actors moved the process forward, specifically toward practices of group reflection.

How, then, could group reflection practices enable institutional innovation? The factors affecting these practices have been identified: the presence of *safe spaces* and *significant diversity* among the participants in group reflection seem to affect the innovation process. When people feel safe to voice concerns or feelings of being inferior, this influences the process of institutional innovation. From the interviews, organizational documents, and participatory observation, it was clear that participatory reflection in safe spaces given significant diversity among the participants in the group reflection practices had been like an engine driving institutional innovation, as illustrated in the following:

The changes came out of these experiences and reflections and sharing and consulting between people from different backgrounds... So, definitely, these reflections inform our practice because they shape our thinking. – Member of the Global Board, Muungano

Reflection across significant diversity in the groups contributed to a variety of perspectives, and this was the most significant part of the values work driving the innovation process. Both Serikat and Muungano intentionally invited people from a diverse set of backgrounds regarding geography, ethnicity, and organizational roles. They took great care in facilitating safe spaces for these diverse voices. We found strongly rooted values, including a belief in the equal dignity of every human being, undergirding this intentional effort to welcome and widen the space for different voices to feed into the conversation:

Begin with some reflection on the image of God. And, then, move to reflection on the mission of God. And the reason I'm saying these two things is that I think it's important for us to realize that our creation in the image of God is so significant because it means that, it is the basis for the equal dignity of every human being, and that needs to be our starting point in our perception of other people. We, as believers, we are all equally called to participate in what God is doing in the world. – Member of ALT, Muungano

It was also evident that even if deeply rooted values were undergirding the exchange among significantly diverse participants and driving the institutional innovation, discomfort still arose when these values required changes in mindset:

Yeah, in the beginning, sometimes, yeah, honestly, [it was] not so comfortable. [It is] not so comfortable when, when we have to live in a different way to receive one another, to receive diversity. Because, you know, or to change something, sometimes, also [is] not so easy. So, if you learn together, if we are willing to do that, it means we have to really change our mindset. To me, it is [important] to be open, to change and open one's mindset. It's also challenging for me because sometimes, I have become very comfortable with my old mindset. Regional representative, Indonesia, Serikat.

During the participatory observation, we saw how the respondents made sure to include as many voices as possible, both during the sessions and in what is reported in the common notetaking. This included allowing a few minutes for the participants in the groups to think and reflect on their own before the group conversation began. The respondents typically asked the non-English speakers to begin the conversation. This is confirmed by the non-English speakers who expressed the following:

We feel equal because we have right to give our opinion and we are heard. People listen to us, and that is a good experience. – National director, South America, Muungano.

However, interestingly, some described how these efforts to provide room for one another and respect various opinions could sometimes hinder disagreement and a frank exchange of opinions:

Due to the value of respecting each other and what the other brings to the table, we sometimes miss the opportunity to disagree. We need to address this in our collaboration. It will not always be smooth sailing. If trust is there, we can overcome difficulties and disagreements. – Member of ALT, Muungano.

Psychological safety and emotional maturity enabled organizational actors to be humble, self-critical, and self-reflective; acknowledge their own mistakes and misunderstandings; and show vulnerability, which fostered new thoughts and innovation, by being open to questioning previous methods, turning away from the old ways, and learning.

[It is] a kind of relentless insistence on not just doing but having a posture of the cycle of doing and reflecting and growing and in critical self-awareness and self-reflection as leaders, which brings with it a kind of vulnerability that is unique. So, the leader who is willing to say we don't have the answer to that, we need to take some time to reflect on that [is important]. – Member of ALT, Muungano

The institutional innovation in Serikat and Muungano runs deep and touches long-held emotional sentiments, and the informants reported it was difficult to press on and make this institutional innovation happen. It required resolve and emotional stamina:

And, and so we, we had to stick to our guns, and to be honest, it was very, very difficult. [In] 2002–2004, things started to shift, but many, many of us on the board or individual directors, we were really struggling to get heard. And the more we saw that, the more convinced we were. The structure was so hierarchical, so centralized. – Former member of ALT, Muungano.

To sum up, values work in the form of collaborative reflection on values and practices given significant diversity in safe places was central to institutional innovation. Intentionally facilitating safe spaces for diverse voices made participants from diverse backgrounds feel safe to voice their opinions. Feeling safe facilitated exploration and reflexivity, which drove institutional innovation. We found that conditions on the micro level (resolve and humility) and on the meso level (safe spaces and significant diversity) affected the group reflection practices and helped generate new ideas and mindsets, which led to decisions about new structures and procedures and, in turn, advanced ongoing institutional innovation.

Ongoing Institutional Innovation

In a changing context, specifically the gravitational shift in World Christianity from the Global North to the Global South, Serikat and Muungano were driven by their values of equality and engaged in values work, creating safe spaces for reflection on values and practices in diverse groups. This led to institutional innovations such as new mindsets, relationships, structures, decision-making processes, and procedures. These group reflection practices fueled further ongoing institutional innovation. Thus, emotions and values work not only contribute to institutional innovation but also play a decisive role in ongoing innovative processes, in which new institutional innovations take place, as described in the following.

The two organizations showed a surprising readiness for open-ended processes and continuous institutional innovation. This puzzled us, and during the analysis, we searched more deeply into the material to understand this better. What struck us were numerous quotes describing how the respondents' faith in God seemed to enable this high level of acceptance of open-ended institutional innovation. It seemed that the organizational actors' faith and trust was a micro-level condition supporting ongoing institutional innovation. We found many participants giving voice to their faith in God and relating this to emotional relief and trust in the idea that God is ultimately in control. It seems that this provided emotional stability and security, allowing them to accept open-ended and ongoing institutional innovation.

We can be actually quite relaxed in this. I would maybe be a bit more nervous if I was in a secular organization, but we truly believe that the spirit then comes into such a space and actually, I mean, generate in the process [...] I guess if I was a CEO of a Fortune 500 company, I could be a bit nervous about what comes out of it [...] but we don't have to be worried, because we don't believe that the organization is ours in the first place. – Member of ALT, Muungano.

Most of the participants mentioned their faith in God during the interviews. This was also evident in the organizational documents and field notes. Their faith seemed to play a decisive role in their deliberations and reflections regarding institutional innovation, as the quotes illustrate.

Discontinuous change is not new. God himself has used it to redirect His people throughout history. [...] It is a position that requires us to look beyond institutional structures and strategies to be obedient to God's call. Organizational documents, Muungano.

God's working in different ways and doing different things. We need, in a sense, to innovate, to be able to participate with God. – Member of ALT, Muungano.

The findings displayed in this chapter show how emotions and values work play significant roles in institutional innovation. Conditions on the micro, meso and macro levels that enable this process are identified. Emotional reactions indicated that values were violated by organizational practice. These emotional reactions triggered values work in terms of group reflections, which were integral to nurturing and sustaining institutional innovation, such as new mindsets, structures, and procedures. Faith and trust provided emotional stability during open-ended and ongoing institutional innovation.

Discussing the Role of Emotions and Values in Institutional Innovation

The empirical findings derived from our study of Serikat and Muungano offer insights into the role emotions and values work play in initiating and sustaining institutional innovation and what conditions that enable this on the micro, meso, and macro levels. These insights provide empirical grounding for an expansion of existing theoretical perspectives, emphasizing the dynamic and intertwined roles of emotions and values in driving institutional innovation.

In the following, we discuss how *emotional reactions* were facilitated by formative personal cross-cultural experiences and how *values work*, in terms of group reflection practices, was facilitated through significant diversity in safe spaces, leading to institutional innovation. Thereafter, we discuss the interconnectedness of emotions and values work through the role of reflexivity. Lastly, the role of faith in ongoing institutional innovation is discussed, and avenues for future research are presented.

Emotional Reactions as Triggers of Institutional Innovation

Empirical observations derived from Serikat and Muungano reveal that feelings of shame and discomfort related to inequality motivated organizational actors to challenge and reconsider entrenched practices and created the energy necessary for institutional disruption. Thus, the emotional reaction fueled an urgency to innovate, resonating with Fisher (2019) and Elfenbein (2023), who argue that emotional cues facilitate critical reflection and sense-making. Our study extends the understanding of emotions as catalysts for institutional innovation. While the previous literature acknowledges emotions as triggers (Vince, 2021; Ruebottom & Auster, 2018), our findings highlight specific emotional experiences, such as shame and discomfort arising from unequal hierarchical dynamics, that uniquely motivate actors to re-evaluate entrenched practices and engage in values work and creative disruption. This nuanced exploration of emotions offers deep insights into how emotional discomfort can serve as a powerful force for initiating the reflexive processes and dis-embedding necessary to challenge the status quo within institutional contexts, leading to institutional innovation.

The role of cross-cultural experiences emerged as a significant theme and condition for emotional reactions, reflexivity, and critical engagement with taken-for-granted institutional norms and practices, which expands the

existing literature. The role of cross-cultural experiences reveals existing institutional complexity, which provides an opportunity for innovators to see beyond the dominant logic that characterizes their field (Phillips, 2014), thus creating the necessary awareness of the social constructedness of their situations (Suddaby et al., 2016) and the possibility of constructing another alternative future. This awareness is central to reflexivity, which enables institutional innovation. On the micro level, formative experiences in cross-cultural settings produced emotional reactions to current institutional arrangements, which provoked institutional dis-embedding. The role of cross-cultural experiences expands the theoretical insights of Van Wijk et al. (2019), demonstrating how personal narratives contribute to institutional dis-embedding and reflexivity. The role of cross-cultural experiences, on the micro level, enriches the innovation efforts on the meso level as well by increasing reflexivity and collective learning, which enable institutional innovation (Van Wijk et al., 2019). The role of cross-cultural experiences demonstrates how these experiences contribute to emotional reactions and dis-embedding and, thus, underscores the importance of diversity and perspective-taking for institutional innovation.

Values Work: Group Reflection in Safe Spaces

Reflection processes were part of the values work considered in this study, and they were enacted through group reflections in safe spaces. This proved to be a significant element of nurturing institutional innovation. The respondents' values, such as equal dignity and participation, catalyzed efforts to foster open dialogue and helped create psychological safety, driving the innovation process and supporting reflexivity as a collective endeavor. This aligns with recent scholarship on values work that underscores its role in challenging existing practices and fostering new organizational arrangements (Espedal & Løvaas, 2022; Espedal & Carlsen 2024, Eriksen & Løvaas, 2024). The creation of psychologically safe environments enabled participants to engage in deep reflexivity and collaborative dialogues, driving reflexive awareness and critical evaluation of established norms. The creation of safe spaces for dialogue and reflection supports van Wijk et al.'s (2019) view on the importance of interactive environments for sustaining social innovations.

Designing spaces so that organizational members feel safe to share their opinions and concerns may challenge the existing structures and practices in organizations (Cartel, 2018, Creed et al., 2022) and thus facilitate institutional innovation. As institutional innovation was largely driven by participatory reflection in safe spaces, it is paramount to design safe spaces

so that participants feel accepted and safe in sharing their opinions and challenging existing structures and practices. When psychological safety is experienced, safe spaces for participatory values inquiry, given significant diversity, may serve as an engine for institutional innovation in organizations. Safe spaces may also allow vulnerability. The finding that vulnerability acts as a facilitator of innovation challenges traditional leadership theories that prioritize strength and decisiveness.

Interconnection Between Emotions and Values—The Role of Reflexivity

The link between emotions and values work is described in this chapter, beginning with emotional reactions that constitute institutional reflection practices (values work) and thus indicating how emotions and values work are related. More specifically, the study indicates how emotions, at the individual level, play a role in values work at the institutional level. Thus, this chapter expands our understanding of how emotions and values are related by investigating how emotions and values at different levels (the micro and meso levels) are intertwined and thus contribute to the ongoing exploration of how emotions and values are related and contribute to institutional innovation.

Furthermore, emotions may serve as alarms, signaling that values are under threat, thereby motivating actors to engage in values work. The findings reveal this interplay, as emotional signals indicate values violations, prompting values work and innovation. This interplay underscores the importance of considering both emotions and values as integral components of the institutional innovation process (Kraatz et al., 2020). Furthermore, the intertwined nature of emotions and values suggest that they are mutually constitutive in institutional contexts (Friedland, 2014). Kraatz et al. (2020) propose that understanding this interplay is crucial to comprehending the collective impact of emotions and values on institutional change. This study offers an empirical argument emphasizing the fact that when emotions align with values, they can amplify one another.

A nuanced way of understanding the interconnectedness between emotions and values work involves the role of reflexivity as an antecedent and outcome of emotion as well as an antecedent and outcome of values work, as described below. Reflexivity, in terms of interacting with others, such as the storytelling practices and metaphors described, was identified as shaping the emotions of individual actors. These reflexive actions and interactions promoted feelings of embarrassment and shame. In this way, reflexivity seems to trigger emotions. Emotions, in turn, can trigger reflexivity. This is

illustrated by the way in which the emotional reactions stimulated creative disruption (Aha moments), providing awareness and reflexivity regarding the current institutional arrangements (dis-embedding), which were necessary for institutional innovation (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). In sum, reflexivity is considered both an antecedent and outcome of emotions, in line with recent research (Cova & Farnese, 2025).

Furthermore, reflexivity is also considered an antecedent and outcome of values work. Aha moments and reflexive dis-embedding led to group reflection practices (values work); this is an example of reflexivity leading to values work. In this way, reflexivity seems to trigger values work. Lastly and conversely, values work (group reflection) increases reflexivity, which can explain that group reflection practices in which organizational actors interact and reflect together seem to enhance reflexivity. This suggests that reflexivity or the ability to see opportunities for change is a result of the group reflection practices (values work), in line with Suddaby et al. (2016). Based on the descriptions above, this chapter expands our understanding of how emotions and values are interconnected by highlighting the role of reflexivity as an antecedent and outcome of emotions and values work. Additionally, reflexivity is, in turn, shown to affect institutional innovation.

The Role of Faith in Ongoing Institutional Innovation

In order to spur ongoing innovation, organizations can enhance their innovative capabilities, generating innovation regarding products, services, business models, and management systems (Eriksen, 2025a, 2025b; Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015; Sørensen & Torfing, 2022). However, the previous literature on ongoing innovation has highlighted the challenges involved in sustaining innovative capabilities amid organizational inertia (Dover & Lawrence, 2012), acknowledging that even if organizational processes, routines, and methods are important, they are “probably not sufficient to maintain innovation capabilities dynamically over time,” as they are expected to “stabilize into inflexible and self-referencing procedures over time” (Strønen et al., 2017, p. 108).

A somewhat surprising finding of this study, one that goes beyond those in the existing literature on institutional innovation, was the role faith played in providing emotional resilience and readiness for open-ended innovation. Trusting in an authority beyond themselves made individuals commit to the process, knowing that they wanted to move on from the existing situation but not knowing where to go or the end state and trusting in God to direct

them step by step. Thus, faith seemed to play a crucial role in ongoing institutional innovation countering organizational inertia. Participants' spiritual beliefs appeared to underpin their emotional stability, enabling them to navigate institutional changes with trust and security. This insight adds a novel dimension to the discussion of emotion and values in organizational contexts, suggesting that faith may enhance adaptability and openness to ongoing institution innovation. This finding challenges existing theories by suggesting additional motivators for innovation that are rooted in spiritual and theological belief that could possibly be activated to sustain ongoing innovation amid organizational inertia.

Pathways for Future Research

Based on this study, several promising pathways for future research have emerged. The role of faith in institutional innovation is an underexplored topic that deserves closer investigation, as argued above. Future research could explore the triadic relationship between emotions, values, and faith, particularly the intersection of spirituality and sustained institutional innovation. Based on this, FBOs emerge as a promising and underexplored context for the further exploration of institutional innovation.

The finding that vulnerability acts as a facilitator of innovation challenges traditional leadership theories that prioritize strength and decisiveness. This invites the further exploration of how humility and vulnerability can be assets, rather than liabilities, in organizational settings in general and for institutional innovation specifically. Furthermore, the discourse on values, emotions, and innovation has a built-in Western positivity bias, which may also have influenced the current study. Despite some critical contributions (Rehn & Örténblad, 2023; Seelos & Mair, 2012), there is still a need to explore the dark side of values and emotions in institutional innovation.

Similarly, there is a need to explore and elaborate on the ethical factors affecting responsible innovation. This indicates the need to explore the role of reflexivity and reflexive leadership in institutional innovation because what is considered ethical and responsible is socially constructed (Lawrence et al., 2014; Micelotta et al., 2021). A related avenue for future research is to investigate the multifaceted role of reflexivity as an antecedent and outcome of institutional innovation, especially in the face of organizational routinization and inertia.

Another related avenue for further research is to explore the role of personal values and individual biographies of institutional entrepreneurs. What kind of personal formative experiences have prepared and enabled them

to critically engage with their institutional setting with the aim of disruption and innovation? This could be a new way to shed light on the paradox of embedded agency and institutional entrepreneurship. In this study, reflection in safe spaces, given significant diversity, emerged as a key driver of institutional innovation. This implies that people from the margins felt safe in expressing their voices in a diverse setting and that those in positions of privilege were sufficiently open and humble to listen to these voices from the margins. Future research would benefit from exploring how safe spaces can be established as a potent force for ongoing institutional innovation.

Concluding Remarks

This chapter adds to the recent literature on the role emotions and values play in core institutional processes by empirically exploring how emotions and values work trigger the emergence of institutional innovation, as well as nurturing ongoing innovation processes. While organizational scholars have treated emotions mostly at an individual level, such as investigating the link between individual emotions and actions, current empirical research pays attention to the link between the emotions of individual actors and actions at the institutional level, such as institutional reflection practices (values work) nurturing institutional innovation. Thus, this chapter expands our understanding of the role played by emotions and values in innovation processes and, thus, contributes to the institutional literature on innovation. The study also contributes to ongoing explorations of how emotions and values are related and intertwined by highlighting the role of reflexivity as an antecedent and outcome of both emotions and values work. Thus, the study also contributes to the emerging literature on the interconnectedness of emotions, values, and institutions.

This study shows how the emotional reactions of individual actors triggered institutional actions in the form of reflection practices (values work). These organizational practices, in turn, stimulated and sustained ongoing institutional innovation. The *emotional reactions* were facilitated by formative personal cross-cultural experiences (micro-level condition), the power of stories and metaphors (meso-level condition), and changing context in the field (macro-level context), enabling the reflexivity and individual and institutional dis-embedding necessary for institutional innovation. The chapter also highlights how *values work*, in terms of group reflection practices, benefits institutional innovation, as different worlds of concern meet and create an awareness of current institutional arrangements. These processes are

empowered by significant diversity among individuals during group reflection practices (meso-level conditions), as reflection in safe spaces may enable participants to reorient their prevailing habits, which is key to institutional innovation. Thus, feeling safe nurtures vulnerability and humility in significantly diverse reflection groups, contributing to institutional innovation.

In sum, this study highlights how emotions may act as a starting point for actions aimed at institutional innovation and how emotions influence values work, which fosters ongoing innovation in organizations. This study offers an empirical argument for the powerful dynamic created when emotions align with values, which can amplify one another, creating a potent force for change. In this study, institutional innovation was triggered when emotions of shame and embarrassment, paired with a strong sense of justice and equality, generated energy for change efforts. These efforts were nurtured throughout the ongoing innovation process when feelings of safety and belonging were aligned with values of equality, trust, and faith, enabling the participants to cope with and thrive in the face of ongoing institutional innovation.

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20

Creating a Community Pollinator Garden: Values and Emotion Work in a Grassroots Initiative

Alain Neher, Lucia Wuersch, and Felicity Small

Introduction

The extant literature indicates that establishing a community garden as a grassroots initiative enhances the values and emotions associated with environmental sustainability (Egerer et al., 2020; Guitart et al., 2012; Pfeil, 2024; Small et al., 2023). In an organisational context, community gardens foster organisational citizenship behaviour by providing individuals with a sense of belonging and creating social relationships as the foundation of organisations (Lindheim, 2020; Welch, 2006), alongside spaces for promoting values of well-being and good health in the workplace (Creed et al., 2022; Frumkin et al., 2017; Neher et al., 2022a, 2022b; Nettle, 2014). Community gardens can come in various shapes and sizes, serving multiple purposes, such as providing opportunities for knowledge sharing and capacity building (Ahmad et al., 2024; Jeong et al., 2018; Small et al., 2023), food production, and creating habitats for bees, butterflies, birds, and other pollinators (Community Gardens Australia, 2025; Foodwise, 2025; Vernon, 2022). However,

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research shows that the natural environment is affected by urbanisation and monocultural farming practices, resulting in declining populations of pollinators both globally and in Australia (Aizen et al., 2009; Cheptou, 2021; Millard et al., 2021; Shivanna, 2022).

In Australia, the community garden movement has grown substantially over the past three decades (Community Gardens Australia, 2017; 2025). In alignment with this movement, gardens on ‘company land’ (Koch, 1979)—that is, in organisational settings—serve the purpose of community development (Small et al., 2022; 2023) and skills development (Foodwise, 2025; Krasny & Tidball, 2009). However, within a higher education institution and its immediate region, it remains unclear how university staff, students, and local community members engage with establishing a pollinator garden on a regional Australian campus, what role values and emotions play in this purposeful creation, and how the social-symbolic work (SSW) perspective (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019) can contribute to developing a deeper understanding of this reflexive, co-constructed workplace reality.

Therefore, our study aims to explore how values work and emotion work are expressed through the creation of a community garden, focusing on biodiversity (pollinators) at a regional Australian university, and to demonstrate how this grassroots initiative fosters community engagement and acts as a social-symbolic object (SSO) linking individuals, organisations, and broader institutions through the SSW framework.

To address the research aims, we interviewed volunteers (staff, students, and community members) during and after the main planting event as part of creating the garden in 2021 to explore the concept of values and emotion work in practice as part of community engagement (Andersson, 2022; Askeland et al., 2020b). Thematic template analysis (King & Brooks, 2017) and NVivo software allowed us to meaningfully organise the emerging themes as the basis for our results. We combined values and emotion work with the co-creation of a community pollinator garden within the SSW framework (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019), which can inspire and guide discussions on further creative grassroots initiatives.

In this chapter, we provide an overview of contemporary research on community and pollinator gardens, their movement, and the application of values and emotion work practices (Askeland et al., 2020b), as well as the SSW framework. We then outline the methodological approach of the study and present the key themes that emerged related to self-work, organisation work, and institutional work. We conclude by discussing valuable contributions, acknowledging limitations, and suggesting directions for future research.

Theoretical Background

Community Gardens in the Wider Societal Context

Before becoming a vital part of today's society, community gardens played various roles throughout their history. The earliest examples of community gardens appeared in the nineteenth century during the Industrial Revolution in Europe to provide fresh, nutritious food and improve public health for the working class (Keshavarz et al., 2016). Likewise, during economically challenging times in urban areas like Detroit and New York, community gardens emerged on vacant land to produce affordable local food in the late nineteenth century (Kordon, 2022; Lawson, 2005). Also serving as a way to obtain food, community gardens were widely used during World Wars I and II, as well as during the Great Depression in between these wars. During this period, community gardens were also known as 'War Gardens', 'Relief Gardens', and 'Victory Gardens' (Kordon, 2022, 2024; Kurtz, 2001). In summary, community gardens, once seen mainly as a source of food and economic support during tough times—especially in the Western world—have more recently been recognised globally for their numerous contributions, including environmental education and community building (Kordon, 2024).

Nowadays, community gardens represent a significant grassroots movement that can redefine the complex relationships between individuals, communities, and their environment (Jhagroe, 2019; Rusciano et al., 2020). It is emerging from the literature that community gardening serves as a mechanism to address broader societal challenges, including environmental outcomes, food systems, economic implications, and health, while also creating a lens for people to envision a future way of living and being (Raneng, 2023). In this way, community gardens can stimulate sustainable transitions at both the individual and societal levels, integrating the values of ecological sustainability, social equity, and community empowerment into 'business-as-usual' thinking (Pascoe & Howes, 2017).

Consequently, along with a deeper connection to nature, participation in community gardens cultivates social networks, promotes collective values, emotions, and identity, and fosters community cohesion (Litt et al., 2015). Research suggests that community gardening can also foster relationships among diverse community members, dismantling social barriers and encouraging community integration (Barnidge et al., 2013; Toda & Lowe, 2022). Moreover, as urban environments become increasingly fragmented, community gardens can act as inclusive spaces that connect people from diverse

and marginalised backgrounds (Ghose & Pettygrove, 2014). For instance, in Melbourne, Australia, community gardens have been shown to enhance social interaction and promote a sense of belonging among diverse groups, facilitating cross-cultural exchanges and the formation of community identity (Lucas, 2022).

In addition to social factors, research has also examined the impact of community gardening on individuals, particularly in terms of its psychological and physical benefits. As anxiety and depression rates rise, involvement in gardening is linked to numerous mental health benefits, such as lower stress and anxiety, due to interactions with nature and social engagement (Coringrato et al., 2024; Ward et al., 2022). Community gardening has also been positively associated with improved mental health outcomes and overall well-being for those involved (Spano et al., 2020; Tharrey & Darmon, 2022). On the physical level, participating in a community garden is associated with improved dietary practices and enhanced personal well-being (Toda & Lowe, 2022). Participants have reported healthier eating habits, including an increased intake of fruits and vegetables, which is directly tied to their involvement in community gardening (Barnidge et al., 2013).

From a food production perspective, community gardens encourage a shift towards food sovereignty, allowing communities to reclaim control over their food sources and production processes. By advocating for local food systems, these gardens motivate communities to grow and access fresh produce, thereby addressing food insecurity and related health disparities (Mehta et al., 2019). Community gardens can offer an alternative to other food systems, enabling individuals to make more informed choices about their diets while participating in a sustainable food movement (Stluka et al., 2019). For example, the 'JArDinS' (meaning 'gardens') study in France demonstrates that participation in community gardening is associated with promoting sustainable lifestyles that align with broader environmental goals, thereby merging health, well-being, and food justice (Tharrey et al., 2019). Thus, community gardens can serve as platforms for enacting food citizenship—a concept that emphasises individuals' roles in contributing to and reforming food systems while championing sustainable and equitable practices (Jhagroe, 2019).

When viewed through an economic perspective, community gardens can create pathways for localised economic growth. In particular, in low-income neighbourhoods, these gardens tackle food justice concerns by providing access to fresh produce at lower prices than traditional grocery stores (Bussell et al., 2017; Kanosvamhira, 2024). The informal economies that emerge from these gardens can revitalise local economies, highlighting the link between

food systems, community health, and economic resilience (Bussell et al., 2017).

Community Pollinator Gardens in the Australian and Organisational Context

For community gardens to thrive and produce food while offering a vibrant environment that enhances the physical and mental well-being of individuals, they must have healthy natural habitats where pollinators are indispensable. Pollinators, including birds, bees, butterflies, and numerous insects, play a crucial role in maintaining biodiversity, supporting ecosystems, and ensuring food production. They are vital in pollinating around three-quarters of the crops humans depend on for food (Beckman, 2021; Shivanna, 2022). Studies also highlight that enhancing the diversity and abundance of pollinators has a direct effect on crop yields, underscoring their significance in food security and the health of our ecosystems (Baldock, 2020; Baldock et al., 2015). However, pollinator numbers are declining worldwide, including in Australia, due to habitat loss, urbanisation, monoculture farming practices, and the extensive use of pesticides and herbicides (Aizen et al., 2009; Cheptou, 2021; Millard et al., 2021; Shivanna, 2022). Nonetheless, pollinator-friendly gardens of any size are essential for creating habitats that conserve biodiversity and sustain the diversity and abundance of pollinators (Foodwise, 2025; Vernon, 2022).

Community and pollinator gardens are becoming an increasingly popular global movement (Nettle, 2014). Over the last 30 years, the movement in Australia has experienced significant growth (Community Gardens Australia, 2017, 2025). These grassroots initiatives, generally motivated by the values of environmental sustainability, raise awareness of the crucial role pollinators play in sustaining natural and agricultural systems and fostering meaningful human-nature interactions (Foodwise, 2025). In Australia, the movement frequently emphasises building connections between people and nature, creating inclusive and interactive spaces (Clarke et al., 2023; Foodwise, 2025; Frumkin et al., 2017). By fostering interactions between people and nature, these gardens not only aid in biodiversity conservation but also nurture emotional ties and promote sustainable practices, leading to impactful social and environmental changes (Foodwise, 2025; Pleeing et al., 2022). Additionally, community gardens can improve organisational citizenship behaviours, including courtesy, conscientiousness, and civic responsibility, within organisations (Small et al., 2023).

In 1979, Koch described a flourishing community garden on ‘company land’, which is within the organisational context and contrasts with communal grounds. From this perspective, establishing a community pollinator garden on a university campus aligns with the goals of fostering community (Li & Huo, 2025; Small et al., 2023), knowledge sharing and skill development (Foodwise, 2025; Krasny & Tidball, 2009), and enhancing health and well-being (Kingsley et al., 2009, 2019) within an organisational and institutional context. Community Gardens Australia (2017, 2025) highlights a handful of universities involved in community gardens, primarily in urban (metro) areas, with a focus on food production. In contrast, our case study showcases a regional Australian university campus that is dedicated to creating safe habitats for local native pollinators. Regional communities tend to have a stronger connection with nature and their native fauna and flora compared to urban communities (Vuong & Nguyen, 2024). They are also generally smaller and foster relationships with local and regional businesses and organisations. Consequently, community initiatives at a regional university benefit both the immediate location and the broader region of the town in which the university is situated.

Emotions and Emotion Work

Organisations are socially constructed and consist of trust-based relationships between people (Welch, 2006). Hence, limited trust impacts the quality of relationships between people and the overall capacity of the organisation to function effectively. Trust is viewed as a meta-emotion, which “precedes first-order emotions ... and represents emotional ties between subjects to achieve another emotion” (Belli & Broncano, 2017, p. 430). Emotions can be understood as socially co-constructed outcomes shaped by shared organisational and institutional values, which influence both emotional and behavioural reactions, including participation in institutional activities (Creed et al., 2020). Values gain meaning through emotions, which are the ‘glue binding people together’ (Løvaas & Vråle, 2020; Zietsma et al., 2019). This was evident in the creation of a community pollinator garden, where shared emotional experiences fostered a sense of collectiveness (Voronov & Jarvis, 2025).

Emotions foster connections among individuals and support the formation and longevity of social relationships (Tracy & Robins, 2004). These ‘social emotions’ arise as responses to how we perceive our social status (Cast et al., 1999) and that of others in relation to the norms and standards inherent in social structures (Tangney et al., 2007; Tracy & Robins, 2004).

The process of social verification and ratification is closely tied to individuals' emotional experiences, influenced by factors such as access to resources and social structures (Lok et al., 2017). Accordingly, as noted by Stryker (2004), negative emotional reactions occur when verification or ratification is denied, potentially obstructing the ongoing interactions essential for cultivating lasting social connections. Similarly, negative affective experiences arise from the incongruence between expected values and the actual manifestation of those values in observed practices. This discrepancy can lead to feelings of injustice or other adverse social emotions (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). In contrast, positive emotions emerge when individuals mutually confirm each other's identity claims and actions, promoting sustained interaction. Such interaction patterns can foster the development of social bonds among individuals who share similar values or sentiments. Therefore, investigating a community-led initiative focused on creating a pollinator garden presents an ideal opportunity to explore positive and negative emotions of the volunteer participants.

Emotions are inherently social in their nature, expression, and effects (Friedland et al., 2014; Kemper, 1978; von Scheve, 2012). Emotions are the "personal expression of what one is feeling in a given moment, an expression that is structured by social convention, by culture" (Gould, 2009, p. 20). Culture, in turn, signifies a sense of belonging (Lindheim, 2020), which is underpinned by the idea that values and cultures are defined as belonging to what Hofstede (2001) describes as the mental framework of individuals, manifesting at collective and personal levels (Leis-Peters, 2022). Thus, belonging is a fundamental human need (Schnell et al., 2019), and people with strong social bonds tend to experience more positive emotions (Stillman & Baumeister, 2009). Baumeister and Leary (1995) define belonging as a "strong desire to form and maintain enduring interpersonal attachments" (p. 522). Almost 40 years ago, Moreland (1987) highlighted that the emergence of shared positive emotions plays a crucial role in forming small groups, enhancing a sense of belonging, and ultimately creating a community centred around specific purposes and values. In this way, a community pollinator garden can foster a sense of belonging and connectedness rooted in the shared interests, emotions, beliefs, and values of community members.

From an organisational and institutional perspective, 'emotion work' refers to the process of managing one's emotions to meet the emotional requirements of work or a social role. Hochschild (1979, 1983), who coined this concept, describes emotion work as the effort individuals put into inducing

or suppressing feelings to conform to societal or organisational expectations. This process includes both surface acting, where individuals alter their outward expressions, and deep acting, where they strive to modify their internal feelings to align with the expected emotions (Zapf, 2002). Emotion work encompasses the management of both internal feelings and emotional expressions, taking place when individuals interact with others in workplace settings or other environments (Zapf et al., 2021), such as in a community garden context.

As discussed earlier, emotion work can yield both positive and negative outcomes. Positive emotions tied to a sense of achievement and work satisfaction result in favourable effects. However, when individuals are required to consistently exude positive emotions that do not align with their true feelings, it can foster emotional dissonance, adversely affecting their psychological well-being (Zapf et al., 2021). This often occurs in the service sector, such as with flight attendants who are always required to be friendly, even to passengers who can be arrogant, as studied by Hochschild (1983). Hence, emotion work functions as a gesture in social interactions, fulfilling a purpose, and should not be seen merely as a personality trait (Hochschild, 1979). Nonetheless, the significance of emotional work is closely tied to identity (belonging), considering both broad cultural contexts and specific organisational and institutional cultures (Zapf et al., 2021).

In conclusion, while emotion work involves managing personal (self) feelings, influencing others, or responding to the emotions of others (Hochschild, 1979), emotions arise when individuals face situations that challenge or validate their values (Mazzetti, 2018), resulting in either a strengthened or weakened sense of belonging. Considering the likelihood of negative emotions at work, creating a garden space that is led by the community yet supported by the organisation can help restore balance and offer employees a respite from emotional stress, especially in the service industry.

Values and Values Work

Recently, values have been defined as “individual and collective trans-situational conceptions of desirable behaviours, objectives and ideals that serve to guide or value practice” (Askeland, 2020, p. 26). Thus, values influence individuals’ attitudes, work behaviour, and decision-making, ultimately directing an organisation’s actions (Askeland et al., 2020a; Neher et al., 2022a). Values are essential for understanding social processes as they highlight what is important in social life, promote social well-being, and create

the conditions that enable humans to thrive (Creed et al., 2022; Selznick, 2008).

Values also play a crucial role in shaping organisational culture as they establish a shared sense of purpose and direction among employees (Neher & Maley, 2020). When values are clearly communicated and consistently upheld, they foster a cohesive and motivated workforce, enhancing overall performance and job satisfaction (Neher et al., 2018). Moreover, values can serve as a benchmark for ethical decision-making (Crossan et al., 2013; Small & Lew, 2021), helping individuals and organisations navigate complex situations with integrity and accountability. By aligning personal and organisational values, a collegial and productive work environment can be achieved, ultimately contributing to long-term success and sustainability (Neher et al., 2022a).

Values work centres on identifying key behaviours deemed valuable to the organisation, as well as values-driven actions in daily work that contribute to the continuous creation of knowledge and reflection (Espedal, 2019). Expanding on Gehman et al.'s (2013) definition of values practices, Espedal (2020) defines values work as “the sayings and doings in organisations that articulate and accomplish *the desirables* in relevance to right and wrong action and behaviour” (p. 36). Given this, values-driven organisations are likely to possess a clearer strategic direction and embedded practices that support staff in ‘living’ the organisation’s values.

In studies on the institutional context of values work, research has focused on either highly institutionalised organisations, recognised as structured social systems (Aldrich, 1992), or on associations and grassroots organisations, which emphasise broad participation in collective political activities (Togeby, 1993). These organisations are usually established with a clear agenda, where micro-processes of values work significantly contribute to enhancing the common good (Espedal, 2020). Overall, organisations centred on values work “are in a better position to improve their practices and quality of services” (Askeland et al., 2020a, p. 1), and consequently contribute to the institutional context (Sirris, 2020).

Social-Symbolic Work Framework

To better illuminate the values and emotion work evident in institutionalised practice, an integrative SSW framework is recognised as a suitable approach (Askeland et al., 2020a). Values and emotions in organisations are vital when considering the broader contexts in which they operate. Organisations function within a diverse and intricate institutional environment, encompassing,

for example, market dynamics, regulatory frameworks, and legal requirements (Askeland et al., 2020a). In SSW, values and emotions interlink in three forms, described by Lawrence and Phillips (2019) as *self work*, *organisation work*, and *institutional work*. Altogether, Lawrence and Phillips (2019, p. 5) describe SSW as “the purposeful, reflexive efforts of individuals, collective actors, and networks of actors to construct the social world”.

Self-work centres on the social construction and shaping of the self and others within and surrounding organisations, aiming to shape the social-symbolic dimensions of the self (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024). The SSW framework perceives the ‘self’ as a socially constructed entity shaped by discourse and relationships with others (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024). Thus, the self is grounded in the principle of always being constructed in relation to others (Chang, 2008). Self-work arises from the coordinated actions of a network of individuals, which, despite being fragmented, reflects the past, present, and future narratives of those involved (Tripathi & Rizvi, 2022). In this study’s context, the concept of values and emotion work emerges as performances embedded in activities, which are reflected in the development and execution of values and emotion practices (Gehman et al., 2013; Wright et al., 2017), specifically in the creation of the community pollinator garden.

Organisation work involves the efforts of individuals, collective actors, and networks of actors (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024). Building on the earlier discussion of the ‘self’, organisations are perceived as SSW entities, resulting in a greater emphasis on shaping and structuring organisational work (Tripathi & Rizvi, 2022). The emergence of contemporary organisations as autonomous entities has significantly contributed to their development as social actors (Selznick, 2008). A university pollinator garden supports the ‘organisation’ by enhancing relationships and trust among individuals. Trusting relationships form the foundation of organisations (Welch, 2006). As relationships shape organisations (Shockley-Zalabak, 2014; Wuersch et al., 2023), a lack of trust suggests that a genuine organisation cannot thrive. Trust is not only a critical value within the set of values work in an organisation, but it also stimulates a sense of belonging (Allen et al., 2017)—hence, linking a trust-based relationship to emotions (Kivle & Espedal, 2022). Thus, trust relies on group membership, social connections, and shared values, with people feeling this emotion after reflecting on the actions or behaviours of others (Earle et al., 2007).

Institutional work is defined as the “purposive action” of individuals and organisations “aimed at creating, maintaining and disrupting institutions” (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006, p. 216). It emphasises the normative framework

of institutions, specifically the roles, values, emotions, and norms that support them (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Wright et al., 2017). The concept of institutional work focuses on the practical work performed within communities (Whittington, 2006) and involves adaptable problem-solving by employing alternative practices to find solutions, as opposed to conventional approaches (Tripathi & Rizvi, 2022). Practice work as part of the institutional SSW involves efforts to create meaning and establish and maintain an SSO, thereby guiding behaviour (Garud et al., 2002; Gawer & Phillips, 2013; Maguire & Hardy, 2009). By creating a community pollinator garden (SSO), the institutional work has been exemplified through the purposeful, reflexive efforts of individuals and collective actors to shape the institutions around them (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). Reflexivity is essential for institutional work because it helps individuals comprehend their social environment (Lawrence et al., 2013). The university social environment consists of individuals directly or indirectly affiliated with the institution, including students, staff, their families, collaborating schools, businesses providing supplies, shops, and government entities. Those involved in initiating the pollinator garden project were sourced from this organisational community. Grassroots initiatives in Australia, like ours, also involve a more formal environment of institutional work, which forms part of a complex interaction including local governance, urban planning, civil society activism, and evolving public policy frameworks like land use regulations (following Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). Since our project is situated within the ‘company land’ context, much of this institutional environment is managed by the university.

We conceptualise values and emotion work within the context of community actions, constructing a ‘social world’ in a defined location. Specifically, by reflecting on the creation of a community pollinator garden—focusing on biodiversity—as a values and emotions-driven initiative (self-work) for the common good within a regional Australian university context (organisation work and institutional work), this study aims to deepen the understanding at the intersection of SSW and the development of social life, particularly the behaviour of individuals within a community.

Studying Values and Emotion Work with an SSW Framework

Creating a community pollinator garden on a regional Australian university campus as an SSO enabled purposeful and reflexive efforts towards the SSW, thereby fostering values and emotion work (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024). The concept of an SSO is described as a combination of

discursive, relational, and material elements that form a meaningful pattern within a social system (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). Therefore, a community pollinator garden serves as an exemplary SSO, fulfilling all elements and imparting meaning to both nature and people.

For our SSO research project, we empirically explored key questions about how the self-work, the organisation work, and the institutional work are interconnected and ‘glued together’. We investigated how a creative grass-roots initiative—the community pollinator garden—situated at the nexus of the workplace (university) and the wider community can shape organisational and social life. To better understand values and emotion work and the purposefully co-constructed social workplace realities, our study poses the following research question: *What role do values and emotions play in the purposeful creation of a community pollinator garden at a regional Australian university?*

Next, we discuss how the research team and volunteers created the university pollinator garden and collected and analysed field data to enhance the understanding of changes in the social context, including the values and emotions of the participants that invigorate organisational and community life.

Methodology

We utilised Yin’s (2018) six stages (plan, design, prepare, collect, analyse, share) of the case study process to investigate our research project. This study was initiated and designed by members of a Business School at a regional Australian university as a collaborative effort involving volunteers of university staff, students, and local community members from a regional town of approximately 50,000 inhabitants. While research was one component of this project, the hands-on creation of the pollinator garden itself was the other component.

Infrastructure work on the designated garden site within the university grounds was carried out as part of the preparations. Due to the pandemic and the resulting restrictions, such as lockdowns and social distancing measures, this work was completed by the research team, comprising five university staff members, rather than in collaboration with volunteers. Nevertheless, from the beginning of the project, we actively engaged with the local community through regular fortnightly live interviews and podcasts broadcast on the campus’s regional community radio station. Additional communication channels included the university’s social media platforms, news outlets, and the

professional and social networks of the staff involved. Through these outreach efforts, we kept community members informed about the garden's progress and its benefits for both the community and the environment. This multifaceted communication approach also aided in recruiting volunteers for the 'planting day' event.

The planting day occurred just two days after the second local COVID-19 lockdown ended in October 2021. For data collection, sampling, and recruitment, staff, students, and community volunteers could register for the event through designated information channels (e.g. via a dedicated email address) or directly arrive on the day. At the start of the planting event, all participants received an information package that included a consent form, allowing them to voluntarily self-nominate for an interview during the event. Before being interviewed, the interviewees were informed about the ethical process, and they could withdraw from or stop the interview at any time. To maintain anonymity, the original names of the interviewees were replaced with pseudonyms, while their gender identities were left unchanged. This research project was approved by the University's Human Research Ethics Committee (protocol number: H21106).

Following the data saturation approach (Patton, 2015), the final sample comprised nine interview participants (of overall 19 volunteers). The nine semi-structured interviews took place between October 2021 and February 2022 and followed an interview guide (Charmaz, 2014, 2025). Questions explored peoples' values, emotions, attitudes, and expectations for engaging in a community pollinator garden project. Three community volunteers (Alice, Grace and Lana) and two staff members (Ida and Maria) consented to individual interviews on the day. Another three university staff members (Vera, Ian, and Paul) and a student (Tom), who were closely involved in the community pollinator garden project, agreed to be interviewed following the event. The interviews were conducted either face-to-face or online, using Zoom, and lasted between eight and 37 minutes.

For the analysis, the interview recordings were transcribed by a high-quality external transcription service. Subsequently, the transcripts were analysed using King and Brooks' (2017) thematic template analysis, combined with Saldaña's (2021, 2025) initial coding technique. This process produced an initial template comprising 134 themes, which underwent a more focused second-cycle coding process (Saldaña, 2021, 2025). As a result, a final template containing three clusters (self-work, organisation work, institutional work) and 57 themes was achieved. NVivo14 (QSR International) aided in the analysis and systematic organisation of the data, which, in turn, supported the interpretation and reporting of the findings.

Findings and Discussion

This case study of a regional Australian university, where volunteers, including staff, students, and community members, co-created a community pollinator garden, highlights the valuable contributions it can make to individuals, the organisation, and the wider community, along with environmental benefits such as enhanced biodiversity. The project also demonstrates the purposeful co-construction of values and emotion work on the planting day. Furthermore, it illustrates how our community pollinator garden on the university campus reflects the interplay between ‘self-work–organisation work–institutional work’, all guided by principles of values and emotion work.

While values work within organisations shapes their purpose, guides the direction of their efforts, and establishes the criteria for assessing organisational practices (Askeland, 2020), emotion work functions as a gesture in social interactions, fulfilling a purpose (Hochschild, 1979). The interview participants highlighted that the common goal of the planting day was to bring people together and help them become part of the planting community. In further alignment with the concept of an SSO, participants also drew on the co-creation of the garden itself, paralleled with recognising the practical and meaningful outcome. Paul, for example, acknowledged, “I think it [community pollinator garden] worked out excellent. Made use of the garden beds around the Dobbin Building, which hadn’t any [plants] in them for years, so it’s been nothing but good outcomes for that whole area.” An essential relational and social aspect of the community pollinator project was community development, or in Paul’s words: “Community can mean many things. Just the coming together of like-minded people with the same interest and goal.” Similarly, engaging in conversation and interaction with others is closely related to personal engagement and creating meaning, a theme that was clearly evident in the SSO and its components.

The following sections explore each of the three SSW forms (self-work, organisation work, institutional work) in relation to values and emotions, supported by literature and excerpts from interviews.

‘Self’ Values and Emotions Towards Building a Community Pollinator Garden

In our case study, participants reflected on how their personal (self) values aligned with supporting the community pollinator garden initiative. For example, Ida said, “I also have a personal [reason]; I guess my values align

with that activity”. She further mentioned that, besides this meaningful environmental sustainability initiative, she enjoyed the idea of connecting the community with the university: “I thought it was quite interesting to see people external to the university involved, and it was really lovely”. Vera complemented by sharing her personal motivation:

I guess the reason I came is because, at the moment, I’m new to the area, and I’m in a rental place, so I no longer have the ability to do all those things I would have done in my own garden. So, it’s nice to know that there’s a community place where you can go and be involved.

Vera’s comment reveals her desire and intention to belong, highlighting the deep-seated urge to establish a meaningful and positive interpersonal connection (Baumeister & Leary, 1995). By engaging in interactions, participants form emotional bonds and foster connections with the individuals and locations (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018).

Further emerging values included sustainability, autonomy in executing tasks, and learning from one another. Regarding sustainability, participants reflected on the project’s permanence, expressing interest in knowing how it would be sustained in the long term. For example, Maria reflected, “These sorts of things are really great, but I was wondering what it will be like in 10- or 20-years’ time, how to keep it going when probably a lot of us won’t be around here in that time.” Similarly, Vera queried, “This is a thing that isn’t just an event that is a point in time, and then disappears, so I’d be interested to know whether you’re able to sustain it”. Therefore, having a long-term sustainability plan for the project was considered essential, particularly in light of concerns about maintaining momentum and attracting new volunteers over time. Given the importance of long-term sustainability, the project team effectively secured the garden’s ongoing viability by integrating the community pollinator garden into the well-established Campus Environmental Working Group and developing a strong relationship with the university’s Grounds Team, providing maintenance support.

Many participants emphasised their values in connecting with others who shared their passion for land care, gardening, and environmental sustainability. Community members with shared understandings and passions thrive by maintaining valued social bonds and fostering their sense of belonging (Creed et al., 2014; Wuersch et al., 2022). Furthermore, participants valued the opportunity to learn more about natural areas and native fauna and flora that were offered. In this way, Maria enjoyed extending her learning beyond the ‘traditional bees’, realising, “I learnt about the native bees. I didn’t really

know anything about them and just learnt how they were solitary.” Similarly, Lana conveyed her interest in deepening her understanding of native wildlife:

I’m happy to learn and gain knowledge about the pollinators that we have in Australia, particularly in relation to native plants, which is my interest. ... I learnt, right at the start, when we wandered over to the dam, that I’m really interested in natural areas, possibly more than gardening with introduced plants.

There was also a focus on values like collaborating and learning from one another. For example, Maria summarised how meeting, learning, and contributing came together during the planting day by saying, “Meeting new people and learning things from them, and just feeling like you’re contributing”. Conversely, while sharing knowledge and helping each other was mentioned frequently, it was also recognised that, at instances, collaboration can pose its challenges, as Vera pointed out: “It is always challenging in the sense that you’re going to have people with different gardening plant knowledge”. Notably, this was the only mild negative emotional voice noted during the interview phase with community volunteers. This suggests that neither denial through verification and ratification (Lok et al., 2017; Stryker, 2004) nor a negative affective experience due to incongruence between values, expectations and the actual experience of manifest values was a prominent aspect of the event (Ruebottom & Auster, 2018). Furthermore, the researchers did not observe any instances of rejection during the event.

Overall, the planting day was commended for its positive spirit of support and collaboration, socially constructing a community shaped by discourse and relationships with others and co-creating values work. Maria’s reflection nicely sums up these ideas: “Well, it’s great to be involved in something where you feel like you’re coming together with a group of people to achieve something that’s good and beneficial for the community”. Maria’s manifestation of belonging and connectedness also showcases that emotions play a direct role in positive affective experiences—like her sense of pride—that arise from the alignment between the values system evident in this community and the values with which she and the other community members identify (Kraatz & Flores, 2015; Toubiana et al., 2017).

The planting day participants showed a mix of individual and collective empowerment by generating emotional energy and nurturing a sense of community within the group (Collins, 2004; Juris, 2008). Ruebottom and Auster (2018) describe this as the ‘reflexive embedding’ of individuals within a community, echoing Chang’s (2008) idea that the self is continuously shaped by interactions with others. Accordingly, as performed in this project,

self-work is a form of coordinated activity with and in relation to others (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). The participants expressed and illustrated their values and emotions while also sharing them with others to facilitate sense-making (Espedal et al., 2024) and co-create meaning through an SSO that incorporates those values (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). The planting day also demonstrated the role that (initially self) values play in creating emotional identification and commitment to the community, and ultimately, to the institutional work (Kraatz & Flores, 2015). From a self-perspective, the sense of belonging emerged as a powerful emotion, as exemplarily highlighted by Lana, “Being part of something, not only just a one-on-one friendship, but belonging to a community, which probably needs to be formalised in some sort.” Indeed, the pollinator garden has become integral to the organisation, creating an SSO that is shaped by both individual (self) and collective (others) influences and values, as well as the emerging values work (Andersson, 2022; Lawrence & Phillips, 2019).

Shaping ‘Organisation’ Through Values and Emotion Work

In line with the literature on organisation work, the participants on the planting day highlighted the importance of trust between individuals. For example, Paul stressed, “As long as the end goal is in sight, and everyone’s working towards that, no matter what role they’re in, you’ve got to be able to trust each other. That’s very important.” Similarly, Maria expressed her emotions when alluding to the feeling of belonging to a trusted community that does something good and beneficial.

Additionally contributing to the ‘organisation’, the garden played a vital role in building and fostering both personal and professional connections, with several volunteers participating in the event to broaden their networks. Some participants enjoyed meeting with other university staff members and making contacts that “aren’t just bee garden related” (Alice). Other participants used the planting event as an opportunity to reacquaint themselves with university staff members, engaging in conversations after an extended period without meeting, also due to the COVID-19 lockdowns. Alongside practical gardening, morning tea provided a welcomed chance to connect and build relationships. Grace, for example, noted that, “The morning tea was nice to talk to people and see people there and engage there.” Vera added,

It was nice to have the break for a cup of tea because it means that’s a more social setting, so that you get the chance to speak to those people, perhaps if

you weren't actually gardening in the same area as them, so you get to meet them.

Volunteers could connect with others who shared similar values and emotions and were like-minded, creating a feeling of belonging to a community (Lindheim, 2020). While Ian expressed his feeling of belonging, "I think there was something about the camaraderie on the day, the feeling of connection", Tom effectively conveyed how the community pollinator garden can serve as a space of belonging, stating, "People should feel like it was theirs ..., and people should feel okay about being there". Ian further added, "I'm a very social person, so being part of a network and social interaction is very important... [then underlining] what a good day it was!" Following Baumeister and Leary (1995), the event generated *positive* emotions of belonging, arising from mutual connections and relationship-building. Conversely, assuming that intrinsic motivation—of which emotions are among the most important in social life (Scott, 2013)—and positive basic emotions, along with mutual interests for participation, were present, *negative* affect, such as loneliness or social exclusion, was not evident on that day. In the same vein, positive emotion work appeared genuine and aligned with the volunteer's feelings, thus not showing emotional dissonance (Zapf et al., 2021).

Additionally, volunteers expected the event participants to be enthusiastic and share the same mindset, which significantly contributed to the event's success. Consequently, the community pollinator garden project created emotions of excitement and satisfaction among participants, primarily due to its collaborative nature and shared environmental tenet. This community ethos represents a unique method of organising and expressing emotions, shaping interactions that influence both the subjectification and self-regulation of its members (Lok et al., 2017). Ida, for example, enjoyed "to pair up with one other person to do stuff. And so, that was quite nice; you got to chat and garden at the same time". Participants generally wanted to support one another and engage actively, as seen in Vera's statement, "I came to get my hands dirty". In the same spirit, Paul emphasised, "I'm all for helping in the community projects in any way I can", while Lana assisted another volunteer who had already begun a task and was, therefore, "happy to be the helper".

In organisations, symbols are linked to values, attitudes, beliefs, behaviours, and emotions (Cheney et al., 2004). In our context, the university pollinator garden emerged as an SSO that can be symbolised as a 'built community capital' (Emery & Flora, 2006). Participants highlighted the symbol, for example, Ian noting, "You're able to see it, not only in the garden itself but in the wider vibrancy of insect life on the campus ground". Maria

reflected on the journey of becoming, saying, “I guess when you start something, you do want to see how it goes and the progress, the plants grow, and what you set out to do, whether it’s happening”. Ian encapsulated the organisational values work by merging the enthusiasm for research in sustainability with the creation of a space dedicated to the common good.

An incredible thing about this pollinator garden project is that you have done all this research, but you’ve also come up with something that’s going to be long-lasting and physical and just a real benefit to the campus community. (Ian)

The general sentiments, attitudes, and emotions of the volunteers reflect a ‘practice perspective’ to values in organisations, focusing on practices and processes in which values are performed (Gehman et al., 2013). Our investigation explored how individual values and emotions relate to the broader perspective of organisational practice (Espedal, 2020). These values and emotions extend beyond the ‘self’ and contribute to the ‘organisation’. By shaping relationships with others, the self ultimately influences the quality and effectiveness of interactions in the organisational context (Chang, 2008). The fundamental values and ethos behind the creation of this community pollinator garden are the commitment to the common good and work that is of value to the world. This encompasses a normative dimension integral to the institutional work (Friedland, 2017; Gehman et al., 2013).

Values and Emotion Work in ‘Institutional’ Work

Our research reveals that a community pollinator garden on a university campus (‘company land’) can make a creative contribution to its local and broader community, extending beyond its primary role. Grace, for instance, mentioned, “I was just imagining enthusiastic people who wanted to make a difference to the landscape and around the university”. At the same time, Ian further stressed, “I think it’s a really valuable project that has a tangible benefit to the community”. He also added,

I mainly have shared with friends that on campus here, some of the students walked past and said, oh, there’s a new garden there; what’s that about? And I could tell them, well, it’s a pollinator garden; it’s doing all these things; it’s creating bee highways between the different locations and allowing the business research team to look at a lot of different aspects of communal behaviour; and I think, oh wow, it’s actually a whole big deal. It’s not just run by the campus services; it’s this whole thing. (Ian)

Participants agreed that the initiative had a positive impact on both the environment and the broader community. Tom pointed out that the pollinator garden “is contributing to the sustainability of the region—contributing to the bee highway. It is contributing to making sure that it gives back to the community. So, the community knowing that, I think, is important”. Other participants highlighted the values of social elements, which bind the individual parts together, allowing the university to integrate into the wider community. For example, Vera expressed, “I liked the concept that this is the university trying to be part of the community”. Ian also valued connecting the community with the university and welcoming local residents to the campus. He further explored this by emphasising a behavioural viewpoint that extends beyond just the organisation work perspective.

It was a really nice community that we could find between a project that was happening here on campus, and then having those people come in and talk about not only the pollination side of it, but also the observations that you guys were making, particularly with regard to the behaviour of people during that volunteer day. (Ian)

Vera expanded on that perception and pondered about “the bee highway and the pollinators, how that then will link into perhaps things happening in the next town or whatever”.

The relationships between universities and their local communities are known as ‘town and gown’ relations (Kemp, 2014; Massey et al., 2014; Wuersch et al., 2026). Higher education institutions play a significant role in the social, economic, and political development of these communities (Hatcher et al., 2020; Kemp, 2014), a role that is even more pronounced in regional areas. Conversely, a collaborative relationship between tertiary institutions and their surrounding communities promotes safety, peace, stability, security, and advancement, which, in turn, enhances the universities’ overall effectiveness and quality outcomes (Yerima et al., 2023). Therefore, all these factors contribute to the broader institutional work and the values and emotions that underpin institutions (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006). Our community pollinator garden project illustrates that values are crucial to the institutional perspective (Sirris, 2020), while emotions influence the lives, actions, and experiences of members within the institutional work (Zietsma & Toubiana, 2018).

Contributions, Limitations, and Further Research

We address the research question, *What role do values and emotions play in the purposeful creation of a community pollinator garden at a regional Australian university?* by demonstrating how values and emotion work integrate the three forms of SSW: self-work, organisation work, and institutional work. This integration occurs through the purposeful and reflexive creation of a community pollinator garden that emerged as an SSO on a regional university campus in Australia. In our case study, we apply Lawrence and Phillips' (2019) SSW framework to illustrate how volunteers engage in a shared sustainability initiative that connects the workplace (university) with the broader community (local town and surrounding region). We particularly emphasise the relational function of the community pollinator garden, providing a space where interpersonal relationships can flourish and trust, considered a meta-emotion (Belli & Broncano, 2017), can be strengthened through collaborative activities. The values and emotion work approach used in the university's pollinator garden can inform discussions about innovative grassroots initiatives.

Contributions

Our study significantly enhances the concept of values and emotion work by demonstrating its practical application in a community-based initiative using a co-creation approach. By integrating the SSW framework (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024), our research further illustrates how values and emotion work can be purposefully and reflexively enacted in real-world settings, while becoming an SSO. The community pollinator garden serves as a tangible example of how values and emotions can guide and shape collective actions towards environmental sustainability and community engagement. This practical demonstration also enriches the theoretical understanding of values and emotion work by showing its dynamic, processual, and context-specific nature, as also highlighted by previous studies (e.g. Askeland et al., 2020b; Gehman et al., 2013; Neher & Maley, 2020; Wright et al., 2017). Moreover, our study illustrates the importance of aligning self, organisation, and institutional work with values and emotion work to create a cohesive and impactful initiative. By focusing on the relational aspects of values and emotion work, such as building trust (e.g. Belli & Broncano, 2017; Welch, 2006), fostering interpersonal connections (e.g. Løvaas & Vråle, 2020), and social well-being (e.g. Creed et al., 2022), our research underscores the social dimensions of values and emotions. This contribution

deepens the theoretical discourse on values and emotion work, providing a nuanced perspective that emphasises the interplay between values, actions, and social contexts. For example, by providing a shared space for individuals to engage in meaningful activities, the pollinator garden emerged as a model environment, fostering community and particularly highlighting the sense of belonging—also known as bonding (Putnam, 1995). By demonstrating the social benefits of a community pollinator garden, our study underlines the importance of creating spaces that facilitate interaction, trust, and well-being. This is especially relevant in today's context, where strengthening community bonds is essential for addressing various social challenges. Our contribution is supported by Christensen et al. (2019), who argue that creating thriving spaces through building community and social capital is one of the most significant advantages of community gardens.

As demonstrated by the volunteers, our community pollinator garden functions as an SSO by embodying shared meanings, values, emotions, and identities that go beyond its physical form (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019). As an SSO, the garden acts as a focal point where community members organise, fostering a sense of belonging and collective purpose. This was clear not only on the planting day but also persisted in everyday actions and collective events, such as World Bee Day (20 May). Following Lok (2010), this grassroots effort, driven by volunteers, involved identity (self) work as participants often aligned their personal values (e.g. environmental sustainability, belonging, and learning from one another) with the goals of the garden and community building. Through this alignment, volunteers shaped and expressed identities as environmentally conscious and community-minded citizens, and to some extent, as local change-makers. Meanwhile, the SSO anchors organisational work by involving informal roles, including the researchers, in planning, coordination, and knowledge sharing. Throughout this process, our grassroots initiative has become a lasting part of the organisation's community. Over time, the pollinator garden contributes to institutional work by subtly challenging dominant urban land use norms (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006), such as growing fruits and vegetables, and promoting biodiversity through advocacy for alternatives—that is, the pollinators. By co-creating and sustaining the garden, volunteers have helped shape new practices at both the immediate and broader community levels. Therefore, we argue that the pollinator garden is more than just a space for biodiversity; it has become a symbol of co-creation, civic identity, and socio-environmental innovation—hence, an SSO.

Building on the social dimension, our project also contributes to the discourse on social innovation initiatives, as organisational citizens initiated

it and mobilised various university stakeholders, including staff, students, and the wider community (Wittmayer et al., 2023). Our initiative aimed to address societal and environmental needs differently: by building a grassroots pollinator garden on ‘company land’, emphasising biodiversity as an alternative to the well-established, often metro-based (communal) community gardens focused on food production. This initiative has become transformative that the pollinator garden has drawn the attention of stakeholders on campus, prompting them to pay closer attention to the values of environmental sustainability—for example, students actively engaging with project members. The dedicated garden also fosters emotional connection, not just during construction, but also in the daily vibrancy of the campus, promoting well-being while enjoying the inspiring space and nature. This change has become the new ‘normal’ on campus, as Wittmayer et al. (2023) anticipate from a social innovation initiative. In other words, our initiative has carried out ‘institutional work’ by providing inspiration for how a community garden can be approached differently (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Möllering & Müller-Seitz, 2018; Rohde & Hielscher, 2021). Hence, our research offers another original example of the transformative social innovation illustrated in Wittmayer and colleagues’ (2023) study.

From a community garden movement perspective, our research utilises a concept that focuses on native flora to benefit native pollinators, thereby contributing to biodiversity and expanding beyond the most common and popular approaches of food-producing community gardens mentioned above and thus enriching this movement. Additionally, with the application of the SSW framework (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019; Wright et al., 2024) within the realm of a regional university pollinator garden, our research offers a fresh perspective on the movement in Australia and beyond. It demonstrates how universities can make a significant contribution to environmental sustainability and promote community engagement, confirming that community gardens *do* encourage civic engagement, as suggested by Litt et al. (2015). Our study serves as a distinctive case of integrating values and emotion work into grassroots initiatives, emphasising the capacity of academic environments to act as catalysts for broader social transformations. This self-work-driven organisational work contribution propels the community garden movement forward by presenting a model that is adaptable and replicable in diverse settings. Following Selznick (2008), this project took on stewardship for the well-being of people and the environment, contributing to the institutional context (Creed et al., 2022; Selznick, 2008). Hence, our findings highlight the essential role academic institutions can play in the local community in promoting environmental sustainability and nurturing a culture of

involvement and collaboration to support well-being in the local town and surrounding region—thus also contributing to the town and gown literature.

Our community pollinator garden initiative has also contributed to education and capacity building. Participants were given the opportunity to learn about plants, pollinators, and insects, as well as sustainable practices. As suggested by the literature (e.g. Sachs et al., 2022; Small et al., 2023), our initiative demonstrated that the educational aspect associated with community groups can help create inclusive and relatable experiences, laying the foundation for a welcoming space for new members within a dedicated community. Our findings further support the view that promoting environmental awareness of sustainable practices among volunteers fosters knowledge sharing and the development of sustainable lifestyles (Cumbers et al., 2017; Tharrey et al., 2019). Therefore, we advocate that by nurturing a culture of sustainability, community pollinator gardens—and community gardens in general—help shape the values, emotions, and behaviours of current and future generations. At the core of community gardening is the desire to generate and support a connection between people and their environment. This may instil a sense of responsibility towards both local and global environments (Milbourne, 2021; Pascoe & Howes, 2017), influencing volunteers' sustainability behaviours beyond the garden and into their daily lives and interactions with others, further driving positive societal change (Lovell, 2010; Zelenika et al., 2018).

Finally, from a practical perspective, our case study presents a valuable blueprint for any organisation, including private companies, as shown by Koch (1979) in the 1970s. It serves as a guide for creating community pollinator gardens or similar initiatives that support broader environmental and social goals. By examining the creation of such a garden on a university campus, our study offers practical insights applicable in diverse contexts. This guidance can help organisations enhance community engagement and promote environmental sustainability, regardless of the project's size and location. By showcasing our research, we may inspire others to initiate grassroots projects that benefit the greater good.

Limitations and Further Research

This inquiry is based on a single garden in regional Australia. While this case study provides a distinct illustration of 'analytic generalisation', the research did not aim for, and the methodological approach does not permit statistical generalisation to a broader population (Yin, 2018). Future research could, therefore, examine additional pollinator and community gardens, particularly

in urban settings with a non-food emphasis, to gain a more comprehensive perspective. It is also worth noting that on the day of the event, when volunteers gathered to plant the garden, it was raining and cool, immediately following the second COVID-19 lockdown in October 2021. The weather and the timing may have influenced the interest and enthusiasm of the volunteers involved. That is, while the number of volunteers was reasonable but not extensive, possibly because of the weather, the highly positive spirit may have stemmed from similar motivations and interests, along with the lack of opportunities to socialise during the pandemic. Further studies could investigate participant behaviour over an extended period to enhance understanding of volunteer engagement in collaborative efforts linking the university with the broader community. At the same time, exploring values and emotion work through Lawrence and Phillips' (2019) SSW framework could provide further insights, enabling comparisons with our short-term study and varying contexts. Lastly, the investigation focused on empirical data collected at the community pollinator garden event, with negative affective emotions and experiences being basically absent. Another angle to consider is the project's own journey, particularly the time leading up to its inception, or planting day, as detailed in our study. Like all projects, there are various obstacles to navigate throughout such a journey, encompassing both the joys and challenges of the individual and shared growth and development process.

Conclusion

This study examined how values and emotion work shape the creation of a community pollinator garden at a regional Australian university. Using the SSW framework, we showed how self, organisation, and institutional work were integrated through this grassroots initiative, which functioned as an SSO, connecting the university with its wider community. The garden fostered trust, a sense of belonging, and collaboration while advancing biodiversity and promoting environmental stewardship. By extending the community garden movement beyond food production, it offered a novel model of civic engagement and sustainability. Our findings highlight the potential of universities to catalyse social innovation by co-creating spaces that cultivate values, emotions, and practices essential for resilient, sustainable communities.

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21

Emotional Maturity, Moral Maturity and Values of Emerging Leaders in Workplace Environments

Kurt April and Janine Downes

Introduction

In 2003, Ashkanasy described how emotions infuse five levels of organizational functioning:

(1) in the moment-by-moment and day-to-day experiences of organizational members, (2) are influenced by emotional dimensions of individual differences, (3) influence interpersonal interactions and communication, (4) affect group processes, including leadership, and (5) ultimately permeate organizational culture and climate. While often conflated, emotional intelligence, emotional competence, and emotional maturity refer to distinct concepts. Emotional intelligence typically involves the ability to recognize, understand, and manage emotions (Goleman, 1998). Emotional competence refers to learned capabilities based on emotional intelligence, such as conflict resolution or empathy. Emotional maturity, however, includes the ethical and contextual deployment of these capabilities, shaped by moral considerations, social positioning, and power relations (Jakimow, 2022). In this sense, emotional maturity encompasses and transcends both intelligence and competence. Emotional maturity, a construct rooted in self-awareness and self-regulation, is indispensable for navigating the complexities of organizational life. Defined as the ability

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to regulate emotions, sustain endurance under stress, and exhibit tolerance (Masih & Wani, 2015), it extends beyond individual development to influence organizational behavior. Emotional maturity shapes how leaders manage unpredictability (Khaleelee & Woolf, 1996) and maintain stability in volatile environments (Wagde & Ganaie, 2013). Its absence, marked by juvenile emotional states (Zinck & Newen, 2008), can disrupt personal and organizational equilibrium, underscoring its relevance in institutional contexts.

Moral maturity reflects an individual's ability to reason ethically and act in accordance with internalized values. It evolves through stages where moral reasoning aligns increasingly with principled values, such as justice and care, rather than external rules or authority (Kohlberg, 1984). Moral maturity complements emotional maturity by introducing ethical considerations into emotional judgments (Hedstrand, 2007). For example, recognizing a context that demands emotional suppression (as in colonial or racialized institutions) may reflect emotional intelligence, but resisting this suppression, for example by asserting identity and dignity, demonstrates moral maturity. The interplay between emotional and moral maturity thus becomes crucial in post-colonial, multicultural workplace settings.

Integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism reveals a dynamic framework for understanding how emotional maturity fosters institutional coherence. Leaders with emotional maturity are adept at leveraging emotions to reinforce values, creating cultures of trust and shared purpose. However, scholarly inquiry often conflates emotional maturity with emotional intelligence, limiting its exploration in institutional settings (Hyatt et al., 2007).

Organizational institutionalism emphasizes values as enduring systems that guide collective behavior, yet often neglects the emotional underpinnings that sustain these values. Emotions, as intrinsic motivators, are fundamental to enacting and upholding organizational values. Given the institutional boundaries of organizational values, emotional job requirements and acceptable workplace relations, the emotions of individuals inevitably need to be regulated—and such regulation of emotions has been studied under two distinct, yet overlapping, research traditions: emotion regulation and emotional labor (Salimzadeh et al., 2021). The two constructs are comparable in that both focus on modifying feelings and expressions through the use of different strategies (Grandey, 2015; Gross, 2013). As mentioned above, emotion regulation—regulating feelings through *reappraisal* as attempts to change feelings to appear genuine, and regulating expressions through *suppressing*

negative and *amplifying positive* emotions—encompasses a heterogeneous set of processes whereby people seek to influence the types of emotions they experience, when these emotions are experienced, and how they are expressed (Grandey, 2000; Gross et al., 2006). Emotional labor (Hochschild, 1983)—*deep acting* (i.e., perspective taking or self-talk in order to appear ‘real’) and *surface acting* (i.e., hiding and faking expressions like a mask)—on the other hand, represents a subtype of emotion regulation that takes place within a given work context where ‘display rules’ prescribe specific emotions that may or may not be publicly expressed (Ashforth & Humphrey, 1993; Grandey, 2000; Grandey & Gabriel, 2015; Gross, 2013; Salimzadeh et al., 2021). Emotional maturity, though, allows individuals to navigate the emotional labor of aligning personal motives with institutional imperatives, fostering congruence between individual aspirations and organizational goals. This interplay becomes crucial in modern organizations where conflicting demands necessitate emotional resilience (Saxenian, 1958).

Friedland (2018, p. 515) asserted that: “[i]nstitutional theory, and the institutional logics approach in particular, lacks the feelings that produce, sustain and disrupt institutional practice. This is due in part to rational, instrumental understandings of the individual in practice, and in part to the cognitive and linguistic understanding of that practice, sustained by classification, qualification and belief”. Voronov (2014) has encouraged institutional scholars to pay closer attention to the role of both intra- and inter-personal emotions in invigorating institutional processes and logics, so that we can better understand personal agency, embedded power, and how to better theorize about institutional change agents. However, emotions, in the main, have remained a blindspot in past theorizing and have been overlooked in institutional theory. As organizations face growing societal complexities, emotional maturity emerges as a critical yet underexplored construct. Bridging emotions and values offers a pathway to institutional sustainability, warranting deeper theoretical and empirical engagement to enhance leadership frameworks globally. We argue that foregrounding the role of emotions as value-laden, and constitutive of institutional dynamics, holds great promise for future theoretical and empirical work.

Theorizing Emotional Maturity in Post-colonial, Multicultural Workplace Settings

In post-colonial, multicultural workplace contexts such as South Africa, emotional maturity is not merely an individual competency but a relational and institutional resource. The historical legacies of colonialism and apartheid have left enduring patterns of inequality and cultural fragmentation that continue to shape organizational life. Within this environment, leaders and employees must navigate tensions between divergent cultural values, systemic inequities, and institutional logics that are often rooted in Eurocentric norms (April & Motlanthe, 2024). Emotional maturity, understood as the capacity to regulate one's emotions in alignment with both personal integrity and institutional demands (Masih & Wani, 2015), becomes a critical capability for fostering cohesion and legitimacy in such contexts. It is not enough for individuals to display emotional intelligence; rather, emotional maturity entails integrating emotional regulation with ethical reasoning, enabling actors to reconcile personal motives with institutional imperatives in ways that sustain both organizational effectiveness and social justice (Voronov, 2014).

This integration is illuminated by linking emotional maturity to moral maturity. While emotional maturity governs how individuals experience and express affect, moral maturity provides the evaluative framework through which these emotions are interpreted and acted upon. Moral maturity evolves through stages of principled reasoning grounded in justice and care (Kohlberg, 1984) and introduces ethical discernment into emotional judgments (Hedstrand, 2007). In multicultural workplaces marked by asymmetrical power relations, emotionally mature actors who also exhibit moral maturity can critically assess when conformity to institutional display rules is ethically inappropriate and when moral courage demands resistance. For example, suppressing anger in response to microaggressions may reflect emotional regulation, but naming and addressing such injustices, even at personal cost, illustrates the convergence of emotional and moral maturity (Jakimow, 2022, p. 515). Thus, emotional maturity in this context cannot be divorced from moral reflexivity; it is precisely the integration of these "two maturities" that equips organizational actors to navigate contested terrains of identity, belonging, and power.

Additionally, this theoretical framing clarifies the link between emotional maturity and emotional labor. Emotional labor involves "the management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display" (Hochschild, 1983, p. 7). Yet, in post-colonial workplaces, emotional labor extends beyond surface compliance to encompass deep alignment between personal motives

and institutional imperatives. Emotional maturity underpins this alignment by enabling individuals to authentically internalize organizational values without erasing their identities. Through self-awareness, reflective regulation, and moral discernment (Goleman, 1998; Grandey & Gabriel, 2015), emotionally mature employees engage in “deep acting” that transforms emotional labor from coerced performance into purposeful enactment. This allows them to bridge institutional logics with lived experience, fostering coherence between organizational goals and personal aspirations (Friedland, 2018, p. 516).

Crucially, in contexts where institutional histories are entangled with exclusionary practices, emotional maturity functions as a mediating resource. It supports the reconstitution of organizational cultures by mobilizing emotions as carriers of values such as fairness, empathy, and accountability (April et al., 2023). Here, emotional labor becomes not only a mechanism of individual adaptation but also a vehicle for institutional transformation. By embedding emotional and moral maturity within organizational institutionalism, we see how affective and ethical capacities sustain institutional coherence while also enabling incremental shifts toward inclusivity (Scott, 2017). In sum, emotional maturity, infused with moral reasoning, offers a dynamic framework for understanding how leaders and employees in post-colonial workplaces can perform emotional labor in ways that reconcile personal and institutional aims, thereby nurturing both organizational integrity and broader societal healing.

Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative, hermeneutic phenomenological methodology, grounded in a subjectivist ontology and interpretivist epistemology, to explore how emerging leaders make sense of emotional maturity in their workplaces. This approach is well-suited for examining phenomena embedded in lived experience, where meaning is co-constructed between researcher and participant (Bradbury-Jones et al., 2010; Lavery, 2003). Rather than imposing a predefined model, our aim was to illuminate how participants themselves narrated, conceptualized, and navigated emotional maturity, and how these understandings were shaped by institutional contexts.

Twenty-two post-experience MBA students at the University of Cape Town's Graduate School of Business, with working tenures between 3 and

13 years, participated in the study, representing diverse genders, racial identities, nationalities, and professional sectors. Consequently, the participants, from eight different nationalities and who spoke nine different languages as their first language, were split between seven Black Africans and eight White/Caucasians, with smaller representations from the five Colored/Mixed Race and two Indian/Asian participants, as defined by employment equity legislation categories. Nine identified as women and thirteen as men, and their ages ranged from 28–48. This diversity enabled a rich exploration of how emotional maturity is situated within South Africa's post-colonial, multicultural workplaces. Participants occupied mid- to senior-level leadership roles in sectors including finance, healthcare, engineering, and public administration, ensuring that their perspectives were grounded in real-world leadership challenges. Data was collected through in-depth, semi-structured interviews, conducted via video conferencing. This format balanced structure with flexibility, allowing participants to articulate their experiences in their own words and at their own pace. The open-ended nature of the questions invited them to reflect on their emotions, describe specific workplace situations, and share metaphors or language they used to make sense of emotional maturity (Qu & Dumay, 2011). This method not only elicited descriptions of experiences but also revealed the interpretive frames through which participants understood and navigated these situations.

In keeping with the hermeneutic phenomenological approach, analysis focused on iterative interpretation rather than linear coding procedures. The researchers engaged in a reflexive process of moving between parts of the data (e.g., individual narratives) and the whole (emerging conceptual patterns)—the 'hermeneutic circle'—to deepen understanding (Saunders et al., 2019). Themes such as *self-awareness*, *resilience*, *empathy*, and *fear* did not simply emerge as abstract categories; they were rooted in participants' own language and situated in their descriptions of navigating workplace hostility, reconciling personal values with organizational imperatives, and managing institutional pressures. Rather than reducing emotional maturity to static "enablers" and "barriers" only, the analysis emphasized its dynamic and processual nature. Participants described, for example, how they moved from fear to assertiveness, or how reflective practices enabled them to reframe conflict as growth opportunities. These insights underscored emotional maturity as an evolving capacity intertwined with institutional structures and norms. Importantly, participants often interpreted these shifts through metaphors ("peeling layers", "finding balance", "wearing masks") which were integral to how they understood their experiences.

Researcher reflexivity was central to this study. As hermeneutic phenomenology acknowledges that interpretation is shaped by the researcher's positionality, we engaged in ongoing reflexive journaling and peer debriefing to interrogate our assumptions (Mays & Pope, 1995). This interpretive stance aligned with our aim to situate individual narratives within broader organizational and institutional contexts, consistent with our assumption that emotional maturity is forged at the nexus of personal meaning-making and institutional dynamics. By privileging participants' voices and focusing on their sensemaking processes, this methodology provided a holistic, context-sensitive understanding of how emotional and moral maturities manifest in practice and interact with institutional demands.

Findings

The discussion to follow summarizes the main themes of emotional maturity enablers and stumbling blocks, respectively.

Enablers of Emotional Maturity

Self-Awareness

Self-awareness emerged as the most frequently cited enabler of emotional maturity, illustrating how integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism fosters coherence between individual capacities and institutional demands. Participants emphasized that recognizing emotions in the moment was essential to avoid impulsive reactions and act constructively within organizational contexts. P2 described how recognizing emotions allowed their "*rational brain to kick in*", enabling actions such as meditating or journaling. Similarly, P10 highlighted the deliberate nature of this process, noting it involves "*taking the time to think ... How can I shift my reaction to take control of the situation*". Self-awareness was also linked to humility and collaboration, qualities that reinforce institutional coherence through value-driven interactions. P6 stated, "*I try to control as much as I can, but I'm humble enough to understand there are things I can't control*", underscoring the importance of accepting limitations in complex organizational settings. This humility translated into collaborative practices, as illustrated by P20, who shared their willingness to "*let others take the lead in areas where they lacked expertise*",

aligning individual behavior with collective goals. Participants further associated self-awareness with emotional release and adaptability. P16 reflected, “*Part of emotional maturity is accepting that you can’t always get closure and learning to let it go*”, highlighting how letting go supports alignment with institutional norms and reduces personal conflict. From an institutional lens, such self-awareness aligns with *institutional reflexivity*—the ability to critically evaluate ingrained beliefs and adapt to shifting organizational values, thereby sustaining coherence. However, participants also revealed tensions between legitimate organizational values (e.g., fairness, accountability) and ‘shadow values’ (e.g., favoritism, exclusion). For marginalized groups, institutional racism and gendered expectations compounded these tensions, limiting opportunities for reflection and growth. These dynamics underscore that fostering emotional and moral maturity through reflective self-awareness is vital for reconciling personal motives with institutional imperatives, ultimately strengthening organizational integrity.

Willingly Seeking Out Different Perspectives

Seeking diverse perspectives emerged as a vital practice illustrating how integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism links emotional and moral maturity to institutional coherence. By reflecting on their biases and embracing difference, participants demonstrated how individual-level maturity can ripple outward to influence organizational cultures. P14 explained that engaging with people from varied backgrounds “*through reading, joining clubs or travel*” helped them confront and “*address their prejudices*”, underscoring the role of curiosity and openness in shaping inclusive workplace norms. Similarly, P16 emphasized the institutional value of diversity, stating that “*building teams and relationships with individuals who have different worldviews*” fosters both “*growth and innovation*”. These personal actions reflect how moral maturity, through valuing fairness and inclusion, aligns individual behavior with institutional imperatives of adaptability and resilience. P11 illustrated this interplay by noting how conversations with their spouse, “*who had not experienced apartheid*”, enabled them to “*distinguish between racism and unintentional behaviors*”, refining their emotional and ethical judgment. Yet, institutional biases and hegemonic masculinity often impeded such sensemaking, as marginalized voices were less “*acknowledged as credible or valued*”. This dynamic highlighted how emotionally and morally mature actors challenge exclusionary norms, fostering coherence by embedding inclusivity within institutional practice.

Accepting Frustration and Handling Hostility Constructively

Managing frustration and hostility revealed how emotional labor connects individual emotional and moral maturity to institutional coherence. Participants emphasized that reflective pause and deliberate response were essential in aligning emotions with organizational values. P20 explained, “*I try to take myself out of the situation and think about what I need to say. Will it offend the person? Will it escalate the issue?*” This illustrates emotional labor as ‘deep acting’, where emotionally mature individuals regulate their feelings to express them in ways that sustain constructive dialogue and institutional trust. Detachment, framed not as avoidance but as preparation for re-engagement, reflects how emotional and moral maturity underpin conflict resolution. By aligning personal motives (e.g., fairness, empathy) with institutional imperatives (e.g., collaboration), participants transformed conflict into opportunities for coherence rather than division. However, marginalized individuals reported that systemic biases and ‘shadow values’ (such as implicit tolerance of aggression) complicated this process, intensifying emotional labor demands. Yet, emotionally mature actors reframed such hostility, using reflection to enact responses consistent with inclusive values. In this way, individual maturity shaped institutional culture, embedding reflective conflict practices that reinforce organizational integrity and reconfigure exclusionary norms through value-driven emotional labor.

Self-Reflection

Self-reflection emerged as central to emotional and moral maturity, illustrating how individual meaning-making shapes institutional coherence. P2 described reflection as essential for “*understanding yourself and managing your actions in the world*”, highlighting how introspection fosters emotional regulation and value alignment. Similarly, P5 noted, “*When I don’t reflect, I won’t know that there is bias*”, underscoring reflection as a precursor to ethical discernment necessary for inclusive organizational practices. P4 emphasized structural support for such processes, stating, “*The lack of structured self-reflection opportunities limits my ability to recognize and even do something about my own biases*”. This points to how institutional conditions can either enable or constrain self-reflective emotional labor. Institutional theory situates reflection as vital for learning, unlearning, and relearning, enabling individuals to challenge entrenched ‘shadow values’ and embed fairness, empathy, and accountability into organizational cultures. Through emotional labor grounded in personal values like integrity and growth orientation, self-reflection not only regulates individual behavior but also cascades upward,

reinforcing institutional coherence and fostering transformation by dismantling exclusionary norms and reconstituting organizational practices around shared values.

The Ability to Delay Gratification

Delaying gratification exemplified how emotional labor, rooted in emotional and moral maturity, sustains institutional coherence by aligning personal discipline with organizational imperatives. P16 described, “*The sense of accomplishment from not giving in and achieving the long-term goal is so much better*”, illustrating how regulating immediate impulses fosters resilience crucial for value-driven leadership. Similarly, P13 emphasized balance, noting that “*occasional rewards throughout the process help maintain motivation*”, reflecting how emotional labor involves sustaining motivation while managing competing demands. From an institutional perspective, this practice bridges individual perseverance with long-term organizational goals. Yet, systemic inequities, particularly for women and people of color, intensified the emotional labor required, as disproportionate workloads and limited advancement opportunities strained their capacity for delayed rewards. Here, integrating emotions and values reveals how perseverance and discipline not only regulate individual behavior but also reinforce institutional stability, while challenging ‘shadow values’ of impatience and short-termism that undermine inclusive and sustainable organizational progress.

Vulnerability and Authenticity

Vulnerability emerged as a critical dimension of emotional labor, revealing how emotional and moral maturity foster institutional coherence by embedding authenticity and trust into organizational life. P6 reflected, “*Being vulnerable allows us to create meaningful bonds and improve communication*”, illustrating how emotional labor involves regulated openness that strengthens relational ties and aligns personal values with institutional goals. Similarly, P5 observed that concealing vulnerabilities “*often led to a gap between their true selves and how others perceived them*”, highlighting how emotional authenticity bridges individual identity and institutional integrity.

However, participants underscored the need for discernment. As P8 cautioned, “*It needs to be appropriate to the circumstance and not used to manipulate others*”, pointing to the moral maturity required to enact vulnerability responsibly. For marginalized participants, vulnerability carried heightened risk, constrained by stereotypes and systemic biases. Yet, when grounded in

honesty and empathy, vulnerability challenged 'shadow values', disrupted outdated norms, and enacted emotional labor that reconstituted workplace cultures around trust and inclusivity, reinforcing institutional coherence through value-driven practice.

Empathy

Empathy emerged as crucial for integrating emotions and values within organisational institutionalism, revealing how emotional and moral maturity foster institutional coherence. P10 stated, "*The key to dialogue is empathy ... not just understanding intellectually but making a heart-to-heart connection*". Similarly, P18 noted that shared feelings enable connection: "*Even if I can't relate to their situation, I can connect to their emotions*". Such emotional labor illustrates how individual-level maturity triggers broader organizational effects, aligning with institutional theory's focus on relational practices. Conversely, institutional dynamics like 'power over others' can suppress empathy, reinforcing stereotypes and divisions. Participants underscored that personal values, such as compassion and openness, underpin empathy, while 'shadow values' like apathy and judgment inhibit it. This interplay highlights the reciprocal influence between individual maturity and institutional culture, emphasizing empathy as both a driver and outcome of emotionally attuned, coherent organizations.

Accountability

Accountability, framed through emotional labor and institutional theory, underscores how integrating emotions and values fosters emotional and moral maturity, which, in turn, drives institutional coherence. P2 linked accountability to control and purpose: "*I always want to be in control, and accountability gives me a sense of safety and certainty*". Similarly, P3 reflected, "*Change starts from within. If something isn't done properly, it's my responsibility*". Such expressions of emotional labor illustrate how individual-level maturity influences organizational integrity while being shaped by institutional expectations. Participants also emphasized how accountability intersects with 'workplace democracy', challenging principal-agent assumptions and demonstrating that institutional factors shape 'democratic accountability' (e.g., who is properly held to account, who has access to information, who has voice, standards of performance assessment, and who consciously and unconsciously carries authority). P22 noted that marginalized individuals "*often have unequal opportunities and unequal power to re-negotiate*

norms”; other participants noted how they felt powerless (even when empowered in managerial positions) to challenge inequalities and extend their access (empowered powerlessness), exposing structural barriers that undermine fairness. Thus, accountability is not merely compliance but reflects the interplay between individual agency and institutional norms and embedded power structures. Personal values like integrity and responsibility strengthen accountability, whereas ‘shadow values’, such as blame-shifting, avoidance and even ‘equality-speak’ without active institutional structural deconstruction, erode it, reinforcing the reciprocal relationship between individual maturity and institutional culture.

Self-Care

Self-care, framed through emotional labor and institutional theory, reflects how integrating emotions and values fosters emotional and moral maturity, sustaining institutional coherence. P15 noted, “*I meet regularly with a coach and therapist to stay in control of my mental state and ensure I’m not a victim of my environment*”, while P19 described meditation and running as effective tools to manage frustration and maintain focus. P16 stressed, “*Setting boundaries allows everyone to interact on a comfortable playing field*”, highlighting how boundary-setting supports relational balance. Similarly, P6 emphasized safeguarding personal values, particularly during ethical dilemmas. These practices demonstrate how individual-level maturity reinforces institutional resilience, while institutional cultures can either enable or constrain such self-care. For marginalized individuals, inequities often exacerbate these constraints, limiting access to supportive practices. Personal values such as self-respect and balance strengthen well-being, whereas ‘shadow values’ like overcommitment or martyrdom undermine it. This interplay shows how emotionally mature self-care practices influence institutional sustainability, while institutional support reciprocally shapes individual capacity for emotional labor and resilience.

The Ability to Deal with Criticism Constructively

Emotional labor in processing criticism underscores how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity, promoting institutional coherence. P9 shared, “*I unpack criticism to understand its validity and use it to better myself*”, reflecting how maturity at the individual level supports growth. Yet, P7 highlighted the tension between individual agency and institutional norms: “*Because my supervisor’s orientation is to skirt away from negative assessments, I think that*

I find it more difficult to deal with negative assessments from other supervisors and colleagues". This illustrates how institutional cultures shape emotional responses to feedback. Similarly, P11 stated, "*Criticism helps develop me into a better person*", emphasizing how separating constructive feedback from emotional reactions supports learning. However, marginalized participants noted difficulty distinguishing constructive feedback from biased scrutiny, complicating their ability to benefit from it. This aligns with institutional theory's focus on feedback loops as mechanisms for improvement while revealing how institutional inequities impede this process. Personal values like humility and adaptability enable individuals to engage in this emotional labor productively, while 'shadow values' such as defensiveness or pride obstruct it. These dynamics reveal the reciprocal influence between individual maturity and institutional cultures, showing how feedback practices can both reinforce and be shaped by emotional maturity.

Learning from Past Experiences

Emotional labor in reflecting on past experiences demonstrates how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity, reinforcing institutional coherence. P3 noted, "*Past experiences provide data and knowledge that help optimize future situations*", highlighting how individual maturity shapes decision-making. Similarly, P20 stated, "*If you're not learning from past experiences, you're not growing as an individual*", linking personal growth to institutional adaptability. Institutional theory supports this by emphasizing organizational memory as a mechanism for leveraging historical insights to guide future practices. However, P12 critiqued the limitations of this view: "*We are just supposed to have a blinkered acceptance of how the organization has been set up in the apartheid past, without an appreciation of its racialized, capitalistic roots and unequal access*". Institutional theory's blind spot, in narrowly focusing on how historical workplace practices become legitimate and accepting the resultant, asymmetries of power in processes of institutionalization, is illuminated by such insights. Personal values such as reflection and resilience enable individuals to engage in this emotional labor productively, turning past experiences into tools for growth, while 'shadow values' like regret or denial obstruct learning. These dynamics illustrate how individual maturity and institutional memory mutually shape one another, driving deeper coherence or perpetuating systemic blind spots.

Stumbling blocks of Emotional Maturity

Fear

Fear, framed through emotional labor and institutional theory, emerged as the most frequently cited challenge, shaping how participants interacted within organizational contexts. Emotional and moral maturity in navigating fear highlights how integrating emotions and values fosters institutional coherence while revealing how individual-level phenomena influence institutional structures and vice versa. P10 remarked, “*Fear of being vulnerable comes from an inability to trust*”, illustrating how fear impedes open communication and reinforces hierarchical norms. Gendered expectations compounded this, with participants noting that men, in particular, face pressure to repress vulnerability, perpetuating emotional suppression in professional settings. Conflicting values further deepened this tension: while formal organizational values may endorse transparency, ‘shadow values’ which prioritize power and control discourage vulnerability. P9 reflected, “*It’s taken me a long time to formulate my own opinion ... A fear of sounding stupid or not being on the same level as others*”, pointing to institutional pressures to conform. For marginalized employees, institutional racism intensified these pressures, stifling authenticity and forcing assimilation to dominant norms, clashing with personal values like integrity. Fear of expressing honest opinions also surfaced. P7 shared, “*I regret that I didn’t defend my position ... In the future, I would have to be brave to raise my concerns*”, underscoring how perceived power imbalances discourage dissent. Systemic biases amplified this fear for marginalized groups, where ‘shadow values’ of discouraging dissent undermine honesty and courage. Past failures also fuelled fear. P6 stated, “*Failure in the past creates fear in the present*”, illustrating how institutional memory stigmatizes mistakes. Marginalized participants described how discrimination and microaggressions magnified such fears, deterring risk-taking. This reflects tensions between espoused values supporting innovation and shadow cultures penalizing failure. Fear additionally constrained delayed gratification. P9 noted, “*The feeling that it might not happen creates a state of panic*”, linking short-term pressures to institutional dynamics that prioritize urgency over long-term thinking. For those facing systemic inequities, mistrust in future opportunities intensified this urgency. Here, personal values like patience and perseverance conflict with ‘shadow values’ privileging immediacy. Collectively, these insights reveal how fear, as emotional labor, is embedded in institutional contexts. Addressing it requires aligning personal values (trust, integrity, resilience) with institutional cultures to reduce shadow practices

that perpetuate power imbalances and emotional suppression. Emotional and moral maturity at the individual level can trigger institutional transformation by modelling authenticity, fostering openness, and challenging inequities, while supportive institutional norms can, in turn, empower individuals to transcend fear. This reciprocal relationship underscores how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism is central to cultivating coherence, dismantling oppressive structures, and enabling inclusive, emotionally attuned workplaces.

Transference and Institutional Patterns

Transference, understood as emotional labor, illustrates how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism reveals the reciprocal relationship between individual maturity and institutional dynamics. It highlights how emotional and moral maturity can foster institutional coherence by disrupting entrenched patterns. Many participants connected transference to formative experiences. P21 shared, “*Growing up in a house with a lot of yelling ... I tend to shut down emotionally when things get heated*”. Similarly, P4 explained, “*My father was very strict, and I learned to shut down*”. These responses show how institutionalized family dynamics influence emotional regulation in professional settings. Gendered expectations amplified these patterns. Women described being socialized to “*prioritize harmony and know their place*”, while men felt pressure to suppress vulnerability and “*look after others*”. Such conditioning creates ‘shadow values’, like conflict avoidance, that challenge personal values of emotional resilience. P9 recalled, “*An accounting teacher ruined accounting for me ... It planted a self-criticism around numbers*”, illustrating how authority figures embed institutional biases shaping self-perception. For marginalized participants, stereotypes about intellectual inferiority compounded these effects, creating tension between personal values of self-worth and organizational ‘shadow values’ reinforcing bias. Participants also used transference defensively. P1 admitted, “*I pull away in relationships due to past disappointments*”. This protective mechanism reflects how institutional norms perpetuate avoidance cycles. Women and participants of color particularly employed such strategies in undervaluing environments. ‘Shadow organizational values’, prioritizing competition over collaboration and relational growth, further entrenched detachment. These findings underscore how emotional labor linked to transference operates across individual and institutional levels. Addressing it requires aligning personal values (resilience, self-worth) with institutional cultures that dismantle ‘shadow values’, fostering collaboration and inclusivity. Emotional and moral maturity not only mitigates defensive behaviors

but also catalyzes institutional coherence by reshaping norms rooted in past institutionalized experiences.

Impulsive Reactions and Institutional Contexts

Impulsive reactions, framed as emotional labor, reveal how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity while exposing tensions between individual behavior and institutional norms. P9 shared, “*Someone cut me off, and I reacted aggressively*”, illustrating how institutional pressures to maintain composure can give way to explosive responses when breached. Gendered expectations further shaped this dynamic, with women participants reporting harsher judgment for emotional reactions. ‘Shadow organizational values’, such as cultures of unchecked competition, were noted as exacerbating these triggers. In professional contexts, impulsive behavior often strained relationships. P13 reflected on yelling at a manager over a canceled project: “*That bridge was burnt*”, highlighting how individual frustration clashed with institutional expectations for professionalism. Marginalized participants noted that such reactions were disproportionately scrutinized, reinforcing stereotypes of emotional instability and amplifying institutional inequities. ‘Shadow values’ prioritizing performance over relational well-being intensified these outcomes. Yet, some participants reframed impulsivity as growth-oriented. P16 stated, “*I hope to take it as a learning experience and give a better response in the future*”. This reflects how emotional and moral maturity at the individual level can transform impulsive episodes into opportunities for reflection. Institutional theory underscores the importance of supportive structures that promote learning over punishment, particularly for marginalized groups. Aligning legitimate values of reflection and growth with institutional practices can counter ‘shadow values’ rooted in punitive responses, fostering coherence between individual maturity and organizational culture. This integration not only mitigates impulsivity but strengthens institutional resilience through emotionally attuned practices.

Blame-Shifting and Criticism

Blame-shifting and difficulty accepting criticism, framed as emotional labor, reveal how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity while exposing the influence of institutional dynamics. P6 admitted, “*When I fail, I unconsciously look for external factors to blame*”, illustrating how hierarchical and competitive

environments stigmatize failure, encouraging deflection rather than accountability. Women and people of color described heightened self-blame linked to systemic biases that impose additional scrutiny, while ‘shadow organizational values’ discouraging accountability further reinforced these tendencies. Criticism was particularly complex across contexts. P14 shared, “*At work, it’s easier to address criticism. At home, it feels like an attack on my personality*”, underscoring how depersonalized workplace feedback can feel less emotionally charged compared to personal settings. Yet, some women noted gendered criticism blurred professional and personal lines, complicating emotional responses. This tension highlights how personal values of self-improvement clash with ‘shadow values’ rooted in judgment and blame. Ego-driven reactions also emerged. P9 confessed, “*I reacted out of ego; I didn’t want to be wrong*”. Similarly, P14 acknowledged, “*I’m a perfectionist; accepting blame feels like admitting I’m not perfect*”. Competitive institutional norms reinforce such behaviors, while marginalized participants noted perfectionism as a strategy to counteract biases and prove credibility. Several also linked this to neoliberal ‘shadow values’ emphasizing relentless achievement and ever-expanding goals, which intensify pressure. Addressing these dynamics requires fostering emotional and moral maturity at the individual level, anchored in humility and accountability, while reshaping institutional cultures to value learning and adaptability over judgment. This integration can dismantle ego-driven, perfectionist norms, aligning personal growth with institutional coherence.

Egocentric Tendencies

Ego-driven behaviors, framed as emotional labor, illustrate how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism highlights the tension between individual maturity and institutional norms. P7 admitted, “*I sometimes dismiss ideas from subordinates due to my ego*”, showing how hierarchical structures reinforce authority over collaboration. For women leaders, such behaviors were judged more harshly due to gendered expectations that emphasize nurturing and teamwork, reflecting how ‘shadow organizational values’ prioritize hierarchy and individual dominance over inclusion and relationality. Egocentricity often had serious consequences. P12 shared, “*I didn’t ask my supervisor for help, leading to patient mismanagement*”, underscoring how ego can undermine institutional protocols, especially in high-stakes contexts. Women participants frequently described reluctance to seek help (especially early on) due to fears of being perceived as incompetent, illustrating how systemic biases amplify this emotional labor. ‘Shadow values’ rooted in individualism and competition can weaken legitimate values of teamwork and psychological safety.

P12 further critiqued institutional practices: “*Colonization and its modern face, neo-liberal capitalism, really tries to impose and sustain the Western-oriented workplace practices that have become acceptable in South Africa ... without an appreciation of our communal Ubuntu and communal orientations in our context*”. Here, personal values tied to relationally-based Ubuntu and collaboration challenge institutional logics steeped in individualism, revealing how emotional and moral maturity can disrupt entrenched ‘shadow values’ and foster institutional coherence.

Bias and Prejudice

Recognizing and addressing bias, framed as emotional labor, illustrates how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity, which is essential for institutional coherence. P6 admitted, “*I was done assessing them within 10 minutes*”, revealing how ingrained norms shape snap judgments and perpetuate inequitable evaluations. Such biases mirror institutionalized preferences that privilege familiarity over fairness. Women and people of color highlighted how unconscious and socially implicit bias created systemic barriers to job access, networks, mentoring, career progression, managerial support, and trust from colleagues. ‘Shadow organizational values’ privileging homogeneity and homosocial reproduction—particularly in environments dominated by white, male-identified, heterosexual, able-bodied, middle-to-upper class elites—were cited as reinforcing exclusion and entrenching unequal power structures. P15 reflected on role-based stereotypes: “*We often assume they’re not technically inclined*”, underscoring how institutional prejudice, including privileging STEM qualifications or elite schooling backgrounds, fosters divisions. These patterns reveal how institutional structures normalize bias while sidelining personal values like fairness and inclusion. Addressing such bias requires emotional and moral maturity to confront ‘shadow values’ and champion equitable practices. This reciprocal relationship shows how individual-level interventions, rooted in self-awareness and inclusion, can challenge institutionalized prejudice, fostering cultural transformation and institutional coherence.

Cultural Influences

Cultural norms, framed through emotional labor, reveal how integrating emotions and values within organizational institutionalism fosters emotional and moral maturity while exposing tensions between cultural frameworks and institutional demands. P4 stated, “*In my culture, the chief is never wrong. You*

take the blame”, illustrating how deference to authority aligns with hierarchical institutional structures and reinforces compliance. For white, Indian/Asian, and Colored/mixed-race/creole/Camissa employees in African black-dominated public sectors, and for women and all people of color in white-dominated private sectors, such norms reinforced silence in the face of systemic inequities. ‘Shadow organizational values’ prioritizing authority over dialogue directly conflicted with personal values of justice and accountability. Participants also described cultural restrictions on vulnerability. P12 reflected, “*In my culture, men are taught not to be, or even appear, vulnerable*”, showing how stoic expectations clash with institutional demands for emotional intelligence. Women reported added emotional labor, expected to manage others’ needs while their own went unaddressed, leading to gender fatigue and deteriorating well-being. These dynamics underscore how ‘shadow values’ of stoicism and compliance inhibit emotional maturity. Aligning institutional practices with inclusive values that respect cultural contexts while fostering emotional openness can create coherence between individual maturity and organizational transformation.

Gratification and Anxiety

Anxiety, framed as emotional labor, often hindered participants’ ability to delay gratification, highlighting how integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism links individual maturity to institutional coherence. P3 admitted, “*I need quick feedback; long processes take away my motivation*”, illustrating how institutional environments prioritizing efficiency intensify anxiety. Marginalized participants described entering workplaces under heightened pressure to prove themselves quickly, often feeling they represented their entire group. This amplified impatience and reflected how systemic inequities intersect with institutional norms. ‘Shadow values’ of urgency were identified as conflicting with personal values like patience and strategic thinking. P9 connected their impatience to early experiences, stating, “*I didn’t have the luxury of waiting for better opportunities*”. This reflects institutional scarcity narratives, rooted in societal exclusion from resources and opportunities, which reinforce survivalist instincts. For marginalized participants, impatience was framed as both an emotional and adaptive response to inequities and stereotypes about their identity. ‘Shadow organizational values’ privileging short-term gains over long-term stability further compounded these pressures. Addressing such anxiety requires aligning institutional practices with values fostering patience, inclusion, and long-term development, demonstrating how individual maturity in managing

anxiety can influence organizational norms and, conversely, how institutional reform can reduce emotional burdens.

Contextual Variations

Participants emphasized how contextual variations shaped their reactions, underscoring emotional labor and its role in linking individual maturity to institutional dynamics. Institutional theory explains how different environments elicit distinct behaviors. P1 noted, *"In professional settings, I keep my feelings to myself; at home, I respond more freely"*, reflecting how institutional norms encourage emotional restraint in workplaces. P11 shared, *"I don't have the luxury of being able to bring my Africanness to the workplace ... not if I want to succeed. I have to adopt white behaviors at work ... speak like them, do and talk about their hobbies and sports, dress like them, go to their neighborhoods and restaurants"*. This highlights how code-switching, driven by racialized expectations and white, heterosexual male dominance in senior roles, demands emotional suppression and conformity, undermining personal authenticity. High-pressure environments further magnified these challenges. P2 stated, *"I react differently in calm versus high-pressure environments"*, illustrating how institutional stress intensifies emotional responses. Marginalized participants described concealing anxiety fuelled by biased interactions, microaggressions, and unfounded stereotypes. 'Shadow values' prioritizing results over well-being worsened these stressors. Crises exacerbated such dynamics. P21 reflected, *"Since the [Covid-19] pandemic, everything has been made harder; I'm practicing self-kindness"*. P3 added, *"When a crisis threatens one's livelihood and ways of working, and compounds existing challenges, you need greater personal resilience ... you need some pillars to turn to or which you can rely on"*. These insights reveal how personal values of self-care and resilience clash with 'shadow values' of relentless productivity. Integrating emotions and values fosters emotional and moral maturity, enabling individuals to challenge institutional pressures and, in turn, drive organizational coherence through adaptive, human-centred practices.

Emotional Maturity Connection in Aligning Personal Values and Organizational Imperatives

The connection between emotional maturity and institutional imperatives lies in its capacity to align personal values with organizational goals, with emotional labor functioning as the bridge between these levels. Emotional maturity, as evidenced in the findings, encompasses self-awareness, reflective practices, empathy, and resilience, enabling individuals to regulate emotions

while maintaining integrity and principled behavior within complex organizational contexts. This alignment fosters institutional coherence by ensuring that personal conduct reinforces shared organizational values, such as trust, inclusivity, and accountability.

Emotional labor operationalizes this alignment by mediating how individuals express and manage emotions within institutional 'display rules'. For emotionally mature individuals, emotional labor moves beyond surface compliance to 'deep acting', where values such as fairness and empathy are authentically enacted in service of institutional objectives. This process not only stabilizes organizational culture but also enables value-driven change, particularly in contexts shaped by historical inequities or systemic bias. Participants demonstrated that emotional maturity allowed them to resist 'shadow values' like favoritism or exclusion while embedding legitimate values into organizational practice, reshaping norms from within.

This dynamic underscores a reciprocal relationship: institutional structures shape emotional maturity by setting behavioral and emotional expectations, while emotionally mature individuals engage in value-laden emotional labor that reinforces, challenges, or transforms those very structures. Thus, emotional maturity and emotional labor jointly mediate the interplay between personal values and institutional imperatives, positioning individuals as agents of both organizational stability and evolution. Cultivating this integration is essential for fostering emotionally attuned, inclusive workplaces capable of responding to contemporary socio-cultural and institutional complexities.

Connection: Dimensions of Emotional Maturity and Moral Maturity

The findings point to an interdependence between emotional maturity and moral maturity, where neither can be understood in isolation. Emotional maturity provides the affective grounding (self-awareness, empathy, reflective capacity, and resilience) that enables individuals to regulate emotions in ways that are contextually appropriate. Moral maturity, however, introduces the evaluative dimension, supplying the ethical compass through which emotions are interpreted and enacted. When participants described pausing before reacting to hostility or criticism, they not only demonstrated emotional regulation but also a moral discernment about fairness, respect, and responsibility. This illustrates how emotional maturity without moral anchoring risks compliance with unjust norms, while moral maturity without emotional regulation may fail to translate values into sustainable relational practice.

The interplay between these maturities is particularly salient in post-colonial, multicultural settings, where institutional ‘shadow values’ such as exclusion or favoritism often undermine espoused commitments to fairness and inclusion. Here, emotional maturity enables actors to manage the affective strain of navigating inequities, while moral maturity equips them to judge when institutional expectations should be resisted. The capacity to align emotional regulation with principled action reflects institutional reflexivity: the ability to interrogate and reshape norms from within.

Ultimately, emotional and moral maturity work together as micro-foundations of institutional coherence. Their integration allows leaders and employees not only to sustain trust and stability but also to model inclusive and value-driven practices that gradually transform organizational cultures. This dual maturity thus provides the affective and ethical infrastructure for reconciling personal integrity with institutional imperatives in complex, diverse workplaces.

Discussion

When initiating this research, the literature reviewed was used to establish a theoretical guideline, which was then explored within the confines of this study. Although the literature revealed no order of importance of enablers and stumbling blocks, from the findings of this study, some themes clearly emerged as stronger drivers than others. The researchers also observed some interconnectivity between some of the enablers and stumbling blocks. To enhance the discussion from the above-mentioned insights, a framework was developed (Fig. 21.1).

The findings from this study illuminate the complex interplay between individual emotional and moral maturities and broader organizational and institutional contexts, underscoring the central assumption that “integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism reveals a dynamic framework for understanding how emotional maturity fosters institutional coherence”. By situating emotional maturity within an institutional framework, this study advances the argument that individual affective capacities do not merely serve personal or interpersonal functions but operate as critical drivers of organizational stability, cultural coherence, and institutional transformation, particularly in South Africa’s post-colonial, multicultural workplace settings.

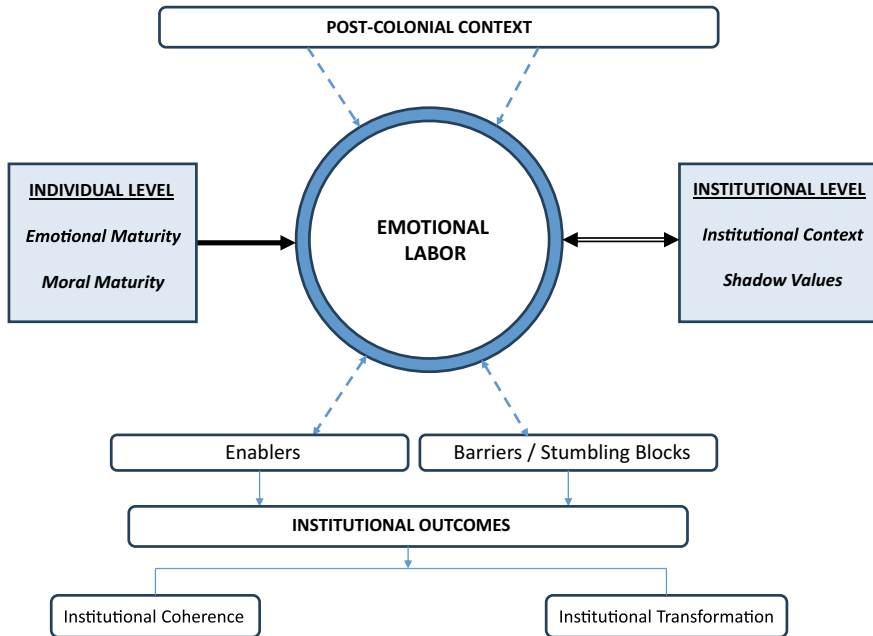


Fig. 21.1 Emotional maturity enablers and stumbling blocks framework

Emotional and Moral Maturities as Micro-Foundations of Institutional Coherence

At the individual level, emotional maturity emerged as a multi-dimensional construct grounded in self-awareness, reflective practices, empathy, and resilience. Participants demonstrated how these capabilities allowed them to regulate affective responses and navigate challenging environments in ways that aligned with both personal integrity and institutional expectations. Emotional maturity in this sense aligns with Alexander's (1967) conceptualization of maturity as a dynamic capacity to flexibly respond to varying situational demands. However, our findings also indicate that emotional maturity alone is insufficient without moral maturity, which introduces an evaluative lens rooted in internalized values and ethical reasoning (Hedstrand, 2007; Kohlberg, 1984). Participants' experiences revealed that emotional regulation devoid of ethical judgment often resulted in compliance with unjust display rules or avoidance of conflict, perpetuating institutional inequities. Conversely, where emotional maturity was combined with moral discernment, participants resisted 'shadow values' (such as favoritism, exclusion, or systemic bias) and modelled principled behaviors that challenged

entrenched organizational norms. This integration of the two maturities foregrounds how micro-level affective and ethical capacities become generative forces for institutional reflexivity and change (Voronov, 2014). In this sense, emotional and moral maturities constitute micro-foundations of institutional coherence, acting as conduits between personal experience and organizational value systems. They enable individuals to navigate tensions between divergent institutional logics, reconcile personal motives with organizational imperatives, and embody values in ways that reinforce shared purpose and trust (Scott, 2017).

Emotional Labour as a Bridge Between the Individual and the Institution

The study's findings further clarify the relationship between emotional maturity and emotional labour. Hochschild's (1983) notion of emotional labor, particularly 'deep acting', provides a useful frame for understanding how emotionally mature individuals internalize organizational values and display emotions congruent with institutional imperatives. Participants described how self-awareness and empathy enabled them to engage in authentic forms of emotional labor, aligning their internal states with organizational expectations without compromising their identities. In contrast, when emotional immaturity prevailed, marked by impulsivity, fear, or defensive ego behaviors, emotional labor became surface-level compliance, often accompanied by dissonance and burnout. Thus, emotional maturity transforms emotional labor from a mechanism of control into a vehicle for congruence, where individuals' affective alignment sustains institutional coherence by bridging personal aspirations and organizational goals (Grandey & Gabriel, 2015). Also, this alignment is not merely stabilizing. In multicultural and historically racialized contexts like South Africa, emotionally and morally mature leaders use emotional labor not only to reproduce institutional norms but also to reconfigure them toward inclusivity. Their 'deep acting' entails not simply conforming to existing display rules but reinterpreting and reshaping them, embedding values such as fairness, empathy, and accountability into institutional practice (Friedland, 2018).

Institutional Dynamics Shaping and Being Shaped by Emotional Maturity

The relationship between individual-level maturities and institutional dynamics is inherently bidirectional. As Scott (2017) notes, institutional logics and structures impose normative and cultural constraints on emotional

expression. Participants' accounts highlighted how deeply embedded historical legacies of colonialism and apartheid continue to shape emotional display rules in organizations. Marginalized employees described pressures to assimilate into Eurocentric workplace cultures, often through emotional suppression and code-switching, reflecting how institutions shape affective experiences and limit authentic expression (April & Motlanthe, 2024). Yet, the findings also demonstrate how emotionally and morally mature actors can serve as institutional change agents. Through reflective self-awareness and principled emotional labor, participants challenged discriminatory practices and advocated for more inclusive organizational cultures. This aligns with Voronov's (2014) call for integrating emotions into institutional theory to better explain agency and change within institutional contexts. For example, participants who engaged in empathetic leadership practices cultivated trust and psychological safety, enabling teams to question entrenched norms without fear of reprisal. Here, emotional maturity functioned as an institutional resource that not only sustained coherence but also facilitated gradual value shifts toward inclusivity and equity.

Key Themes Anchored in Emotions and Values

The themes identified (self-awareness, reflective practice, learning from experience, fear regulation, and empathy) demonstrate how emotional maturity is deeply embedded within institutional contexts:

- **Self-awareness** provided the foundation for regulating affect within institutionally defined boundaries while enabling critical reflection on these very boundaries (Kapri & Rani, 2014).
- **Reflective practices** served as mechanisms for interrogating both personal biases and institutional norms, fostering what Scott (2008) terms 'institutional reflexivity'.
- **Learning from past experiences** (Mezirow, 1990) illuminated how historical organizational practices continue to shape current emotional scripts, highlighting the need for discriminatory judgment (Alexander, 1967) to discern when past patterns should be challenged or retained.
- **Fear**, identified as a major stumbling block, revealed how institutionalized hierarchies and systemic inequities constrain emotional expression, creating environments where defensive behaviors undermine both individual growth and institutional coherence (Scarnati, 1998).
- **Empathy and perspective-taking**, by contrast, emerged as enablers of inclusive leadership, demonstrating how emotions can bridge differences in

multicultural contexts and align diverse actors around shared values (April et al., 2023).

Together, these findings underscore that emotions are not merely personal or interpersonal phenomena but are constitutive of institutional life, shaping both organizational coherence and possibilities for change (Friedland, 2018).

Implications for Theory and Practice

The integration of emotions and values within organizational institutionalism offers several theoretical contributions. First, it extends institutional theory by positioning emotional and moral maturities as mechanisms through which institutional logics are both reproduced and disrupted. This moves beyond traditional rationalist accounts by showing how affective and ethical capacities ground institutional coherence while also enabling agents to challenge exclusionary practices. Second, it reframes emotional labor as a process of value enactment rather than mere compliance. Emotional labor performed by emotionally mature individuals embodies institutional values authentically, thereby reinforcing legitimacy and cohesion (Grandey & Gabriel, 2015). Third, it emphasizes that institutional transformation is affectively mediated. In South Africa's post-colonial workplaces, where institutional histories carry the residues of exclusion, emotionally mature leaders play a critical role in reshaping organizational cultures. By aligning emotional expression with moral reasoning, they embed inclusive values into organizational routines, thereby reconstituting institutional logics from within. Practically, these insights highlight the importance of leadership development programs that integrate emotional and moral maturity training into institutional contexts. Organizations must go beyond teaching emotional intelligence skills to fostering reflective, values-driven approaches to emotional regulation that prepare leaders to navigate complex socio-historical dynamics.

Conclusion

This study reinforces the view that emotional maturity is not merely an individual trait but a dynamic, multi-level phenomenon deeply embedded within organizational and institutional contexts. By foregrounding our core assumption (i.e., that integrating emotions and values in organizational institutionalism provides a dynamic framework for understanding how emotional maturity fosters institutional coherence), we show that emotional and moral

maturities are not isolated personal attributes but foundational mechanisms that link individual agency to institutional logics and organizational practices.

Our findings demonstrate that emotional maturity, when coupled with moral maturity, equips individuals with the capacity to regulate emotions in ways that are both ethically grounded and institutionally relevant. This dual maturity enables leaders and employees to navigate the demands of organizational life while sustaining integrity and aligning with core values. At the individual level, emotional and moral maturities foster resilience, empathy, and reflective self-awareness, which not only improve interpersonal functioning but also ripple upward, reinforcing institutional coherence by anchoring behavior in shared values.

Conversely, the institutional environment shapes these maturities in profound ways. Organizational cultures, rooted in historical and socio-political contexts such as South Africa's post-colonial legacy, establish display rules, value hierarchies, and normative frameworks that influence how emotions are experienced and expressed. These institutional structures can either constrain emotional expression, through implicit demands for conformity and emotional suppression, or provide enabling conditions for emotional development, such as reflective spaces and inclusive leadership practices. Thus, emotional maturity is forged at the intersection of personal agency and institutional forces.

Furthermore, this study illustrates how emotional labor functions as a bridge between personal capacities and institutional imperatives. Emotionally mature individuals engage in 'deep acting', authentically internalizing organizational values and performing emotional labor that aligns personal motives with institutional goals. This alignment not only sustains organizational trust and coherence but also enables institutional transformation: leaders and employees who bring emotional and moral reflexivity into their emotional labor challenge exclusionary practices, embedding new values such as inclusivity, fairness, accountability and justice into organizational routines. This demonstrates that individual-level phenomena can actively reshape institutional logics, positioning emotionally and morally mature actors as institutional change agents.

By situating emotional maturity within organizational institutionalism, this research contributes to a multi-level understanding of leadership and institutional change. It underscores that emotional maturity does not simply respond to institutional demands but actively mediates the reproduction and evolution of those very institutions. In multicultural, post-colonial workplace settings, this bidirectional relationship is particularly salient: while institutions condition emotional experience, emotionally mature actors equipped

with moral discernment can disrupt entrenched power dynamics and reconstitute institutional norms toward inclusivity and coherence.

In practical terms, these insights call for leadership development frameworks that explicitly integrate emotional and moral maturity into institutional contexts. Organizations must create enabling structures (including reflective practices, inclusive policies, and value-driven cultures) that nurture these maturities while recognizing their critical role in sustaining institutional trust and coherence. This also implies that institutional theory must fully embrace emotions and values, not as peripheral considerations, but as constitutive elements of organizational life and institutional change.

In conclusion, this study bridges the micro (individual) and macro (institutional) levels, demonstrating how emotional and moral maturities provide the affective and ethical foundations through which institutional coherence is both sustained and transformed. By integrating emotions and values into organizational institutionalism, we present a dynamic, relational framework that captures how personal development and institutional evolution are inextricably linked, offering a pathway for cultivating inclusive, coherent, and values-driven organizations.

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22

Executive Decision-Making in the Face of Competing Demands: The Role of Emotions and Values

Thora Lou and Inger G. Stensaker

Introduction

In complex and highly institutionalized contexts, organizational members are often confronted with competing demands, which can create conflict and tension, leading to challenges in decision-making. Institutionalized contexts include hospitals, where the logic of managerialism may confront the logic of medical professionalism (Reay & Hinings, 2009), and universities, where conflicts may arise among the logics of autonomy, utilitarianism, and managerialism (Shields & Watermeyer, 2020). With their conflicting logics, these complex contexts are particularly prone to generating competing demands for executives. While some researchers have argued that competing demands can be resolved at the organizational level by privileging one goal or demand over the other or by structurally separating the distinct goals within an organization (Poole & Van de Ven, 1989; Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996), others have suggested that incompatible goals and demands cannot always be

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“organized away” but instead need to be managed continuously on a day-to-day basis by individuals embedded in those contexts (e.g., Smith & Lewis, 2011).

For executives, dealing with competing demands means making decisions with no absolute answers, as the paradoxical nature of situations pushes arguments in opposing directions. Strategic decision-making is a crucial component of effective executive leadership. Increasingly volatile external contexts may exacerbate both organizational complexity and the consequences of top executives’ strategic decision-making, with long-lasting implications for organizations and their people. Therefore, in this chapter, we examine if and how senior executives operating in highly institutionalized contexts incorporate competing demands as they make difficult and important strategic decisions.

Existing research suggests that rationality often falls short when making decisions in the face of competing demands, which can lead to emotional strain (e.g., Miron-Spektor et al., 2018; Smith & Lewis, 2011). In the context of competing demands, emotions and personal values are thus liable to influence the decision-making of senior executives. What remains unclear, however, is how senior executives are influenced by their personal values—that is, their beliefs regarding appropriate behavior (Bettenhausen & Murnighan, 1985; Gioia & Poole, 1984)—and their emotional responses to tensions from competing demands as they make impactful decisions.

To explore the role of emotions and values in decision-making under competing demands, we draw on a recent paradox-hermeneutic phenomenological study of 10 senior executives in complex organizational contexts. Based on the lived experiences of these executives, we present two distinct decision-making processes that involve emotions and values to different extents. Drawing on paradox theory, we discuss how emotions and values can help executives sustain their decision-making capacity amid intense and ongoing organizational tensions from competing demands. We elaborate on the importance of emotional equanimity and how executives build this capacity.

Theoretical Background

Interdependent and persistent competing demands—you cannot have one without the other, and they are impossible to eliminate—have been conceptualized as organizational paradoxes (Smith & Lewis, 2011). Due to the persistent nature of organizational paradoxes, individuals addressing them

must find ways to continuously integrate competing demands by incorporating the competing issues into their decision-making. As emotions are essential in paradox theory (Miron-Spektor et al., 2018), we consider a paradox lens both appropriate and valuable for investigating the role of values and emotions in executive decision-making.

Paradoxes, Cognitive Complexity, and Emotions

Smith and Lewis (2011) defined organizational paradoxes as “contradictory yet interrelated elements that exist simultaneously and persist over time” (p. 382). The process of breathing can illustrate interdependence; after inhaling, there follows an inevitable need to exhale. Likewise, in an organizational context, after exploiting existing products and services, business survival requires innovation and renewal to remain competitive in the marketplace. These processes are continuously ongoing and thus unresolvable. In practical terms, this means that leaders are constantly pulled in opposing directions. For example, they are required to reduce costs while generating new business revenue or to comply with a global business strategy while addressing the expectations and requirements of local clients. Leadership obligations stemming from organizational paradoxes may seem impossible to reconcile and may challenge organizational actors, as “organizational paradoxes are undecidable trade-off decisions” (Berti & Cunha, 2023, p. 873). Any attempt to privilege one over the other will backfire, since paradoxes are interdependent and persisting.

In their seminal paper, Smith and Lewis (2011) proposed that actors living with paradoxes must relinquish their expectations of rationality and linearity and accept paradoxes as unsolvable puzzles. Furthermore, they suggested that a paradoxical leader must possess the cognitive and behavioral complexity necessary to comprehend and address paradoxes. They argued that staying calm in potentially stressful situations allows such a leader to maintain an overview of the challenge and incorporate the complexity of the paradoxical tensions. They referred to this as emotional equanimity. Several studies have supported these key characteristics of a paradoxical leader (e.g., Keller & Chen, 2017; Lavine, 2014; Pearce et al., 2019; Van Neerijnen et al., 2022; Waldman & Bowen, 2016; Zhang et al., 2015). Thus, cognitive complexity and emotional equanimity are specifically relevant for investigating executives’ decision-making processes in the face of competing demands. We elaborate on each concept below.

Cognitive Complexity. In the discourse on interdependent and opposing forces that constitute organizational paradoxes (Lewis, 2000; Poole & Van

de Ven, 1989; Smith & Lewis, 2011), the polarization of categories—such as new–old, local–global, and innovation–operation—is at play. The opposing constructs—such as local–global—can be viewed as interdependent (Smith & Lewis, 2011, 2012) because one cannot exist without the other. Global corporate organizations are simultaneously global and local (Fredberg, 2014). An organization may have a common global strategy that all local business units are required to comply with; thus, the global strategy becomes the local strategy. However, if the local units do not comply with the global strategy, its execution is sabotaged. Conversely, if the global strategy requires local subsidiaries to adjust to local market conditions, it becomes a compilation of local practices, potentially compromising global brand characteristics. Thus, from a paradoxical viewpoint, a *local* perspective cannot be inferred without understanding its global counterpart. Moreover, a local strategy cannot be changed without affecting the global strategy. There is an inherent push for global corporate organizations to become more global and more local simultaneously, which infuses paradoxical leadership tensions (Fredberg, 2014).

Individuals with higher-level cognitive complexity tend to be more aware of paradoxes. They differentiate local from global, yet they can integrate the two while perceiving the similarities and how they are dynamically interrelated (Hooijberg et al., 1997; Miron-Spektor et al., 2018; Smith & Tushman, 2005). Leaders with a higher level of integrative complexity—referring to the ability to both differentiate and integrate constructs (Tetlock et al., 1993)—adapt their decision-making and behaviors to a situation by processing available contextual information while also considering their own resources (Hannah et al., 2013; Hooijberg et al., 1997). In contrast, individuals with a lower degree of cognitive complexity tend to prefer exclusive categorization to simplify the world (Miron-Spektor et al., 2018).

Emotional Equanimity. Living at the center of the tension field formed by shifting and competing demands may be stressful and evoke anxiety, leading to paralysis and, consequently, loss of the ability to lead (Lewis, 2000). Thus, emotional equanimity—the ability to stay calm, especially in difficult situations (Cambridge Dictionary, n.d.)—is considered a prerequisite for paradoxical leadership (Smith & Lewis, 2011). How individuals emotionally experience tensions related to competing demands is related to prior experience and personal preferences (Manderscheid & Freeman, 2012). Experiencing control over a situation provides a sense of security, and in situations of conflicting logics, some people may feel more comfortable dealing with one logic and neglecting the other (Lewis, 2000). Recent research has revealed that when emotions are closely connected to one of the poles of a paradox,

downplaying these emotions and giving preference to the nonpreferred pole can lead to emotional fatigue (Pradies, 2022).

Paradox Mindset. Miron-Spektor et al. (2018) developed the concept of a *paradox mindset* as an indicator of leaders' capacity to deal constructively with the tensions emanating from paradoxes. Cognitively holding different perspectives and lines of reasoning simultaneously while engaging in paradoxical situations with energy and excitement are crucial elements of a paradox mindset. Miron-Spektor et al. (2018) emphasized the emotional part of the paradox mindset, reflecting the degree to which emotional equanimity is present when dealing with tensions stemming from paradoxes. Thus, the paradox mindset incorporates the concepts of cognitive complexity and emotional equanimity.

Research Methodology

To explore how top executives make decisions and how emotions and values influence their leadership in the face of institutional complexity and competing demands, we conducted a phenomenological study of 10 leading Norwegian executives. Phenomenology seeks to gain a deep understanding of individuals' lived experiences, capturing the essence of a phenomenon. Our research was inspired by the hermeneutic Heideggerian tradition, in which "intuitive" interpretation and double hermeneutics—that is, a double-loop sensemaking process between the participant and the researcher—are considered essential for understanding and illustrating the essence of lived experience. Therefore, to ensure participant verification and double hermeneutics, we adopted a longitudinal approach with two rounds of phenomenological interviews spaced two years apart. Moreover, the study was designed to allow multiple leadership decision-making processes to emerge (phenomenology) while enabling clustering and describing the variety (phenomenography), thereby facilitating the transfer of findings to other leaders.

For a phenomenological study, participants with informational power—that is, extensive experience with the phenomenon of interest, a willingness to share deeply personal information, and the cognitive capacity to do so—are required to ensure the quality of the interviews (Malterud et al., 2016). A multistage strategy of homogeneity and heterogeneity was applied to identify relevant participants (Palinkas et al., 2015). First, the essential in-role experience of each individual was specified to provide similarity and thus comparability among participants. To ensure competing demands, we selected participants who occupied the position of executive director or CEO and held

strategic responsibility for a complex organization in a dynamic environment (homogeneity). Organizational complexity was evaluated as high if the governance constituted two or more institutional logics (commercial, academic, bureaucratic, political, scientific, or crossing the boundaries of local–global business), as this would typically give rise to competing demands. Second, participants across different professional segments (e.g., public, private, or NGO and regional, national, or international) were selected to increase the robustness and transferability of the findings (heterogeneity).

Since the topic of this study is somewhat complex and abstract, we aimed to stimulate the participants' reflective processes prior to data collection. Thus, before each round of interviews, they were asked to respond to the questionnaire defined in the Miron-Spektor et al. (2018) paradox mindset framework. This framework elicits respondents' levels of tension experienced from competing demands and the degree to which they react to tensions with a paradox mindset.

The data analysis aligned with Heidegger's hermeneutic ontology, conducted using an interpretive grounded theory approach (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). We stayed close to the respondents' language, aiming to understand their experiences, and juxtaposed the analysis with the responses to the paradox mindset questionnaire; hence, we conducted a paradox-hermeneutic phenomenological study (Peoples, 2020). The analysis was also inspired by Gioia's methodology for rigor in inductive research (Gioia et al., 2013). We identified two distinct patterns of decision-making in which emotions and values appeared to play different roles.

Introducing the Executives

Our study encompassed 10 executives from complex organizations in which competing institutional logics—due to different governance structures, regulations, market conditions, collaborative networks, and other factors—had been identified. Moreover, competing demands arose from complex power structures and resource scarcity. Recurring opposing themes across the organizations were *financial concerns* versus *quality of services or products*, *agency* versus *restrictions in acting*, and *political priorities* versus *administrative/business priorities*.

To illustrate the complex institutional settings of the executives, the following sections provide background information on four executives representing low, medium, and high levels of paradox mindset. These executives were selected because their levels of paradox mindset emerged as key explanatory factors underlying their different decision-making processes. Two executives fell within the high level of paradox mindset (Owens and Larsson);

both are included, as their changes in paradox mindset illustrate two separate emotional dynamics, allowing for interesting comparisons. When presenting our findings, we supplement them with reference to the broader sample of executives to show nuances.

Owens, Director of University (High Paradox Mindset)

Owens was the director of *University*, in which two lines of command coexisted: an academic, democratically elected line among peers, with a decentralized operation, and a centralized administrative, bureaucratic line. Owens described how he was learning to navigate the tensions between these dimensions as a recently appointed director. Attracting highly qualified scholars and students was paramount to success; however, international universities offered fierce competition. Owens' strategy was to beat in-sector competition through cross-sector collaboration. Although engaging in cross-sector collaborations may come with tensions from competing strategic agendas, Owens emphasized the potential of looking beyond campus activities to leverage regional cutting-edge expertise and resources. Owens had a strong vision for how academia and private organizations—holding differentiated and opposing operational logics—can integrate their interests and boost the region's attraction to ambitious, innovative, and highly competent academics through collaboration. Owens came across as a visionary and ambitious director, scoring highly on experience with tensions arising from competing demands and on a paradox mindset within the Miron-Spekter framework.

Larsson, CEO of Medical Instruments (High Paradox Mindset)

Larsson was the CEO of a national subsidiary of *Medical Instruments*, an international corporation providing high-technology instruments to public healthcare. In this private commercial business, Larsson faced tensions between the rapid technological advancement of products and the low adoption rate exhibited by public buyers, due to the complexity of political and bureaucratic processes. Thus, corporate pressure to increase sales was difficult to satisfy. Larsson found himself trying to absorb and negotiate the tensions between the employer's top-down expectations for him to meet sales targets—that is, maximizing profit—and the bottom-up needs of employees not to set unrealistic targets that would deplete the sales organization, thus protecting sustainable working conditions. Larsson felt that his integrity was challenged when his international superiors forced him to accept what he considered unreasonable business targets and requests. The autonomy to adapt solutions

to the national context was lacking, and Larsson had to operationalize initiatives that he found damaging to the organization. Multiple organizational reporting structures, combined with a lack of autonomy, put Larsson under competing demands without the required agency. Larsson, like Owens, experienced a high level of competing demands and scored high on a paradox mindset.

Bentson, CEO of Medical (Medium Paradox Mindset)

Bentson was the CEO of *Medical*, a public medical organization operating nationally within an international professional network. He experienced tensions between individual and collective interests, with four groups of actors playing specific roles: patients, doctors, the federal government, and the international network. Patients prioritized the safety and effectiveness of treatment to secure their health while maintaining autonomy that could not be compromised; doctors complied with national regulations and operated in accordance with the Hippocratic Oath; and the international professional network sought shared medical guidelines. In this network, there was a sense of collegial loyalty. Still, professional integrity and the national assessment of the benefits and risks of drugs had to be safeguarded. During the pandemic, *Medical*'s representatives represented Norway in assessing the quality of vaccines and were concerned about the risk of side effects. Their strong concern for the individual triggered fierce international reactions. Some vaccines raised more concerns than others, and differing national guidelines became apparent across the network. The UK was using the AstraZeneca vaccine and did not report any concerns related to adverse side effects. At the same time, Norway found that the benefit-to-risk ratio was unacceptable and initiated a referral to the European Medicines Agency. In the interviews, Bentson came across as kind and somewhat conflict-avoiding; his experience of competing demands was at a medium level, as was his paradox mindset.

Petterson, CEO of Blue Ocean (Low Paradox Mindset)

Petterson was the CEO of *Blue Ocean*, an independent private research institution and commercial consultancy specializing in ocean environmental issues. Subject matter expertise, combined with political and financial independence in research activities, was crucial for trustworthiness. In cases where research involved collaboration with consultancy clients, this could be particularly challenging. Unlike other research organizations, *Blue Ocean* lacked public funding, making financial security essential for its employees, and the research funding opportunities were unpredictable. However, *Blue Ocean* was

privileged to have large, loyal clients for its consultancy activities. In both its research and consultancy markets, Blue Ocean faced intense competition. Thus, collaboration with other highly qualified agencies was necessary to form coalitions and win new contracts. In some instances, these collaborating partners were also Blue Ocean's competitors. Despite operating at the intersection of research independence and clients' commercial interests, as well as the opposing dynamics of collaboration and competition, Petterson did not experience tensions of competing logics and adhered to sequential, logical thinking aimed at optimizing Blue Ocean's revenue. Petterson displayed a low-level paradox mindset.

Although all the selected executives led organizations with competing demands, the above descriptions illustrate the differences in the extent to which they experienced tensions due to these competing demands and their reactions to such tensions. As mentioned, their levels of paradox mindset were linked to the decision-making processes they adopted, to which we turn below.

Decision-Making Processes in the Institutional Context of Competing Demands

In this section, we present two distinct decision-making processes that top executives adopt when facing competing demands: a linear analytical approach and a slow, circular, values-based process. Discrepancies in these processes corresponded to the participants' experiences of tensions (i.e., perceptions of the decision to be made) and paradox mindsets. Lower levels of experienced tension and paradox mindset were associated with more linear analytical decision-making processes. In contrast, executives who experienced increased tensions and held a medium- to high-level paradox mindsets tended to adopt decision-making processes that were slow and circular, comprising both facts and subjective viewpoints.

Linear Analytical Decision-Making

The linear analytical decision-making process involves simplifying complexity by separating tasks and calculating the risks and consequences of decisions. The predictability of cause and effect is a basic assumption in this approach, characterized by trade-offs or synergetic solutions in which different requirements are combined through processes of optimization (Berti & Cunha, 2023). Petterson (the CEO of Blue Ocean) and Meyer (a municipal director

responsible for the bureaucratic line in a parliamentary system) adopted this decision-making process, in which emotions and values do not appear to play an important role. It is noteworthy that while Petterson involved other people to cover her back and Meyer did so to sell his decisions, neither used this approach to improve their decisions.

In the following extract, **Petterson** assesses risk and potential loss through financial calculations and states how important it is to have the owners on board:

I don't think I'm a very risk-tolerant person. For me, it's about what you can figure out ... If you have at least made good assessments, then, in a way, you can say, "Yes, we know this will cost us so much. What kind of risk is it? What can we risk losing? What is the potential loss if we fail?" And then, for me, it's about having my back covered by the owners.

Below, **Meyer** creates legitimacy for his decisions through the involvement of the management team. This involvement contributes to a shared understanding of the situation:

I'm very strong at decision-making; I don't think it's hard to make decisions. So, by securing involvement and ensuring that information flows throughout the organization and that we have built a common picture of the situation, I can make difficult decisions more legitimately than if I were just fast and furious.

Slow, Circular, Values-Based Decision-Making

Slow, circular, values-based decision-making characterizes the other decision-making process. The leaders who adopted the slow decision-making process included Owens (the director of University), Bentson (the CEO of Medical), and five other executives: Johnson (the CEO of a complex utility), Williams (the CEO of a public university hospital), Berg (the director of a national health organization), Adams (the director of a company providing homes for ordinary people), and Smith (the CEO of a local hospital). They all emphasized the importance of collecting and analyzing facts, as well as investigating other people's perspectives. Owens and Johnson explicitly emphasized that their decisions were values-based (i.e., "*what feels right*"), while Bentson discussed being wise and pragmatic. Johnson, Williams, Bentson, and Adams addressed the iterations and the importance of allowing time to enable values-based decisions to emerge.

In the following extract, **Bentson** holds the overall goal or direction in mind while actively listening to his colleagues' opinions and testing his ideas with them. He finds it essential to include all perspectives on a situation and takes time to decide:

Listening is important. Listen, observe, discuss, and test ideas with those around you. Constantly have the overarching goal in your head and think that there are many roads to get there. Be pragmatic. I think that is the difference between those who shoot from the hip and people like me, who buzz around, figure out all sorts of weird things, and still are not quite able to decide.

Below, **Johnson** emphasizes the importance of letting impressions mature to find better solutions as well as his willingness to accept not having quick answers:

I can remain in situations long before a conclusion is drawn. The advantage is that you find better answers; the disadvantage is that the organization feels the stress of a decision not being made. Sometimes I don't have a very good answer, and there can be conflicting interests, so I wait to conclude and take the cost or uncertainty.

He also combines people's viewpoints with fact-based analyses and finally makes a decision based on his values:

Information gathering, and—in a way—yes, there are two things: more information and more analysis ... Information, conversation with others, what others think, what kind of picture others see, trying to create various analyses, setting up pros and cons, creating economic analysis, technical analysis, and other things. I am old enough to know that if I have two choices that look pretty similar, I should go for what makes sense to me, based on my values.

In the following, Owens recounts how he seeks advice and opinions from his colleagues and explicitly appreciates conflicting advice to assess the complexity of the situation before he eventually makes a decision:

Often, the decision is colored by who you ask for advice. I'm probably very keen to ask people for advice and gather information. It is not for me to waive my responsibility, but ... I think that the most important thing for me—whether it's a crisis or everyday life—is having good people around me whom I trust and with whom I can openly discuss certainty and uncertainty. To shed light on it, and then you decide. [...] And if they are good advisers, they give different advice, and then I get to see the complexity of it.

Concerned about his integrity and that of the organization, he states that when a decision is made, it is based on *what feels right* and on respect for the people involved, not on an analysis of the organization's strategy:

I must preserve both my own and the organization's integrity and verifiability. And, in a way, it should be what feels—based on all the complex thoughts—the wisest way forward. [...] what determines the decision to be made is that the decision feels right in the setting. [...] So I don't want to analyze what is written in the strategy, the board document, or the budget; it will be at a higher level of aggregation.

Figure 22.1 illustrates the slow, circular, values-based decision-making process. With the overall goal in mind—including the ambiguity of competing demands—leaders collect and analyze objective information, allowing their impressions to settle before discussing their views with others to hear their subjective perspectives. More information is collected, and another iteration is conducted. Executives' experience and intuition guide the data collection process—that is, which facts to collect and whom to involve. Moreover, allowing impressions time to ripen may be considered a complex process of discerning the path forward, based on external input, the severity of the situation, and the executives' resources and preferences. This process continues until it reaches a tipping point, at which the pieces in the puzzle seem to fit and one decision *feels (most) right* from a personal, values-based point of view. The arrows around the goal and the hourglass were added

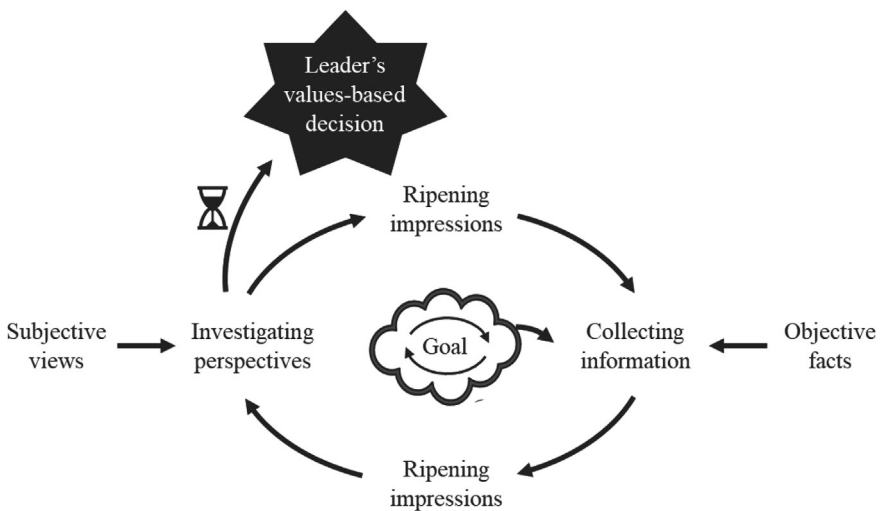


Fig. 22.1 Slow, circular, values-based decision-making

by the executives during the second round of interviews, when the preliminary results were shared and discussed in a double-hermeneutic process. The arrow around the goal indicates that the goal becomes clearer and is likely to be slightly adjusted during the process. The hourglass symbolizes time limitations that may force executives to conclude earlier than preferred. Cognitive complexity—a tenet of the paradox mindset—enables executives to incorporate elements of consideration into their decision-making processes continually.

Emotional Reactions to the Tensions of Competing Demands

In this section, we elaborate on the emotional strain experienced by Bentson, Owens, and Larsson. These executives experienced emotions such as stress and anxiety, a lack of agency, and having their personal integrity or morale at work challenged. During an uncertain and critical period during the pandemic, Bentson (the CEO of Medical) experienced the gravity of his responsibilities for the national health situation colliding with his tendency to avoid risk taking. He expressed this in the following way:

Then we are on the emotions; it wears and tears at me and drains me. I do not like that. I do not like it, but at the same time, when you're convinced enough, there is also a kind of pride in it, too ... Yes, it creates satisfaction, but it's overwhelming when it's going on.

Owens (the director of University) experienced being personally harassed. He neglected his personal needs and emotions, which resulted in a six-month sick leave:

I was out running one Saturday morning and got a call with nasty comments from the rector because he was sitting in the office while I was out exercising on a Saturday ...! So, I ... I think the emotional part of it is to take emotions seriously—to feel the emotions, feel that this is difficult. But also, try not to hide from it, right? I'm a pretty robust type, and I'm not afraid of talking about emotions, usually.

Larsson (the CEO of Medical Instruments) was responsible for reorganizing a subsidiary, yet he believed the changes would harm the organization. As a result, he felt his integrity was challenged and that he lacked agency:

But because of competing priorities, matrices, and three-dimensional matrices, it's not all that simple anymore. So, my mandate is more limited compared to a few years ago because there are people everywhere who have opinions on things... Eh ... I certainly don't like to come across as someone with low integrity. I've been told

that I have very high integrity. But [...] sometimes I'm dragged across the table by my superiors, and I feel that my integrity is under pressure and being challenged.

Values and Emotional Equanimity

Although some of the experiences recounted were emotionally demanding and draining, the executives who operated in medium to high levels of tension explicitly discussed their strategies for increasing emotional equanimity (i.e., calmness). This involved mobilizing their values-based purpose, that is, the intrinsic motivation that drove them to hold this leadership position in particular, while also prioritizing adequate self-care. Self-care, in this context, refers to the mental and physical restorative activities that help executives recover from the stress of managing competing demands (Beard, 2022). In the following, we exemplify what a values-based purpose and self-care constitute for executives.

A sense of purpose could elevate the executives above the field of tension and draw them toward a higher level of abstraction, where competing demands could be reconciled and thus seem more tolerable. Several described a strong sense of values-based purpose. This purpose was not necessarily shared with others; instead, it provided them with intrinsic motivation and kept them going. For instance, Bentson (the CEO of Medical) and Meyer (the municipal director) talked explicitly about being tools for a higher cause, faith, and democracy. When the tensions became too intense, Bentson asked God for guidance and allowed his moral and ethical compass to guide him. Similarly, when Meyer experienced the rapidly shifting and opposing political agendas in the municipality, which created tensions, his values-based purpose—to develop and facilitate arenas for democratic processes—expanded his tolerance of tension. Without tensions between competing political parties, there would be no democracy. Williams found her purpose in working for the justice of patients from minority groups at the university hospital. Owens (the director of the University) believed that the survival of the Norwegian welfare state was threatened and that he could contribute to its survival through his work. In all cases, the purpose was deeply rooted in the executives' values, and for most of the executives, it was linked to their organization's purpose. However, for Owens, the purpose went beyond that of the organization and took the form of a personal quest or sense of obligation that he would later pursue in another organization. Why Owens was motivated by a purpose that went beyond the organization's purpose is not evident. However, it may be associated with his high level of cognitive

complexity (reflected in his level of paradox mindset), allowing him to see how everything is interconnected at the societal level.

Although a values-based purpose can provide executives with motivation and determination, emotional equanimity also depends on the restoration of the mind and body to stay fit and cope with daily challenges. The self-care component of emotional equanimity reflected the personal needs and hence the values of the executives in a given situation. Restitution could take various forms. For instance, Owens counterbalanced the complexity and unpredictability at the university with micromanagement of home projects, Bentson from Medical found calmness in meditation, Berg mobilized mental images and imagined that he was in the eye of a hurricane when things around him in the national health organization became chaotic, and Smith enjoyed slow mornings before a stressful day in the local hospital.

Figure 22.2 illustrates how top-level executives develop and maintain emotional equanimity. In the model, the personal values-based *purpose* forms a persistent and stable foundation for choosing and staying in a job, with tensions stemming from shifting and competing demands. The stability of the higher purpose is illustrated by one of the triangle's sides steadily resting on the substratum. In contrast, personal *self-care* is a crucial yet easily neglected element that requires regular attention to maintain the energy to keep going. The top triangle can easily tip to either side. This risk of instability of the self-care element is illustrated by the heavy top and by placing the upper triangle with one peak slightly embedded in the higher purpose triangle, suggesting that this requires a careful balancing act. Placing the two elements in conjunction with one another highlights the fragile emotional dynamics of leaders addressing competing demands over time.

A strong personal values-based purpose can spur determination to pursue a cause; however, this may lead to burnout if the self-care element is lacking or insufficient. The second interview with Owens, while he was on sick leave from the university, clearly illustrates this risk:

My current situation is a result of not prioritizing my self-care sufficiently. And where I sit right now and wonder if I have a higher personal purpose in being ... when it is at the expense of my own ... my own health. Is it then worth it?

Still, Owens does not easily let go of his higher purpose:

Or is ... is it so important to me, or do I think that ... that I can still make it happen...?

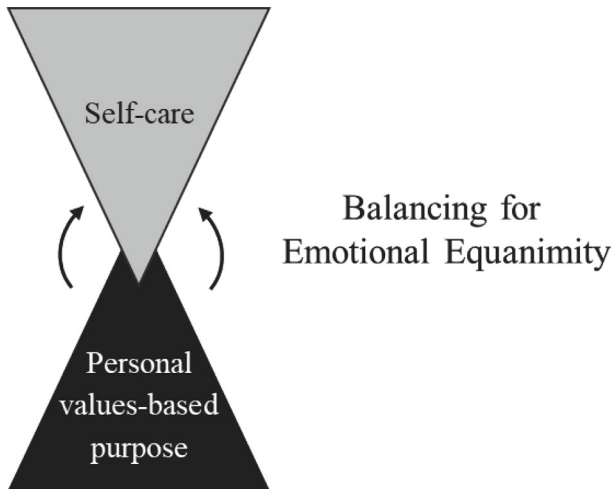


Fig. 22.2 Balancing personal values-based purpose and self-care for emotional equanimity

He begins considering other avenues for achieving the goal of having business, academia, and the public sector work together for the region:

But it may be that I have to find other ways to try to... because I see that ... my work at [University] does not mean that I contribute to this goal.

In contrast, Larsson (at Medical Instruments) neither displayed a values-based sense of purpose nor took good care of himself. In the first round of interviews, he scored high on both *experience of tensions* and *paradox mindset*, which could have provided him with the capabilities needed to handle the tensions. Still, he found the role very stressful and was close to burnout. Lacking personal purpose in the role, along with sufficient self-care, eroded his stamina when facing multiple crossing lines of command, creating a systemic catch-22 situation (Berti & Simpson, 2021). This reaction is contradictory to Owen's, who, even while on long-term sick leave, continued to search for ways to pursue his purpose. When talking about the experience of constrained agency, Larsson says:

I think it's challenging. And don't ask how I feel about it, because I'm not OK with it [laughs nervously].

Moreover, on the topic of self-care, Larson reflects:

How do I take care of myself? That's a difficult question. How should I answer that? No, maybe not at all... [laughs nervously].

Thus, the executives' values-based purpose and self-care influenced their emotional strain and stamina as they made decisions amid competing demands. Emotional equanimity appears to be a state the executives aimed for rather than an achievable destination. However, those who held a values-based purpose and a high awareness of the need for self-care generally operated at a higher level of emotional equanimity than executives who disregarded their values and need for self-care.

Emotions and values can thus play an essential role in senior executives' decision-making. This is particularly the case when senior executives, who have a paradox mindset and experience tensions at a medium-to-high level, make slow, circular, values-based decisions in the face of competing demands. Executives who have found a way to balance personal purpose and self-care are privileged by an inner calmness (i.e., emotional equanimity) that—alongside cognitive complexity—allows them to consider a situation's complexity and buy themselves time when making decisions while facing competing demands. Executives' values serve as a primary guide rather than formal organizational strategy documents or organization-level values.

Discussion

In the face of competing demands, cognition, emotions, and values intersect to influence the decision-making of senior executives. However, the role of emotions and values differs substantially across the two decision-making approaches. In the linear analytical decision-making process, emotions appear to be absent or perhaps neglected. In contrast, they are at the fore and guide executive decision-making through a slow, circular, values-based process.

Why values and emotions are obscure in the linear analytical process is unclear. One could argue that rationality dominates this decision-making process and that rationality is a value. Following this argument, the linear analytical process is equally values-based as the slow, circular decision-making process. Regarding the vagueness of emotions in the linear analytical approach, we share two reflections. While executives who adhere to the slow, circular, values-based decision-making process experience stress and anxiety, those following the linear analytical approach may alleviate these emotions through a sense of "rightness," legitimized by rationality, which for some is considered the only valid way to make sound decisions. Moreover, and probably more importantly, these executives convey a low-level paradox mindset

and thus tend to decompose paradoxes, avoiding the emotional strains of paradoxical tensions.

In contrast, the slow, circular, values-based decision-making process allows emotions and values to interplay, signaling to executives when a decision has matured and can be acted upon—that is, when it *feels right*. Executives who rely on their values and emotions connect the head and the heart and eventually make decisions based on what intuitively feels right. However, emotions may facilitate or postpone reaching the point of decision-making depending on their nature. Those related to excitement and optimism may accelerate the decision-making process, whereas emotions related to conflict avoidance and insecurity may hinder progress. Bentson (the CEO of Medical) experienced such bewilderment as he tried to reconcile his value of responsibility (urge to act) with his emotion of anxiety related to risk-taking (reluctance to act). However, if the executive's experience of a values-based purpose is strong, it may help them overcome the emotional strain from competing demands.

As we have illustrated, tensions from competing demands may be cognitively and emotionally challenging, prompting executives to seek emotional equanimity, through which they can pursue their values-based purpose and practice self-care. The sense of emotional equanimity enables them to take the time needed to collect and process objective facts and subjective views until a state of perceived saturation is reached. However, experiences of constrained agency may undermine the sense of emotional equanimity and lead to the risk of emotional burnout, especially if the executive disregards the need for self-care.

Surprisingly, it is the intuitive and affective element—"knowing what feels right" (Liebowitz et al., 2019) —that slows down the circular and values-based decision-making process. From Kahneman's well-known theories (Kahneman, 2011; Kahneman et al., 1982), we learn that the intuitive and affective processes of System 1 are fast and spontaneous, which does not seem to be the case in decision-making related to competing demands. This could be because competing demands influence intuition's natural flow, as they are often paradoxical and dynamic, and thus appear unprecedented. Due to the novelty of the situation, the "holistic, big picture and inferential intuition" (Pretz et al., 2014) that typically develops with seniority and experience (Liebowitz et al., 2019) is unavailable to executives when deciding on competing demands. Consequently, experience-based intuition does not flow freely to guide an executive's decision-making process, and the spontaneous feeling of knowing how to act is often postponed. Meanwhile, executives' search for decision support involves analyzing data, considering subjective

views, and waiting for information to mature before making intuitive and values-based decisions.

Implications for Practice

Executives can benefit from a deeper understanding of how emotions and values interact with cognition in decision-making and how this can play out in highly institutionalized contexts. Awareness of the slow, circular, values-based decision-making process (Fig. 22.1) may encourage leaders to clarify the goal or desired situation (i.e., *What is it that I really want to achieve?*) and evaluate which subjective views and objective facts to collect and process. More importantly, the model prompts practitioners to clarify the core values guiding their decisions. If the values are unclear to the leader, the decision-making process risks becoming elongated, making it more challenging to reach a saturation point when collecting information. It may also be beneficial to explicitly set the timeframe for the process to unfold and evaluate the costs and benefits of a longer or shorter process.

Additionally, executives' well-being and in-role performance can benefit from exploring the values-based purpose in their leadership positions and clarifying the value they add to their organization and to society. For some leaders, this reflective process may lead to reevaluating their career choices. Furthermore, assessing the balance between values-based purpose and self-care components is essential. This study shows that a high values-based purpose can be all-consuming and a health risk if self-care needs are neglected over time. The model on balancing purpose and self-care (Fig. 22.2) can be used by executives for self-reflection, in leadership development programs, and in coaching for those facing competing demands.

Future Research

The understanding of the role of emotions and values in complex organizational contexts is still in its infancy, and our discussion points to several opportunities for future research. We elaborate on four intriguing avenues below.

First, in describing the slow, circular, values-based decision-making process for executives dealing with competing demands, we discussed the delayed intuitive process. We argued that this may be due to the novelty of the paradoxical situation, resulting in a lack of experience-based intuition. This explanation requires further investigation to gain a deeper understanding of the delayed intuition process.

Second, future research should explore whether and how slow, circular, values-based decision-making processes are featured at lower levels of organizations. We reported on senior-level executives, showing two distinct decision-making models: one more rational and the other involving values, emotions, and intuition. Do managers at lower levels also exhibit these decision-making patterns, and more specifically, how do the decision-making patterns of senior executives influence their subordinate managers?

Third, future research could investigate the interplay between executives' values and those of the organization. The executives in our study primarily emphasized their personal values and rarely referred to specific value conflicts. However, what happens if the context requires a decision that conflicts with personal values? If there is a misalignment of values, how can executives attempt to integrate them? Under what conditions do executives rely on and privilege their personal values rather than contextual demands and requirements?

Finally, our findings suggest that emotional equanimity can be achieved by balancing personal purpose and self-care. However, there were indications that perceptions of constrained agency could tip this balance. Future research could benefit from a closer empirical examination of how perceptions of agency play into decision-making processes as well as the broader ability to handle competing demands.

Conclusion

This chapter discusses the role of emotions and values in the decision-making processes of senior executives in highly institutionalized contexts. We argued and showed that emotions and values influence executives' decision-making to various degrees. While emotions and values play a limited role for executives who follow a linear analytical process, they play an essential role for those who navigate a slow, circular, values-based decision-making process, leading to decisions that "feel right" in situations in which logical reasoning is deemed insufficient due to the tensions of competing demands.

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Part V

Rethinking Methodologies and Practices



23

Field Research Approaches for Studying Values and Emotions: Centering Theory, Phenomenon or Personhood

April L. Wright

Introduction

Theorizing of values and emotions in organizational and institutional phenomena is flourishing, propelled by researchers undertaking interpretive qualitative field studies in diverse empirical contexts, including wineries (Massa et al., 2017), prisons (Toubiana, 2020), chef kitchens (Burrow et al., 2022), surgical camps in Afghanistan (de Rond & Lok, 2016), animal rights organizations (Jarvis et al., 2019), and mafia-dominated communities in Sicily (Vaccaro & Palazzo, 2015). Surprisingly few published qualitative studies, however, have collected and analyzed rich empirical material about *both* values *and* emotions. Instead, studies tend to shine light on one concept—*either* values *or* emotions—while the other concept remains hidden in the shadows. While there are many reasons for this, one significant cause of this lack of *both/and* studies is methodological for qualitative researchers. Conducting field research to collect original data in context and over time to build theory is always challenging (Locke, 2011; Michailova et al., 2014). However, this challenge escalates when the values and emotions of research participants are of primary interest in fieldwork (Cunliffe & Alcadipani, 2016), where the qualitative researcher's own emotions and values also come into play (Claus, de Rond, Howard-Grenville, & Lodge, 2019; Hansen & Quinn Trank, 2016; Hibbert, 2021).

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This chapter is focused on qualitative research and aims to open up the methodological conversation about how to undertake field studies in ways that generate empirically based insights into the relationships between values and emotions. The chapter proposes that researchers can focus their attention on theory, phenomenon or personhood as pathways for potentially uncovering *both/and* insights. Together, the three approaches—*theory-centered*, *phenomenon-centered*, and *personhood-centered*—represent different choices that field researchers can make about how and where to center their attention during what methodologists broadly label the “getting on” and “getting out” stages of field data collection (Buchanan et al., 1988). Field research involves systematically collecting original data in and around real organizations as a basis for building theory (Edmondson & McManus, 2007).

Each approach within the framework represents a “mode of engagement” for the researcher (Wright et al., 2023). That is, an approach describes how a qualitative researcher engages with the field and what they predominantly pay attention to as they go about processes of data collection and analysis. Thus, theory-centered, phenomenon-centered, and personhood-centered approaches are available for adoption by qualitative researchers who are interested in studying values and/or emotions using any qualitative research design and method of data collection that involves fieldwork, including ethnographies (Cunliffe, 2010; Van Maanen, 2009), case studies (Eisenhardt & Graebner, 2007; Yin, 2009), interview studies (Silverman, 2014), and action research or participatory inquiry methods (Reason & Bradbury, 2001). Regardless of the specific method of data collection chosen, the researcher can choose to focus their attention on theory, phenomenon or personhood at any moment in time. Each approach has important implications for the different ways that values and emotions potentially show up in field data and in the study’s analysis, emergent findings and theoretical contributions.

In the chapter that follows, I introduce each approach to qualitative field research and illustrate its utility by drawing on illustrative examples from my own program of field research in emergency departments in Australia, which generated published studies that meaningfully investigated and explicitly theorized *both* values *and* emotions. I outline the basic elements of each particular approach along with the approach’s advantages and disadvantages for studying values and emotions. In doing so, the chapter contributes to the literature by highlighting fruitful methodological avenues for more generative theorizing of values, emotions and the relationships and dynamics between them.

Theory-Centered Approach to Studying Values and Emotions

A theory-centered approach to field research when studying values and emotions keeps theory as the researcher's central focus of attention during data collection and analysis. Consistent with the conventions of social science research about theory-method fit (Gehman et al., 2018; Pettigrew, 1990) the researcher designs an empirical investigation with prior theory in hand relevant to values, emotions or both and then assembles and analyzes a dataset to elaborate and extend theoretical explanations of values and emotions. Using forms of organization-scientific reasoning through deduction, induction, or abduction (Mantere & Ketokivi, 2013), the researcher analyzes their empirical material to produce theories of the middle range rather than universal laws or grand theories typical of hard sciences (Merton, 1957; Pinder & Moore, 1980). The hope is that this analysis will generate middle-range theories that make contributions to the literature on values and emotions that meet conventional criteria of being interesting, original, and useful (Corley & Gioia, 2011; Cornelissen & Durand, 2014; Whetten, 1989).

My own study of maintaining professional values through institutional work and moral emotions in an emergency department in Australia is an illustration of the theory-centered approach to field research (Wright et al., 2017). After writing my PhD research on institutional change processes involving rules, values, and logics in County cricket in England (Wright & Zammuto, 2013), I was awarded a national government grant to undertake a longitudinal qualitative study of institutional processes associated professional work at a fieldsite emergency department (ED). While I began the research with a broad theoretical commitment to institutional processes involving professions, as data collection progressed at the fieldsite with our research team we narrowed our theoretical and empirical focus to the values of professions.

When we entered the field, what struck me as both theoretically interesting and practically important was the question of how the professional values of emergency physicians—who are specialists in emergency medicine within the medical profession—were being maintained in everyday work in the ED. The traditional values of professions involve acting for the best interests of patients and clients. Historically, members of a profession like medicine and law have been expected to internalize a commitment to a professional value of altruistic service through their training and socialization (Abbott, 1988; Parsons, 1939) and to strive to uphold this value in their everyday work in professional practice (Muzio et al., 2019). An ongoing puzzle in the sociology of professions literature is whether or not it is possible for traditional values of

professions to be maintained in light of shifts in contemporary organizing of professional work into large-scale organizations and bureaucratic structures (Brint, 1994; Evetts, 2006) and growing specialization within the knowledge base of professions like medicine (Pratt et al., 2006). I found myself observing and interviewing emergency physicians at the fieldsite of a large multi-specialist hospital where professional values were clearly visible in the everyday clinical work of our research participants. Occasionally, professional values also seemed to be a source of tension in interactions with other specialists and while performing certain hospital practices to assess and treat acutely ill patients. Thus, we adopted an approach to field research in which our attention was centered on theory pertaining to professional values.

I recall that at different points in the research project, well-intentioned scholars (including international colleagues, audiences at conferences, and eventually a journal reviewer) encouraged our research team to broaden our theory-centered approach from professional values by reframing the study around institutional logics. Since the literature on institutional logics was surging at the time and values were one component that make up professional logics, they anticipated excellent opportunities for the dataset we were building to advance scholarly conversations about institutional logics and institutional complexity. In response, I remained open-minded by revisiting our data analysis and collecting additional data at the fieldsite with our research team. After confirming the relevance of professional values, we recommitted to telling a values story to remain authentic to what we believed we were seeing being lived out every day by our research participants as frontline professionals in the ED.

As data collection progressed at the fieldsite, we directed more focused attention to evaluating, collecting, and preserving empirical materials that captured aspects that might relate to our theoretical interest in professional values. We noticed that negative emotions like anger and frustration, and also other emotions associated with empathy for the patient, were aroused whenever something happened in which professional values seemed to be in tension. The most striking example of this came to our attention when we were shadowing emergency physicians on the floor of the ED. We were repeatedly told a story of how one of the emergency physicians (Dr. X) had “completely lost it” by shouting at operating theater nurses when their strict adherence to normal protocols for patient identification delayed the start of surgery for Dr. X’s critically ill patient, who died on the operating table. Participants described this particular patient case and Dr. X’s explosive outburst of emotion using the official terminology of a “sentinel event” and explained that it motivated interdepartmental collaboration to customize a

new operating theater protocol. We made a note in our fieldnotes to follow up with Dr. X, who told us about his anger that the protocol had prevented him from acting in the best interests of his patient according to the medical profession's values:

There's lots of protocols for patients who normally go to theatre and they're in place for a reason, but there's times when they need to be removed and this was certainly one of those times. I did create a bit of havoc up there. ... When the clock's ticking, they're actually putting the patient at risk. ... The patient was probably destined to die anyway [but] it's much easier to live with something like that outcome when you know the system has given their best shot for the patient. ... Most of the [surgical and nursing] staff appreciated why I was behaving that way.

Intrigued by the heightened emotions aroused in this sentinel event and what it could tell us about values tensions, we added questions to our interview guide in which we asked emergency physicians about the development of the new operating room protocol and their personal experiences with patients similar to that of Dr. X. This generated more descriptive accounts of values tensions and emotions, with one interviewee telling us, for example, about his own anger and sadness when his patient “bled out and bled to death because there was no good system in place to manage that patient—that was crap.”

No one involved with our research project had any expertise or *à priori* theoretical interest in emotions. However, the motivation to understand how professional values worked on and through our research participant's actions and interactions was strong so we turned to the literature on emotions for guidance. I came across “affective events theory” (Weiss & Cropanzo, 1996), which describes how work events can cause affective reactions. We “tested out” this theory by evaluating how comprehensively and meaningfully it could explain Dr. X's emotions and actions in the operating theater. Applying this theory, we speculated that when nursing staff tried to stop surgery until after they had completed the protocol, Dr. X cognitively appraised this resistance as a problem that threatened professional values by delaying the patient's access to treatment. This appraisal elicited anger as a felt emotional response, which Dr. X described to us as follows: “I was pretty angry with the nursing staff up there because all they cared about was that I'd obviously broken (their protocols) ... I didn't think they were acting in the best interest of the sickest patient in the hospital.”

To our limited knowledge of the emotions literature, this initial “testing out” of affective events theory seemed to be sound. We then drew on the

theory to try to explain the relationship between values and emotions across the rest of our fieldwork data. When we submitted the paper for review, a journal reviewer helpfully suggested Haidt's (2003) theory of moral emotions as an alternative. Noting that affective events theory is usually utilized to explain more or less mundane events at work, the reviewer commented that the theory of moral emotions seemed a "more natural fit" given our focus on the work of maintaining and defending professional values of acting for the interests of others.

Engaging in a process of iteration (Locke et al., 2022), we continuously moved back and forth comparing our emerging theoretical ideas about the work of maintaining professional values, extant theory about moral emotions as suggested by the reviewer, and our data. The literature on moral emotions provided categories for assigning data segments to different types of moral emotions (Tangney et al., 2007), which sharpened the theoretical precision of our data coding for the affective mechanisms involved in maintaining values. Overall, we were able to make much more of the relationship between emotion, values, and micro-institutional processes through our theory-centered approach to field research. By being alert to expressions of professional values and associated values tensions when we engaged with our research participants at our fieldsite, we came to see the theoretical salience of emotions as a mechanism for maintaining values. Professional values as the normative pillar of a profession as an institution remained central, and our data offered strong support for the role of values as emotion elicitors that trigger institutional maintenance work.

Advantages. The theory-centered approach to field research has three key advantages for researchers interested in values and emotions. First, it positions the researcher to see, engage with, and solve theoretical puzzles that matter for advancing the literature on values, emotions or both. As Langley (2021: 251) explains, to build theory from research in organization and management studies, "*we constantly ask ourselves 'What is this a case of?' In other words, we try to connect the specific phenomena that we are studying with theories or metaphors that will help us understand them.*" In the theory-centered approach, the researcher is continually asking *how and why* is this a case of values and/or emotions as the field research unfolds. In doing so, the researcher opens up the potential for new lines of sight on the theories they already know (Locke et al., 2008; Shaw et al., 2017) and for problematizing past scholars' taken-for-granted assumptions (Alvesson & Sandberg, 2013).

Second, adopting a theory-centered approach is likely to feel meaningful and manageable for researchers who already have existing expertise in the literatures on *either* values *or* emotions because it does not require mastery of,

or framing across, both literatures. For example, a values scholar can leverage what they already know about the nature of values to develop their puzzle and theoretical framing, and simply stay alert to how, when, and why emotions show up in the field and the data and for whom. An emotions scholar can draw on the extensive emotions literature to develop the core theoretical framing and research questions for their empirical study, while remaining open during field data collection and analysis to the role that values might be playing beneath the surface as emotion elicitors. In our study, for example, an emotions scholar might have been attuned to how, when, and for whom affective events theory explained the work of emergency physicians in ways that were different from moral emotions. Values scholars and emotions scholars might also choose to collaborate on research projects where the primary theoretical focus is on dynamics involving *both* values *and* emotions.

Finally, the researcher who is theory-centered during field research can generate findings that expose the boundary conditions of established theories, concepts, and relationships relevant to values and emotions (Busse et al., 2017). Given that there is now an emergent line of inquiry in organization and management studies that theorizes relationships between values and emotions (as described in the chapters in this book), field studies can be designed and conducted that focus on *both* values *and* emotions from the outset. This type of field research can refine existing concepts, while also clarifying the limits of established explanations of interplay between emotional dynamics and value commitments and priorities. Pursuing strategies for field data collection and analysis that enable a detailed tracing of both values and emotions within and across different empirical contexts might also clarify the boundaries of conceptual borrowing from other fields (Oswick et al., 2011; Whetten et al., 2009). For example, paying close attention to both values and emotions in organizational and professional field settings might reveal what is lost or hidden when micro-level models of emotion disconnected from macro-level values (e.g., organizational, professional, societal levels) are imported from psychology into organization and management studies.

Disadvantages. I suggest there are two potential disadvantages that researchers should be mindful of when using a theory-centered approach during field research. First, the researcher needs to ensure that the scope and depth of their fieldwork is not negatively impacted by “reductionist curiosity” (Hannah, 2020). Reductionist curiosity is defined as “examining relatedly narrow ideas in exacting detail” (Hannah, 2020: 47). This type of curiosity can mean a researcher notices and pays attention to cues during fieldwork whenever they “sense” close connections with values and emotions, and overlooks more distant connections. For example, the researcher might

notice the “big and loud” emotions that research participants like Dr. X display when values are being violated, only to miss the “smaller and quieter” emotions through which these same participants express and act upon their values in their everyday work. When conducting interviews, a researcher may vigorously and meticulously probe responses that immediately strike them as connecting with values and emotions, while limiting their efforts to probe the interviewee’s other responses where values and emotions seem peripheral. This fieldwork behavior could produce a rich and tightly focused data set that is generative for theory building (Weick, 2007). However, a lack of curiosity about events, actions, and interactions that are dismissed as peripheral can also mean deeper mechanisms about values and emotions may remain hidden because relevant data was never collected in the field.

Second, the researcher needs to be careful that strong theoretical commitments to values and/or emotions do not create a “tendency to theoretically over-determine and over-frame research projects” (Ganesh, 2014: 456) both in the field and during data analysis. During fieldwork, they may reject, rather than generatively engage, doubts about their chosen framing (Locke et al., 2008) and thereby collect insufficient data to rule out alternative theoretical explanations. For example, when a researcher is “locked” into a theoretical framing centered on professional values, they might steer the nature and scope of data gathering in a way that prevents ruling out institutional logics as an alternative framing. The researcher might also ignore sparks of insight in the field which, if pursued with an open mind and imagination (Weick, 2007), could lead to novel theoretical contributions about values, emotions, or some other theory entirely. When coding and iterating between the data and theory (Locke et al., 2022), the researcher might relate their data only to concepts and theories of values and emotions with which they are already familiar and prematurely cut off efforts to explore emergent patterns in the data. As a result, the data patterns can become over-simplified and the findings will be obvious and unsurprising. If the researcher continues to tunnel deeper and deeper into the data using their chosen lens of values and/or emotions even when it is not generative or meaningful for theory building, they risk becoming stuck in an endless, and unproductive, cycle of iteration (Locke et al., 2022).

Phenomenon-Centered Approach to Studying Values and Emotions

In contrast to the theory-centered approach, a phenomenon-centered approach to field research foregrounds understanding an empirical phenomenon during data collection and analysis (Wright et al., 2023). The researcher's efforts are primarily focused on investigating the nature, dynamics, and novelty of the focal phenomenon itself (Dencker et al., 2023; Gkeredakis & Constantinades, 2019). During field data collection, the researcher stays attentive to values and emotions only in so far as they help explain *what* the phenomenon is and *who* is involved and affected, *how* and *why* the phenomenon is happening and impacting the research site, and *when* and *where* the phenomenon is playing out. Thus, in contrast to the theory-centered approach, the researcher's attention to values and emotions during fieldwork is relational to the phenomenon.

My own study of an emergency department in Australia during the global outbreak of the Ebola haemorrhagic virus in 2014 (Wright et al., 2021) is an illustration of the phenomenon-driven approach. I had spent many years collecting data in my fieldsite ED using the theory-centered approach based on values, outlined in the previous section, when an Ebola outbreak occurred in West Africa and was declared a global health emergency by the World Health Organization. I was observing an evening clinical shift at my field-site ED and standing in the “fishbowl” area among a cluster of doctors when the news broke that two nurses in a hospital in the United States had become infected while treating an international traveler suffering from the Ebola virus. Almost instantaneously, emotions exploded to the surface in ways that I had never seen before in the field. Over the days and weeks that followed, Ebola loomed so large in our research participant's professional lives that this phenomenon—which carried risks of serious harm and potentially death for health-workers—seemed to pervade all of their interactions with patients, colleagues, nurses, other clinicians, and trainees. Not surprisingly, it also pervaded the researcher–participant interactions during our observational shifts, debriefs, and interviews because an “extreme phenomenon involving risk” (Hällgren et al., 2018) had up-ended everything our research participants had taken for granted in their professional world.

Shifting from our typical theory-centered approach during field research, we pursued a phenomenon-centered approach directed at Ebola. Investigating an international epidemic was not in my research plans, so I did not have a specific research question in mind. Rather, I simply attended to Ebola as an extreme phenomenon which had emerged unexpectedly and become

constitutive of the human and organizational experiences at our fieldsite. Our research participants' lived experiences of the Ebola phenomenon involved expressing and navigating intense emotions associated with fear both individually and collectively. My fieldnotes captured these emotions not because I was theorizing emotions per se but because, as an organizational ethnographer, I was situated "where the action is" (Goffman, 1969) and the action happened to flow from and through Ebola during this period of data collection. As my fieldnotes recorded the *what*, *how*, *why*, *who*, *when*, and *where* of the Ebola phenomenon unfolding in front of me (Corbin & Strauss, 2014), the "how" included descriptions of different aspects of emotions (e.g., types, intensity) and "who" was feeling them. In debriefs and interviews, when I asked questions about Ebola, interviewees gave narrative responses that were emotion-laden because the phenomenon was bringing their emotions into play in ways that were visceral and surprising for them in a professional setting. In the words of several interviewees and also noted in our fieldnotes, there was "hysteria of Ebola is coming to kill us all." Below, I present an example of how fear, as an emotional response to Ebola, was captured in our fieldnotes and verified in our interviews:

World Health authorities have just announced that a second nurse has become infected while caring for an Ebola patient in a US hospital. In the ED's central work area, doctors and nurses are alarmed that hospitals in the first-world could not prevent Ebola transmission to healthcare workers wearing Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) and following protocols recommended by the Center for Disease Control. 'So how did they get sick if they were wearing the correct PPE?' 'Do we really understand how Ebola is transmitted?' Throughout the shift, doctors anxiously check for updates and review the ED's stocks of protective clothing, concerned about its effectiveness. In a follow-up interview, a doctor justified their fears, 'Suddenly two nurses actually catch it in America and then the staff suddenly can see we've got a right to be scared.' (fieldnotes).

As researchers, our curiosity was directed toward collecting empirical materials in the field that would help us to better understand Ebola as a phenomenon. In doing so, I found that values emerged in response to the "why" question. That is, when our research participants described their emotional feelings about Ebola (*how* the phenomenon was impacting the fieldsite), their responses were entangled with values (*why* the phenomenon was having this effect). Yet the values being expressed by and contested among our research participants regarding what might be "right" and "proper" to do in the current situation were not associated with the medical profession. This is because the values did not stem from the ED as a place of medicine.

Instead, the relevant values were embedded in public hospital EDs as places of social inclusion that are universally accessible for Australian citizens with acute health needs. The values of inclusiveness that are a defining feature of a “place of social inclusion” as a special type of institution are rooted in the values of the democratic state. They elicit moral emotions for the ED’s doctors and nurses, motivating them to work to uphold and protect the values of the public ED as an inclusive place. Delving deeper into this new conceptualization of a “place of social inclusion” revealed how an ED’s inclusive values trigger interplay between moral emotions and fear when an extreme phenomenon like Ebola happens. An emergency physician gave this explanation in an interview:

That’s not the way we’re built in the Emergency Department. We can’t say, ‘Come here if you’re sick and we’ll see you and we’ll sort you out unless you’ve got Ebola’. There’s that real challenge to the way we’ve always seen ourselves as ‘We’ll see anyone, we’ll help you, we’ll heal you’. And Ebola’s really challenged that. And I think that’s what’s caused that real level of angst and it’s challenged the way you perceive yourself [as an emergency physician of a public hospital ED] much more so than anything else.

Adopting a phenomenon-centered approach in the field meant the “right” data (illustrated in the above quote) was collected that brought the tensions and emotions surrounding the ED’s values of social inclusion to the surface so they were visible to our research team when coding for patterns. It inspired deeper analysis of the relationships between emotions and values by comparing field data collected when the ED was impacted by the extreme phenomenon of Ebola and when it was not. The resultant process model explained the dynamics of fear and moral emotions involved in protecting the values of a place of social inclusion from both normal and extreme risks. Overall, by pursuing a phenomenon-centered approach during field research, we were able to bring forward new theoretical insights into the emotional dynamics and values of places of social inclusion (Wright et al., 2021).

Advantages. The phenomenon-centered approach to field research offers several advantages for studying values and emotions. First, it is underpinned by an expansionist curiosity as the field researcher “striv[es] to understand the full corpus of an issue in broad strokes” (Hannah, 2020: 46). This means a researcher can adopt this approach in the field when they come across an empirical phenomenon that is relevant to organizational and institutional life and which they find inherently fascinating. With their imagination sparked, like ours was with the Ebola virus, the researcher engages with the focal

phenomenon with an intense curiosity—and assembles rich and voluminous empirical materials with energy and fascination—that the phenomenon’s nature and dynamics are likely to become “transparently observable” (Pettigrew, 1990: 275). Values, emotions, and the relationships between them—if relevant—will come to the surface.

Second, the researcher’s attention in the field is oriented toward understanding the particularities of a phenomenon in its local context (Davison & Martinsons, 2016). Scholars have argued that research designs which enable the researcher to pay close attention to the phenomenon in context may unveil new concepts and relationships (e.g., Bamberger, 2008; Bamberger & Pratt, 2010; Davison & Martinsons, 2016; Johns, 2017) and can help protect against “strip[ping] out most of what matters” for theory building (Weick, 2007: 18). Thus, the phenomenon-centered approach during fieldwork can be useful for developing a more contextualized understanding of when and where relationships between different types of values and emotions are activated.

Third, because the researcher does not view their field research as being narrowly scoped by the theoretical domains of values and emotions, the researcher is free to engage with multiple and heterogenous knowledge communities within and across disciplines (Davis, 2010; Hibbert et al., 2014). This freedom encourages engaging with field data collection and analysis by openly and pluralistically seeking out diverse ideas, competing views, alternative explanations, and new literatures to help theorize the phenomenon captured in the empirical material from the field. As a consequence, the phenomenon-centered approach has the potential to carve out a wider and more imaginative path to new *both/and* insights into values and emotions, compared to the “conservative incrementalism” of theory creeping forward within dominant knowledge communities (Hibbert et al., 2014: 280).

Disadvantages. I see two key disadvantages that researchers interested in studying values and emotions should bear in mind when adopting a phenomenon-centered approach during field research. First, the theoretical insights into values and emotions that emerge are generated by what Van Maanen (2009: 251) has referred to as “the logic of pluck-and-luck discovery.” The researcher’s interest in the field lies in explaining the focal phenomenon. There is no guarantee that focusing fieldwork attention on that specific phenomenon will ultimately turn out to be productive and meaningful for novel theory building about values and/or emotions and the relationships between them.

Second, the researcher may become so enthralled with the phenomenon chosen as the central focus of their attention during fieldwork that it blurs

their ability to abstract a theoretical explanation anchored by a set of precise concepts about values and emotions and the relationships between them. Scholars argue that theory building is obstructed when researchers cannot see the forest for the trees in their chosen context (Bansal & Corley, 2012). Extending this analogy to the phenomenon-centered approach, a researcher's vision could become so "zeroed in" on the phenomenon that they miss *both* forests and trees—that is, relevant literatures and potentially salient concepts associated with values and emotions. When the novelty of a phenomenon overshadows forests and trees, the result is likely to be a set of findings that is overly descriptive of the phenomenon and offers minimal theoretical contributions (Wright et al., 2023).

Personhood Approach to Studying Values and Emotions

In contrast to the previous approaches which focus the researcher's attention on theory or phenomena when collecting and analyzing field data, the final approach to studying values and emotions directs the researcher's attention inward to their own personhood (Wright & Wright, 2019). A personhood approach recognizes that researchers are people who experience fieldwork in "emotional, personal and subjective ways" (Coffey, 1999: 10) and requires self-reflexivity about a researcher's own value priorities and emotions in relation to those of their research participants and the field context. By interrupting the ordinary flow of fieldwork to contemplate "how we are in relation with the contexts we study and with our informants" (Fine, 1994: 72), potential opens up for a shift in perspective on the ways values and emotions are showing up in the field. As Hibbert (2021: 1) notes, "the essence of reflexivity ... is a process of engaging with experience, that changes our ways of understanding."

I had an unusual experience of the personhood approach to studying values and emotions when undertaking my research in the ED (Wright & Wright, 2019). My then teenaged daughter became seriously ill with recurring seizures, and I had to take her multiple times to my fieldsite ED. In doing so, I repositioned my relations with the field from competent researcher to frightened mother of a patient. As I explain in a personal essay co-authored with my daughter (Wright & Wright, 2019), this experience of relationally repositioning myself with the field aroused a complicated bundle of emotions (in addition to my maternal fears). It also surfaced tensions over moral values

because “the answer to the question ‘who am I when I am here?’ had become unsettled and ambiguous” (Wright & Wright, 2019: 267).

From the perspective of my own emotions, prioritizing intimate engagement with my fieldsite over professional distance (Anteby, 2013; Cunliffe & Karunanayake, 2013) aroused feelings of vulnerability and a sense of being exposed. At the same time, as an outsider researcher with some insider knowledge of the ED context and a trusted relationship with doctors built up over 7 years of fieldwork observing and interviewing (Brannick & Coghlan, 2007), I felt empowered. My preunderstanding of what was happening at each stage of my daughter’s patient journey through the ED allowed me to better support her, and I also felt reassured and grateful that she was in expert care.

From a values perspective, I experienced some values tension surrounding “mutuality” in interpersonal ethics, which involves “the researcher hold[ing] herself morally accountable to research participants” (Cunliffe & Alcadiyani, 2016: 541). As a mother, I was observing the work of my research participants from a much more intimate perspective than I ever could as a researcher, including being able to follow a patient’s journey through the ED (something I had not been permitted to do previously). Ethically, I couldn’t record these lived experiences as data, but I also could not unsee them when I was trying to make sense of the field data we had collected prior to my daughter becoming ill.

Ultimately, bringing my own personhood into the ED field research opened up not only my emotions but also novel and unfamiliar sensemaking cues. I began self-reflexively looking at “old” data through a “new” lens of my shared humanity with the research participants. I could more clearly see how my fieldsite ED was animated by inclusive values and moral emotions when treating all patients and was not unique to the extreme phenomenon of Ebola. This increased the conceptual clarity of the emergent theory of EDs as places of social inclusion.

Advantages. The personhood-centered approach to field research offers three major advantages for studying values and emotions. First, fieldwork is deepened by the researcher’s reflexive attention in terms of “looking *at the self* ... and looking *from the self*” (Hibbert, 2021: 12, italics in original). Researchers are encouraged to explore values and emotions in the “spaces of possibilities” (Cunliffe & Karunanayake, 2013) that emerge in researcher–participant interactions, including insiderness or outsiderhood and degrees of personal engagement or professional distance (Anteby, 2013; Cunliffe & Karunanayake, 2013; Langley & Klag, 2019). Fieldwork unfolds as a fluid, evolving and pluralistic process of multi-layered attention to how, when, and

for whom values are navigated and emotions are expressed in the relations among the researcher, participants, and the context.

Second, shared humanity with research participants creates potential for experiences in the field that push the researcher to “be astonished by what is most familiar and make familiar what is strange,” which Galibert (2004: 456) argues is necessary for conducting field research effectively and generatively. When a researcher’s personhood is reflexively engaged in the field, different aspects of values and emotions can become animated in their interactions with participants, which can strike the researcher as surprising and deserving of more targeted data collection. Other field aspects that had previously seemed noteworthy, perhaps guided by a theory-centered approach, might now appear as less relevant. Thus, the personhood approach can unlock new and surprising ways for researchers to “see” the enactment of values and emotions in the field and to capture them in empirical materials as the basis for revelatory insights.

Third, the personhood approach supports more novel theorizing by encouraging the researcher to embrace and act upon their emotions during fieldwork and in the overlaps with data analysis, rather than attempt to neutralize or ignore their own feelings and vulnerabilities. As Whiteman (2010: 335) advocates, when field researchers approach “strong feelings as legitimate analytic clues, we can enrich our understanding of management phenomena and open up new lines of enquiry.” Drawing on the work of reflexivity scholars (Cunliffe, 2003; Hibbert, 2021; Hibbert et al., 2014), reflexive awareness coupled with strong emotional cues can open up a generative space for the researcher to interpret and reinterpret things they once found familiar in the field context and/or their emergent theoretical insights about participants’ experiences.

Disadvantages. I suggest there are two key disadvantages to centering attention on personhood during field research for values and emotions. First, although there is a growing body of literature advocating reflexive practice in management and organization research (Alvesson et al., 2008; Cutcher et al., 2020; Hibbert, 2021; Hibbert et al., 2014; Johnson & Duberley, 2003), many researchers may feel they lack the necessary self-reflexivity and self-conscious awareness to implement this approach in a meaningful way in their own field research. Experiences of value tensions, emotions, and vulnerability in the context and in interactions with participants might, or might not, provoke self-reflexivity for a researcher.

Second, engaging in personhood approach requires “being courageous with our identities” (Howard-Grenville, 2021: 2) and in our relations with

the field and research participants in ways that a researcher may find uncomfortable. Some researchers who study values and emotions may resist the expression of values and emotions in their interactions with their fieldsite, research participants, and their own sense of self. There may also be concerns about how to publish the results of this approach.

Conclusion

This chapter advanced methodological scholarship of values and emotions by presenting three approaches to undertaking qualitative field research: (1) theory-centered approach, (2) phenomenon-centered approach, and (3) personhood-centered approach. Drawing on illustrative examples from my own field research in emergency departments, I showed how each approach has been used in field research that generated findings and contributions that explicitly theorized *both* values *and* emotions. Table 23.1 presented a summary of the three approaches.

Throughout the chapter, each approach was presented separately for ease of presentation. However, researchers can use the approaches in conjunction with each other to study values and emotions. They are able to switch between approaches if new phenomenon spark their interest or events occur that trigger moments of deeper engagement with their own personhood. Field researchers will find these approaches helpful in opening fruitful avenues for more generative theorizing of values, emotions and the relationships and dynamics between them.

Table 23.1 Summary of qualitative fieldwork approaches to values and emotions

	Theory-centred approach	Phenomenon-centred approach	Personhood approach
Focus of researcher attention during field data collection and analysis	Theories of values and/or emotions and gaps in literature	What, who, how, why, when and where, of the empirical phenomenon	Own value priorities and emotions in relation to the field context and research participants
Advantages	- Positions researcher to engage with theoretical puzzles that matter for values and/or emotions - Draws on researcher's existing expertise in a literature - Can generate findings that expose boundary conditions of established theories	- Curiosity-driven data collection allows values and/or emotions to come to the surface if relevant - Contextualised understanding of expressing values and arousing emotions - Openness to diverse ideas and alternative explanations promotes imaginative theorizing	- Explores values and emotions in spaces of possibilities in researcher-participant interactions - May unlock new and surprising ways to see values and emotions during fieldwork - Reflexive awareness and emotional cues can inspire novel theorizing
Disadvantages	- Narrow theoretical focus may reduce curiosity in data collection - Failure to collect data on alternative explanations	- No guarantee of productive theory building about values and emotions - Fascination with phenomenon may generate overly descriptive findings	- Requires a high level of self-reflexivity and self-awareness to implement - Researcher may be uncomfortable with vulnerability and unsure how to report the approach in publications

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24

Navigating Doubt: Emotional Complexity in Child Sexual Abuse Casework

Mari Dalen Herland

Introduction

The profession of social work is intrinsically emotional. Engaging with families in crisis, navigating ethical dilemmas, and intervening in cases involving child sexual abuse require intense emotional labor. These encounters evoke profound feelings such as doubt, fear, anger, guilt, and empathy, that are neither incidental nor disruptive. Rather, they are integral to how social workers interpret and respond to ethically charged and morally complex situations. Yet, despite their centrality, emotions have often been treated as peripheral in both theory and organizational practice.

Recent research increasingly emphasizes the importance of emotional reflexivity, the ability of practitioners to identify, critically assess, and learn from their emotional responses (Allan et al., 2018; Barlow & Hall, 2007; Herland, 2022). Emotional reflexivity enables professionals to better understand the moral foundations of their actions and enhances their capacity to engage ethically with clients. However, this reflexivity cannot flourish in isolation. It must be nurtured by organizational leadership that legitimizes emotional discourse and provides reflective spaces for practitioners to process the emotional toll of their work.

Emotions often arise in situations where deeply held values are at stake or in conflict (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024a, 2024b). For example, feelings

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of unease may signal tension between the values of child protection and family autonomy. Thus, emotions serve both as indicators and constructors of professional values. Emotional reflexivity, therefore, also becomes a process of value inquiry, a means of interrogating and clarifying what matters most in professional decision-making.

In this chapter, I explore the research question: How do professional social workers handle emotions and values in cases of sexual abuse involving children? Drawing on empirical investigation, the chapter illustrates how professionals navigate the multilayered concept of uncertainty within child welfare institutions where decisions must be made under judicial discretion and in accordance with legislation, often amid doubt and emotional strain. These predicaments can generate internal conflict, as workers strive to uphold professional values while grappling with hesitation and ambiguity. This tension may manifest as a blurred phenomenon, what some describe as a “gut feeling” which can translate into physical discomfort.

When formal recognition of uncertainty and its emotional dimensions is lacking, professionals often develop informal practices to cope. These adaptive strategies, while necessary, may conflict with formal organizational or institutional rules. Such responses raise critical questions about institutional responsibility and the paradigms that govern contemporary social work. When emotional and normative needs go unmet, individuals create informal structures to fulfill them, prompting a deeper inquiry: What do official systems reveal when they fail to reflect and support the lived reality and natural flow of practice?

To clarify this argument, the chapter highlights the practical challenges faced by social workers, particularly in emotionally intense situations such as child abuse cases. The emotional toll of this work creates a demanding environment that significantly affects professionals (Evans et al., 2006).

By foregrounding uncertainty as a focal concept, this chapter deepens the understanding of emotional reflexivity and value inquiry in social work. It argues that the intersection of emotions, values, and uncertainty deserves greater attention, not only in theory but also in the design of organizational systems that support ethical and emotionally sustainable practice.

Theoretical Framework

The profession of social work is intrinsically emotional. Engaging with families in crisis, navigating ethical dilemmas, and intervening in cases involving child sexual abuse require intense emotional labor. These encounters evoke

profound feelings such as doubt, fear, anger, guilt, and empathy—that are neither incidental nor disruptive. Rather, they are integral to how social workers interpret and respond to ethically charged and morally complex situations. Yet, despite their centrality, emotions have often been treated as peripheral in both theory and organizational practice.

Recent research increasingly emphasizes the importance of emotional reflexivity; the ability of practitioners to identify, critically assess, and learn from their emotional responses (Allan et al., 2018; Herland, 2022; Morrison, 2007; Stanley & Mettilda, 2020). Emotional reflexivity enables professionals to better understand the moral foundations of their actions and enhances their capacity to engage ethically with clients. However, as noted, this reflexivity cannot flourish in isolation. It must be nurtured by organizational leadership that legitimizes emotional discourse and provides reflective spaces for practitioners to process the emotional toll of their work.

This process of navigating and reflecting on emotions is not separate from professional practice; rather, it constitutes value work performed within it (Espedal et al., 2024). Emotions often arise in situations where deeply held values are at stake or in conflict. For example, feelings of unease may signal tension between the values of child protection and family autonomy. Thus, emotions serve both as indicators and constructors of professional values. Emotional reflexivity, therefore, also becomes a process of value inquiry, a means of interrogating and clarifying what matters most in professional decision-making.

This chapter illustrates how professionals navigate the multilayered concept of uncertainty within child welfare institutions, where decisions must be made under judicial discretion and in accordance with legislation, often amid doubt and emotional strain. These predicaments can generate internal conflict, as workers strive to uphold professional values while grappling with hesitation and ambiguity. This tension may manifest as a blurred phenomenon—what some describe as a “gut feeling”, which can translate into physical discomfort.

According to Spicer (2021), doubt is an important yet largely overlooked part of organizational life. More recently, the concept of phenomenological doubt has been introduced in organization studies to highlight the relevance of the multiplicity and the equity of viewpoints to avoid ideological understanding of organizational life (Strati, 2025). When formal recognition of doubt and its emotional dimensions is lacking, professionals often develop informal practices to cope. These adaptive strategies, while necessary, may conflict with formal organizational or institutional rules. Such responses raise critical questions about institutional responsibility and the paradigms that

govern contemporary social work. When emotional and normative needs go unmet, individuals create informal structures to fulfill them, prompting a deeper inquiry: What do official systems reveal when they fail to reflect and support the lived reality and natural flow of practice?

To clarify this argument, the chapter highlights the practical challenges faced by social workers, particularly in emotionally intense situations such as child abuse cases. The emotional toll of this work creates a demanding environment that significantly affects professionals. Existing academic literature typically frames these emotional challenges as individual burdens that may lead to burnout, emphasizing coping strategies like supervision and peer support. While these approaches are valuable, they often treat emotions as side effects of practice rather than central components of it.

By foregrounding uncertainty as a focal concept, this chapter deepens the understanding of emotional reflexivity and value inquiry in social work. It argues that the intersection of emotions, values, and uncertainty deserves greater attention—not only in theory but also in the design of organizational systems that support ethical and emotionally sustainable practice.

Traditionally, social work theory has emphasized values as central to professional identity and practice. Wright et al. (2017, p. 202) highlight the historical role of values in professional life, referring to early sociological work that underscored the moral force of professions and the centrality of altruism. While there is growing interest in how normative values are retained within professions, scholarship remains limited on how these values manifest in organizational settings and how frontline professionals contribute to their preservation (p. 201). Wright et al. focus on institutional work related to the normative pillar, examining how professionals maintain shared values through everyday interactions within organizational structures.

However, just as values are foundational to institutional life, emotions are essential to social life, and thus deserve a more explicit place in organizational theory. Despite their significance, emotions have often been treated implicitly in literature. Drawing on my earlier work (Herland, 2022), I build on pioneering contributions by Biestek (1950), Hollis (1949), Horney (1934), and Rogers and Farson (1957) to explore the role of emotions in social work practice and organizational life, particularly within child welfare contexts.

Emotions are fundamental to human experience, serving a wide range of purposes, from alerting individuals to danger to facilitating the formation of social relationships (Grant et al., 2014; Herland, 2022). In social work, emotionally charged cases, especially those involving trauma, suffering, violence, and abuse, can provoke significant distress (Douglas, 2013; Horwitz, 1998; Herland, 2025). Sexual abuse cases often involve uncertainty

due to lack of disclosure (Steine et al., 2016), intensifying complex emotions such as ambivalence and doubt.

While much of the literature on professional stress focuses on structural and organizational factors such as legislation, workload, and institutional rules, there is a need to more explicitly theorize the emotional dimensions of practice. Professionals are expected to maintain emotional awareness and regulation while engaging in emotionally demanding labor (Bunce et al., 2019), yet the reflective emotional complexity of their work is often overlooked.

To address this gap, I propose a contemporary framework that integrates emotional reflexivity with value work and value inquiry. Emotional reflexivity involves identifying and observing one's own emotions such as anxiety, empathy, and doubt and understanding how these emotions shape professional judgment and behavior. Value work refers to the active engagement with normative principles in practice, while value inquiry involves critically examining the meaning and application of these principles in specific contexts (Espedal et al., 2024).

By bringing emotional reflexivity into dialogue with value work and value inquiry, we can better understand how emotions and values are intertwined in professional life. This integrated perspective allows us to explore how professionals navigate uncertainty and ambiguity, particularly in cases involving taboo topics such as child sexual abuse. It also sheds light on the phenomenon of "unclean" emotions, those that are socially or professionally uncomfortable but nonetheless significant.

A persistent dilemma in the field is the lack of organizational responsibility for supporting emotional and normative complexity. Institutions may inadvertently avoid addressing uncertainty, resulting in a cycle of ambiguity in which professionals feel unsupported. This complicates their ability to manage tensions between values such as knowledge-based decision-making and efficiency. By exploring the causes and consequences of this organizational irresponsibility, the discussion contributes to a more cohesive framework that emphasizes emotional awareness and normative reflection at the level of organizational management.

In my earlier work (Herland, 2022), I argued that emotions can heighten awareness of individuals' pre-existing cultural reasoning and beliefs. In this chapter, I extend that argument by examining how institutions can create space for doubt, ambiguity, and emotional complexity. This matters not only for individual well-being but also for the integrity of professional practice.

Methodology

This chapter draws on a qualitative, interview-based empirical study designed to deepen the theoretical exploration and conceptualization of emotions, values, and beliefs within organizational settings, specifically in the context of child welfare services (Kristensen & Herland, 2026). The primary aim of the study was to gather insights into informants' experiences and perspectives on emotions encountered while working on cases involving suspicions of child sexual abuse.

To ensure rich and meaningful data, participants were selected based on a criterion of having more than three years of experience in child welfare services, particularly in handling abuse cases. This requirement was established to ensure that the caseworkers had accumulated sufficient professional experience to offer in-depth reflections grounded in practice.

In addition, I have sought to transparently outline my own position to uphold the integrity and reliability of the analysis by adopting a reflexive stance (Braun & Clark, 2021). This approach involves maintaining a critical and introspective perspective, remaining aware of how my emotional narration may influence the interpretation of the data, being a former case worker myself having experienced working with child abuse cases. The findings are presented in a manner that is both reflective and analytically rigorous, incorporating theoretical perspectives to enrich the analysis.

The following findings section will present empirical examples illustrating how professionals draw on emotional and intuitive skills to navigate emotionally charged situations. Analytical questions addressed in the material include: What constitutes acceptable behavior within the organization? What are considered appropriate emotional responses, and how are these issues discussed among staff? What values and beliefs embedded in the organization surface in these narratives? Handling cases of child sexual abuse often requires professionals to reconcile their personal values with those of the organization, fostering a workplace culture where shared beliefs and principles guide decision-making in the face of uncertainty.

Findings

In the following sections of this chapter, I will examine empirical examples and offer a more in-depth analytical exploration of employees' experiences of uncertainty and the tension of doubt in relation to cases of child sexual abuse. Based on the research question of this chapter: how do social workers handle

emotions and values in cases of sexual abuse where children are involved, I will present three overall categories: Reading Others: Developing Emotional Literacy, Self-Awareness: Listening to the Body and Embracing Embodiment, and Organizational Insight: Understanding Development and Change.

I will further illuminate what occurs when professionals are compelled to act in situations where they must rely on gut feelings or internal doubts about what to do or what they believe, particularly when faced with suspicions of abuse.

Reading Others: Developing Emotional Literacy

The overall impression of the empirical data, it becomes evident that working on cases involving child sexual abuse, presents numerous emotionally demanding challenges. This type of work requires practitioners to maintain confidence in their roles while navigating the emotional weight of doubt and fear. Several participants described barriers they encountered when addressing the topic of abuse, despite their professional knowledge and experience. One informant expressed this tension:

We are not good enough at using what we actually know about the topic of abuse. I believe we have a lot of knowledge about it, and you might be aware of all the small signs to look out for, but then we struggle to apply this knowledge in practice.

Another participant added:

Knowledge about the subject is very wise, but I think maybe you're not confident enough in yourself, leading to a fear of the answer. But don't ask the child if you're afraid of the answer.

These excerpts highlight emotional uncertainty, particularly doubt and hesitation to engage with the topic of abuse. They also reflect fear, especially regarding the child's potential responses to sensitive inquiries. This raises questions about what is expected of staff within the organization and the values embedded in these expectations. Addressing abuse appears to be an overwhelming task that evokes significant emotional strain. There is reason to question whether there is space within the organization to accommodate these emotions. One informant emphasized the importance of awareness and courage in confronting these challenges:

So, I think the essential thing is that we keep ourselves updated. I am up to date on the theory, but I also think it's important to be curious and to dare to dig in and ask about things when I have doubts. This can lead to experiences where you recognize something might be wrong when you just dare to ask about it. Yeah, so I think there are two key concepts: knowledge and experience, crucial to daring to articulate one's gut feelings.

This quote illustrates the complexity of working with abuse and the uncertainty that accompanies it. It also prompts reflection on the strategies staff rely on when facing doubt or when their intuition indicates that something may be wrong. This leads to a reflection on whether emotional states are compatible with what is perceived as rational thinking. Another participant revealed a layer of ambivalence related to assumptions about perpetrators:

We can also fall into the trap, I think, many times, of trying to find out who the perpetrator is. But in many cases, it's about who the perpetrators are; often it's not just one.

This insight underscores how preconceived notions can hinder the recognition of multiple perpetrators in abuse cases, highlighting both the ability and the problematic nature of reading others. Discomfort may lead employees to hesitate in pursuing further investigations, but also to misconceptions. Gut feelings alone are insufficient; continued inquiry and legal processes require an organizational culture that supports openness—not only to facts but also to uncertainty and emotionally complex states such as hesitation, intuition, and doubt.

There is reason to ask how systems can take responsibility when they lack the structural support to navigate such uncertainty, especially when it remains beneath the surface. Despite the legal requirement to complete investigations within three months according to the Norwegian Welfare Act, staff are nonetheless expected to act. Yet emotions do not simply vanish, they may be suppressed or dismissed, both individually and organizationally. Participants highlighted lack of time and the inability to build meaningful relationships with children and families as major organizational barriers. One informant explained:

What is difficult in our job is that we don't have time. We don't have time to build relationships with children that are crucial for them in order to disclose abuse with us.

Another added:

As a caseworker, it's not always easy because I only have one hour for a conversation, and then maybe... maybe I'll move on. You notice it best when you're in it, meeting them often; there is perhaps a need, if we suspect something, to meet them more frequently and get to know them better.

These reflections underscore the importance of relationship-building and how time constraints can obstruct meaningful engagement, all while managing the ambiguity of being in doubt about abuse. While efficiency may be a core organizational value, it can conflict with the emotional demands of abuse cases, creating a profound dilemma.

Self-Awareness: Listening to the Body and Embracing Embodiment

Employees reported feelings of unease, uncertainty, fear, and discomfort when suspecting sexual abuse. One might wonder where all these emotions go, do they manifest physically in the body, linger in the unconscious, or disrupt the caseworker's sleep. One informant captured this emotional strain this way:

Our emotions play a significant role in how we handle an investigation and conclude these cases. Do I have the strength to confront this?

This statement, echoed by others, highlights the need for emotional awareness and organizational support. Working with sexual abuse is challenging on many levels. It can be difficult to accept that children are subjected to such harm, and the stigma and shame surrounding the issue often evoke discomfort. Some of the informants also emphasized how this discomfort was residing in their bodies foremost. Several informants expressed unease when discussing suspected child sexual abuse. Two described their experiences as follows:

I think for my part it is mostly unease. What can I say? I expect unexpected things may happen to those I work with. I find it hard to confront the severity of what the child is going through. I do, however, handle it better than not knowing what has happened.

I feel uneasy. I experience a frustrating feeling because I really want to protect them... I feel like I'm failing.

These quotes reflect complex embodied emotions such as helplessness, blending responsibility, anxiety, and foremost uncertainty. They suggest that organizational values may not foster a sense of safety or provide adequate

guidance for navigating the emotional terrain of this taboo subject. The professionals interviewed engaged with the surrounding culture, including organizational values, leadership, and support structures, all of which shaped how they coped with emotions and expressed themselves, considering their emotional literacy.

Analysis of the empirical data primarily emphasized uncertainty and emotional intensity as significant challenges, alongside feelings of inadequacy or lack of confidence in handling such situations. One informant expressed this concern:

We are not good enough at utilizing what we know. I believe we have a lot of knowledge about abuse... you just 'kind of know,' and while you may be aware of the small signs to look for, you still struggle to apply it in practice.

This excerpt points to a form of tacit knowledge, an intuitive awareness of subtle indicators that several informants described as a "gut feeling." Yet, many questioned the reliability of these instincts, expressing uncertainty and self-doubt. This ambiguity reflects a broader emotional landscape marked by blurriness, ambivalence, and hesitation. Another participant elaborated:

Our emotions play a significant role in how we handle and conclude an investigation—whether it leads to action or dismissal of the case, and this is particularly true when it comes to sexual abuse cases. It's about asking oneself, 'Can I truly process and confront this?'...

Emotional awareness and confidence in one's professional abilities, alongside organizational recognition of these emotional states, are essential, especially when action is required. However, doubt persists, particularly regarding case outcomes and decision-making. Articulating thoughts and embodied emotions was not always straightforward, especially within peer interactions. One informant voiced her frustration:

I feel, you know, like damn I just can't handle such cases... Because it involves intense discussions about emotions, and I think it's crucial to discuss one's feelings to distinguish between what's happening in your body and your mind. I find it challenging to confront this with colleagues. And the hopelessness about uncovering it, because what help is available for these children...

This statement reflects emotional strain and frustration. It also raises questions about whether such emotions are accepted within the organizational culture and whether formal structures exist to address these complexities.

If not, one might question whether informal or shadow structures emerge to contain these dilemmas, and if emotions are not acknowledged, where do they go, one might also wonder. These questions center around two key dimensions that become evident in the empirical material: how emotions and reactions are managed at both personal and organizational levels, and to what extent these processes are formalized.

Organizational Insight: Understanding Development and Change

For child welfare professionals, hesitation and uncertainty often correlate with fear, of doing wrong, but also regarding potential responses from children. This fear may prevent some workers from fully exploring cases and uncovering abuse. The data analysis revealed that emotional obstacles occur when dealing with sensitive topics like sexual abuse. Despite possessing knowledge and having experience, many informants reported significant barriers in these cases. They emphasized the need for confidence and organizational support to navigate complex situations and follow emotions. One informant described the hesitation leading to physical toll this way:

I think and ponder a lot, which leads to more headaches. It's not exactly nausea, but there's a strange feeling in my body indicating that something isn't right. Something is wrong. In the end, I feel responsible for the case. Yes, so I physically feel it in my body. I can sense my arms becoming heavy; there's a sensation that settles in my body. But it mainly churns within me... leading to headaches and more tension in my neck when you work with such cases.

Several informants emphasized these types of embodied emotional reactions. Such sensations call for organizational guidance, safeguarding, and competence. If left unaddressed, these emotions may become internalized, often residing in their bodies. These experiences often include ambivalence and complex, physical manifestations of uncertainty, yet this remains unclear in the data. Moreover, a lack of language to articulate and process these emotions emerged as a significant barrier. The interviews suggested that explicit guidance and leadership are necessary to manage the emotional burden associated with child abuse cases. One participant shared:

You can't get to the bottom of it... You can't figure out what's going on... something is wrong. You see children struggling and having difficulties. And we can rarely uncover it. That makes me very worried... because if there's one thing we seldom manage to uncover, it's sexual abuse. So, I get a bad feeling in my stomach.

This quote underscores the uncertainty and bodily reactions that accompany such cases. These complex emotions generate discomfort and may affect professionals' health. They appear to linger in their minds and bodies, unaddressed, and may be perceived as "unclean" or incompatible with organizational values that prioritize rationality and procedural clarity. Another participant reflected on the difficulty of uncovering the truth:

The expression on the child's face suggests that something is seriously wrong. It's difficult to get to the bottom of it. First of all, you can't necessarily prove it, and we know that it's hard for a child to disclose it. It's stigmatized for those who are exposed... And I've never encountered a case where a child confesses or admits to the abuse. There's always denial.

This excerpt illustrates the doubt and emotional complexity professionals face in terms of uncertainty when working with abuse cases, as well as the challenges of accessing the "truth" in a stigmatized and emotionally charged context. This empirical exploration has shown potential for understanding "gray areas" within the organization, which opens up possibilities for structural change concerning values and emotions.

Discussion

This empirical exploration has identified three overall findings: Reading Others, Developing Emotional Literacy, Self-Awareness, Listening to the Body and Embracing Embodiment, and Organizational Insight: Understanding Development and Change.

Following, I will discuss this chapter's research question: How do social workers handle emotions and values in cases of sexual abuse where children are involved? Several emotions that emerge are central to child welfare work on abuse cases; however, they often appear messy and unrefined, misaligned with the values upheld within the organization. Structural constraints frequently hinder such efforts, including the emotional toll, the time required to build relationships with clients, the absence of an organizational climate conducive to supporting these emotions, and the lack of language to articulate them. Moreover, the failure to acknowledge the embodied responsibility shouldered by caseworkers calls for a paradigm shift in how these issues are approached within child welfare organizations, fostering a new public management ideal (Visser, 2025).

A central dimension of social work is the ability to "read others" the skill of interpreting the emotions, reactions, and subtle cues of those around us.

This capacity is especially vital in child protection, where professionals work with children who have experienced suffering, such as trauma and abuse. By attuning themselves to nonverbal signals such as body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice, practitioners can better understand their clients' emotional states and foster empathetic, trust-based relationships. This, in turn, contributes to a more supportive organizational climate, provided the institution values and legitimizes these "softer" emotional competencies (Herland, 2025).

Equally important is the dimension of self-awareness. This involves the ability to recognize and comprehend one's own emotional responses, including complex and messy feelings such as uncertainty and doubt, emotions that have been explored throughout this chapter. These internal states can significantly influence decision-making, behavior, and interpersonal dynamics, often manifesting as anxiety or indecision. Cultivating self-awareness enables professionals to acknowledge these emotions, trace their origins, and develop healthier coping mechanisms. However, without an organizational structure that actively supports emotional reflection and psychological safety, such efforts may be stifled or unsustainable.

The third dimension pertains to "reading the organizational environment," a skill particularly relevant for leaders and executives. This involves understanding the emotional and relational dynamics at play within the workplace, including how structural conditions and interpersonal relationships affect employee well-being. Especially in times of uncertainty, leaders who are attuned to these dynamics can foster environments that promote resilience, trust, and emotional health. Organizations that prioritize emotional well-being are better equipped to support their staff in managing feelings of doubt and insecurity—ultimately cultivating more engaged, satisfied, and ethically grounded employees.

Together, these three dimensions raise a critical question: Do organizational structures exist that actively recognize and promote emotional competence at all levels? Addressing the emotional complexities within institutions, particularly in child welfare, can enhance collaboration, strengthen morale and professional ethics, and foster a workplace culture that prioritizes emotional health. This, in turn, benefits not only employees and clients but also advances the broader mission of child welfare by bridging a long-missing link between emotional insight and institutional integrity.

The findings presented in this chapter underscore a central argument: the practical dilemmas of social work—particularly in child welfare that cannot be adequately addressed without a structured and organizationally supported approach to emotions and emotional reflexivity. In an institutional field

that prioritizes objectivity, certainty, and procedural efficiency, there is little space to process feelings of doubt, hesitation, and emotional discomfort. This absence contributes to high levels of emotional distress among professionals, especially in cases involving trauma and abuse.

The tension between emotional acceptance and the operational demands of new public management is particularly pronounced. Time constraints and productivity pressures challenge organizations to reconcile human-centered service delivery with bureaucratic imperatives. Achieving this balance requires more than individual coping strategies, it demands a systemic rethinking of how values and emotions are embedded in daily practice. Emotional acceptance must be actively integrated into organizational culture, not merely acknowledged in abstract terms. This also calls for a broader redefinition of efficiency—one that includes emotional sustainability as a core component of quality service delivery.

Emotional awareness has the potential to improve outcomes for children and families, but only if it is institutionally supported. Otherwise, case-workers risk absorbing the emotional strain physically, as Douglas (2003) describes in her notion of “impurities.” The empirical data reveals how systems often evade accountability, leaving professionals to carry emotional burdens without adequate structural support. In such contexts, informal or “shadow structures” may emerge—networks and practices that accommodate messy emotions like uncertainty and doubt, even when these conflict with formal rules.

This phenomenon raises critical questions about the legitimacy and relevance of official organizational frameworks. If formal systems fail to reflect the lived reality of practice, can they truly be considered sufficient? Without foundational structures to navigate emotional complexity, responsibility is frequently deflected, and accountability becomes diffuse. Professionals, in turn, construct informal mechanisms to manage emotional and normative tensions—an act of resistance, but also a symptom of systemic failure.

Organizational norms shape not only behavior but also the emotional vocabulary available to professionals. In abuse cases, where disclosure is often delayed (Steine et al., 2016), practitioners may rely on emotional reflexivity, gut feelings, embodied discomfort, and intuitive judgments, to guide decision-making. Yet these emotional tools are rarely legitimized within institutional discourse. The absence of formal recognition for emotional reflexivity leaves professionals navigating uncertainty without a map, forced to reconcile intuitive responses with rigid procedural expectations.

This chapter calls for a pragmatic reassessment of how emotions are viewed in professional contexts. Drawing on Douglas’s (2003) concept of

“messy and unclear” realities, it becomes clear that emotional pressures can trigger instinctive reactions or moral panic. Rather than suppressing these dynamics, organizations must create structured spaces for reflection, legitimizing emotional discourse and supporting practitioners in emotionally demanding roles.

The dualism between emotion and cognition is a false binary. These elements are deeply intertwined, especially in ethically complex situations. Theoretical perspectives must evolve to reflect this entanglement, recognizing that emotions are not irrational disruptions but essential components of professional reasoning. Emotional reflexivity, when institutionally supported, becomes a powerful tool for value inquiry, helping professionals interrogate what matters most in moments of uncertainty.

A pivotal question emerges: How do emotions influence decision-making in contexts marked by ambiguity and doubt? And how do organizations manage the “unclean” dimensions of emotional experience, where emotion and cognition collide? These questions demand further research, particularly in child welfare settings where emotional burdens are high and institutional support is often lacking.

Despite the underexplored nature of emotions in professional literature, the discourse is gaining momentum. Emotions are central to the “embodied world of concerns” that shape engagement with institutional processes (Creed et al., 2020). Yet many professionals continue their work under high emotional stress, unaware of the toll it takes (Herland, 2022). Time constraints, chaotic environments, and heavy workloads prevent meaningful reflection, reinforcing a culture of emotional suppression.

Vaccaro and Palazzo (2015) argue that values work is an ongoing performance rooted in daily practice. In welfare organizations shaped by new public management, this performance often clashes with the emotional realities of frontline work (Visser, 2025). Values are frequently treated as abstract ideals, yet they are enacted, negotiated, and internalized through emotionally charged interactions. Emotional values illuminate how professionals apply moral labels to their actions and uphold ethical norms, particularly in child welfare contexts.

This type of values work requires emotional reflexivity, self-awareness, and institutional support. Organizational structure and leadership play a critical role in legitimizing these dimensions. Without them, emotional labor remains invisible, and the profession continues to struggle with the very dilemmas it seeks to resolve.

I conclude this discussion with a call for further research and heightened awareness of these critical issues, particularly the intrinsic emotional

dimension of social work, where practitioners navigate complex emotional landscapes. This chapter underscores the importance of emotional reflexivity: the ability of social workers to recognize, understand, and critically engage with their own and others' emotional experiences. Equally vital is the role of organizations and leadership in cultivating environments that support and nurture this reflexivity.

Concluding Remarks

This chapter has illuminated how emotions and values enable exploration of how professionals enact and negotiate values in the messy realities of front-line practice. In this view, values are not merely inherited ideals or static abstractions; they are continuously shaped, contested, and redefined through emotional, embodied experiences within specific institutional contexts.

This dynamic and interactive perspective opens up the possibility of examining the phenomenon of uncertainty; not as a sign of professional failure, but as a theoretically rich entry point for understanding how emotions and values operate in practice. Uncertainty is ubiquitous in child welfare work. It arises in moments of incomplete information, ambiguous risk, or conflicting responsibilities. In these moments, emotions such as hesitation, anxiety, and “gut feelings” take center stage. Far from being obstacles to objectivity, such emotions may illuminate the moral and organizational tensions inherent in social work. These dimensions require recognition not only at the individual level but also as features of professional judgment that demand institutional support.

According to Espedal and Carlsen (2021), the discourse surrounding values within organizations has shifted—from cognitive and cultural interpretations of values as abstract principles or symbolic entities, to a view of values work as a form of practice (Rokeach, 1973; Schwartz, 1992; Schein, 1987; Wright et al., 2017). In this chapter, I have focused on the emotionally charged dimensions of values work as articulated by caseworkers handling abuse cases, reflecting the organizational values at play within child welfare settings when uncertainty arises. My aim was to explore how these emotional values are upheld, translated, applied, shared, and internalized within organizations. I will argue that understanding these processes is essential for illuminating how individuals assign moral significance to their actions and uphold ethical standards, particularly in sensitive contexts such as abuse.

By examining the concept of doubt, we gain insight into the complexities of value-driven actions and the maintenance of ethical standards in

professional settings, especially within child welfare. The alignment between personal and organizational values reveals how shared beliefs and principles guide decision-making and behavior in responding to child sexual abuse cases, particularly in relation to existential phenomena such as uncertainty and doubt. This exploration underscores the intricate interplay and tensions between individual and collective actions, ethical considerations, and institutional constraints.

Rafaeli and Sutton (1987) emphasized the need for “more inductive work so that our theories can capture the complexities of emotional expression in organizational life” (p. 35). This need remains critical for understanding the implicit dynamics of emotions, assumptions, and values within organizations. Furthermore, we must consider how systems evade responsibility when workers lack the structural support necessary to navigate emotions such as doubt and uncertainty. How can organizations assume accountability in complex situations where messy and unclear emotions arise?

The concept of uncertainty is particularly significant in this context, as sexual abuse cases often involve emotions such as doubt due to delayed disclosure, meaning that children rarely speak about the abuse immediately (Herland, 2025). Social workers must manage these complex processes, where doubt often resides in their bodies as a “gut feeling.” These inquiries are vital not only for understanding the challenges faced in abuse cases but also for exploring the broader implications for ethical practice and organizational integrity within child welfare and beyond.

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From Concern to Redemption: Exploring Emotional Arcs of Social Entrepreneurs' TED Talks

Bogdan Prokopovych

Introduction

Consider the following words from a TED Talk by Jessica Ladd, a social entrepreneur and founder of Callisto, a nonprofit that developed technology to help survivors of sexual assault report their experiences. As she ends her speech, Jessica looks up to a better future: *"We can create one where those who do wrong are held accountable, where survivors get the support and justice they deserve, where the authorities get the information they need, and where there's a real deterrent to violating the rights of another human being."*¹ Another social entrepreneur, Dianna Cohen, who co-founded the Plastic Pollution Coalition, finishes her TED Talk with a similarly upbeat and hopeful message: *"We can cut the stem—tide the stem of this into our oceans and in doing so, save our oceans, save our planet, save ourselves."*²

Although both speakers tackle different societal problems, their arguments end on a hopeful note with respect to emotional language. A logical next

¹ Jessica Ladd's 2016 Ted Talk (https://www.ted.com/talks/jessica_ladd_the_reporting_system_that_sexual_assault_survivors_want?language=en).

² Dianna Cohen's 2010 Ted Talk (https://www.ted.com/talks/dianna_cohen_tough_truths_about_plastic_pollution).

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question a reader could ask is, how does emotional language change in the middle of these talks? In other words, how do social entrepreneurs use emotional language throughout their stories to engage with their audiences?

As there is a large body of work documenting how social entrepreneurs work on addressing complex societal challenges (Dorado & Ventresca, 2012), in this chapter, I explore how they craft emotional narratives by examining the emotional tone dynamics from the beginning to the end of their narrative as they communicate about their entrepreneurial ventures. Furthermore, exploring the emotional language in the context of the TED Talks allows us to see how social entrepreneurs connect to societal values as they seek to raise awareness and pitch their narratives of the importance of a societal issue they care about.

The field of social entrepreneurship is shaped by its institutional contexts, which are represented by local and geopolitical developments and trends. In many contexts, governments have enacted policies that restrict or impose a burden on the work of nonprofits and social enterprises. There are plenty of well-known examples, such as in India, the long-standing Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) created significant administrative barriers to doing business by nonstate organizations, limiting their access to foreign funding (Bornstein & Sharma, 2016); similarly, more recent Hungary's 2017 Transparency Act mandated disclosures for foreign-funded civil society organizations (Krishnakumar, 2020), as well as the most recent, the dismantling of USAID and the suspension of foreign aid programs by the U.S. government in 2025, which disrupted funding pipelines for many international social initiatives (Fraser, 2025). Such institutional pressures that create challenges leak into the language of social entrepreneurs' narratives (Nayir & Shinnar, 2020).

In response to the institutional pressures, as organizational scholars have argued, emotions can be used as one of the strategic tools to create, maintain, or change the existing institutional arrangements (Lok et al., 2017; Voronov & Vince, 2012). As entrepreneurs promote their ventures, technologies, or social causes, they skillfully navigate their institutional landscape, and emotions help them do that. Masterfully woven into rhetoric, emotions constitute fundamental elements of entrepreneurial storytelling to appeal to potential stakeholders (Suddaby et al., 2021). Entrepreneurs, especially at the beginning of their journey, rely on the emotional and financial support of those close to them. Thus, emotions help nascent entrepreneurs "draw others in," developing a base of supporters and followers (Goss, 2005).

Emotions as a strategic tool can help promote social change. Organizational scholars have shown that when attracting attention to social causes,

social entrepreneurs engage in what they call “emotion-symbolic” work by utilizing the power of words and visuals (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019). Each entrepreneurial narrative told by the entrepreneur conveys their subjective opinions and personal feelings regarding a specific cause. These opinions and feelings constitute their emotions, expressed through the sentiments of the words (Liu, 2012, p. 20).

The global presence and reach of TED Talks make them a platform for social entrepreneurs where they can promote the causes they seek to address. Typically, TED speakers are coached and rehearse their performances (Anderson, 2016). This intentionality and preparation make TED Talks a viable strategic tool that social entrepreneurs can use to present their pro-social pursuits. Unlike investor pitches or presentations, TED Talks are designed for a general audience and remain publicly accessible over time. This makes them especially well-suited for studying how entrepreneurs use emotional language as they seek to spark interest, compassion, and concern for the social change they seek to advance, hence, engage in emotion-symbolic work.

By exploring narratives told by social entrepreneurs in their TED Talks, this chapter contributes to the emotion-symbolic perspective of entrepreneurship (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019). It explores how emotions are expressed by individuals at the level of a story, and how these stories align with a specific type of narratives used in entrepreneurship at the field level. Pursuing the research question—*how do social entrepreneurs use emotional language in their narratives to shed light on the solutions to the societal problems they care about?*—this paper examines the so-called “emotional arcs” (Vonnegut, 1981) of entrepreneurial stories, the trajectories of emotional sentiment as it rises or falls, unfolding within narratives. Examining these sentiment trajectories of narratives helps reveal the emotional mechanisms of how the rhetorical appeal of social entrepreneurs to stakeholders is formed (Suddaby et al., 2021).

Background Literature

Social entrepreneurs are both entrepreneurs who pursue to develop entrepreneurial solutions and individuals, often viewed as larger-than-life figures, who prioritize and are driven by pro-social missions (Bacq & Janssen, 2011; Dorado, 2006; Mair & Martí, 2006). Hence, the emotions that they employ are used to both promote their ventures and to mobilize support for addressing the societal problems that they are concerned about.

Social Entrepreneurs and Emotions

Generally, the importance of emotions has been shown in the entrepreneurship literature, connecting it to the writings of Joseph Schumpeter (Goss, 2005). The literature has shown that riding the “emotional rollercoaster” of entrepreneurship may trigger a myriad of emotional states that include both negative and positive emotions (Cardon et al., 2012; Shepherd & Patzelt, 2018), and is related to the individual well-being of those who decide to take upon entrepreneurial pursuits (Stephan et al., 2022; Shepherd & Patzelt, 2015). The studies on social entrepreneurship have also pointed to the existence of a “dark side” of engaging in pro-social pursuits that results in a negative impact on individual well-being (Kibler et al., 2019). In their review, Williamson et al. (2022) document how negative affect among entrepreneurs may emerge during the entrepreneurship process, which is connected with individual and entrepreneurship-occupation-related issues.

Emotions that result from entrepreneurs’ interactions with their stakeholders may influence entrepreneurial outcomes (Doern & Goss, 2014). This is a plausible argument as it is intuitive that entrepreneurs, as they experience either positive or negative emotions, would be more or less likely to engage in or continue their entrepreneurial pursuits. Positive emotions have also been argued to aid social ventures in their work by helping retain volunteers (Farny et al., 2019).

The role of emotions has been researched by the community of institutional theory scholars. Similar to the situation with entrepreneurs, emotions both are impacted by and impact institutional dynamics at the organizational and community levels (Toubiana & Zietsma, 2017). It is argued that emotions interact with institutional contexts through the micro-process of individual practices that constitute these contexts (Voronov, 2014). Institutional scholars argue that emotions may indicate persons’ commitments to existing institutional arrangements, which they evaluate and re-evaluate (Creed et al., 2010, 2022). Thus, entrepreneurs, when interacting with different elements of institutional contexts in which they are embedded, engage in what has been termed *emotion-symbolic work* (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019).

It has been argued in the social entrepreneurship literature that emotions can be strategically mobilized through the Weberian notion of enchantment, serving as an agentic force that motivates actors toward change (Mauksch, 2017). For example, compassion has been shown to motivate individuals to pursue ventures that benefit others (Miller et al., 2012). Emotions are also

linked to creativity, enabling social entrepreneurs to respond to complex societal challenges (Erro-Garcés, 2020). Social entrepreneurs communicate using emotional language to motivate and garner support for their ventures as they respond to societal challenges.

Generally, entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs, in particular, commonly weave in references to symbols and emotions in their narratives. Trying to disrupt the existing status quo, they engage in institutional work (Lawrence & Suddaby, 1996), in which emotions play a significant role (Voronov & Vince, 2012). Barberá-Tomás et al. (2019) document how such work unfolds during a period of time, drawing on a case of a nonprofit organization representing the anti-plastic pollution movement. They show the multimodal nature of what they call “emotion-symbolic” work that includes showing shocking visuals and words to promote the cause of interest (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019). This paper examines the emotion-symbolic work in the context of entrepreneurs’ and social entrepreneurs’ narratives of their TED Talks, focusing on the linguistic mechanisms that convey emotions throughout the individual story. As emotions flow through social entrepreneurs’ stories on the TED Talks platform, these mechanisms serve as a powerful tool at social entrepreneurs’ disposal, which they can use to amplify their message of the need to address a societal need.

This chapter also advances another theoretical viewpoint that helps us better understand how social entrepreneurs weave their emotion-symbolic work into their entrepreneurial pursuits through how they engage with institutions. The concept of the “world of concern” proposed by Creed and co-authors in their recent work (Creed et al., 2022) offers a lens that elaborates such engagement. For example, their “world of concern” comprises two perspectives—the “embodied world of concern” that represents the experiences and aspirations of individuals that shape how they perceive institutional realities and “the shared world of concern” representing collective embeddedness of individuals in social relationships as they participate in the institutional processes (Creed et al., 2022). The emotional language of entrepreneurs is not just a part of their rhetorical strategy to get the desired outcome, but a reflection of their experiences with institutions, both individually and through their relationships with other institutional players.

Symbolic Construction: Telling Stories of Redemption in Social Entrepreneurial Narratives

Organizational scholars have shown how narratives can be understood as symbolic construction mechanisms in framing the stories of professional

success and successful pursuit of goals (Creed et al., 2014; Lok et al., 2019). In doing so, they have drawn on the work of American psychologist McAdams (2006) regarding the language of redemption. According to McAdams, the idea of redemption may have religious roots and is found in the life stories of so-called “generative”³ individuals, who are willing to give back to their society. Social entrepreneurs are generally considered to be those individuals as they “initiate and lead change processes that are self-correcting, growth-oriented, and impact-focused,” and “create new configurations of people and coordinate their efforts to attack problems more successfully than before” (Bornstein & Davis, 2010, p. 24). As individual tell their stories of redemption, based on McAdams (2006), they may follow six types of languages of redemption—atonement, emancipation, upward mobility, recovery, enlightenment, and development. In each of them, the individual moves from adversity to a point of redemption, culminating in acquiring a desired status or achieving objectives. The presence of negative emotional language is a must to tell the story of redemption. As McAdams puts it:

“Redemptive narratives are not simply happy stories. Rather, they are stories of suffering and negativity that turn positive in the end. Without the negative emotions, there can be no redemption in the story” (p. 44).

Similarly, it has been shown that entrepreneurs experience their venture failure as a process—starting with self-stigmatization, social ostracism, and eventual epiphanies that help them transform their perception of failure into positive learning opportunities (Singh et al., 2015). McAdams’ (2006) in his identified type of redemption language of upward mobility drew on a number of examples of individuals pursuing their American dream as a path of rags-to-riches. A person constructs a narrative in which they defy the odds through concerted efforts to reach the desired societal status.

As individuals engage in such social symbolic construction efforts focused on purposeful shaping of their past experiences to accommodate their agentic objectives (Lawrence & Phillips, 2019), there is another important aspect that entrepreneurial narratives represent. Entrepreneurs develop impression management strategies to narrate their stories of failed entrepreneurial pursuits (Kibler et al., 2021; Maclean et al., 2015). Successful entrepreneurs can also pursue “moral redemption,” as, for example, Andrew Carnegie used his immense wealth for philanthropy to reframe his legacy through altruistic motives (Humphreys et al., 2019).

³ A notion of *generativity* of individuals is borrowed by McAdams from psychoanalyst Erik Erikson (McAdams, 2006, p. 4).

Emotions in Entrepreneurial Narratives

The extant research shows that emotions both impact entrepreneurs and can be used by them through the power of stories. There is ample evidence of linguistic strategies exploited by entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs (Allison et al., 2013, 2014; Chandra et al., 2016; Parhankangas & Renko, 2017). Narratives constructed by entrepreneurs reach their audiences through several mechanisms that help expressing emotions. They can be visual using facial expressions during funding pitches (Warnick et al., 2021). Entrepreneurs use rhetorical devices as their means to pursue their objectives (Sanchez-Ruiz et al., 2021; Suddaby et al., 2021).

Organizational actors can use emotions to construct an institutional logic conducive to addressing the cause pursued by the organization, thus facilitating organizational agency (Fan & Zietsma, 2017). Emotions integrated into a narrative can be part of entrepreneurs' efforts to sensemake and process their failures (Mantere et al., 2013), hence serving as a coping mechanism.

Skillful integration of emotions in the narratives can serve as a tool at entrepreneurs' disposal to achieve their goals. The construct of emotion-symbolic work points to the importance of the language used by actors for achieving desired institutional outcomes (Barbera-Tomas et al., 2019). Recent research shows that entrepreneurs use linguistic tools such as historical tropes to create narratives that bring together stakeholders with different perspectives on the issue of interest (Suddaby et al., 2021). One of the communications means entrepreneurs have been using where emotions manifest themselves in the language of their expression is the online platforms, such as X/formerly known as Twitter. For example, it has been shown that entrepreneurs, when Tweeting, use more positive emotional language than non-entrepreneurs, and that social entrepreneurs' language scores higher on positive emotions than that of other entrepreneurs (Waters et al., 2021). Intuitively, through their microblogs, entrepreneurs tend to discuss their work and venture-related issues, and thus, on average, use more positive emotional language (Tata et al., 2017). Waters et al., (2021, p. 18) suggest several explanations for the differences in the sentiment between social and traditional entrepreneurs that include higher altruistic motives among social entrepreneurs, their sense of social duty, and seeking to impact the decision-making of investors. While these mechanisms proposed in the literature are plausible, microblogs like X/Twitter are short texts that do not allow for capturing variation of sentiment throughout the individual narrative that entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs seek to create. This paper explores

such emotional variation change using the texts of TED Talks of social and traditional entrepreneurs as they are larger in their text size.

Redemptive Emotional Arc of Social Entrepreneurs' Narratives

So, how does the emotional language change throughout a narrative constructed by a social entrepreneur? Despite the significant body of extant research on the role of emotions in the institutional theory and entrepreneurship literature, little is still understood about the specific mechanism of how entrepreneurs use emotions throughout their stories. Understanding the flow of emotional sentiment during the narrative would enrich our understanding of the mechanisms of emotion-symbolic work (Barbera-Tomas et al., 2019).

A construct helpful to explore such a mechanism is the story's emotional arc, a term that illustrates how the emotions flow through from the beginning to the end of the narrative (Vonnegut, 1981, 1995). Among many, it has been used by researchers to study the large corpora of fiction stories (Reagan et al., 2016), movie scripts (Del Vecchio et al., 2021), advertisements (Ghosh & Deb, 2022), including TED Talks (Boyd et al., 2021). Emotional arcs have been also applied to map visual valence of movies (Chu et al., 2017).

This paper considers the emotional arc (Vonnegut, 1981) of the social entrepreneurs' narratives to be an instantiation of their emotion-symbolic work (Barbera-Tomas et al., 2019). An emotional arc, as used by researchers, represents the flow of sentiment as a story progresses (e.g., Del Vecchio et al., 2021; Reagan et al., 2016). As a rule, it is represented by a curve on a plane that maps positive ups and negative downs of the sentiment throughout a story. The horizontal axis traditionally denotes the duration of the story in minutes, percentage of a book, etc. The vertical axis refers to a sentiment score.

Next, I describe the data and explain the methodology used to construct and examine emotional arcs displayed in the TED Talks of entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs. It is followed by the results and the discussion of implications for theory and practice.

Data and Methods

TED Talks were chosen as the data source for this study because of their characteristics, such as being publicly available video presentations, which are typically developed through rigorous public speaking coaching and rehearsals

to enhance their effectiveness. For the most part, they offer relatively standardized settings for how videos are organized. The global availability of TED Talks allows for access from different audiences. While the contexts where those videos are watched can be different, one of the main mechanisms through which these talks achieve impact is the narratives' language, which includes an emotional component. The dataset of TED Talk speakers (www.ted.com) was constructed by drawing on the transcripts from the Web Inventory of Transcribed and Translated Talks (WIT3) (Cettolo et al., 2012).

The speakers were coded into three categories: social entrepreneurs (social value creation indicated as the primary objective when they discover and act upon opportunities to contribute to solving societal or environmental problems (Seelos & Mair, 2005; Zahra et al., 2009), entrepreneurs based on experience of having founded a venture (Bacq et al., 2016), and non-entrepreneurs. After removing the non-entrepreneurs and ambiguous cases from the dataset, there were 358 entrepreneurs' TED Talks and 195 social entrepreneurs' TED Talks (Table 25.1).

To examine differences in sentiment between the TED Talks of entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs, I used the lexicons widely used in research and practice (e.g., Galperin, 2020; Zunic et al., 2020). These are the so-called general-purpose lexicons (Silge & Robinson, 2017), such as "AFINN," "Bing," and "NRC," and proprietary LIWC. The "AFINN"-lexicon (Nielsen, 2011) was developed based on the scoring of the sentiment of Twitter microblogs, with sentiment score values ranging between -5 and 5. The "Bing"-lexicon (Hu & Liu, 2004) was developed using customer reviews with around 7 thousand words assigned to the two categories of "positive" and "negative." The "NRC"-lexicon (Mohammad & Turney, 2013) draws on the crowdsourced coding of more than 13.5 words into ten emotions—trust, fear, negative, sadness, anger, surprise, positive, disgust, joy, and anticipation. Another dictionary used to compare the emotional language of entrepreneurs' and social entrepreneurs' TED Talks from the Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count, LIWC (Pennebaker et al., 2015), a proprietary software initially developed for psychometric measurements of health-related writings and now

Table 25.1 Descriptive statistics

Category	n	Mean tokens	Min tokens	Max tokens	St. dev. tokens	Mean sentences	Min sentences	Max sentences	St. dev. sentences
Entrepreneur	358	2280.2	127	6637	1177.1	125.8017	12	404	66.9
Social entrepreneur	195	2433.3	348	6072	1190.2	131.6615	22	351	70.1

a widely used application among researchers and practitioners (Tausczik & Pennebaker, 2010).

In order to examine emotional arcs of narratives, I used an R package “syuzhet” that, besides the “AFINN,” “Bing,” and “NRC” lexicons, has a dictionary developed by Matthew L. Jockers/Nebraska Literary Lab (Jockers, 2015a). This dictionary assigns a sentiment value of emotional valence to more than 10.5 thousand tokens with values ranging between -1 and 1. According to the author of this open-source package, “syuzhet” allows plotting how the narrative progresses from the very beginning to the end (Jockers, 2015b, 2020). Since the TED Talks vary in length, I used the Discrete Cosine Transformation function available in this R package to calculate an average emotional arc for both categories—entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs. This technique transforms the list of sentiment values into a scale of 100. After the list of sentiment values for every text in the dataset was transformed to lengths of 100, I calculated an average value of each point across all the texts and plotted the emotional arcs of entrepreneurs’ and social entrepreneurs’ TED Talks.

When analyzing texts, I applied the so-called “tidy” methods in arranging every word of the TED Talks in a long-data format and assigned sentiment scores to each word and then calculated the mean sentiment value for each TED Talk (Silge & Robinson, 2017).

Results

The “worlds of concern” as expressed in social entrepreneurs’ narratives

Throughout their narratives, social entrepreneurs—TED speakers—choose to blend references to their personal stories with the experiences that they gained through their social interactions. For example, Dianna Cohen relates to her work with plastic as an artist mentioning that some of her began cracking and breaking down into smaller plastic pieces over time. Then, she “came together with a group of other people who were all looking at this issue” as they created the Plastic Pollution Coalition as one of the solutions to the ubiquity of consumer plastic. Similarly, Bart Weetjens, the founder of APOPO, an organization that trains rodents (rats) to detect landmines, shares his early dissatisfaction with his career as an industrial engineer and a product developer. His solution gets socialized through the interactions that transfer skills in post-conflict zones in places like Mozambique, which shapes the way the solutions are deployed. Jessica Ladd from Callisto echoes this pattern and explains her work through the blend of personal expertise and

collective insights that shaped her solution, as well as the ultimate aspiration of creating the world “where those who do wrong are held accountable” (see Table 25.2 for the illustrating quotes from the TED Talks transcripts).

These examples point to a feature of the social entrepreneurs’ narratives in the TED Talks: social entrepreneurs recount personal experiences and recognize that their solutions to societal problems evolve through social interactions and engagement with societal contexts. Such stories serve as examples of the worlds of concern proposed by Creed et al. (2022). The two dimensions—the embodied world of concern, grounded in the personal experiences, and the shared world of concern, the experience of being embedded in social interactions (Creed et al., 2022)—may serve as explanatory mechanisms that show how social entrepreneurs make sense of their pursuits of dislodging the unjust equilibrium of the society that surrounds them (Martin & Osberg, 2007).

The world of concern of social entrepreneurs also manifests through a more negative emotional tone of the language they use, when compared to that of a peer group, the traditional entrepreneurs. This shows in the differences of emotional valence observed across their narratives.

The analysis of the sentiment of the entrepreneurial narratives in TED Talks revealed a significant difference in the emotional language used by entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs. Specifically, the comparison of averages of mean per-Ted-Talk sentiments has consistently shown that social entrepreneurs’ stories use more negative language. For example, there is a statistically significant difference between mean sentiment scores of entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs ($t(354.40) = 4.73, p < .001$) using the AFINN lexicon (Nielsen, 2011). Social entrepreneurs scored lower in this lexicon, i.e., they used, on average, more words with negative or low-positive scores (Fig. 25.1).

A similar pattern emerges when analyzing the language using the “Bing” lexicon (Hu & Liu, 2004). Social entrepreneurs have shown, on average, to use more negative language and fewer positive words. Since in this lexicon all the words are assigned either a “positive” or “negative” label, the relative share of positive tokens to the total words and negative tokens to the total words is compared across the two groups—entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs. As Fig. 25.2 shows, for the negative tokens, the mean of entrepreneurs was lower compared to social entrepreneurs ($t(350.23) = -3.70, p < .001$). For the positive tokens, the mean share was higher ($t(383.03) = 2.21, p < .05$). These findings suggest that social entrepreneurs’ narratives tend to adopt a more negative emotional tone compared to those of traditional entrepreneurs.

Table 25.2 World of concern illustrating quotes

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Dianna Cohen	Co-founder of the Plastic Pollution Coalition focused on eliminating plastic pollution	I'm a visual artist, and I'm also one of the co-founders of the Plastic Pollution Coalition. I've been working with plastic bags, which I cut up and sew back together as my primary material for my artwork for the last 20 years. I turn them into two and three-dimensional pieces and sculptures and installations. Upon working with the plastic, after about the first eight years, some of my work started to fissure and break down into smaller little bits of plastic. And I thought, "Great. It's ephemeral just like us."	[T]his is a huge problem in the oceans, but this is a problem that we've created as consumers and we can solve. We can solve this by raising awareness of the issue and teaching people to choose alternatives. So whenever possible, to choose alternatives to single-use plastics. We can cut the stem—tide the stem of this into our oceans and in doing so, save our oceans, save our planet, save ourselves
Bart Weetjens	Founder of APOPO, an organization that trains rats to detect landmines	I became an industrial engineer, engineer in product development, and I focused on appropriate detection technologies, actually the first appropriate technologies for developing countries. I started working in the industry, but I wasn't really happy to contribute to a material consumer society in a linear, extracting and manufacturing mode. I quit my job to focus on the real world problem: landmines	This is our team in Mozambique: one Tanzanian trainer, who transfers the skills to these three Mozambican fellows. And you should see the pride in the eyes of these people. They have a skill, which makes them much less dependent on foreign aid. Moreover, this small team together with, of course, you need the heavy vehicles and the manual de-miners to follow-up

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Casey Gerald	Co-founder of MBAs Across America, aiming to bridge gaps between elite education and grassroots economic empowerment	So I went to church as often as I could. I listened for silence as anxiously as one might listen for noise, trying to be sure that the Lord hadn't pulled a fast one on me and decided to come back early. And just in case he did, I built a backup plan, by reading the "Left Behind" books that were all the rage at the time	I had to travel up the road to Harlem, where I found myself sitting in an urban farm that had once been a vacant lot, listening to a man named Tony tell me of the kids that showed up there every day. All of them lived below the poverty line. Many of them carried all of their belongings in a backpack to avoid losing them in a homeless shelter. Some of them came to Tony's program, called Harlem Grown, to get the only meal they had each day. We collect this plastic and we grind it to the size we find it in the ocean, which is very small because it breaks down. And so this is how we work. I let the imaginations of my students run wild. And my job is to try to collect the best of each kid's idea and try to combine it into something that hopefully would work. And so we have agreed that instead of collecting plastic bits, we are going to collect only the data. So we're going to get an image of the plastic with a robot—so robots, kids get very excited. And the next thing we do—we do what we call "rapid prototyping." We are so rapid at prototyping that the lunch is still in the lunchbox when we're hacking it
Cesar Harada	Founder of Protei, a project building an open-source sailing robot to clean up environmental waste	When I was a kid, my parents would tell me, "You can make a mess, but you have to clean up after yourself." So freedom came with responsibility. But my imagination would take me to all these wonderful places, where everything was possible. So I grew up in a bubble of innocence—or a bubble of ignorance	(continued)

Table 25.2 (continued)

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Ellen Gustafson	Co-founder of FEED Projects, which creates products that help fund hunger and malnutrition programs	I'm Ellen, and I'm totally obsessed with food. But I didn't start out obsessed with food. I started out obsessed with global security policy because I lived in New York during 9/11, and it was obviously a very relevant thing. And I got from global security policy to food because I realized when I'm hungry, I'm really pissed off, and I'm assuming that the rest of the world is too Now, I'm an infectious disease epidemiologist by training. I'm interested in systems and networks and where we can concentrate our resources to do the most good. So this, to me, is a tragic but a solvable problem	So the problematic food system is affecting both hunger and obesity. Not to beat a dead horse, but this is a global food system where there's a billion people hungry and billion people obese. I think that's the only way to look at it We started by talking to college survivors. And what they wish they'd had in college is pretty simple; they wanted a website, one they could use at the time and place that felt safest to them with clearly written information about their reporting options
Jessica Ladd	Founder of Callisto, a nonprofit that develops technology to combat sexual assault and help survivors		

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Khalida Brohi	Founder of the Sughar Empowerment Society, a nonprofit that provides Pakistani tribal women with the education, skills, and income opportunities	While preparing for my talk I was reflecting on my life and trying to figure out where exactly was that moment when my journey began. A long time passed by, and I simply couldn't figure out the beginning or the middle or the end of my story. I always used to think that my beginning was one afternoon in my community when my mother had told me that I had escaped three arranged marriages by the time I was two	I remember my father receiving anonymous letters saying, "Your daughter is spreading Western culture in the honorable societies." Our car was stoned at one point. One day I went to the office and found our metal signboard wrinkled and broken as if a lot of people had been hitting it with something heavy. Things got so bad that I had to hide myself in many ways. I would put up the windows of the car, veil my face, not speak while I was in public, but eventually situations got worse when my life was threatened, and I had to leave, back to Karachi, and our actions stopped When coming up with the curriculum for Ruby's world, I needed to really ask the kids how they see the world and what kind of questions they have and I would organize play testing sessions. I would start by showing the kids these four pictures. I would show them a picture of a car, a grocery store, a dog and a toilet
Linda Liukas	Founder of Rails Girls that organizes workshops to teach girls to code	When I was a girl, I wanted to be a storyteller. I loved make-believe worlds and my favorite thing to do was to wake up in the mornings in Mooninvalley. In the afternoons, I would roam around the Tatoolines. And in the evenings, I would go to sleep in Narnia. And programming turned out to be the perfect profession for me. I still create worlds. Instead of stories, I do them with code	(continued)

Table 25.2 (continued)

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Mike Velings	Co-founder of Aqua-Spark, an investment fund focused on sustainable aquaculture	I got involved in aquaculture a couple of years ago. We were inspired by Sylvia Earle, who won the TED Prize in 2009. We actually met on Mission Blue I in the Galapagos. Amy was there as the TED Prize Director, me, an entrepreneur from the Netherlands and concerned citizen, love to dive, passion for the oceans	And there are a lot of great, sustainable fishing initiatives across the planet working towards better practices and better-managed fisheries. But ultimately, all of these initiatives are working towards keeping current catch constant. It's unlikely, even with the best-managed fisheries, that we are going to be able to take much more from the ocean than we do today
Shabana Basij-Rasikh	Co-founder of the School of Leadership, Afghanistan (SOLA), a boarding school for Afghanistan girls	During Taliban years, I remember there were times I would get so frustrated by our life and always being scared and not seeing a future. I would want to quit, but my father, he would say, "Listen, my daughter, you can lose everything you own in your life. Your money can be stolen. You can be forced to leave your home during a war. But the one thing that will always remain with you is what is here, and if we have to sell our blood to pay your school fees, we will. So do you still not want to continue?"	What I've come to realize about Afghanistan, and this is something that is often dismissed in the West, that behind most of us who succeed is a father who recognizes the value in his daughter and who sees that her success is his success. It's not to say that our mothers aren't key in our success. In fact, they're often the initial and convincing negotiators of a bright future for their daughters, but in the context of a society like in Afghanistan, we must have the support of men. Under the Taliban, girls who went to school numbered in the hundreds—remember, it was illegal

TED speaker	Description	Embodied world of concern (Creed et al., 2022)	Shared world of concern
Vikram Patel	Co-founder of Sangath (Goa, India), a nonprofit delivering care for individuals with developmental disabilities and mental health challenges in underprivileged communities	I found myself working first in Zimbabwe and then in India, and I was confronted by an altogether new reality. This was a reality of a world in which there were almost no mental health professionals at all. In Zimbabwe, for example, there were just about a dozen psychiatrists, most of whom lived and worked in Harare city, leaving only a couple to address the mental health care needs of nine million people living in the countryside	But beyond the staggering numbers, what's truly important from a global health point of view, what's truly worrying from a global health point of view, is that the vast majority of these affected individuals do not receive the care that we know can transform their lives, and remember, we do have robust evidence that a range of interventions, medicines, psychological interventions, and social interventions, can make a vast difference. And yet, even in the best-resourced countries, for example here in Europe, roughly 50 percent of affected people don't receive these interventions

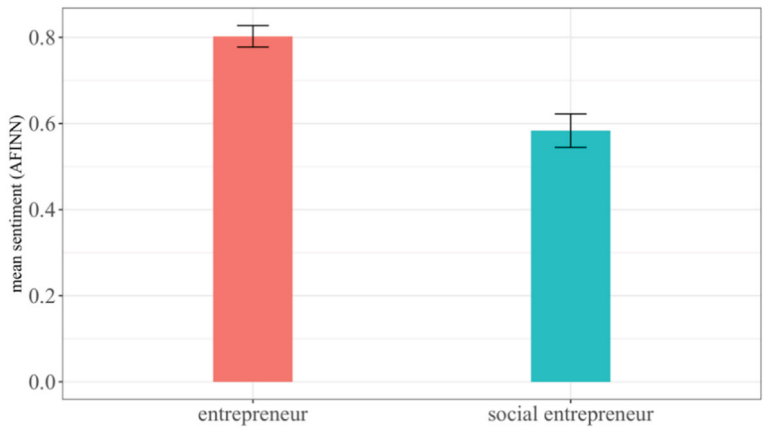


Fig. 25.1 Differences of mean AFINN sentiment

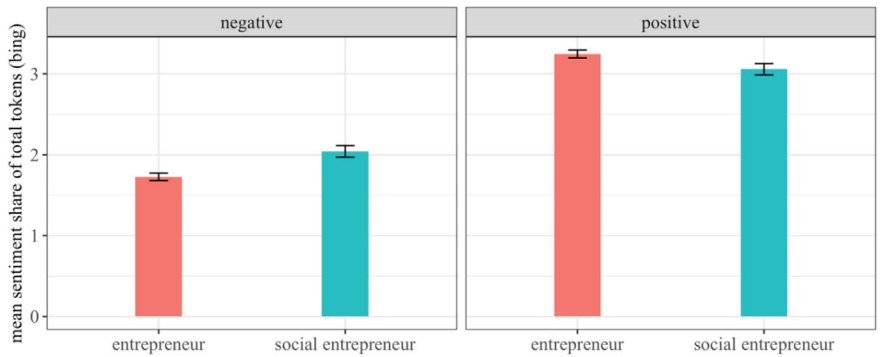


Fig. 25.2 Differences between means of shares of “bing” sentiment categories

As shown in Fig. 25.3, comparing the TED Talks of entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs across the ten emotion categories of the “NRC” lexicon (Mohammad & Turney, 2013). Social entrepreneurs scored on average higher on anger ($t(348.76) = -2.67, p < .001$), disgust ($t(370.21) = -1.96, p < .05$), fear ($t(340.35) = -3.46, p < .001$), negative tone ($t(365.52) = -3.96, p < .001$), and sadness ($t(400.19) = -3.26, p < .01$). Interestingly, social entrepreneurs also scored higher on **trust** ($t(380.28) = -3.48, p < .001$), which differs from the generally negative tone observed. As in the “Bing”-lexicon, NRC sentiment is labeled based on ten emotions, so the share of each emotion word to the total words in individual texts was compared.

Finally, Fig. 25.4 presents the comparison of LIWC (Pennebaker et al., 2015) dictionary scores for the psychological processes that include affect, positive emotions, negative emotions, anxiety, anger, sadness, and a summary

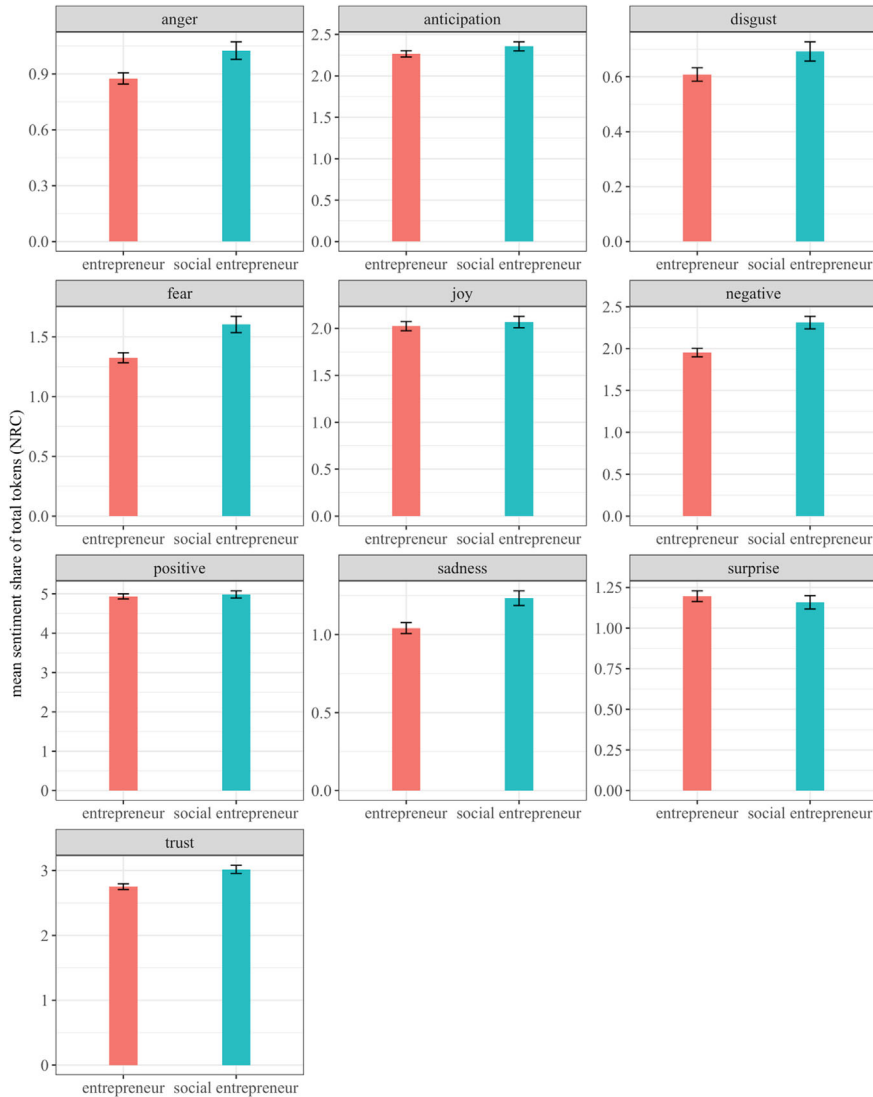


Fig. 25.3 Differences between means of shares of "NRC" sentiment categories

variable for emotional tone. The average scores for entrepreneurs versus social entrepreneurs are statistically significant lower for affect ($t(380.11) = -1.97$, $p < .05$), anger ($t(352.50) = -3.39$, $p < .001$), anxiety ($t(274.96) = -3.08$, $p < .01$), negative emotions ($t(332.77) = -4.56$, $p < .001$), sadness ($t(352.04) = -2.18$, $p < .05$), and emotional tone ($t(341.64) = 3.80$, $p < .001$). These LIWC findings underscore the emotional complexity in social entrepreneurs' narratives, reflecting the gravity of the challenges they engage with.

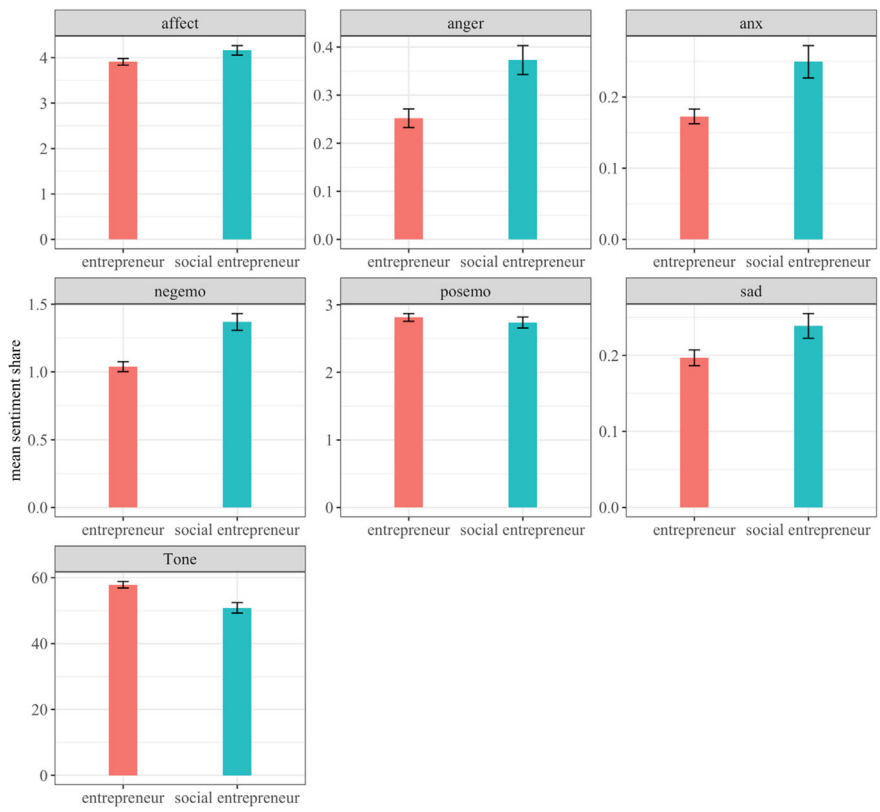


Fig. 25.4 Differences between means of LIWC categories

Together, these findings suggest that social entrepreneurs’ narratives are characterized by a more emotionally negative linguistic tone. These patterns may reflect the severity of the societal problems they aim to address and point to their attempts to influence how audiences perceive and engage with their stories.

Redemptive Emotional Arcs of Social Entrepreneurs’ Narratives

To provide insights into how emotions unfold throughout their narratives, it is useful to explore the emotional arcs of the TED Talks for those who fit the definition of social entrepreneurs. These arcs are represented by the average sentiment scores, transformed to a 100-scale using Syuzhet R package and plotted in the order in which they appear in the texts (Jockers,

2020). Figure 25.5 illustrates the emotional arc of the social entrepreneurs' narratives.

The figure reveals differences in how emotions are distributed over the course of the narratives. At the start of the talks, social entrepreneurs demonstrate a more positive sentiment compared to entrepreneurs, as indicated by their higher initial curve. One could argue that this positive opening reflects an attempt to establish hope or optimism when framing the problem they try to address in their work.

In the middle of the narratives, between the 25th and 70th percentiles, the emotional arc of social entrepreneurs significantly drops below that of the traditional entrepreneurs. Usually, the language of social entrepreneurs delves deeper into the societal challenges they encounter. On the other hand, the curve of the comparison group, the traditional entrepreneurs, remains higher

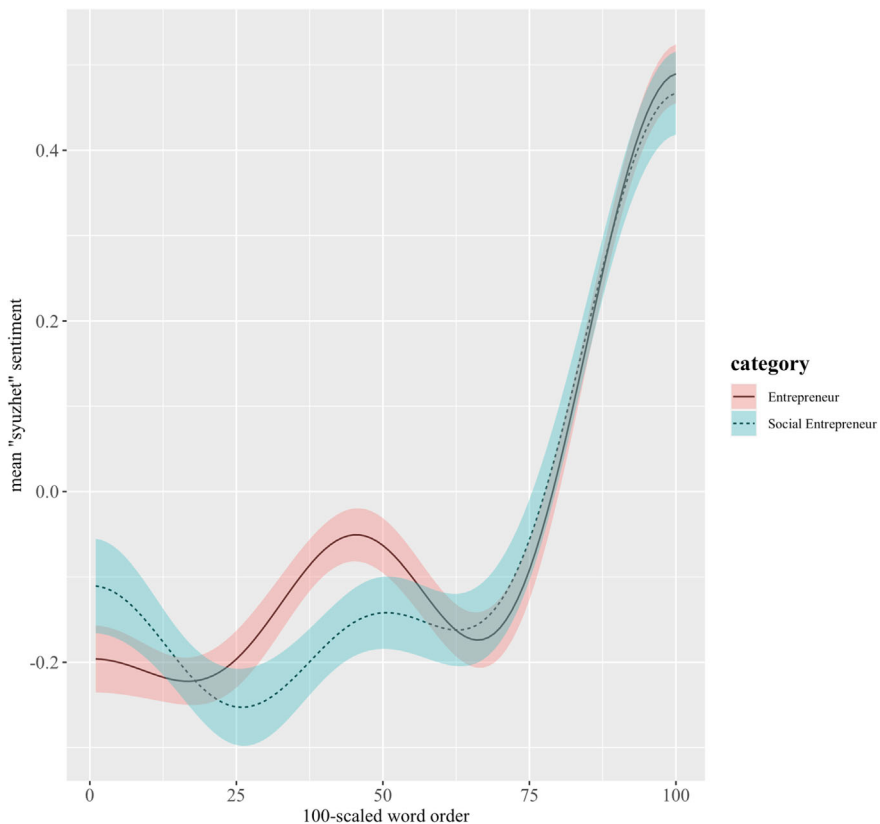


Fig. 25.5 “Emotional arc of TED Talks of entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs”. As it is in figure mode, we couldn’t able to change

and exhibits relatively more stable emotional tone during the middle part of the narrative.

As Fig. 25.5 shows, toward the end of the narratives, both social and traditional entrepreneurs' emotional trajectories converge at a positive peak. This upward pattern points to a hopeful and/or inspiring note regarding the proposed solution to a societal challenge for social entrepreneurs and the achievement of success for traditional entrepreneurs.

Overall, the emotional arcs of both groups show that social entrepreneurs tend to take their audience on a more emotionally volatile journey throughout their narratives, which could reflect the magnitude of the societal problems they aim to solve. The curve of traditional entrepreneurs' arcs exhibits a steadier narrative, potentially focusing more on the success of their business idea.

Discussion

This exploratory study contributes to the construct of the “world of concern” (Creed et al., 2022) by illustrating how social entrepreneurs address the “unjust equilibria” in society (Martin & Osberg, 2007) through emotional storytelling. TED Talks provide a unique context for examining such emotional storytelling. The videos of the narratives are globally accessible and typically follow a standardized visual format, and one of the main mechanisms through which these stories engage with institutional contexts is the emotional language. According to Creed et al. (2022), the world of concern is analytically comprised of the two “inseparable and mutually constitutive” parts—embodied and shared (Creed et al., 2022, p. 366). The embodied lens of the world of concern represents personal evaluations of experiences and social interactions, while the shared lens represents the evaluation of concerns acquired through social/collective interactions (Creed et al., 2022). These two dimensions of this construct are explored through the lens of emotional language used by social entrepreneurs as they construct their narratives to share their experiences and appeal for their cause.

This chapter also uncovers emotional patterns within the narratives of social entrepreneurs, highlighting the differences from their “traditional” peers. On average, social entrepreneurs use more negative emotional language in their narratives and take their audience on a more volatile journey throughout their stories, as illustrated by the emotional arcs. These emotional arcs, characterized by dips and rises of the emotional tone throughout the

narratives, show how social entrepreneurs engage with addressing societal challenges.

Methodologically, emotional arcs are useful tools that organizational scholars can use to gain deeper insights into the social construction of narratives, and the results show how such social construction may unfold. On average, social entrepreneurs use more negative emotional language. While the emotional arcs of both groups share similarities, with a “higher start,” a “dip in the middle,” and an “uplifting end,” social entrepreneurs exhibit a more pronounced negative dip in the middle. This may suggest that social entrepreneurs narratively engage with the depth of societal challenges before finishing their stories on an optimistic note. Traditional entrepreneurs, by contrast, demonstrate steadier arcs, potentially emphasizing the trajectory of their successful business idea.

The literature on emotional arcs has identified several prototypical emotional arc patterns (Reagan et al., 2016; Del Vecchio et al., 2021). Different from it, this study's contribution is not to classify entrepreneurial narratives into a specific typology. This chapter uses emotional arcs as a mechanism that illustrates social entrepreneurs' narrative journey from adversity to hope, mirroring McAdams' (2006) notion of redemption—a story where adversity is a precursor to some positive life transformation. Social entrepreneurs' narratives align particularly well with McAdams' redemption language types. These individuals confront societal problems as they narrate their stories, moving from adversity to redemption as “works in progress” (McAdams, 2006, p. 9). As McAdams (2006, p. 44) notes, “[w]ithout negative emotions, there can be no redemption”. The deep emotional troughs in the middle of social entrepreneurs' arcs reflect their immersion in societal issues, while the rise toward the end underscores the hopeful resolutions they offer. This framing allows social entrepreneurs to construct what Creed et al. (2022) call their “world of concern,” motivating audiences to act on behalf of societal causes.

The emotional arcs of the entrepreneurs' stories function as instantiations of emotion-symbolic work. This study contributes to a better understanding of how entrepreneurs and, in particular, social entrepreneurs mobilize emotions as part of the emotion-symbolic work (Barbera-Tomas et al., 2019). As organizational scholars argue, narratives play a performative rather than simply descriptive function in constructing identities (Lok et al., 2019). Emotional arcs capture how entrepreneurs and social entrepreneurs utilize the emotional flow in their storytelling. Such performative use of emotions helps entrepreneurs frame their pursuits as credible and transformative for society or the marketplace.

Overall, the findings of this study underscore the strategic role emotion's play in the narratives that social entrepreneurs construct utilizing compassion (Miller et al., 2012) as sources of motivation and enchantment (Mauksch, 2017) to resonate with their audiences (Erro-Garcés, 2020). Employing emotions in social construction strategies may contribute to the alignment of stakeholders' perceptions. In particular, this study illustrates the masterful use of emotions in the rhetoric of entrepreneurs as another linguistic tool used by entrepreneurs, in addition to those discussed in the recent work (Ingardi et al., 2021; Sanchez-Ruiz et al., 2021; Suddaby et al., 2021). For example, Suddaby et al. (2021) explore how entrepreneurs' narratives work as mechanisms to unite stakeholders, encouraging them toward actions. The findings of this study reveal a detail that positive peaking emotional language may be helpful in influencing the perceptions of an uncertain future by stakeholders. While studies similar to Ingardi et al. (2021) explore narratives used by leaders to communicate professional failures, examining emotional arcs of entrepreneurs provides a unique perspective on how entrepreneurs frame challenges and successes in the course of their narratives.

The concept of emotional arcs can serve as a useful analytical tool for organizational scholars as it aligns well with theoretical constructs, such as emotion-symbolic work (Barbera-Thomas et al., 2019) and redemption. One of the advantages of identifying and mapping the emotional arc of a narrative is that it provides a systematic approach to track how emotional language unfolds throughout a story. The emotional arc can help highlight the moments of redemption as pivotal junctures within a narrative, as these moments may represent critical points in emotion-symbolic work performed by social entrepreneurs. These redemptive moments are strategically important for social entrepreneurs as they leverage them to mobilize stakeholders to address societal issues arising from the persistent "unjust equilibrium" (Martin & Osberg, 2007).

Although, as an analytical tool, the concept of emotional arcs provides valuable insights about the structure of the emotional language flow throughout a narrative, its reliance, as applied in this study, on textual analysis has a significant limitation. Specifically, this text-based approach misses out on capturing other modes of communication, such as images, gestures, or intonation. These important non-verbal modes, as well as how they interact with institutional contexts, shape the emotional and social symbolic work of organizational actors (Barbera-Thomas et al., 2019; Karakulak & Lawrence, 2024). Ideally, future research that incorporates multimodal analytical approaches that rely on both verbal and non-verbal modes of communication will enrich our understanding of emotion-symbolic

work. It will help us better understand how social entrepreneurs act, as agents of change, and strategically deploy communication tools to usher in institutional change.

Conclusion

This chapter has explored how social entrepreneurs use emotions in their TED Talk narratives to communicate the urgency of societal problems and the promise of their entrepreneurial solutions. By analyzing the emotional arcs of these narratives (Jockers, 2015b; Reagan et al., 2016; Vonnegut, 1981), it has been shown that social entrepreneurs, when compared to their traditional, commercial counterparts, lead their audiences through narratives with emotionally varying amplitude. Through the flow of their stories, they start slightly positive, often expressing hope, then go into negative emotional troughs that point to the seriousness of the social issue they tackle, and finally rise in the emotional sentiment to illustrate the promise of their solution.

This study contributes to the following two literatures. First, it extends the construct of the “world of concern” as proposed by Creed et al. (2022) as it shows how social entrepreneurs engage in framing of societal problems and their entrepreneurial solutions, which are grounded in their personal experiences and social interactions. Then, it illustrates the analytical use of emotional arcs (Jockers, 2015b; Reagan et al., 2016; Vonnegut, 1981) to improve understanding of how emotions unfold in entrepreneurial narratives that align with the language of redemption (McAdams, 2006). Such narratives start with an explanation of the adversity associated with a social problem that needs to be addressed, and then a redemptive solution that they undertook through entrepreneurial action. Together, these contributions strengthen our understanding of emotion-symbolic work (Barberá-Tomás et al., 2019) by showing how social entrepreneurs strategically build emotions into their storytelling.

Methodologically, this chapter illustrates how the concept of *emotional arcs* (Jockers, 2015b; Reagan et al., 2016; Vonnegut, 1981) can be used to examine the flow of emotional language throughout entrepreneurial narratives, from the beginning to the end of the story. Unlike the average sentiment values for the entire language of individual stories, this approach allows to see how the sentiment varies as the story proceeds. For practitioners, this work can be helpful in understanding how social entrepreneurs utilize emotions to motivate and call for action to create social impact. This study

is limited to textual analysis and does not incorporate non-verbal emotional communication through gestures, tones, and visuals.

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Epilogue: Integration of Emotions and Values in Organizational Life

Gry Espedal and Marta Struminska-Kutra

In recent decades, management practice and theory have gone hand in hand in emphasizing the rational dimensions of decision making, strategy building, and managing in organizations. What is *worth* doing or, even more, what *feels* right was, and still is, considered irrelevant beyond strategic goal and mission setting. Furthermore, what feels right or wrong may be seen as a distraction from “getting things done.” Both in practice and theory, inevitable dimensions of human experience, such as intuition, feelings of uneasiness or anxiety, or, in contrast, excitement, tend to be suppressed and hidden, while explanations privileging rationality take center stage. Bringing values or emotions into surface often result in acts of rationalization, creating logical-sounding reasons that justify decisions and actions and protect us from inconvenient questions such as “What feels right?” and “What feels wrong?”.

In this *Handbook*, we claim that attention to affective and normative dimensions of management practices in organizational contexts is of importance on many levels. Inquiry into what matters to us and to others creates

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trust and commitment and facilitates individual and organizational learning. Even if such engagement requires facing uncomfortable questions, dealing with one's own and others' difficult emotions, value conflicts, and tensions may be worthwhile in many ways. This is because emotions can be part of people's sedimented practical experiences, evaluations, commitments, and aspirations—that is, signs of concern and, by extension, signs of what matters (Creed et al., 2022). In this sense, emotions and values may be seen as sources of practical, experiential knowledge and moral intuition that provide the impetus for reflection over courses of actions that can and perhaps should be taken in the situation at hand.

We explicitly argue that inquiring into emotions and values becomes crucial in times of turbulence, profound social change, and radical institutional disruption. This inquiry helps us to better understand the concerns that animate our own and others' engagement in the social world by critically investigating ways of thinking and evaluating, including reflections on whether the goals and aspirations we have had until now are in fact worth striving for. Without this inquiry into the concerns and conditions that created them we risk that our actions and decisions will be based on false interpretations of others' knowledge, worldviews, and concerns. As our social world becomes increasingly fragmented and plural, this risk becomes greater. When concern and tension arise, it can be important to give up routine “autopilot” responses prompted by institutionalized decision-making patterns and enter into a dialogue about what is at stake in one's social life (Selznick, 2008). In a sense, entering values and emotions inquiry becomes a way of handling institutional crises rooted in the disjunction between values professed by an institution and its actual behaviors (Peters, 2012).

In what follows, we wish to briefly summarize some of the many theoretical advancements emerging from the chapters of the Handbook. We propose a framework for guiding organizational research and practice that integrates the relationships between values, emotions, and institutions. Since leaders are equipped with instrumental and symbolic power to shape organizational structures that are sensitive to emotions and values, this framework can serve as a heuristic tool for leadership.

Animating Emotions and Values in Institutions

Both professional and organizational contexts can shape the ways in which emotions and values are experienced and expressed. In some organizations, expressing (or even faking) enthusiasm and joy may be taken for granted or

expected (creative industry, marketing departments), while in others, it may be a source of general embarrassment (legal and accounting departments). In other organizations, it may be normal to express frustration and criticism, but in others, it is better to keep critical opinions to oneself. Some professions are expected to express specific emotions while carefully hiding others, such as care workers expressing compassion but hiding frustration, while some are expected to be “neutral” or “politely inattentive” towards others, such as police officers at a traffic stop (Goffman, 1959).

The ways in which the roles of emotions and values are shaped in institutions have led some scholars to suggest that emotions could constitute a fourth pillar of institutions (Zietsma et al., 2019), supplementing the three classical pillars: normative, regulative, and cognitive (Scott, 2014). The various pillars are believed to influence what drives institutions. While the normative pillar tells us what to value in specific circumstances, the regulative pillar tells us what to do or not do in relation to regulations. The cognitive pillar informs us about what we see and how we distinguish and classify reality. In contrast to these pillars, a suggested emotional pillar can be understood as influencing people’s feelings and helping define what is considered right or wrong in terms of emotional responses.

In fact, social life in organizations is full of “feeling rules” (Hochschild, 1979). These become especially visible when someone defies them. “Shame on you!” is an indictment that is supposed to restore compliance with some violated norm. Refusal to feel shame or to respond as expected to shaming can be a form of activism and an open challenge to the system. An active rejection of the feeling rule not only questions the rightfulness of an institutional and moral order of which it is part; it also usually triggers social attention and explicit efforts to enforce the violated norm. This recursive relationship between emotion, value, and institution is animated by a felt concern about one’s own well-being and vulnerability and the well-being and vulnerability of significant others (Creed et al., 2022). Such recursiveness is present in a range of chapters of this *Handbook*. Ruebottom and Toubiana (Chapter 10) illustrate how interactions between individuals and institutions trigger feelings of shame and describe how this feeling, when shared, can develop into social connectedness that creates an institutionalized habitus of hate. Narratives of resilience or of entrepreneurship allow people to heal from the pain of shame and reclaim agency. The process is illustrated by Goswami and Smolka, who show how using the body can communicate emotions and stigmatized identity (Chapter 17), while at the same time challenging stigma and the dominant institutional arrangement that conceptualizes indigeneity as inferior. Scholars who leave academia (Górska, Chapter 8) or “come out”

with feelings of frustration and experiences of moral corruption (Pouthier & Ma, Chapter 7) open discussions about a core value of an institution they are (or were) part of and explain how academic organizations fail to deliver these values. Social workers who express doubts about procedures (Herland, Chapter 24) challenge institutionally embedded organizational rules based on a deeply felt emotion.

In each of these cases, individuals (e)valuate a complex situation through reference to the past—the sedimented experiences of an institution. Space for reflection and moral agency opens up when tension enters a space between the sedimented (institutional) and the experienced (individual). Through visceral evaluations of their own commitments, individuals may rebel against the institution of which they are a member. Importantly, rebellious actions may emerge in the name of the institution's professed but inconsistently enacted values, such as in the case of academia (academic freedom and commitment to public values) or in the case of social work (care). As such, these actions can be seen as a way of closing the legitimacy gap that is created when the discrepancy between the values processed and enacted widens.

The chapters draw on several conceptual traditions to explain the dynamics connecting emotions, values, and institutions. While Peña and Toubiana (Chapter 2) and Wang et al. (Chapter 5) propose combining institutional logics with constructions of emotional models, Kraatz and Flores (Chapter 3) suggest two recursively related concepts that refer to top-down and bottom-up processes of institutional dynamics that move between micro, meso, and macro levels of analysis. The first, evaluative embodiment, speaks to the individual-level process through which abstract values become lived commitments. The second, emotional historical sedimentation, speaks to the institutional-level crystallization of accumulated embodied patterns. In a similar vein, Edwards et al. (Chapter 15) explore the explanatory power of the “world of concerns” metaphor that links the realism of participant concerns to the micro dynamics that underpin institutions. The world of concern, which is the product of people's sedimented experiences of thriving and suffering, becomes the basis for their commitments and antagonisms toward certain social arrangements (Creed et al., 2022). The added value of this theorizing is that it advances the treatment of emotions and sedimented values as essential to how people encounter, evaluate, and choose courses of action. It facilitates exploration of the integral role of emotional, embodied aspects of cognition, as well as its socially embedded evaluations driving persons' participation in institutional processes. In this vein Peña and Toubiana (Chapter 2) draw on Martha Nussbaum's moral philosophy and the work of psychologist and neuroscientist Lisa Feldman Barrett, to show how

reflexivity combined with explicit and implicit cognition opens the possibility of theorizing both institutional logics and moral agency.

Leadership and its Role in Animating Emotions and Values in Organizations

Following arguments developed by Peña and Toubiana, as well as other researchers exploring the relationship between emotions, values, and cognition, we arrive at assumptions close to pragmatist approaches that emphasize the role of implicit cognition in learning and decision-making. This type of cognition assumes an entanglement of feelings, moral intuitions, and experiential knowledge in the development of the individual practices that take place in the context of management. Therefore, inquiry into values and emotions has the potential to shape morally reflective practitioners (Argyris & Schön, 1978) and morally responsible organizations. The question emerges: How can we develop organizational structures that facilitate this kind of inquiry? A focus on leadership is one possible route to arrive at an answer. Leaders are in a unique position to harness the potential of emotions and values expressions to improve organizational operations and facilitate the moral and professional development of individuals. The uniqueness of their position lies in their ability to control meaning to a greater extent than that of an average organizational member. In this sense, leadership can be seen as repeated leading-following interactions whereby meaning is maintained, modified, and questioned. In this sense, the task of leadership is not so much decision making, but making a situation meaningful through natural and doable decisions (Arnulf, 2014, p. 32). In this regard, we think that leaders who pay attention to emotions and concerns can create an organizational structure that is not only able to cope with emotions, but also to use them to inquire into the multidimensional nature of the problems at hand. In these cases, emotions and values facilitate the identification of concerns and the evaluation of what is at stake, thereby potentially guiding decision making and prompting action.

Worline and Dutton (2017) illustrate how leadership builds organizational capacity for compassionate responses to the emotion of suffering. Their approach embraces employees and leaders as humans who, while at work, remain human beings, not cogs in the organizational machinery. While normatively arguing for the importance of an organization's capacity for compassion, they point to the ways in which leaders structure attention or inattention to suffering, how they shape the meaning of suffering, how they

impact feelings of empathic concern, and how they take actions to alleviate suffering. We take inspiration from their approach to build a provisional heuristic tool that explores the role of leadership in shaping organizations' capacities to embrace emotions and values.

One chapter in this *Handbook* offers insight into the ways in which emotions and the enactment of compassion can be recognized and institutionalized through the reasoning processes of compassion-in-work. This work includes asking self-reflecting questions through processes of value inquiry, paying attention to time and remembering organizational attitudes and events, and telling organizational and sacred stories (Espedal, Chapter 12). In the case of the latter, compassion is not "just" a capacity that every organization should have to build good, caring social relationships (Worline & Dutton, 2017), but an institutional core value that supports organizational goals and identity. Here, inquiry into (moral) intuitions and emotions takes place in an area of strategic importance for an organization's potential ability to attain goals. In our volume, both Jellema and Werner (Chapter 11) and Fioravante and Vaccaro (Chapter 4) suggest similar steps.

Importantly, and in line with the pragmatist argument, inquiry into embodied emotions and values is inseparable from knowledge development. In this sense, the inquiry of concerns, emotions, and values is an investigation into the contextual circumstances of decision-making. It is a way of gaining a "complicated" understanding of a situation, which is an understanding of critical importance for leadership (Bartunek et al., 1983). An empirical illustration of how sensitivity to emotions and values facilitates the capacity for decision making and action is presented in our investigation of how individual and collective inquiry into "what matters most" helped hospital managers cope with the crisis of the COVID pandemic and how engagement with emotions and values facilitated their growth in both managerial and moral terms (Espedal et al., 2023). The ambiguity of the overarching situation made organizational members painfully aware of the stakes in particular circumstances. As such, leaders became essential in creating organizational spaces in which people could engage in meaning-making in relation to emotions and concerns. The short description below illustrates leader's responses to emotionally and morally charged situations under research.

First, the uncertainty and ambiguity of the situation opened the door for leaders to take a leap of faith in which they made their own thoughts and feelings transparent and their own not-knowing and anxiety observable to themselves and others. In this purposive "leadership move," that is action directed toward others (Worline & Dutton, 2017), they normalized

the expression of directed attention to emotions and opened up processes of value inquiry (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). An important element of this move was being present and making oneself available for conversation. Second, the leaders infused attention to emotions and values into organizational routines by incorporating them into hiring, problem-solving, planning, decision making, and daily practices. The managers established spaces for collective value inquiry into different imagined courses of action and also in the midst of ongoing action. The purpose of leaders sharing their internal conversations in what became shared inquiry was to exchange information and calibrate values. Finally, the leaders gave a *work-related sense* to emotions and values by suggesting when and how the discussion of emotions and values was relevant and worthy of resources. Leaders openly addressed their vulnerability, their own state of “not-knowing,” and their accompanying dilemmas while at the same time recognizing others’ concerns and caring for others. For the collective, a major way of coping with these emotions was to repeatedly ask how to organize work to address these diverse concerns while maintaining commitment to the core values and functions of the organization.

Through these processes, leaders secure the normalization of values and emotions in their organizations. The enactment of care and recognition of concerns reinforced and strengthened a social bond that became a safety net for individuals acting in the midst of uncertainty. The managers did not know what to do, but they acted together with others and with others in mind. At this particular moment of crises, the leaders relinquished control over the situation and/or over others while retaining control over themselves and their own inquiry process (Yanow & Tsoukas, 2009).

Understanding Emotions and Values Work in Institutions— Three Steps

In gaining knowledge of the productive force of involving emotions and values in organizations, we further propose a processual framework that facilitates understanding emotions and values work in institutions. First, this framework emphasizes that 1) emotions and values are ambiguous and difficult to identify and therefore require inquiry into the concerns in an emerging situation. What kinds of vulnerabilities are involved? What is at stake? What are people *really* talking about when they express their concerns? Second, the model indicates that inquiry triggers recognition and collective sense-making, in the process of which organizational members name and reflect on the values involved. What is the right way of coping with the given problem, and

why? The third step/move is action, which is accompanied by what people say and do, and how they relate (Kemmis, 2011). The questions asked here are: What actions are communicating values? How do these actions address existing concerns and bring new ones to life?

Concerns can manifest in various forms, such as personal worries, role expectations, and emotionally displayed norms. The intentions behind expressions are often concealed, making behavior difficult to interpret. Developing competence in recognizing emotions and values is thus essential, as it involves the ability to identify and manage one's emotions and those of others and to understand what these feelings and notions are pushing against in relation to values in institutions.

In this *Handbook*, different chapters name various concerns e.g. about incentives structures in contemporary academia (Pouthier & Ma, Chapter 7; Górska, Chapter 8) and about working procedures in social care (Herland, Chapter 24). Other concerns include those related to sustainability and the climate (Edwards et al., Chapter 15; Neher et al., Chapter 20), the polarization of social media (Castello et al., Chapter 14), empathy and chatbot technology (Ahmad & Phillips, Chapter 13), and the erosion of democracy by the passivity of “mainstreamers” (Malhotra & Voronov, Chapter 9).

Conducting an **inquiry** into these concerns means establishing discovery-oriented processes that investigate what is at stake and asking questions about the situation (Espedal & Carlsen, 2024). Inquiries into reflexive capacities can assist in assessing the social condition and vitalizing the institutional processes that affect the well-being of those involved (Edwards et al., Chapter 15). This reflexive capacity is understood as the manner in which individuals engage with the world of others to foster a shared world of concern (Creed et al., 2022). Some fundamental overarching values influence attention to what is at stake. One study in this *Handbook* presents how investigating the overarching values in a situation or organization can be a step toward identifying guiding universal principles that provide consistency, legitimacy, and ethical guidance (Fioravante & Vaccaro, Chapter 4). Another chapter suggests paying attention to values-centric institutionalism, which includes attending to people-centered perspectives on emotions within this perspective and in institutional life, suggesting that these inform and enrich each other (Flores & Kraatz, Chapter 3).

While subjective feelings are hardly observable, behavioral reactions to emotions can serve as indicators of internal emotional struggles, enabling their **recognition**. The very fact that emotions are felt and behaviorally expressed can be a sign of engagement in a value and, by extension, an institutional arrangement, or even a moral order. One study shows that the ability to

recognize what is at stake for others and oneself is an important element of emotional maturity (April & Downes, Chapter 21). Recognizing emotions and values is particularly pertinent in scenarios characterized by dilemmas or paradoxes. One study illustrates how senior executives were influenced by a slow, circular, values-based decision-making process when faced with challenging situations (Lou & Stensaker, Chapter 22). This process involves recognizing the emotional strain from the tensions of paradoxes, potentially leading to emotional equanimity. Recognizing personal purpose, continuous self-care, and a sense of values that align with what “feels right” can help balance work and shape transformations. However, an “overemphasizing” of recognizing value-driven ideals may hinder work on values in organizations (Forester, 2021).

The excessive or “dark side” values can pose significant emotional challenges and make recognizing the situation difficult, particularly when the dark side circulates within an organization characterized by democratic and consensus-seeking leadership. E.g. Jellema and Werner (Chapter 11) discuss how emotional attachments to personal ideals led to a diverse and sometimes conflicting array of organizational aspirations. This diversity in values provoked strong emotions, which influenced collective sensemaking processes and contributed to tensions and paralysis (Jellema & Werner, Chapter 11). Another study identified the paternalistic, caste-based agrarian economy in India as maintained through processes of upholding traditional values, leading to the moral indebtedness of Indian rural farmers (Sharma & Amis, Chapter 16).

Recognition of these emotions, concerns and ongoing reflection can be achieved through strategic use of narratives, as suggested by Prokopovych (Chapter 25) and Ruebottom and Toubiana (Chapter 10), as well as through attention to institutional values, institutional logics, and frameworks (Peña & Toubiana, Chapter 2). A study by Espedal and Askeland (Chapter 6) suggests that the interplay between emotions and values offers insights into reflexivity and recognition processes that enhance relational practices and initiate moral dialogues.

Recognition and reflection process deepens understanding of emotions and values implicated in a specific situation. It provides foundations for **actions**, the collective, knowledgeable execution of tasks that become the emotional and values practices of an organization. These actions guide members in understanding their experiences and discerning right from wrong. In this Handbook, leadership actions are shown to foster some kind of belonging (Tappel & Løvaas, Chapter 18). Additionally, reflection

of action can lead to a new mindset, structure, and innovative actions, as highlighted by Eriksen and Løvaas (Chapter 19).

As emotions and values in institutions can be blurred and hard to identify in practice, one chapter initiates methodological actions on conducting field studies of values and emotions to generate empirically based insights into the relationships between emotions and values (Wright, Chapter 23). The chapter suggests that researchers can focus on theory, phenomenon, or personhood as pathways to potentially uncover *both/and* insights within the field of emotions and values. These three approaches—theory-centered, phenomenon-centered, and personhood-centered—offer different options for field researchers and managers to direct their focus during the “getting on” and “getting out” stages of field data collection (Buchanan et al., 1988), thus making a frame for narrating and identifying the actions toward an identification of the emotions and values involved.

The processual framework of emotion and value work in organizations is presented in Fig. 26.1.

The outcomes of these leadership steps may provide valuable insights into the subtle, complex work within organizations that maintains, disrupts, and transforms organizational operations. Having emotional responses that align with self-transcending values fosters a sense of moral integrity, which is essential for leadership consistency (Michie & Gooty, 2005). Morality can be reawakened when emotions play a fundamental role in moral lives (Oakley, 1992).

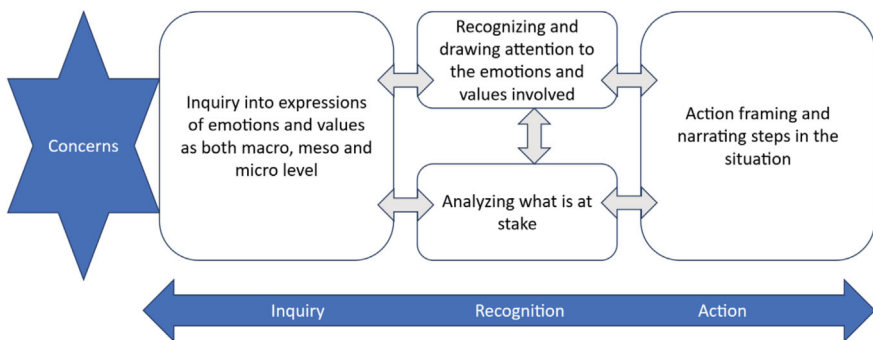


Fig. 26.1 Leadership steps to enhance awareness of work on emotions and values in organizations

Future Research

In this chapter, we have investigated the dynamic interconnection between emotions, values, and institutions and explored diverse ways in which this connection can be theorized. We suggest embracing values and emotions in organizations and paying attention to them as signals worthy of attention, as triggers of reflection that help align organizational goals with organizational practices.

Inquiring into values and emotions offers a way of morally aware and reflective transforming of contemporary institutions and organizations. It also becomes a way of saving individuals from the destructive experience of moral corruption and denial—experiences that are not uncommon to organizational members worldwide whose work may often feel meaningless, so called “bullshit jobs”, (Graeber, 2018) or just wrong because it makes them complicit of greenwashing, whitewashing, we-washing, and so on. We are not so naïve as to assume that call for taking emotions and values seriously in organizations will change these conditions, but—since “not everything that is faced can be changed; but nothing can be changed until it is faced” (Baldwin, 2010[1962], p. 110) —we believe that knowledge and the availability of alternative approaches may open ways to deal with some of these problems.

Having gained insights through our work on this Handbook, we recognize the need for further research into the interconnected dynamics of emotions and values within organizations. By focusing on reflexivity and their interactions, we can gain insights into their collective impact on institutional dynamics and address complexities within these systems. Future studies should investigate how institutional ambiguity affects emotions and values, especially its implications for professional practice and decision-making. Additionally, we encourage incorporating embodied and aesthetic perspectives in this research to a greater extent than mentioned here. Such an approach challenges assumptions about how institutions constrain or enable community cohesion. Analyzing body language and aesthetic expressions can reveal the deeper, often hidden forces shaping institutions. Finally, we suggest further examining of the darker aspects of emotions and values to understand how they can support or undermine social arrangements that foster social justice, equality, and human flourishing.

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